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1 Historical Materialism (1).pdf

1 Kinship.pdf

1 Middle Range Theory.pdf

1 Modernity and Emergence of Sociology (1).pdf

1 Modernity and Emergence of Sociology.pdf

1 Qualitative and quantitative methods.pdf

1 Science, scientific method and critique.pdf

1 Social Action.pdf

1 Social Exclusion.pdf

1 Social Fact.pdf

1 The Structure of Social Action.pdf

2 Class Struggle and Social Change (1).pdf

2 Division of Labour.pdf

2 Functional Analysis.pdf

2 Ghurye on Caste.pdf

2 Major theoretical strands of research methodology.pdf

2 Marriage.pdf

2 Social Mobility.pdf

2 Techniques of data collection.pdf

2 The Social System.pdf

2 Verstehen.pdf

3 Asiatic Mode of Production (1).pdf

3 Fact, Value and Objectivity.pdf

3 Family.pdf

3 Ghurye on Tribe.pdf

3 Observation.pdf

3 Social Change.pdf

3 The Protestant Ethic and Spirit of Capitalism.pdf

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3 The Rules of Sociological Method.pdf

4 Alienation (1).pdf

4 Bureaucracy.pdf

4 Content Analysis.pdf

4 Ghurye on Indian culture.pdf

4 Parsons - An Assessment.pdf

4 Reflexive Sociology.pdf

4 Suicide.pdf

5 Focus Group.pdf

5 Ghurye - The Nationalist.pdf

5 Marx -An Assessment.pdf

5 Religion and Society.pdf

5 Weber - An Assessment.pdf

6 Durkheim - An Assessment.pdf

6 Ghurye - An Assessment.pdf

6 Variables and Hypothesis.pdf

7 Comparative Method.pdf

A.R.Desai.pdf

Agitation.pdf

Citizenship.pdf

Class.pdf

Collective Action.pdf

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G. S. Ghurye (1893-1983)

Govind Sadashiv Ghurye is a towering figure in intellectual and academic life of India. For his unique contribution in the field of Indian Sociology, he has often been acclaimed as the "father of Indian Sociology". Analysis of his life and works is very interesting as it gives a perspective of the development of sociology in India. When Ghurye began his academic career, sociology was almost non-existent as an academic discipline. It grew slowly but steadily through the efforts of individuals as well as at the behest of governmental administration. In fact, governmental inquiries into Indian social conditions came much earlier than the endeavors of academics to install sociology in India. It was rather opportune for Ghurye to have been in Bombay University where sociology got its start in 1919 through the efforts of Patrick Geddes. Since then, Ghurye had been there and he did single-handedly what was possible for him to do for sociology in this country. His persistent research endeavour, wide-ranging interest and upholding of the best of academic tradition made him the centre of sociological creativity and research for several generations of Indian sociologists. His own works, which are as diverse as the research output of his students, have been highly esteemed in academic quarters.

Because of his unique role played by Ghurye in the development of sociology in India, high tributes and panegyrics have been offered to him both in India and abroad. B.S. Guha has written that there are very few people who have done so much for the cause of Indian Anthropology both in teaching as well as in research as Professor Ghurye has done. D.P. Mukherji commented that while there are many sociologists in India, Ghurye, by his deep mooring in Indian tradition, provides the only example of an 'Indian sociologist'. Similar tributes have been paid to him by M.N. Srinivas, Y.B. Damle, D. Narain, M.S.A. Rao and others. Among the foreigners, Merton described Ghurye as the "symbol of sociological creativeness", whereas Mandelbaum, in personal letter to Ghurye, wrote: "All of us, who are interested in India and in anthropology, are your debtors". In recognition of his services to the cause of sociology, the University of Bombay instituted an award in his name in 1969. Two felicitation volumes have also been published on the occasion of Ghurye's sixtieth and eightieth birthdays.

Ghurye was born on 12th December, 1893 in a Saraswat Brahmin family in Malavan, Maharashtra, the West Coast of India. Sociology was not a school or college subject when Ghurye showed a flair for Sanskrit. After passing the matriculation examination, Ghurye got himself admitted to the Elphinstone College, Bombay with Honours in Sanskrit. The college that was so well-known for its Sanskrit teachers, library and its prestige with the government. He had a brilliant academic career throughout. He stood first class second at the B.A.

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examination and was awarded the Bhau Dazi prize – the blue ribbon of Sanskrit competence in the university. He stood first class first at the M.A. examination in English and Sanskrit in 1918 and was awarded the Chancellor's Gold Medal. None before that time had obtained a first class at the M.A. with Sanskrit. With this type of background in Sanskrit, Ghurye finally came to sociology. This, as we shall see later on, profoundly influenced Ghurye's own writings and the course of research made in the field of sociology under his leadership.

In 1919 the university proposed a traveling fellowship for the study of sociology. Since his Sanskrit thesis had involved the study of social institutions, Ghurye was intrigued. But the fellowship was under the control of the professor of sociology. Strangely enough, this was the celebrated Scottish city planner Patrick Geddes. Geddes had been a botany professor in Dundee for 31 years, most of which he had actually spent as a sociological activist in London. But in 1914, the opportunities of imperial town planning had brought him to India at the invitation of his old friend (and fellow Scot) Lord Pentland. Having lost both his son and his wife in 1917, Geddes decided to settle in India. Patrick Geddes was invited by the University of Bombay to start a Department of Sociology in 1919.

While teaching at the Elphinstone College, Ghurye submitted an essay to Patrick Geddes on "Bombay As An Urban Centre". It won him a foreign scholarship. The scholarship was instituted by the University of Bombay to train promising young men in sociology. Ghurye went to London School of Economics where he briefly worked with L. T. Hobhouse. Despite his initial efforts, however, Ghurye could not stomach the recommended London PhD in Comtean social evolutionism under L. T. Hobhouse. He followed one of Geddes's other letters of introduction to A. C. Haddon, who in turn took him to W. H. R. Rivers, who not only became Ghurye's patron and sponsor at Cambridge but also arranged for two extensions of his Bombay fellowship. Rivers died in 1922 before Ghurye completed his doctoral work. In 1923, he completed his PhD under A.C. Haddon on *Caste and Race in India*. His work was published by Routledge and Kegan Paul in 1932 in C.K. Ogden's *History of Civilization Series*. It immediately established Ghurye's reputation.

[Please note that W.H.R. Rivers (1864-1922) was the popular Cambridge anthropologist, who was also a qualified psychologist. His approach is popularly known as diffusionist approach. Diffusion is the process by which culture traits spread from one society to another. Rivers was also one of the first scholars who studied the Todas of Nilgiri in a scientific way. In India, Todas are found only in the Nilgiri District of Tamil Nadu State. The Todas are a small community who live on the isolated Nilgiri plateau. In the year 1906, he published two volumes in the name of '*The Todas*'.]

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Sociology in Bombay developed under the leadership of G.S. Ghurye. Ghurye succeeded Geddes as head and as a Reader, took charge of the Department of Sociology at Bombay University in 1924. He was appointed as Professor in 1934 and retired in 1959. When he retired in 1959, the University of Bombay made him an Emeritus Professor. Ghurye was the first Emeritus Professor in Bombay University. He did not cease to be academically active after retirement from service. His last research student submitted thesis in 1971. During these about fifty years' span, he supervised as many as eighty theses. Of these, forty have been published as books. As a teacher, Ghurye was very serious and meticulous in preparing his lectures notes. Many of his students have testified that his lectures were heavily documented. As a *research guide*, he was more impressive and more successful. He created a 'sociological awareness'. The 'second generation' of Indian sociologists was largely his creation. They include M.N. Srinivas, K.M. Kapadia, I. Karve, I.P. Desai, A.R. Desai, M.S.A. Rao and many others.

As an institution-builder, deservedly, the most profound impact on Indian sociology was made by Ghurye. Ghurye was the principal architect of the Department of Sociology of Bombay University and produced a batch of renowned scholars including M.N. Srinivas, who is now internationally known. His students headed (and many of them are still heading) the departments of sociology in many universities in India. Ghurye was the prime mover in the formation of Indian Sociological Society in 1952 and was also instrumental in the publication of its mouthpiece, *Sociological Bulletin*, as its official bi-annual journal. However, the first sociological journal in India, *The Indian Journal of Sociology*, was started in January 1920 under the editorship of Alban G. Widgery of Baroda College in Baroda.

Ghurye was elected the president of the anthropological section of the Indian Science Congress in 1934. In the same year, he was also elected as the nominee to the Royal Asiatic Society and continued to hold this position till 1948. During his lifetime, his won several top honours accorded to any intellectual in India. As a scholar, in fact, throughout, his life, Ghurye has been active from the academic standpoint. His 16 books, out of a total of 31 books, published during his lifetime. Several of them are noteworthy as pioneering contributions to the sociology field. His output is indeed prodigious by any standard.

Despite this prodigious academic output, Ghurye was a loner in the world of sociology. Since 1967, neither he attended a single conference, seminar or symposium nor did he send any article to any academic journal for publication. During the last years, he had not maintained any contact with his university–his Alma Mater–for which he had done so much throughout his life. Much of this state of estrangement between Ghurye and the academic community was due to the self

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assertive, highly emotional, sensitive and somewhat egoistical nature of Ghurye. He had never been a 'popular' man throughout his life. He was highly irritated by any slightest provocation. Indeed none but Professor Ghurye could be moved so deeply by even the smallest of courtesies shown to him or so violently outraged by the least signs of ingratitude or boorishness. Academically, he was outright–no consideration stood in the way of expressing what he thought to be right. It is far from truth that the academic community in India was totally indifferent to Ghurye. The fact is, on the other hand, that Ghurye had shown a stiff disinclination to accept any offers made to him if he thought that he had to compromise his sense of dignity in order to accept them. A few incidents may be cited in this regard. In 1969, the Ministry of Education requested him to give his bio-data. Ghurye began to write it. Then came a telegram requesting him to give five copies of it. The first thing which he did then was to tear off those two pages which he had already written and thrown them into waste paper basket. In 1970, Dr. M.S. Gore came to him with a proposal of the government to award him the honorific Padmabhusan. Ghurye turned that down because, according to him, it was beneath his dignity to receive that award. In 1971, the University Grants Commission offered him the post of National Lecturer. Ghurye considered the proposal ridiculously because thereby he would have to move from place to place whereas the students would remain tight in their places. In 1974, he refused to send biographical data to the Indian Council of Social Science Research because "those who do not know about my writings do not deserve to get replies from me." A month or so after the publication of Ghurye's *India Recreates Democracy* in 1978, a letter from the then prime minister came to Ghurye congratulating him on the thesis. But Ghurye did not reply because he thought that the format of the letter was not proper. Ghurye died in 1983, having published *The Burning Cauldron of North-East India*, his last book, in 1980, when he was 87.

Dear Candidate, let us now come to an analysis of Ghurye's writing. What immediately strikes one in this respect is the enormous diversity of Ghurye's writings. Ghurye's broad area of interest was the general process of evolution of culture in different civilizations in general, and in Indian (Hindu) civilization in particular. There is a central theme underlying all the diverse writings of Ghurye. The theme is a very broad one; it is the theme of *acculturation* that goes on and on since the time of arrival of the Vedic Aryans in India. Indian society, through its long historical process of growth, presents a picture of a vast mosaic of culture held together by religion, values and norms of Hinduism. As a sociologist, Ghurye feels the imperative of exploring this unifying and synthesizing process. In spite of many diversions, exploration and analysis of the process of cultural unity in India through ages constitutes the major thrust of Ghurye's writing. And to establish his thesis he moves, with perfect case, back and forth, from the Vedic to the present-day India.

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[A note on diffusion and acculturation: Diffusion, as stated earlier, generally refers to the spread of specific cultural traits or elements from one society or social group to another. Acculturation, on the other hand, refers to the modification of the culture of a group or an individual through contact with one or more other cultures and the acquiring or exchanging of culture traits. From a social point of view acculturation implies the diffusion of particular values, techniques and institutions and their modification under different conditions. It may give rise to cultural conflict and to adaptation leading to a modification of group identity. Some scholars defined acculturation as 'those phenomena which result when groups of individuals having different cultures come into first hand contact, with subsequent change in the original cultural patterns of both groups. The processes of acculturation and diffusion have been going on in human society since very ancient times.]

However, before we proceed to discuss Ghurye's ideas, a few comments on his overall theoretical perspective and methodology would be useful. As stated earlier, the exploration and analysis of the process of cultural unity in India through ages constitutes the major thrust of Ghurye's writing. Thus, in theoretical terms, his focus on the unity and integration aspect of Indian culture reflects his broad acceptance of the structural-functional approach.

Since Ghurye's initial training was in Sanskrit, he emphasized on the Indological approach in the study of social and cultural life in India. Indology literally means a systematic study of Indian society and culture. Indologists claimed that the uniqueness of Indian civilization cannot be fitted into the framework of European Sociology. They claimed that Indian society could be understood only through the concepts, theories and frameworks of Indian civilization. They rely primarily on the book-view, in other words, understanding the society through classical literature, such as *Vedas*, etc. The sources of Indological studies are primarily classical texts, manuscripts, archaeological artefacts, and symbolic expressions. Ghurye utilized literature in sociological studies with his profound knowledge of Sanskrit literature, extensively quoted from the *Vedas*, *Shastras*, epics, and poetry of *Kalidasa* or *Bhavabhuti* to shed light on the social and cultural life in India.

Despite his initial training in Sanskrit, and later on at Cambridge under W.H.R. Rivers (diffusionism), Ghurye was not dogmatic in the use of theory and methodology. He seems to have believed in practicing and encouraging disciplined eclecticism in theory and methodology. Thus, although trained in the craft of Indology, Ghurye was not averse to the fieldwork traditions of social and cultural anthropology. His field survey of *Sex Habits of Middle Class People in Bombay*, conducted in the 1930s and published in 1938 and the monograph on the *Mahadev*

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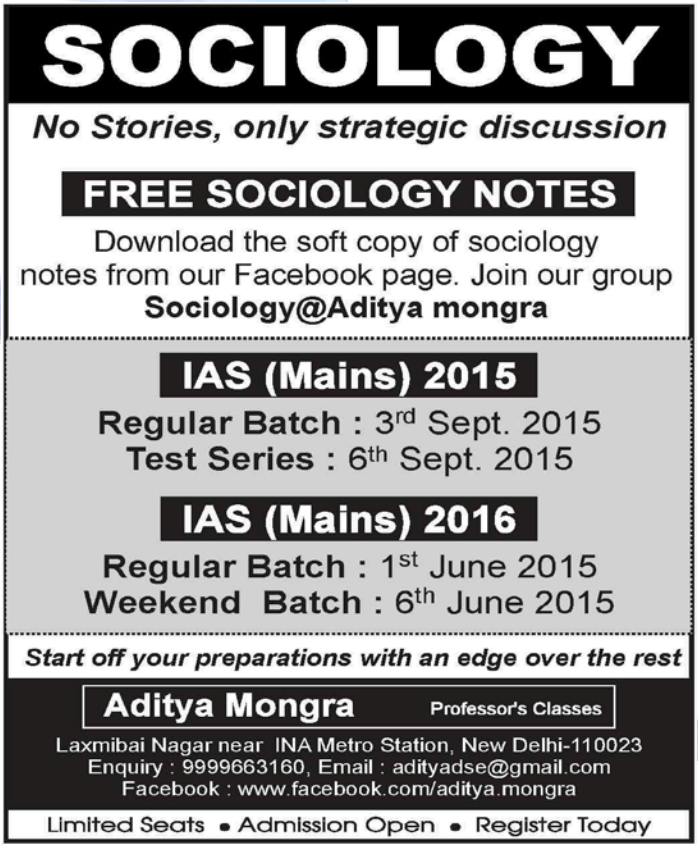
Kolis (1963) demonstrated Ghurye was far from promoting an armchair textual scholarship. He was an empirical field worker too.

Drawing on his initial training as a Sanskritist, Ghurye attempted a fruitful synthesis of Indological and sociological perspectives. This constitutes his most enduring contribution to Indian sociology. Indeed, Ghurye helped the emergence of Sociology as a distinct discipline in India from its early beginnings in Indology and descriptive ethnology. His own classic study of caste and race in India moved the focus of sociological study from a reconstruction of a social institution (caste) from Sanskrit texts to a study of how it functioned in contemporary social reality. Ghurye's conception of the sociology of India included the study of modern, medieval and ancient India, as well as rural urban and tribal India. There is now an increasing realization of the value of combining the sociological-anthropological approach, on the one hand, and the historical-textual approach, on the other.

It would be appropriate to characterize Ghurye as a practitioner of 'theoretical pluralism'. It is also likely that Ghurye's flexible approach to theory and methodology in sociology and social anthropology was born of his faith in intellectual freedom, which is reflected in the diverse theoretical and methodological approaches that his research students pursued in their works. Ghurye also used historical and comparative methods in his studies which have also been followed by his students.



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Dear Candidate, if we are to understand Ghurye, we need to look more closely at the trends of thought which shaped his approach to sociology, and at their connections with the political and social context of empire and the anti-colonial struggle. Orientalism, Indology and Diffusionism are the three major intellectual influences which mark Ghurye's sociology. We have already discussed briefly about Indology and Diffusionism. Let me briefly introduce you British Orientalism.

The term 'orientalism' implies the literary and cultural study of Middle Eastern and East Asian societies. In literal sense, orientalism refers to the Orient or East, in contrast to the Occident or West, and often, as seen by the West. In recent times the term 'orientalism' has become highly problematic and contested, carrying several meanings which do not sit altogether comfortably with each other. It is helpful to begin with the two earliest meanings of the term as a foundation for analyzing the nature and impact of orientalism. First, it was a scholarly study of the languages, literatures and cultures of the Orient (initially conceptualized as the Middle East but later encompassing all of Asia).

Secondly, the term also refers to the 18th century administrative policy of the East India Company favouring the preservation of Indian languages, laws and customs. It was during this period that Indology as a systematized modern discipline was established due to the demands that arose from British rule over India. To govern efficiently, British administrators felt the need for a deeper understanding of the ancient laws and customs of Indian society. Hence British encouraged indological studies whose primary aim was to gain a deeper understanding of the Indian culture. The mainstream of Indology, however, has been the creation of Western scholars. As an independent discipline, Indology is much older than Sociology in India. The first important centre of indological studies in India was started by Sir William Jones in 1784 by establishing Asiatic Society of Bengal in Calcutta. William Jones emphasized the point that originally European languages were very much similar to Sanskrit and Iranian languages.

It is worth noting that the "Orientalists" were the dominant faction in the Indology of this time. The term "Orientalist" as used here requires some explanation. In the history of the British Raj, there were two major schools of thought concerning the system of rule over India. One was the "Orientalist" camp and the other was the "Anglicist" camp. The Orientalists placed major importance on Indian culture and sought to rule India based on its own traditions. In the history of the British Raj, this Orientalist attitude was predominant toward the end of the eighteenth century, before it was replaced by the Anglicist attitude early in the nineteenth century.

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The Anglicists, on the other hand, believed in the supremacy of the English language and English culture. Hence, they tried to establish a system of rule fashioned on that of Britain itself, particularly through the introduction of English-language education. These British writers influenced by Utilitarianism and Evangelicism constructed a negative image of Indian civilization in order to provide a moral basis for empire. James Mill was the most prominent representative of this trend; in his *History of India* he attempted to downgrade the place allotted to India on the scale of civilization by the early Orientalists by deprecating all that the latter had glorified. They argued that British had a civilizing mission to modernize India, to 'liberate Indians from their own past'. Thus the ancient wisdom of India, earlier seen as a fount of western civilization through its connections to ancient Greece and Egypt, became opposed to western civilization, which stood for progress in contrast to the stagnation and backwardness of the east.

The first major influence on Ghurye is clearly the tradition of British Orientalism that developed in the 18th century. The Orientalists produced a theory of Indian history and society that had far-reaching consequences for the development of both nationalist and academic thought. The most important theme that emerged from their writings and that runs throughout Ghurye's work is that of the antiquity and unity of Indian civilization. The early British Orientalists sought to reconstruct ancient Indian civilization through the study of Sanskrit texts, and with this knowledge to place India within various universal schemes of human history. This reconstruction was oriented to an overarching concern with the origins of civilization, then defined as the cultivation of the higher arts and sciences. India's civilization was regarded as one of the oldest and most highly developed, as demonstrated in the complexity of ancient Indian knowledge and culture and the perfection of the Sanskrit language. The Orientalists identified ancient Indian civilization with Hinduism, and Sanskrit was regarded as the vehicle of Hindu civilization.

Because Indian society was seen as static and monolithic, the ancient texts could be taken as authentic guides to the study of Indian civilization and even to the organisation of contemporary society, for example in the production of 'Hindu law'. "Indian society was seen as a set of rules which every Hindu followed'. By reconstructing Hinduism and Hindu law, positing the distant past as normative, and drawing an unbroken connection between past and present, Orientalist scholarship had a lasting effect on the understanding of Indian society and history, an understanding that is reflected clearly in the work of Ghurye, among many others. The great 19th century German Orientalist, Max Muller, a product of the German romantic movement, played a major role in the popularisation of knowledge about India and in the glorification of ancient Indian religion, especially of the Vedic

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period. He collected and published the full text of the Vedas for the first time, because he believed that they were the only "natural basis of Indian history". Like the earlier Orientalists, Max Muller wanted to reveal to Indians the knowledge contained in their ancient tradition, and he believed that the Vedas were the root of Hindu religion, law and philosophy.

Let us now analyze some of the key ideas of Ghurye in the backdrop of his this intellectual background. To simply and facilitate your better understanding I have discussed some of the very important ideas of Ghurye from the examination point of view under the following heads:

1. Ghurye's views on Caste
2. Ghurye's views on Tribe
3. Ghurye's views on Indian culture, and
4. Ghurye - The Nationalist

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Karl Marx (1818-1883)

Karl Marx was born in 1818 in Trier in Germany into a prosperous middle-class family. His parents were Jewish but his father converted to Protestantism so that he could retain his job as a senior lawyer in the Court of Appeal. This was due to the increased pressure and persecution of the Jews under the newly established Prussian regime following the fall of the more lenient Napoleonic government. Born in a bourgeois household and brought up by a highly educated lawyer, Marx naturally thought of pursuing an advanced university education upon completing his early studies at the Trier gymnasium. At age 17, in 1835, Karl Marx entered the University of Bonn to study law. The following year, unlike most German students who attend several universities before sitting for the university degree examinations, he journeyed to Berlin to study on the university faculty. Though Hegel had died in 1831, the university was still very much under the spell of his theory of history. Quickly succumbing to Hegelianism, he joined a rather loosely knit band of young radicals marginally affiliated with the university, who called themselves unabashedly the Doktorklub. Law was abandoned, and joining these Young Hegelians, Marx took up the study of philosophy.

Finally, in 1841 at the age of twenty-three, he received the doctorate degree from the University of Jena for his thesis on Greek natural philosophy. Having destroyed his chances at a university teaching career due to his radical and outspoken views, shortly after completing his studies, he began writing for a radical left-wing paper in Cologne, *Rheinische Zeitung*, and became its editor in 1842. Following the forced closure of the paper by the government because of a series of radically controversial articles by Marx on social conditions, Marx and his fiancée, Jenny, married and moved to Paris in 1843. The move to Paris was crucial for Marx for two reasons. First, still aged only 26, he wrote his most important philosophical work known as the 1844 *Paris Manuscripts*. Although these were not published until 1930 (and were not widely read until the 1950s), it is here that he introduced the concept of alienation, and laid the philosophical foundations for much of his later work. The second important event was meeting his lifelong friend Friedrich Engels (1820-1895). Despite being heir to flourishing textiles business with factories in Germany and a mill in Manchester, Engels had developed a reputation as a forthright critic of capitalist industry in his book, published in 1845, *The Condition of the Working Class in England*. Sharing many ideas with Marx, and certainly also favouring a socialist political outlook, Marx and Engels began a 40 year collaboration that lasted until Marx's death in 1883.

But, as in Germany two years before, the governmental authorities, this time of Guizot in Paris, expelled Marx and many of his associates. In 1845 Marx and his family were forced to leave Paris by the authorities there and they spent the next

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three years in Brussels. Moving to Brussels, he re-established contact with like-minded German refugees there, especially a socialist organization called the German Workers' Educational Association. This organization interestingly had headquarters in London and was federated with the Communist League of Europe. With a draft from Engels, and under commission from the G.W.E.A., Marx wrote *The Communist Manifesto* which was sent on to London headquarters in 1848. Just prior to that, he had published *The Holy Family* (1845) and *The Poverty of Philosophy* (1847). Another book, *The German Ideology*, was written in 1845-6, but was not published until 1932.

Under what appeared to be favourable but later proved unfavourable circumstances, Marx and Engels returned to Paris in 1848 following the outbreak of revolution in Germany, assuming the editorship of the radical paper, *Neue Rheinische Zeitung*. Failing to work out a working-class/bourgeoisie alliance against the feudal government, Marx was presented an ultimatum by the government in August 1849, of retiring to the French hinterlands or leaving the country. Opting for the latter, Marx migrated to London where he established permanent residence. The first few years in London proved productive, intellectually and literally, producing such works as *The Class Struggles in France* (1850) and *The 18th Brumaire of Louis Bonaparte* (1852). During these years, Marx also spent a great deal of time researching for his major work, the three-volume *Das Kapital* (or simply *Capital*). The first volume was published in 1867 and volumes two and three, edited by Engels after Marx's death, in 1885 and 1894. Also important from the period around 1859 is his *Contributions to a Critique of Political Economy* and a collection of 'fragments' or 'notes', which he wrote as a "preliminary work" to *Capital*, were eventually published in 1953 as *Grundrisse*.

Arriving in London in 1849 at the age of thirty one, Marx's life was just half over-a refugee thrice, twice exiled as an editor of a radical political paper, and once as the author of *The Communist Manifesto*, it would appear he had much to live and hope for. But in London, he withdrew with Engels into a close-knit circle composed of his family and a select few devoted disciples. This self-enforced isolation continued throughout the remainder of his life. After securing an admission card to the British Museum's reading room, much of the remainder of his active life centered around the analysis and the criticism of the industrial capitalism of the day. During this period, he was desperately impoverished, and save for the loyal assistance of Engels, all might have been lost. Three children died in the Marx household owing to malnutrition and impoverishment during the time he was completing the first volume of *Das Kapital* (or simply *Capital*). Except for the one pound sterling he received for each article he wrote for the New York Daily Tribune, he had nothing. For a brief time, Marx came out of seclusion and was saved from continued poverty due to the appearance of and subsequent

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leadership offered by him to *The International*, an international federation of European and English workers committed to altering the present economic system. From 1864 to 1872 Marx worked with the First International, which was filled with strife and in which various anarchists, in particular, were opposed to Marx. Marx quit the organization after writing *The Paris Commune*, following the fall of the Paris Commune in 1871. Marx, now wrecked by illness and broken health due to early poverty, and unfulfilled dreams, produced little during his last remaining years. Though a little comfortable towards the end of his life financially, and a distinct celebrity, for socialist leaders from all over the world came to visit him in London, he sustained two blows – the deaths of his eldest daughter and wife – from which he never recovered. Marx died on March 14, 1883.

As is the case with all philosophers and social theorists, Marx's social theory was a critical response to the leading theories and intellectual traditions of the day. His approach was to become fully engaged with a particular set of issues, reach conclusions about them and then fashion his own variations. In many ways, Marx's impact on social theory comes from the fact that his theory does not simply amount to a moderate reworking of what went before, a slight modification here and a bit of tinkering there, but is instead a complete transformation of it. It is this radical intellectual technique that makes Marx a *revolutionary thinker* rather just than somebody who writes *about* revolution in capitalist society. A common thread that runs throughout is Marx's preoccupation with conflict in society. One could say that, whether as a philosophy, an approach to social theory or as a political strategy, Marxist social theory specialises in the analysis of social conflict. This contrasts with the emphasis on social order in the work of Durkheim.

Dear Candidate, before I proceed further, I would like to throw some light on the social and intellectual background of Karl Marx.

Karl Marx's life coincided with the beginning of a change in the European countries from agrarian to industrial societies. It was in England, particularly, in the late eighteenth century that the Industrial Revolution began a concentration of the new working class into factories and housing areas; and Marx obtained most of his basic empirical data for his theory of the development of capitalism from England. Just as important to Marx's theory, however, was the French Revolution of 1789 with its abolition of feudal conditions, the growth of a bourgeois society, and appearance of an anti-bourgeois socialist left.

When Marx appeared on the scene, Germany, compared to England and France, was still a feudal country that was not united until 1871. The direct intellectual background for Marx's theories involved Germany's chances of catching up with more developed countries, and this debate was carried on by the

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radical successors of the philosopher G. W. F. Hegel (1770-1831). With his grand philosophical system, Hegel had attempted to show that human history had a goal, the most salient features of which were the creation of a reasonable state and the realization of the concept of freedom. Since Hegel believed that the Prussian state of his time had made the greatest advances toward realizing freedom and reason, as a professor in Berlin he became somewhat of a "state philosopher" for Prussia. The radicals among Hegel's followers, the young Hegelians objected to this and criticized the dominant position of religion in Prussia. Marx belonged to the young Hegelian movement for a time, but he soon came to criticize its belief that philosophical analysis would lead to change in and liberation of Germany. Instead, he was more influenced by Hegel's historical method in which development and change through *dialectic contradictions* are the primary components, although he rejected Hegel's emphasis on spiritual forces in history. In contrast, Marx stressed human social conditions, particularly their material production, as crucial to historical development.

Another important source of inspiration for Marx was the French Socialist tradition that arose during the French Revolution of 1789 and continued through the revolutions of 1830 and 1848. The most important aspect of this tradition was the idea and goal of a new and more radical revolution than that of 1789. In the coming revolution the new class, the industrial workers or proletariat, would take power and abolish all classes. Beside these revolutionaries who were oriented toward class struggle, these were more reform oriented socialists such as the "utopian socialists," Claude Henri Saint-Simon (1760-1825) and Charles Fourier (1772-1837). Like the Englishman, Robert Owen (1771-1858), they wanted to build a socialist society through state reforms or by creating small local societies in which the division of labour was abolished and people lived in harmony with one another and with nature. Although Marx was critical of these socialists and based his thinking more on the "theory of class struggle," he incorporated some of their criticism of the modern capitalist industrial society into his own theories.

A third tradition of importance in Marx's scientific work was British political economy, with names such as Adam Smith (1723-90) and David Ricardo (1772-1823). They had analyzed the new capitalist market economy and Marx continued their analyses, although to a great extent he reached different conclusions. Of particular importance was the fact the Marx took up their *labour theory of value*, the idea that the value of commodity in determined by the quantity of work put into it. Other socialists also took up this tradition, particularly the so-called *Ricardian socialists*, who tried to demonstrate the injustice of a system in which the workers created all value but received only part of it for themselves. Marx objected to their moral criticism of the distribution of value and in his own theory of surplus value he tried to explain why the workers received only a part of the value they created. These three traditions – German philosophy and Hegel in

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particular, French socialism, and British political economy – form the most important intellectual background for the theories of Marx. Which of them is most important depends on what perspective one has on Marx whether we see him primarily as a philosopher, a revolutionary, or a scientist. Whatever the case, we may say that all three traditions are present in Marx's lifework and that this work is characterized by the special way in which he synthesized these (and other) traditions.

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Hegal: Idealism

When Marx entered university in the 1830s the German intellectual world was dominated by the work of the German idealist philosopher G.W.F. Hegal (1770-1831). In his key works, *The Phenomenology of Mind* (1807) and *The Philosophy of Right* (1821), Hegal developed a very ambitious philosophical system based on the premise that the ultimate purpose of human existence was to express the highest form of what he called the human Geist or 'Spirit'. This Spirit was not a physical or material entity but an abstract expression of the moral and ethical qualities and capacities, the highest cultural ideals, which, he argued, were the ultimate expression of what it is to be a human being. For Hegel, material life was the practical means through which this quest for the ultimate realisation of human consciousness, the search for a really truthful awareness of reality, could be expressed. Material life, and this included such things as the economy, the political institutions of the state and other social organisations in civil society, are a means to this higher end and not an end in themselves.

In saying all this Hegel was building on the philosophical system of his great German predecessor Immanuel Kant (1724-1804). Kant was a rationalist philosopher believing that the human mind is uniquely equipped with the capacity to understand the exterior physical world *before* we encounter it. This understanding is generally well organised and sensible, and thus 'rational'. It is well-established, for example, that all humans are born with the capacity to learn language. We learn the words and grammar of a language through experience but *the capacity* to do so in an orderly fashion comes before the learning process, or is *a priori*, which would in fact not be possible without it. We do not learn the capacity to learn, this is something that we already have. For rationalists, and especially rationalist idealists, human knowledge and understanding are more about what goes on inside our minds than outside of them. Real reality, or the most significant version of reality, is not the physical stuff that surrounds us, but the reflection of it we hold or create in our minds. For Hegel, then, reason and thought are not simply part of reality *they are reality*. It follows from this that the laws and principles that govern human thought must also be the laws and principles that govern the whole of reality.

Combining a strongly rationalist position with his own idealist system based on the idea of Spirit as the search for a really truthful understanding of human consciousness and its real relation with material or objective reality, Hegel goes beyond Kant by suggesting that, because the minds of all human beings are essentially the same (physiologically and in terms wired-in capacities for interpreting the exterior world), we are all part of *the same* overarching consciousness. My consciousness of the highest human ideals and my desire to

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find the most truthful ways of expressing them are essentially the same as yours because my consciousness works in the same way as yours does. If Hegel is correct in arguing that thought and reality are one and the same thing, and that the laws that govern human thought are therefore also the laws that govern reality, then in a sense all of humanity will eventually have the same thoughts. Differences between social actors in terms of their thoughts are to do with differences in their stages of development, how far they have progressed in the capacity for reason, not with differences in how they think.

According to Hegel, the process by which this quest for the ultimate truth is carried on involves a *dialectical* process in which one state of awareness about the nature of reality (thesis) is shown to be false by a further and higher state of awareness (antithesis) and is finally resolved in a final and true state of awareness (synthesis). The idea of the dialectic comes from Ancient Greek philosophy and describes a situation in which truth is arrived at through a process of debate or conversation. A particular point of view is stated, this is challenged by an alternative view and eventually a third view emerges, which is superior to them both. Hegel refines the term to refer to the pattern or logic that human thought must follow. The dialectic is his explanation of the intellectual and philosophical process, inherent within and throughout human consciousness, by which social actors finally come to realise the truth of the idea that thought is reality. Hegel uses the same triadic approach in suggesting that the contradictions or imperfections of the family and of civil society (corresponding with thesis and antithesis) are finally resolved by the institutions of the state, which correspond with the new ethical synthesis. The state thus provides the practical means of expressing the universal Spirit.

A further important analytical device used by Hegel is the idea of *sublation*. He uses this term to describe the need social actors have to feel at ease with their understanding of reality and how they fit into it. Lack of sublation shows itself as a feeling of **estrangement**, of not fitting in, of being at odds with the world and being confused about the nature of reality. Moving away from home for the first time, starting an unfamiliar job or being let down by a friend are all situations where, in Hegel's terms, the social actors experience a sense of estrangement and insecurity, a lack of sublation. Hegel felt that at its root, estrangement arose because uncertainty about the nature of reality 'out there' caused us to be uncertain about reality 'in here'. The extent to which we do not fully understand the objective world around us is also the extent to which we are ignorant about our own subjective inner nature. However much we live inside our heads and build up versions of reality there (and it is very difficult to see where else consciousness could come from), we are ourselves also physical objects that are a part of the

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exterior world we are trying to understand. We are both subjects (things that do things) and objects (things that have things done to them) at one and the same time. Hegel believed that his system of idealist rationality offered a solution to this fundamental dilemma and that his ideas presented the highest synthesis of philosophical thought so far achieved. The fact that he had discovered the underlying principle of the dialectic process as it applies to the development of true human awareness of the nature of reality made Hegel even more convinced of the value of his contribution. The Spirit had become self-aware in terms of understanding the mechanism of its own creation.

Although Hegel's work was extremely popular in Germany in the 1830s, not least because it led people to believe that the German state of the time represented the most advanced and civilized kind of society yet achieved, it was eventually challenged by a new generation of intellectuals who proposed a counter-thesis of their own. The Young Hegelians as they were known applied the triadic apparatus of thesis, antithesis and synthesis to Hegel's own philosophical system. The most influential of this group was **Ludwig Feuerbach** (1804-72), who argued that by subordinating the material world to the realm of consciousness and ideas, Hegel's obsession with the coming of the great universal Spirit, was not in the least bit rational or objective in the scientific sense and was in fact nothing more than a form of religious mysticism. Rather than describing how social actors might overcome their sense of estrangement from material reality, Hegel simply made matters worse by suggesting that it was not objective reality that was the problem but simply the inadequacy of social actors' understanding of it. As Marx puts it: 'Feuerbach's great achievement is to have shown that philosophy is nothing more than religion brought into thought and developed in thought, and that it is equally to be condemned as another form….of the estrangement of man's nature.'

At university Marx soon became interested in the ideas of the counter thesis group and of Feuerbach in particular and eventually rejected much of the Hegelian thesis. Crucial to his own development, however, Marx retained key elements and adapted them for his own use. While giving Hegel, 'that mighty thinker', credit for developing a number of very important insights, Marx argued that he had applied them incorrectly, and had thus reached incomplete conclusions about true nature of real reality. Marx's social theory can be thought of as the new synthesis that emerged out of the collision of Hegel's thesis and the Young Hegelians' antithesis. The key to Marx's critique of Hegel is very simple; he takes a number of his most useful conceptual tools and uses them the other way around.

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Marx: Historical Materialism or Dialectical Materialism

For Marx, it is quite inadequate to regard human history, the development of society itself, as merely a by-product of the quest for ultimate knowledge in the abstract realm of human consciousness. So Marx reverses Hegel's approach by arguing that the quest for knowledge should not begin with abstract conceptions in the realm of ideas, but with a positive analysis of actually existing material things in the real physical world. While Hegel, in common with all idealist thinkers, argues that the most truthful version of the world is the one that we hold in our consciousness, Marx proposed the opposite or **materialist view**, which is that the most real version must be the one we can actually touch and feel. For materialist thinkers, the really real world is not the one we create in our minds but the untidy, crowded, noisy physical matter that surrounds us. If we want to know about real reality, and provide a truthful account of it, social theory must begin with an analysis of real things and not become preoccupied with their 'ideal' representation in our thoughts. Even the most perfectly polished mirror needs something to reflect or it has no purpose at all. Worse still, it might be used to project a completely false image or ideology.

Let us now try to understand the underlying assumptions of this materialist view of Marx. In Marx's view man is essentially a social being. Marx regards man as both the producer and the product of society. Man makes society and himself by his own actions. History is therefore the process of man's self-creation. Yet man is also a product of society. He is shaped by the social relationships and systems of thought which he creates. An understanding of human history therefore involves an examination of these relationships, the most important of which are the relations of production. A society forms a totality and can only be understood as such. The various parts of society are interconnected and influence each other. Thus economic, political, legal and religious institutions can only be understood in terms of their mutual effect. Economic factors, however, exert the primary influence and largely shape other aspects of society. The history of human society is a process of tension and conflict. According to Marx, apart from the communities based on primitive communism at the dawn of history, all societies are divided into social groups known as classes. The relationship between classes is one of antagonism and conflict. Class conflict forms the basis of the dialectic of social change. Social change is not a smooth, orderly progression which gradually unfolds in harmonious evolution. Instead it proceeds from contradictions built into society which are a source of tension and ultimately the source of open conflict and radical change. In Marx's view, '*The history of al hitherto existing society is the history of the class struggle*'.

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It is often argued that Marx's view of history is based on the idea of the dialectic. From this viewpoint any process of change involves tension between incompatible forces. Dialectical movement therefore represents a struggle of opposites, a conflict of contradictions. Conflict provides the dynamic principle, the source of change. The struggle between incompatible forces grows in intensity until there is a final collision. The result is a sudden leap forward which creates a new set of forces on a higher level of development. The dialectical process then begins again as the contradictions between this new set of forces interact and conflict, and propel change. As stated earlier, the idea of dialectical change was developed by the German philosopher Hegel. He applied it to the history of human society and in particular to the realm of ideas. Hegel saw historical change as a dialectical movement of men's ideas and thoughts. He believed that society is essentially an expression of these thoughts. Thus in terms of the dialectic, conflict between incompatible ideas produces new concepts which provide the basis for social change. Marx rejects the priority Hegel gives to thoughts and ideas. He argues that the source of change lies in contradictions in the economic system in particular and in society in general. As a result of the priority he gives to economic factors, to 'material life', Marx's view of history is often referred to as 'dialectical materialism'. Since men's ideas are primarily a reflection of the social relationships of economic production, they do not provide the main source of change. It is in contradictions and conflict in the economic system that the major dynamic for social change lies. Since all parts of society are interconnected, however, it is only through a process of interplay between these parts that change occurs.

History begins when men actually produce their means of subsistence, when they begin to control nature. At a minimum this involves the production of food and shelter. Marx argues that, 'The first historical act is, therefore, the production of material life'. Production is a social enterprise since it requires cooperation. Men must work together to produce the goods and services necessary for life. From the social relationships involved in production develops a 'mode of life' which can be seen as an expression of these relationships. This mode of life shapes man's nature. In Marx's words, 'As individuals express their life so they are. What they are, therefore, coincides with their production, with what they produce and how they produce it'. Thus the nature of man and the nature of society as a whole derive primarily from the production of material life.

Thus, according to Marx, the major contradictions which propel change are found in the economic infrastructure of society. At the dawn of human history, when man supposedly lived in a state of primitive communism, those contradictions did not exist. The forces of production and the products of labour were communally owned. Since each member of society produced both for himself

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and for society as a whole, there were no conflicts of interest between individuals and groups. However, with the emergence of private property, and in particular, private ownership of the forces of production, the fundamental contradiction of human society was created. Through its ownership of the forces of production, a minority is able to control, command and enjoy the fruits of the labour of the majority. Since one group gains at the expense of the other, a conflict of interest exists between the minority who own the forces of production and the majority who perform productive labour. The tension and conflict generated by this contradiction is the major dynamic of social change.

For long periods of history, men are largely unaware of the contradictions which beset their societies. This is because man's consciousness, his view of reality, is largely shaped by the social relationships involved in the process of production. Marx maintains that, '*it is not the consciousness of men that determines their being, but, on the contrary, their social being determines their consciousnesses*'. The primary aspect of man's social being is the social relationships he enters into for the production of material life. Since these relationships are largely reproduced in terms of ideas, concepts, laws and religious beliefs, they are seen as normal and natural. Thus when the law legitimizes the rights of private property, when religious beliefs justify economic arrangements and the dominant concepts of the age define them as natural and inevitable, men will be largely unaware of the contradictions they contain. In this way the contradictions within the economic infrastructure are compounded by the contradiction between man's consciousness and objective reality. This consciousness is false. It presents a distorted picture of reality since it fails to reveal the basic conflicts of interest which exist in the world which man has created. For long periods of time man is at most vaguely aware of these contradictions, yet even a vague awareness produces tension. This tension will ultimately find full expression and be resolved in the process of dialectical change.

To conclude it may be argued that historical materialism is a methodological approach to the study of society, first articulated by Karl Marx. Marx himself never used the term but referred to his approach as "the materialist conception of history," which was later referred to as "historical materialism" by Engels.

Marx drew heavily from Hegel in terms of his "manner of approach" to social phenomena and his analysis of it. However, Hegel was an idealist who asserted the primacy of "mind" or "ideas", whereas Marx was "materialist" who asserted the primacy of "matter." Marx was not satisfied with Hegelian idealism but Hegel's use of the dialectical methodology did grab Marx's imagination. By turning from idealism to materialism (i.e., inverting Hegel), Marx was able to make good use of the dialectic in what came to be called "historical materialism"

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or "dialectical materialism." Please note that it was Georgi Plekhanov, the father of Russian Marxism, who later introduced the term *dialectical materialism* to Marxist literature.

According to Friedrich Engels, historical materialism "designates that view of the course of history, which seeks the ultimate causes and the great moving power of all important historic events in the economic development of society, in the changes in the modes of production and exchange, with the consequent division of society into distinct classes and the struggles of these classes."

Historical materialism is thus both, a perspective as well as the methodology. As a perspective, it looks for the causes of development and change in human society in the material conditions or the economic structure of society. As a methodology, it seeks to examine the social structure and explain social change in terms of the dialectical movement of forces of production and relations of production in the mode of production of a given society.

Although Marx did not consistently argue for a crude economic determinism, he left no doubt that he considered the economy to be the foundation of the whole socio-cultural system. Throughout their study, Marx and Engels emphasized the primacy of economics in human relationship and the centrality of the economic dimension in political structures. The economic system of production and distribution, or the means and relations of production in the Marxian sense, constitute the basic structure of society on which are built all other social institutions, particularly the state and legal system. According to Engels, "... the production of immediate material means of subsistence, and consequently, the degree of economic development attained by a given people or during a given epoch, form the foundation upon which the state institutions, the legal conceptions, the ideas on art, and even on religion, of the people concerned have been evolved."

All other factors in the human experience of social relations were subservient and dependent upon the economic factor in the Marxian theory of social relationships. "The political, legal, philosophical, literary, and artistic development," Marx wrote, "rests on the economic. But they all react upon one another and upon the economic base. It is not that the economic situation is the sole active cause and that everything else is merely a passive effect, there is, rather a reciprocity within a field of economic necessity which in the last instance always asserts itself". He would argue, even, that human thought, human awareness, and human consciousness, were not self-originating but were derivatives of the economic principle. Consistent with his economic interpretation of history, Marx developed a variant of the sociology of knowledge which stressed the primacy of the economic principle in the evolution of ideologies, philosophical systems,

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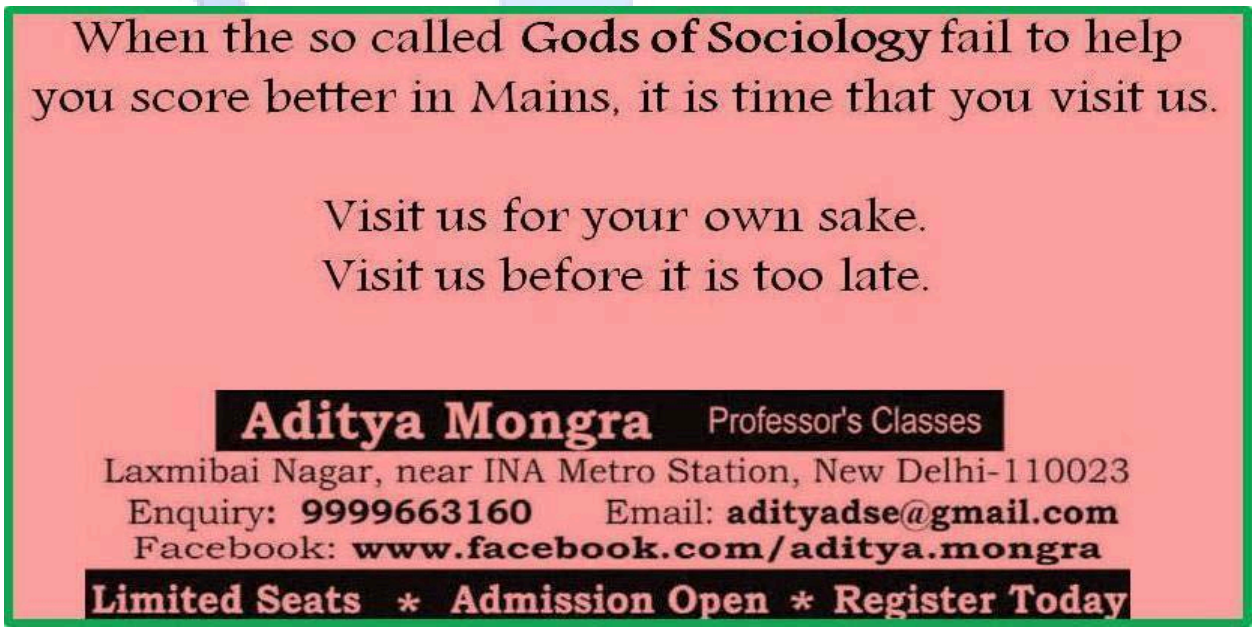
politics, ethics and religion. The central thesis of Marx is this: "It is not the unfolding of ideas that explains the historical development of society (as Hegel and Comte would have argued), but the development of the social structure in response to changing material conditions that explains the emergence of new ideas."

According to Marx, ideas belong to the realm of the superstructure and are determined by the economic infrastructure. He believed that the ideologies prevailing at any particular point in time reflect the worldview of the dominant class. In other words, ideas depend on the social positions – particularly on the class positions of their proponents. These views, moreover, tend either to enhance or undermine the power and control of whatever class happens to be dominant at the time. If generated from the dominant class, they tend to be supportive and reinforce the predominance of the social structure. "The ideas of the ruling class", Marx pointed out "are, in every age, the ruling ideas: i.e., the class which is the dominant *material* force in society is at the same time its dominant *intellectual* force. The class which has the means of material production at its disposal, has control at the same time over the means of mental production." Marx warned that we will fail to understand the historical process "if...we detach the ideas of the ruling class from the ruling class itself and attribute to them an independent existence, if we confine ourselves to saying that in a particular age these or those ideas were dominant, without paying attention to the conditions of production and the producers of these ideas, and if we thus ignore the individuals and the world conditions which are the source of these ideas." Thus Marx sought to trace the evolution of ideas to the life conditions in general, and the forces and relations of production in particular. As it is with conservative ideas, so it is with revolutionary ideas: the former originate in the worldview of the ruling class and the latter in the material conditions of the revolutionary class.



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Dear Candidate, it would be wise at this point of our discussion to briefly examine what many see as the central issue of Marxism, the question of 'economic determinism'. Critics have often rejected Marxism on this basis though they admit that the charge of economic determination is more applicable to certain of Marx's followers than to Marx himself. It is possible to select numerous quotations from Marx's writings which support the views of his critics. In terms of these quotations, history can be presented as a mechanical process directed by economic forces which follow 'iron laws'. Man is compelled to act in terms of the constraints imposed by the economy and passively responds to impersonal forces rather than actively constructing his own history. Thus the proletariat is 'compelled' by its economic situation to overthrow the bourgeoisie. The contradictions in the capitalist infrastructure will inevitably result in its destruction. The superstructure is 'determined' by the infrastructure and man's consciousness is shaped by economic forces independent of his will and beyond his control. In this way Marx can be presented as a crude positivist who sees causation solely in terms of economic forces.

On closer examination, however, Marx's writings prove more subtle and less dogmatic than many of his critics have suggested. Marx rejects a simplistic, one-directional view of causation. Although he gives priority to economic factors, they form only one aspect of the dialectic of history. From this perspective the economy is the primary but not the sole determinant of social change. The idea of the dialectic involves an interplay between the various parts of society. It rejects the view of unidirectional causation proceeding solely form economic factors. Instead it argues that the various parts of society are interrelated in terms of their mutual effect. Marx described the economic infrastructure as the 'ultimately determinant element in history'. Yet he added that, 'if somebody twists this into saying that the economic element is the *only* determining one, he transforms that proposition into a meaningless, abstract and senseless phrase. The economic situation is the basis, but the various elements of the superstructure . . . also exert their influence upon the course of the historical struggle and in many cases preponderate in determining their *form*'. Thus the various aspects of the superstructure have a certain degree of autonomy and a part to play in influencing the course of history. They are not automatically and mechanically determined by the infrastructure.

Marx consistently argued that 'man makes his own history'. The history of human society is not the product of impersonal forces, it is the result of man's purposive activity. In Marx's view, 'It is not "history" which uses men as a means of achieving – as if were an individual person – *its* own ends. History is *nothing* but the activity of men in pursuit of their ends'. Since men make society only men can change society. Radical change results from a combination of consciousness of reality and direct action. Thus members of the proletariat must be fully aware of

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their situation and take active steps in order to change it. Although a successful revolution depends ultimately on the economic situation, it requires human initiative. Men must make their own utopia.

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Kinship

Kinship is one of the main organizing principles of human society. Marriage is a link between the family of orientation and the family of procreation. This fact of individual membership in two nuclear families gives rise to kinship system. Kinship is defined as "a social relationship based upon family relatedness" (Theodorson). The relationship which may be consanguineal (based on blood) or affinal (based on marriage), determines the rights and obligations of related persons. As such, kinship system is referred to as "a structured system of statuses and roles and of relationship in which the kin (primary, secondary, tertiary and distant) are bound to one-another by complex interlocking ties". **G.P. Murdock** argues that kinship is merely a structured system or relationship in which individual are bound to one another by complex interlocking and ramifying ties. **Radcliffe-Brown** (*Structure and Function in Primitive Society*) looks at kinship system as a part of social structure and insists upon the study of kinship in terms of the rights and obligations of the individuals involved.

Every kinship system distinguish between blood relatives (biologically related, actually or by social fiction), who are technically called consanguineal relatives, and relatives by marriage, technically called affinal relatives. Married couples may in some systems be related by blood, but they are always regarded as affinal relatives since the marriage bond is socially the most important bond between them. The various types of family therefore always include some affinal relatives. The only exception we know of is the Nayar *Taravad*, which consists of brothers and sisters, with the children of the sisters and of the women in successive generations. All these consanguineal relatives can live in the same household only because among the Nayars husband and wife do not live together for more then three days.

According to the Oxford Dictionary of Sociology, 'Kinship systems establish relationships between individuals and groups on the model of biological relationships between parents and children between siblings, and between marital partners.' Relationships established by marriage, which form alliances between groups of person related by blood (or consanguineous ties), are usually referred to as affinal relationship. Some social scientists make a distinction between the study of kinship and the study of affinity. It should be noted that actual biological relationships are not necessary for status within a kinship system to be established. For instance, it may be more important to establish that a child has a social father, who will take responsibility for its welfare and have a right to the product of its labour, than to find out who the biological father might be.

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For example, the **Todas** of Nilgiri Hills who practiced fraternal polyandry, used to observe an interesting ceremony called ***bow and arrow ceremony*** to declare the paternity socially. In this ceremony, all brothers and the common wife used to assemble amidst the rest of the villagers in the fourth or fifth month of pregnancy of the wife and as a result of consensus one of the brothers used to present a set of bow and arrow to the wife. This was taken as declaration that this particular brother would be accepted as father of the coming child. In this way, the 'social fatherhood' overrides the 'biological fatherhood'.

Kinship structure is a commonly used term in both sociological as well as anthropological literature. Structure means a more or less lasting pattern of social relationship. Thus, structure of kin groups refers to those persisting patterns of relations which form the basis of their organisation. **Robin Fox** in his major work *Kinship and Marriage* has identified certain conditions which have to be met by every kinship system in order to survive and sustain itself. He has called these conditions as **structural principles of kinship** because the manner in which these conditions are fulfilled shape the structure of the kinship system. These structural principles of kinship are: (i) men impregnate women, (ii) women bear the children, (iii) men control economic activity and (iv) incest taboo. According to Robin Fox, these four conditions have to be met by all kinship systems. He further argues that the way these conditions are met will determine the structure or pattern of relations in the kinship system.

Kinship Terms and Usages:

Kinship terms are used to designate and address a kin. **A.R. Radcliffe Brown**, the famous anthropologist, has observed that kinship terms indicate, among other things, classification of ego's rights and duties. Prior to him, **L.H. Morgan**, pointed out that kinship terms provides the context and idiom for our social relationship. Kinship terms are technically classified in different ways, but there are two broad categories of the terms as given by Morgan: (i) Descriptive, and (ii) Classificatory.

The **Descriptive System** refers to a kinship system in which a single term refers to a particular relative and a specific kind of relationship of the ego (the person from whom the relationship is calculated) with her or him. For example, mother's brother is referred to as *mam*a, father's brother as *chacha* etc. The **Classificatory System** uses kinship terms that merge or equate relatives who are genealogically distinct from one another. Here the same term is used for different kin. For example, in English, the term 'grandfather' includes both father's father and mother's father, brother-in-law applies to both wife's and husband's brother

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and also sister's husband and so on. In Hindi, the term '*samdhi*' is used for both, daughter's father –in-law and son's father –in-law.

The North Indian kinship terminology is comparatively descriptive in the sense that it describes elementary relationships starting from the ego. In order to emphasise the patrilineal descent, the terms in the system make a clear-cut distinction between parallel and cross cousins, e.g., *bhatiji* - one's brother's daughter and *bhanji* - one's sister's daughter. In the South Indian kinship terminology there is relative stress on classificatory terminology. Here the same term *mama* includes mother's brother, father's sister's husband and wife's father. However, in most contemporary societies, both terms – descriptive and classificatory – are used.

Within each kin group there are certain reciprocal behavioural patterns. These behaviours, verbal or non-verbal constitute **kinship usages**. Relationships of avoidance, joking relationships and teknonymy are some of the usages which are almost universally practised. In **relations of avoidance**, we find that certain relationships are of restricted nature. Such kins maintain a distance and avoid free interaction between themselves. A man's relationship with his son's wife or with his younger brother's wife is the example of this category of relationship. Certain other relationships are there in which opposite is the case. Interaction between them is intimate and frank and they have **joking relationship** including use to obscene and vulgar references. Joking relationship between a man and his wife's sister or between a woman and her husband's younger brother are very common. **Teknonymy** is yet another kinship usage. It was used in anthropology for the first time by Tylor. According to this usage, a kin is not referred to directly but he is referred to through another kin. A kin becomes the medium of reference between two kins. Thus, in traditional Hindu family a wife does not utter the name of her husband. She calls him through her son or daughter. For example, he is referred to by her as the father of Bittoo or Gudiya.

Kinship usages accomplish two major tasks. First, they create groups: special groupings of kin. Thus marriage assigns each mother a husband, and makes her children his children, thereby creating a special group of father, mother and children, which we call "family". The second major function of kinship usage is to govern the role relationships between kin: that is, how one kinsman should behave in a particular kinsman's presence, or what one kinsman owes to another. Kinship assigns guidelines for interactions between persons. It defines proper, acceptable role relationship between father and daughter, between brother and sister, between son-in-law and mother-in-law and between fellow lineage members and clansmen. Kinship thus acts as a regularizer of social life and maintains the solidarity of social system.

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Irawati Karve has divided Indian society into three major linguistic zones and she found that kinship practices within each of these zones showed high degree of similarity while remarkable differences were to be found between the kinship systems of different zones. Please note that a linguistic region is one where several languages belonging to one language- family are spoken. She distinguished three linguistic regions in India. These regions are (i) Indo- European Linguistic region, (ii) Dravidian Linguistic region and (iii) Austro-Asiatic Linguistic region. Based on these linguistic regions, Irawati Karve divided India into four kinship zones viz., (i) Northern Zone (ii) Central Zone, (iii) Southern Zone and (iv) Eastern Zone.

Rules of Residence, Descent and Inheritance:

[Note: Rules of Residence have already been discussed under the topic 'Family'.]

Kinship serves two important and related purposes. Firstly, it serves to establish and maintain effective social group and secondly, it provides a way of transmitting status and property from one generation to the next. In most societies where kinship connections are important, the rules of descent affiliate individuals with different sets of kin. Descent concerns the tracing of relationships through succeeding generations, i.e., who has descended from whom. Different societies follow different-different rules of descent and inheritance. Some of the important ones are mentioned in the following section in brief.

In most societies a child is regarded as the offspring of both parents, and so has relationships of kinship traced through both. Those kin traced through the father are termed **paternal** or **patrilateral**; those traced through the mother, **maternal** or **matrilateral**. The totality of matrilateral and patrilateral kin recognized by a person within a certain degree is sometimes termed his **kindred**. It is also usual to distinguish lineal from collateral kin. **Lineal** kin are the direct ancestors and direct descendants of an individual: his parents, grandparents, great-grandparents, etc., and his children, grandchildren, etc. **Collaterals** are the other descendants of one's lineal kin (parents' siblings, cousins, etc.). Some writers consider a person's siblings and their descendant as lineal, others as collateral kin. Yet another distinction is made between primary, secondary and tertiary kin. **Primary kin** are one's parents, one's siblings and one's own offspring (father, mother, brother, sister, son, daughter). **Secondary kin** are the primary kin of these (father's father, mother's brother, brother's daughter, etc.). **Tertiary kin** are the primary kin of secondary kin, and so on.

The classic way of defining consanguinity is in terms of common descent from ancestor. All the descendants of a common ancestor may be termed as **stock**. Thus an individual is a member of as many stocks as he recognizes ultimate lineal

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ancestors. Through his parents he is a member of two stocks, through his grandparents of four…. etc. A person is said to be a **cognate** of, or related cognatically to, all those people with whom he shares a common ancestor.

For some purposes, however, the descent criterion may be restricted to males, and only those descendants of a common ancestor in the male line will be recognized as kin. These are known as **agnatic** or **patrilineal** kin. If descent is traced through female exclusively for some purposes, then the descendants would be called **uterine** or **matrilineal** kin. These two modes of tracing descent are called unilineal: that is, they select one 'line' only, either the male or the female. These principles are not necessarily mutually exclusive within a society. It is possible, for example, for an individual to recognize all cognates as kin for some purposes, but to restrict recognition to agnates for some other purposes. Indeed, almost all kinship systems recognize bilateral relationship, i.e relationship to both maternal and paternal kin. Some societies, such as the Yako of Nigeria, utilize matrilineal descent for some purposes and patrilineal for other, thus achieving a system of **double unilineal descent**, known usually as **double-descent** for short.

Rules of inheritance tend to coordinate with the reckoning of descent in most societies, but not necessarily in a one- to- one manner. In fact, it is quite often the case that certain types of property pass from father to son, and other types from mother to daughter. In most parts of India, in the past, immovable property such as land and housing was inherited only by sons. In the absence of sons, except under rare circumstances, by the nearest male relatives on the father's side. On the other hand, movable property in the form of cash and jewellery was given to the daughter at the time of her marriage, with a certain amount of jewellery also passing from the mother-in-law to the daughter-in-law.

Until the passing of the **Hindu Succession Act**, **1956**, two systems of inheritance dominated among patrilineal Hindus. In one system (called the **Mitakshara** school, adopted in most regions) a son has a vested interest in his father's ancestral property from the moment of his birth. The father cannot give away any part of this property to the detriment of his son's interest. Under the other system (the **Dayabaga** school, adopted in Bengal and Assam) the father is the absolute owner of his share and has a right to alienate his property the way he wants.

However with the passing of the Hindu Succession Act of 1956, a uniform system of inheritance has been established. The individual property of a male Hindu, dying intestate (having made no will), passes in equal shares between his son, daughter, widow and mother. Male and female heirs have come to be treated as equal in matters of inheritance and succession. Another important feature of the

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Act is that any property possessed by a female Hindu is held by her as her absolute property and she has full power to deal with it the way she likes. This Act has also given a woman the right to inherit from the father as well as from the husband. However the benefit conferred on a woman is limited when compared to the right of the male members who still have rights to coparcenary ancestral property by birth. Daughters are not part of the coparcenary and have no birthrights.

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Robert King Merton (1910-2003)

Robert King Merton was born of Jewish immigrant parents in a South Philadelphia slum, where his father was a carpenter and truck driver. He grew up with a passion for learning and won a scholarship at Temple University. There he received his BA and became interested in sociology while taking an introductory sociology course taught by George E. Simpson. Recalling this experience, Merton has said, "It wasn't so much the substance of what Simpson said that did it. It was more the joy of discovering that it was possible to examine human behaviour objectively and without using loaded moral preconceptions".

With the help of a fellowship, Merton received a doctorate from Harvard University, where he was one of Parsons's earliest and most important graduate students. Looking back over his career at Harvard, Parsons stated that of the significant relations he had with graduate students, "the most important single one was with Robert Merton." He adds, "For a considerable time, Merton and I came to be known as the leaders of a structural-functional school among American sociologists."

While at Harvard, Merton was also influenced by Pitirim Sorokin, who was not sympathetic to Parson's work. Sorokin shared Parsons's propensity for large-scale theorizing, but he balanced this with an equally strong interest in empirical research and statistical studies. It was Paul K. Lazarsfeld who influenced Merton to become active in empirical research, and Merton was closely associated with him at the Bureau of Applied Social Research at Columbia University until Lazarsfeld's death in 1976. Parsons saw himself as an "incurable theorist," but Merton was actively engaged in empirical research beginning in 1941, when he joined the faculty at Columbia.

Merton's two classic essays on the relationship between sociological theory and empirical research appear as chapters in his best-known book, *Social Theory and Social Structure* (1957). Unlike Parsons, Merton did not stop with abstract theory and typology; he formulated empirical hypotheses and often tested them in the real world by gathering data himself and analyzing the results. Please note that most of his writings have been in essay form. An important complication of these essays is his famous work *Social Theory and Social Structure*. Among the wide range of areas to which he contributed, the most important ones are related to the nature of sociological theory (middle-range theory), clarification and refocusing of functional analysis, theory of deviance, theory of reference group behaviour, sociology of science, etc. In 1957 the American Sociological Society elected Robert K. Merton as its president.

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Theories of the Middle Range

One of the most important ways in which Merton diverged from Parsonian functionalism was in his decision to abandon the quest for an all-encompassing theory. He chose, rather, to take the path of what he calls "middle-range theories" designed to guide empirical inquiry. As Merton himself explained,

> At the summit of human thought, some sociologists are seeking a single unified theory - a generalized body of explanations as to what cements society together, how institutions fit into a social framework, how discrepant values arise and work their changes upon a society, and so on. My friend and occasional colleague, Talcott Parsons, is doing just that, and, I think, making useful progress. But for most of our energies to be channeled that way would be decidedly premature. Einstein could not have followed hard on the heels of Kepler, and perhaps we haven't even had our Kepler yet. Just as it would stifle sociology to spend all its time today on practical problems before developing theory sufficiently, so it would to spend all its time on abstract, all-encompassing theories. Our major task today is to develop special theories, applicable to limited ranges of data - theories, for example, of deviant behaviour, or the flow of power from generation to generation, or the unseen ways in which personal influence is exercised.

Theories of the middle range transcend sheer description of social phenomena. **They are theories with limited sets of assumptions, from which specific hypotheses can be derived and tested empirically. In Merton's view, middle-range views would gradually consolidate into more general theory.** What he set out to do was to fill in the blanks between raw empiricism (what is referred to by some sociologists as the "fishing expeditions" of researchers who cross-tabulate data with abandon and with no guiding theoretical framework) and grand or all-inclusive theory of the type Parsons was working on in his general theory of action.

Let me simplify this. Merton argues that a theory is a clearly formulated generalization between specific variables. Further, a theory can be productive when while being a general theory it is specific enough to produce a 'testable hypothesis'. Please note that a hypothesis is a tentative statement asserting a relationship between certain specific variables. Merton argues that the most important criterion of a testable hypothesis is its potential falsifiability. In other words, it implies that a hypothesis when subjected to empirical enquiry may either be proved or disproved. Parsons's theory of social system is too general to be falsified.

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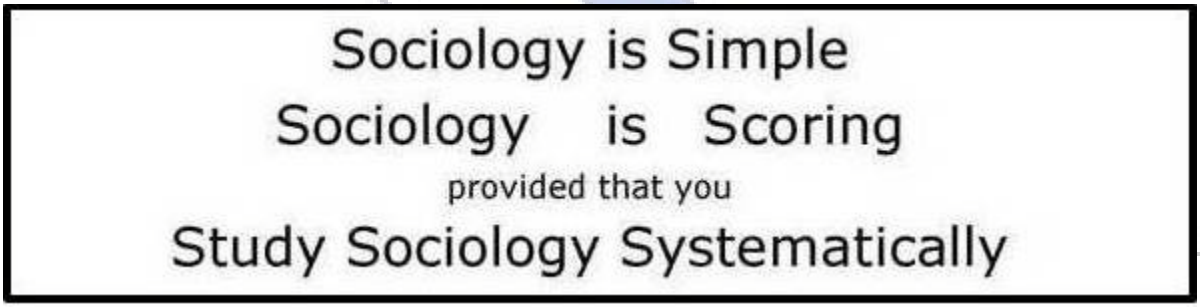
According to Merton, sociology, at its present stage of development, needs theories of middle range. Such theories should be grounded in empirical data and at the same time should use concepts which are clearly defined and can be operationalised. Middle range theories are so formulated that specific and verifiable hypothesis can be deduced from these theories and can be subjected to empirical verification. Please note that Merton was not against building generalizations. According to Merton, building generalizations is central to any scientific discipline. However, in an attempt to arrive at higher level generalizations, scientific research should not be compromised. Hence, Merton advocated 'middle-range theories' which are empirical, thus, ideologically-neutral. Such theories of middle range offer only limited generalizations, thus, not deterministic. Further, these middle-range theories can act as a bridge between macro and micro sociological theories. Merton argues that middle range theories do not remain separate but are consolidated into wider networks of theory. In other words, from various middle range theories, a more general theory (higher level generalization) could be derived.

In his plea for theories of the middle range, Merton was standing on the shoulders of such great sociologists as Durkheim and Weber. He presented two classical examples of middle-range theories: Durkheim's *Suicide* and Weber's *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism.* What Merton advocated is not a new approach but a proliferation of works like these classics. For Merton, both theory and research are integral and inalienable aspects of sociological enquiry.

Dear Candidate, Merton has elaborated on the interrelationship of theory and empirical research in his two essays, viz. '*The bearing of sociological theory on empirical research*' and '*The bearing of empirical research on sociological theory*'. We have already discussed this earlier under the topic: Fact, Value and Objectivity.



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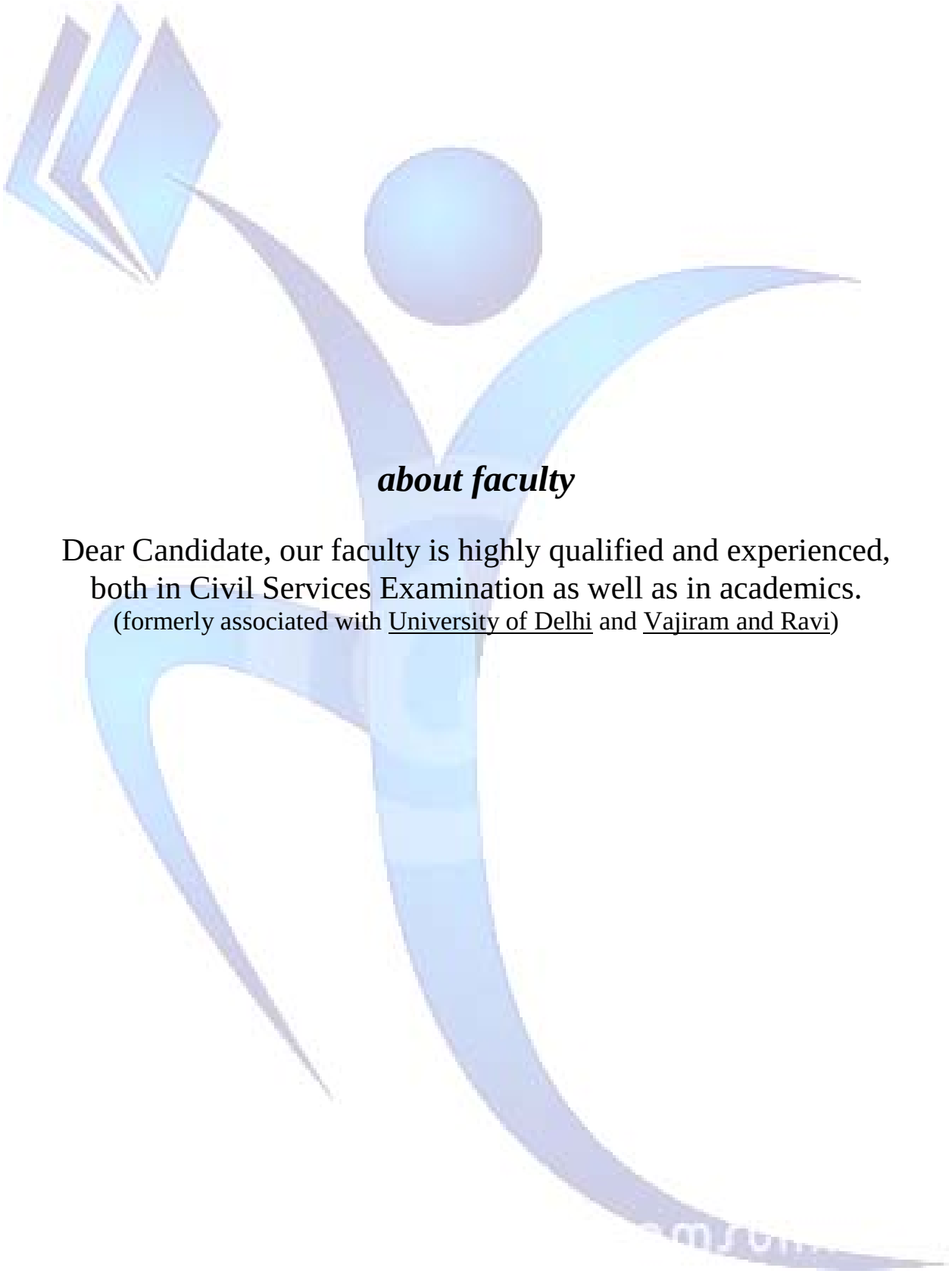

about faculty

Dear Candidate, our faculty is highly qualified and experienced, both in Civil Services Examination as well as in academics.
(formerly associated with University of Delhi and Vajiram and Ravi)

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about Civil Services as a career

Dear Candidate, before I introduce you to this work I would like to share a few things with you. As you know Civil Services Examination is considered to be one of the toughest examinations. But I believe that there is no such thing as EASY or DIFFICULT per se because I feel that it is our thinking that makes it so. Therefore, if you begin your journey to IAS with a positive attitude that **'YES, I CAN DO IT'**, then trust me your journey would become not only a pleasant and enjoyful learning experience but also far more easier than otherwise. Further, before you decide to take Civil Services Examination or any other examination, make sure that your decision is well thought of. For that, firstly, you must take time and introspect and see whether your aptitude and interest matches with the career that you are planning to choose. Since it is the most important step for anyone, any amount of time spent on this is worth.

Secondly, whatever decision you take must be your own independent decision and must be taken with the conviction that whatever may be the outcome you will never regret having taken such decision. Thirdly, one must also make a comparative analysis of the requirements or the level of preparation that an examination demands and the ability or level of preparation one actually has. This is important because it will not only help you in placing the examination in right perspective but also enable you to set realistic expectations from yourself. It will go a long way in guarding you from negative thoughts often arising out of self-doubts during the course of preparation. Thus, saving you both, time as well as energy.

Last, but not the least, I would like to caution those students who go on a shopping spree collecting study material from various coaching institutes during the course of their preparation for this examination. I wish to make it clear that this examination does not require too much of content. Rather, on the basis of my personal experience as well as that of toppers, I can confidently say that ***this examination is less about content and more about analysis, both comparative as well as contemporary***.

That's why in light of the changing pattern of the Civil Services Examination, I always suggest my students to:

Read Adequately * Think Logically * Write Relevantly

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how to prepare Sociology

Dear Candidate, given the **Limited Time** that you have and the **Infinite Syllabus** that you have to prepare for the Civil Services Examination, it becomes very important to manage your time wisely and utilize your energy efficiently. It becomes all the more important in light of the fierce competition that you face ahead. Here, I recall a line from the book *You Can Win* by Shiv Khera, that,

"Winners don't do different things, they do things differently".

Now, I would like to brief you about how our approach is different from the rest, and also the best, for preparing Sociology optional for the Civil Services Examination.

Firstly and foremostly, you must understand that no matter how many sleepless nights you may spend preparing for this examination, ultimately, it is only those 3 hours (at the examination hall during the Mains (Written) Examination) that are going to decide your fate. So it is very important for the candidates to prepare their subject strictly in an **Exam Oriented** manner. What is important here is not how much you have studied for the exam but how much you would be able to write at the time of the exam? So, what is important here is not to master the subject in all its possible details but rather, one should prepare the subject strictly in a professional manner keeping in mind the demands for 'conceptual clarity', 'analytical reasoning' and 'correct writing expression' as set forth by Union Public Service Commission. Only then one can hope to cover the syllabus for this exam in a time-bound manner with better chances of success. This you would realize step-by-step as you move along these notes and with vital inputs from my side at regular intervals.

Secondly, one must follow a **Theme-Based Approach** instead of Topic-Based Approach, whereby one should identify the major theme that underlies a given topic and runs through several other related sub-topics. Particularly, in light of the revised syllabus and the changing orientation of the Civil Services Examination, it has become all the more important to adopt theme-based approach because many a times questions are also asked on topics which are not mentioned in the syllabus. Though at the outset such questions may appear to be out of syllabus to the candidate but actually they are not. Questions on such topics are basically of implied nature and thus very much a part of the major theme that underlie the mentioned topic. So by following a theme-based approach we can

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cover not only the topics that are mentioned in the syllabus but also those which are implied in nature.

Thus, following a theme-based approach you would not only realize the depth of understanding that is expected from candidates at this examination but also it would keep you focused throughout your preparation. Please note that the theme-based approach would help you develop **Mental Framework** of the entire syllabus. Further, once you are confident that you have understood the broader dimensions of the theme then it would also resist your temptation to collect more and more material on the same topic. Thus, saving you both time as well as energy. You will learn this art as we proceed with the syllabus.

So, when I say **Read Relevantly**, I simply imply that given the limitations of time and energy, one should focus only on the important themes that underlie a given topic. Otherwise, given the vastness of the syllabus it would be impossible to do justice with all the topics mentioned in the syllabus in a time span of 3-4 months. Students must understand that just any information on the topic mentioned in the syllabus may not be equally important from the examination point of view. Hence we have to exercise selectivity.

To **Think Logically** implies that you must correlate your arguments in a logical manner. This will happen only if you have a thorough grasp of the concepts. So, **Conceptual Understanding** and **Conceptual Interlinking** both are very important. But equally important is its practical application in the contemporary scenario. So, whatever concepts or theories you study in the syllabus, you must also try to relate them with the contemporary society and changes therein. Please remember that conceptual clarity and its practical application is equally important at the Interview stage as well, as you may be asked to define or explain any sociological concept and to contextualize it in the light of contemporary developments, both in national and international arena.

Write Relevantly is the most critical stage of all. As I mentioned in the beginning that no matter how much you might have studied and what all sources you might have referred, ultimately it is your answer sheet that determines your destiny. Thus, your written answer must be a perfect blend of *conceptual clarity*, *conceptual interlinking* and *sociological language*. More importantly, such an answer needs to be produced on paper within the Time-and-Word Limit.

Dear Candidate, ultimately, you get only those 3 hours to convince the examiner that how dedicated you are about Civil Services and what importance does it carry in your life. So, with our **Dialectical Approach** (see page. 48) to answer writing we will make sure that all your efforts and sacrifices made

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during the course of preparation for this exam find a reflection in our answers. So along with working hard **(Hard Work)**, we also need to work smartly **(Smart Work)**. As you would proceed with the chapters you would be guided about note-making and answer-writing. Please follow the instructions sincerely.

Thank You

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Dear Candidate, after years of experience gained while preparing for this exam as well as in academics, I can say with firm conviction that this exam requires only **one and a half year** of dedicated and focused preparation. Generally those who take more time than this are the ones who either do not have the right guidance or realize the significance of these crucial aspects when it is already too late. In my view, an intensive but focused study of 3-4 months is more than sufficient to prepare Sociology optional for the civil services exam. I would also like to say that with regular answer-writing practice, a sincere candidate can easily score 250-300 marks, particularly in the new format of the Sociology Paper. I am sure that with these notes and with this approach you will start your preparations with an edge over other candidates. How far and how well you carry this advantage would largely depend upon the consistency and sincerity of your effort. Hence I request you to go through these notes step by step and follow the instructions sincerely.

all the best

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a word of caution

Dear Candidate, you just need to sincerely follow the topic-specific instructions that would be provided during the course. You will never find yourself alone while preparing this subject because I will always be there beside you with some useful tips and vital inputs. If at any stage you need some clarification, you can freely contact me on phone, email, or Facebook.

Now, you need to give at least three readings to the entire syllabus. But, these readings need to be done in a proper and professional manner. Remember, your aim is to qualify Civil Services Examination, not to master the subject. If you keep this thing in mind, I assure you that you will never waste even a single minute on unnecessary pursuits for collecting unnecessary and irrelevant material available in the market. In order to qualify this examination, all you need to do is that you must focus upon understanding the principle arguments related to the mentioned topic in the syllabus and develop you own understanding out of it. This is what I had already mentioned that conceptual clarity combined with its practical application in our daily life is the key to your success in Civil Services Examination.

As far as these three readings are concerned, I want to you to follow a very simple approach. In your first reading, just read these notes as a story. In your second reading, please underline, mark or highlight the important points and attempt the **Notes-Making Assignment** and **Writing-Skill Assignment** with a pencil. It is only in your third reading that you will refer to the suggested readings (that too only selectively), that I have mentioned wherever necessary and attempt the test given at the end of each topic in **Test Yourself** section. Please make sure that you get each and every test evaluated so that I can suggest you the corrective course of action before it is too late.

Just do this and see the difference in your preparation. You will not only be able to complete the entire syllabus in the shortest possible time but that too with conceptual clarity and good writing skills.

Wish you all the best

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Oath

- I believe that **Life** is the most beautiful gift bestowed upon us by **Mother Nature**. Mother Nature has blessed us all with Life so that we live happily and spread happiness all around. Mother Nature has empowered us all with its supreme divine power to realize our dreams. It is entirely up to us how we take care of our lives and what we make of it. We must respect Life and Mother Nature.

- I believe that there is no substitute for **Hard Work** and there is no shortcut to success. Those who tend to opt for shortcuts, their march to success is often cut short.

- I will place highest value on time and will try my best for its optimum utilization. I believe that **Time Management** is the key to success.

- I will set **Realistic Goals** and will make my best effort to achieve them.

- I believe that no success is final and no failure is fatal. It is the **Courage** to continue that counts.

- I will never, never, never, **Never Give Up**.

- I will adhere to the **Six Ethics of Life:**

Before you Pray	-	Believe
Before you Speak	-	Listen
Before you Spend	-	Earn
Before you Write	-	Think
Before you Quit	-	Try
Before you Die	-	Live

- I will be **Honest** and **Truthful** in my daily life.

- I will abide by the **Discipline**, code of conduct, terms and conditions of my institute.

(signature)

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Dear Candidate, I am also enclosing two sheets, one for your **Monthly Schedule** and another for your **Weekly Schedule** to facilitate better Time Management. You can get these sheets printed and photocopied and with regular practice you can yourself evaluate your performance.

Rule: While recording the numbers of hours in your Weekly Schedule, make sure that you deduct half an hour from each of your sitting. For example, if in one sitting you have studied for 2 hours, then, record only one and a half hours in the Weekly Schedule. If in the next sitting, you have studied for 3 hours, then, record two and a half hours only.

Dear Candidate, by following this method, you can tentatively arrive at the amount of qualitative time you are devoting to your preparations for the Civil Services Examination. By following this method, if any sincere candidate is devoting 8-10 hours per day on a regular basis, he is doing justice with his time, labour and above all, his aim.

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1. Sociology – The Discipline
Modernity and social changes in Europe and emergence of sociology
Scope of the subject and comparison with other social sciences
Sociology and common sense

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Modernity and social changes in Europe and emergence of sociology

Instructions: Dear Candidate, in this topic the examiner is primarily interested in testing your overall understanding about the process of transformation that took place in Europe in the eighteenth and nineteenth century. Further, he is interested to know that why this process of transformation, which included large-scale social, economic and political changes, is associated with the idea of modernity or why this transformation came to be identified as modernization. Last, but not the least, he wants to know that how the prevailing social conditions of those times created the need for a new discipline and how the intellectual conditions of those times contributed to the emergence of Sociology as a distinct discipline.

Theme: *Process of modernization in Europe (in the eighteenth and nineteenth century) and its impact on the emergence of sociology.*

Related Concepts: Feudalism, Renaissance, Commercial Revolution, Scientific Revolution, Reformation, Industrial Revolution, Enlightenment, French Revolution and Modernity.

Important: Dear Candidate, I have discussed this topic in detail here only to facilitate your thorough understanding and command over related concepts. But while writing an answer in the examination it would not be possible for you to incorporate each and every detail mentioned here. Hence, I suggest you to exercise selectivity in picking up only the relevant content as per the demand of the question. Given the Time and Word Limit in the examination, you will be able to write a concise and precise answer only if you remain focused on the theme.

My advice to you here is to understand and focus on the theme rather than the topic. I believe that given the changing pattern and focus of the Civil Services Examination, the topic-based approach is an outdated one because it leaves the candidate with a fragmented knowledge. While, on the other hand, a theme-based approach would help the candidate to interlink the concepts more easily. Thus, it would not only give the candidate a comprehensive understanding of the subject but also help him perform well both at the written as well as the interview stage of the examination.

To facilitate your better understanding and to enable you to interlink the concepts, these notes have been written in a continuing series of interlinked concepts and theories.

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Modernity has often been viewed as being in opposition to and representing a break from tradition. If tradition looked to the past, modernity presumably turned its eye to the future. Modern culture is frequently associated, as Swedish social theorist Goran Therborn (1995) notes, "with words like progress, advance, development, emancipation, liberation, growth, accumulation and enlightenment". One might add to this the idea that modernism is often depicted as an expansive, and thus global, phenomenon. The association with these terms suggests that modern culture possesses an optimistic orientation about our ability to collectively resolve problems, to remedy human suffering, and to enrich social life. It presupposes our ability to acquire knowledge of both the natural and the social worlds and to use this knowledge to beneficially control and mold these worlds. As Wagner (2008) sees it, "modernity is associated with the open horizon of the future, with unending progress towards a better human condition brought about by a radically novel and unique institutional arrangement". Historians as well as social theorists generally agree that from the fourteenth century to the sixteenth century A.D., Europe had been witnessing changes in its political, social and economic structures, which marked the beginning of what we call the modern period.

Before proceeding further with our discussion on modernity, we must understand that if modernity is viewed as being in opposition to and representing a break from tradition, then what was tradition like? In other words, what were the features of society of medieval Europe? [Note: Medieval period, also sometimes called as Middle Ages, roughly refers to the period from A.D. 600 to about A.D. 1500]

Society of medieval Europe (before fourteenth century) was largely feudal in character. Feudalism was the dominant system of social-economic and political organization in Western Europe from tenth to fifteenth century. It had emerged on account of downfall and decentralization of Roman Empire and absence of any central authority. The word 'feudal' comes from *feud* which originally meant a *fief* or land held on condition or service. In a feudal society, land was the source of the power. Thus, feudal system was based on allocation of land in return for service.

Feudalism was based upon a system of land tenure in which land estates of various sizes (fiefs) were given to hold (not to own) by an overlord to his vassals (knights) in return for military service. The fiefs may further be subdivided by a vassal among other knights who would then be his vassals. Such fiefs consisted of one or more *manors*, that is, *estates* with serfs whose agricultural production provided the economic basis for the existence of the feudal class. When receiving a fief a vassal took an oath of homage and fealty (fidelity) to his lord and owed him loyalty as well as a specified amount of military service. Upon the death of a vassal the fief would technically revert to the overlord, but it was a common practice for

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the eldest son to take his father's place as vassal of the lord, and thus, in effect, fiefs were passed on through primogeniture.

Estate system of social stratification was the characteristic feature of feudal European societies. Estates are defined as a system of stratification found in feudal European societies whereby one section or estate is distinguished from the other in terms of status, privileges and restrictions accorded to that estate. The feudal estates of medieval Europe had three important characteristics. Firstly, estates were legally defined. In other words, each estate had a status, in the precise sense of a legal complex of rights and duties, of privileges and obligations. The differences between estates can also be seen in the different penalties imposed for similar offences. Secondly, the estates represented a broad division of labour, and were regarded in the contemporary literature as having definite functions. 'The nobility were ordained to defend all, the clergy to pray for all, and the commons to provide food for all.' Thirdly, the feudal estates also acted as political groups.

Thus, the feudal society in Europe was a hierarchical and graded organization in which every person was allotted a position. At the top stood the king. He bestowed fiefs or estates on a number of lords who were known as dukes and earls. These lords in turn distributed a part of their fiefs among a number of lesser lords who were called barons and, in return, secured their military support. Thus the dukes and earls were the king's vassals, that is to say, they owed allegiance directly to the king. The barons were the vassals of the dukes and earls. The knights formed the lowest category of feudal lords. Usually they were the vassals of barons for whom they performed military service. Knights did not have any vassals of their own. Every feudal lord was expected to pay homage to his overlord and could then be in vested with some formal rights. Every feudal lord, except the knight, was first a vassal and then an overlord with a number of vassals under him. The relationship from top to bottom was one of allegiance. No vassal owned any land; he only held the land as of his overlord. The vassal was in every way his lord's man. He recognized no other authority than of his overlord. In time of need, for example, when the kind fought a war, he could demand military assistance from his vassals, these vassals - the dukes and the earls - demanded the same assistance from their vassals, the barons, and the barons from their vassals, the knights. Every feudal lord contributed a detachment of warriors, and thus a fighting army would be formed.

Feudal life, as explained in the previous section, was based on agriculture. The village farm was the *manor*, the size of which varied from place to place. Its centre was the manor house of the lord where he lived or which he visited, for the lords often possessed several manors. The manor included a large farm which supported all those who worked on it, a pasture area where the manor cattle grazed,

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and common woods which supplied fuel and timber. A manor always had a number of cottages where the common people lived, some workshops to provide for manor needs, and a chapel. *Manorialism* was an essential element of feudal society. It was a system of land tenure and the organizing principle of rural economy. It was characterized by the vesting of legal and economic power in a lord, supported economically from his own direct landholding and from the obligatory contributions of a legally subject part of the peasant population under his jurisdiction. These obligations could be payable in several ways, in labour, in kind or in coin, etc. *Manor* was the lowest unit of territorial organization in the feudal system in Europe. It may also be referred as the land tenure unit under manorialism. Country people often lived on a manor. On a manor there was a village, church, lord's house or castle, and the farmland upon which the people worked.

Please note that the Roman Catholic Church was as powerful an institution as feudalism in western Europe during medieval times. At the head of the Church was the Pope, who was accepted as the vicar of Christ. Popes were often stronger than the kings and could force them to obey their orders. Christianity taught that man's life on earth was not the end of existence, and that he should give up pleasures in this life in order to have a life of the spirit after death. Many Christian monks - St. Francis, St. Benedict, St. Augustine - laid great stress on purity, resistance to temptation and the pursuit of 'goodness'. Some people withdrew from worldly life and led a life of virtue and penance. Some men became monks and took the vows of obedience, poverty and chastity. Some women became nuns and lived in nunneries. The institutions where the monks lived together were called monasteries. This may remind you of the Budddhist *bhikshus* and their *viharas*. Life in monastery was well organized. Monks and nuns had to observe rigid rules of discipline. They could not marry or own property. They either worked or prayed. The slightest disobedience brought hard punishment. Some monasteries, like those funded by St. Benedict, were centres of learning and assured the members a well-ordered life. Through their strict rules of discipline, they trained groups who by their example and preaching, sought to uplift the moral life of the people, educate the laity and tend the sick. Gradually, however corruption crept into the monasteries. They acquired land and amassed wealth, helping to make the Church one of the biggest land-owners in medieval times. With cultivation and other work done by serfs, the life of many monks and nuns was no longer frugal and austere. Luxury, good food and drink, and idleness became common. Some great leaders sought to reform this state of affairs by introducing a new religious order - that of wandering monks. Members of this order had no homes but moved among the people, living on charity and setting an example of a life of chastity and self-sacrifice.

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During the early Middle Ages, Churches were the only centres of education and learning. The kinds of schools to which parents sent their children, when the Greek and Roman civilizations were still flourishing, had disappeared. The education that churches could provide was like a drop in the ocean. For a long time, monks and priests were the only literate men in Europe. Learning was kept alive by the Church and the monks in the monasteries. However, the learning fostered by the Church was a narrow type. Subjects that it taught were grammar, logic, arithmetic and theology. The only calling for which this education was suitable was that of a monk or a priest. The language of learning was Latin, which only churchmen could read. Everything was dominated by faith and anybody who appealed to reason against dogma was punished. Science had come to standstill. Magic and superstition held the day. Belief in witches was common and the punishment for witches was to burn them alive.

However, by the end of the Middle Ages (fourteenth century onwards), some changes started taking place in European societies which marked the decline of feudal system.

The revival of trade (discussed later under 'commercial revolution') was accompanied by the growth of towns. Old towns became larger and many new towns emerged, mainly as centres of manufacture and trade. Towns, often walled, gradually freed themselves from feudal control. They had their own governments and the townsmen elected their officials. They had their own militia and their own courts. Unlike the serfs, there were no restrictions on their movements. They could come and go as they pleased and buy and sell property. Towns provided asylum to serfs who escaped from feudal oppression. The towns encouraged the cultivation of cash crops needed for manufactures, and peasants received their payments in money. The peasants could now pay their dues to the lord in cash rather than by labour.

With the growth of trade, there was increasing use of money. Money had little use in feudal societies. A feudal manor was more or less self-sufficient for its needs. There was very little of buying and selling and whatever there was, was done through barter. The use of money indicated far-reaching changes in economy. In feudal societies, the indictor of a man's wealth was land. Some people had wealth, particularly the Church and sometimes the nobles, in the form of gold and silver, but it was idle wealth. It could not be used to make more wealth. With the growth of trade and manufactures, this changed, marking the beginning of the transition from feudal economy to capitalist economy in which wealth is used to make a profit. This is done by investing money in business, in trade and industry. The profits made are re-invested to make further profits. Such wealth or money is called 'capital'. Money, not the landed property, increasingly became the measure

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of man's wealth. In feudal societies, there were three classes of people: the prayers, that is, the clergy who prayed, the soldiers or the knights who fought, and workers or the peasants who worked for both the prayers and the soldiers. With the growth of trade a new class emerged - the 'middle class' - comprising mainly the merchants. Even though small in number, they began to play an important role in society because of the wealth they possessed. This early phase of capitalism is known as 'mercantile capitalism'. Thus mercantile capitalism is a system of trading for profit, typically in commodities produced by non-capitalist production methods.

Simultaneous with these developments changes took place in the system of manufacturing goods. In the early medieval period, most of the non-agricultural products required by the peasants were produced in the household of the peasant and by serfs, who were skilled craftsmen, for the lord. With the growth of towns, many of these activities shifted to towns where people skilled in particular crafts organized themselves into 'guilds'. Each craft guild had master craftsmen, journeyman and apprentices. To learn a craft, a person joined a master as an apprentice or learner. After having learned the craft, he worked as a journeyman with the master on a wage or, if he had mastered the craft, he would himself become a master craftsman. The units of production were small, consisting of three or four people, and each unit had a shop to sell its produce. There were no inequalities within a unit or between units of the same guild. The guild system, was not suited to the requirements of large scale production required by an expanding market for goods, and the system began to decline. Inequities appeared with the system, with masters refusing to let journeymen become masters and paying them low wages. With the introduction of 'the putting out system', their independence declined. The merchant, under this system, would bring the master craftsmen the raw materials, the craftsmen would work with their tools as before in their homes and the produce would be taken away by the merchant who had supplied them with raw materials. Thus, in effect, unlike before, the craftsmen did not own what they produced. They were increasingly reduced to the position of wage-earners, except that they still owned the tools used by them and worked at home.

Subsequently, this system gave way to the factory system (discussed later under 'industrial revolution') under which the production was carried out in a building owned by the capitalist with the help of machines also owned by him. The workers, owing nothing, worked only for wages. In industries, such as mining and metal-working, the new system came into being early. The period saw tremendous expansion of manufactures. This was accompanied by a growing differentiation in towns and the emergence of working class.

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As a result of these developments, the feudal system broke down. The towns which were free from the control of the lords began to undermine the stability of the feudal society. In course of time, towns became very prosperous. Kings who were quite powerless in the feudal system began to take the help and support of townsmen to increase their power and to enforce their will over the lords. The kings also started having their own armies and thus freed themselves from their earlier dependence on the lords for soldiers. This led to the emergence of strong nation-states. Thus, feudalism began to decline although it was finally ended in most countries only in the 18th and 19th centuries. In its place, a new system of society (Capitalist Society) began to emerge.

However, feudalism served its purpose of bringing a measure of orderliness, safety and security to medieval life. It allowed social and economic activity to run its normal course. But feudalism had also another side to it. It developed, and was dependent on, a rigid class system. Man was divided from man, class from class, and this stood in the way of political unity. The nobles looked down upon the common man, and their inherited authority brought with it one-man rule and oppression. The lords were often too powerful for the kings to control and fought among themselves for small selfish ends. The king had no contact with the common man, who was left entirely to the mercy of his lord, and the lord was usually irresponsible and unmindful of the welfare of common people. The feudal system also led to economic stagnation. The wealth produced by the peasants and the artisans was wastefully consumed by the feudal lords, in luxurious living and in wars. Individual enterprise and initiative were all but unknown. Further, the desire for the new lands and riches encouraged the lords and leaders of the Church to fight the 'holy wars', or the Crusades.

The medieval period, lasting roughly from fifth through the thirteenth centuries A.D. have often been called the "Dark Ages" and to some extent it was truly so. The helplessness of the common man, the arbitrary rule of the king and the barons and the absence of national unity were some of the aspects of the darker side of those times. Education was very uncommon and people led a miserable life. The prevailing European view of the "Dark Ages" was that civilization had stagnated. Not only were scientific and artistic advances rare, but much of the knowledge of the classical period was lost. Cultural activities came to an end with the arrival of invading "barbarians", and the western Roman Empire disintegrated into thousands of isolated villages where there was little interest in, or time for, study. Memory of the classical period faded except in a few sequestered monasteries, where ancient texts were stored and in the Islamic world, where scholars translated Greek texts into Arabic. During the "Dark Ages" the overwhelming majority of Europeans were crude illiterates, and even educated

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people knew less about science, medicine, and art than their counterparts in the classical period.

Task:

1. Notes-Making Assignment

Please note that in the notes-making assignment you have to identify only those points which constitute the central theme of the given topic. To gain an edge over other candidates, you need to continuously enrich your notes with vital but relevant inputs. For this you may also include here some recent data, case studies or examples. For this you may refer newspapers (*The Hindu*, *The Times of India*, *The Indian Express*), magazines (*Yojana*, *Kurushetra*, *Frontline*, *The Economic and Political Weekly*, *Mainstream*) and government publications (*India Year Book*, *The Economic Survey*, *The Census of India*) etc.

Please take this exercise seriously because you would need to refer these self-made notes only just a couple of days before exam. So, be as brief and precise as possible. The first exercise is done for you to help you understand the approach as well as the methodology better.

Identify five important features of feudal society (only in the form of Pointers).

- Dominant system of social-economic and political organization in Medieval Europe
- Based upon a system of land tenure (King → Dukes and Earls→ Barons → Knights → Peasants)
- Characterized by estate system of stratification (Clergy, Nobility and Commoners)
- Largely subsistent economy characterized by the absence of a strong central authority
- Started declining fourteenth century onwards on account of revival of trade and commerce and emergence of urban centres (Commercial Revolution)

2. Writing-Skill Assignment

Now, once you have made your notes on the given topic in the pointers form, it is time to practice writing short notes so as to sharpen your answer-writing skills. Dear Candidate, I repeat that no matter for how many hours or years you may have studied but ultimately it is only those 3 hours in the examination hall that would decide your fate. Hence I always suggest my students to continuously monitor their

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progress in writing-skills by regularly writing answers and getting it evaluated by me.

The first exercise is done for you.

Write a short note on feudalism. (100-120 words)

Feudalism was the dominant system of social-economic and political organization in Medieval Europe. It was based upon a system of land tenure in which land estates of various sizes (fiefs) were given to hold (not to own) by an overlord to his vassals (knights) in return for military service. Estate system of social stratification was the characteristic feature of feudal European societies whereby one section or estate was distinguished from the other in terms of status, privileges and restrictions accorded to that estate. Feudal society was largely subsistent and stagnant economy characterized by the absence of a strong central authority. However, feudal social order started declining fourteenth century onwards on account of revival of trade and commerce and emergence of urban centres in western European societies. (Total Words: 126)

3. For Interview

Questions may be asked on the following to test your conceptual clarity and grasp of the subject.

Feudalism * Estate system of stratification * Manorialism * Factors responsible for the decline of feudalism * Karl Marx on feudalism

However, fourteenth century onwards the society in Europe started changing. A number of interrelated developments took place in the period from about fourteenth to seventeenth century which marked the beginning of modern age.

Anthony Giddens also states in *The Consequences of Modernity* (1990) that modernity refers to 'modes of social life or organization which emerged in Europe from about the seventeenth century onwards and which subsequently became more or less worldwide in their influence'. According to Giddens, modernity represents a sharp qualitative break from previous traditional social orders.

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Let us first understand that what were these changes which took place from about fourteenth to seventeenth century in Europe and marked the beginning of modern age? How the new social order which emerged in Europe from about the seventeenth century onwards was qualitatively different from the previous traditional social orders.

Historians generally agree that from fourteenth to sixteenth centuries, Europe had been witnessing changes in its social, economic and political structures, which marked the beginning of the modern period. In the next section, we will learn about the various social, economic and political changes that Europe witnessed in the form of Renaissance, Commercial Revolution, Scientific Revolution, Reformation, Enlightenment, Industrial Revolution, French Revolution, etc.

One of the first developments that marked the beginning of a new era was the *Renaissance*. The medieval Dark Age was followed by the Renaissance, coming in the fourteenth century and lasting to the end of the sixteenth century. The Renaissance refers, in a literal sense, to the intellectual rebirth of Europe as people tried to recapture the artistic, philosophical, scientific, and commercial glory of the 'classical period'. It is important to emphasize that the conventional nineteenth-century assessment was that the Renaissance had been a period of rediscovery. There was a great appreciation for the cultural accomplishments of the Greeks and Romans and a genuine desire to replicate those accomplishments and, hence, to recapture the cultural glory of earlier times. [Please note that the "Classical Period" of Western history, the era of Greece and, later, Rome, lasted roughly from the eighth century B.C. until the fourth century A.D. Many note-worthy scientific and artistic advances were made during that period. To name just a few: geometry was developed; money came into circulation; trade expanded; accounting practices emerged; shipbuilding improved; the Phoenician alphabet was made more precise with the inclusion of vowels; literature was born; comedies and tragedies were written; amphitheaters were constructed; great philosophical debates raged; engineers achieved wondrous feats (literally, the "wonders of the ancient world"); monuments were built; medicine advanced; libraries were constructed; elements of democratic governmental forms came into being; and education expanded. In short, civilization flowered. Advances were intermittent, to be sure, but over time the total stock of knowledge increased and diffused widely to other parts of the world. At least it was the nineteenth-century European view that the classical period of the Greeks and Romans marked such a flowering of civilization.]

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The term 'Renaissance' literally means rebirth and is, in a narrow sense, used to describe the revival of interest in the learning of the classical civilizations of Greece and Rome. This revival first began in Italy when a number of scholars from Constantinople migrated to Italy and a number of Italian scholars went to Constantinople and other cities of the old Byzantine empire in search of Greek classics. The Renaissance emerged in Italy roughly between A.D. 1300 and A.D. 1550 and then spread to northern Europe during the first half of the 16th century. The renaissance started in Italy because of several factors. First, Italy always had a cultural advantage over the rest of Europe because its geography made it the natural gateway between the East and the West. Venice, Genoa, Milan, Pisa and Florence traded uninterruptedly with the Asian countries and maintained a vibrant urban society. The Italian cities had grown up in an atmosphere of freedom from feudal control. Freedom encouraged thinking and a spirit of adventure. The rulers of the Italian states were patrons of learning and the arts.

During the 13th and the 14th centuries, mercantile cities expanded to become powerful city states dominating the political and economic life of the surrounding countryside. Italian aristocrats customarily lived in urban centres rather than in rural castles unlike their counterparts in northern Europe and consequently became fully involved in urban public affairs. The neo-rich mercantile communities which came to be known as the *bourgeoisie* tried to gain the status of aristocracy. Merchant families tried to imitate an aristocratic life-style. Their wealth and profession became an important factor for the development of education in Italy. There was not only a demand for education for the development of skills in reading and accountancy, necessary to become successful merchants, but also the richest and most prominent families looked for able teachers who would impart to their offspring the knowledge and skills necessary to argue well in the public arena. Consequently Italy produced a large number of educators, many of whom not only taught students but also demonstrated their learning in the production of political and ethical treaties and works of literature.

Another reason, why the late medieval Italy became the birthplace of an intellectual and artistic renaissance, was because it had a far greater sense of rapport with the classical past than any other region of Europe. In Italy the classical past appeared immensely relevant as ancient Roman monuments were present all over the peninsula and the ancient Latin literature referred to cities and sites that Italians recognized as their own. Further, Italian renaissance was also facilitated by the patronage that it received in abundance. The wealthy cities of Italy vied with each other to construct splendid public monuments and support writers whose role was to glorify the urban republic in their writing and speeches. As a result, hundreds of classical writings, unknown to Europeans for centuries, were circulating first in Italy and then other parts of Europe. The interest in classical

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learning and in other achievements of the civilizations of Greece and Rome deeply influenced Europeans. The Renaissance, however, was not, as mentioned earlier, a mere revival of ancient learning and knowledge of the achievements of ancient Greece and Rome. It was marked by a series of new developments in the field of art, literature, religion, philosophy, science and politics.

The early phase of Renaissance was described as a period of revival as it concentrated in reviving the old learning which was disseminated through the traditional methods. The latter phase was described as a period of innovation as much new knowledge was generated during this period, which laid the foundation for the growth of modern thought. This new knowledge was spread by a new medium, i.e print. This meant that a large number of people and countries could share the knowledge and debate the changes. Though, the study of classical and Christian antiquity existed before the renaissance, there was a significant difference between the learning of the middle age scholars and the renaissance thinkers. The renaissance thinkers recovered the works of lesser-known scholars and made them popular along side the more famous ones. The Greek scientific and the philosophical treatises were made available to the westerners in Latin translations. The renaissance thinkers used classical texts in new ways such as to reconsider their preconceived notions and alter their mode of expression.

So, rational thinking tempered with a spirit of scientific enquiry about the universe and the existence of humanity in it, became the important characteristic of the renaissance outlook. These rational ideas also helped in developing a society that was increasingly non-ecclesiastical in comparison to the culture of the Middle ages. The intellectual and cultural life of Europe for centuries had been dominated by the Catholic Church. The renaissance undermined this domination. The revival of pre-Christian classical learning and of interest in the cultural achievements of ancient Greece and Rome were, in themselves, also an important factor in undermining the domination of the Church.

The chief characteristic of the Renaissance way of thinking was *humanism*. It was the heart and soul of the Renaissance. Basically, it meant a decisive shift in concern for human as distinct from divine matters. Humanism was a system of views which extolled man, stressed his essential worth and dignity, expressed deep faith in his tremendous creative potential, and proclaimed freedom of the individual and inalienable rights of the individual. It was centered on the man of flesh and blood with all his earthly joys and sorrows, opposed to religious asceticism and defended his right to pleasure and the satisfaction of earthly desires and requirements. It meant the glorification of the human and natural as opposed to the divine and other-worldly. The humanists rejected and even ridiculed religious asceticism, mortification of the flesh and withdrawal from the world. They urged

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man to seek joy on this earth rather than in an afterlife which the Church advocated. Their works were permeated with the faith that a man with an active mind and body was capable of knowing and controlling the world, of performing miracles and fashioning his own happiness. The proper study of Mankind, it was asserted, is Man, Humanity rather than Divinity. The Renaissance men, hungered after more knowledge. They came to feel that human life is important, that man is worthy of study and respect, that there should be efforts to improve life on this earth. Because of this interest in human affairs, the study of literature and history became major areas of study. Literature and history came to be called the 'humanities' which were primarily concerned with understanding the affairs of man in his earthly life, not with life after death.

Task:

1. Notes-Making Assignment

Identify the main characteristics of Renaissance. (only Pointers)

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2. Writing-Skill Assignment

'Renaissance marked a qualitative shift in the history of western European society'. Discuss. (150 words)

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3. For Interview

Renaissance	*	Factors responsible for its origin in Italy

Another development which marked the beginning of the modern age was the 'commercial revolution', fostered by a series of 'voyages of discovery'. The "Commercial revolution" refers to the expansion of trade and commerce that took place from the 15th century onwards. It was of such a large scale and organized manner that it is called a Revolution. The Commercial revolution signaled a shift from the largely subsistence and stagnant economy of medieval Europe to a more dynamic and world wide system. This expansion was as a result of the initiative taken by certain European countries to develop and consolidate their economic and political power. These countries were Portugal, Spain, Holland and England.

The same spirit of curiosity that led some of Europe's Renaissance men to effect new developments in art, literature, science, and religion led others to adventure and the discovery of new lands. The main motivation behind these adventures was the profits that trade with the East would bring. Earlier, Europe trade with the Oriental or Eastern countries like India and China was transacted by land routes. The northern Italian cities of Venice and Genoa were the major centres of trade. The result of the Italian monopoly was that the prices of goods like spices and silks imported form the East was extremely high. For example, after his first voyage to India, Vasco Da Gama found that the price of pepper in Calicut was one-

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twenty sixth of the price prevailing in Venice. The prosperity of the Italian cities that had grown rich from their trade with eastern countries aroused the envy of the other European nations; they longed to have a share in the trade.

But after 1453, the Turks cut off this trade through Asia Minor and if the Europeans were to continue to have spices, these products had to be brought by a different route. Finding new routes was a challenge to the adventurous sailors of the Renaissance. Thus, a shift from land routes to sea-routes began. Helped by some remarkable inventions, daring sailors sailed for distant lands. Invention of mariner's compass, astrolabe and newly prepared maps and guidebooks greatly facilitated these voyages. With the help of the compass, navigators determined the directions on high seas. The Astrolabe helped in determining the latitude of a particular area. These voyages were financed by rulers and merchants who sponsored the costly voyages of the sea-farers for the profits that the voyages would bring. The discoveries of the sea-farers extended the knowledge about the world and the old maps which were both inaccurate and incomplete had to be redrawn.

The voyages and discoveries of Columbus, Vasco da Gama and Magellan changed man's idea of the world, revolutionized trade and started waves of colonization that have determined the course of world history ever since. Portugal and Spain were among the first Europe countries, which financed these explorations and discoveries. Britain, France and Holland soon followed Spain and Portugal. Soon parts of Asia, Africa, Malacca, the Spice Islands, West Indies, N. America and S. America came under the control of Spain, Portugal, Britain, France and Holland. Commerce expanded into a world enterprise. The monopoly of the Italian cities was destroyed. European markets were flooded with new commodities; spice & textiles from the East, tobacco from N. America, Cocoa, Chocolate & quinine from S. America, ivory and, above all, human slaves from Africa. With the discovery of Americas, the range of trade widened. Formerly, the items sought for were spices and cloth, but later, gold and silver were added to the list. As the commercial revolution progressed, the position of Portugal and Spain declined. Britain, France and Holland came to dominate Europe and the world. This marked the early phase of capitalism known as 'mercantile capitalism'. It was characterized by growth of trade and commerce and generating profits through trade.

Subsequently, this accumulated wealth or capital was further reinvested in land & agriculture (scientific farming and sheep-rearing) to generate further profits. This led to the transformation of agriculture in Europe, called as 'agricultural revolution'. The agrarian revolution saw the transformation of a system of subsistence into a system of surplus by production of cash crops for the

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market, the surplus being made possible by reformed and mechanized cultivation. So, mercantile capitalism was followed by the capitalistic transformation of agriculture or agrarian capitalism. The first sign of capitalistic transformation of agriculture manifested itself in England in the form of land enclosures which began to occur in the rural economy as early as 1560, when landholders began to assert rights of private property over feudal land. It has been called by the historians as Enclosure Movement. Essentially, the enclosure movement can be described as a system whereby tenant holdings in feudal land and agriculture became enclosed and made available for the private use of landholder. As, a result peasant families were evicted from their holdings and in many cases thrown off the land. While many of the first enclosures were initiated by landlords in order to appropriate tenant holdings, in latter stages of change they were used to make way for sheep pastures. However, by 1710 the first Enclosure Bill appeared which legalized the enclosure of tenant holdings by Parliamentary Acts. With parliamentary approval, enclosures could proceed at a more advanced rate and eventually became commonplace by mid century as conversions became more rapid. By 1800, 4000 Parliamentary Acts had been passed and in excess of six million acres of land had been enclosed.

As the pace of economic change began to intensify, the rate of enclosures accelerated to the point where the displaced population of agricultural workers began to increase dramatically and this began to mobilize a transfer of the population to the centers of industry. As statutory enactments gave the power of eviction to landlords, legal proceedings multiplied the rate of local evictions and at the same time restricted the use of pastures from domestic animals, prohibited the use of arable land from tenant agriculture, and displaced agricultural workers and hereditary tenants. In practice, enclosures became a society-wide depopulation movement fueled by mass evictions and foreclosures which coercively separated peasants from their means of livelihood by removing them from their own agricultural holdings. As serfs were forced off the land, landlords were able to assert rights of modern private property over land to which they previously held only feudal title. This hastened the transformation of land into a commercial commodity, first by subjecting it to buying and selling, and second by extending its capacity to produce money rent. Under these circumstances, customary rights and obligations in land began to be forcibly dissolved, and with this went the bonds connecting peasants to the land through heredity tenure and leasehold. As soon as money rents replaced labour rent, peasants were forced to focus their attention on their own holdings, making money rent a precondition to economic survival. Those who were unable to pay were eventually ruined or evicted. At this point it became possible to express the value of land in money, and this led to the transformation of land into private property and eventually a commercial commodity. As land became subject to buying and selling, the economic balance between serfs and

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landlords was upset and feudal obligations in land and livelihood began to deteriorate.

As the breakdown of feudal obligations in land continued, it began to place the serf population under new forces of social differentiation and fragmentation. This put the serf population at the disposal of the new forces of production, which put into play a massive demographic transfer of the agricultural population into the industrial centers, bringing about a more complete transition to a new category of labour based on wages. At this stage, the flow of population from the old feudal economies to the new economies of industry became a more urgent fact of economic change, and this began to complete the process of transforming the agricultural worker of previous centuries into the wage labourer of the industrial economy. By 1840 the transition to an industrial economy was more or less complete. Several consequences ensued as a result of the displacement of the serf population from the rural economies. Firstly, as the transfer of the population proceeded, it brought about a massive social displacement which dispersed families, uprooted local economies and undermined regional modes of life and livelihood. Secondly, it dissolved the serf's relationship to the land and altered the system of economic livelihood, forcing serfs to sell their labour for a wage, and severing the serf's feudal relation to the agricultural means of production. Thirdly, the shift to an industrial economy meant that wage labourers were unable to employ the means of production on their own as they once did in a feudal economy, and as a result they lost control over the ability to put the means of production to work. Further, as the shift to an industrial economy became finalized, the old class structure of feudal society was replaced by the formation of a new commercial class who were at the center of power and industry. This began to bring about the transfer of the ownership of the means of production to the commercial classes and, consequently, as the means of production fell into private hands, it became the property of one class.

During much of the eighteenth century, the last remnants of the old economic order were crumbling under the impact of the industrial revolution. In historical terminology, industrial revolution means primarily the period of British History from the middle of the eighteenth century to the middle of nineteenth century. England in the 18^{th} century was in the most favourable position for an industrial revolution. Through her overseas trade, including trade in slaves, she had accumulated vast profits which could provide the necessary capital. In the trade rivalries of European countries, she had emerged as an unrivalled power. She had acquired colonies which ensured a regular supply of raw materials. The term 'industrial revolution' was first used in the 1880s to denote the sudden acceleration of technical developments by the application of steam power to machines which replaced tools. The term got popularized when Arnold Toynbee's

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Industrial Revolution appeared in 1884. As discussed earlier, the new system of society which had been emerging in Europe from the 15th century was called *capitalism.* Under capitalism, the instruments and the means by which goods are produced are owned by private individuals and the production is carried out for making profit. The workers under this system do not own anything but work for a wage. The owners of wealth under capitalism who are called capitalists do not keep their wealth or consume it or use it for purposes of display but invest it to make profit. Goods are produced for sale in the market with a view to making profit. This system is in marked contrast with the feudal system in which goods were produced for local use and the investment of wealth for making profit did not take place. Economic life under feudalism was static as goods were produced for local consumption and there was no incentive to produce more by employing better means of producing goods for a bigger market. In contrast, the economy under capitalism was fast moving with the aim of producing more and more goods for bigger markets so that more profits could be made.

The desire to produce more goods at low cost to make higher profits led to the Industrial Revolution and further growth of capitalism. The Industrial Revolution began in England in about 1750. It was then that machines began to take over some of the works of men and animals in the production of goods and commodities. That is why we often say that the Industrial Revolution was the beginning of a 'machine age'. You have read before that the guild system had given way to the 'domestic' or the 'putting-out' system. In the 18th century, the domestic system had become obsolete. It started giving way to a new system called the 'factory system'. In place of simple tools and the use of animal and manual power, new machines and steam power came to be increasingly used. Many new cities sprang up and artisans and dispossessed peasants went there to work. Production was now carried on in a factory (in place of workshops in homes), with the help of machines (in place of simple tools). Facilities for production were owned and managed by *capitalists*, the people with money to invest in further production. Everything required for production was provided by the capitalists for the workers who were brought together under one roof. Everything belonged to the owner of the factory, including the finished product, and workers worked for wages. This system, known as the factory system, brought on the *Industrial Revolution.* This phase of capitalism is known as industrial capitalism. Industrial capitalism is capitalism's classical or stereotypical form.

The eighteenth century saw the growth of free labour and more competitive manufacturing. The cotton industry was the first to break the hold of the guilds and chartered corporations, but with each decade, other industries were subjected to the liberating effects of free labour, free trade, and free production. By the time large-scale industry emerged – first in England, then in France, and later in

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Germany – the economic reorganization of Europe had been achieved. Large-scale industry and manufacture simply accelerated the transformations in society that had been occurring for decades. These transformations involved a profound organization of society. Labour was liberated from the land; wealth and capital existed independently of the large noble estates; large-scale industry accelerated urbanization of the population; the extension of competitive industry hastened the development of new technologies; increased production encouraged the expansion of markets and world trade for securing raw resources and selling finished goods; religious organizations lost much of their authority in the face of secular economic activities; family structure was altered as people moved from rural to urban areas; law became as concerned with regularizing the new economic processes as with preserving the privilege of the nobility; and the old political regimes legitimated by "divine right" successively became less tenable.

Thus, the emergence of a capitalist economic system inexorably destroyed the last remnant of the feudal order and the transitional mercantile order of restrictive guilds and chartered corporations. Such economic changes greatly altered the way people lived, created new social classes (such as the bourgeoisie and urban proletariat), and led not only to a revolution of ideas but also to a series of political revolutions. These changes were less traumatic in England than in France, where the full brunt of these economic forces clashed with the Old Regime. It was in this volatile mixture of economic changes, coupled with the scientific revolution of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, that political and intellectual revolutions were to be spawned. And out of these combined revolutions, sociology emerged.

The 'Renaissance' period also saw the beginning of the 'Scientific Revolution'. It is an undeniable fact that, if we want to seek out the cause of the Scientific Revolution, we must look for them among the wider changes taking place in that sea-change of European history known as the Renaissance. The Scientific Revolution cannot be explained without reference to the Renaissance. The Scientific Revolution, like the Protestant Reformation, can and should be seen as one of the outcomes of the Renaissance. The Scientific Revolution marked an era of description and criticism in the field of science. It was a clear break from the past, a challenge to old authority. The impact of the scientific revolution was crucial not just in changing material life, but also man's ideas about Nature and Society. It is worth noting that science does not develop independent of society, rather, it develops in response to human needs. For example, various vaccines were developed out of the necessity to cure diseases. Apart from influencing the physical or material life of society, science is intimately connected with ideas. The general intellectual atmosphere existing in society influences the development of science. Similarly, new developments in science can also change the attitudes and

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beliefs of people about nature and society. New scientific ideas influenced scholars to think about society in new ways. The emergence of sociology in Europe owes a great deal to the ideas and discoveries contributed by science.

As stated earlier, the medieval society was characterized by the feudal system. The Church was the epicenter of authority and learning. Knowledge was largely religious in nature. Nothing could challenge the 'dogmas' or rigid beliefs of the Church. New, daring ideas could not flower in such an atmosphere. Thus the development of science was restricted mainly to improvement in the techniques of production. However, the renaissance thinkers rejected the blind acceptance of authority. They asserted that knowledge could be gained 'by going out and studying mentally and manually the Book of Nature', and not by speculation. This new outlook marked a break with the past and prepared the way for the advancement of science. It was summed up by **Francis Bacon**, an English philosopher, who said that knowledge could be gained only by observation and experimentation. According to Bacon, he who seeks knowledge should *first look at things that happen in the world around him*. He should then ask himself *what causes these things to happen* and, after he has formed a theory or belief, as to the possible cause, he should experiment. *The experiment is to test his belief* and see whether the assumed cause does, in fact, produce the result he has observed. Bacon believed that the 'true and lawful end of the sciences is that human life be enriched by new discoveries and powers.'

One of the first achievements of the Renaissance in science was in astronomy. The year 1543 marked the development of modern astronomical studies with the publication of Copernicus' *Six Books Concerning the Revolutions of the Heavenly Spheres*. **Copernicus** (1473-1543) was a polish scholar who lived in Italy for many years. His work in mathematics and astronomy demolished the hypothesis of the geocentric (Earth-centred) universe derived from Ptolemy and other astronomers of the past. In its place he advanced the revolutionary new hypothesis of the heliocentric (Sun-centred) universe. This meant that the earth moved round a fixed Sun and not the other way round. The Copernican hypothesis had radical implications. It destroyed the idea of the earth's uniqueness by suggesting that it acted like other heavenly bodies. More importantly, his theory contradicted the earlier notions about the centrality of the earth to the cosmic order. The very idea of an open universe of which the earth was but a small part shattered the earlier view of a closed universe created and maintained in motion by God. This was an important break with the ancient system of thought. For over a thousands years, it was believed that the earth was the centre of the universe. It was one of the basic dogmas of the philosophers of the time. Its refutation was an attack on the conception of the universe held by the Church. This was, therefore, condemned as a heresy. Copernicus' book was published in 1543, the year in

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which he died. He had hesitated from publishing it for fear of the hostility of the Church. About half a century after the publication of Copernicus' book, in 1600, Giordano Bruno was burnt at the stake on the charge of heresy. He had advocated ideas which were based on Copernicus' view of the universe.

The next major steps toward the conception of a heliocentric system were taken by the Danish astronomer **Tycho Brahe** (1546-1601) and the German astronomer **Johannes Kepler** (1571-1630). Tycho Brahe constructed the most accurate tables of astronomical observations. After his death, these observations came into the possession of Kepler, who after much work, agreed to the heliocentric theory, though he abandoned the Copernican concept of circular orbits. The mathematical relationship that emerged from a consideration of Brahe's observations suggested that the orbits of the planets were elliptical. Kepler published his findings in 1609 in a book entitled *On the Motion of Mars*. Thus, he solved the problems of planetary orbits by using the Copernican theory and Brahe's empirical data. However, in the same year when Kepler published his book, an Italian scientist **Galileo Galilei** (1564-1642), first turned a telescope invented by him on to the sky. Through this instrument he saw stars where none had been known to exist, mountains on the moon, spots moving across the sun and the moon and the orbiting Jupiter. Some of Galileo's colleagues at the University of Padua were so unnerved that they refused to look through the telescope because it revealed the heaven to be different from the teachings of the Church and the Ptolemaic theories. Galileo published his findings in numerous works, the most famous of which is his *Dialogues on the Two Chief Systems of the World* (1632). This book brought down on him the condemnation of the Roman Catholic Church. His life was spared only after he agreed to withdraw his views. He spent the rest of his life virtually under house arrest.

Isaac Newton was born in England in 1642, the year Galileo died. He solved the major remaining problems on the planetary motions and established a base for the modern physics. Much of the researches of Newton were based on the work of Galileo and other predecessors. In 1687, he published his treatise, *The Mathematical Principles of Natural Philosophy*. In this work he proposed that the planets and, in fact, all other particles in the universe moved through the force of mutual attraction, a law which came to be known as the Law of Gravitation. In this way, Newton combined mathematics and physics for the study of astronomy. Incidentally, he was preceded in this by **Varahamihira** and **Aryabhatta** in the 5^{th} and 6^{th} centuries A.D. in India.

The modern age of science that began with these Renaissance scientists not only increased man's knowledge but also established a method of study that could be applied to other branches of knowledge. Significant discoveries, for example

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were made in the study of the human body and circulation of the blood which helped to fight many superstitions. In 1543, the year in which Copernicus' book was published, **Vesalius**, a Belgian, published his profusely illustrated *De Humani Corporis Fabrica*. Based on his study of the dissections of the human body, this book provided the first complete description of the anatomy of the human body. **Servetus**, a Spaniard, published a book explaining the circulation of blood. He was condemned to death for questioning the Church belief in Trinity. A completed account of the constant process of circulation of blood, from the heart to all parts of the body and back to the heart was given by Harvey, an Englishman, in about 1610. This knowledge helped to start a new approach to the study of the problems of health and disease. It is important to remember that what the Renaissance scientists began learning by questioning, observation, and experimentation is the method that scientists continue to use even today. This is scientific method. It is by applying this method that our knowledge has grown so greatly. The knowledge produced during scientific revolution deeply influenced the attitudes and beliefs of people about nature and society. New scientific ideas influenced scholars to think about society in new ways. This is very important. Please keep this in mind when we discuss the ideas of enlightenment scholars later.

As mentioned earlier, that in medieval Europe Church was the epicenter of authority and learning. Knowledge was largely religious in nature. Nothing could challenge the 'dogmas' or rigid beliefs of the Church. Any idea or action which challenged the authority of the Church was, therefore, condemned as a heresy. This newly emerging scientific knowledge, which was based on empirical observation and experimentation, was not only different but also contradictory to the many teachings of the Church. This stimulated the process of 'reformation' in the religious sphere of the European society. Thus, European people with new spirit of inquiry and thought started questioning the superstitious beliefs and malpractices of the Catholic Church.

The term 'Reformation' refers to two major developments in the history of Europe towards the later part of the Renaissance. The first was the Protestant reformation which resulted in a split in Christianity and the secession of a large number of countries from the Roman Catholic Church and establishment of separate Churches in those countries, generally on national lines. The second development concerned reforms within the Roman Catholic Church, generally referred to as Catholic Reformation or Counter Reformation. But Reformation was not merely a religious movement. It was intimately connected with, and was in fact a part of, the social and political movement of the period which brought about the end of the medieval period and the emergence of the modern world.

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The Catholic Church, during the early medieval period, had become a vast hierarchical organization headed by the Pope in Rome. The Pope was the supreme authority over the entire hierarchy and he exercised this authority directly. The position of the Pope is often described by the phrase 'papal monarchy'. Systematic efforts were made to extend the authority of the Church over everyone, high or low, making an oral confession of his sins to a priest at least once a year and suffering the punishment imposed was made obligatory for everyone. The people who did not follow this were excommunicated. An excommunicated person was supposed to have been temporarily consigned to hell. If he died, his body could not be buried with the prescribed rituals. Other Christians were forbidden from associating with him. An important component of the religious thinking propagated by the Church was the theory of sacraments. A sacrament was defined as an instrument by which divine grace is communicated to men. The sacraments were regarded indispensable for securing God's grace and there was no salvation without them. Another was the theory of priesthood. It was held that the priest who was ordained by a bishop (who was confirmed by the Pope) was the inheritor of a part of the authority conferred by Christ on Peter. The priest, according to this theory had the power to co-operate with God in performing certain miracles and in releasing sinner from the consequences of their sins. Besides the sacraments, various other beliefs came to be accepted.

Reformation is often described as a revolt against abuses which had grown in the Catholic Church. Some of the priests and higher-ups in the Church hierarchy received their appointments through corrupt means. Many such appointees were utterly ignorant. They led lives of luxury and immorality. Religious offices were sold to the highest bidder and those who bought positions after spending money made good by taking high fees for the services they performed. The Popes and the higher clergy lived like princes. A new abuse was the sale of letters which remitted punishments of the sinners who bought them, both in this life and after their death in purgatory. Normally, the priests imposed a penance or punishment on a person who had sinned and he was required to perform a special service or make a pilgrimage to a holy place. But increasingly sinners with enough money could be freed from doing penance for their sins by paying the clergy for a "Letter of Indulgence". The sale of indulgences which began to be considered as passports to heaven became one of the major immediate issues which caused the protestant Reformation. Besides the sale of indulgences, one could now gain salvation in exchange for fees. The priests, the bishops and the wandering monks could pronounce a marriage lawful or unlawful. By payment of fees, the problem could be solved. There were fees for every transaction in life, from birth to death, fees for the peace of the soul and fees for the souls of the people dead long ago. The wandering monks when they wanted to, heard confessions, awarded punishments for sins and remitted the punishments for fees.

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The Protestant Revolution can be said to have begun in 1517 when **Martin Luther**, a monk of the Order of St. Augustine, nailed his ninety-five theses or statements which attacked the sale of indulgences, on the door of the Church in Wittenberg in Germany. He challenged people to come and hold debates with him on his theses and sent copies of his theses to his friends in a number of cities. During the next two years Luther wrote a series of pamphlets. He knew that his doctrines could not be reconciled with those of the Catholic Church and that he had no alternative but to break with the Catholic Church. In 1520, the Pope ordered him to recant within sixty days or be condemned as a heretic. Luther burnt the proclamation of the Pope in public. During this period, he was protected by the ruler of Saxony who was his friend. Many rulers in Germany were hostile to the Church and when Luther was excommunicated, he remained unharmed. During the next 25 years, he occupied himself with the task of building an independent German Church, and in expounding his doctrine. He rejected the entire system of the hierarchy of the Catholic Church, introduced German as the language of Church services, abolished the special status of priests as representatives of God on earth, eliminated most of the sacraments, and emphasized faith rather than pilgrimages. He gave the highest priority to the supreme authority of the scriptures. Another important change was the abandonment of the view of the Catholic Church that the Church was supreme over the state. The German rulers and common people of Germany supported Luther. There were political reasons for the support of the rulers. They wanted to be free from the authority of Popes and get possession of the wealth in German monasteries for themselves. The common people liked Luther's teaching because it gave them an opportunity to demand more freedom from their rulers.

Ulrich Zwingli and **John Calvin** became the leaders of the Protestant movement in Switzerland. Under the leadership of Calvin, the Swiss cities became a refuge for Protestants fleeing to other countries in western Europe due to religious persecution. Calvin established an academy for the training of Protestant missionaries, who in return would spread the true word of God in other lands. As part of the work of propagating his version of Protestantism, Calvin composed a treatise entitled, *The Institutes of the Christian Religion*, wherein he gave a more concise and logical definition of the Protestant doctrines than what had been given by any other leader of this movement.

In England the Protestant movement was led by political leaders, particularly King Henry VIII and Queen Elizabeth I. Their reforms were not driven by the ides of religious or social reforms but by the interests of the state and more practically, the personal ambition of Henry VIII. Henry VIII sought to divorce his wife Catherine of Aragon and wanted to marry his beloved Anne Boleyn. The Pope refused to grant the divorce on the ground that Henry, before marrying Catherine,

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had asked for and had received a special Papal dispensation declaring his marriage with Catherine as valid and indissoluble. Rebuffed by the Pope, Henry promptly declared himself the "sole protector and supreme head of the Church and the Clergy of England". After that he married Anne Boleyn. From this marriage was born Elizabeth I, who later became the Queen of England. England's final break with the Pope came in 1529, when in a special session of the British Parliament a series of laws were passed to make the English Church completely free from the jurisdiction of the Pope. The King of England was also declared as the head of the English Church, which hereafter came to be known as the Anglican Church.

The Roman Catholic Church had been shaken to its very root by the movements started by Luther, Zwingli and Calvin. To counter the damage caused by the Protestant Movements, a series of reforms began within the Catholic Church, which came to be known as the 'Counter-Reformation'. During Counter-Reformation efforts were made to restore the Catholic Church's universal authority. One of these efforts took place in the Council of Trent (1545) summoned by Pope Paul III. The Council was to consider the ways and means to combat Protestantism. So it decided to settle the doctrinal disputes between the Catholics and the Protestants; clean up moral and administrative abuses within the Catholic Church and organise a new crusade against the Muslims. The next step was the organization of an order of missionaries, known as the Jesuits, with the dedicated purpose of spreading the message of Christ. The above measures adopted by the Catholic Church were not sufficient to bring the whole of Europe under the authority of the Pope. The campaign, however, did achieve a considerable measure of success in checking the further spread of Protestantism. Though much of Europe remained Protestant, new lands overseas were being won to the Catholic Church.

Reacting to economic and political changes, the concomitant reorganization of social life, much of the eighteenth century was consumed by intellectual ferment. The intellectual revolution of the eighteenth century is commonly referred to as the ***Enlightenment***. In England and Scotland, the Enlightenment was dominated by a group of thinkers who argued for a vision of human beings and society that both reflected and justified the industrial capitalism that first emerged in the British Isles. For scholars such as Adam Smith, individuals are to be free of external constraint and allowed to compete, thereby creating a better society. In France, the Enlightenment is often termed the *Age of Reason*, and it was dominated by a group of scholars known as the *philosophes*. It is out of the intellectual ferment generated by the French philosophes that sociology was born.

This section is very important, not only for your written examination but also for the interview. Please read it carefully.

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The term 'Enlightenment' is used in an academic and technical sense to indicate the intellectual movement in 18th century western and central Europe especially in England and France. Its historical significance lay in breaking the shackles of ideas imposed by tradition or authority whether of state or Church. For a long period in history up to that time, the standard method of arriving at the truth lay in an appeal to authority. It meant in practice, that truth was determined by one's superiors and one was not expected to doubt or question their wisdom. To buttress their claim, both state and Church would base their authority on supernatural sanction rather than on popular sovereignty. This had been the basis of absolutism and absolute monarchs ruled in nearly all parts of Europe. Conflicts between Church and state were not infrequent but these rarely concerned the common man in an age when communications were poor and his struggle for existence much harder.

Things in the meantime had changed fast during the 16th and 17th Centuries. Significant advances had been made in discoveries of new lands and routes; technologies as applied to agriculture and industries had increased production, and that possibly accounts for the rapid increase of population that took place both in England and France. Urban areas expanded and a middle class emerged to avail itself of the new opportunities in sectors like banking, industry, trade, journalism and above all education that served as a catalyst in the movement of ideas.

The essence of Enlightenment lay in its challenge to absolutism, the questioning of authority through a new conception of truth. In the course of Enlightenment, reason supplanted authority as the accepted method of arriving at the truth. All who look part in this movement of ideas were convinced that human understanding is capable by its own power and without recourse to supernatural assistance, of comprehending the system of the world. A new optimism was breathed about man's capacity to usher in a happier social order. The basic difference between the Absolutist view and Enlightened view centered round the individual. Under absolutism, the individual had to submit to the authority which was supposed to possess the monopoly of the truth; but under Enlightenment the individual acquired a new importance, dignity and self respect. Any man's opinion was potentially worth something. One no longer had to be a bishop or prince to claim access to truth. Enlightenment stood for the classic trilogy - Liberty, Equality, Fraternity; and as such represented the fight against oppression imposed by the old social hierarchy that had developed a vested interest in keeping people ignorant and superstitious. A challenge was thrown to religious education since it was believed that such education sapped a young person's courage and killed initiative by training him to fear and obey.

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Thus, the enlightenment was a period of remarkable intellectual development and change in the philosophical thought. A number of long-standing ideas and beliefs – many of which related to social life – were overthrown and replaced during the Enlightenment. The most prominent thinkers associated with the Enlightenment were the French philosophers **Charles Montesquieu** (1689-1755) and **Jean Jacques Rousseau** (1712-1778).

Montesquieu in his book, *The Spirit of the Law*, held that there should not be concentration of authority, such as executive, legislative, and judicial, at one place. He believed in the theory of separation of powers and the liberty of the individual.

Rousseau in his book *The Social Contract* argued that the people of a country have the right to choose their sovereign. He believed that people can develop their personalities best only under a government which is of their own choice. For Rousseau, the social contract is the sole foundation of the political community. By virtue of this social contract, individuals lose their natural liberties (limited merely by their ability to exercise force over one another). However, man's natural liberty promoted unlimited acquisitiveness and avarice and thus encouraged individuals to destroy the freedom of others weaker than they. By submitting to a law vested in a social contract – a mandate that can be withdrawn at any time – individuals find in the laws to which they consent a pure expression of their being as civilized human entities.

Although the Enlightenment was fueled by the political, social, and economic changes of the eighteenth century, it derived considerable inspiration from the scientific revolution of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries. As noted earlier, the scientific revolution reached a symbolic peak, at least in the eye of eighteenth-century thinkers, with Newtonian physics. In the light of various revolutionary developments in science, particularly Physics, the universe (physical world) came to be viewed as orderly or patterned. It was argued that with scientific inquiry (based on empirical observation and application of reason) the underlying natural laws governing the universe can be discovered. Further, the knowledge of these laws would facilitate better prediction and greater control over the physical world. Thus, Physics was to become the vision of how scientific inquiry and theory should be conducted. And the individual and society were increasingly drawn into the orbit of the new view of science. This gradual inclusion of the individual and society into the realm of science represented a startling break with the past, because heretofore these phenomena had been considered the domain of morals, ethics, and religion.

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So, the enlightenment thinkers argued that just as the physical world was governed by the natural laws, it was likely that social world was, too. Thus it was up to the philosopher, using reason and research, to discover these social laws. And once such social laws are discovered, then with the knowledge of those laws we can control and create a better society (social engineering).

It is important to note that almost all enlightenment thinkers also shared 'a vision of human progress.' Humanity was seen to be marching in a direction and was considered to be governed by a "law of progress" that was as fundamental as the law of gravitation in the physical world. For example, with economic modernization and advancement of technology agricultural and industrial revolution took place leading phenomenal increase in the agricultural and industrial outputs. With commercial revolution (trade and commerce), unprecedented wealth or capital was generated. Further, scientific revolution demolished the traditionally held superstitious beliefs (sanctified by Church) and ushered in the age of reason. With its emphasis on empirical observation and application of reason, it significantly changed the social outlook of man and brought about social modernization.

At psychological level, modernity was reflected in terms of reflexivity. Reflexivity refers to the reflexive monitoring of action: that is, the way in which humans think about and reflect upon what they are doing in order to consider acting differently in future. Humans have always been reflexive up to a point, but in pre-industrial societies the importance of tradition limited reflexivity. Humans would do some things simply because they were the traditional things to do. However, with modernity, tradition loses much of its importance and reflexivity becomes the norm (psychological modernization). Social reflexivity implies that social practices are constantly examined and reformed in the light of incoming information about those very practices, thus continuously altering their character.

Further, with the rise various social and political movements, demands for greater individual freedom and democratization were being made. For the first time in human history, the idea of fundamental rights of the individuals was being entertained in the public discourse. Traditional authoritarian and autocratic systems of governance were being challenged. The enlightenment scholars argued that all humans had certain inalienable "natural rights" which must be respected such as right to freedom of speech and expression, right of participation in the decision-making process, etc. This marked a significant step towards political modernization.

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Thus, the enlightenment scholars saw these developments as the sign of progress and the enlightenment period was marked by a new optimism or hope about the man's capacity to usher in a happier social order.

Task:

1. Notes-Making Assignment

Identify the main features of Enlightenment period.

- ……
- ……
- ……
- ……
- ……
- ……
- ……

2. Writing-Skill Assignment

Write a short note on 'Enlightenment'. (100-120 words)

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3. For Interview

Enlightenment Philosophy * Major Enlightenment Philosophers

Now let us briefly discuss the developments taking place in France, the birthplace of Sociology. In the years preceding the revolution, France retained the political and economic characteristics of a feudal society: rigid social hierarchy, social and economic inequality, monarchy, etc. The French society was divided into feudal **'estates'**. The structure of the feudal French society comprised the 'Three Estates'. Estates are defined as a system of stratification found in feudal European societies whereby one section or estate is distinguished from the other in terms of status, privileges and restrictions accorded to that estate. **The First Estate** (the Church) consisted of the clergy, which was stratified into higher clergy, such as the cardinal, the archbishops, the bishops and the abbots. They lived a life of luxury and gave very little attention to religion. In fact, some of them preferred the life of politics to religion. They spent much of their time in wasteful activities like drinking, gambling, etc. The Church owned one-fifth of the cultivated lands in France and enjoyed great influence with the Government. Like the nobles, the higher clergy was also exempt from paying most of the taxes. With the nobles they supported absolute monarchy. The Church collected tithe, a tax from the people for providing community services. It also maintained institutions of learning. In comparison to the higher clergy, the lower parish priests were over worked and poverty-stricken.

The Second Estate consisted of the nobility. There were two kinds of nobles, the nobles of the sword and the nobles of the robe. The nobles of the sword were big landlords. They were the protectors of the people in principle but in reality they led a life of a parasite, living off the hard work of the peasants. They led the life of pomp and show and were nothing more than 'high born wastrels'; that is, they spent extravagantly and did not work themselves. They can be compared to the erstwhile zamindars in India. The nobles of the robe were nobles not by birth but by title. They were the magistrates and judges. Among these nobles, some were very progressive and liberal as they had moved in their positions from common citizens who belonged to the third estate. However, these noble families continued to enjoy all the privileges such as non-payment of most of the taxes, avenues to higher positions in the French administration, and income from various feudal dues of the peasants.

The Third Estate comprised the rest of the society and included the peasants, the merchants, the artisans, and others. There was a vast difference between the condition of the peasants and that of the clergy and the nobility. The

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peasants worked day and night but were overloaded with so many taxes that they lived a hand to mouth existence. They produced the food on which the whole society depended. Yet they could barely survive due to failure of any kind of protection from the government. The King, in order to maintain the good will of the other two estates, the clergy and the nobility, continued to exploit the poor. The poor peasants had no power against him. While the clergy and the nobility kept on pampering and flattering the King.

As compared to the peasants, the condition of the middle classes, also known as the **bourgeoisie** comprising the merchants, bankers, lawyers, manufacturers, etc. was much better. These classes too belonged to the third estate. But the poverty of the state, which led to a price rise during 1720-1789, instead of adversely affecting them, helped them. They derived profit from this rise and the fact that French trade had improved enormously also helped the commercial classes to a great extent. Thus, this class was rich and secure. But it had no social prestige as compared with the high prestige of the members of the first and the second estates. In spite of controlling trade, industries, banking etc. the bourgeoisie had no power to influence the court or administration. They were looked down upon by the other two estates and the King paid very little attention to them. Thus, gaining political power became a necessity for them.

The clergy and the nobility both constituted only two per cent of the population but they owned about 35 per cent of the land. The peasants who formed 80 per cent of the population owned only 30 per cent of the land. The first two estates paid almost no taxes to the government. The peasantry, on the other hand, was burdened with taxes of various kinds. It paid taxes to the Church, the feudal lord, taxed in the form of income tax, poll tax, and land tax to the state. Thus, you can see how much burdened and poverty stricken the peasants had become at this time. They were virtually carrying the burden of the first two estates on their shoulders. On top of it all the prices had generally risen by about 65 per cent during the period 1720-1789. The French system of taxation was both unjust and unfair.

Like in all absolute monarchies, the theory of the Divine Right of King was followed in France too. For about 200 years the Kings of the Bourbon dynasty ruled France. Under the rule of the King, the ordinary people had no personal rights. They only served the King and his nobles in various capacities. The King's word was law and no trials were required to arrest a person on the King's orders. Laws too were different in different regions giving rise to confusion and arbitrariness. There was no distinction between the income of the state and the income of the King. The kings of France, from Louis XIV onwards, fought costly wars, which ruined the country, and when Louis XIV died in 1715, France had

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become bankrupt. Louis XV instead of recovering from this ruin kept on borrowing money from bankers. His famous sentence, "After me the deluge" describes the kind of financial crisis that France was facing. Louis XVI, a very weak and ineffective king, inherited the ruin of a bankrupt government. His wife, Queen Marie Antoinette, known for her expensive habits, is famous for her reply, which she gave to the poor, hungry people of France who came to her asking for bread. She told the people that, 'if you don't have bread, eat cake'.

Now let us examine the intellectual developments in France, which proved to be the igniting force in bringing about the French revolution. France, like some other European countries during the eighteenth century, had entered the age of reason and rationalism. Some of the major philosophers, whose ideas influenced the French people, were rationalists who believed that all true things could be proved by reason. Some of these thinkers were Locke (1632-1704), Montesquieu (1689-1755), Voltaire (1694-1778), and Rousseau (1712-1778).

Locke, an Englishman, advocated that every individual has certain rights, which cannot be taken by any authority. These rights were (i) right to live, (ii) right to property, and (iii) the right to personal freedom. He also believed that any ruler who took away these rights from his people should be removed from the seat of power and replaced by another ruler who is able to protect these rights.

Montesquieu in his book, *The Spirit of the Law*, held that there should not be concentration of authority, such as executive, legislative, and juridical, at one place. He believed in the theory of the separation of powers and the liberty of the individual.

Voltaire became internationally famous as a great writer and critic whose style and pungent criticism were inimitable. It was through his plays and writings that he launched his bitter attacks against the existing institutions like the church and the state. He made fun of the eccentricities of the nobles. He advocated religious toleration and freedom of speech. He also stood for the rights of individuals, for freedom of speech and expression.

Probably the greatest French philosopher of the age was **Jean Jacques Rousseau**. In his book *The Social Contract*, he argued that the people of a country have the right to choose their sovereign. He believed that people can develop their personalities best only under a government which is of their own choice. He further explained that the king and his subjects are parties to a contract, and therefore if the king does not rule the people according to their general will, he loses their loyalty. Rousseau was advocating popular sovereignty

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theory. His writings cast such a spell on his admirers that they were ready to revolt against the oppressive monarchy.

The major ideas of these and several other intellectuals struck the imagination of the French people. Also some of them who had served in the French army, which was sent to assist the Americans in their War of Independence from British imperialism, came back with the ideas of equality of individuals and their right to choose their own government. The French middle class was deeply affected by these ideas of liberty and equality. So far you have leant about the basic picture of the French society just before the Revolution. Now let us discuss some of the major events that took place during the Revolution.

It is worth noting that when the American colonists revolted against the oppressive rule of the mother country and won a resounding victory at Saratoga, the French government decided to help them with men, money and materials. It caused a serious strain on the finances of the country and cast a heavy burden on the poor peasants. Turgot was appointed as the Minister of Finance to suggest remedies. He advised the king to tax the privileged class. He was summarily dismissed at the instance of the queen. Unfortunately, France witnessed near-famine conditions in 1788 with the result that there was a serious food shortage. It was at this critical juncture that the king was advised by his courtiers to summon the Estates-General (French Parliament) to get approval for further dose of taxation.

When the Estates-General was summoned, the king ignored the importance of the Third Estate (600 representatives elected by the common people) and tried to consult the representatives of the three estates separately. The representatives of the third estate advised the king to bring together the representatives of all the three estates at one place for discussion of state problems. The king discarded their advice. Subsequently, it led to a quarrel between the king and the representatives of the third estate. This led to the formation of the National Assembly. The meeting of the National Assembly led by middle class leaders and some liberal minded nobles was met with stiff resistance. On 20th June 1789 when a meeting was to be held in the Hall at Versailles near Paris, the members found that it was closed and guarded by the King's men. Therefore, the National Assembly members led by their leader Bailey went to the next building which was an indoor tennis court. It was here that they took an Oath to draw a new constitution for France. This Oath, which marks the beginning of the French Revolution, is popularly known as the Oath of the Tennis Court.

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Next, on July 14th, 1789 took place one of the most important events of the French Revolution. It was the storming of the Bastille, an ancient royal prison that stood as a symbol of oppression. On this date the mobs of Paris, led by some middle class leaders, broke open this prison and set its inmates free. The causes for this event were the shortage of food, on the one hand, and the dismissal of a very popular minister called Necker, on the other. The mobs of Paris rebelled against the ruling class, especially the King. This day is celebrated in France as its Independence Day.

Shortly after these events, the National Assembly drafted the 'Declaration of the Rights of Man,' which was a central political document defining human rights and setting out demands for reform. The political rights and freedoms proclaimed by the 'Declaration' were so wide-ranging in their human emancipation that it set the standard for social and political thinking, and formed the central rallying point of the revolution. The 'Declaration' stated at the outset that all human beings were born free and equal in their political rights, regardless of their class position, and this proceeded to set up a system of constitutional principles based on liberty, security and resistance to oppression. With philosophical authority, the 'Declaration' proclaimed that all individuals had the prerogative to exercise their 'natural right' and that the law rather than the monarch was the expression of the common interest. This led to the elimination of all social distinctions on the one hand, and the right to resist oppression on the other. Thus, the ideas of Liberty, Equality and Fraternity were enshrined in this declaration. Liberty and equality put an end to the age of serfdom, despotism and hereditary privileges found in the old feudal society.

By August the National Assembly began to deal directly with political and legal reforms, first by eliminating feudal dues and then by abolishing selfdom. Second, by compelling the church to give up the right to tithes, the National Assembly altered the authority and class position of the clergy. Third, in declaring that 'all citizens, without distinction, can be admitted to ecclesiastical, civil and military posts and dignities,' it proclaimed an end to all feudal social distinctions.

As the criticism of social and political inequalities spread throughout society, there was a widespread critique of economic inequality altogether and this led to putting into question all other forms of subordination. With this came the idea that human beings, without distinctions, were the bearers of natural rights – a concept which had a corrosive effect on all other forms of inequality. Finally, from the assertions inherent in the 'Declarations of Rights,' a new category of social person came into being which came fundamentally to rest in the concept of the 'citizen,' whose social and political rights were brought within the framework of the state.

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As the political changes began to take effect, there were abrupt social changes in the form of altered politics and in the form of the political reorganization of the feudal way of life. This brought with it two central historical shifts. First, it transformed the existing class structure of feudal society and led to the decline of class privilege and a change in the relations of subordination which had existed up until that time. Second, it set loose political and legal reforms which brought about a change from a political aristocracy based on sovereign authority to a democratic republic based on the rights of the citizen. Thus French Revolution of 1789 marked the phase of political modernization.

Now let us once again return to our discussion of enlightenment. As we had discussed earlier, the enlightenment scholars saw these socio-economic and political developments as the sign of progress. The enlightenment period was marked by a new optimism or hope about the man's capacity to usher in a happier social order. So, enlightenment thinkers represented intellectual modernity. But there were also some scholars who viewed these changes otherwise. These scholars were not only skeptic about these changes taking place in European society but even condemned these changes. We call these scholars as Counter–Enlightenment scholars and their views as a Conservative Reaction to enlightenment (anti–modernity). The most extreme form of opposition to Enlightenment ideas was French Catholic counterrevolutionary philosophy, as represented by the ideas of **Louis de Bonald** (1754-1840) and **Joseph de Maistre** (1753-1821). These men were reacting against not only the Enlightenment but also the French Revolution, which they saw partly as a product of the kind of thinking characteristic of the Enlightenment. De Bonald, for example, was disturbed by the revolutionary changes and yearned for a return to the peace and harmony of the Middle Ages.

In general, these scholars deplored the disruption of socio-economic and political fabric of the traditional medieval society caused by Industrial Revolution and French Revolution. As mentioned earlier that there was massive dislocation of rural population due to enclosure movement. The newly emerging social life in towns and cities was bereft of close-knit community and kinship bonds, we-feeling, stability and harmonic social order. Since these cities had emerged spontaneously, without any proper planning, they lacked even the basic amenities such as proper sewage and sanitation. As a result, due such unhygienic living conditions, epidemics were a common phenomenon. Further, these newly emerging industrial cities were marked by gross socio-economic disparities. Workers, including women and children, were forced to work for long hours in the factories marked by inhuman working conditions. In this new mode of production, worker had lost control over both, the process of production as well as his product. He was simply reduced to a wage-labourer. In Marxist terms, the worker became alienated from the product of his labour.

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Further, demand for political rights fuelled by the writings of enlightenment scholars, often led to civil wars leading to political anomie. Furthermore, religion too, which until now regulated the social order started declining. Religion, as the source of solace and meaning of life, started losing its appeal with the advances in science. So, Conservatives saw these changes, i.e. decline of family & community life, decline of religion, economic exploitation of workers in factories, rising socio-economic disparities and political turmoil as a sign of social decay and not as progress. Hence, they were preoccupied with their concerns for peace and harmony, and stability in the society.

So, while enlightenment scholars glorified change, conservatives deplored such changes and emphasized on stability, peace and harmony. However, the idea that there must be peace and harmony in social life came to be generally accepted by scholars of both the traditions.

Thus, the social conditions prevalent in Europe in 18th and 19th centuries, generated by social changes such as Renaissance, Commercial Revolution, Scientific Revolution, Reformation, Counter-Reformation, Industrial Revolution and French Revolution created the need for a distinct discipline to understand and analyze these changes. As we know that the existing knowledge that was prevalent during those times was largely religious in nature. Traditionally, the only source of knowledge was religion, propagated by the Church. But, the then existing body of religious knowledge had no answer to these challenges. Further, with the growth of science, religion itself was under attack and religious ideas were loosing their plausibility. So, there was a need for a new body of knowledge. A new body of knowledge was needed to understand what was happening and also help people to find solutions to the newly emerging problems.

That is how, the social changes created by modernity in Europe in the late 18th and early 19th century created the need for new knowledge.

Thus, while social conditions created the need for sociology, intellectual conditions provided the means for building sociology as a distinct discipline. It is the combination of both enlightenment and conservative school of thought which led to the emergence of sociology.

How?

As the early social theorists were largely preoccupied with understanding the puzzle of social change unfolding in Europe and to create a harmonic social order, hence, we can say that the goals of sociology were dictated by the conservative reaction. As we had already discussed that how the Conservative scholars were

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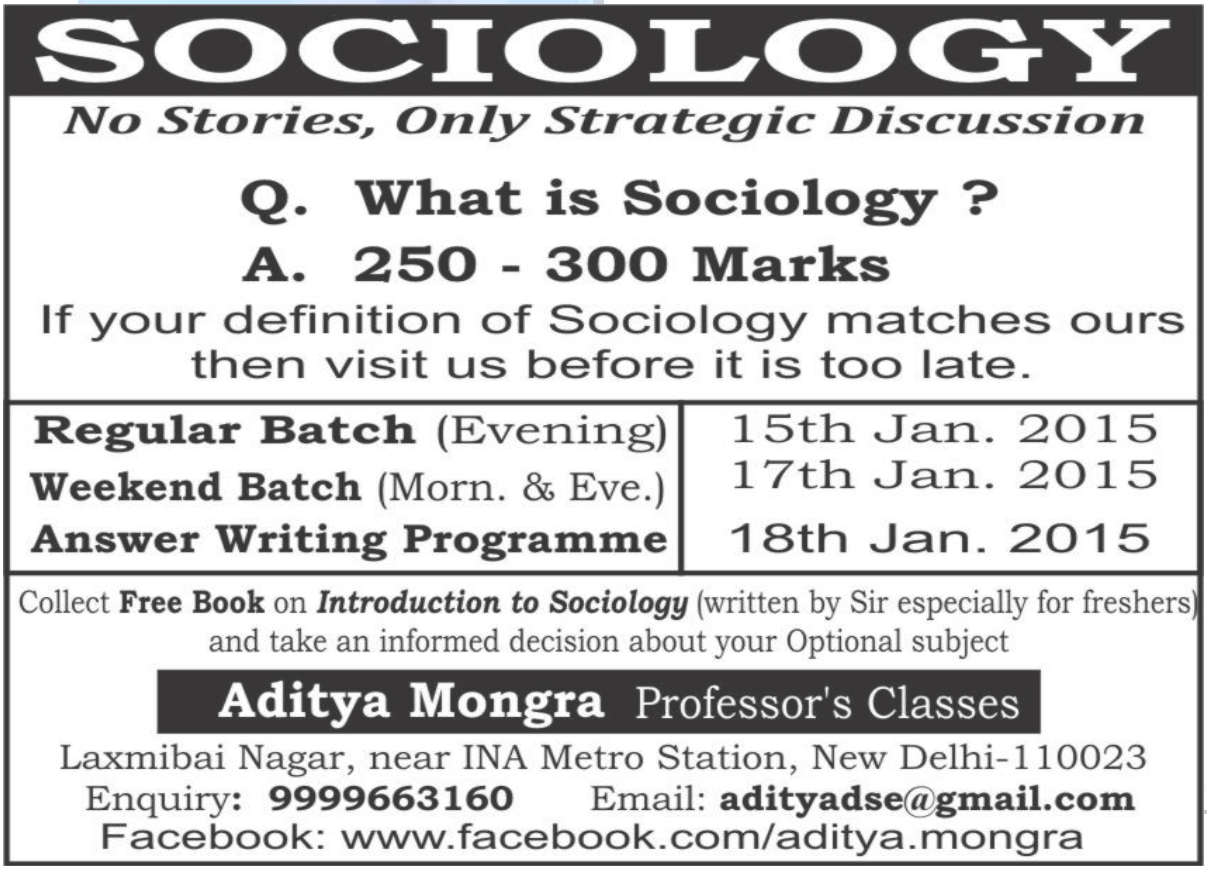
preoccupied with concerns for peace and harmony, and stability in the society. Therefore, sometimes it is also said that the early sociology developed as a reaction to the Enlightenment.

But, as far as the methodology or means to understand and study these social changes was concerned, it was largely influenced by the intellectual contributions of the Enlightenment scholars. Unlike conservatives, who yearned for a return to the peace and harmony of the Middle Ages, early social theorists emphasized on the need for scientific study of society based on empirical observation and reason (an idea of Enlightenment scholars) to be the basis of this new knowledge. They argued that through scientific study of society, social scientists can discover social laws that govern social order and thus, through corrective social legislation, can create a harmonic society. So, that is how the intellectual conditions helped in creating a new discipline which would use scientific method to study society, discover the laws that govern society and use that knowledge of laws to create a peaceful and harmonic society.

So, social conditions created the need for sociology, intellectual conditions provided the means for building sociology and that is how modernity and social change in Europe led to the emergence of sociology.



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Test Yourself

Q1. Write a note on 'Modernity and social changes in Europe and emergence of Sociology'. (300-350 words/ 30 marks)

Dear Candidate, before I give you a model answer for this question, I wish to discuss with you the correct strategy of writing an answer. I call this '**Dialectical Approach**', a term borrowed from Hegel. But before you apply the dialectical approach to a question make sure that you have read that question at least three times and understood it. It is a very common error on the part of the candidates to write in the examination 'what they know' rather 'what has been asked by the examiner.' Hence, the key to score well in this examination is to read the mind of the examiner and accordingly answer the question, meeting the expectations of the examiner. If you do this, you would get marks as per your expectations too.

All you have to do for this is to follow a very simple process. Firstly, read the question carefully and underline the keywords. Secondly, try to understand from which dimension the question has been framed on the topic. This is very important because questions can be framed from multiple dimensions or angles on the same topic. You would have no problem doing this if you sincerely follow the theme-based approach. Thirdly, divide the question into 3-4 logical sub-questions. When you do this it will not only keep you focused on the main theme but also help you complete the paper in time.

Now, let me share with you something about the structure of your answer. Your answer must be divided in four sections, viz. **introduction**, **thesis**, **anti-thesis** and **synthesis**. The Introduction section is the most important section of your answer as it introduces yourself as a candidate to the examiner. The examiner forms an image about you and your understanding of the concept just by reading the introduction. Hence, you must start by directly addressing the question, without beating the bush. By this I mean that given the limitations of Time and Word Limit, please avoid developing the background and glorifying the thinkers. In the introduction, briefly explain the key concept asked in the question. The introduction section should constitute nearly 20 % of the total length of your answer.

The next section is Thesis. In this section, you need to identify the main arguments in favour of the given concept or statement. Here, you must enrich your answer by highlighting the works of the scholars and case studies in support of

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your argument. In the Anti-Thesis section, you must write a critique of the concept or statement. This would balance your answer. Both, Thesis and Anti-Thesis should constitute nearly 30% each of the total length of your answer. Last, but not the least, is the Synthesis section. You may also call it as concluding remarks. Please remember that the concluding remarks reflect your overall understanding of the subject to the examiner. Your concluding remarks are not supposed to be your personal opinion about the ideas or concepts asked in the question. Rather, your concluding remarks must reflect the insight that you have gained as a student of Sociology. Thus, when write synthesis, make sure it is an academic conclusion rather than personal opinion.

Structure of the Model Answer:

Introduction: Briefly discuss the concept of modernity and the process of social change in Europe that brought about modernity

Thesis: Arguments in favour of the modernization process, viz. the ideas of Enlightenment scholars, with examples

Anti-thesis: Conservative reaction to Enlightenment

Synthesis: Emergence of Sociology as a by-product of the confluence of the two intellectual currents – Enlightenment and Conservatives

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Model Answer

Modernity refers to the rational transformation of social, psychological, economic and political aspects of society. In this sense, the process of modernization could be said to have begun in the late 18th and early 19th century in Western Europe. During that period, the entire social structure and the economic and political institutions were undergoing transition, particularly in the backdrop of Renaissance and Enlightenment movement. With industrial revolution, traditional feudal agrarian society was in decline and a new capitalist industrial society was emerging. The commercial and scientific revolutions which marked the period laid the foundations for the transformation of a predominant rural, agricultural and manual way of life to an urban industrial and mechanized pattern of living.

These extensive changes integral to the process of industrialization however, involved a major paradox. They brought a new society with great productive potential and more sophisticated and complex ways of living while at the same time generating extensive disruptions in traditional patterns of life and relationship. Thus, creating new problems of overcrowding, unhygienic urban conditions, poverty and unemployment. Demand for greater political rights gave rise to social and political movements, such as French Revolution, often leading to civil wars.

However, the early scholars who were carefully observing the changes in the patterns of social life with the rise of industrial society were divided in their opinion with regard to the nature, impact and direction of such changes. Enlightenment scholars like Rousseau, Montesquieu, Adam Smith, Saint Simon and Augusts Comte had a positive view of the newly emerging social order. They considered such changes as progressive and hence desirable. They favoured modern scientific knowledge, advanced technology, individualism and political ideas of justice and liberty. They encouraged the forces of liberalization and industrialization. Whereas, the Conservatives like Louis de Bonald, Joseph de Maistre and other such scholars had a rather skeptic view of these profound and far reaching institutional changes that were taking place in society. They were preoccupied with the concern for social stability and order in the society as the new social order was marked by violent political revolutions, class wars, extreme economic inequalities and widespread misery and poverty.

Thus, while social conditions created the need for sociology, intellectual conditions provided the means for building sociology as a distinct discipline. It is the combination of both enlightenment and conservative school of thought which led to the emergence of sociology.

Total Words: 355

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Dear Candidate, after completing a given topic and preparing your notes in pointer form, you must attempt questions asked so far in previous years and get them evaluated. As I have discussed before, what really counts here is how you are articulating the learned knowledge in the given Time and Word Limit. Always remember that Civil Services Examination is not about information, it is more about analysis. So, you must practice by writing more and more answers and getting them periodically evaluated.

All the best

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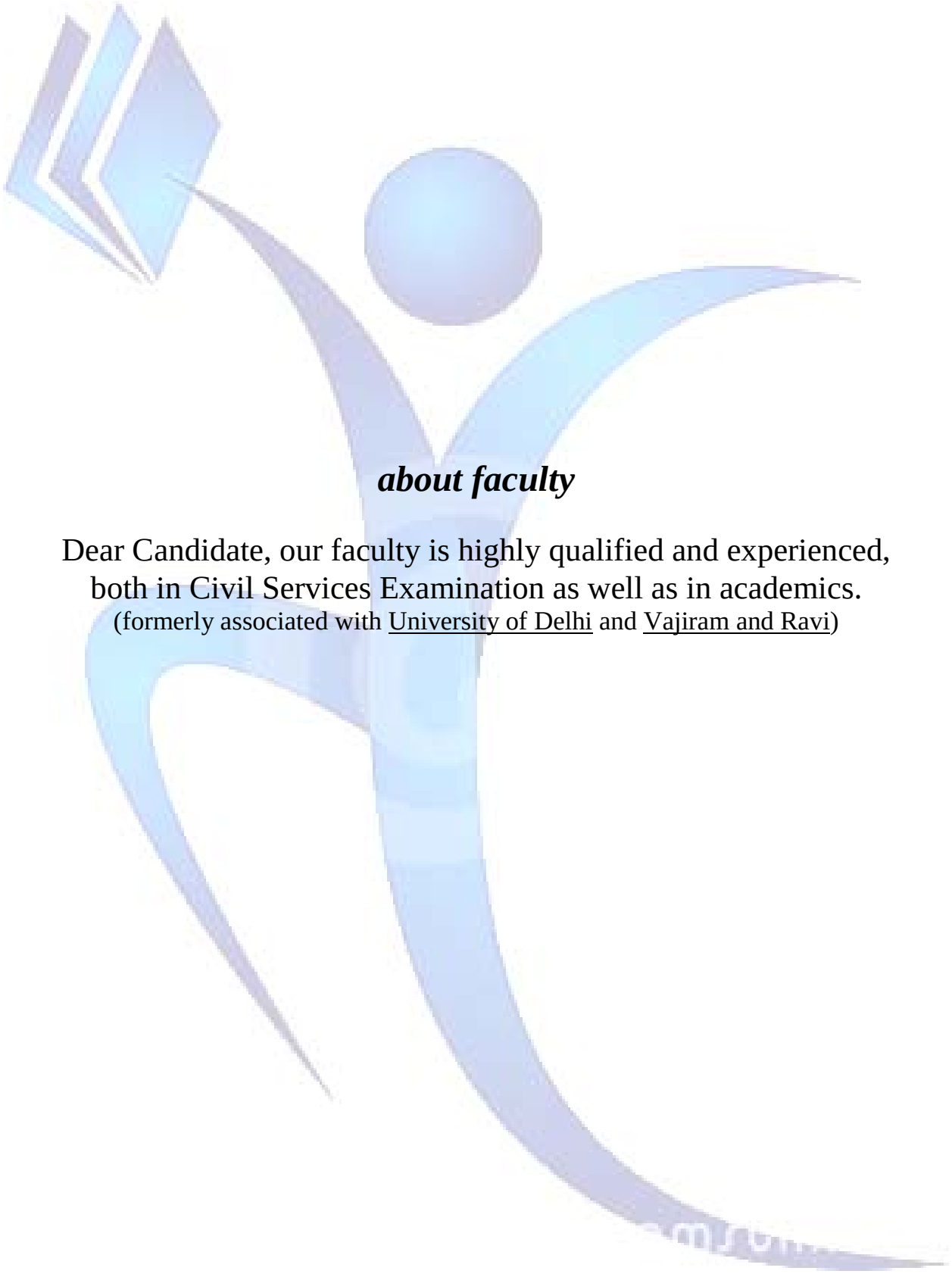

about faculty

Dear Candidate, our faculty is highly qualified and experienced, both in Civil Services Examination as well as in academics.
(formerly associated with University of Delhi and Vajiram and Ravi)

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about Civil Services as a career

Dear Candidate, before I introduce you to this work I would like to share a few things with you. As you know Civil Services Examination is considered to be one of the toughest examinations. But I believe that there is no such thing as EASY or DIFFICULT per se because I feel that it is our thinking that makes it so. Therefore, if you begin your journey to IAS with a positive attitude that **'YES, I CAN DO IT'**, then trust me your journey would become not only a pleasant and enjoyful learning experience but also far more easier than otherwise. Further, before you decide to take Civil Services Examination or any other examination, make sure that your decision is well thought of. For that, firstly, you must take time and introspect and see whether your aptitude and interest matches with the career that you are planning to choose. Since it is the most important step for anyone, any amount of time spent on this is worth.

Secondly, whatever decision you take must be your own independent decision and must be taken with the conviction that whatever may be the outcome you will never regret having taken such decision. Thirdly, one must also make a comparative analysis of the requirements or the level of preparation that an examination demands and the ability or level of preparation one actually has. This is important because it will not only help you in placing the examination in right perspective but also enable you to set realistic expectations from yourself. It will go a long way in guarding you from negative thoughts often arising out of self-doubts during the course of preparation. Thus, saving you both, time as well as energy.

Last, but not the least, I would like to caution those students who go on a shopping spree collecting study material from various coaching institutes during the course of their preparation for this examination. I wish to make it clear that this examination does not require too much of content. Rather, on the basis of my personal experience as well as that of toppers, I can confidently say that ***this examination is less about content and more about analysis, both comparative as well as contemporary***.

That's why in light of the changing pattern of the Civil Services Examination, I always suggest my students to:

Read Adequately * Think Logically * Write Relevantly

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how to prepare Sociology

Dear Candidate, given the **Limited Time** that you have and the **Infinite Syllabus** that you have to prepare for the Civil Services Examination, it becomes very important to manage your time wisely and utilize your energy efficiently. It becomes all the more important in light of the fierce competition that you face ahead. Here, I recall a line from the book *You Can Win* by Shiv Khera, that,

"Winners don't do different things, they do things differently".

Now, I would like to brief you about how our approach is different from the rest, and also the best, for preparing Sociology optional for the Civil Services Examination.

Firstly and foremostly, you must understand that no matter how many sleepless nights you may spend preparing for this examination, ultimately, it is only those 3 hours (at the examination hall during the Mains (Written) Examination) that are going to decide your fate. So it is very important for the candidates to prepare their subject strictly in an **Exam Oriented** manner. What is important here is not how much you have studied for the exam but how much you would be able to write at the time of the exam? So, what is important here is not to master the subject in all its possible details but rather, one should prepare the subject strictly in a professional manner keeping in mind the demands for 'conceptual clarity', 'analytical reasoning' and 'correct writing expression' as set forth by Union Public Service Commission. Only then one can hope to cover the syllabus for this exam in a time-bound manner with better chances of success. This you would realize step-by-step as you move along these notes and with vital inputs from my side at regular intervals.

Secondly, one must follow a **Theme-Based Approach** instead of Topic-Based Approach, whereby one should identify the major theme that underlies a given topic and runs through several other related sub-topics. Particularly, in light of the revised syllabus and the changing orientation of the Civil Services Examination, it has become all the more important to adopt theme-based approach because many a times questions are also asked on topics which are not mentioned in the syllabus. Though at the outset such questions may appear to be out of syllabus to the candidate but actually they are not. Questions on such topics are basically of implied nature and thus very much a part of the major theme that underlie the mentioned topic. So by following a theme-based approach we can

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cover not only the topics that are mentioned in the syllabus but also those which are implied in nature.

Thus, following a theme-based approach you would not only realize the depth of understanding that is expected from candidates at this examination but also it would keep you focused throughout your preparation. Please note that the theme-based approach would help you develop **Mental Framework** of the entire syllabus. Further, once you are confident that you have understood the broader dimensions of the theme then it would also resist your temptation to collect more and more material on the same topic. Thus, saving you both time as well as energy. You will learn this art as we proceed with the syllabus.

So, when I say **Read Relevantly**, I simply imply that given the limitations of time and energy, one should focus only on the important themes that underlie a given topic. Otherwise, given the vastness of the syllabus it would be impossible to do justice with all the topics mentioned in the syllabus in a time span of 3-4 months. Students must understand that just any information on the topic mentioned in the syllabus may not be equally important from the examination point of view. Hence we have to exercise selectivity.

To **Think Logically** implies that you must correlate your arguments in a logical manner. This will happen only if you have a thorough grasp of the concepts. So, **Conceptual Understanding** and **Conceptual Interlinking** both are very important. But equally important is its practical application in the contemporary scenario. So, whatever concepts or theories you study in the syllabus, you must also try to relate them with the contemporary society and changes therein. Please remember that conceptual clarity and its practical application is equally important at the Interview stage as well, as you may be asked to define or explain any sociological concept and to contextualize it in the light of contemporary developments, both in national and international arena.

Write Relevantly is the most critical stage of all. As I mentioned in the beginning that no matter how much you might have studied and what all sources you might have referred, ultimately it is your answer sheet that determines your destiny. Thus, your written answer must be a perfect blend of *conceptual clarity*, *conceptual interlinking* and *sociological language*. More importantly, such an answer needs to be produced on paper within the Time-and-Word Limit.

Dear Candidate, ultimately, you get only those 3 hours to convince the examiner that how dedicated you are about Civil Services and what importance does it carry in your life. So, with our **Dialectical Approach** (see page. 48) to answer writing we will make sure that all your efforts and sacrifices made

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during the course of preparation for this exam find a reflection in our answers. So along with working hard **(Hard Work)**, we also need to work smartly **(Smart Work)**. As you would proceed with the chapters you would be guided about note-making and answer-writing. Please follow the instructions sincerely.

Thank You

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Dear Candidate, after years of experience gained while preparing for this exam as well as in academics, I can say with firm conviction that this exam requires only **one and a half year** of dedicated and focused preparation. Generally those who take more time than this are the ones who either do not have the right guidance or realize the significance of these crucial aspects when it is already too late. In my view, an intensive but focused study of 3-4 months is more than sufficient to prepare Sociology optional for the civil services exam. I would also like to say that with regular answer-writing practice, a sincere candidate can easily score 250-300 marks, particularly in the new format of the Sociology Paper. I am sure that with these notes and with this approach you will start your preparations with an edge over other candidates. How far and how well you carry this advantage would largely depend upon the consistency and sincerity of your effort. Hence I request you to go through these notes step by step and follow the instructions sincerely.

all the best

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a word of caution

Dear Candidate, you just need to sincerely follow the topic-specific instructions that would be provided during the course. You will never find yourself alone while preparing this subject because I will always be there beside you with some useful tips and vital inputs. If at any stage you need some clarification, you can freely contact me on phone, email, or Facebook.

Now, you need to give at least three readings to the entire syllabus. But, these readings need to be done in a proper and professional manner. Remember, your aim is to qualify Civil Services Examination, not to master the subject. If you keep this thing in mind, I assure you that you will never waste even a single minute on unnecessary pursuits for collecting unnecessary and irrelevant material available in the market. In order to qualify this examination, all you need to do is that you must focus upon understanding the principle arguments related to the mentioned topic in the syllabus and develop you own understanding out of it. This is what I had already mentioned that conceptual clarity combined with its practical application in our daily life is the key to your success in Civil Services Examination.

As far as these three readings are concerned, I want to you to follow a very simple approach. In your first reading, just read these notes as a story. In your second reading, please underline, mark or highlight the important points and attempt the **Notes-Making Assignment** and **Writing-Skill Assignment** with a pencil. It is only in your third reading that you will refer to the suggested readings (that too only selectively), that I have mentioned wherever necessary and attempt the test given at the end of each topic in **Test Yourself** section. Please make sure that you get each and every test evaluated so that I can suggest you the corrective course of action before it is too late.

Just do this and see the difference in your preparation. You will not only be able to complete the entire syllabus in the shortest possible time but that too with conceptual clarity and good writing skills.

Wish you all the best

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Oath

- I believe that **Life** is the most beautiful gift bestowed upon us by **Mother Nature**. Mother Nature has blessed us all with Life so that we live happily and spread happiness all around. Mother Nature has empowered us all with its supreme divine power to realize our dreams. It is entirely up to us how we take care of our lives and what we make of it. We must respect Life and Mother Nature.

- I believe that there is no substitute for **Hard Work** and there is no shortcut to success. Those who tend to opt for shortcuts, their march to success is often cut short.

- I will place highest value on time and will try my best for its optimum utilization. I believe that **Time Management** is the key to success.

- I will set **Realistic Goals** and will make my best effort to achieve them.

- I believe that no success is final and no failure is fatal. It is the **Courage** to continue that counts.

- I will never, never, never, **Never Give Up**.

- I will adhere to the **Six Ethics of Life:**

Before you Pray	-	Believe
Before you Speak	-	Listen
Before you Spend	-	Earn
Before you Write	-	Think
Before you Quit	-	Try
Before you Die	-	Live

- I will be **Honest** and **Truthful** in my daily life.

- I will abide by the **Discipline**, code of conduct, terms and conditions of my institute.

(signature)

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Dear Candidate, I am also enclosing two sheets, one for your **Monthly Schedule** and another for your **Weekly Schedule** to facilitate better Time Management. You can get these sheets printed and photocopied and with regular practice you can yourself evaluate your performance.

Rule: While recording the numbers of hours in your Weekly Schedule, make sure that you deduct half an hour from each of your sitting. For example, if in one sitting you have studied for 2 hours, then, record only one and a half hours in the Weekly Schedule. If in the next sitting, you have studied for 3 hours, then, record two and a half hours only.

Dear Candidate, by following this method, you can tentatively arrive at the amount of qualitative time you are devoting to your preparations for the Civil Services Examination. By following this method, if any sincere candidate is devoting 8-10 hours per day on a regular basis, he is doing justice with his time, labour and above all, his aim.

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1. Sociology – The Discipline
Modernity and social changes in Europe and emergence of sociology
Scope of the subject and comparison with other social sciences
Sociology and common sense

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Modernity and social changes in Europe and emergence of sociology

Instructions: Dear Candidate, in this topic the examiner is primarily interested in testing your overall understanding about the process of transformation that took place in Europe in the eighteenth and nineteenth century. Further, he is interested to know that why this process of transformation, which included large-scale social, economic and political changes, is associated with the idea of modernity or why this transformation came to be identified as modernization. Last, but not the least, he wants to know that how the prevailing social conditions of those times created the need for a new discipline and how the intellectual conditions of those times contributed to the emergence of Sociology as a distinct discipline.

Theme: *Process of modernization in Europe (in the eighteenth and nineteenth century) and its impact on the emergence of sociology.*

Related Concepts: Feudalism, Renaissance, Commercial Revolution, Scientific Revolution, Reformation, Industrial Revolution, Enlightenment, French Revolution and Modernity.

Important: Dear Candidate, I have discussed this topic in detail here only to facilitate your thorough understanding and command over related concepts. But while writing an answer in the examination it would not be possible for you to incorporate each and every detail mentioned here. Hence, I suggest you to exercise selectivity in picking up only the relevant content as per the demand of the question. Given the Time and Word Limit in the examination, you will be able to write a concise and precise answer only if you remain focused on the theme.

My advice to you here is to understand and focus on the theme rather than the topic. I believe that given the changing pattern and focus of the Civil Services Examination, the topic-based approach is an outdated one because it leaves the candidate with a fragmented knowledge. While, on the other hand, a theme-based approach would help the candidate to interlink the concepts more easily. Thus, it would not only give the candidate a comprehensive understanding of the subject but also help him perform well both at the written as well as the interview stage of the examination.

To facilitate your better understanding and to enable you to interlink the concepts, these notes have been written in a continuing series of interlinked concepts and theories.

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Modernity has often been viewed as being in opposition to and representing a break from tradition. If tradition looked to the past, modernity presumably turned its eye to the future. Modern culture is frequently associated, as Swedish social theorist Goran Therborn (1995) notes, "with words like progress, advance, development, emancipation, liberation, growth, accumulation and enlightenment". One might add to this the idea that modernism is often depicted as an expansive, and thus global, phenomenon. The association with these terms suggests that modern culture possesses an optimistic orientation about our ability to collectively resolve problems, to remedy human suffering, and to enrich social life. It presupposes our ability to acquire knowledge of both the natural and the social worlds and to use this knowledge to beneficially control and mold these worlds. As Wagner (2008) sees it, "modernity is associated with the open horizon of the future, with unending progress towards a better human condition brought about by a radically novel and unique institutional arrangement". Historians as well as social theorists generally agree that from the fourteenth century to the sixteenth century A.D., Europe had been witnessing changes in its political, social and economic structures, which marked the beginning of what we call the modern period.

Before proceeding further with our discussion on modernity, we must understand that if modernity is viewed as being in opposition to and representing a break from tradition, then what was tradition like? In other words, what were the features of society of medieval Europe? [Note: Medieval period, also sometimes called as Middle Ages, roughly refers to the period from A.D. 600 to about A.D. 1500]

Society of medieval Europe (before fourteenth century) was largely feudal in character. Feudalism was the dominant system of social-economic and political organization in Western Europe from tenth to fifteenth century. It had emerged on account of downfall and decentralization of Roman Empire and absence of any central authority. The word 'feudal' comes from *feud* which originally meant a *fief* or land held on condition or service. In a feudal society, land was the source of the power. Thus, feudal system was based on allocation of land in return for service.

Feudalism was based upon a system of land tenure in which land estates of various sizes (fiefs) were given to hold (not to own) by an overlord to his vassals (knights) in return for military service. The fiefs may further be subdivided by a vassal among other knights who would then be his vassals. Such fiefs consisted of one or more *manors*, that is, *estates* with serfs whose agricultural production provided the economic basis for the existence of the feudal class. When receiving a fief a vassal took an oath of homage and fealty (fidelity) to his lord and owed him loyalty as well as a specified amount of military service. Upon the death of a vassal the fief would technically revert to the overlord, but it was a common practice for

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the eldest son to take his father's place as vassal of the lord, and thus, in effect, fiefs were passed on through primogeniture.

Estate system of social stratification was the characteristic feature of feudal European societies. Estates are defined as a system of stratification found in feudal European societies whereby one section or estate is distinguished from the other in terms of status, privileges and restrictions accorded to that estate. The feudal estates of medieval Europe had three important characteristics. Firstly, estates were legally defined. In other words, each estate had a status, in the precise sense of a legal complex of rights and duties, of privileges and obligations. The differences between estates can also be seen in the different penalties imposed for similar offences. Secondly, the estates represented a broad division of labour, and were regarded in the contemporary literature as having definite functions. 'The nobility were ordained to defend all, the clergy to pray for all, and the commons to provide food for all.' Thirdly, the feudal estates also acted as political groups.

Thus, the feudal society in Europe was a hierarchical and graded organization in which every person was allotted a position. At the top stood the king. He bestowed fiefs or estates on a number of lords who were known as dukes and earls. These lords in turn distributed a part of their fiefs among a number of lesser lords who were called barons and, in return, secured their military support. Thus the dukes and earls were the king's vassals, that is to say, they owed allegiance directly to the king. The barons were the vassals of the dukes and earls. The knights formed the lowest category of feudal lords. Usually they were the vassals of barons for whom they performed military service. Knights did not have any vassals of their own. Every feudal lord was expected to pay homage to his overlord and could then be in vested with some formal rights. Every feudal lord, except the knight, was first a vassal and then an overlord with a number of vassals under him. The relationship from top to bottom was one of allegiance. No vassal owned any land; he only held the land as of his overlord. The vassal was in every way his lord's man. He recognized no other authority than of his overlord. In time of need, for example, when the kind fought a war, he could demand military assistance from his vassals, these vassals - the dukes and the earls - demanded the same assistance from their vassals, the barons, and the barons from their vassals, the knights. Every feudal lord contributed a detachment of warriors, and thus a fighting army would be formed.

Feudal life, as explained in the previous section, was based on agriculture. The village farm was the *manor*, the size of which varied from place to place. Its centre was the manor house of the lord where he lived or which he visited, for the lords often possessed several manors. The manor included a large farm which supported all those who worked on it, a pasture area where the manor cattle grazed,

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and common woods which supplied fuel and timber. A manor always had a number of cottages where the common people lived, some workshops to provide for manor needs, and a chapel. *Manorialism* was an essential element of feudal society. It was a system of land tenure and the organizing principle of rural economy. It was characterized by the vesting of legal and economic power in a lord, supported economically from his own direct landholding and from the obligatory contributions of a legally subject part of the peasant population under his jurisdiction. These obligations could be payable in several ways, in labour, in kind or in coin, etc. *Manor* was the lowest unit of territorial organization in the feudal system in Europe. It may also be referred as the land tenure unit under manorialism. Country people often lived on a manor. On a manor there was a village, church, lord's house or castle, and the farmland upon which the people worked.

Please note that the Roman Catholic Church was as powerful an institution as feudalism in western Europe during medieval times. At the head of the Church was the Pope, who was accepted as the vicar of Christ. Popes were often stronger than the kings and could force them to obey their orders. Christianity taught that man's life on earth was not the end of existence, and that he should give up pleasures in this life in order to have a life of the spirit after death. Many Christian monks - St. Francis, St. Benedict, St. Augustine - laid great stress on purity, resistance to temptation and the pursuit of 'goodness'. Some people withdrew from worldly life and led a life of virtue and penance. Some men became monks and took the vows of obedience, poverty and chastity. Some women became nuns and lived in nunneries. The institutions where the monks lived together were called monasteries. This may remind you of the Budddhist *bhikshus* and their *viharas*. Life in monastery was well organized. Monks and nuns had to observe rigid rules of discipline. They could not marry or own property. They either worked or prayed. The slightest disobedience brought hard punishment. Some monasteries, like those funded by St. Benedict, were centres of learning and assured the members a well-ordered life. Through their strict rules of discipline, they trained groups who by their example and preaching, sought to uplift the moral life of the people, educate the laity and tend the sick. Gradually, however corruption crept into the monasteries. They acquired land and amassed wealth, helping to make the Church one of the biggest land-owners in medieval times. With cultivation and other work done by serfs, the life of many monks and nuns was no longer frugal and austere. Luxury, good food and drink, and idleness became common. Some great leaders sought to reform this state of affairs by introducing a new religious order - that of wandering monks. Members of this order had no homes but moved among the people, living on charity and setting an example of a life of chastity and self-sacrifice.

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During the early Middle Ages, Churches were the only centres of education and learning. The kinds of schools to which parents sent their children, when the Greek and Roman civilizations were still flourishing, had disappeared. The education that churches could provide was like a drop in the ocean. For a long time, monks and priests were the only literate men in Europe. Learning was kept alive by the Church and the monks in the monasteries. However, the learning fostered by the Church was a narrow type. Subjects that it taught were grammar, logic, arithmetic and theology. The only calling for which this education was suitable was that of a monk or a priest. The language of learning was Latin, which only churchmen could read. Everything was dominated by faith and anybody who appealed to reason against dogma was punished. Science had come to standstill. Magic and superstition held the day. Belief in witches was common and the punishment for witches was to burn them alive.

However, by the end of the Middle Ages (fourteenth century onwards), some changes started taking place in European societies which marked the decline of feudal system.

The revival of trade (discussed later under 'commercial revolution') was accompanied by the growth of towns. Old towns became larger and many new towns emerged, mainly as centres of manufacture and trade. Towns, often walled, gradually freed themselves from feudal control. They had their own governments and the townsmen elected their officials. They had their own militia and their own courts. Unlike the serfs, there were no restrictions on their movements. They could come and go as they pleased and buy and sell property. Towns provided asylum to serfs who escaped from feudal oppression. The towns encouraged the cultivation of cash crops needed for manufactures, and peasants received their payments in money. The peasants could now pay their dues to the lord in cash rather than by labour.

With the growth of trade, there was increasing use of money. Money had little use in feudal societies. A feudal manor was more or less self-sufficient for its needs. There was very little of buying and selling and whatever there was, was done through barter. The use of money indicated far-reaching changes in economy. In feudal societies, the indictor of a man's wealth was land. Some people had wealth, particularly the Church and sometimes the nobles, in the form of gold and silver, but it was idle wealth. It could not be used to make more wealth. With the growth of trade and manufactures, this changed, marking the beginning of the transition from feudal economy to capitalist economy in which wealth is used to make a profit. This is done by investing money in business, in trade and industry. The profits made are re-invested to make further profits. Such wealth or money is called 'capital'. Money, not the landed property, increasingly became the measure

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of man's wealth. In feudal societies, there were three classes of people: the prayers, that is, the clergy who prayed, the soldiers or the knights who fought, and workers or the peasants who worked for both the prayers and the soldiers. With the growth of trade a new class emerged - the 'middle class' - comprising mainly the merchants. Even though small in number, they began to play an important role in society because of the wealth they possessed. This early phase of capitalism is known as 'mercantile capitalism'. Thus mercantile capitalism is a system of trading for profit, typically in commodities produced by non-capitalist production methods.

Simultaneous with these developments changes took place in the system of manufacturing goods. In the early medieval period, most of the non-agricultural products required by the peasants were produced in the household of the peasant and by serfs, who were skilled craftsmen, for the lord. With the growth of towns, many of these activities shifted to towns where people skilled in particular crafts organized themselves into 'guilds'. Each craft guild had master craftsmen, journeyman and apprentices. To learn a craft, a person joined a master as an apprentice or learner. After having learned the craft, he worked as a journeyman with the master on a wage or, if he had mastered the craft, he would himself become a master craftsman. The units of production were small, consisting of three or four people, and each unit had a shop to sell its produce. There were no inequalities within a unit or between units of the same guild. The guild system, was not suited to the requirements of large scale production required by an expanding market for goods, and the system began to decline. Inequities appeared with the system, with masters refusing to let journeymen become masters and paying them low wages. With the introduction of 'the putting out system', their independence declined. The merchant, under this system, would bring the master craftsmen the raw materials, the craftsmen would work with their tools as before in their homes and the produce would be taken away by the merchant who had supplied them with raw materials. Thus, in effect, unlike before, the craftsmen did not own what they produced. They were increasingly reduced to the position of wage-earners, except that they still owned the tools used by them and worked at home.

Subsequently, this system gave way to the factory system (discussed later under 'industrial revolution') under which the production was carried out in a building owned by the capitalist with the help of machines also owned by him. The workers, owing nothing, worked only for wages. In industries, such as mining and metal-working, the new system came into being early. The period saw tremendous expansion of manufactures. This was accompanied by a growing differentiation in towns and the emergence of working class.

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As a result of these developments, the feudal system broke down. The towns which were free from the control of the lords began to undermine the stability of the feudal society. In course of time, towns became very prosperous. Kings who were quite powerless in the feudal system began to take the help and support of townsmen to increase their power and to enforce their will over the lords. The kings also started having their own armies and thus freed themselves from their earlier dependence on the lords for soldiers. This led to the emergence of strong nation-states. Thus, feudalism began to decline although it was finally ended in most countries only in the 18th and 19th centuries. In its place, a new system of society (Capitalist Society) began to emerge.

However, feudalism served its purpose of bringing a measure of orderliness, safety and security to medieval life. It allowed social and economic activity to run its normal course. But feudalism had also another side to it. It developed, and was dependent on, a rigid class system. Man was divided from man, class from class, and this stood in the way of political unity. The nobles looked down upon the common man, and their inherited authority brought with it one-man rule and oppression. The lords were often too powerful for the kings to control and fought among themselves for small selfish ends. The king had no contact with the common man, who was left entirely to the mercy of his lord, and the lord was usually irresponsible and unmindful of the welfare of common people. The feudal system also led to economic stagnation. The wealth produced by the peasants and the artisans was wastefully consumed by the feudal lords, in luxurious living and in wars. Individual enterprise and initiative were all but unknown. Further, the desire for the new lands and riches encouraged the lords and leaders of the Church to fight the 'holy wars', or the Crusades.

The medieval period, lasting roughly from fifth through the thirteenth centuries A.D. have often been called the "Dark Ages" and to some extent it was truly so. The helplessness of the common man, the arbitrary rule of the king and the barons and the absence of national unity were some of the aspects of the darker side of those times. Education was very uncommon and people led a miserable life. The prevailing European view of the "Dark Ages" was that civilization had stagnated. Not only were scientific and artistic advances rare, but much of the knowledge of the classical period was lost. Cultural activities came to an end with the arrival of invading "barbarians", and the western Roman Empire disintegrated into thousands of isolated villages where there was little interest in, or time for, study. Memory of the classical period faded except in a few sequestered monasteries, where ancient texts were stored and in the Islamic world, where scholars translated Greek texts into Arabic. During the "Dark Ages" the overwhelming majority of Europeans were crude illiterates, and even educated

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people knew less about science, medicine, and art than their counterparts in the classical period.

Task:

1. Notes-Making Assignment

Please note that in the notes-making assignment you have to identify only those points which constitute the central theme of the given topic. To gain an edge over other candidates, you need to continuously enrich your notes with vital but relevant inputs. For this you may also include here some recent data, case studies or examples. For this you may refer newspapers (*The Hindu*, *The Times of India*, *The Indian Express*), magazines (*Yojana*, *Kurushetra*, *Frontline*, *The Economic and Political Weekly*, *Mainstream*) and government publications (*India Year Book*, *The Economic Survey*, *The Census of India*) etc.

Please take this exercise seriously because you would need to refer these self-made notes only just a couple of days before exam. So, be as brief and precise as possible. The first exercise is done for you to help you understand the approach as well as the methodology better.

Identify five important features of feudal society (only in the form of Pointers).

- Dominant system of social-economic and political organization in Medieval Europe
- Based upon a system of land tenure (King → Dukes and Earls→ Barons → Knights → Peasants)
- Characterized by estate system of stratification (Clergy, Nobility and Commoners)
- Largely subsistent economy characterized by the absence of a strong central authority
- Started declining fourteenth century onwards on account of revival of trade and commerce and emergence of urban centres (Commercial Revolution)

2. Writing-Skill Assignment

Now, once you have made your notes on the given topic in the pointers form, it is time to practice writing short notes so as to sharpen your answer-writing skills. Dear Candidate, I repeat that no matter for how many hours or years you may have studied but ultimately it is only those 3 hours in the examination hall that would decide your fate. Hence I always suggest my students to continuously monitor their

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progress in writing-skills by regularly writing answers and getting it evaluated by me.

The first exercise is done for you.

Write a short note on feudalism. (100-120 words)

Feudalism was the dominant system of social-economic and political organization in Medieval Europe. It was based upon a system of land tenure in which land estates of various sizes (fiefs) were given to hold (not to own) by an overlord to his vassals (knights) in return for military service. Estate system of social stratification was the characteristic feature of feudal European societies whereby one section or estate was distinguished from the other in terms of status, privileges and restrictions accorded to that estate. Feudal society was largely subsistent and stagnant economy characterized by the absence of a strong central authority. However, feudal social order started declining fourteenth century onwards on account of revival of trade and commerce and emergence of urban centres in western European societies. (Total Words: 126)

3. For Interview

Questions may be asked on the following to test your conceptual clarity and grasp of the subject.

Feudalism * Estate system of stratification * Manorialism * Factors responsible for the decline of feudalism * Karl Marx on feudalism

However, fourteenth century onwards the society in Europe started changing. A number of interrelated developments took place in the period from about fourteenth to seventeenth century which marked the beginning of modern age.

Anthony Giddens also states in *The Consequences of Modernity* (1990) that modernity refers to 'modes of social life or organization which emerged in Europe from about the seventeenth century onwards and which subsequently became more or less worldwide in their influence'. According to Giddens, modernity represents a sharp qualitative break from previous traditional social orders.

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Let us first understand that what were these changes which took place from about fourteenth to seventeenth century in Europe and marked the beginning of modern age? How the new social order which emerged in Europe from about the seventeenth century onwards was qualitatively different from the previous traditional social orders.

Historians generally agree that from fourteenth to sixteenth centuries, Europe had been witnessing changes in its social, economic and political structures, which marked the beginning of the modern period. In the next section, we will learn about the various social, economic and political changes that Europe witnessed in the form of Renaissance, Commercial Revolution, Scientific Revolution, Reformation, Enlightenment, Industrial Revolution, French Revolution, etc.

One of the first developments that marked the beginning of a new era was the *Renaissance*. The medieval Dark Age was followed by the Renaissance, coming in the fourteenth century and lasting to the end of the sixteenth century. The Renaissance refers, in a literal sense, to the intellectual rebirth of Europe as people tried to recapture the artistic, philosophical, scientific, and commercial glory of the 'classical period'. It is important to emphasize that the conventional nineteenth-century assessment was that the Renaissance had been a period of rediscovery. There was a great appreciation for the cultural accomplishments of the Greeks and Romans and a genuine desire to replicate those accomplishments and, hence, to recapture the cultural glory of earlier times. [Please note that the "Classical Period" of Western history, the era of Greece and, later, Rome, lasted roughly from the eighth century B.C. until the fourth century A.D. Many note-worthy scientific and artistic advances were made during that period. To name just a few: geometry was developed; money came into circulation; trade expanded; accounting practices emerged; shipbuilding improved; the Phoenician alphabet was made more precise with the inclusion of vowels; literature was born; comedies and tragedies were written; amphitheaters were constructed; great philosophical debates raged; engineers achieved wondrous feats (literally, the "wonders of the ancient world"); monuments were built; medicine advanced; libraries were constructed; elements of democratic governmental forms came into being; and education expanded. In short, civilization flowered. Advances were intermittent, to be sure, but over time the total stock of knowledge increased and diffused widely to other parts of the world. At least it was the nineteenth-century European view that the classical period of the Greeks and Romans marked such a flowering of civilization.]

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The term 'Renaissance' literally means rebirth and is, in a narrow sense, used to describe the revival of interest in the learning of the classical civilizations of Greece and Rome. This revival first began in Italy when a number of scholars from Constantinople migrated to Italy and a number of Italian scholars went to Constantinople and other cities of the old Byzantine empire in search of Greek classics. The Renaissance emerged in Italy roughly between A.D. 1300 and A.D. 1550 and then spread to northern Europe during the first half of the 16th century. The renaissance started in Italy because of several factors. First, Italy always had a cultural advantage over the rest of Europe because its geography made it the natural gateway between the East and the West. Venice, Genoa, Milan, Pisa and Florence traded uninterruptedly with the Asian countries and maintained a vibrant urban society. The Italian cities had grown up in an atmosphere of freedom from feudal control. Freedom encouraged thinking and a spirit of adventure. The rulers of the Italian states were patrons of learning and the arts.

During the 13th and the 14th centuries, mercantile cities expanded to become powerful city states dominating the political and economic life of the surrounding countryside. Italian aristocrats customarily lived in urban centres rather than in rural castles unlike their counterparts in northern Europe and consequently became fully involved in urban public affairs. The neo-rich mercantile communities which came to be known as the *bourgeoisie* tried to gain the status of aristocracy. Merchant families tried to imitate an aristocratic life-style. Their wealth and profession became an important factor for the development of education in Italy. There was not only a demand for education for the development of skills in reading and accountancy, necessary to become successful merchants, but also the richest and most prominent families looked for able teachers who would impart to their offspring the knowledge and skills necessary to argue well in the public arena. Consequently Italy produced a large number of educators, many of whom not only taught students but also demonstrated their learning in the production of political and ethical treaties and works of literature.

Another reason, why the late medieval Italy became the birthplace of an intellectual and artistic renaissance, was because it had a far greater sense of rapport with the classical past than any other region of Europe. In Italy the classical past appeared immensely relevant as ancient Roman monuments were present all over the peninsula and the ancient Latin literature referred to cities and sites that Italians recognized as their own. Further, Italian renaissance was also facilitated by the patronage that it received in abundance. The wealthy cities of Italy vied with each other to construct splendid public monuments and support writers whose role was to glorify the urban republic in their writing and speeches. As a result, hundreds of classical writings, unknown to Europeans for centuries, were circulating first in Italy and then other parts of Europe. The interest in classical

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learning and in other achievements of the civilizations of Greece and Rome deeply influenced Europeans. The Renaissance, however, was not, as mentioned earlier, a mere revival of ancient learning and knowledge of the achievements of ancient Greece and Rome. It was marked by a series of new developments in the field of art, literature, religion, philosophy, science and politics.

The early phase of Renaissance was described as a period of revival as it concentrated in reviving the old learning which was disseminated through the traditional methods. The latter phase was described as a period of innovation as much new knowledge was generated during this period, which laid the foundation for the growth of modern thought. This new knowledge was spread by a new medium, i.e print. This meant that a large number of people and countries could share the knowledge and debate the changes. Though, the study of classical and Christian antiquity existed before the renaissance, there was a significant difference between the learning of the middle age scholars and the renaissance thinkers. The renaissance thinkers recovered the works of lesser-known scholars and made them popular along side the more famous ones. The Greek scientific and the philosophical treatises were made available to the westerners in Latin translations. The renaissance thinkers used classical texts in new ways such as to reconsider their preconceived notions and alter their mode of expression.

So, rational thinking tempered with a spirit of scientific enquiry about the universe and the existence of humanity in it, became the important characteristic of the renaissance outlook. These rational ideas also helped in developing a society that was increasingly non-ecclesiastical in comparison to the culture of the Middle ages. The intellectual and cultural life of Europe for centuries had been dominated by the Catholic Church. The renaissance undermined this domination. The revival of pre-Christian classical learning and of interest in the cultural achievements of ancient Greece and Rome were, in themselves, also an important factor in undermining the domination of the Church.

The chief characteristic of the Renaissance way of thinking was *humanism*. It was the heart and soul of the Renaissance. Basically, it meant a decisive shift in concern for human as distinct from divine matters. Humanism was a system of views which extolled man, stressed his essential worth and dignity, expressed deep faith in his tremendous creative potential, and proclaimed freedom of the individual and inalienable rights of the individual. It was centered on the man of flesh and blood with all his earthly joys and sorrows, opposed to religious asceticism and defended his right to pleasure and the satisfaction of earthly desires and requirements. It meant the glorification of the human and natural as opposed to the divine and other-worldly. The humanists rejected and even ridiculed religious asceticism, mortification of the flesh and withdrawal from the world. They urged

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man to seek joy on this earth rather than in an afterlife which the Church advocated. Their works were permeated with the faith that a man with an active mind and body was capable of knowing and controlling the world, of performing miracles and fashioning his own happiness. The proper study of Mankind, it was asserted, is Man, Humanity rather than Divinity. The Renaissance men, hungered after more knowledge. They came to feel that human life is important, that man is worthy of study and respect, that there should be efforts to improve life on this earth. Because of this interest in human affairs, the study of literature and history became major areas of study. Literature and history came to be called the 'humanities' which were primarily concerned with understanding the affairs of man in his earthly life, not with life after death.

Task:

1. Notes-Making Assignment

Identify the main characteristics of Renaissance. (only Pointers)

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2. Writing-Skill Assignment

'Renaissance marked a qualitative shift in the history of western European society'. Discuss. (150 words)

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3. For Interview

Renaissance	*	Factors responsible for its origin in Italy

Another development which marked the beginning of the modern age was the 'commercial revolution', fostered by a series of 'voyages of discovery'. The "Commercial revolution" refers to the expansion of trade and commerce that took place from the 15th century onwards. It was of such a large scale and organized manner that it is called a Revolution. The Commercial revolution signaled a shift from the largely subsistence and stagnant economy of medieval Europe to a more dynamic and world wide system. This expansion was as a result of the initiative taken by certain European countries to develop and consolidate their economic and political power. These countries were Portugal, Spain, Holland and England.

The same spirit of curiosity that led some of Europe's Renaissance men to effect new developments in art, literature, science, and religion led others to adventure and the discovery of new lands. The main motivation behind these adventures was the profits that trade with the East would bring. Earlier, Europe trade with the Oriental or Eastern countries like India and China was transacted by land routes. The northern Italian cities of Venice and Genoa were the major centres of trade. The result of the Italian monopoly was that the prices of goods like spices and silks imported form the East was extremely high. For example, after his first voyage to India, Vasco Da Gama found that the price of pepper in Calicut was one-

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twenty sixth of the price prevailing in Venice. The prosperity of the Italian cities that had grown rich from their trade with eastern countries aroused the envy of the other European nations; they longed to have a share in the trade.

But after 1453, the Turks cut off this trade through Asia Minor and if the Europeans were to continue to have spices, these products had to be brought by a different route. Finding new routes was a challenge to the adventurous sailors of the Renaissance. Thus, a shift from land routes to sea-routes began. Helped by some remarkable inventions, daring sailors sailed for distant lands. Invention of mariner's compass, astrolabe and newly prepared maps and guidebooks greatly facilitated these voyages. With the help of the compass, navigators determined the directions on high seas. The Astrolabe helped in determining the latitude of a particular area. These voyages were financed by rulers and merchants who sponsored the costly voyages of the sea-farers for the profits that the voyages would bring. The discoveries of the sea-farers extended the knowledge about the world and the old maps which were both inaccurate and incomplete had to be redrawn.

The voyages and discoveries of Columbus, Vasco da Gama and Magellan changed man's idea of the world, revolutionized trade and started waves of colonization that have determined the course of world history ever since. Portugal and Spain were among the first Europe countries, which financed these explorations and discoveries. Britain, France and Holland soon followed Spain and Portugal. Soon parts of Asia, Africa, Malacca, the Spice Islands, West Indies, N. America and S. America came under the control of Spain, Portugal, Britain, France and Holland. Commerce expanded into a world enterprise. The monopoly of the Italian cities was destroyed. European markets were flooded with new commodities; spice & textiles from the East, tobacco from N. America, Cocoa, Chocolate & quinine from S. America, ivory and, above all, human slaves from Africa. With the discovery of Americas, the range of trade widened. Formerly, the items sought for were spices and cloth, but later, gold and silver were added to the list. As the commercial revolution progressed, the position of Portugal and Spain declined. Britain, France and Holland came to dominate Europe and the world. This marked the early phase of capitalism known as 'mercantile capitalism'. It was characterized by growth of trade and commerce and generating profits through trade.

Subsequently, this accumulated wealth or capital was further reinvested in land & agriculture (scientific farming and sheep-rearing) to generate further profits. This led to the transformation of agriculture in Europe, called as 'agricultural revolution'. The agrarian revolution saw the transformation of a system of subsistence into a system of surplus by production of cash crops for the

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market, the surplus being made possible by reformed and mechanized cultivation. So, mercantile capitalism was followed by the capitalistic transformation of agriculture or agrarian capitalism. The first sign of capitalistic transformation of agriculture manifested itself in England in the form of land enclosures which began to occur in the rural economy as early as 1560, when landholders began to assert rights of private property over feudal land. It has been called by the historians as Enclosure Movement. Essentially, the enclosure movement can be described as a system whereby tenant holdings in feudal land and agriculture became enclosed and made available for the private use of landholder. As, a result peasant families were evicted from their holdings and in many cases thrown off the land. While many of the first enclosures were initiated by landlords in order to appropriate tenant holdings, in latter stages of change they were used to make way for sheep pastures. However, by 1710 the first Enclosure Bill appeared which legalized the enclosure of tenant holdings by Parliamentary Acts. With parliamentary approval, enclosures could proceed at a more advanced rate and eventually became commonplace by mid century as conversions became more rapid. By 1800, 4000 Parliamentary Acts had been passed and in excess of six million acres of land had been enclosed.

As the pace of economic change began to intensify, the rate of enclosures accelerated to the point where the displaced population of agricultural workers began to increase dramatically and this began to mobilize a transfer of the population to the centers of industry. As statutory enactments gave the power of eviction to landlords, legal proceedings multiplied the rate of local evictions and at the same time restricted the use of pastures from domestic animals, prohibited the use of arable land from tenant agriculture, and displaced agricultural workers and hereditary tenants. In practice, enclosures became a society-wide depopulation movement fueled by mass evictions and foreclosures which coercively separated peasants from their means of livelihood by removing them from their own agricultural holdings. As serfs were forced off the land, landlords were able to assert rights of modern private property over land to which they previously held only feudal title. This hastened the transformation of land into a commercial commodity, first by subjecting it to buying and selling, and second by extending its capacity to produce money rent. Under these circumstances, customary rights and obligations in land began to be forcibly dissolved, and with this went the bonds connecting peasants to the land through heredity tenure and leasehold. As soon as money rents replaced labour rent, peasants were forced to focus their attention on their own holdings, making money rent a precondition to economic survival. Those who were unable to pay were eventually ruined or evicted. At this point it became possible to express the value of land in money, and this led to the transformation of land into private property and eventually a commercial commodity. As land became subject to buying and selling, the economic balance between serfs and

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landlords was upset and feudal obligations in land and livelihood began to deteriorate.

As the breakdown of feudal obligations in land continued, it began to place the serf population under new forces of social differentiation and fragmentation. This put the serf population at the disposal of the new forces of production, which put into play a massive demographic transfer of the agricultural population into the industrial centers, bringing about a more complete transition to a new category of labour based on wages. At this stage, the flow of population from the old feudal economies to the new economies of industry became a more urgent fact of economic change, and this began to complete the process of transforming the agricultural worker of previous centuries into the wage labourer of the industrial economy. By 1840 the transition to an industrial economy was more or less complete. Several consequences ensued as a result of the displacement of the serf population from the rural economies. Firstly, as the transfer of the population proceeded, it brought about a massive social displacement which dispersed families, uprooted local economies and undermined regional modes of life and livelihood. Secondly, it dissolved the serf's relationship to the land and altered the system of economic livelihood, forcing serfs to sell their labour for a wage, and severing the serf's feudal relation to the agricultural means of production. Thirdly, the shift to an industrial economy meant that wage labourers were unable to employ the means of production on their own as they once did in a feudal economy, and as a result they lost control over the ability to put the means of production to work. Further, as the shift to an industrial economy became finalized, the old class structure of feudal society was replaced by the formation of a new commercial class who were at the center of power and industry. This began to bring about the transfer of the ownership of the means of production to the commercial classes and, consequently, as the means of production fell into private hands, it became the property of one class.

During much of the eighteenth century, the last remnants of the old economic order were crumbling under the impact of the industrial revolution. In historical terminology, industrial revolution means primarily the period of British History from the middle of the eighteenth century to the middle of nineteenth century. England in the 18^{th} century was in the most favourable position for an industrial revolution. Through her overseas trade, including trade in slaves, she had accumulated vast profits which could provide the necessary capital. In the trade rivalries of European countries, she had emerged as an unrivalled power. She had acquired colonies which ensured a regular supply of raw materials. The term 'industrial revolution' was first used in the 1880s to denote the sudden acceleration of technical developments by the application of steam power to machines which replaced tools. The term got popularized when Arnold Toynbee's

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Industrial Revolution appeared in 1884. As discussed earlier, the new system of society which had been emerging in Europe from the 15th century was called *capitalism.* Under capitalism, the instruments and the means by which goods are produced are owned by private individuals and the production is carried out for making profit. The workers under this system do not own anything but work for a wage. The owners of wealth under capitalism who are called capitalists do not keep their wealth or consume it or use it for purposes of display but invest it to make profit. Goods are produced for sale in the market with a view to making profit. This system is in marked contrast with the feudal system in which goods were produced for local use and the investment of wealth for making profit did not take place. Economic life under feudalism was static as goods were produced for local consumption and there was no incentive to produce more by employing better means of producing goods for a bigger market. In contrast, the economy under capitalism was fast moving with the aim of producing more and more goods for bigger markets so that more profits could be made.

The desire to produce more goods at low cost to make higher profits led to the Industrial Revolution and further growth of capitalism. The Industrial Revolution began in England in about 1750. It was then that machines began to take over some of the works of men and animals in the production of goods and commodities. That is why we often say that the Industrial Revolution was the beginning of a 'machine age'. You have read before that the guild system had given way to the 'domestic' or the 'putting-out' system. In the 18th century, the domestic system had become obsolete. It started giving way to a new system called the 'factory system'. In place of simple tools and the use of animal and manual power, new machines and steam power came to be increasingly used. Many new cities sprang up and artisans and dispossessed peasants went there to work. Production was now carried on in a factory (in place of workshops in homes), with the help of machines (in place of simple tools). Facilities for production were owned and managed by *capitalists*, the people with money to invest in further production. Everything required for production was provided by the capitalists for the workers who were brought together under one roof. Everything belonged to the owner of the factory, including the finished product, and workers worked for wages. This system, known as the factory system, brought on the *Industrial Revolution.* This phase of capitalism is known as industrial capitalism. Industrial capitalism is capitalism's classical or stereotypical form.

The eighteenth century saw the growth of free labour and more competitive manufacturing. The cotton industry was the first to break the hold of the guilds and chartered corporations, but with each decade, other industries were subjected to the liberating effects of free labour, free trade, and free production. By the time large-scale industry emerged – first in England, then in France, and later in

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Germany – the economic reorganization of Europe had been achieved. Large-scale industry and manufacture simply accelerated the transformations in society that had been occurring for decades. These transformations involved a profound organization of society. Labour was liberated from the land; wealth and capital existed independently of the large noble estates; large-scale industry accelerated urbanization of the population; the extension of competitive industry hastened the development of new technologies; increased production encouraged the expansion of markets and world trade for securing raw resources and selling finished goods; religious organizations lost much of their authority in the face of secular economic activities; family structure was altered as people moved from rural to urban areas; law became as concerned with regularizing the new economic processes as with preserving the privilege of the nobility; and the old political regimes legitimated by "divine right" successively became less tenable.

Thus, the emergence of a capitalist economic system inexorably destroyed the last remnant of the feudal order and the transitional mercantile order of restrictive guilds and chartered corporations. Such economic changes greatly altered the way people lived, created new social classes (such as the bourgeoisie and urban proletariat), and led not only to a revolution of ideas but also to a series of political revolutions. These changes were less traumatic in England than in France, where the full brunt of these economic forces clashed with the Old Regime. It was in this volatile mixture of economic changes, coupled with the scientific revolution of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, that political and intellectual revolutions were to be spawned. And out of these combined revolutions, sociology emerged.

The 'Renaissance' period also saw the beginning of the 'Scientific Revolution'. It is an undeniable fact that, if we want to seek out the cause of the Scientific Revolution, we must look for them among the wider changes taking place in that sea-change of European history known as the Renaissance. The Scientific Revolution cannot be explained without reference to the Renaissance. The Scientific Revolution, like the Protestant Reformation, can and should be seen as one of the outcomes of the Renaissance. The Scientific Revolution marked an era of description and criticism in the field of science. It was a clear break from the past, a challenge to old authority. The impact of the scientific revolution was crucial not just in changing material life, but also man's ideas about Nature and Society. It is worth noting that science does not develop independent of society, rather, it develops in response to human needs. For example, various vaccines were developed out of the necessity to cure diseases. Apart from influencing the physical or material life of society, science is intimately connected with ideas. The general intellectual atmosphere existing in society influences the development of science. Similarly, new developments in science can also change the attitudes and

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beliefs of people about nature and society. New scientific ideas influenced scholars to think about society in new ways. The emergence of sociology in Europe owes a great deal to the ideas and discoveries contributed by science.

As stated earlier, the medieval society was characterized by the feudal system. The Church was the epicenter of authority and learning. Knowledge was largely religious in nature. Nothing could challenge the 'dogmas' or rigid beliefs of the Church. New, daring ideas could not flower in such an atmosphere. Thus the development of science was restricted mainly to improvement in the techniques of production. However, the renaissance thinkers rejected the blind acceptance of authority. They asserted that knowledge could be gained 'by going out and studying mentally and manually the Book of Nature', and not by speculation. This new outlook marked a break with the past and prepared the way for the advancement of science. It was summed up by **Francis Bacon**, an English philosopher, who said that knowledge could be gained only by observation and experimentation. According to Bacon, he who seeks knowledge should *first look at things that happen in the world around him*. He should then ask himself *what causes these things to happen* and, after he has formed a theory or belief, as to the possible cause, he should experiment. *The experiment is to test his belief* and see whether the assumed cause does, in fact, produce the result he has observed. Bacon believed that the 'true and lawful end of the sciences is that human life be enriched by new discoveries and powers.'

One of the first achievements of the Renaissance in science was in astronomy. The year 1543 marked the development of modern astronomical studies with the publication of Copernicus' *Six Books Concerning the Revolutions of the Heavenly Spheres*. **Copernicus** (1473-1543) was a polish scholar who lived in Italy for many years. His work in mathematics and astronomy demolished the hypothesis of the geocentric (Earth-centred) universe derived from Ptolemy and other astronomers of the past. In its place he advanced the revolutionary new hypothesis of the heliocentric (Sun-centred) universe. This meant that the earth moved round a fixed Sun and not the other way round. The Copernican hypothesis had radical implications. It destroyed the idea of the earth's uniqueness by suggesting that it acted like other heavenly bodies. More importantly, his theory contradicted the earlier notions about the centrality of the earth to the cosmic order. The very idea of an open universe of which the earth was but a small part shattered the earlier view of a closed universe created and maintained in motion by God. This was an important break with the ancient system of thought. For over a thousands years, it was believed that the earth was the centre of the universe. It was one of the basic dogmas of the philosophers of the time. Its refutation was an attack on the conception of the universe held by the Church. This was, therefore, condemned as a heresy. Copernicus' book was published in 1543, the year in

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which he died. He had hesitated from publishing it for fear of the hostility of the Church. About half a century after the publication of Copernicus' book, in 1600, Giordano Bruno was burnt at the stake on the charge of heresy. He had advocated ideas which were based on Copernicus' view of the universe.

The next major steps toward the conception of a heliocentric system were taken by the Danish astronomer **Tycho Brahe** (1546-1601) and the German astronomer **Johannes Kepler** (1571-1630). Tycho Brahe constructed the most accurate tables of astronomical observations. After his death, these observations came into the possession of Kepler, who after much work, agreed to the heliocentric theory, though he abandoned the Copernican concept of circular orbits. The mathematical relationship that emerged from a consideration of Brahe's observations suggested that the orbits of the planets were elliptical. Kepler published his findings in 1609 in a book entitled *On the Motion of Mars*. Thus, he solved the problems of planetary orbits by using the Copernican theory and Brahe's empirical data. However, in the same year when Kepler published his book, an Italian scientist **Galileo Galilei** (1564-1642), first turned a telescope invented by him on to the sky. Through this instrument he saw stars where none had been known to exist, mountains on the moon, spots moving across the sun and the moon and the orbiting Jupiter. Some of Galileo's colleagues at the University of Padua were so unnerved that they refused to look through the telescope because it revealed the heaven to be different from the teachings of the Church and the Ptolemaic theories. Galileo published his findings in numerous works, the most famous of which is his *Dialogues on the Two Chief Systems of the World* (1632). This book brought down on him the condemnation of the Roman Catholic Church. His life was spared only after he agreed to withdraw his views. He spent the rest of his life virtually under house arrest.

Isaac Newton was born in England in 1642, the year Galileo died. He solved the major remaining problems on the planetary motions and established a base for the modern physics. Much of the researches of Newton were based on the work of Galileo and other predecessors. In 1687, he published his treatise, *The Mathematical Principles of Natural Philosophy*. In this work he proposed that the planets and, in fact, all other particles in the universe moved through the force of mutual attraction, a law which came to be known as the Law of Gravitation. In this way, Newton combined mathematics and physics for the study of astronomy. Incidentally, he was preceded in this by **Varahamihira** and **Aryabhatta** in the 5^{th} and 6^{th} centuries A.D. in India.

The modern age of science that began with these Renaissance scientists not only increased man's knowledge but also established a method of study that could be applied to other branches of knowledge. Significant discoveries, for example

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were made in the study of the human body and circulation of the blood which helped to fight many superstitions. In 1543, the year in which Copernicus' book was published, **Vesalius**, a Belgian, published his profusely illustrated *De Humani Corporis Fabrica*. Based on his study of the dissections of the human body, this book provided the first complete description of the anatomy of the human body. **Servetus**, a Spaniard, published a book explaining the circulation of blood. He was condemned to death for questioning the Church belief in Trinity. A completed account of the constant process of circulation of blood, from the heart to all parts of the body and back to the heart was given by Harvey, an Englishman, in about 1610. This knowledge helped to start a new approach to the study of the problems of health and disease. It is important to remember that what the Renaissance scientists began learning by questioning, observation, and experimentation is the method that scientists continue to use even today. This is scientific method. It is by applying this method that our knowledge has grown so greatly. The knowledge produced during scientific revolution deeply influenced the attitudes and beliefs of people about nature and society. New scientific ideas influenced scholars to think about society in new ways. This is very important. Please keep this in mind when we discuss the ideas of enlightenment scholars later.

As mentioned earlier, that in medieval Europe Church was the epicenter of authority and learning. Knowledge was largely religious in nature. Nothing could challenge the 'dogmas' or rigid beliefs of the Church. Any idea or action which challenged the authority of the Church was, therefore, condemned as a heresy. This newly emerging scientific knowledge, which was based on empirical observation and experimentation, was not only different but also contradictory to the many teachings of the Church. This stimulated the process of 'reformation' in the religious sphere of the European society. Thus, European people with new spirit of inquiry and thought started questioning the superstitious beliefs and malpractices of the Catholic Church.

The term 'Reformation' refers to two major developments in the history of Europe towards the later part of the Renaissance. The first was the Protestant reformation which resulted in a split in Christianity and the secession of a large number of countries from the Roman Catholic Church and establishment of separate Churches in those countries, generally on national lines. The second development concerned reforms within the Roman Catholic Church, generally referred to as Catholic Reformation or Counter Reformation. But Reformation was not merely a religious movement. It was intimately connected with, and was in fact a part of, the social and political movement of the period which brought about the end of the medieval period and the emergence of the modern world.

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The Catholic Church, during the early medieval period, had become a vast hierarchical organization headed by the Pope in Rome. The Pope was the supreme authority over the entire hierarchy and he exercised this authority directly. The position of the Pope is often described by the phrase 'papal monarchy'. Systematic efforts were made to extend the authority of the Church over everyone, high or low, making an oral confession of his sins to a priest at least once a year and suffering the punishment imposed was made obligatory for everyone. The people who did not follow this were excommunicated. An excommunicated person was supposed to have been temporarily consigned to hell. If he died, his body could not be buried with the prescribed rituals. Other Christians were forbidden from associating with him. An important component of the religious thinking propagated by the Church was the theory of sacraments. A sacrament was defined as an instrument by which divine grace is communicated to men. The sacraments were regarded indispensable for securing God's grace and there was no salvation without them. Another was the theory of priesthood. It was held that the priest who was ordained by a bishop (who was confirmed by the Pope) was the inheritor of a part of the authority conferred by Christ on Peter. The priest, according to this theory had the power to co-operate with God in performing certain miracles and in releasing sinner from the consequences of their sins. Besides the sacraments, various other beliefs came to be accepted.

Reformation is often described as a revolt against abuses which had grown in the Catholic Church. Some of the priests and higher-ups in the Church hierarchy received their appointments through corrupt means. Many such appointees were utterly ignorant. They led lives of luxury and immorality. Religious offices were sold to the highest bidder and those who bought positions after spending money made good by taking high fees for the services they performed. The Popes and the higher clergy lived like princes. A new abuse was the sale of letters which remitted punishments of the sinners who bought them, both in this life and after their death in purgatory. Normally, the priests imposed a penance or punishment on a person who had sinned and he was required to perform a special service or make a pilgrimage to a holy place. But increasingly sinners with enough money could be freed from doing penance for their sins by paying the clergy for a "Letter of Indulgence". The sale of indulgences which began to be considered as passports to heaven became one of the major immediate issues which caused the protestant Reformation. Besides the sale of indulgences, one could now gain salvation in exchange for fees. The priests, the bishops and the wandering monks could pronounce a marriage lawful or unlawful. By payment of fees, the problem could be solved. There were fees for every transaction in life, from birth to death, fees for the peace of the soul and fees for the souls of the people dead long ago. The wandering monks when they wanted to, heard confessions, awarded punishments for sins and remitted the punishments for fees.

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The Protestant Revolution can be said to have begun in 1517 when **Martin Luther**, a monk of the Order of St. Augustine, nailed his ninety-five theses or statements which attacked the sale of indulgences, on the door of the Church in Wittenberg in Germany. He challenged people to come and hold debates with him on his theses and sent copies of his theses to his friends in a number of cities. During the next two years Luther wrote a series of pamphlets. He knew that his doctrines could not be reconciled with those of the Catholic Church and that he had no alternative but to break with the Catholic Church. In 1520, the Pope ordered him to recant within sixty days or be condemned as a heretic. Luther burnt the proclamation of the Pope in public. During this period, he was protected by the ruler of Saxony who was his friend. Many rulers in Germany were hostile to the Church and when Luther was excommunicated, he remained unharmed. During the next 25 years, he occupied himself with the task of building an independent German Church, and in expounding his doctrine. He rejected the entire system of the hierarchy of the Catholic Church, introduced German as the language of Church services, abolished the special status of priests as representatives of God on earth, eliminated most of the sacraments, and emphasized faith rather than pilgrimages. He gave the highest priority to the supreme authority of the scriptures. Another important change was the abandonment of the view of the Catholic Church that the Church was supreme over the state. The German rulers and common people of Germany supported Luther. There were political reasons for the support of the rulers. They wanted to be free from the authority of Popes and get possession of the wealth in German monasteries for themselves. The common people liked Luther's teaching because it gave them an opportunity to demand more freedom from their rulers.

Ulrich Zwingli and **John Calvin** became the leaders of the Protestant movement in Switzerland. Under the leadership of Calvin, the Swiss cities became a refuge for Protestants fleeing to other countries in western Europe due to religious persecution. Calvin established an academy for the training of Protestant missionaries, who in return would spread the true word of God in other lands. As part of the work of propagating his version of Protestantism, Calvin composed a treatise entitled, *The Institutes of the Christian Religion*, wherein he gave a more concise and logical definition of the Protestant doctrines than what had been given by any other leader of this movement.

In England the Protestant movement was led by political leaders, particularly King Henry VIII and Queen Elizabeth I. Their reforms were not driven by the ides of religious or social reforms but by the interests of the state and more practically, the personal ambition of Henry VIII. Henry VIII sought to divorce his wife Catherine of Aragon and wanted to marry his beloved Anne Boleyn. The Pope refused to grant the divorce on the ground that Henry, before marrying Catherine,

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had asked for and had received a special Papal dispensation declaring his marriage with Catherine as valid and indissoluble. Rebuffed by the Pope, Henry promptly declared himself the "sole protector and supreme head of the Church and the Clergy of England". After that he married Anne Boleyn. From this marriage was born Elizabeth I, who later became the Queen of England. England's final break with the Pope came in 1529, when in a special session of the British Parliament a series of laws were passed to make the English Church completely free from the jurisdiction of the Pope. The King of England was also declared as the head of the English Church, which hereafter came to be known as the Anglican Church.

The Roman Catholic Church had been shaken to its very root by the movements started by Luther, Zwingli and Calvin. To counter the damage caused by the Protestant Movements, a series of reforms began within the Catholic Church, which came to be known as the 'Counter-Reformation'. During Counter-Reformation efforts were made to restore the Catholic Church's universal authority. One of these efforts took place in the Council of Trent (1545) summoned by Pope Paul III. The Council was to consider the ways and means to combat Protestantism. So it decided to settle the doctrinal disputes between the Catholics and the Protestants; clean up moral and administrative abuses within the Catholic Church and organise a new crusade against the Muslims. The next step was the organization of an order of missionaries, known as the Jesuits, with the dedicated purpose of spreading the message of Christ. The above measures adopted by the Catholic Church were not sufficient to bring the whole of Europe under the authority of the Pope. The campaign, however, did achieve a considerable measure of success in checking the further spread of Protestantism. Though much of Europe remained Protestant, new lands overseas were being won to the Catholic Church.

Reacting to economic and political changes, the concomitant reorganization of social life, much of the eighteenth century was consumed by intellectual ferment. The intellectual revolution of the eighteenth century is commonly referred to as the ***Enlightenment***. In England and Scotland, the Enlightenment was dominated by a group of thinkers who argued for a vision of human beings and society that both reflected and justified the industrial capitalism that first emerged in the British Isles. For scholars such as Adam Smith, individuals are to be free of external constraint and allowed to compete, thereby creating a better society. In France, the Enlightenment is often termed the *Age of Reason*, and it was dominated by a group of scholars known as the *philosophes*. It is out of the intellectual ferment generated by the French philosophes that sociology was born.

This section is very important, not only for your written examination but also for the interview. Please read it carefully.

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The term 'Enlightenment' is used in an academic and technical sense to indicate the intellectual movement in 18th century western and central Europe especially in England and France. Its historical significance lay in breaking the shackles of ideas imposed by tradition or authority whether of state or Church. For a long period in history up to that time, the standard method of arriving at the truth lay in an appeal to authority. It meant in practice, that truth was determined by one's superiors and one was not expected to doubt or question their wisdom. To buttress their claim, both state and Church would base their authority on supernatural sanction rather than on popular sovereignty. This had been the basis of absolutism and absolute monarchs ruled in nearly all parts of Europe. Conflicts between Church and state were not infrequent but these rarely concerned the common man in an age when communications were poor and his struggle for existence much harder.

Things in the meantime had changed fast during the 16th and 17th Centuries. Significant advances had been made in discoveries of new lands and routes; technologies as applied to agriculture and industries had increased production, and that possibly accounts for the rapid increase of population that took place both in England and France. Urban areas expanded and a middle class emerged to avail itself of the new opportunities in sectors like banking, industry, trade, journalism and above all education that served as a catalyst in the movement of ideas.

The essence of Enlightenment lay in its challenge to absolutism, the questioning of authority through a new conception of truth. In the course of Enlightenment, reason supplanted authority as the accepted method of arriving at the truth. All who look part in this movement of ideas were convinced that human understanding is capable by its own power and without recourse to supernatural assistance, of comprehending the system of the world. A new optimism was breathed about man's capacity to usher in a happier social order. The basic difference between the Absolutist view and Enlightened view centered round the individual. Under absolutism, the individual had to submit to the authority which was supposed to possess the monopoly of the truth; but under Enlightenment the individual acquired a new importance, dignity and self respect. Any man's opinion was potentially worth something. One no longer had to be a bishop or prince to claim access to truth. Enlightenment stood for the classic trilogy - Liberty, Equality, Fraternity; and as such represented the fight against oppression imposed by the old social hierarchy that had developed a vested interest in keeping people ignorant and superstitious. A challenge was thrown to religious education since it was believed that such education sapped a young person's courage and killed initiative by training him to fear and obey.

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Thus, the enlightenment was a period of remarkable intellectual development and change in the philosophical thought. A number of long-standing ideas and beliefs – many of which related to social life – were overthrown and replaced during the Enlightenment. The most prominent thinkers associated with the Enlightenment were the French philosophers **Charles Montesquieu** (1689-1755) and **Jean Jacques Rousseau** (1712-1778).

Montesquieu in his book, *The Spirit of the Law*, held that there should not be concentration of authority, such as executive, legislative, and judicial, at one place. He believed in the theory of separation of powers and the liberty of the individual.

Rousseau in his book *The Social Contract* argued that the people of a country have the right to choose their sovereign. He believed that people can develop their personalities best only under a government which is of their own choice. For Rousseau, the social contract is the sole foundation of the political community. By virtue of this social contract, individuals lose their natural liberties (limited merely by their ability to exercise force over one another). However, man's natural liberty promoted unlimited acquisitiveness and avarice and thus encouraged individuals to destroy the freedom of others weaker than they. By submitting to a law vested in a social contract – a mandate that can be withdrawn at any time – individuals find in the laws to which they consent a pure expression of their being as civilized human entities.

Although the Enlightenment was fueled by the political, social, and economic changes of the eighteenth century, it derived considerable inspiration from the scientific revolution of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries. As noted earlier, the scientific revolution reached a symbolic peak, at least in the eye of eighteenth-century thinkers, with Newtonian physics. In the light of various revolutionary developments in science, particularly Physics, the universe (physical world) came to be viewed as orderly or patterned. It was argued that with scientific inquiry (based on empirical observation and application of reason) the underlying natural laws governing the universe can be discovered. Further, the knowledge of these laws would facilitate better prediction and greater control over the physical world. Thus, Physics was to become the vision of how scientific inquiry and theory should be conducted. And the individual and society were increasingly drawn into the orbit of the new view of science. This gradual inclusion of the individual and society into the realm of science represented a startling break with the past, because heretofore these phenomena had been considered the domain of morals, ethics, and religion.

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So, the enlightenment thinkers argued that just as the physical world was governed by the natural laws, it was likely that social world was, too. Thus it was up to the philosopher, using reason and research, to discover these social laws. And once such social laws are discovered, then with the knowledge of those laws we can control and create a better society (social engineering).

It is important to note that almost all enlightenment thinkers also shared 'a vision of human progress.' Humanity was seen to be marching in a direction and was considered to be governed by a "law of progress" that was as fundamental as the law of gravitation in the physical world. For example, with economic modernization and advancement of technology agricultural and industrial revolution took place leading phenomenal increase in the agricultural and industrial outputs. With commercial revolution (trade and commerce), unprecedented wealth or capital was generated. Further, scientific revolution demolished the traditionally held superstitious beliefs (sanctified by Church) and ushered in the age of reason. With its emphasis on empirical observation and application of reason, it significantly changed the social outlook of man and brought about social modernization.

At psychological level, modernity was reflected in terms of reflexivity. Reflexivity refers to the reflexive monitoring of action: that is, the way in which humans think about and reflect upon what they are doing in order to consider acting differently in future. Humans have always been reflexive up to a point, but in pre-industrial societies the importance of tradition limited reflexivity. Humans would do some things simply because they were the traditional things to do. However, with modernity, tradition loses much of its importance and reflexivity becomes the norm (psychological modernization). Social reflexivity implies that social practices are constantly examined and reformed in the light of incoming information about those very practices, thus continuously altering their character.

Further, with the rise various social and political movements, demands for greater individual freedom and democratization were being made. For the first time in human history, the idea of fundamental rights of the individuals was being entertained in the public discourse. Traditional authoritarian and autocratic systems of governance were being challenged. The enlightenment scholars argued that all humans had certain inalienable "natural rights" which must be respected such as right to freedom of speech and expression, right of participation in the decision-making process, etc. This marked a significant step towards political modernization.

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Thus, the enlightenment scholars saw these developments as the sign of progress and the enlightenment period was marked by a new optimism or hope about the man's capacity to usher in a happier social order.

Task:

1. Notes-Making Assignment

Identify the main features of Enlightenment period.

- ……
- ……
- ……
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2. Writing-Skill Assignment

Write a short note on 'Enlightenment'. (100-120 words)

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3. For Interview

Enlightenment Philosophy * Major Enlightenment Philosophers

Now let us briefly discuss the developments taking place in France, the birthplace of Sociology. In the years preceding the revolution, France retained the political and economic characteristics of a feudal society: rigid social hierarchy, social and economic inequality, monarchy, etc. The French society was divided into feudal **'estates'**. The structure of the feudal French society comprised the 'Three Estates'. Estates are defined as a system of stratification found in feudal European societies whereby one section or estate is distinguished from the other in terms of status, privileges and restrictions accorded to that estate. **The First Estate** (the Church) consisted of the clergy, which was stratified into higher clergy, such as the cardinal, the archbishops, the bishops and the abbots. They lived a life of luxury and gave very little attention to religion. In fact, some of them preferred the life of politics to religion. They spent much of their time in wasteful activities like drinking, gambling, etc. The Church owned one-fifth of the cultivated lands in France and enjoyed great influence with the Government. Like the nobles, the higher clergy was also exempt from paying most of the taxes. With the nobles they supported absolute monarchy. The Church collected tithe, a tax from the people for providing community services. It also maintained institutions of learning. In comparison to the higher clergy, the lower parish priests were over worked and poverty-stricken.

The Second Estate consisted of the nobility. There were two kinds of nobles, the nobles of the sword and the nobles of the robe. The nobles of the sword were big landlords. They were the protectors of the people in principle but in reality they led a life of a parasite, living off the hard work of the peasants. They led the life of pomp and show and were nothing more than 'high born wastrels'; that is, they spent extravagantly and did not work themselves. They can be compared to the erstwhile zamindars in India. The nobles of the robe were nobles not by birth but by title. They were the magistrates and judges. Among these nobles, some were very progressive and liberal as they had moved in their positions from common citizens who belonged to the third estate. However, these noble families continued to enjoy all the privileges such as non-payment of most of the taxes, avenues to higher positions in the French administration, and income from various feudal dues of the peasants.

The Third Estate comprised the rest of the society and included the peasants, the merchants, the artisans, and others. There was a vast difference between the condition of the peasants and that of the clergy and the nobility. The

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peasants worked day and night but were overloaded with so many taxes that they lived a hand to mouth existence. They produced the food on which the whole society depended. Yet they could barely survive due to failure of any kind of protection from the government. The King, in order to maintain the good will of the other two estates, the clergy and the nobility, continued to exploit the poor. The poor peasants had no power against him. While the clergy and the nobility kept on pampering and flattering the King.

As compared to the peasants, the condition of the middle classes, also known as the **bourgeoisie** comprising the merchants, bankers, lawyers, manufacturers, etc. was much better. These classes too belonged to the third estate. But the poverty of the state, which led to a price rise during 1720-1789, instead of adversely affecting them, helped them. They derived profit from this rise and the fact that French trade had improved enormously also helped the commercial classes to a great extent. Thus, this class was rich and secure. But it had no social prestige as compared with the high prestige of the members of the first and the second estates. In spite of controlling trade, industries, banking etc. the bourgeoisie had no power to influence the court or administration. They were looked down upon by the other two estates and the King paid very little attention to them. Thus, gaining political power became a necessity for them.

The clergy and the nobility both constituted only two per cent of the population but they owned about 35 per cent of the land. The peasants who formed 80 per cent of the population owned only 30 per cent of the land. The first two estates paid almost no taxes to the government. The peasantry, on the other hand, was burdened with taxes of various kinds. It paid taxes to the Church, the feudal lord, taxed in the form of income tax, poll tax, and land tax to the state. Thus, you can see how much burdened and poverty stricken the peasants had become at this time. They were virtually carrying the burden of the first two estates on their shoulders. On top of it all the prices had generally risen by about 65 per cent during the period 1720-1789. The French system of taxation was both unjust and unfair.

Like in all absolute monarchies, the theory of the Divine Right of King was followed in France too. For about 200 years the Kings of the Bourbon dynasty ruled France. Under the rule of the King, the ordinary people had no personal rights. They only served the King and his nobles in various capacities. The King's word was law and no trials were required to arrest a person on the King's orders. Laws too were different in different regions giving rise to confusion and arbitrariness. There was no distinction between the income of the state and the income of the King. The kings of France, from Louis XIV onwards, fought costly wars, which ruined the country, and when Louis XIV died in 1715, France had

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become bankrupt. Louis XV instead of recovering from this ruin kept on borrowing money from bankers. His famous sentence, "After me the deluge" describes the kind of financial crisis that France was facing. Louis XVI, a very weak and ineffective king, inherited the ruin of a bankrupt government. His wife, Queen Marie Antoinette, known for her expensive habits, is famous for her reply, which she gave to the poor, hungry people of France who came to her asking for bread. She told the people that, 'if you don't have bread, eat cake'.

Now let us examine the intellectual developments in France, which proved to be the igniting force in bringing about the French revolution. France, like some other European countries during the eighteenth century, had entered the age of reason and rationalism. Some of the major philosophers, whose ideas influenced the French people, were rationalists who believed that all true things could be proved by reason. Some of these thinkers were Locke (1632-1704), Montesquieu (1689-1755), Voltaire (1694-1778), and Rousseau (1712-1778).

Locke, an Englishman, advocated that every individual has certain rights, which cannot be taken by any authority. These rights were (i) right to live, (ii) right to property, and (iii) the right to personal freedom. He also believed that any ruler who took away these rights from his people should be removed from the seat of power and replaced by another ruler who is able to protect these rights.

Montesquieu in his book, *The Spirit of the Law*, held that there should not be concentration of authority, such as executive, legislative, and juridical, at one place. He believed in the theory of the separation of powers and the liberty of the individual.

Voltaire became internationally famous as a great writer and critic whose style and pungent criticism were inimitable. It was through his plays and writings that he launched his bitter attacks against the existing institutions like the church and the state. He made fun of the eccentricities of the nobles. He advocated religious toleration and freedom of speech. He also stood for the rights of individuals, for freedom of speech and expression.

Probably the greatest French philosopher of the age was **Jean Jacques Rousseau**. In his book *The Social Contract*, he argued that the people of a country have the right to choose their sovereign. He believed that people can develop their personalities best only under a government which is of their own choice. He further explained that the king and his subjects are parties to a contract, and therefore if the king does not rule the people according to their general will, he loses their loyalty. Rousseau was advocating popular sovereignty

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theory. His writings cast such a spell on his admirers that they were ready to revolt against the oppressive monarchy.

The major ideas of these and several other intellectuals struck the imagination of the French people. Also some of them who had served in the French army, which was sent to assist the Americans in their War of Independence from British imperialism, came back with the ideas of equality of individuals and their right to choose their own government. The French middle class was deeply affected by these ideas of liberty and equality. So far you have leant about the basic picture of the French society just before the Revolution. Now let us discuss some of the major events that took place during the Revolution.

It is worth noting that when the American colonists revolted against the oppressive rule of the mother country and won a resounding victory at Saratoga, the French government decided to help them with men, money and materials. It caused a serious strain on the finances of the country and cast a heavy burden on the poor peasants. Turgot was appointed as the Minister of Finance to suggest remedies. He advised the king to tax the privileged class. He was summarily dismissed at the instance of the queen. Unfortunately, France witnessed near-famine conditions in 1788 with the result that there was a serious food shortage. It was at this critical juncture that the king was advised by his courtiers to summon the Estates-General (French Parliament) to get approval for further dose of taxation.

When the Estates-General was summoned, the king ignored the importance of the Third Estate (600 representatives elected by the common people) and tried to consult the representatives of the three estates separately. The representatives of the third estate advised the king to bring together the representatives of all the three estates at one place for discussion of state problems. The king discarded their advice. Subsequently, it led to a quarrel between the king and the representatives of the third estate. This led to the formation of the National Assembly. The meeting of the National Assembly led by middle class leaders and some liberal minded nobles was met with stiff resistance. On 20th June 1789 when a meeting was to be held in the Hall at Versailles near Paris, the members found that it was closed and guarded by the King's men. Therefore, the National Assembly members led by their leader Bailey went to the next building which was an indoor tennis court. It was here that they took an Oath to draw a new constitution for France. This Oath, which marks the beginning of the French Revolution, is popularly known as the Oath of the Tennis Court.

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Next, on July 14th, 1789 took place one of the most important events of the French Revolution. It was the storming of the Bastille, an ancient royal prison that stood as a symbol of oppression. On this date the mobs of Paris, led by some middle class leaders, broke open this prison and set its inmates free. The causes for this event were the shortage of food, on the one hand, and the dismissal of a very popular minister called Necker, on the other. The mobs of Paris rebelled against the ruling class, especially the King. This day is celebrated in France as its Independence Day.

Shortly after these events, the National Assembly drafted the 'Declaration of the Rights of Man,' which was a central political document defining human rights and setting out demands for reform. The political rights and freedoms proclaimed by the 'Declaration' were so wide-ranging in their human emancipation that it set the standard for social and political thinking, and formed the central rallying point of the revolution. The 'Declaration' stated at the outset that all human beings were born free and equal in their political rights, regardless of their class position, and this proceeded to set up a system of constitutional principles based on liberty, security and resistance to oppression. With philosophical authority, the 'Declaration' proclaimed that all individuals had the prerogative to exercise their 'natural right' and that the law rather than the monarch was the expression of the common interest. This led to the elimination of all social distinctions on the one hand, and the right to resist oppression on the other. Thus, the ideas of Liberty, Equality and Fraternity were enshrined in this declaration. Liberty and equality put an end to the age of serfdom, despotism and hereditary privileges found in the old feudal society.

By August the National Assembly began to deal directly with political and legal reforms, first by eliminating feudal dues and then by abolishing selfdom. Second, by compelling the church to give up the right to tithes, the National Assembly altered the authority and class position of the clergy. Third, in declaring that 'all citizens, without distinction, can be admitted to ecclesiastical, civil and military posts and dignities,' it proclaimed an end to all feudal social distinctions.

As the criticism of social and political inequalities spread throughout society, there was a widespread critique of economic inequality altogether and this led to putting into question all other forms of subordination. With this came the idea that human beings, without distinctions, were the bearers of natural rights – a concept which had a corrosive effect on all other forms of inequality. Finally, from the assertions inherent in the 'Declarations of Rights,' a new category of social person came into being which came fundamentally to rest in the concept of the 'citizen,' whose social and political rights were brought within the framework of the state.

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As the political changes began to take effect, there were abrupt social changes in the form of altered politics and in the form of the political reorganization of the feudal way of life. This brought with it two central historical shifts. First, it transformed the existing class structure of feudal society and led to the decline of class privilege and a change in the relations of subordination which had existed up until that time. Second, it set loose political and legal reforms which brought about a change from a political aristocracy based on sovereign authority to a democratic republic based on the rights of the citizen. Thus French Revolution of 1789 marked the phase of political modernization.

Now let us once again return to our discussion of enlightenment. As we had discussed earlier, the enlightenment scholars saw these socio-economic and political developments as the sign of progress. The enlightenment period was marked by a new optimism or hope about the man's capacity to usher in a happier social order. So, enlightenment thinkers represented intellectual modernity. But there were also some scholars who viewed these changes otherwise. These scholars were not only skeptic about these changes taking place in European society but even condemned these changes. We call these scholars as Counter–Enlightenment scholars and their views as a Conservative Reaction to enlightenment (anti–modernity). The most extreme form of opposition to Enlightenment ideas was French Catholic counterrevolutionary philosophy, as represented by the ideas of **Louis de Bonald** (1754-1840) and **Joseph de Maistre** (1753-1821). These men were reacting against not only the Enlightenment but also the French Revolution, which they saw partly as a product of the kind of thinking characteristic of the Enlightenment. De Bonald, for example, was disturbed by the revolutionary changes and yearned for a return to the peace and harmony of the Middle Ages.

In general, these scholars deplored the disruption of socio-economic and political fabric of the traditional medieval society caused by Industrial Revolution and French Revolution. As mentioned earlier that there was massive dislocation of rural population due to enclosure movement. The newly emerging social life in towns and cities was bereft of close-knit community and kinship bonds, we-feeling, stability and harmonic social order. Since these cities had emerged spontaneously, without any proper planning, they lacked even the basic amenities such as proper sewage and sanitation. As a result, due such unhygienic living conditions, epidemics were a common phenomenon. Further, these newly emerging industrial cities were marked by gross socio-economic disparities. Workers, including women and children, were forced to work for long hours in the factories marked by inhuman working conditions. In this new mode of production, worker had lost control over both, the process of production as well as his product. He was simply reduced to a wage-labourer. In Marxist terms, the worker became alienated from the product of his labour.

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Further, demand for political rights fuelled by the writings of enlightenment scholars, often led to civil wars leading to political anomie. Furthermore, religion too, which until now regulated the social order started declining. Religion, as the source of solace and meaning of life, started losing its appeal with the advances in science. So, Conservatives saw these changes, i.e. decline of family & community life, decline of religion, economic exploitation of workers in factories, rising socio-economic disparities and political turmoil as a sign of social decay and not as progress. Hence, they were preoccupied with their concerns for peace and harmony, and stability in the society.

So, while enlightenment scholars glorified change, conservatives deplored such changes and emphasized on stability, peace and harmony. However, the idea that there must be peace and harmony in social life came to be generally accepted by scholars of both the traditions.

Thus, the social conditions prevalent in Europe in 18th and 19th centuries, generated by social changes such as Renaissance, Commercial Revolution, Scientific Revolution, Reformation, Counter-Reformation, Industrial Revolution and French Revolution created the need for a distinct discipline to understand and analyze these changes. As we know that the existing knowledge that was prevalent during those times was largely religious in nature. Traditionally, the only source of knowledge was religion, propagated by the Church. But, the then existing body of religious knowledge had no answer to these challenges. Further, with the growth of science, religion itself was under attack and religious ideas were loosing their plausibility. So, there was a need for a new body of knowledge. A new body of knowledge was needed to understand what was happening and also help people to find solutions to the newly emerging problems.

That is how, the social changes created by modernity in Europe in the late 18th and early 19th century created the need for new knowledge.

Thus, while social conditions created the need for sociology, intellectual conditions provided the means for building sociology as a distinct discipline. It is the combination of both enlightenment and conservative school of thought which led to the emergence of sociology.

How?

As the early social theorists were largely preoccupied with understanding the puzzle of social change unfolding in Europe and to create a harmonic social order, hence, we can say that the goals of sociology were dictated by the conservative reaction. As we had already discussed that how the Conservative scholars were

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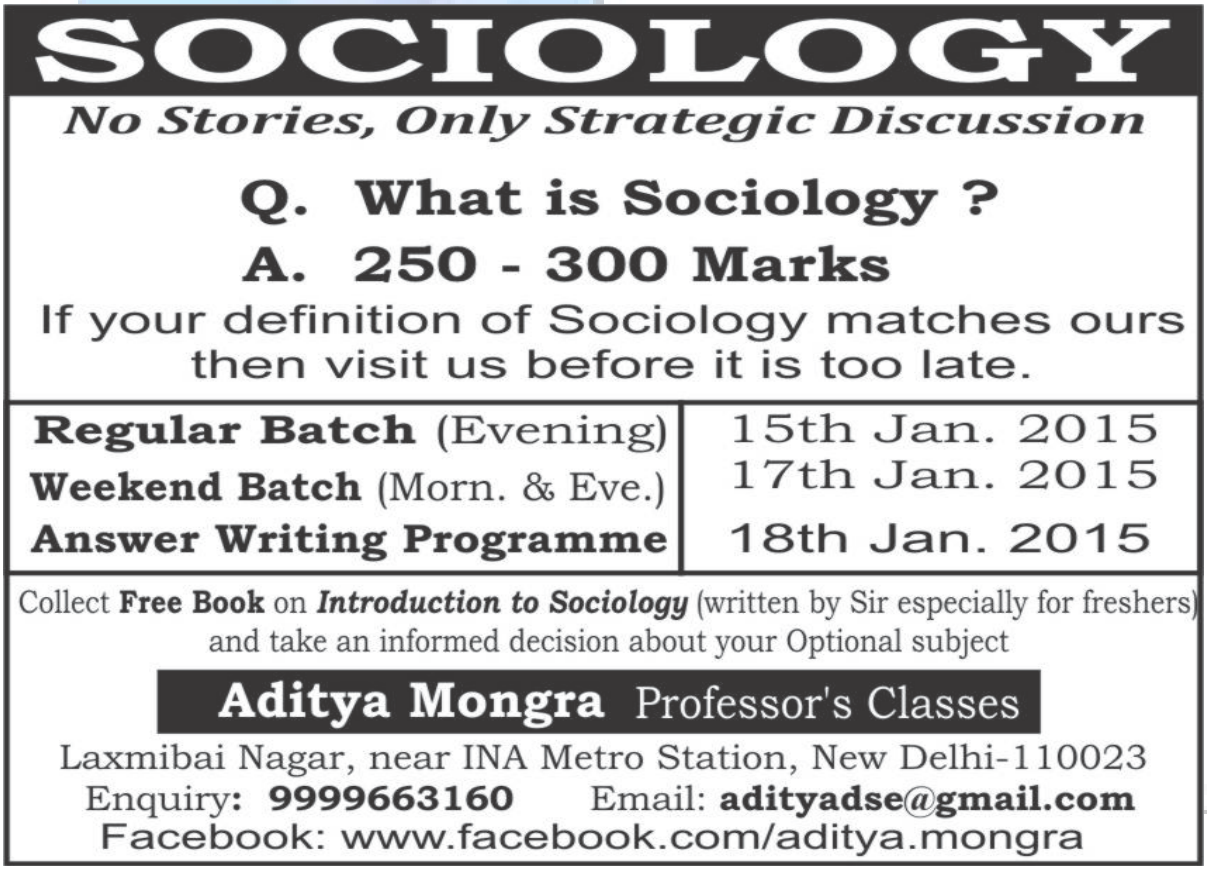
preoccupied with concerns for peace and harmony, and stability in the society. Therefore, sometimes it is also said that the early sociology developed as a reaction to the Enlightenment.

But, as far as the methodology or means to understand and study these social changes was concerned, it was largely influenced by the intellectual contributions of the Enlightenment scholars. Unlike conservatives, who yearned for a return to the peace and harmony of the Middle Ages, early social theorists emphasized on the need for scientific study of society based on empirical observation and reason (an idea of Enlightenment scholars) to be the basis of this new knowledge. They argued that through scientific study of society, social scientists can discover social laws that govern social order and thus, through corrective social legislation, can create a harmonic society. So, that is how the intellectual conditions helped in creating a new discipline which would use scientific method to study society, discover the laws that govern society and use that knowledge of laws to create a peaceful and harmonic society.

So, social conditions created the need for sociology, intellectual conditions provided the means for building sociology and that is how modernity and social change in Europe led to the emergence of sociology.



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Test Yourself

Q1. Write a note on 'Modernity and social changes in Europe and emergence of Sociology'. (300-350 words/ 30 marks)

Dear Candidate, before I give you a model answer for this question, I wish to discuss with you the correct strategy of writing an answer. I call this '**Dialectical Approach**', a term borrowed from Hegel. But before you apply the dialectical approach to a question make sure that you have read that question at least three times and understood it. It is a very common error on the part of the candidates to write in the examination 'what they know' rather 'what has been asked by the examiner.' Hence, the key to score well in this examination is to read the mind of the examiner and accordingly answer the question, meeting the expectations of the examiner. If you do this, you would get marks as per your expectations too.

All you have to do for this is to follow a very simple process. Firstly, read the question carefully and underline the keywords. Secondly, try to understand from which dimension the question has been framed on the topic. This is very important because questions can be framed from multiple dimensions or angles on the same topic. You would have no problem doing this if you sincerely follow the theme-based approach. Thirdly, divide the question into 3-4 logical sub-questions. When you do this it will not only keep you focused on the main theme but also help you complete the paper in time.

Now, let me share with you something about the structure of your answer. Your answer must be divided in four sections, viz. **introduction**, **thesis**, **anti-thesis** and **synthesis**. The Introduction section is the most important section of your answer as it introduces yourself as a candidate to the examiner. The examiner forms an image about you and your understanding of the concept just by reading the introduction. Hence, you must start by directly addressing the question, without beating the bush. By this I mean that given the limitations of Time and Word Limit, please avoid developing the background and glorifying the thinkers. In the introduction, briefly explain the key concept asked in the question. The introduction section should constitute nearly 20 % of the total length of your answer.

The next section is Thesis. In this section, you need to identify the main arguments in favour of the given concept or statement. Here, you must enrich your answer by highlighting the works of the scholars and case studies in support of

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your argument. In the Anti-Thesis section, you must write a critique of the concept or statement. This would balance your answer. Both, Thesis and Anti-Thesis should constitute nearly 30% each of the total length of your answer. Last, but not the least, is the Synthesis section. You may also call it as concluding remarks. Please remember that the concluding remarks reflect your overall understanding of the subject to the examiner. Your concluding remarks are not supposed to be your personal opinion about the ideas or concepts asked in the question. Rather, your concluding remarks must reflect the insight that you have gained as a student of Sociology. Thus, when write synthesis, make sure it is an academic conclusion rather than personal opinion.

Structure of the Model Answer:

Introduction: Briefly discuss the concept of modernity and the process of social change in Europe that brought about modernity

Thesis: Arguments in favour of the modernization process, viz. the ideas of Enlightenment scholars, with examples

Anti-thesis: Conservative reaction to Enlightenment

Synthesis: Emergence of Sociology as a by-product of the confluence of the two intellectual currents – Enlightenment and Conservatives

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Model Answer

Modernity refers to the rational transformation of social, psychological, economic and political aspects of society. In this sense, the process of modernization could be said to have begun in the late 18th and early 19th century in Western Europe. During that period, the entire social structure and the economic and political institutions were undergoing transition, particularly in the backdrop of Renaissance and Enlightenment movement. With industrial revolution, traditional feudal agrarian society was in decline and a new capitalist industrial society was emerging. The commercial and scientific revolutions which marked the period laid the foundations for the transformation of a predominant rural, agricultural and manual way of life to an urban industrial and mechanized pattern of living.

These extensive changes integral to the process of industrialization however, involved a major paradox. They brought a new society with great productive potential and more sophisticated and complex ways of living while at the same time generating extensive disruptions in traditional patterns of life and relationship. Thus, creating new problems of overcrowding, unhygienic urban conditions, poverty and unemployment. Demand for greater political rights gave rise to social and political movements, such as French Revolution, often leading to civil wars.

However, the early scholars who were carefully observing the changes in the patterns of social life with the rise of industrial society were divided in their opinion with regard to the nature, impact and direction of such changes. Enlightenment scholars like Rousseau, Montesquieu, Adam Smith, Saint Simon and Augusts Comte had a positive view of the newly emerging social order. They considered such changes as progressive and hence desirable. They favoured modern scientific knowledge, advanced technology, individualism and political ideas of justice and liberty. They encouraged the forces of liberalization and industrialization. Whereas, the Conservatives like Louis de Bonald, Joseph de Maistre and other such scholars had a rather skeptic view of these profound and far reaching institutional changes that were taking place in society. They were preoccupied with the concern for social stability and order in the society as the new social order was marked by violent political revolutions, class wars, extreme economic inequalities and widespread misery and poverty.

Thus, while social conditions created the need for sociology, intellectual conditions provided the means for building sociology as a distinct discipline. It is the combination of both enlightenment and conservative school of thought which led to the emergence of sociology.

Total Words: 355

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Dear Candidate, after completing a given topic and preparing your notes in pointer form, you must attempt questions asked so far in previous years and get them evaluated. As I have discussed before, what really counts here is how you are articulating the learned knowledge in the given Time and Word Limit. Always remember that Civil Services Examination is not about information, it is more about analysis. So, you must practice by writing more and more answers and getting them periodically evaluated.

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Quantitative and qualitative methods

(including Field: Issues and Context)

Dear Candidate, before proceeding with our discussion on quantitative and qualitative research methods, I would like you to recall our discussion on 'Major theoretical strands of research methodology'. There I had mentioned that broadly we can identify two major traditions in sociological theory. They are the positivist and anti-positivist traditions. I had also discussed the various sociological perspectives that fall under each category. Most importantly, I had also cautioned you that how we conceive of society cannot be separated from the question of how we should proceed in our study of it. In other words, what methodology a researcher would adopt in carrying out his research would largely be determined by the perspective or orientation that he has towards social reality. In our discussion, I had made it clear that the emphasis on the objective measurement of human social behaviour forces the positivist scholars to rely more on the quantitative methods while conducting research. While on the other hand, anti-positivist scholars who emphasise on the interpretative understanding of the social behaviour rely more on qualitative methods.

However, whatsoever be the perspective and methodology of the researcher, ultimately he has to carry out his research in the field. The topic 'field' has not been explicitly mentioned in the syllabus but the theme based approach suggests that any discussion on research methodology would be futile without understanding field and issues associated with it. So let's first understand what 'field' implies in a sociological enquiry and what are the problems or challenges associated with the field-work.

In the context of sociological research, the term 'field' refers to the members of a social group which is the prime object of study for a social scientist. In its early phase, Malinowski and Radcliffe-Brown laid the foundations of intensive fieldwork among anthropologists in Britain. However, in Indian context, it was M.N. Srinivas who strongly advocated for the 'field-view' of Indian society in place of the 'book-view'. Book-view of Indian society was largely championed by the Indologists like B.K. Sarkar, G.S. Ghurey, Radhakamal Mukerjee, Irawati Karve. Indologists claimed that Indian society could be understood only through the concepts, theories and frameworks of Indian civilization. They believed that an examination of the classical texts, manuscripts, archaeological artefacts, etc. should be the starting point for the study of the present.

Srinivas was critical of the 'book-view' of Indian society. He argued that the book-view gave a distorted picture of society by dwelling on the ideals of the past

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from which the present reality departed considerably. The book-view of Indian society presented an idealized picture of its institutions – marriage, family, kinship, caste and religion – dwelling more on what they were supposed to be than how they actually worked. For example, the book-view had represented caste in terms of the invariant and immutable scheme of the four *varnas*. Field studies shifted attention away from the four-fold scheme of *varnas* to the operative units of the system which were the innumerable *jatis*. They also drew attention to the ambiguities of caste ranking and the very distinctive process of caste mobility. Thus, the field-view revealed the gap everywhere between ideal and the actual. By bringing to attention ambiguities, contradictions and conflicts, it paved the way for a better understanding of the dynamics of social change. Thus, the idea of an unchanging and immutable society began to give way, and the field-view changed not only the perception of India's present, but to some extent also the perception of its past.

However, like every other method, field-work too is marked by its own set of challenges and problems in conducting a genuine sociological research. Firstly and foremostly, the researcher faces the problem of the choice of the 'field' to carry out his field-work as no typical field exists in reality. As stated earlier, unlike natural sciences, sociology cannot study any particular social phenomena in a laboratory by the experimental method due to certain moral and ethical reasons. As a result, social research takes place in the open, where, unlike a scientific experiment, it is extremely difficult to control the extraneous variables. Hence, it becomes increasingly challenging for the social scientist to establish a cause-effect relationship between the variables stated under hypothesis. After having identified the field for his research, the researcher faces the challenge of entry into the field. This implies that unless the researcher is able to establish a good rapport with the natives, he would find it hard to carry out his research. Thus, in order to seek the cooperation of the native population for his data collection, the researcher must gain their acceptability. In this, the social background of the researcher also plays an important role.

Further, since the researcher can only carry out a limited study of any given social phenomenon, the problem of holism looms large. Since holistic study appears impractical in study of complex societies, the researcher should keep in mind that the segment he is studying is the part of a larger and complex whole and should look for interrelationships. Researcher may also face problem in the formulation of hypothesis and might have to reformulate or modify his hypothesis because hypotheses cannot be formulated in the vacuum, without the knowledge of the field. Further, the issues of objectivity and ethical-neutrality also need to be addressed. The researcher should be aware of his biases and prejudices and try to make certain that they do not influence his collection and interpretation of data.

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Though some of these challenges are endemic to any social science enquiry, yet they can be dealt with a cautious and informed approach on the part of the researcher. Since the field-work basically involves dealing with people, the researcher must be empathetic and flexible in his approach and employ the services of well trained field workers.

In the ultimate analysis, it may be argued that in any field research, the sociologist is an integral part of the research process. The data so collected has no existence independent of him. His data are 'constructions, not reflections of facts or relationships alone. In the process of knowing, external facts are sensorily perceived and transformed into conceptual knowledge. Thus, the sociologist as a researcher in an active factor in the creation of knowledge and not just a mere passive recipient. The importance of his perception makes a sociologist as integral a part of the research process as the data he observes.

Dear Candidates, I had mentioned in our earlier discussion on reflexivity that a long question on reflexivity may be asked in reference to its contribution in reconstituting the 'field' and the practices of fieldwork in social anthropological research. Let us try to understand it.

As you now know that reflexivity offers an alternate perspective to study social reality. Reflexivity in social anthropological research implies that the ideas about 'field' and 'practices' of field-work are constantly examined and reformed in the light of new developments, thus continuously altering their character. Reflexivity challenges the conventional notions of anthropological research with regard to field and practices of field-work. Early social anthropological research was largely concerned with the study of small scale societies in their natural state or surroundings. Hence the term 'field' came to denote a distinct social group which was to be studied in its unique socio-cultural and geographical setting. Early anthropological research was largely based on the dichotomy of subject and object. In other words, it was based on the separation of the social scientist (subject) from those 'others' whom he observes (object). It was based on the assumption that over involvement of the social scientist with his object of study (social group) may contaminate the research findings. The idea about 'otherness' remained remarkably central to the fieldwork practices of Malinowski, A.R. Radcliffe-Brown, etc.

Amory shows how these ideas about 'otherness' and taking for granted of a white subject have shaped the field of African studies in the United States. She shows that African American scholars were discouraged from working in Africa, on the grounds that they were "too close" and would not manage to be "objective", while white scholars were judged to have the appropriate distance from the black "other". This helps to explain that why the contemporary field of African studies

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contains remarkably few black American scholars. Kath Weston too in her study of gay and lesbian communities in United States arrived at a similar conclusion. She argued that her position as a native ethnographer itself blurs the subject-object distinction on which ethnography is conventionally founded. She calls native ethnographer as a 'virtual anthropologist'.

Akhil Gupta and James Ferguson also question the conventional notion of field and argue that in the light of new developments there is a need for reconstruction of field and field-work practices. They argue that processes such decolonization and globalization, accompanied by processes of diffusion and acculturation, have challenged the traditional definition of field and the very idea of a clearly demarcated space of 'otherness'. They argue that the conventional notion about the 'field' in terms of a homogenous social group with its unique culture and geographical surroundings has come to be questioned in the wake of globalization. Social groups are no longer tightly territorialized or spatially bounded. Further, the process of diffusion and acculturation, have significantly altered the homogenous character of social groups and today cultural heterogeneity is more common.

Gupta and Ferguson further question the 'field-home dichotomy' in social anthropological research. They question the traditional notion of field which rested on the idea that different cultures exist in discrete and separate places. They argued that the 'location' of the field should not merely be seen in geographical sense alone. They advocated retheorizing of fieldwork from spatial sites to social and political locations in terms of unequal power relations. For example, subaltern approach in sociology has significantly contributed towards a better understanding of various socio-economic and political processes in India, which were until now largely studied from an elitist perspective. Gupta and Ferguson argue that with decolonization, there is proliferation of domestic research led by the natives. As a result, today, the very idea of 'otherness', which was central to the early anthropological fieldwork, is subjected to review. Hence, there is a need to modify the practices of fieldwork accordingly.

Further, Gupta and Ferguson also question the fundamental premise of early anthropological field-work practices that only professionally trained observers could be trusted to collect ethnographic data. As Paul Radin in his study found that his untrained native research assistants proved to be better than the academically and professionally qualified observers in terms of gathering valuable data. This is because, as Radin argues that such professionals are socially separated from those whom they study by their very training. The training of the professional observers erects an undesirable barrier between themselves and the persons to be interrogated. It may lead to a difficulty in establishing direct and immediate contact

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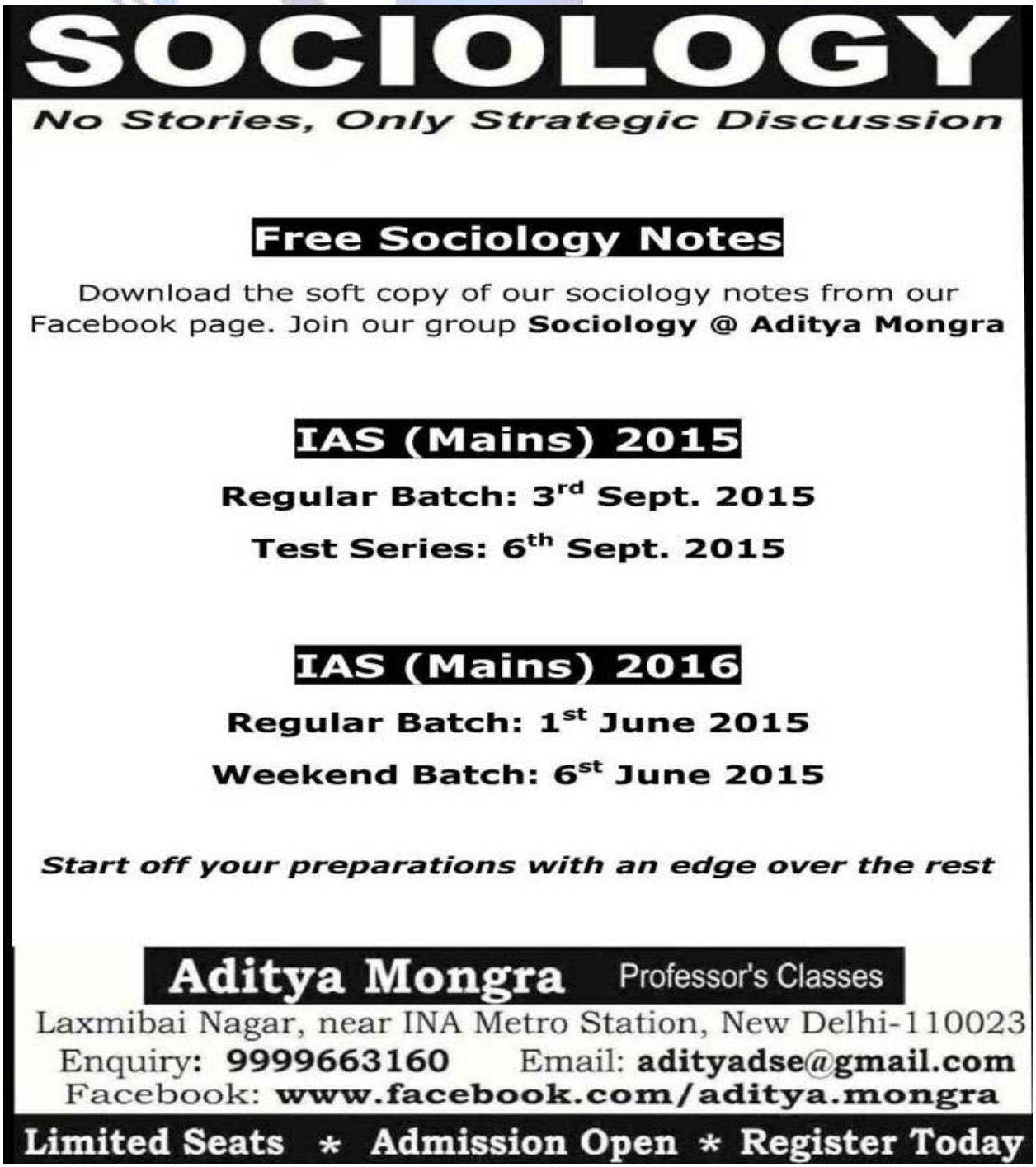
and building rapport with their sources of information. While on the other hand, the native research assistants or local intellectuals are better positioned at least for certain sorts of data collection.

Thus, reflexivity has significantly contributed in reconstruction of the ideas about field and field-work practices in social anthropology. Such a rethinking of the idea of the 'field' coupled with an explicit attentiveness to 'location' might open the way for a different kind of anthropological knowledge and a different kind of anthropological subject.



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Let us now discuss now discuss some of the fundamental characteristics of quantitative as well as qualitative research methods.

As you know that sociology first developed in Europe in the nineteenth century when industrialization resulted in massive social changes. Accompanying these social changes were intellectual changes during which science started to enjoy a higher reputation than ever before. Science appeared to be capable of producing objective knowledge that could be used to solve human problems and increase human productive capacity in an unprecedented way. It was not surprising therefore, that many early sociologists chose to turn to science for a methodology on which to base their subject. However, not all sociologists have agreed that it is appropriate to adopt the methodology of the natural sciences. For these sociologists, studying human behaviour is fundamentally different from studying the natural world. Unlike the subject matter of, for example, chemistry or physics, people possess consciousness, which means that sociology requires a different type of methodology from science. Thus on the basis of the above discussion, two broad traditions within sociology could be identified.

1. Those who advocated the use of scientific and usually quantitative methods. (Positivists)
2. Those who supported the use of more humanistic and qualitative methods. (Anti-Positivists)

Though in recent years, some sociologists have questioned the need for such a rigid division between quantitative and qualitative methodology, and have advocated combining the two approaches.

Quantitative Research Methods:

Quantitative research in sociology is largely associated with the 'positivist tradition'. Early sociologists belonging to the positivist tradition such as Comte, Spencer, Durkheim, etc. believed that the methods and procedures of natural sciences could be adopted in sociology as well. Quantitative research is associated with a number of techniques of data collection such as survey, questionnaire, structured interview and secondary sources of data, etc. Some of the features of quantitative research in sociology are discussed below:

1. **Social facts:** As a positivist, Comte believed that the scientific study of society should be confined to collecting information about phenomena that can be objectively observed and classified. Comte argued that sociologists should not be concerned with the internal meanings, motives, feelings and emotions of individuals. Since these mental states exist only in the person's

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consciousness, they cannot be observed and so they cannot be measured in any objective way. Similarly, Durkheim also argued that social facts should be treated as *'things'*. This means that the belief systems, customs and institutions of society – the facts of the social world – should be considered as things in the same way as the objects and events of the natural world.

2. **Statistical data:** The second aspect of quantitative approach as advocated by positivists is the use of statistical data. Positivists believed it was possible to classify the social world in an objective way. Using these classifications it was then possible to count sets of observable social facts and so produce statistics. For example, Durkheim collected data on social facts such as the suicide-rate and membership of different religions.

3. **Correlation:** The third aspect of positivist methodology entails looking for correlations between different social facts. In his study of suicide, Durkheim found an apparent correlation between a particular religion, Protestantism, and a high suicide rate.

4. **Causation:** The fourth aspect of positivist methodology involves a search for causal connections. The quantitative research is highly preoccupied with establishing the causal relationship between variables. If there is a strong correlation between two or more types of social phenomena, then a positivist sociologist might suspect that one of these phenomena was causing the other to take place. For example, Durkheim in his study of suicide had explained that low solidarity among the Protestants was the causal factor for high suicide rate amongst them.

5. **Generalization and Replicability:** The quantitative researcher is invariably concerned to establish that his result of a particular investigation can be generalized to the larger population. Positivists like Comte and Durkheim, believed that just as natural sciences could arrive at universal laws with regard to matter, similarly, laws of human behaviour can also be discovered in social sciences. They believed that laws of human behaviour can be discovered by the collection of objective facts about the social world, by the

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careful analysis of these facts and by repeated checking of the findings in a series of contexts (replication).

Positivism is based upon an understanding of science that sees science as using a mainly inductive methodology. An inductive methodology starts by collecting the data. The data are then analysed, and out of this analysis theories are developed. Once the theory has been developed it can then be tested against other sets of data to see if it is confirmed or not. If it is repeatedly confirmed (replicated), then positivists like Comte, Durkheim, etc. assume that they have discovered a law of human behaviour.

Qualitative Research Methods:

A significant number of sociologists choose not to use the more scientific approaches to the study of human behaviour. They prefer to sacrifice a certain precision of measurement and objectivity in order to get closer to their subjects, to examine the social world through the perspective of the people they are investigating. These sociologists sometimes refer to quantitative researchers as those who "measure everything and understand nothing." Qualitative research fundamentally refers to that approach to the study of the social world which seeks to describe and analyse the culture and behaviour of humans and their groups from the point of view of those being studied. As we have discussed earlier that quantitative data are data in a numerical form: for example, official statistics on crime, suicide and divorce rates. By comparison, qualitative data are usually presented in words. These may be a description of a group of people living in poverty, providing a full and in-depth account of their way of life, or a transcript of an interview in which people describe and explain their attitude towards and experience of religion. Compared to quantitative data, qualitative data are usually seen as richer, more vital, as having greater depth and as more likely to present a true picture of a way of life, of people's experiences, attitudes and beliefs. Participant observation, unstructured interview, focus group discussion, life-history or case study method are some of the major methods or techniques of data collection in qualitative research. The main intellectual undercurrents which tend to be viewed as providing qualitative research with their distinct methodology are phenomenology, symbolic interactionism, *verstehen*, ethnomethodology, etc. Some of the features of qualitative research in sociology are discussed below:

1. **Empathetic description of social reality:** The most fundamental characteristic of qualitative research is its express commitment to viewing events, actions, norms, values, etc. from the perspective of the people who are being studied.

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2. **Contextualism:** Qualitative research exhibits a preference for contextualism in its commitment to understanding events, behaviour, etc. in their respective context. It is almost inseparable from another theme in qualitative research, namely 'holism' which entails an undertaking to examine social entities – schools, tribes, firms, slums, delinquent groups, communities, or whatever – as wholes to be explicated and understood in their entirety.

3. **Emphasis on processual dimension:** Qualitative research views social life in processual, rather than static terms. The emphasis on process can be seen as a response to the qualitative researcher's concern to reflect the reality of everyday life which, they tend to argue, takes the form of streams of interconnecting events. The general image that qualitative research conveys about the social order is one of interconnection and change.

4. **Flexibility:** Qualitative researchers tend to favour a research strategy which is relatively open and unstructured. Such strategy allows them access to unexpectedly important topics which may not have been visible to them had they foreclosed the domain of study by a structured, and hence potentially rigid strategy.

Some sociologists, in recent years, have questioned the need for such a rigid division between quantitative and qualitative methodology and have advocated combining the two approaches. Alan Bryman has suggested a number of ways in which a plurality of methods – a practice known as *triangulation* – can be useful.

1. Quantitative and qualitative data can be used to check on the accuracy of the conclusions reached on the basis of each.
2. Qualitative research can be used to produce hypotheses which can then be checked using quantitative methods.
3. The two approaches can be used together so that a more complete picture of the social group being studied is produced.
4. Qualitative research may be used to illuminate why certain variables are statistically correlated. For example, Durkheim concluded in his study on suicide that the rate of suicide varies from religion to religion because of their varying degree of solidarity.

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Bryman believes that both quantitative and qualitative research have their own advantages. Neither can produce totally valid and completely reliable data, but both can provide useful insights into social life. He argues that each has its own place and they can be most usefully combined. Generally, quantitative data tends to produce rather static pictures, but it can allow researchers to examine and discover overall patterns and structures in society as a whole. Qualitative data is less useful for discovering overall patterns and structures, but it does allow a richer and deeper understanding of the process of change in social life.

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Science, scientific method and critique

Science refers to the application of objective methods of investigation, reasoning and logic to develop a body of knowledge about given phenomena. There are three goals of science. The first is to explain why something happens. The second is to make generalizations, that is, to go beyond the individual cases and make statements that apply to a collectivity. The third is to predict, to specify, what will happen in future, in the light of the available stock of knowledge.

Thus, science refers to a systematic body of certified and changing knowledge which is based upon observable and verifiable facts and the methods used to acquire this knowledge. So, the term science is used both for the knowledge as well the methods that are used to acquire this knowledge.

Like all scientists, sociologists must study the specific in order to understand the general. The true concern of the geologist is not the peculiarity of the rock he holds in his hand, the concern of the botanist is not the fate of the flower he finds in the field, the concern of the sociologist is not the specific event he observes and records. All science is concerned with the order and pattern of its subject matter – what it is that rocks or flowers or persons or societies have in common. One of the ways scientists move from the specific to the general is through statistical averaging. A chemist who observes the reactions of millions of atoms cannot predict with certainty the behaviour of any single hydrogen atom, but he can say with assurance that most hydrogen atoms behave in a certain way. Similarly, although a sociologist can never predict the political opinion of any particular blue-collar worker, he can say that most members of a given socio-economic class have political opinions of a certain kind.

Sociology is a scientific discipline. It is a science in the sense that it involves objective and systematic methods of investigation and evaluation of social reality in the light of empirical evidence and interpretation. But, it cannot be directly modeled on the patterns of natural sciences, because human behaviour is different from the world of nature. Among other differences, the subject matter of natural sciences is relatively static and unchanging whereas human behaviour as the subject matter of sociology is flexible and dynamic. Whereas, the natural phenomena can be put under controlled observation, it may not be possible to do the same regarding the subject matter of sociology. This is because all social phenomena and social institutions like family, marriage, caste, etc. are constantly changing even while they are being studied. In sociological research, it is difficult to be completely value-free. Moreover, the research situation itself becomes a social situation where the researcher confronts another human being and gets involved in a process of interaction. This makes it difficult to be objective. Good

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social scientists keep these limitations in mind and try to be as objective as possible. For that purpose, different research tools are used, and data are checked and crosschecked.

To sum up, it may be said that any discipline is considered to be scientific when it is empirical, theoretical, cumulative and value-neutral. Against this yardstick, let us examine the status of sociology as a science:

(a) Sociology is empirical: It is based on observation and reasoning, not on supernatural/ speculative revelations, and its results are not speculative. In the early stages of their creative work, all scientists speculate, of course, but ideally at least, they submit their speculations to the test of fact before announcing them as scientific discovers. All aspects of sociological knowledge are subject to evaluation made about social behaviour or can be put to test for empirical evidence.

(b) Sociology is theoretical: It attempts to summarize complex observations in abstract logically related propositions which purport to explain causal relationships in the subject matter. Its main aim is to interpret and to inter-relate sociological data in order to explain the nature of social phenomena and to produce hypotheses whose final validity can be cheeked by further empirical research.

(c) Sociology is cumulative: Sociological theories are built upon one another, extending and refining the older ones and producing the new ones. As such, theoretical integration becomes a goal in the construction of sociological formulations. Thus, sociology is cumulative.

(d) Sociology is non-ethical: Sociologists do not ask whether particular social actions are good or bad; they seek merely to explain them. It addresses issues. Study of human relations is the prime consideration in sociology. In this context, Morris Ginsberg observes that ethical problems should be dealt with neutrality. Objectivity and rationality based on a thorough knowledge of a situation alone can ensure scientific status to the discipline of sociology.

In all these respects, sociology is far from having reached perfection; but is being steadily made. Hence, sociology can at best be described as a social science.

As discussed earlier, science is a body of verified knowledge about physical or social reality. The method used to acquire this kind of knowledge is called **scientific method**. The general guideline for all scientific research is the scientific

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method. Although it is possible to outline the series of steps that comprise this method, its real importance is not as a body of rules but as an attitude toward the work of observation and generalization. It has often been said that many scientific discoveries are due to a lucky accident; Galvani, for example, discovered that nerves transmit electrical impulses when one of his assistants left a freshly dissected frog on the lab table near an unrelated experiment in electrical conduction. But it is not the element of chance that should be stressed in such an occurrence, the key element was Galvani's trained powers of observation, his ability to derive a possible explanation for what he saw, his knowledge of the way to test that explanation. While Galvani's assistant, who also observed this lucky accident, dismissed it as a curious coincidence, Galvani the scientist saw the implications of the coincidence.

How can one learn to observe and generalize in a scientific manner? The following steps serve as general guidelines when applying the scientific method in sociological research.

First, make a careful statement of the problem to be investigated and frame a hypothesis. A sociologist begins by defining precisely what it is he wants to know. He generally states the problem so that it fits into existing theoretical frameworks and is related to the relevant findings of previous research. Stating the problem in this manner insures that knowledge will be cumulative and that one researcher's findings can be easily utilized by others. The problem must also be formulated as a verifiable **hypothesis**, one that can be tested before it is accepted or rejected. Many provocative hypotheses can never be tested. For example, one might hypothesize that God exists, but no one has found a way to test this hypothesis. Scientists must modify the original hypothesis to one they can test, such as: the majority of adult Americans believe that God exists. Please note that a hypothesis is nothing but a tentative statement asserting a relationship between certain facts (or variables). You will learn more about hypothesis in our later discussion.

In sociological research the application of this first step in the scientific method can be illustrated by the case of a researcher who suspects an association between urban residence and mental illness. The researcher would begin by identifying certain defining qualities of a city: How big is it? What are its social characteristics? How does it differ from a nearby suburb? With a definition in mind, he looks for the aspects of a city that might be associated with mental illness: population size and density, quality of housing, prevalence of low-income groups, availability of recreational facilities. After examining existing theories and research findings in this area, he would frame a hypothesis stating a suspected or tentative relationship between some specific urban characteristic and mental

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illness. For example, he might hypothesize that the incidence of mental illness increases in proportion to the size of the city, with the largest cities having the highest rates of mental illness.

In the search for ways that these **variables** (characteristics that are present in varying amounts or degrees) could be measured, the hypothesis might be further refined. The researcher might choose to limit his study to those patients actually hospitalized with a diagnosis of mental illness, thus eliminating all those mentally ill urban residents who have not been diagnosed and are not being treated. Although this refinement makes the hypothesis easier to test, it also introduces an additional problem: the number of institutions that can diagnose and treat mental illness. Thus, the rates of mental illness might appear higher in some cities simply because they have more facilities to treat the mentally ill, whereas in other cities a large percentage of the mentally ill population go untreated. Each choice of a specific measure brings with it new possibilities of error and bias, yet the general hypothesis must be reduced to specifics if it is to be tested at all.

Second, develop a research design. A **research design** is a plan for the collection, analysis, and evaluation of data; it involves deciding how facts are to be selected, how they are to be evaluated and classified, and how they are to be analyzed to uncover relationships and patterns that bear on the original hypothesis. The major goal of the research design is to insure that the evidence gathered to test a hypothesis will be trustworthy, and that extraneous factors that might falsify the results will be controlled. Please note that **extraneous variables** are undesirable variables that influence the relationship between the variables that an experimenter is examining. In other words, extraneous variables are the variables which though not a part of the study yet are capable enough to influence the outcome of the study. These variables are undesirable because they add error to an experiment. A major goal in research design is to decrease or control the influence of extraneous variables as much as possible. The classic **controlled experiment** in a laboratory is the ideal scientific research design. It is an experiment designed in advance and conducted under conditions in which it is possible to control all relevant factors while measuring the effect on an experimentally induced variable. In a controlled experiment the subjects are divided into two groups. The variable whose effect is to be tested, or the **independent variable**, is then introduced into one group, called the **experimental group**, while it is withheld from the other group, called the **control group**. The two groups are subsequently compared to determine whether there are any significant differences between them regarding the variable that is expected to change, or the **dependent variable**. On the basis of this comparison, the original hypothesis, which proposes a specific relationship between the independent and dependent variables, can be confirmed or rejected.

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The use of the controlled experiment can best be illustrated by cancer research. Suppose one wishes to test the hypothesis that nicotine causes cancer in mice. A number of mice can be randomly assigned to experimental and control groups. Those in the experimental group are then given a dose of nicotine (the independent variable) while those in the control group are not. Everything else about the two groups is held constant. If the incidence of cancer (the dependent variable) is subsequently found to be higher in the experimental than in the control group, a cause-and-effect relationship between nicotine and cancer in mice may be assumed. It is seldom possible to test sociological hypotheses under controlled laboratory conditions. The typical social research design is therefore developed with this limitation in mind.

Third, collect data in accordance with the research design. One way for obtaining information about human behaviour and social life is to observe the way people actually behave: how they act in a given situation, what they do on a daily and regular basis. This constitutes the *objective reality*. Accurate and objective observation by trained observers is a fundamental distinguishing feature of all the sciences. Another way is to ask people about their actions, attitudes, and beliefs. Their answers help to reveal the *subjective reality* – the meanings and thoughts, or "reasons," that lie behind a person's behaviour. Subjective reality distinguishes the social sciences from the natural sciences, which deal only with objective reality, that which can be seen to happen.

Some sociologists, however, question whether subjective reality can be accurately analyzed scientifically and prefer to concentrate exclusively on the observation of objective reality. They maintain that the only valid evidence for scientific purposes is what they can observe about human behaviour, not what people tell them. Such scholars are called as ***'positivists'***. In sociology, positivism is generally associated with the view that there is an objective world which is capable of being understood in objective and scientific terms. The founders of sociology, be it Comte, Spencer or Durkheim, all advocated positivist approach to study social life. Though, this approach had its own limitations and was later criticized by the scholars belonging to the anti-positivist tradition. You will read about this in more detail in our subsequent discussion on 'Positivism and its critique'.

The fourth step in the scientific method is to analyze the data and draw conclusions. It is at this step that the initial hypothesis is accepted or rejected and the conclusions of the research are related to the existing body of theory, perhaps modifying it to take account of the new findings. The findings are usually presented as articles in scholarly journals, monographs, or books. The accuracy and significance of scientific findings are assessed in terms of their validity and

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reliability. **Validity** refers to the correspondence between what a scientific investigation or technique purports to measure and what it actually measures. An example of this kind of assessment is the current challenge by many social scientists of the validity of IQ tests. These scientists question whether the tests really measure innate human intelligence or something else. **Reliability** refers to the degree to which a scientific test or measurement is consistent and accurate. There is less doubt about the reliability of IQ tests; although they may not measure intelligence, they seem to measure some particular characteristic consistently. To determine reliability, replication, the repetition of an experiment a number of times, is done to see if the same results are obtained.

By no means do all, or even most, sociological research investigations closely follow this outline of the scientific method. Many sociologists are simply interested in accurate descriptions, others do not develop precise hypotheses or elaborate research designs, and most do not formally go through the step of either accepting or rejecting a hypothesis. Nevertheless, this model of the scientific method is highly influential as a guideline for both planning research and evaluating research findings. It represents the ideal that all scientists seek to attain.

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Max Weber (1864-1920)

It is difficult not to compare the work of the German social theorist Max Weber (1864-1920) with that of Karl Marx. It could even be suggested that a full appreciation of key aspects of Weber's work only emerges by making this comparison. There comparisons are inevitable since the writings of Marx, and the political claims of the Marxists who followed him, provided much of the academic and political context of Weber's own social theory. It is important to remember, however, that Weber's understanding of Marx was very limited since many of Marx's most important works (the *Paris Manuscripts*, *The German Ideology*, the *Grundrisse*) were not available during Weber's lifetime. The Marx that Weber did know was mostly based on his economic writings and *The Communist Manifesto*, and even these as they were being interpreted, rather simplistically, by the German Social Democratic Party in the 1890s. For Weber, Marx was the author of an original, but rigid and one-sidedly materialist, theory of historical development, a point that he tries to prove by offering an alternative explanation of the emergence of modern capitalism in his famous essay published in 1904/05, *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*.

Having boldly stated the need for comparing Weber with Marx we need to qualify this by saying that not all of Weber's work should be treated in this way. The comparison actually relates to the fairly specific topic of what social theory has to say about the origins and nature of modern industrial capitalism. To the extent that Weber's political concerns, his worries about the feasibility of socialism and the dominance of economic interests, can all be seen in terms of the rise of capitalism then the comparison is fair enough. Weber did have other interests, however, such as his analysis of German society and politics, his comparative history of the world religions, and the contribution he made to the methodology of social theory, which often have very little to do with Marx and Marxism.

Let us now briefly discuss the biographical and political context of Weber's work. The accusation that Weber produced bourgeois social theory as opposed to the proletarian social theory of Marx is partly based on the fact that Weber came from a wealthy establishment family, and thus had the benefits of a privileged education and good social and career prospects. Following his father (who was a member of the German Parliament), he trained as a lawyer in Berlin and then took a doctorate in economics in 1889. He gained his first academic post in 1893, and only three years later became professor of economics at Freiburg University in 1896 at the remarkably young age of 32 (he later held posts at Heidelberg and Munich). He then suffered the first of a series of serious bouts of psychological illness that forced him to give up his job and abandon academic work for the next six years. The period between 1905 and around 1915 was his most productive,

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beginning with the publication of two extended essays as *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism* in 1904/05. He then worked intermittently on a number of detailed studies in economics, religion, the development of the legal system and other social institutions. These subsequently appeared in print as *Economy and Society* (1921), *The Religion of India* and *The Religion of China* (both published in 1916). *The General Economic History* (1927) was compiled from a series of lectures he gave in Freiburg during 1919-20, and *On the Methodology of the Social Sciences* was published posthumously in 1922 from a variety of articles and lectures given between 1903 and 1917. In most cases, complete English translations only became available during the 1950s and 1960s.Weber died from pneumonia in 1920 at the age of 56.

In terms of the kind of society in which Weber worked, the dominant political issue was the decline of the liberal, Protestant and highly individualist attitude of the established middle classes, and the emergence of an authoritarian, militarised, bureaucratic regime that accompanied the rise of the 'new Germany' following Bismark's unification of the German states in 1870. The success of the new regime rested on an alliance between the landowner class of Junkers (who were forced to rely on political power as their economic power declined), the military and the emerging classes of industrialists, financiers, bankers and career bureaucrats. In the last decades of the 19th century, Germany went thought a period of rapid industrialisation, a process that was accompanied by the emergence of the German industrial working class although not, significantly, of an independent bourgeois middle class of the kind found in Britain, France and elsewhere. For Weber and many of his contemporaries, the demise of traditional liberal values of personal responsibility and autonomy, and their replacement with a much more paternalistic notion of national service, was a matter of great concern. Both Weber and his father made various attempts to express this opposition in the political sphere. The rather pessimistic tone of Weber's work, his sense that German society and its liberal values were in decline, certainly reflects his rather dismal political outlook.

Whereas Marx began his academic career by engaging with the abstract philosophical debates engendered by Hegelian idealism, Weber started out with the altogether more practical intention of training as a lawyer and economist. The emergence of a specifically social-theoretical emphasis in his interests really only arose after he had already begun to analyse specific topics as part of his professional work. Weber tended to deal with the more conceptual challenges of social theory on a need-to-know basis. In this sense, Weber was more interested in getting on with studying actual things than in devoting time either to establishing an entire account of historical development, as Marx had done, or to developing a set of principles for turning the study of social phenomena into a proper science, in

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the manner of Auguste Comte and Emile Durkheim. This approach accounts for why there is no unifying theme in Weber's work, no overall framework into which each of his concepts and ideas can be fitted. Whether he liked it or not, however, Weber could not help but become involved in the heated discussions about the role of social-scientific study, and the differences between this and the natural sciences, that were taking place in intellectual and academic circles in Germany around 1900. These philosophical debates began with a revival during the 1890, in Germany and elsewhere, of one of the old chestnuts of chestnuts of philosophy and social theory, which is the distinction between **empirical knowledge**, that is, knowledge that comes through physical sensation, and **rational knowledge**, that is, knowledge in the form of the ideas and other intellectual constructs through which it is made intelligible in the mind.

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Immanuel Kant (1724-1804), a German philosopher, had argued that while knowledge of the real world was something that comes through our physical senses, it can only be made sense of once this information has been structured and organised by the mind. The human mind thus imposes a rational structure on the raw data of experience and feeling. All knowledge is thus a production of rational intellectual processing and as such reality cannot be regarded as a thing that is entirely distinguishable from knowledge of it. Reality 'in itself' cannot be known. (Kant's position is dualistic because he accepts the necessary combination of sense perception and cognitive reason. Hegel is monistic as he emphasises the absolute primacy of intellectual reason alone.)

Kant tried to reconcile his rationalist view with the strict objectivism and empiricism of John Locke (1632-1704) and David Hume (1711-96) who argue that all our ideas and concepts, including both physical sensations and intellectual reflections, are derived from practical experience of the world around us and not from pre-existing capacities of the human mind. From an empiricist viewpoint, there cannot be any knowledge or consciousness until *after* we have had physical contact with the material world around us. This dispute over the two basic kinds of knowledge – knowledge derived *a priori* from within the conscious mind and knowledge derived retrospectively from sense perception – provides an important backdrop to debates about the nature of social-scientific knowledge.

Kant further argued that the free individual was intuitively capable of moral self-direction. As *natural objects* (objects of investigation), the properties or behaviors of individuals could be investigated according to the same scientific methodologies that would be appropriate for any natural object. As *moral subjects*, however, individuals are not part of the natural world, for God has given the individual free choice to act in either a moral or an immoral fashion. A civilized society is one that encourages individuals to act morally. But society cannot deterministically generate morality because moral action is always, in part, an outcome of free will.

The Kantian emphasis on the dualism of the individual - the view of man as both natural object and moral subject - strongly influenced Simmel and Weber. Both of these latter theorists were Kantian in their belief that, in the final analysis, the moral decisions of individuals never could be judged good or bad from a sociological point of view. For Simmel and Weber, sociology, unlike biology or chemistry, had to come to terms with the fact that, to some extent, the individual was not, and could not be, constrained by determinate laws. Kant's greatest impact on modern thought then was perhaps the idea that as a rational, independent moral entity, the individual is free from at least some extrinsic, causal determinants of behaviour.

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The younger followers of Kant or 'neo- Kantians' were faced with the problem of defending the rationalist approach, used in the historical, cultural and social sciences, against the empiricist approach of the natural sciences. The considerable success of the natural sciences during the 19th century (a success that was reinforced with every new advance in technology or feat of industrial engineering), allowed the empiricists to suggest that the kind of knowledge that was generated by the speculative, metaphysical and inductive approach of the social sciences, really did not constitute proper knowledge at all. Indeed, there was no reason to suppose that the search for the general 'laws of motion' of social phenomena should not be carried out using the tried-and-tested empirical methodology and methods of the natural sciences.

The neo-Kantians, and other interested parties including Max Weber, thus turned their attention to these issues:

- They wanted to challenge the idea that the kind of knowledge generated by the natural sciences was *the only* kind of knowledge available.
- They wanted to show that the two kinds of science had to be different because they were looking at two fundamentally *different kinds* of phenomena.
- If these points are valid, then it was obvious that two distinct *methodologies* were required to investigate them.

These philosophical debates, between the positivists and anti-positivists, which began in Germany in the latter part of the nineteenth century, are popularly referred as *Methodenstreit*. For some three decades prior to the outbreak of the First World War, German academic life was dominated by a number of related disputes about methodology (the so-called *Methodenstreit*), the most general and probably the most important of which dealt with the relationship between the natural and social sciences.

One group led by Carl Menger, an economist, who advocated the use of positive science methods in social sciences as well. He argued that the scientific methodology of natural sciences should be used to arrive at general theories in social sciences – seeing human motives and social interaction as far too complex to be amenable to statistical analysis. On the other hand, the anti-positivist scholars (particularly the neo-Kantians) emphasized upon the subjective dimension of social reality and thus, did not see the possibility of any kind of universal generalizations in social sciences.

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It will be useful to begin by outlining the controversy between those who think of sociology in terms of natural science and those who think of it as being quite different from any natural science and perhaps more like history or philosophy. What are the differences between 'nature' and 'society' which would require radically different methods of enquiry? They were first clearly stated by Wilhelm Dilthey (1833-1911) and were then widely discussed by German historians and philosophers, especially Wilhelm Windelband (1848-1915) and Heinrich Rickert (1863-1936).

There are two major differences between the natural world and the social or cultural world. First, the natural world can only be observed and explained from the outside, while the world of human activity can be observed and comprehended from the inside, and is only intelligible because we ourselves belong to this world and have to do with the products of minds similar to our own. Secondly, the relations between phenomena of the natural world are mechanical relations of causality, whereas the relations between phenomena of the human world are relations of value and purpose. It follows from this, in Dilthey's view, that the 'human studies' should be concerned, not with the establishment of causal connections or the formulation of universal laws, but with the construction of typologies of personality and culture which would serve as the framework for understanding human strivings and purposes in different historical situations. Dilthey contrasted 'nature' and 'society' in terms of their subject-matter. He argued that reality can be divided into autonomous sectors – a fundamental distinction being that between the realms of 'nature' and 'human spirit' – with each sector being the prerogative of a separate category of sciences. In other words, Dilthey believed that since social or cultural science studied acting individuals with ideas and intentions, a special method of understanding (*Verstehen*) was required, while natural science studied soulless things and, consequently, it did not need to understand its objects.

Wilhelm Windelband (1848-1915), one of the leading neo-Kantians, on the other hand proposed a logical distinction between natural and social sciences on the basis of their methods. Natural sciences, according to Windelband, use a 'nomothetic' or generalizing method, whereas social sciences employ an 'ideographic' or individualizing procedure, since they are interested in the non-recurring events in reality and the particular or unique aspects of any phenomenon. He argued that the kinds of knowledge generated by the natural and the social sciences were different because they were looking at two different levels of reality. Whereas the natural scientists were concerned with material objects and with describing the general laws that governed their origins and interactions, social and cultural scientists were concerned with the ethical realm of human action and culture. Although knowledge of natural phenomena could be achieved directly

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through observation and experimentation, knowledge of human motivation, of norms and patterns of conduct, and of social and cultural values, necessarily had to be based on a more abstract process of theoretical reasoning. You can only infer that somebody is in love; you cannot actually see 'love'.

The association of social phenomena with values was also considered by the German philosopher Heinrich Rickert (1863-1936) who strongly influenced Weber's views on the matter. Rickert (who was himself adopting a famous distinction between fact and value that had been made by the Scottish Enlightenment philosopher David Hume [1711-76]), argued that the natural sciences are 'sciences of fact' and so questions of value were necessarily excluded from the analysis. The social sciences, in contrast, are 'sciences of value' because they are specifically concerned with understanding why social actors choose to act in the ways that they do. While it is appropriate to disregard questions of value when studying the physical or chemical properties of things, it is certainly not appropriate to do so when studying human social action and its consequences. It is relatively easy to show what the properties of carbon are, where it comes from and what will happen if you combine it with some other material. What you never need to do is explain how carbon atoms *feel* about any of these things.

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The prevalent intellectual and political context had a deep influence on Weber in shaping his perspective as well as ideas on subject matter. Weber partly accepted and partly rejected all the three major theoretical orientations. For example, he accepted the positivists' argument for the scientific study of social phenomena and appreciated the need for arriving at generalizations if sociology has to be a social science. But, he criticized the positivists for not taking into account the unique meanings and motives of the social actors into consideration. Further, he argued that sociology, given the variable nature of the social phenomena, could only aspire for *limited generalizations* (which he called 'thesis'), not universal generalizations as advocated by the positivists.

Similarly, Weber appreciated the neo-Kantians for taking into cognizance the subjective meanings and motives of the social actors in order to better understand the social reality but also stressed the need for building generalizations in social sciences. As stated earlier, taking a cue from Immanuel Kant, the neo-Kantian scholars argued that the reality is of two kinds, *natural reality* and *social reality*. What distinguishes social reality from the natural reality is the presence of '*Geist*'(Spirit or Consciousness) and by virtue of the presence of Geist, human beings respond to the external stimuli in a meaningful manner, not mechanically as the physical objects do. Therefore, human behaviour can only be understood in the light of these meanings. Thus social sciences should try to understand the human behaviour from the actor's point of view keeping in mind the meaning and motives that underlie such behaviour.

Weber, agreeing with the neo-Kantians, believed that human beings respond to their environment in a meaningful way and therefore, human behaviour has to be understood in the context of the underlying meanings. Therefore, Weber argued that to build the strategies of social research on the methods of natural sciences alone would be a serious mistake. The methodology of social sciences should focus on understanding the human behaviour. According to Weber, the cognitive aim of social sciences is to understand the human behaviour. A sociological explanation should therefore be meaningfully as well as causally adequate. (Please note that the causal explanations are used in all sciences. Social sciences should also use causal explanations but besides the causal explanation, the explanation in social sciences should be adequate at the level of meanings as well. That is how the cognitive aim of social sciences goes beyond that of the natural sciences.)

However, Weber criticized the neo-Kantians' proposition that generalizations are not possible in social sciences. Weber argued that all sciences, whether natural or social, begin with the study of a particular phenomenon and try to arrive at some generalization. Though Weber admitted that social sciences may not attain as much success in arriving at generalizations as natural sciences because

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the ability to discover generalizations is dependent upon the degree to which there is a pattern in the reality. So, given the variable nature of the social phenomena, social sciences could only aspire for limited generalizations. He further argued generalizations arrived in social sciences would not have the same exactitude as of those in natural sciences. Such generalizations would merely be indicative of a trend or tendency. Weber argued that we may call such limited generalizations as 'thesis' rather than the 'theory'.

Weber also partly accepted Marx's view on class conflict (economic factors) in society but argued that there could be other dimensions of the conflict as well such as status, power, etc. Further, Weber was also skeptical about the inevitability of revolution as forecasted by Marx. Weber accepted the Marxian logic of explaining conflict and change in terms of interplay of economic forces but at the same time criticized Marxian theory as mono-causal economic determinism. According to Weber, the social phenomenon is far too complex to be explained adequately in terms of a single cause. Hence Weber argued that the social science methodology should be based on the principle of *causal pluralism*. (Please note that Weber was not rejecting the Marxian theory but rather supplementing it. Weber agreed with Marx that economic factors do have a profound influence on social life. But he considered economic factor as only one of the factors that influence social life.)

To summarize, Weber is regarded to have been influenced by 'neo-Kantian' ideas in his perception of the nature of social life. According to him, behaviour of man in society is qualitatively different from that of physical objects and biological organisms. What accounts for these differences is the presence of meanings and motives which underlie the social behaviour of man. Thus any study of human behaviour in society must take cognizance of these meanings to understand this behaviour. The cognitive aims or objectives of sociological studies are, therefore, different from those of positive sciences. While positive sciences seek to discover the underlying patterns of interactions between various aspects of physical and natural phenomena, the social sciences, on the other hand, seek to understand the meanings and motives to explain the social phenomena. Hence positive science method alone would prove inadequate to study the social behaviour. However, Weber was not opposed to building generalization in social sciences, but, he pointed out that given the variable nature of social phenomena, only limited generalization can be made.

Weber conceived of sociology as a comprehensive science of 'social action' which constitutes the basic unit of social life. In consonance with his general perception of the nature of social reality, he defined social action as '*the meaningful action oriented towards other individuals*'. Presence of meanings

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as well as other individuals is equally important for any behaviour to qualify as social action. For Weber, the combined qualities of 'action' and 'meaning' were the 'central facts' for sociology's scientific analysis. Weber defined sociology as "a science which attempts the interpretive understanding of social action in order thereby to arrive at a causal explanation of its course and effects.' The technical category of 'action' described in Weber's work is all human behavior to which an actor attaches subjective meaning. "Action is social," explains Weber, "in so far as, by virtue of the subjective meaning attached to it by the acting individual, it takes account of the behavior of others and is thereby oriented in its course." However, an isolated social act does not exist in real social life. Only at the analytical level can one conceptualize an isolated social act. What exists in reality is an on-going chain of reciprocal social actions, which we call social interaction.

Thus, according to Weber, sociology is a science concerning itself with the interpretive understanding of social action. For Weber, social action is the basic unit of social life and hence the subject matter of sociology. This logically follows from his basic assumption that individuals are cultural beings but have an ability to take a deliberate stand of their own. Therefore, individuals are capable of attributing a subjective meaning to their behaviour. Thus, as a sociologist, one must look at human behaviour as social action. As stated earlier, there are two elements of social action viz. *presence of meaning* and *orientation towards others*. In the absence of assigned 'meanings' by the individuals, the actions are meaningless and thus outside the purview of sociology. Similarly, the actions which are not oriented towards others are also outside the purview of sociology.

Now, since meanings are the fundamental character of social action, so if the nature of meanings changes, the type of social action also undergoes change. Thus, based on the nature of meanings, Weber constructed a classificatory typology of social action. However, he cautioned that this classificatory typology is only for the purpose of analysis. Though it is rooted in reality but it does not mirror the reality. He based his classification of social action on the pure types of meanings, although such pure types of meanings are never found in reality. Weber argued that social reality is infinitely complex. There is an infinite variety of meanings that can exist in social life. However, according to Weber, all these meanings can be analytically reduced to four pure types of meanings. These four pure types of meanings are not found in reality. In reality, any given social action reflects a combination of two or more pure types of meanings.

Thus, based on these four pure types of meanings, there are four pure types of social actions. Weber classified social action into four major types on the basis of the nature of meaning involved. These four types of social action are:

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1. Goal–Rational Action (Zweckrational action):

   The actor determines the practical goal (rational, specific, and quantifiable) and chooses his means purely in terms of their efficiency to attain the goal. (Please note that in reality there is no pure goal-rational action. But the meaning involved in action tends to be predominantly goal rational).

2. Value-Rational Action (Wertrational action):

   Value-rational action is the one where the means are chosen for their efficiency but the goals are determined by value. The action of a captain who goes down with the sinking ship or that of a soldier who allows himself to be killed rather than yield in a war are examples of such action.

3. Affective or Emotional Action:

   In certain situations the sole meaning involved in people's behaviour is to give expression of their emotional state. Here emotion or impulse determines the ends and means of action. Such an action is termed as affective or emotional action. For example, the case of a mother who hugs her child, embracing an old friend, etc.

4. Traditional Action:

   Traditional actions are those where both ends and means are determined by custom. Here, the meaning involved is that of maintaining a continuity of the tradition. Rituals, ceremonies and practices of tradition fall in this category.

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Social Exclusion

In almost all human societies, exclusion in some or the other form exists. Certain groups or individuals are excluded from the mainstream society. They are deprived of some opportunities which are needed for the full blossom of human life. While, the way in which individuals or groups are excluded is context-specific, certain social differences continue to serve as grounds for exclusion. These differences include belonging to a particular ethnic, religious, caste, gender, or age group; or living in a particular geographic area; or having certain physical or mental disabilities. Various forms of social differences overlap and intersect in complex ways over time.

Compared with established concepts such as poverty, class or social mobility, social exclusion has a relatively short history. The term itself was coined in the 1970s by French politician **Rene Lenoir** to describe that section of the French population that had been cut-off or marginalized from mainstream society and had slipped through the 'welfare net'. The concept has particular resonance in countries which share with France a Republic tradition, in which social cohesion is held to be essential in maintaining the contract on which society is founded.

Social exclusion terminology was adopted at a European Union level in the late 1980s and early 1990s. Right-wing governments, including the Thatcher government in the UK, did not recognize the existence of poverty in their own countries, while commentators on the left were becoming increasingly concerned about the social polarization associated with rapidly growing income inequality. By the 1980s, the concept had a prominent place in the European political agenda and today, the European Social Charter guarantees all citizens of the European Union protection against poverty and social exclusion. By the mid-1990s, use of the term 'social exclusion' by Labour politicians in the UK was commonplace, and the Social Exclusion Unit was set up shortly after the 1997 General Election. [Please note that while poverty and income inequality were high on the agenda of Old Labour in UK, social exclusion was the central theme of New Labour. New Labour in UK, for example Tony Blair, was keen to establish that social exclusion was more than traditional 'poverty'. It is more damaging to individual self esteem, corrosive for society as a whole and is more likely to be passed down from generation to generation than material poverty.]

In the international arena, the United Nations Development Programme has been at the forefront of attempts to conceptualize social exclusion across the developed and developing world. A series of country studies led to the formulation of a rights-focused approach, which regards social exclusion as lack of access to the institutions of civil society (legal and political systems), and to the basic levels

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of education, health, and financial well-being necessary to make access to those institutions a reality.

There are a multitude of definitions of social exclusion but no single official definition of the concept exists, and apart from the shared notions of marginalization and non-participation, particular definitions often emphasize different aspects of exclusion. The Social Exclusion Unit described social exclusion as 'what can happen when individuals or areas suffer from a combination of linked problems such as unemployment, poor skills, low incomes, poor housing, high crime environments, bad health and family breakdown'.

The statement alerts us to the possibility that communities and not simply individuals can experience social exclusion. Further, the impact of social inclusion on individuals and communities is greater than the sum of its parts (2+2=5). In other words, the elements of social exclusion are multidimensional, interlinked, mutually reinforcing and cumulative. For example, poor health can impact on employability or family breakdown may impact on a child's educational performance and poor quality housing can undermine physical and mental health. **Ruth Levitas** focuses on this interconnectedness and the multidimensional nature of social exclusion. There is also an acknowledgement that exclusion is not just an individual experience but has wider implications related to the question social cohesion.

Levitas argues that social exclusion is a complex and multi-dimensional process. It involves the denial or lack of resources, rights, goods and services, and the inability to participate in the normal relationships and activities, available to the majority of people in society, whether in economic, social, cultural or political arenas. **It affects both the quality of life of individuals and the equity and cohesion society as a whole.**

Walker and **Walker**, drawing on T H Marshall's framework, identify social exclusion as denial of citizenship. They recognize that exclusion is not simply an absolute state but that it has gradations:

> The dynamic process of being shut out, fully or partially, from any social, economic, political and cultural systems which determine the social integration of a person in society. Social exclusion may, therefore, be seen as the denial (or non-realization) of the civil, political and social rights of citizenship.

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Social exclusion: a more powerful concept than poverty?

How useful is the concept of 'social exclusion' and does it have greater explanatory power than poverty? Similarly, does social exclusion offer us enhanced insights into the experiences of marginalized group and communities? Many would argue that poverty is a narrower, more limited concept than social exclusion. Poverty focuses essentially on the distribution of material resources, on matters related to income, wealth and consumption. Social exclusion is a broader, more multidimensional notion which focuses on economic, political, cultural and social detachment (Walker and Walker, 1997).

G.J. Room has argued that the notion of poverty is primarily focused upon ***distributional*** issues: the lack of resources at the disposal of an individual or household. In contrast, notions such as social exclusion focus primarily on ***relational*** issues: in other words, adequate social participation, lack of integration and lack of power, etc.

Poverty and social exclusion often go hand in hand. Poverty is frequently a significant element in social exclusion and can trigger social exclusion. However, the relationship is contingent rather than categorical; someone can be socially excluded without being poor. For example, there is no evidence that the experience of sexual minorities is essentially defined by poverty. Nevertheless, their lives continue to be defined by a social, cultural and political exclusion. They continue to be vulnerable to hate crimes and have their sexuality denied legitimacy. Likewise, not all people with a physical disability may be poor but will experience a degree of social exclusion, most obviously a lack of accessibility which impacts on their mobility and on social relations. Some elderly people may not be poor but in an ageist society they will experience a degree of social exclusion. The value of social exclusion lies in the fact that it offers explanatory insights beyond that of poverty.

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Social exclusion and mental health

The Social Exclusion Unit report described people with mental health issues as 'one of the most excluded groups in society'. It is clear that the concept of poverty fails to capture and explain their experience, although poverty is often part of their lives.

> For some of us, an episode of mental distress will disrupt our lives so that we are pushed out of the society in which we were fully participating. For others, the early onset of distress will mean social exclusion throughout our adult lives, with no prospect of training for a job or a future in meaningful employment. Loneliness and loss of self-worth lead us to believe we are useless, and so we live with this sense of hopelessness, or far too often chose to end our lives. Repeatedly when we become ill we lose our homes, we lose our jobs and we lose our sense of identity.

The severity of the social exclusion experienced by people with a mental health problem is well documented – poor physical health, high level of unemployment, social isolation, vulnerability to stigma and suspicion. The Social Exclusion Unit recognized that these deprivations are interconnected and may form a 'cycle of deprivation'. Some elements in this cycle are particularly significant. In terms of work, it has been said that there is greater discrimination against those with a record of mental illness than those with a criminal record. People with mental health problem have one of the lowest employment rates of all disabled groups. Unemployment can be an important driver of social exclusion as it often has significant financial, social and psychological implication. Financially, unemployment means restricted power to consume in a society in which consumption is an important source of status. Exclusion from employment means a loss of, or reduced, social networks and psychologically, our sense of identity, our sense of self, is often defined by our occupation. As Secker argues:

> In addition to the negative impact on confidence, self-esteem and mental health itself, unemployment can result in restricted income, fewer opportunities to meet other people or develop skill, and loss of a productive identity that, for many people, is central to a sense of belonging within society.

Through such studies, one begins to develop a sense of the intensity of social exclusion experienced by people with mental health problems.

The concept of social exclusion alerts us to dynamic and complex process; the way in which different forms of deprivation do not exist independent of each other but interact and are mutually reinforcing. Poor mental health can be both a cause and consequence of social exclusion, and mental illness can cause or intensify social exclusion; similarly, social exclusion can deepen mental illness. While the concept of poverty will remain a vital tool for student of social policy,

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social exclusion expands the realm of our enquiries into issues of marginalization and disadvantage that may not be related to income and wealth.

Competing discourses of social exclusion

Dear candidate, as previously noted, there is no simple, single, accepted definition of social exclusion and the concept implies diverse things to different people with politicians of different political persuasions seeking to harness the concept for diverse ends. There are competing discourses of social exclusion which variably stress that the causes of social exclusion may be seen as being located at the level of the individual, the family, or locally, nationally or even globally.

Ruth Levitas (2005) has made an important contribution to our understanding and identifies three discourses of social exclusion. Please note that social exclusion discourses are underpinned by different assumptions about the way in which society is structured and the distribution of power within it. They offer opposing accounts of the causes and extent of, and solutions to, social exclusion.

The first discourse identified by Levitas is a **Moral Underclass Discourse** (MUD). Here, individuals and communities are seen as deviant, immoral, impulsive, welfare dependent, unhealthy and criminal. Often, poor parenting and the notion of the dysfunctional family is implicated. Deviant values and norms are passed from generation to generation (deviant culture). There is often a spatial dimension to this discourse, with an identified 'underclass' concentrated in deprived neighbourhoods, characterized by high levels of crime, poverty, unemployment and poor health, and low levels of educational attainment. This kind of analysis, notably associated with the work of American political scientist Charles Murray, has attracted a powerful sociological and political critique. It is worth noting that cultures do not develop in a vacuum but can be understood as a response to a particular set of material conditions. In other words, individuals or communities cannot be understood in isolation from their relationship to wider societal structures and groups. The application of a MUD-type discourse is ideologically driven and diverts attention away from social divisions such as 'race' and 'class', which are rendered insignificant in explaining and understanding the deviance and social protest.

The second discourse identified by Levitas is the **Social Integrationist Discourse** (SID). Here, social exclusion is viewed primarily as a consequence of exclusion from the paid labour market. SID was at the forefront of New Labour's attack on social exclusion where access to paid work was seen as the most effective way of overcoming social exclusion and entry into the labour market was

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considered to be the key to inclusion. It was stated that 'The best defence against social exclusion is having a job, and the best way to get a job is to have a good education, with the right training and experience'. Under New Labour's **conditional welfare state**, welfare policy became a way of integrating people into the labour market. This strategy involved using a mixture of 'carrots' such as benefit incentives, and 'sticks', i.e. the threat of a reduction or withdrawal of benefits for those who failed to recognize their responsibilities to work. There is a moral dimension to SID, as paid work is seen to offer more than simply income. The employed citizen is a 'responsible' citizen and exposure to the discipline of the workplace is viewed as important because it is said to give a structure to unemployed people's lives.

The idea that work is the key to social inclusion has an attractive simplicity but Levitas herself is less than convinced. A social integrationist discourse seems to suggest that those in employment are equally included but this ignores the hierarchical structure of the paid labour market and the fact that much work is poorly paid, insecure and casual and that many people who work hard remain in poverty despite their best efforts. It makes no reference to the status of the working poor – those who remain poor in spite of being in paid work. Inclusion in the labour market through marginal, low paid, insecure jobs under poor working conditions does not constitute genuine poverty free social inclusion. Also, work within this discourse is very narrowly defined – it is paid work. Levitas argues that many of those excluded are employed. They are simply not in *paid* employment, rather they are engaged in informal, familial, 'caring' work. Such work, generally carried out by women, is often invisible, undervalued and unrecognized. More broadly, a SID lacks sociological rigour. It closes down analysis prematurely by failing to consider adequately the structural causes of unemployment.

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In the third discourse identified by Levitas, the **Redistributionist Discourse** (RED), a social exclusion is viewed as a consequence of poverty and structural inequality. If SID was a defining idea of New Labour, then RED is associated with Old Labour and socialism. Here, poverty is not seen as a residual problem but as an inevitable product of capitalism. Social exclusion is therefore rooted in de-industrialization, global economic change and a rolling back of the welfare state. The other two discourses, i.e. MUD and SID, are seen as distraction or diversions which shift attention from the broader processes that cause social exclusion. New questions begin to emerge under RED, about power and the way it is exercised. If someone is excluded, than someone or something is doing the excluding. The focus is on the structural causes of that exclusion, and not simply the operation of the labour market or the individual 'immorality' of the excluded.

If the causes of social exclusion are seen as structural, then structural change is required to counter it, for example a programme of redistribution (through state intervention) including a reform of the taxation system and an expansion of welfare benefits and public services: 'RED broadens out from its concern with poverty into a critique of inequality, and contrasts exclusion with a version of citizenship which calls for substantial redistribution of power and wealth'. RED offers a radically different perspective on the social disturbances, refuting any notion of 'pure criminality'. Thus rioting or any form of social protest is not simply a meaningless, abnormal phenomenon but is deeply rooted in the history and culture of a given society. Social protest can be understood as a form of political action – as a meaningful, if chaotic, protest by those who are socially excluded.

It is important to recognize Levitas's discourses as artificial constructs. They are ideal type accounts – grounded in reality but not capturing the diversity and complexity of that reality; nonetheless they have heuristic value and offer a framework to develop competing understanding of social exclusion. Thus it would be misleading to suggest, in a simple way, that MUD is a discourse of the New Right, or SID of New Labour or RED of Old Labour; the reality of policy is more complex.

It is important to go beyond the simple binary (i.e. consisting of only two parts) divisions in our understanding of social exclusion. For example, mental illness may be the defining experience of a person or group but it does not exist in isolation from other aspects of difference, and people with mental health issues are not a homogenous group. The experience of a person with mental illness may also be defined by their class, gender, ethnicity, etc. In other words, mental illness can be an important driver of social exclusion but when this condition is associated with membership of an ethnic minority community, for example, that exclusion can be sharpened and even more debilitating.

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Finally, social exclusion is not simply an issue for the socially excluded. It has wider significance for issues of equality, citizenship, social stability and cohesion. Social exclusion is not just a problem for those who are excluded, it is a problem for social structure and social solidarity generally. If significant numbers of people are excluded……..then social order will likely become more polarized and unequal – and ultimately perhaps more unstable for all.

Social Exclusion in India: refer class notes

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Emile Durkheim (1858-1917)

Emile Durkheim was born in 1858, in Epinal, France. He grew up in a traditional, orthodox Jewish family. His father was a rabbi (as his grandfather and great-grandfather had been). The family was quite poor. Like his father before him, young Durkheim expected to become a rabbi. His training began early in Hebrew and Old Testament and the Talmud. His Jewish parents nurtured their son's ambition in the strongly homogeneous and cohesive community of Jews. The Jewish minority status and his early contact with the disastrous Franco-Prussian War made a major impression upon Durkheim, which is reflected in his constant fascination with the study of group solidarity. However, Durkheim changed his mind and later on even rejected the Jewish faith. He remained a non-believer for the rest of his life. In 1879 he became a student at the most prestigious postgraduate school of higher education, the Ecole Normale Superieure in Paris. Though his primary training was in philosophy, his strong personal interest was in politics and sociology. Because he was so astute in the application of his fledgling scientific skills of political and social analysis and partly because of his rebellious demeanor vis-a-vis the more traditional ways of doing things at the Ecole, Durkheim was not always in favour with the university establishment. Upon graduation in 1882, he taught philosophy in several provincial Lycees in the neighbourhood of Paris, the University, from 1882 to 1887. Determined in his professional growth, Durkheim took a leave of absence from teaching to do further study in Germany from 1885-1886, primarily in Berlin and Leipzig where he was especially impressed with the scientific precision in the experiments of the renowned psychologist Wilhelm Wundt.

During this time, Durkheim began to publish articles, first on the German academic life and then critical articles on various kinds of scholarship thereby gaining considerable recognition from the French academy. In 1887, he was appointed to the faculty of the University of Bordeaux where the first course in social science in all of France was created for him to teach. Shortly thereafter, he married Louise Dreyfus, a Jewish girl from a strong traditional family. They had two children, Marie and Andre. Little is known about family life except that Louise seems to have been a strong and supportive wife and encouraging mother.

During the years in Bordeaux (until 1902) Durkheim was very productive and wrote three of his most important books. His students and friends described him as very disciplined, serious, and stern. Durkheim alongwith Max Weber must be credited with founding the modern phase of sociological theory. It began with his first book, *The Division of Labour in Society*, submitted as his French doctoral thesis at the Sorbonne alongwith his Latin doctoral thesis on Montesquieu in 1893. Two years after his monumental work on the *Division of Labour* (1893), he

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published his second major study, *The Rules of Sociological Method* (1895), completing his Bordeaux trilogy in 1897 with his incomparable *Suicide*. Because of the tremendous impact Durkheim was having in French universities and given the increasing numbers of France's finest young intellectuals who began to cluster around him, Durkheim became convinced that a literary forum was necessary both to accommodate the burgeoning of sociological scholarship and to further enhance the already accelerating recognition sociology was receiving across the spectrum of the French academy. For this purpose, Durkheim founded in 1898, while at Bordeaux, the *L'Annee Sociologique*, a scholarly journal under his own editorship that became the organ of research, debate, and discussion among not only Durkheim and his immediate followers but of all accepted sociological work going on in France. He remained its most important contributor until the war in 1914 when journal was closed.

Four years later and as everyone was anticipating, Durkheim was called to the Sorbonne, Paris's great university and headquarters of the French intelligentsia. The chair created for him in 1902 was in sociology and education, and though education was soon dropped from his prestigious title, Durkheim remained interested in the application of sociology to the field of education throughout his career. His final and in many respects provocative book came fifteen years after his previous study and ten years after going to the Sorbonne, entitled, *The Elementary Forms of the Religious Life* (1912). It was the ripe harvest of a long process of intensive cultivation. Religion, once a major passion for him in childhood, became once again a major pre-occupation, not so much as an unwitting participant but as a scrutinizing observer.

The tragedy of the First World War was a very great blow to France, and Durkheim, a man so much committed to the understanding of social solidarity, felt the strain acutely. Half of his class from his Sorbonne student days were killed in combat. Keeping the university activities going in the name of truth and scholarship became increasingly difficult. Distraction, anxieties, despair over loss of friends, students, relations, and colleagues intensified. And, just before Christmas, 1915, Durkheim was notified that his only son, Andre, had died in a Bulgarian hospital of wounds taken in battle. The pride and hope of Durkheim had been shattered by the ravages of war. The loss was too great to bear, his health failed, and in less than two years at the age of fifty-nine, Durkheim died on November 15, 1917.

Dear Candidate, to a considerable extent, the great classical theories are influenced by, and expressions of, the political and moral conflicts, economic processes, and ideological movements of the nineteenth century. Durkheim's sociology too is characterized by this tension between science and morality,

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politics and ideology. As already mentioned above, Durkheim lived through a very turbulent period in French history—the disastrous war with the Prussians, the chaos and socio-political turmoil which inevitably followed, and the instability and internal conflicts of the Third Republic. Durkheim was also involved in the greatest political conflicts of his time known as the Dreyfus Affair. In 1894, a French officer named Dreyfus was found guilty of treason for supposedly writing to the German embassy about secret French documents. What made the conviction especially controversial was that Dreyfus was a Jew and the French military had a notorious reputation for anti-Semitism. Two years later, when evidence came to light exonerating Dreyfus, the military tried to suppress it. In response to this the author Emile Zola wrote a famous letter accusing the French government of convicting an innocent man. Many leading French intellectuals defended the rights of Dreyfus and condemned the traditions of anti-Semitism and authoritarianism in the military. Because of prevailing public concerns this was soon framed as a conflict between individual rights and traditional authority. Although a Jew and therefore personally concerned about anti-Semitism, Durkheim, entered the debate on the side Dreyfus from a more abstract position. The idea of moral individualism became especially important to Durkheim after the Dreyfus affair. In his essay "Individualism and the Intellectuals," he fully develops his idea of moral individualism. He cleverly shows how a defense of the rights of the individual is the best way to strengthen our traditions and to guard against the social threat of egoism. Individualism has become our modern tradition, and to attack it not only is to risk social disorder, but is tantamount to blasphemy.

All these problems of the French society along with his own back-ground of belongingness to a highly well-knit Jewish community, pre-disposed him towards a search for the basis of moral order in society. It made him assert the primacy of 'group' over the individuals and pre-occupied him with exploring the sources of social order and disorder, the forces that make for regulation or deregulation in the body social. His overriding concern as a moral man and scientist was with the social order. Durkheim believed that the traditional sources of morality upon which the social order was built, especially religion, were no longer viable or valid without serious and rational alterations. The new source of moral integration, so necessary for the establishment and stability of society, would be found in the discipline designed to scientifically analyze social order, stability, and continuity, viz., that of sociology.

Much of his scientific work displays an interest in promoting moral reform. His general sociological aim was to define the necessary conditions for a stable, smoothly functioning, modern society. On this foundation, he thought it possible to formulate "correct," scientific solutions to the most pressing problems of his age. He was in favour of a liberal, democratic constitution, the development of the

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welfare state, and the regulation of the capitalist economy. He aligned himself with reformist socialism, but was also influenced by *conservative* ideas on the importance of morality, the family, religion, and tradition. Please note that Durkheim's interest in socialism is sometimes taken as evidence against the idea that he was a conservative, but his kind of socialism was very different from the kind that interested Marx and his followers. In fact, Durkheim labeled Marxism as a set of "disputable and out-of-date hypothesis." To Durkheim socialism represented a movement aimed at the moral regeneration of society through scientific morality, and he was not interested in short-term political methods or the economic aspects of socialism. He did not see proletariat as the salvation of society, and he was greatly opposed to agitation or violence. Socialism for Durkheim was very different from what we usually think of as socialism: it simply represented a system in which the moral principles discovered by scientific sociology were to be applied.

Although Durkheim was aware of Marx's work, and was a contemporary of Max Weber (Durkheim died in 1917, Weber in 1920), his training and intellectual orientation were quite different. Marx built his social theory on the basis of the German idealist philosophy of Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel, the British political economy of Adam Smith and David Ricardo, and the French socialist tradition. Weber's social theory developed out of the philosophical debates that dominated German intellectual circles in the 1880s. In contrast Durkheim stood as the successor to a quite different current of thought in the French positivist tradition.

The roots of Durkheim's sociology reach deep into the history and intellectual life of France. His theory of the foundation and progress of modern society is based on ideas first clearly formulated during the dramatic social changes that came about from the end of the eighteenth century onwards. Durkheim's most significant predecessor was Auguste Comte, the founder of French positivism. Comte was the first to use the term "sociology" to identify the new social science, and his was one of the first attempts to establish an autonomous basis for the scientific study of society. From Comte he was inspired by the idea that it was possible and necessary to develop a knowledge of social phenomena that would be as rigorous, reliable and concrete as the positivistic knowledge provided by the biological and natural sciences. He also followed Comte in seeing human society in naturalistic terms as an organic unity. Although in his later work, Durkheim used the organic analogy less often, he always believed that a central task of social theory was to understand the linkages and dependencies between one part or organ of the social body and another. A doctor might have a specialist interest in the digestive system, but this system can only be understood in the context of the other bodily systems with which it is connected. A

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similar challenge faces the social theorist in trying to understand how one social phenomenon interconnects with another.

Durkheim sets out his own view of these tasks in his influential book *The Rules of Sociological Method*, which was published in France in 1895. The key advance he makes on Comte's approach is to emphasise that it is possible to identify a category of social phenomena, or **social facts** as he calls them, which is objectively identifiable, and which can be studied quite independently of any grand system of analysis that might be applied to them:

"Here, then, is a category of facts with very distinctive characteristics: it consists of ways of acting, thinking, and feeling, external to the individual, and endowed with a power of coercion, by reason of which they control him….They constitute, thus, a new variety of phenomena; and it is to them exclusively that the term 'social' ought to be applied. And this term fits them quite well, for it is clear that, since their source is not in the individual, their substratum can be no other than society."

Durkheim, *The Rules of Sociological Method* (1895)

Durkheim believed that sociology, as an idea, was born in France in the nineteenth century. He wanted to turn this idea into a discipline, a well-defined field of study. Although the term *sociology* had been coined some years earlier by Auguste Comte, there was no field of sociology per se in late nineteenth-century universities. There were no schools, departments, or even professors of sociology. There were a few thinkers who were dealing with the ideas that were in one way or another sociological, but there was as yet no disciplinary "home" for sociology. Indeed, there was strong opposition from existing disciplines to the founding of such a field. The most significant opposition came from psychology and philosophy, two fields that claimed already to cover the domain sought by sociology. The dilemma for Durkheim, given his aspirations for sociology, was how to create for it a separate and identifiable niche.

To separate it from philosophy, Durkheim argued that sociology should be oriented toward empirical research. In his view, the two other major figures of the epoch who thought of themselves as sociologists, Comte and Herbert Spencer, were far more interested in philosophizing, in abstract theorizing, than they were in studying the social world empirically. If the field continued in the direction set by Comte and Spencer, Durkheim felt, it would become nothing more than a branch of philosophy. As a result, he found it necessary to attack both Comte and Spencer for relying on preconceived ideas of social phenomena instead of actually studying the real world. Thus Comte was said to be guilty of assuming theoretically that the social world was evolving in the direction of an increasingly perfect society, rather than engaging in the hard, rigorous, and basic work of actually studying the

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changing nature of various societies. Similarly, Spencer was accused of assuming harmony in society rather than studying whether harmony actually existed.

Thus, in order to help sociology move away from philosophy and to give it a clear and separate identity, Durkheim proposed that **the distinctive subject matter of sociology should be the study of social facts**. Briefly, *social facts* are the social structure and cultural norms and values that are external to, and coercive of, actors. Students, for example, are constrained by such social structures as the university norms and the value that a given society places on education. Similar social facts constrain people in all areas of social life. Crucial in separating sociology from philosophy is the idea that social facts are to be treated as "things" and studied empirically. This means that social facts must be studied by acquiring data from outside of our own minds through observation and experimentation. This empirical study of social fact as things sets Durkheimian sociology apart from more philosophical approaches.

A social fact is every way of acting, *fixed or not*, capable of exercising on the individual an *external constraint*: or again, every way of acting which is *general* throughout a given society, while at the same time existing in its own right *independent* of its individual manifestations.

Durkheim, *The Rules of Sociological Method* (1895)

Note that Durkheim gave two ways of defining a social fact so that sociology is distinguished from psychology. First, it is experienced as an *external* constraint rather than an internal drive; second, it is *general* throughout the society and is not attached to any particular individual.

Durkheim argued that social facts cannot be reduced to individual, but must be studied as their own reality. Durkheim referred to social facts with the Latin term *sui generis*, which means "unique." He used this term to claim that social facts have their own unique character that is not reducible to individual consciousness. To allow that social facts could be explained by reference to individuals would be to reduce sociology to psychology. Instead, social facts can be explained only by other social facts. To summarize, social facts can be empirically studied, are external to the individual, are coercive of the individual, and are explained by other social facts.

Dear Candidate, let me just simplify all that we have discussed above. Durkheim simply argues that when individuals come together and start living in a group, a new level of reality emerges, that is, social reality or society. In a given society, individuals interact and enter into relations with each other giving rise to a way of life (social currents, for Durkheim). For example, members of a given

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society may develop certain norms to regulate sexual behaviour of its members or to regulate the production, distribution and exchange of goods and services. Over a period of time, these norms or social currents crystallize and take the form of social institutions such as marriage, kinship, market, etc. Thus emerge social facts. Durkheim argues that although society (and its various institutions) develop out of the continuous process of interaction of its individual members yet it comes to acquire a unique and independent existence of its own. It cannot be simply explained by reducing it to a mere aggregation of individuals. Society is not a mere sum of individuals. In other words, it is more than the sum of its parts. Despite the fact that society is made up only of human beings, it can be understood only through studying the interactions rather than the individuals. The interactions have their own levels of reality. For Durkheim, society is a *reality sui generis*. Society has an objective existence; it is independent of the consciousness of the individual members who comprise it. It is external, and enduring. Individuals may die and new members take their place, but society lives forever. This view of Durkheim (**his perspective**) is sometimes also described as '**sociological realism**' because he ascribes the ultimate sociological reality to the group and not to the individual.

Durkheim further argues that since each science is concerned with its own chosen aspect of reality, therefore, a new level of reality, *social reality*, must be studied by a new science namely Sociology. In keeping with the tradition of nineteenth century thinkers like Comte, Spencer, etc., Durkheim believed that this new science of society must be built on the lines of positive sciences. This, he thought would be possible because social reality has its own objective existence, independent of the consciousness of the individual members who comprise it.

Dear Candidate, please also note that Durkheim viewed society as an integrated whole made up of inter-connected and inter-dependent parts. These parts fulfill the needs of the society. This contribution of parts towards fulfillment of the needs of the whole is called, 'function'. Thus, these contributions of the parts enable the society to persist. An attempt to explain the persistence of society should therefore take into account the consequences of the parts for the society as a whole. You have already studied functionalism in detail in our discussion earlier.

The subject matter of sociology, Durkheim proposed, should be the study of social facts. Social facts are nothing but those aspects of social life which have an independent existence of their own, over and above their individual manifestations. According to Durkheim, ***social facts are those ways of acting, thinking and feeling which are capable of exerting an external constraint on individual members, which are generally diffused throughout a given society and which can exist in their own life independent of their individual manifestations***.

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Examples of such social facts are religion, law, language, any form of socio-economic and political institutions, etc.

On the basis of the discussion above, let us summarize the major characteristics of social facts.

Firstly, social facts have distinctive **social** characteristics and determinants which are not amenable to explanation on either the biological or psychological level;

Secondly, they are **external** to the individual; it means that social facts are external to and independent of the individual members of the society;

Thirdly, social facts are diffused throughout the collectivity and are commonly shared by most of the members. In other words, they are **general** throughout a given society. They are not the exclusive property of any single individual rather they belong to the group as a whole. They represent the socially patterned ways of thinking, feeling and acting and exclude the individual idiosyncrasies;

Fourthly, they **endure** through time outlasting any set or group of individuals;

Fifthly, they are, in Durkheim's own words, "endowed with **coercive** power, by virtue of which they impose themselves upon him, independent of his individual will". In other words, social facts constrain the individual to abide by the social norms and code of conduct. People living in groups are not free to behave according to their volition. Instead, their behaviour follows the guidance laid down by the group and the group exercises a moral pressure on the individual members, compelling them to conform to group norms. According to Durkheim, true human freedom lies in being properly regulated by the social norms.

Important: Dear Candidate, I would like to elabourate this point a little further. As discussed earlier, the prevailing problems of the French society along with his own back-ground of belongings to a highly well-knit Jewish community had pre-disposed Durkheim towards a search for the basis of moral order in society. It made him assert the primacy of 'group' over the individuals and pre-occupied him with exploring the sources of social order and disorder. His overriding concern as a moral man and scientist was with the social order. Durkheim was a sociologist of morality in the broadest sense of the word. Durkheim's view of morality had two aspects.

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First, Durkheim was convinced that morality is a social fact, in other words, that morality can be empirically studied, is external to the individual, is coercive of the individual, and is explained by other social facts. This means that morality is not something which one can philosophize about, but something that one has to study as an empirical phenomenon. This is particularly true because morality is intimately related to the social structure. To understand the morality of any particular institution, you have to first study how the institution is constituted, how it came to assume its present form, what its place is in overall structure of society, how the various institutional obligations are related to the social good, and so forth.

Second, Durkheim was a sociologist of morality because his studies were driven by his concern about the moral "health" of modern society. Much of Durkheim's sociology can be seen as a by-product of his concern with moral issues. It was not that Durkheim thought that society had become, or was in danger of becoming, immoral. That simply was impossible because morality was, for Durkheim, identified with society. Therefore, society could not be immoral, but it could certainly lose its moral force if the collective interest of society became nothing but the sum of self-interests. Only to the extent that morality was a social fact could it impose an obligation on individuals that superseded their self-interest. Consequently, Durkheim believed that society needs a strong common morality. What the morality should be was of less interest to him.

Durkheim's great concern with morality was related to his curious definition of freedom. In Durkheim's view, people were in danger of a "pathological" loosening of moral bonds. These moral bonds were important to Durkheim, for without them the individual would be enslaved by ever-expanding and insatiable passions. People would be impelled by their passions into a mad search for gratification, but each new gratification would lead only to more and more needs. According to Durkheim, the one thing that every human will always want is "more." And, of course, that is the one thing we ultimately cannot have. If society does not limit us, we will become slaves to the pursuit of more. Consequently, Durkheim held the seemingly paradoxical view that the individual needs morality and external control in order to be free. This view of the insatiable desire at the core of every human is central to his sociology.

Sixthly, social facts are not static but **dynamic** in nature. For example, as society evolves over a period of time, there is also a corresponding change in its socio-economic and political institutions (this point is important and we will come back to it in our discussion on 'Anomie'); and

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Finally, Durkheim argued that social facts can be explained only by other social facts. It implies that in order to understand social consequences, one must look for social causes.

For Durkheim, sociology is a science of such social facts. Society or '*Conscience collective*' is the ultimate social fact. Further the constituent social facts of the conscience collective exist in a state of interrelationship or interdependence. Therefore, these social facts have to be studied in terms of their interrelationship and interdependence with each other. According to Durkheim, what holds the society together as an ongoing concern is the cohesiveness between these interdependent parts. This 'cohesiveness' has been termed by him as **'solidarity.'**

Before proceeding further, I would like to briefly mention about the distinction that Durkheim made between two broad types of social facts—material and nonmaterial. *Material social facts*, such as forms of technology, styles of architecture, and legal codes are easier to understand of the two because they are directly observable. Clearly, such things as laws are external to individuals and coercive over them. More importantly, these social facts often express a far larger and more powerful realm of *moral forces* that are at least equally external to individuals and coercive over them. These are *nonmaterial social facts*. The bulk of Durkheim's studies, and heart of his sociology, lies in the study of nonmaterial social facts. He argued that a sociologist usually begins a study by focusing on material social facts, which are empirically accessible, in order to understand nonmaterial social facts, which are the real focus of his work. Some of the examples of nonmaterial social facts are morality, collective conscience, collective representations, and social currents.

Durkheim attempted to deal with his interest in common morality in various ways and with different concepts. In his early efforts to deal with this issue, Durkheim developed the idea of the c*onscience collective. Conscience collective*, a French term, when translated into English is collective conscience. In French, the word *conscience* means both "consciousness" and "moral conscience." Durkheim characterized the collective conscience in the following way:

> The totality of beliefs and sentiments common to average citizens of the same society forms a determinate system which has its own life; one may call it the collective or common conscience….It is, thus, an entirely different thing from particular consciences, although it can be realized only through them.
>
> (Durkheim, 1893)

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Several points are worth underscoring in this definition. First, it is clear that Durkheim thought of the collective conscience as occurring throughout a given society when he wrote of the "totality" of people's beliefs and sentiments. Second, Durkheim clearly conceived of the collective conscience as being independent and capable of determining other social facts. It is not just a reflection of a material base as Marx sometimes suggested. Finally, although he held such views of the collective conscience, Durkheim also wrote of its being "realized" through individual consciousness.

In simpler words, we can describe collective conscience as *"the totality of beliefs and sentiments common to the average member of the society, which forms a determinate system with a life of its own."* Thus collective conscience refers to the general structure of shared understandings, norms, and beliefs. It links successive generations to one another. Individuals come in and go out of society, however collective conscience remains. Although collective conscience can only be realized through individuals, it has a form beyond a particular person, and operates at a level higher than him. It is therefore an all-embracing and amorphous concept. As we will see later, Durkheim employed this concept to argue that "primitive" societies had a stronger collective conscience – that is, more shared understandings, norms, and beliefs – than modern societies.

Because collective conscience is such a broad and amorphous idea, it is impossible to study directly, but must be approached through related material social facts. Durkheim's dissatisfaction with this limitation led him to use the collective conscience less in his later works in favour of the much more specific concept of *collective representations*. Durkheim used the concept of collective representations in order to highlight the richness and diversity of the commonly shared beliefs and sentiments, for example, commonly shared cognitive beliefs (concepts), moral beliefs, religious beliefs, etc.

The French word *representation* literally means "idea." Initial definition forwarded by Durkheim in his book *Suicide* (1897) stated that 'essentially social life is made of representations.' Let us try to understand this. See, there is a difference between an object, and the way it is seen, the manner in which it is described, and its meaning understood commonly in a society. The object is thus presented again in terms of meanings, a word is given a meaning. The object or the word is thus 'represented.' C*ollective representation* is a term introduced by Durkheim to refer to a symbol having a common intellectual and emotional meaning to the members of a group. They include not only symbols in the form of objects, such as a flag, but also the basic concepts that determine the way in which one views and relates to the world. Collective representations express collective

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sentiments and ideas which give the group its unity and unique character. Thus they are an important factor contributing to the solidarity of a society.

Collective representations are states of the collective conscience which are different in nature from the states of the individual conscience. They express the way in which a particular group of individuals conceives itself in relation to the objects which affect the social group. Collective representations are socially generated and they refer to, and are, in some sense, about society. Durkheim states that collective representations result from the substratum of associated individuals. But they cannot be reduced to and wholly explained by features of constituent individuals. They are 'sui generis', that is, they generate themselves.

Durkheim used the term *collective representations* to refer to both a collective concept and a social "force." Examples of collective representations are religious symbols, myths, and popular legends. All of these are ways in which society reflects on itself. They represent collective beliefs, norms, and values, and they motivate us to conform to these collective claims. As stated earlier, collective representations also cannot be reduced to individuals, because they emerge out of social interactions, but they can be studied more directly because they are more liable to connected to material symbols such as flags, icons, and pictures or connected to practices such as rituals. Therefore, the sociologist can begin to study how certain collective representations fit well together or have an affinity, and others do not.

Dear Candidate, after giving at least three readings to these notes and making notes in the 'pointer form,' please go through the questions asked in previous years and try to attempt them. Always remember that without answer-writing practice, any amount of sociological knowledge would be of little use for you in qualifying civil services examination. Thus, along with understanding the sociological ideas discussed here, you must also master the art of expressing them in your own words as per the standards of the examination and expectations of the examiner, and that too, in the given Time-and-Word Limit.

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Talcott Parsons (1902-1979)

Talcott Parsons was born in 1902 in Colorado Springs and grew up under conditions that may be characterized as Protestant religious, liberal, and intellectual. In 1920 he went to the rather conservative Amherst College in Massachusetts where he took biology as his major subject. In 1924 he moved to Europe, first to the London School of Economics, where he attended lectures by the social anthropologist Bronislaw Malinowski, and studied economics. The following year he went to Heidelberg, where Max Weber had been a professor until 1918. Besides Max Weber, Parsons became acquainted here with the then contemporary debates in German Philosophy and economic history, and wrote his doctoral thesis on *The Concept of Capitalism in Recent German Literature.*

In 1926 Parsons returned to America and became an instructor in economics and sociology, first at Amherst and then at Harvard, where he stayed until his death in 1979. In his earlier years he played an important role in making Weber (and other European classical sociologists) known to English-language audiences, partly by translating Max Weber's *The Protestant Ethic and the Sprit of Capitalism* (1930). Parsons moved to the new Department of Sociology at Harvard, created in 1931 with Pitirim A. Sorokin as its head. Parsons became Professor of Sociology there in 1938 and Chairman of the Department in 1942.

Beyond this, especially after World War-II, his academic standing grew rapidly, and it is no exaggeration to say that during the following two decades he became one of the dominant figures in postwar sociology in the United States. In 1946 he became the head of the new, multidisciplinary Harvard Department of Social Relations from which emanated an impressive list of publications during the next ten years, and in which "structural functionalism" was constructed and articulated. Most of Parsons' later work can be seen as elaborations, corrections, and reactions to criticism of his theoretical constructions from that period. In 1967, Parsons became the first social scientist to be elected as the president of the American Academy of Arts and Sciences.

From the late 1960s, however, Parsons witnessed the decline of structural functionalism, but he energetically continued his scholarship after retirement in 1973. He died of heart failure in 1979 in Germany, on a visit taking part in celebrations in Heidelberg of the fiftieth anniversary of his own doctoral degree.

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Parsons published a very large number of books and articles during his long career (over 160 published items). The most important are: *The Structure of Social Action* (1937), *The Social System* (1951) and *Toward a General Theory of Action* (1951), *Societies: Evolutionary and Comparative Perspectives* (1966) and *The System of Modern Societies* (1971).

Talcott Parsons was probably the most prominent theorist of his time, and it is unlikely that any one theoretical approach will so dominate sociological theory again. In the years between 1950 and the late 1970s, Parsonian functionalism was clearly the focal point around which theoretical controversy raged. Even those who despised Parsons' functional approach could not ignore it. Even now, years after his death and more than four decades since its period of dominance, Parsonian functionalism is still the subject of controversy.

Drawing initially on the work particularly of Max Weber and Emile Durkheim (he also read Karl Marx, Werner Sombart and Thorstein Veblen but regarded their approach as insufficiently 'scientific'), **Parsons spent his whole career trying to develop a general theory of social action and of the social system by means of which, and within the limits of which, social action takes place.** Parsons' approach can be described as 'synthesising' in the sense that he draws together into a single grand design what he regarded as the key insights of the leading European social theorists. Developing what became known as **general systems theory** his objective was to devise a theoretical framework for making sense of all aspects of human social action within a single explanatory framework. The grand design would, he hoped, provide a blueprint for a universal sociological understanding of social action. It is useful to think of Parsons' work not so much as a theory that tries to explain social action as such, but as a *theoretical schema* into which theoretical explanations can be fitted. It is a grand design *for* theory rather than just *of* theory.

The possibility of developing such a grand design obviously also meant having a conception of 'society' or 'the social system' as a single unified system. The different systems, structures and functions could be looked at separately, but essentially they never are separate because they all fit together into one overall system. In this conception the combined entity of the *total social system* must also be regarded as greater than the sum of its parts in the sense that social systems have 'emergent properties' that cannot be attributed to any individual component when looked at individually. Very much following Durkheim's strong conception of society as an entity that has a real existence which exceeds that of its individual components, the meaning and purpose of the individual parts is lost unless they are seen in the context of the larger system. The

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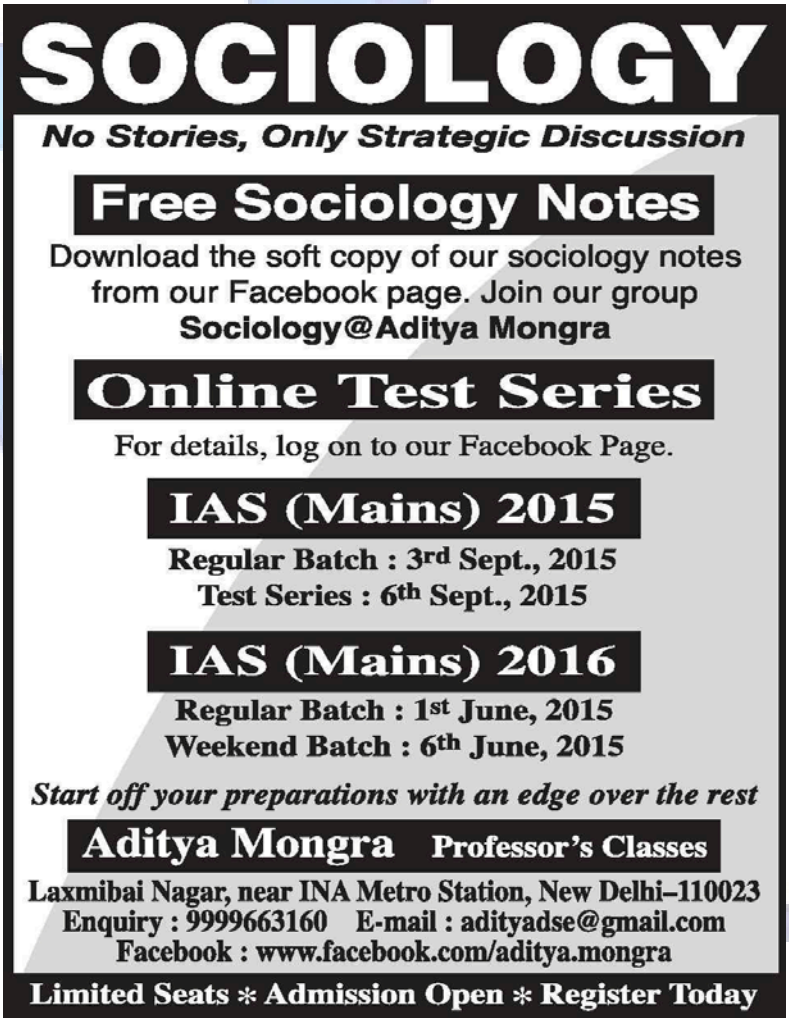
human liver, for example, is fascinating as piece of anatomical matter, but to really understand its significance it has to be seen in the context of the body it is part of.

[Dear Candidate, in simple words, a system refers to an orderly arrangement – an organization of interrelated and interdependent parts that form a unity. The term 'system' signifies patterned relationship among the constituent parts of any given structure, which is based on functional relations and which binds them into unity. 'System' is only a concept, it is not real. It is only an abstraction; it does not exist in reality. It is only a methodological tool that is used by sociologists to comprehend social reality. In sociology, the term 'social system' is primarily used as a conceptual tool to understand and comprehend the ever evolving social reality, in terms of the interconnectedness and interdependence of its various component parts. It is nothing but an analytical construct or model which is used by various sociologists in their sociological investigations. Although the origin of the systemic analysis of society could be traced back to Spencer's idea of *organic analogy* but it was in the works of Talcott Parsons that the concept of system was applied as a conceptual tool in a comprehensive way to analyze social life.]



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For Parsons, then, the unit of analysis of social theory is the total social system. Although the system, subsystems that it is made up of and the various functions they perform are massively complex, Parsons thought it was possible for social theorists to identify features that are found in all the systems of a particular society, and possibly of all forms of human society, and to describe some of the always-repeated characteristics of how functions are performed. For Parsons, the main effort of social theory should be directed towards perfecting our understanding of these systems, structures and functions. General systems theory provided theorists who were more interested in developing specific hypotheses about the nature of social action (sometimes referred to as 'middle-range' theory) with a higher-order theoretical map of the social system, thus giving empirical researchers a framework within which to make sense of their empirical data.

These assumptions of Parsons are also seen by some as a reaction against the then contemporary trend in American Sociology. American sociology of that period was dominated by the Chicago School which was pre-occupied with empirical research. Parsons considered this over-emphasis on empiricism by American sociologists as futile. According to him, empirical research tends to be barren unless guided by general theoretical framework. Parsons took upon himself the responsibility to provide a general theoretical structure for the whole of sociology which would serve also to integrate all the social sciences. Thus, in his own words, he wanted to build ecology of sociology.

To appreciate Parsonian achievement in bringing functionalism to the second half of the twentieth century, it is best to start at the beginning, in 1937, when he published his first major work, *The Structure of Social Action*.

The Structure of Social Action (1937)

The first exposition of Parsons' theoretical scheme for the analysis of social action is found in his more than 800-page book of 1937, *The Structure of Social Action*. The focus of this volume is a comprehensive scrutiny of the works of various social scientists, including utilitarians (classical economists) like Alfred Marshall (1842-1924), positivists like Durkheim and idealists like Weber. Critically analyzing these works, Parsons came to the conclusion that all their ideas represent only partial truths. Their works were like "the efforts of blind men to see the elephant", whereby each blind man came out with one-sided view of the elephant, not being able to describe the elephant in its totality. The book became the starting point for a new theoretical movement in American sociology.

Parsons starts with tracing the solution to *the problem of social order*, that is, how relatively ordered patterns of social actions are maintained in a society

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resulting in the overall social order. Parsons calls it 'the Hobbesian Problem of Order' as Thomas Hobbes (1588-1679), an English philosopher, was one of the first scholars to raise and address the problem of social and political order: how human beings can live together in peace and avoid the danger and fear of civil conflict. For Hobbes, all humans existed 'in a state of nature', by which he meant that they were dominated by their base instincts. Because basic human nature was essentially egoistic and self-centered, human relationships took the form of a 'war of all against all', of selfish and aggressive competition. Under these circumstances, Hobbes believed, 'the life of man' was likely to be 'solitary, poor, nasty, brutish and short'.

In order that social relations should not collapse into a state of total self-destruction, Hobbes developed the idea of a social contract, arguing that people are prepared to compromise a little by forfeiting some of their autonomy to a sovereign authority. Thus, the only solution for Hobbes was the force of a sovereign, installed through a contract, who by sword could compel people into obedience to law and order. This represents a coercive solution to the problem of social order. (However, critics saw this argument of Hobbes as an attempt to justify absolute monarchy.)

This type of solution Parsons considered flawed. Like Durkheim, he did not believe in sheer fear of punishment as sufficient to secure social order. Parsons' main objection was the perception of human action underlying the individualist theories, and especially the utilitarian model of human action (egoistic and self-centered). Typical of the utilitarian model is the perception that all action is rational in the sense of purposive (means-end) rational, taking for granted the ends which actors pursue. The problem of action is reduced to (1) choosing the most efficient strategies when (2) the end (goal) is given and (3) the situational conditions are known. Rationality simply refers to collecting data about situational conditions and causal laws in order to predict consequences of feasible action, and then calculating optimal action.

The defect in this model is defined under the label "the utilitarian dilemma." The dilemma, according to Parsons, emanates from the indeterminate status given to the *ends* in the utilitarian model of action.

'though the conception of action as consisting in the pursuit of ends is fundamental, there is nothing in the theory dealing with the relations of the ends to each other, but only with the character of the means-end relationship…..the failure to state anything positive about the relation of means and ends to each other can then have only one meaning – that there are no significant relations, that ends are random in the statistical sense.'

Talcott Parsons, *The Structure of Social Action* (1937)

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Parsons then proceeds to demonstrate that utilitarianism thus understood is unable to account for the existence of social order. In reviewing the thought of classical economists, Parsons noted the excessiveness of their utilitarianism: unregulated and atomistic actors in a free and competitive marketplace rationally attempting to choose those behaviors that will maximize their profits in their transactions with others. Parsons believed such a formulation of the social order presented several critical problems: Do humans always behave rationally? Are they indeed free and unregulated? How is order possible in an unregulated and competitive system? Here Parsons criticizes the classical economic theory for making overly simplified assumptions about the nature of the man. Classical economic theory treats man as a purely rational being, ignoring thus, the non-rational aspects of human behavior. Secondly, it also ignores the fact that economic activities of man are essentially embodied in a wider socio-political and cultural context. Thus a purely economic theory could never achieve the status of a general theory, not even of economic behavior because it left out non-economic (sociological) factors which also need to be taken into account.

Yet, Parsons saw as fruitful several features of utilitarian thought, especially the concern with actors as seeking goals and the emphasis on the choice-making capacities of human beings who weigh alternative lines of action. Stated in this minimal form, Parsons felt that the utilitarian heritage could indeed continue to inform sociological theorizing.

In a similar critical stance, Parsons rejected the extreme formulations of radical positivists, who tended to view the social world as observable cause-and-effect relationships among physical phenomena. In so doing, he felt, they ignored the complex symbolic functioning of the human mind. According to Parsons, the positivist tradition, in its attempt to mould sociology on the pattern of natural sciences has ignored the fact that man is essentially an active, creative and evaluating creature. While trying to objectify the study of human behavior, positivism ignores the subjective dimension of the social action. Thus, Parson argues that positivist theories leave no room for such notions as mind, consciousness, motives, values, etc. Parsons strongly asserts that a comprehensive sociological theory must necessarily be a 'voluntaristic theory', that is, it should also take into account the role played by subjective factors like meaning, motives, values etc., in guiding social action.

Finally, in assessing idealism, Parsons saw as useful the conceptions of "ideas" that circumscribe both individual and social processes although all too frequently these ideas are seen as detached from the ongoing social life they were supposed to regulate. Parsons wanted to avoid the idealist pitfalls of the hermeneutic, Neo-Kantian tradition of Rickert and Dilthey, which were also visible

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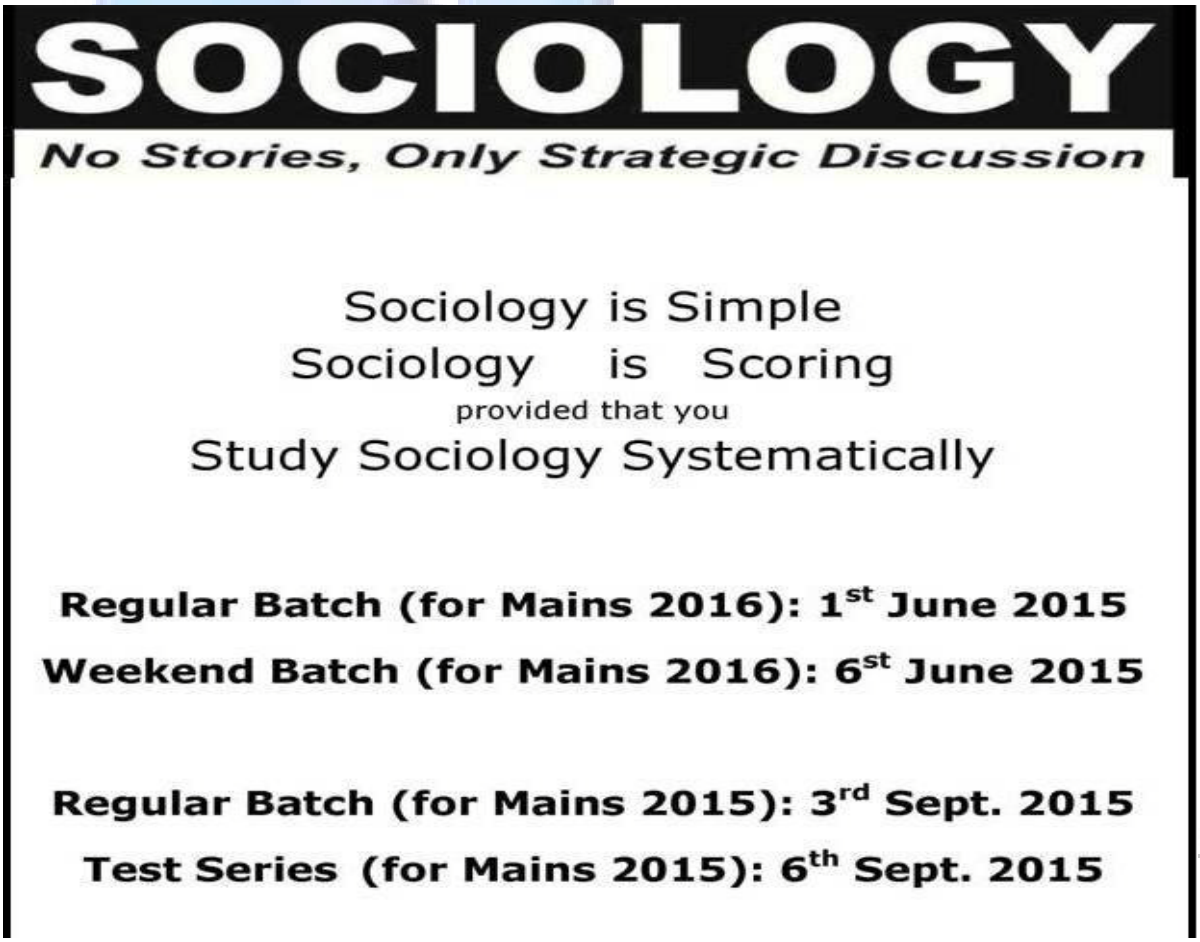
in the work of Max Weber, George Simmel and others. Here he found a tendency toward allowing material situational conditions to disappear so that actions and their products could be understood as the "externalization of spirit," that is, actions, norms, social institutions, and cultural product are seen as external, objectified products of ideas, intentions, and other subjective factors.

In other words, idealists have been concerned with the human qualities of action like meanings, motives, values, etc. Parsons did appreciate this. Nevertheless, he also saw serious defects in the way these elements have been treated by the idealists. According to him, they tended to explain or interpret each society in terms of its own unique spirit. They have not formulated general theories or laws which would apply to all societies. According to Parsons, a sociological theory while taking into account the subjective dimensions should also be a general theory permitting systematic comparison of all societies and the development of general laws about them.

Thus, the explanatory problem that Parsons confronted was how to explain the existence of relatively ordered patterns of social actions and recurring social institutions from individualistic premises, implying that people independently choose what they want to do.



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Thus, having reviewed the theories of utilitarianism, positivism and idealism, Parsons arrived at certain basic orientations on sociological theory. Parsons' basic orientations toward sociological theory can be summarized in terms of three guiding principles which are as follows:

Firstly, a sociological theory should adequately be a '*general theory*' which could be applied to different societies.

Secondly, a sociological theory must be a '*voluntaristic theory of action*', implying that it should take into account goals, values, normative standards and action choices which actors make on the basis of alternative values and goals.

Thirdly, a sociological theory must take into account the 'principle of emergence'. For Parsons, this means that at various levels of organizational complexity, systems emerge with properties which cannot be explained merely in terms of the way their component parts operate. In simpler words, it means that social interaction among individuals in a society give rise to a new level of reality, that is, social reality. Parsons had developed a systemic view of social reality, that, '*social reality must be viewed as a system*'. By this he implies that social reality or society must be seen as an 'integrated whole' made up of various parts (institutions) existing in a mutual interrelationship with each other. Following Durkheim (his concept of *conscience collective*), Parsons argues that this systemic reality, being a distinct level of reality, cannot be adequately explained or understood by reducing it to its component parts.

Thus, Parsons found the solution to the 'problem of social order' in his 'voluntaristic theory of action'. The guiding principle here, clearly influenced by the teachings of Max Weber and his method of *Verstehen*, was the idea that sociology should be the study of (subjectively) *meaningful social action*. It had to be built upon a *voluntaristic* perception of social action, that is, the assumption that action is the result of what people voluntarily choose to do. Please read the next section very carefully.

As stated earlier, the explanatory problem that Parsons confronted was how to explain the social stability and order in a society or 'a social system'. We also now know that Parsons was driven by the ambition of developing a 'general systems theory,' or, in other words, to account for social stability and order at a macro level, *systemic level*. (Please note that by social system, here, Parsons implies a plurality of patterns of interactions in society.) However, before he did that, he argued that the conception of social system begins at the micro level with *interaction between ego and alter ego*. This could be understood as the most elementary form of the social system.

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Parsons, in his book, *The Structure of Social Action*, begins with a basic assumption that **social action is the basic unit of social life**. He defines social action as 'the meaningful response of the actor (an individual) to the external stimuli.'

Thus, in his first step, he proceeds to specify that the basic building block of all social action is '*the unit act*', i.e., a single social action.

Please note that a 'single social act' does not exist in social reality. Each action is a response to some previous action (*stimuli*) and, in turn, gives rise to a further action. So what exists in reality is a chain of interconnected actions – social interactions. It is, however, used by Parsons to facilitate our understanding of his major theoretical assumptions.

The *unit act*, according to Parsons, consists of the following elements:

- **The actor:** (actor, who at this point in Parsons' thinking, is an individual person. To be an actor means 'being-in-a-situation'. However, in his later works, 'actor' may be understood as any *agency* that is involved in attributing meaning to a given situation. This agency, then, could either be an individual, group or any form of collectivity.)
- **An end (or goal):** (a future state of affairs toward which the process of action is oriented. In other words, actor is viewed as goal seeking.)
- **The situation:** This is divided into two.
    i. **The <u>conditions</u> of action** (these are the factors that cannot be altered by the actor, such as his own biological makeup and heredity as well as various external ecological constraints, that influence the selection of goals and means);
    ii. **The <u>means</u> of action** (these are the factors that the actor can control, such as the resources and technique at his disposal)

    (In simple words, whatever the actor gives meanings to, at a given point of time, becomes the situation. Further, any given situation may have three kinds of components

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viz. physical, social and cultural objects. Physical objects imply the physical environment, social objects may be understood as the 'other' actors with whom the actor enters into certain relationship, or to whom the actor's action is oriented. Cultural objects include shared norms, values, ideas, symbols, etc. in a given society.)

- **Norms:** (actors are governed by norms, values, and other ideas such that these ideas influence what is considered a goal and what means are selected to achieve it. In other words, the business of acting to achieve a purpose by responding to environmental conditions has to be done in a way that conforms to the prevailing norms of that society. There has to be what he calls '*a normative orientation to action*' in the sense that when making choices over how to act, and assuming that alternatives are available, the making of choices is guided by social norms. (Please note that this view of Parsons tends to legitimize and maintain the status quo, for which he was criticized later.)

So, this is what constitutes, according to Parsons, the structure of social action i.e., the structure of a single *unit act*.

Parsons further argues that action involves actors making subjective decisions about the means to achieve goals, all of which are constrained by ideas and situational conditions. In this initial formulation, he conceptualized voluntarism as the subjective decisions-making processes of individual actors, but he viewed such decisions as the partial outcome of certain kinds of constraints, both normative and situational. [In other words, all of the elements have to take place in a knowledgeable or informed way so that the action-choices social actors make can be regarded, not as passive and random responses, but as consciously made rational choices. Part of what makes a choice of action rational is whether or not it conforms to the social norms of that society. If a social actor is unable to make rational and informed choices they are likely to be categorized by others as irrational or possibly as mad.]

Confused? Let me simplify this.

As we know that for Parsons, social action is the meaningful response of the actor to the external stimuli in a given situation. An actor is goal seeking. **Important:** However, he further argues that both, the goals as well as means employed to achieve them by the actor, are guided by the normative orientation,

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i.e., they are largely prescribed by the culture. So, it is within the realm of the culturally prescribed goals and means that the actor exercises his volition.

In other words, what Parsons is implying here is that it is through culture (cultural knowledge) that the actor interprets the situation, finds meaning in it or assigns meanings to it. So, meanings are culturally shaped. Hence, what goals to pursue and what means to be chosen for their achievement, are largely prescribed by the normative charter (culture) of the society. Culture offers a range of choice within which the actor exercises his volition, which is expressed in his choice of action, in order to attain the goal.

'Action must be thought of as involving a state of tension between two different orders of elements, the normative and the conditional. As process, action is, in fact, the process of alteration of the conditional elements in the direction of conformity of norms.'

Talcott Parsons, *The Structure of Social Action* (1937)

(Dear Candidate, please read this quote very carefully. This holds the essence of the Parsons' *voluntaristic theory of action*. The figure below represents this conceptualization of voluntarism.)

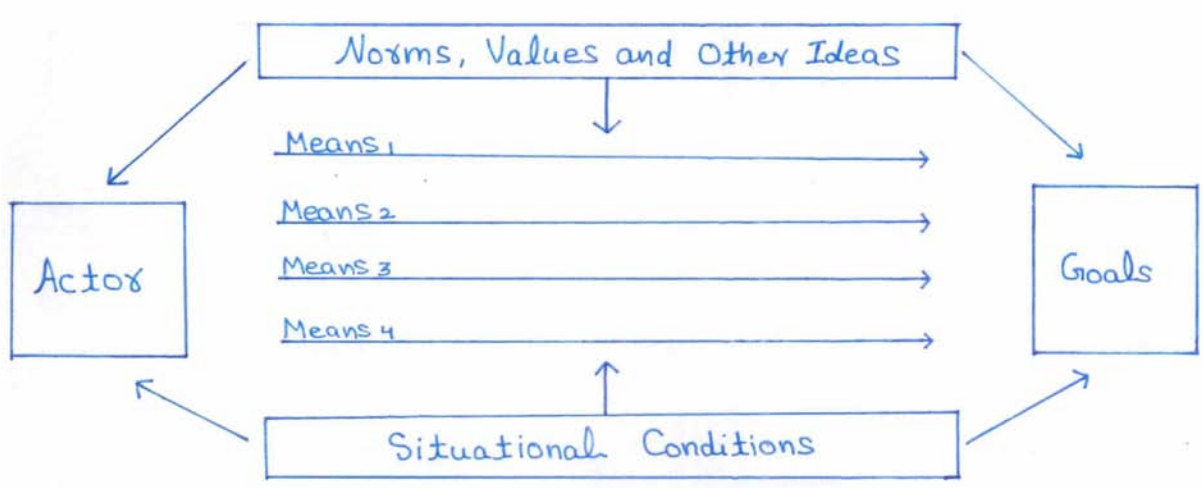

Figure: The Units of Voluntaristic Action

Parsons refers to his approach as an '*action frame of reference*' as he is keen to specify that he is developing a theoretical framework not only for making objective assessments of social action in the manner of a positivist (observing the mechanical actions of a cyclist), but also to include the subjective or voluntaristic dimension of action as well (why cyclists cycle). He regards social actors as conscious, knowledgeable and intentional. This is why he makes a sharp distinction between sociology and psychology, and especially behaviour

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psychology, which had become very popular in America at this time. As soon as social actors are recognized as acting in accordance with value-laden social norms, human action cannot be adequately explained in terms of psychological or biological causes alone.

In terms of the concepts used by classical social theorists discussed in the previous sections, the first three constituents of the unit act (agents, ends and conditions) correspond with a fairly straight forward positivistic and utilitarian conception of action in which social action is explained in terms of the ends actors seek and the means they employ to achieve them. It is by introducing the fourth element, the key idea that all of this takes place in the context of, or is oriented in terms of, identifiable systems of norms and values, that Parsons really moves social theory forwards. Metaphorically speaking, if classical social theory (Marx, Weber, Durkheim) provides the basic spokes of a theory for describing social action in terms of a series of means-ends relationships, Parsons adds the rim of the wheel by asking what the relationship is between these various 'ends'. As far as Parsons is concerned, patterns of norms and values are the means by which the different spokes of social action are combined into something that really can rock and roll.

Dear Candidate, please note here that Parsons is combining the Weberian notion of the subjective (voluntary) aspect of social action with the Durkheimian notion of the objective contexts of action in society. From the Weberian side, social actors do act in a rationalistic means-ends kind of way and make knowledgeable choices in order to fulfill various goals and objectives. Often these goals and choices are to do with the ideas, values and beliefs they hold. From the Durkheimian side Parsons takes the idea that social actors cannot act in an entirely free way, because the resources at their disposal, and the rules and conventions that they have to follow if their actions are to be effective, are, to a greater or lesser extent, regulated by society.

If we take the example of language, there is nothing to prevent a social actor from making whatever vocal sounds they like. If, however, they want others to understand these sounds, they need to accept the rules and convention of the language system around them. Making linguistic sense to others means accepting the limits of their language code. The language code does not belong to any particular social actor, but to society (for Durkheim the rules of language are a social fact). Human action can be regarded as free in the modified sense that once social actors *have accepted* the limitations imposed by the rules and norms of society, they can express themselves in any way they like up to those limitations.

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Please note that the introduction of 'norms' constitutes a radically new element in Parsons' theory when compared to the utilitarian theory. It is their role in specifying and reconciling the ends of individual actors, and integrating them with the ends of other actors which provides the solution to the problem of order. Normative orientation, including norms, values, beliefs, etc., is supposed to guide and limit the choice of ends, as well as means, in the course of action. As Parsons describes, 'normative orientation is the *motor* of social action'.

The processes diagrammed above are often termed the *unit act*, with social action involving a succession of such unit acts by one or more actors. As stated earlier, a single social act does not exist in isolation. Each action is a response to some previous action and, in turn, gives rise to a further action. So what exists in reality is a chain of interconnected actions – social interactions. Please keep in mind that, it is this plurality of patterned interactions that Parsons calls social system. This will also help you to understand the shift in Parsonian works from the study of structure of social action to the analysis of action systems.

[*After the Second World War, Parsons sought to construct a rigorous sociological theory by, in particular, analyzing the systematic properties of societies that allow them to maintain and reproduce themselves. Commentators are divided over the extent to which this shift in focus represents a conceptual break with Parsons' earlier writings, which follow Weber and Neo-Kantian tradition in stressing the 'voluntaristic' character of human action.*]

[Please note that though in *The Structure of Social Action* Parsons lays great stress on Weber's contribution to the development of the voluntaristic theory of action, (but as the later developments and shifts in his theory suggests) his approach to social theory seems in fact much closer to Durkheim's. Indeed he declared in 1967: 'My own inclination is to refer above all to Durkheim (*The Division of Labour in Society*, especially) as the fountainhead of the primary fruitful trend.']

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Marx: Class, Class Struggle and Social Change

Let us now try to understand this in simpler terms. Marxian theory begins with the simple observation that in order to survive, man must produce food and material objects. In doing so he enters into social relationships with other men. From the simple hunting band to the complex industrial state, production is a social enterprise. Production also involves a technical component known as the **forces of production** which includes the technology, raw materials and scientific knowledge employed in the process of production. Each major stage in the development of forces of production will correspond with a particular form of the **social relationships of production**. Thus the forces of production in a hunting economy will correspond with a particular set of social relationships. Taken together, the forces of production and the social relationships of production form the economic base or infrastructure of society (**mode of production**). The other aspects of society, known as the superstructure, are largely shaped by the infrastructure. Thus the political, legal and educational institutions and the belief and value system are primarily determined by economic factors. A major change in the infrastructure will therefore produce a corresponding change in the superstructure. Marx maintained that, with the possible exception of the societies of prehistory, all historical societies contain basic contradictions which mean that they cannot survive forever in their existing form. These contradictions involve the exploitation of one social group by another, for example in feudal society, lords exploit their serfs, in capitalist society, employers exploit their employees. This creates a fundamental conflict of interest between social groups since one gains at the expense of another. This conflict of interest must ultimately be resolved since a social system containing such contradictions cannot survive unchanged.

Thus, according to Marx, the major contradictions in society are between the forces and relations of production. The **forces of production** include land, raw materials, tools and machinery, the technical and scientific knowledge used in production, the technical organization of the production process and the labor power of the workers. The **relations of production** are the social relationships which men enter into in order to produce goods. Thus in feudal society they included the relationship between the lord and vassal and the set of right, duties and obligations which make up that relationship. In capitalist industrial society they included the relationship between employer and employee and the various rights of the two parties. The relations of production involve the relationship of social groups to the forces of production. Thus in feudal society, land, the major

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force of production, is owned by the lord whereas the serf has the right to use land in return for services or payment to the lord. In Western industrial society the forces of production are owned by the capitalist whereas the worker owns only his labor which he hires to the employer in return for wages.

The idea of contradiction between the forces and relations of production may be illustrated in terms of the infrastructure of the capitalist industrial society. Marx maintained that only labour produces wealth. Thus wealth in capitalist society is produced by the labour power of the workers. However, much of this wealth is appropriated in the form profits by the capitalists, the owners of the forces of production. The wages of the workers are well below the value of the wealth they produce. There is thus a contradiction between the forces of production, in particular the labour power of the workers which produce wealth, and the relations of production which involve the appropriation of much of that wealth by the capitalists. A related contradiction involves the technical organization of labour and the nature of ownership. In capitalist society, the forces of production include the collective production of goods by large numbers of workers in factories. Yet the forces of production are privately owned, the profits are appropriated by individuals. The contradiction between the forces and relations of production lies in the social and collective nature of production and the private and individual nature of ownership. Marx believed that these and other contradictions would eventually lead to the downfall of the capitalist system. He maintained that by its very nature, capitalism involves the exploitation and oppression of the worker. He believed that the conflict of interest between capital and labour, which involves one group gaining at the expense of the other, could not be resolved within the framework of a capitalist economy.

Marx saw history as divided into a number of time periods, each being characterized by a particular mode of production. Marx believed that Western society had developed through four main epochs: primitive communism, ancient society, feudal society and capitalist society. Major changes in history are the result of new forces of production. For example, the change from feudal to capitalist society stemmed from the emergence, during the feudal epoch, of the forces of production of industrial society. This resulted in a contradiction between the new forces of production and the old feudal relations of productions. Capitalist industrial society required relations of production based on wage labour, rather than the traditional ties of lord and vassal. When they reach a certain point in their development, the new forces of production lead to the creation of a new set of

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relations of production. Then, a new epoch of history is born which sweeps away the social relationships of the old order. However, the final epoch of history, the **communist** or **socialist society** which Marx believe would eventually supplant capitalism, will not result from a new force of production. Rather, it will develop from a resolution of the contradictions contained within the capitalist system. Collective production will remain but the relations of production will be transformed. Ownership of the forces of production will be collective rather than individual and members of society will share the wealth that their labour produces. No longer will one social group exploit and oppress another. This will produce an infrastructure without contradiction and conflict. In Marx's view this would mean the end of history since communist society would no longer contain the contradictions which generate change.

Note: In view of the contradictions which beset historical societies, it appears difficult to explain their survival. Despite its internal contradictions, capitalism has continued in the West for over 200 years. This continuity can be explained in large part by the nature of the superstructure. In all societies the superstructure is largely shaped by the infrastructure. In particular, the relations of productions are reflected and reproduced in the various institutions, values and beliefs that make up the superstructure. Thus the relationships of domination and subordination found in the infrastructure will also be found in social institutions. In Marx's words, 'The existing relations of production between individuals must necessarily express themselves also as political and legal relations'. The dominant social group or ruling class, that is the group which owns and controls the forces of production, will largely monopolize political power and its position will be supported by laws which are framed to protect and further its interests. In the same way, beliefs and values will reflect and legitimate the relations of productions. Members of the ruling class 'rule also as thinkers, as producers of ideas'. These ideas justify their power and privilege and conceal from all members of society the basis of exploitation and oppression on which their dominance rests. Thus under feudalism honour and loyalty were 'dominant concepts' of the age. Vassals owed loyalty to their lords and were bound by an oath of allegiance which encouraged the acceptance of their status. In terms of the dominant concept of the age, feudalism appeared as the natural order of things. Under Capitalism, exploitation is disguised by the ideas of equality and freedom. The relationship between capitalist and wage laborer is defined as an equal exchange. The capitalist buy the labour power which the worker offers for hire. The worker is defined as a free agent since he has the

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freedom to choose his employer. In reality, equality and freedom are illusions. The employer-employee relationship is not equal. It is an exploitive relationship. The worker is not free since he is forced to work for the capitalist in order to survive. All he can do is exchange one form of 'wage slavery' for another. Marx refers to the dominant ideas of each epoch as '**ruling class ideology**'. Such ideology is a distortion of reality, a false picture of society. It blinds members of society to the contradictions and conflict of interest which are built into their relationships. As a result they tend to accept their situation as normal and natural, right and proper. In this way a 'false consciousness' of reality is produced which helps to maintain the system. However, Marx believed that ruling class ideology could only slow down the disintegration of the system. The contradictions embedded in the structure of society must eventually find expression.

In summary, the key to understanding society from a Marxian perspective involves an analysis of the infrastructure. In all historical societies there are basic contradictions between the forces and relations of production and there are fundamental conflicts of interest between the social groups involved in the production process. In particular, the relationship between the major social groups is one of exploitation and oppression. The superstructure derives largely from the infrastructure and therefore reproduces the social relationships of production. It will thus reflect the interests of the dominate group in the relations of production. Ruling class ideology distorts the true nature of society and serves to legitimate and justify the status quo. However the contradictions in the infrastructure will eventually lead to a disintegration of the system and the creation of a new society.

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According to Karl Marx, in all stratified societies, there are two major social groups; a **ruling class** and a **subject class**. The power of the ruling class derives from its ownership and control of the forces of production. The ruling class exploits and oppresses the subject class. As a result, there is a basic conflict of interest between the two classes. The various institutions of society such as the legal and political systems are instruments of ruling class domination and serve to further its interests. Only when the forces of production are communally owned will classes disappear, thereby bringing an end to the exploitation and oppression of some by others.

From a Marxian perspective, systems of stratification derive from the relationships of social groups to the forces of production. Marx used the term **class** to refer to the main strata in all stratification systems, though most modern sociologists would reserve the term for strata in capitalist society. **From a Marxian view, a class is a social group whose members share the same relationship to the forces of production.** Thus during the feudal epoch, there are two main classes distinguished by their relationship to land, the major force of production. They are the feudal nobility who own the land and the landless serfs who work the land. Similarly, in the capitalist era, there are two main classes, the bourgeoisie or capitalist class which owns the forces of production and the proletariat or working class whose members own only their labour which they hire to the bourgeoisie in return for wages.

Marx believed that Western society had developed through four main epochs; **primitive communism**, **ancient society**, **feudal society** and **capitalist society**. Primitive communism is represented by the societies of prehistory and provides the only example of a classless society. From then on, all societies are divided into two major classes: masters and slaves in ancient society, lords and serfs in feudal society and capitalists and wage labourers in capitalist society. During each historical epoch, the labour power required for production was supplied by the subject class, that is by slaves, serfs and wage labourers respectively. The subject class is made up of the majority of the population whereas the ruling or dominant class forms a minority. The relationship between the two major classes will be discussed shortly.

Classes did not exist during the era of primitive communism when societies were based on a socialist mode of production. In hunting and gathering band, the earliest form of human society, the land and its products were communally owned.

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The men hunted and the woman gathered plant food, and the produce was shared by members of the band. Classes did not exist since all members of society shared the same relationship to the forces of production. Every member was both producer and owner, all provided labour power and shared the products of their labour. Hunting and gathering is a subsistence economy which means that production only meets basic survival needs.

Classes emerge when the productive capacity of society expands beyond the level required for subsistence. This occurs when agriculture becomes the dominant mode of production. In an agricultural economy, only a section of society is needed to produce the food requirements of the whole society. Thus many individuals are freed from food production and are able to specialize in other tasks. The rudimentary **division of labour** of the hunting and gathering band was replaced by an increasingly more complex and specialized division. For example, in the early agricultural villages, some individuals became full-time producers of pottery, clothing and agricultural implements. As agriculture developed, surplus wealth, that is goods above the basic subsistence needs of the community, was produced. This led to an exchange of goods and trading developed rapidly both within and between communities. This was accompanied by the development of a system of **private property**. Goods were increasingly seen as commodities or articles of trade to which the individual rather than the community had right of ownership. **Private property and the accumulation of surplus wealth form the basis for the development of class societies**. **In particular, they provide the preconditions for the emergence of a class of producers and a class of non-producers**. Some are able to acquire the forces of production and others are therefore obliged to work for them. The result is a class of non-producers which owns the forces of production and a class of producers which owns only its labour power.

From a Marxian perspective, the relationship between the major social classes is one of mutual dependence and conflict. Thus in capitalist society, the bourgeoisie and proletariat are dependent upon each other. The wage labourer must sell his labour power in order to survive since he does not own a part of the forces of production and lacks the means to produce goods independently. He is therefore dependent for his livelihood on the capitalists and the wages they offer. The capitalists, as non-producers, are dependent on the labour power of the wage labourers, since without it, there would be no production. However, the mutual dependency of the two classes is not a relationship of equal or symmetrical

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reciprocity. Instead, it is a relationship of exploiter and exploited, oppressor and oppressed. In particular, the ruling class gains at the expense of the subject class and there is therefore a conflict of interest between them. This may be illustrated by Marx's view of the nature of ownership and production in capitalist society.

The basic characteristics of a capitalist economy may be summarized as follows. **Capital** may be defined as money used to finance the production, of commodities for private gain. In a capitalist economy goods, and the labour power, raw materials and machinery used to produce them, are given a monetary value. The capitalist invests his capital in the production of goods. Capital is accumulated by selling those goods at a value greater than their cost of production. **Capitalism therefore involves the investment of capital in the production of commodities with the aim of maximizing profit**. Capital is privately owned by a minority, the capitalist class. However, in Marx's view, it is gained from the exploitation of the mass of the population, the working class. Marx argued that capital, as such, produces nothing. Only labour produces wealth. Yet the wages paid to the workers for their labour are well below the value of the goods they produce. The difference between the value of wages and commodities is known as '**surplus value**'. This surplus value is appropriated in the form of profit by the capitalists. Since they are non-producers, the bourgeoisie are therefore exploiting the proletariat, the real producers of wealth. Marx maintained that in all class societies, the ruling class exploits and oppresses the subject class.

In simpler words, Marx argues that class divisions result from the differing relationships of members of society to the forces of production. The structure of all societies may be represented in terms of a simplified two class model consisting of ruling and subject class. The ruling class owes its dominance and power to its ownership and control of the forces of production. The subjection and relative powerlessness of the subject class is due to its lack of ownership and therefore lack of control of the forces of production. The conflict of interest between the two classes stems from the fact that productive labour is performed by the subject class yet a large part of the wealth so produced is appropriated by the ruling class. Since one class gains at the expense of another, the interests of their members are incompatible. The classes stand opposed as exploiter and exploited, oppressor and oppressed.

The labour of the subject class takes on the character of 'forced labour'. Since its members lack the necessary means to produce for themselves they are

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forced to work for others. Thus during the feudal era, landless serfs were forced to work for the landowning nobility in order to gain a livelihood. In the capitalist era, the means necessary to produce goods – tools, machinery, raw materials and so on – are owned by the capitalist class. In order to exist, members of the proletariat are forced to sell their labour power in return for wages. Ownership of the forces of production therefore provides the basis for ruling class dominance and control of labour.

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From a Marxian perspective political power derives from economic power. The power of the ruling class therefore stems from its ownership and control of the forces of production. Since the superstructure of society – the major institutions, values and belief systems – is seen to be largely shaped by the economic infrastructure, the relations of production will be reproduced in the superstructure. Thus the dominance of the ruling class in the relations of production will be reflected in the superstructure. In particular, the political and legal systems will reflect ruling class interests since, in Marx's words, 'The existing relations of production between individuals must necessarily express themselves also as political and legal relations'. For example, the various ownership rights of the capitalist class will be enshrined in and protected by the laws of the land. Thus the various parts of the superstructure can be seen as instruments of ruling class domination and as mechanisms for the oppression of the subject class. In the same way, the position of the dominant class is supported by beliefs and values which are systematically generated by the infrastructure. Marx refers to the dominant concepts of class societies as **ruling class ideology** since they justify and legitimate ruling class domination and project a distorted picture of reality. For example, the emphasis on freedom in capitalist society, illustrated by phrases such as 'the free market', 'free democratic societies' and the free world', is an illusion which disguises the wage slavery of the proletariat. Ruling class ideology produces '**false class consciousness**', a false picture of the nature of the relationship between social classes. Members of both classes tend to accept the status quo as normal and natural and are largely unaware of the true nature of exploitation and oppression. In other words, members of both social classes are largely unaware of the true nature of their situation, of the reality of the relationship between ruling and subject classes. Members of the ruling class assume that their particular interests are those of society as a whole, members of the subject class accept this view of reality and regard their situation as a part of the natural order of things. This false consciousness is due to the fact that the relationships of dominance and subordination in the economic infrastructure are largely reproduced in the superstructure of society. In Marx's words, the relations of production constitute 'the real foundation on which rise legal and political superstructures and to which correspond definite forms of social consciousness. The mode of production in material life determines the general character of the social, political and spiritual processes of life'. Ruling class dominance is confirmed and legitimated in legal statues, religious proscriptions and political legislation. The consciousness of all members of society is infused with ruling

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class ideology which proclaims the essential rightness, normality and inevitability of the status quo. In this way the conflict of interest between the classes is disguised and a degree of social stability produced but the basic contradictions and conflicts of class societies remain unresolved.

Marx believed that the class struggle was the driving force of social change. He states that, '**The history of all societies up to the present is the history of the class struggle**'. A new historical epoch is created by the development of superior forces of production by new social group. These developments take place within the framework of the previous era. For example, the merchants and industrialists who spearheaded the rise of capitalism emerged during the feudal era. They accumulated capital, laid the foundations for industrial manufacturers, factory production and the system of wage labour, all of which were essential components of capitalism. The superiority of the capitalist mode of production led to a rapid transformation of the structure of society. The capitalist class became dominant, and although the feudal aristocracy maintained aspects of its power well into the nineteenth century, it was fighting a losing battle.

The class struggles of history have been between minorities. For example, capitalism developed from the struggle between the feudal aristocracy and the emerging capitalist class, both groups in numerical terms forming a minority of the population. Major changes in history have involved the replacement of one form of private property by another and of one type of production technique by another. For example, capitalism involved the replacement of privately owned land and an agricultural economy by privately owned capital and an industrial economy. Marx believed that the class struggle which would transform capitalist society would involve none of these processes. The protagonists would be the bourgeoisie and the proletariat, a minority versus a majority. Private property would be replaced by communally owned property. Industrial manufacture would remain as the basic technique of production in the society which would replace capitalism.

Marx believed that the basic contradictions contained in a capitalist economic system would lead to its eventual destruction. The proletariat would overthrow the bourgeoisie and seize the forces of production, the source of power. Property would be communally owned and, since all members of society would now share the same relationship to the forces of production, a classless society would result. Since history is the history of the class struggle, history would now end. The communist society which replaces capitalism will contain no

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contradictions, no conflicts of interest and therefore be unchanging. However, before the dawning of this utopia, certain changes must occur.

Marx distinguished between a **'class in itself'** and a **'class for itself'**. **A class in itself is simply a social group whose members share the same relationship to the forces of production.** Marx argues that a social group only fully becomes a class when it becomes a class for itself. At this stage its members have class consciousness and class solidarity. Class consciousness means that false class consciousness has been replaced by a full awareness of the true situation, by a realization of the nature of exploitation. Members of a class develop a common identity, recognize their shared interests and unite, so producing class solidarity. The final stage of class consciousness and class solidarity is reached when members realize that only by collective action can they overthrow the ruling class and when they take positive steps to do so.

Marx believed that the following aspects of capitalist society would eventually lead to the proletariat developing into a class for itself. Firstly capitalist society is by its very nature unstable. It is based on contradictions and antagonisms which can be resolved by its transformation. In particular, the conflict of interest between the bourgeoisie and proletariat cannot be resolved within the framework of a capitalist economy. The basic conflict of interest involves the exploitation of workers by the capitalists. Marx believed that this contradiction would be highlighted by a second, the contradiction between social production and individual ownership. As capitalism developed, the workforce was increasingly concentrated in the large factories where production was a social enterprise. Social production juxtaposed with individual ownership illuminates the exploitation of the proletariat. Social production also makes it easier for workers to organize themselves against the capitalists. It facilitates communication and encourages recognition of common circumstances and interest.

Apart from the basic contradictions of capitalist society, Marx believed that certain factors in the natural development of a capitalist economy will hasten its downfall. These factors will result in the polarization of the two main classes. Firstly the increasing use of machinery will result in a **homogeneous working class**. Since 'machinery obliterates the differences in labour' members of the proletariat will become increasingly similar. The differences between skilled, semi-skilled and unskilled workers will tend to disappear as machines remove the skill required in the production of commodities. Secondly, the difference in wealth

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between the bourgeoisie and the proletariat will increase as the accumulation of capital proceeds. Even though the real wages and living standards of the proletariat may rise, its members will become poorer in relation to the bourgeoisie. This process is known as **pauperization**. Thirdly, the competitive nature of capitalism means that only the largest and most wealthy companies will survive and prosper. Competition will depress the immediate strata, those groups lying between the two main classes, into the proletariat. Thus the 'petty bourgeoisie', the owners of small businesses, will 'sink into the proletariat'. At the same time the surviving companies will grow larger and capital will be concentrated into fewer hands. These three processes - the obliteration of the differences in labour, the pauperization of the working class and the depression of the intermediate strata into the proletariat - will result in the **polarization** of the two major classes. Marx believed he could observe the process of polarization in nineteenth-century Britain when he wrote, 'Society as a whole is more and more splitting into two great hostile camps..... bourgeoisie and proletariat'. Now the battle lines were clearly drawn, Marx hoped that the proletarian revolution would shortly follow and the communist utopia of his dreams would finally become a reality.

Marx argued that while the superstructure may stabilize society and contain its contradictions over long periods of time, this situation cannot be permanent. The fundamental contradictions of class societies will eventually find expression and will finally be resolved by the dialectic of historical change. A radical change in the structure of society occurs when a class is transformed from a 'class in itself' to a 'class for itself'. A class in itself refers to members of society who share the same objective relationships to the forces of production. Thus, as wage labourers, members of the proletariat form a class in itself. However, a class only becomes a class for itself when its members are fully conscious of the true nature of their situation, when they are fully aware of their common interests and common enemy, when they realize that only by concerted action can they overthrow their oppressors, and when they unite and take positive, practical steps to do so. When a class becomes a class for itself, the contradiction between the consciousness of its members and the reality of their situation is ended.

A class becomes a class for itself when the forces of production have developed to the point where they cannot be contained within the exiting relations of production. In Marx's words, 'For an oppressed class to be able to emancipate itself, it is essential that the existing forces of production and the existing social relations should be incapable of standing side by side'. Revolutionary change

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requires that the forces of production on which the new order will be based have developed in the old society. Therefore the 'new higher relations of production never appear before the material conditions of their existence have matured in the womb of the old society'. This process may be illustrated by the transition from feudal to capitalist society. Industrial capitalism gradually developed within the framework of feudal society. In order to develop fully, it required, 'the free wage labourer who sells his labour-power to capital'. This provides a mobile labour force which can be hired and fired at will and so efficiently utilized as a commodity in the service of capital. However, the feudal relations of production, which involved 'landed property with serf labour chained to it', tended to prevent the development of wage labourers. Eventually the forces of production of capitalism gained sufficient strength and impetus to lead to the destruction of the feudal system. At this point the rising class, the bourgeoisie, became a class for itself and its members united to overthrow the feudal relations of production. When they succeeded the contradiction between the new forces of production and the old relations of production was resolved.

Marx further argued that once a new economic order is established, the superstructure of the previous era is rapidly transformed. The contradiction between the new infrastructure and the old superstructure is now ended. Thus the political dominance of the feudal aristocracy was replaced by the power to the newly enfranchised bourgeoisie. The dominant concepts of feudalism such as loyalty and honour were replaced by the new concepts of freedom and equality. In terms of the new ideology the wage labourer of capitalist society is free to sell his labour power to the highest bidder. The relationship between employer and employee is defined as a relationship between equals, the exchange of labour for wages as an exchange of equivalents. But the resolution of old contradictions does not necessarily mean an end to contradictions in society. As in previous eras, the transition from feudalism to capitalism merely results in the replacement of an old set of contradictions by a new.

The predicted rise of the proletariat is not strictly analogous with the rise of the bourgeoisie. The bourgeoisie formed a privileged minority of industrialists, merchants and financiers who forged new forces of production within feudal society. The proletariat forms an unprivileged majority which does not create new forces of production within capitalist society. Marx believed, however, that the contradictions of capitalism were sufficient to transform the proletariat into a class for itself and bring about the downfall of the bourgeoisie. He saw the magnitude of

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these contradictions and the intensity of class conflict steadily increasing as capitalism developed. Thus there is a steady polarization of the two major classes as the intermediate strata are submerged into the proletariat. As capital accumulates, it is concentrated more and more into fewer hands, a process accompanied by the relative pauperization of the proletariat. Production assumes an increasingly social and cooperative character as larger and larger groups of workers are concentrated in factories. At the same time the wealth produced by labour is appropriated by fewer and fewer individuals as greater competition drives all but the larger companies out of business. Such processes magnify and illuminate the contradictions of capitalism and increase the intensity of conflict. It is only a matter of time before members of the proletariat recognize that the reality of their situation is the alienation of labour. This awareness will lead the proletariat to 'a revolt to which it is forced by the contradiction between its *humanity* and its situation, which is an open, clear and absolute negation of its humanity'.

The **communist society** which Marx predicted would arise from the ruins of capitalism will begin with a transitional phase, '**the dictatorship of the proletariat**'. Once the communist system has been fully established, the reason for being of the dictatorship and therefore its existence will end. The communist society of the new era is without classes, without contradictions. The dialectical principle now ceases to operate. The contradictions of human history have now been negated in a final harmonious synthesis.

Judging from the constant reinterpretations, impassioned defences and vehement criticisms of Marx's work, his ideas are as alive and relevant today as they ever were. Many of his critics have argued that history has failed to substantiate Marx's views on the direction of social change. Thus they claim that class conflict, far from growing in intensity, has become institutionalized in advanced capitalist society. They see little indication of the proletariat becoming a class for itself. Rather than a polarization of classes, they argue that the class structure of capitalist society has become increasingly complex and differentiated. In particular, a steadily growing middle class has emerged between the proletariat and bourgeoisie. Turning to communist society, critics have argued that history has not borne out the promise of communism contained in Marx's writings. Significant social inequalities are present in communist regimes and there are few, if any, signs of a movement towards equality. The dictatorship of the proletariat clings stubbornly to power and there is little indication of its eventual disappearance. Particular criticism has been directed towards the priority that Marx assigns to

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economic factors in his explanation of social structure and social change. Max Weber's study of ascetic Protestantism argued that religious beliefs provided the ethics, attitudes and motivations for the development of capitalism. Since ascetic Protestantism preceded the advent of capitalism, Weber maintained that at certain times and places aspects of the superstructure can play a primary role in directing change. The priority given to economic factors has also been criticized by elite theorists who have argued that control of the machinery of government rather than ownership of the forces of production provides the basis for power. They point to the example of communist societies where, despite the fact that the forces of production are communally owned, power is largely monopolized by a political and bureaucratic elite.

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Important: The German sociologist **Ralf Dahrendorf** claims that the social structure of advanced societies has undergone some very significant changes since Marx's time. These changes have resulted in a "transformed" capitalism, and the modern industrial societies are organized in terms of "**imperatively coordinated associations**," i.e. associations of people controlled by a hierarchy of authority and power. According to Dahrendorf, some of the key features of advance industrial societies are:

- **Decomposition of capital** (stock holders and managers): This implies the separation of ownership and control over large corporations such as joint stock companies where the ownership (in the form of equity) lies with the public at large while the control is exercised by the management, professionals, technocrats and other experts.

- **Decomposition of labour** (from homogeneous group of equally unskilled and impoverished people, to differentiated occupational groups, with differentiated attributes and status (prestige, responsibility, authority)): Dahrendorf believes that during the twentieth century there has been a 'decomposition of labour', a disintegrating of the manual working class. Contrary to Marx's prediction, the manual working class has become increasingly heterogeneous or dissimilar by the emergence of new differentiations of skill. He sees this resulting from changes in technology arguing that 'increasingly complex machines require increasingly qualified designers, builders, maintenance and repair men and even minders'. Dahrendorf claims that the working class is now divided into three distinct levels: unskilled, semi-skilled and skilled manual workers. Differences in economic and prestige rewards are linked to this hierarchy of skill. In view of the differences in skill, economic and status rewards and interests within the ranks of manual workers, Dahrendorf claims that 'it has become doubtful whether speaking of the working class still makes much sense'. He believes that during the twentieth century there has been a 'decomposition of labour', a disintegration of the manual working class.

- **Institutionalisation of class conflict (**industrial bargaining): According to Dahrendorf, the tension between labour and capital is recognized as a principle of the structure of the labour market and has become a legal institution of society. As workers have become increasingly skilled, educated and better paid, they have become more integrated into the middle layers of society. The traditional sources of discontent and labour militancy have been dissolved. The basis for class struggle is gone. Conflicts now develop within imperatively coordinated associations (institutional structures

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such as business organizations, unions and so forth) and are resolved rationally and fairly through mediation, arbitration or adjudication.

However, despite criticisms, Marx's work on class has been examined in detail for the following reasons. Firstly, many sociologists claim that his theory still provides the best explanation of the nature of class in capitalist society. Secondly, much of the research on class has been inspired by ideas and questions raised by Marx. Thirdly, many of the concepts of class analysis introduced by Marx have proved useful to Marxists and non-Marxists alike. And, as T.B. Bottomore writing in 1965 notes, 'For the past eighty years Marx's theory has been the object of unrelenting criticism and tenacious defence'. This observation remains true today.

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Dear Candidate, let us now look at some of the important ideas of Durkheim discussed in his major works.

The Division of Labour in Society (1893)

The Division of Labour in Society (1893) has been called sociology's first classic. It was Durkheim's first major theoretical work. It was written during the 1880s as part of his doctoral requirement and later published as a complete study in 1893 while Durkheim was at the University of Bordeaux. In this work, Durkheim traced the development of the relationship between individuals and society. Please note that since it was the first of his major works and his methodology for sociological research was still in its formative stage, it was to some extent a speculative exercise. Durkheim presented his methodological framework with clarity and precision in his second major work '*The Rules of Sociological Method*' (1895).

In his study on division of labour in society, Durkheim was primarily responding to the rise of industrial society highlighting both, its positive and negative sides. The rise of industrial society was seen as a consequence of technological advancement which itself was regarded as a natural concomitant of increasing division of labour or specialization. However, Durkheim was not the first to discuss the consequences of division of labour. Prior to him, classical economist Adam Smith had also explained division of labour in terms of its economic consequences.

The term 'division of labour' is used in social theory to refer to the process of dividing up labour among individuals in a group so that the main economic and domestic tasks are performed by different people for the purposes of the collective maintenance of society. The process of the division of labour therefore begins as soon as individuals form themselves into groups where, instead of living isolated or alone, they cooperate collectively by dividing their labour and by coordinating their economic and domestic activities for purposes of survival. Durkheim believed that the division of labour was therefore the result of a social process taking place within the structure of society rather than the result of the private choices of individuals or the result of organic traits that emerged during evolution.

Classical economist Adam Smith was the first to introduce the term 'division of labour' into social thought and to discuss the role it played in the manufacturing process. In looking at the division of labour in different societies, Durkheim, began by making a distinction between what he called the 'social division of labour' and what Adam Smith had called the 'economic division of labour'. In the

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eighteenth century, Smith used the term economic division of labour to describe what happens in the production process when labour is divided during manufacturing. Smith had used the term initially to pinpoint the increase in productivity that takes place when production tasks are divided between workers during the manufacturing process. Smith noted that as soon as people divide their labour to perform various tasks and operations, the quantity of what they produce increases dramatically and that the process of dividing labour tends to accelerate the rate of production.

Durkheim rejected such a narrow and purely economic interpretation of division of labour. Durkheim argued that a purely economic interpretation of division of labour as given by Smith is sociologically inadequate. Since 'division of labour' is a social fact, it must be explained in terms of its overall social consequences and not simply in its economic consequences. The term social division of labour was thus used by Durkheim to describe the *social links and bonds* which develop during the process that takes place in societies when many individuals enter into cooperation for purposes of carrying out joint economic and domestic tasks. Under these circumstances, Durkheim thought that the social division of labour was distinct from the economic division of labour. When used by Smith, the division of labour referred only to the process of dividing up labour for purposes of increasing the rate of production; whereas when used by Durkheim, it referred to the ***principle of social cohesion*** that develops in societies whose social links and bonds result from the way individuals relate to one another when their labour is divided along economic and domestic tasks.

In other words, in this study Durkheim explores the consequences of division of labour for the society as a whole. Beyond focusing explicitly on the social division of labour, Durkheim looked at the question of the overall unity of society. Generally speaking, he referred to this unity as ***social solidarity***. He argued that what holds a society together is the cohesiveness or solidarity among its parts. Hence in this study of social division of labour, Durkheim probes the relationship between division of labour and the manner in which solidarity comes about in a given society. Please remember that his preoccupation with the idea of social order and solidarity was largely a by-product of his own back-ground of belongings to a highly well-knit Jewish community and a very turbulent period in French history. This pre-disposed him towards a search for the basis of moral order in society.

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Before proceeding further, let me just mention three important concerns which Durkheim was trying to address in his study of division of labour.

Firstly, Durkheim wanted to study the social dimension of division of labour. He made a clear distinction between economic and the social consequences of division of labour.

Secondly, since Durkheim and many other before him had explained the rise of industrial society in terms of increase in division of labour, he wanted to study that how division of labour affects social solidarity. In other words, how the change in the division of labour affects the structure of the society and consequently, the nature of social solidarity.

Thirdly, in the post-Enlightenment period, when individualism was on rise, how does individual, while becoming more autonomous, also becomes more solidary. As Durkheim puts it:

'This work had its origins in the question of the relations of the individual to social solidarity. Why does the individual, while becoming more autonomous, depend more upon society? How can he be at once more individual and more solidary? Certainly, these two movements, contradictory as they appear, develop in parallel fashion. This is the problem we are raising. It appeared to us that what resolves this apparent antimony is a transformation of social solidarity due to the steadily growing development of the division of labour. That is how we have been led to make this the object of our study.'

Durkheim, *The Division of Labour in Society* (1893)

Durkheim argues that the change in the division of labour has had enormous implications for the structure of society. Durkheim was most interested in the changed way in which social solidarity is produced, in other words, the changed way in which society is held together and how its members see themselves as part of a whole. To capture this difference, Durkheim referred to two types of solidarity – mechanical and organic.

He argues that in pre-modern society the division of labour is relatively undeveloped. Agrarian production close to home is the prevailing way of life, and working relationships and other kinds of social dependence associated with it are also largely immediate, local and uncomplicated. The most typical trait of such primitive societies is their *segmentary* nature. Such societies consist of clearly delimited collectivities or clans, characterized by homogeneity and equality between individuals within these collectivities. Role specialization and division of labour are rudimentary – with the exception of some authority figures. Individuals have little or no autonomy within the group. The bond among people is that they

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are all engaged in similar activities and have similar responsibilities. However, in this form of society the division of labour is not in fact able on its own to provide enough in the way of social solidarity. The remainder comes from what Durkheim calls the *collective conscience*, 'the totality of beliefs and sentiments common to average citizens of the same society', which binds individuals together not so much in terms of their daily activity but of the religious and cultural beliefs, the social and political ideology, they share. **Mechanical solidarity** is the term Durkheim uses for the association of actors that emerges here. This is the dominant foundation of cohesion in simple societies where there is little differentiation. People may be similar in many respects – in terms of housing, occupation and the use of tools, clothing, customs, cuisine and lifestyle; they may be equal with regard to power; experience the same emotions, needs, and ideas, and hold similar moral and religious attitudes. The more primitive a society, the more similarity will these be on all these dimensions, and the more conspicuous is its mechanical solidarity. Such societies are characterized by collectivism.

We may note that Durkheim takes both material and nonmaterial aspects into account – shared ideas are as important as equality in material living conditions in primitive societies. A comprehensive, strong conscience collective is an essential characteristic of any primitive society. The conscience collective is basically religious in primitive societies. By religious Durkheim means possessing a strong sense of right and wrong, of what is sacred, and this is manifest in the form of all the various rules, rituals, and ceremonies that must be observed to show respect for the sacred. As a result of equality in material living conditions and customs, the intimacy of social life and the continuous reciprocal "surveillance" of behavior, and the intense conscience collective which demands respect for rules and all that is held sacred, there will be a strong reaction to any form of deviancy in primitive societies. Deviancy is often regarded as a religious offence.

On the other hand, there is a comprehensive division of labour in modern societies. Individuals engage in different, often highly specialized occupations. They are no longer so closely bound to groups marked by a large degree of internal equality and homogeneity. They can move within and between several social groups or circles, and no single group has the kind of irresistible power – typical of collectivities in primitive societies – to rigidly impose a particular way of life on the individual. This is the primary reason why individuals in modern societies necessarily develop in different directions. Differences of many kinds emerge between individuals, just as differences also emerge between professions and trades. And because so many differences emerge between individuals, groups, and occupations, many theorists in Durkheim's day thought that high levels of conflict were inevitable in modern societies. Solidarity or a sense of collectivity would be weakened as a result of the numerous conflicts of interest resulting from all the

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differences. Durkheim, on the other hand, thought that in a modern society marked by increased division of labour, a specifically modern form of solidarity would emerge, which he calls **organic solidarity**.

In primitive societies, solidarity is a manifestation of "attraction through similarity." What type of attraction could possibly exist between people when similarity is replaced by numerous differences? Will these differences not rather give rise to conflict? Durkheim seeks to demonstrate that the many differences that develop as a corollary of modernization take a specific form: through occupational specialization, a large number of differences necessarily arise, but at the same time comprehensive *mutual dependency* is created between the many kinds of labour, and between individuals. The shoemaker dedicates al his working hours to making shoes, and thus simultaneously becomes dependent on others who produce the commodities he needs – clothes, tools, food, etc.. All producers are dependent on each other's products, and thus a complex dependency emerges. They complement one another, participating in a differentiated, coherent system, just as specialized organs function in a living organism (hence the term *organic* solidarity). For this reason, Durkheim also states that modern societies are "functionally integrated."
Modern society, in Durkheim's view, is thus held together by the specialization of people and their need for the services of many others. This specialization includes not only that of individuals but also of groups, structures, and institutions.

'The most remarkable effect of the division of labour is not that it increases the output of functions divided, but that it renders them solidary. Its role in all these cases is not simply to embellish or ameliorate existing societies, but to render societies possible which, without it, would not exist.'

Durkheim (1893)

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Durkheim further argued that primitive societies have a stronger collective conscience, that is, more shared understandings, norms and beliefs. The increasing division of labour has caused a diminution of the collective conscience. The collective conscience is of much less significance in a society with organic solidarity than it is in a society with mechanical solidarity. People in modern society are more likely to be held together by the division of labour and the resulting need for the functions performed by others than they are by a shared and powerful collective conscience. Nevertheless, even organic societies have a collective consciousness, albeit in a weaker form that allows for more individual differences.

Anthony Giddens points out that the collective conscience in the two types of society can be differentiated on four dimensions – volume, intensity, rigidity, and content. Volume refers to the number of people enveloped by the collective conscience; intensity, to how deeply the individuals feel about it; rigidity, to how clearly it is defined; and content, to the form that the collective conscience takes in the two types of society (see Table below).

THE FOUR DIMENSIONS OF THE COLLECTIVE CONSCIENCE

Solidarity	Volume	Intensity	Rigidity	Content
Mechanical	Entire Society	High	High	Religious
Organic	Particular Groups	Low	Low	Moral Individualism

Durkheim also argued that a society with mechanical solidarity is characterized by *repressive law*. Because people are very similar in this type of society, and because they tend to believe very strongly in a common morality, any offense against their shared value system is likely to be of significance to most individuals. Since everyone feels the offense and believes deeply in the common morality, a wrongdoer is likely to be punished severely for any action that offends the collective moral system. Theft might lead to the cutting off of the offender's hands; blaspheming might result in the removal of one's tongue. Even minor offenses against the moral system are likely to be met with severe punishment. In contrast, a society with organic solidarity is characterized by *restitutive law*, where offenders must make restitution for their crimes. In such societies, offenses are more likely to be seen as committed against a particular individual or segment of society than against the moral system itself. Because there is a weak common morality, most people do not react emotionally to a breach of the law. Instead of

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being severely punished for every offense against the collective morality, offenders in an organic society are likely to be asked to make restitution to those who have been harmed by their actions. Although some repressive law continues to exist in a society with organic solidarity (for example, the death penalty), restitutive law predominates, especially for minor offenses.

If Durkheim's theory was correct, modern society would normally have evolved relatively free of conflict. But Durkheim himself was aware of that antagonism and powerful conflicts were commonplace in the nineteenth century. He put this down to the fact that development had not occurred along "normal" lines, and attempted to explain this anomaly. He thought this was partly due to the persistence into modern society some old disparities of power and wealth – from feudalism, for instance – which were incompatible with the new order. He also argued that very rapid changes and adjustments in any given period do not allow the various elements of society time to adjust to one another.

In order to explain this anomaly between 'what ought to be' and 'what is', Durkheim makes a distinction between '***normal***' and '***pathological***' forms of division of labour. He called the above description as normal division of labour. While on the other hand, he explained the prevailing chaos and conflict of 19th century laissez-faire society, its wholly unregulated markets, extreme inequalities, etc. as the manifestations of the pathological or abnormal division of labour. He identified three abnormal forms, viz., anomic division of labour, forced division of labour, and poorly coordinated division of labour.

Anomie, in literal sense, implies 'normlessness.' Durkheim used the concept of *anomie* to refer to the breakdown of the normative regulation in a given society. The *anomic division of labour* refers to the lack of regulation in a society that celebrates isolated individuality and refrains from telling people what they should do. Durkheim further develops this concept of *anomie* in his work on suicide. In both works, he used the term to refer to those social conditions where humans lack sufficient moral constraint. For Durkheim, modern society is always prone to anomie, but it comes to the fore in times of social and economic crises. Without the strong common morality of mechanical solidarity, people might not have a clear concept of what is and what is not proper and acceptable behaviour. Even though the division of labour is a source of cohesion in modern society, it cannot entirely make up for the weakening of the common morality. Individuals can become isolated and be cut adrift in their highly specialized activities. They can more easily cease to feel a common bond with those who work and live around them. This gives rise to anomie. Organic solidarity is prone to this particular pathology, but it is important to remember that Durkheim saw this as an abnormal situation. The modern division of labour has the capacity to promote increased moral

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interactions rather than reducing people to isolated and meaningless tasks and positions.

While Durkheim believed that people needed rules and regulation to tell them what to do, his second abnormal form pointed to a kind of rule that could lead to conflict and isolation and therefore increase anomie. He called this the *forced division of labour*. This second pathology refers to the fact that outdated norms and expectations can force individuals, groups, and classes into positions for which they are ill suited. Traditions, economic power, or status can determine who performs what jobs regardless of talent and qualification. [It is here that Durkheim comes closest to a Marxist position. However, Durkheim did not elabourate in detail on the fundamental causes for the extreme economic inequalities prevailing in the modern industrial societies of Europe in those times, as Marx did in terms of the ownership and non-ownership of the forces of production. Moreover, Durkheim saw this only as an aberration of the industrial society, occurring only in an abnormal situation.]

Under the heading of the forced division of labour, Durkheim discusses those socially structured inequalities which undermine solidarity. Durkheim explicitly recognizes that class inequalities restrict the opportunities of the lower classes and prevent the realization of their abilities. Resentment accumulates and men are led to revolutionary thoughts. The problem here is not lack of rules but rather the excess of them in that rules themselves are the cause of evil. The rules have in fact arisen in order to enforce the division of labour coercively. Individual specialism and occupations are not freely chosen but forced upon each person by custom, law and even sheer chance. Individuals find themselves estranged, resentful and aspiring to social positions which have been arbitrarily closed off to them. The forced division of labour then brings about a situation which one modern author has called the *anomie of injustice*. It is this which has produced class conflict and not, as Marx would have it, the inherently exploitative nature of capitalism. Nor, did Durkheim consider that all inequality could be abolished. But whereas some inequalities are 'natural' and occur spontaneously, others are external inequality and can be mitigated. What in effect he is urging is the creation of what today is called 'equality of opportunity' or a meritocracy. For this to be possible all forms of hereditary privilege should be abolished.

Finally, the third form of abnormal division of labour is where the specialized functions performed by different people are *poorly coordinated*. Again Durkheim makes the point that organic solidarity flows from the interdependence of the people. If people's specializations do not result in increased interdependence but simply in isolation, the division of labour will not result in social solidarity.

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Durkheim argued that for the division of labour to function as a moral and socially solidifying force in modern society, anomie, the forced division of labour, and the improper coordination of specialization must be addressed. Durkheim suggested a few broad guidelines to address the problems arising out of the abnormal or pathological division of labour. Please remember that this was essentially a speculative exercise, not based on any empirical research.

Durkheim argued that the conscience collective and religion would become less and less significant in a functionally differentiated society, due to the differences between people. With increasing differentiation in working and social life, as well as the weakening of the conscience collective as a binding force, modern society would be characterized by individualism. When individualism gains too much strength, it has the effect of destroying solidarity. To avoid total disruption, individualism must be counteracted through the development of new institutional bonds between people. There is some uncertainty on this point in Durkheim's theory. Because he views society as a self-regulating system, he assumes that such a correction of individualism will emerge naturally and spontaneously. On the other hand, however, he is also interested in finding practical measures that might restrain rampant individualism. He thought the family had too limited an importance in modern society to constitute an effective counterweight. Nor did he believe in the socialist notion that a powerful state would be adequate. According to Durkheim, the state was too distant from everyday social life to be capable of having any decisive moral effect on the collectivity.

In several works after 1893 he suggested certain measures: for instance, he advocated establishing new types of organization in the economic sector – so-called corporations, which had certain similarities with the medieval guild system. The point was that those involved in a certain kind of occupation, employers and employees alike, should unite in a national organization. He thought this would lead to the development of solidarity between actors, and thus counteract the tendencies toward ruthless competition and individualism. He cites the example of professional organizations, such as lawyers' organizations, which create professional ethics governing their work. According to him, this would go a long way in controlling the anomic state of professional, industrial, and commercial life. He also thought school reforms, in the shape of new syllabuses and modes of cooperation, might restrain individualism. If children were educated in the spirit of solidarity at school, they would develop social habits that would also be important in adulthood. He also suggested restrictions on the right to divorce.

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Many commentators have pointed to a tendency in the development of Durkheim's theories: early in his career, he expressed a strong belief in society's ability to develop solidarity and unity spontaneously. Later, he came to accentuate more and more the need for active political and moral regulation of social life, especially in the economic sphere. Eventually, he concluded that the basic principles of the modern market economy largely nurtured competition and egoism, and that the economy therefore had to be actively regulated in order to ensure widespread solidarity. We could not just wait for solidarity to evolve "naturally."

Later, Durkheim also modified his previously negative judgment of individualism. He reached the perception that individualism was not necessarily the same as egoism and the radical destruction of social bonds. It became clear to him that modern societies could not be based on a strictly collectivist ethos. The problems associated with the division of functions and specialization in modern societies could be solved only by assuming values and relations that took a high level of individualism for granted. He thought a more positive and more valuable type of individualism, one distinct from egoism, was in the process of emerging. This he termed *moral individualism*. The autonomy of the individual is fundamental, but this autonomy also involves the capacity for moral reflection, and moral obligations. Given the correct form of socialization and the development of social relations, *modern* individualists would be able to strike a balance between individual independence and social bonding.

In other words, rather than driving a wedge between individuals and society the advanced division of labour gives rise to new kinds of individuals and endorses the strong notion of individuality. Modern society, just like modern industry, needs 'modern' individuals, just as individuals who want to behave in modern ways and to express modern attitudes and beliefs need an advanced division of labour where they can be expressed. The division of labour serves to reconcile the individual with society.

As Durkheim sees it, 'the problem of the individual' in modern society is that politicians and other intellectuals have been slow to recognize the emergence of this new kind of individualism. Like many other social critics, Durkheim believes that the earlier conception of 'acquisitive individualism' in which individuals are seen as selfish, egoistic and aggressively competitive, which had been popularised by utilitarian philosophers like Jeremy Bentham and John Stuart Mill, and liberal economists like Adam Smith and David Ricardo, had to be set aside. Utilitarian conceptions of competitive individualism were being superseded by a new and properly socialized conception. This is moral individualism, in which

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individuals are seen as an embodiment of the core virtue of doing things for the common good.

The strength of modern individuality is not measured in terms of how much it promotes the selfish and egoistic interests of any particular individual, but in terms of the contribution the individual makes to the collective social body, that is, to society. Indeed, Durkheim goes so far as to suggest that the new cult of the individual becomes a central facet of the *conscience collective* of modern society. Just as it is the duty of the individual to work towards the social good, it is the function of society to provide individuals with fruitful opportunities to express themselves in as many ways as possible. The key point to grasp is that individuality and social opportunity cannot be separated one from the other.

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Dear Candidate, let us now assess Durkheim's study of division of labour both, in terms of its contribution to social theory as well as the criticisms it invited.

The key theme in Durkheim's sociological theory, the major theoretical issue he is concerned with throughout his work, is that of ***the relationship of the individual to society***. In this book-length investigation, Durkheim analyses the individual-versus-society issue in terms of the different kinds of social solidarity that hold society and individuals together. One of the advantages of linking the individual-versus-society debate explicitly with the question of social solidarity is that it allows Durkheim to argue that developments in the demands of individuals and of modern notions of individuality, are actually complimented by changes in the nature of society rather than being in opposition to them. Durkheim sees the emergence of modern individuals, and of modern notions of individuality, as an inevitable corollary of the advanced division of labour in society.

Durkheim's study of division of labour, though to an extent speculative, but proved to be a landmark study as it was for the first time that the social significance of division of labour was explored in such a comprehensive manner. As stated earlier that prior to him division of labour was studied only in terms of its economic consequences. Durkheim was one of the first sociologists to explore the social dimension of division of labour. In this study he explained that how with increase in the division of labour new forms of solidarity emerge in society to provide for its cohesiveness and stability. This finding opened new vistas of research in social sciences. It initiated a number of studies which attempted to explore that how and to what extent the experience at work can also have social implications. So much so that it gave rise to an altogether new branch of knowledge called *Sociology of Occupations and Professions*.

For example, Elton Mayo, a professor at the Harvard Business School, in his investigation (from 1927-1932) at the Hawthorne plant of the Western Electric Company in Chicago, found out that the 'sense of belongingness' to a social group is as important for a worker as the economic rewards. Mayo began with the assumptions of scientific management believing that the physical conditions of the work environment, the aptitude of the worker and financial incentives were the main determinants of productivity. The theory of scientific management was first spelt out in detail by Frederick W. Taylor whose book, *The Principles of Scientific Management* was published in America in 1911. Taylor assumed that man's primary motivation for work was financial. He argued that by increasing the monetary incentives paid to the worker, the productivity too can be maximized. In practice this usually involved a wage incentive scheme based on piece work – payment according to the amount of work done. Taylor believed that the scientific planning of work tasks, the selection and systematic training of suitable workers

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for the performance of those tasks plus a carrot and stick system of financial incentives would maximize productivity. On the contrary, Mayo in his study found that the behaviour of the worker was largely a response to group norms rather than simply being directed by economic incentives. Most of the workers belonged to one or the other informal group. The researchers discovered that the workers had established a norm which defined a fair day's work, and that this norm, rather than standards set by management, determined their output. From the Hawthorne studies, and research which they largely stimulated, developed the human relations school. It stated that scientific management provided too narrow a view of man and that financial incentives alone were insufficient to motivate workers and ensure their cooperation.

However, though a remarkable study, Durkheim's study of division of labour also came under criticism on several accounts.

Firstly, the concept of *conscience collective* as a common and determinate system of shared beliefs and sentiments was criticized on various accounts by other scholars. For Durkheim, the reality of society preceded the individual life. Durkheim frequently, especially in discussions on the collective conscience, reached a degree of sociological realism that seemed to deny altogether the social significance of individual volition or decision. Society is real, to be true, but so is the individual. And the two, it should be remembered, are always in interaction. Giving priority to one over the other is misleading in the long run.

Further, conflict theorists also argued, on Marxian lines, that modern industrial society is characterized by class divisions and extreme economic inequalities. Given the pluralistic character of modern society it is difficult to conceive of an all encompassing and shared value system which is based on consensus of all its members. Rather they argue that such collective conscience is nothing but a reflection of the values of the dominant classes in society. The values of the dominant classes are imposed on masses either by indoctrination through education and religion, or by coercion. In other words, it implies that the ideas and aspirations of the subaltern groups may find no representation in such body of belief systems.

Secondly, anti-positivist scholars also question the concepts of collective conscience and social facts. They argue that human behaviour is a meaningful behaviour, guided by meanings, motives and values. By defining collective conscience in terms of an all embracing and determinate system and according primacy to groups over the individual has somehow subordinated the individual conscience to that of collectivity. Further, by focusing on the exteriority dimension

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and empirical study of the social facts, Durkheim leaves no room for the interpretative understanding of human behaviour.

Thirdly, conflict theorists also question the suggestion offered by Durkheim of state intervention in regulating the economy in order to address the problem of abnormal division of labour. Durkheim believed that the state, being an executive organ of the conscience collective, would work for the welfare of all sections of the society. However, conflict theorists argue that state is nothing but an executive organ of only the dominant classes and would only further their interests.

Fourthly, conflict theorists also criticize Durkheim's theory for its conservative outlook. They argue that there is a built-in conservative bias in Durkheim's theory. By repeatedly emphasizing on the normative regulation and collective morality, Durkheim focus was primarily on explaining maintenance and sustenance of the stability and social order in society. Conflict theorists argue that Durkheim failed to account for conflict and conflict led change as Marx did.

Fifthly, some scholars also argue that the solutions offered by Durkheim to address the problems of abnormal division of labour are overly simplified. For example, Durkheim explained the anomic division of labour in terms of the breakdown of the normative regulation in the society. As if by restoring the normative regulation alone all problems associated with the increase in division of labour could be addressed. These scholars argue that there are certain inherent problems associated with the increase in division of labour such as de-skilling, fragmentation of work, alienation, etc., which Durkheim did not take elaborated upon.

Further, there are also some problems with the Durkheim's view of the individual. Despite having made a number of crucial assumptions about human nature, Durkheim denied that he had done so. He argued that he did not begin by postulating a certain conception of human nature in order to deduce sociology from it. Instead, he said that it was from sociology that he sought an increasing understanding of human nature. However, Durkheim may have been less than honest with his readers, and perhaps even with himself.

One of Durkheim's assumptions about human nature is that people are impelled by their passions into a mad search for gratification that always leads to a need for more. If these passions are unrestrained, they multiply to the point where the individual is enslaved by them and they become a threat to the individual as well as to society. It can be argued that Durkheim's entire theoretical edifice, especially his emphasis on collective morality, was erected on this basic assumption about people's passions. However, Durkheim provides no evidence for

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this assumption, and indeed, his own theories would suggest that such an insatiable subject may be a creation of social structures rather than the other way around.

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Paradigm of Functional Analysis

Merton devoted considerable attention to what he called the "codification of functional analysis in sociology." This work displays some important differences from Parsons's functionalism. For one thing, Merton's functional paradigm is not open to criticisms of inherent conservatism and teleology (explaining things by their function). At the same time, however, Merton offered fewer specific propositions about the structure of societies than Parsons did.

As we have seen, functionalists in general conceive of society as a system of interrelated parts. This is equally true of Merton, who argued that the central orientation of functionalism is expressed in the practice of interpreting data by establishing their consequences for larger structures in which they are implicated. Merton was also deeply interested in social integration, or equilibrium. Like Durkheim and Parsons, he analyzed society with reference to whether the cultural and social structures are well or badly integrated; was interested in the contributions of customs and institutions to the persistence of societies; and defined **functions** as those contributions or consequences that "make for the adaption or adjustment of a given system." Finally, Merton argued that shared values are central in explaining how societies and institutions work, thus sharing the other major distinguishing concern of all functionalist analysis.

However, through his paradigm Merton clarified and refocused some major aspects of functionalist theory. The most important are his emphasis on **dysfunctions**, his distinction between **manifest** and **latent functions**, his concept of **functional alternatives**, and his insistence on the importance of uncovering and understanding the mechanisms by which functions are fulfilled.

Merton prefers to use the word *functional analysis* rather than structural-functionalism. Merton makes an attempt to refine and develop functional approach. His basic aim to functional analysis is that to point out fundamental errors in the substance of structural functionalism and its related terminology. For a research strategy, according to him, it is necessary to combine the outlined criticisms of functional structuralism and empirical studies in the functional analysis.

Dear Candidate, Merton's work must be seen in the context when classical functionalism championed by Durkheim, Radcliffe-Brown and Malinowski was being severely criticized for its conservative teleology and inability to account for conflict and conflict-led change. Merton rejected the core idea of classical functionalism that recurrent social phenomena should be explained by their functions, such as their benefits to society as a whole.

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By 1950s the criticism grew stronger and sharper, thus compelling Merton to take up the task of clarifying and correcting certain basic tenets of classical functionalism. Merton begins with the review of the mistakes of the early functionalists particularly Malinowski and Radcliffe Brown. Merton saw functional theorizing as embracing three questionable postulates:

1. Postulate of the Functional Unity of Society
2. Postulate of Universal Functionalism
3. Postulate of Indispensability

Merton has explained: "Substantially, these postulates hold first, that standardized social activities or cultural items are functional for the *entire* social or cultural system; second, that all such social and cultural items fulfill sociological functions; and third, that these items are consequently *indispensable*."

According to Merton, the belief in the above mentioned postulates as self-evident truths rather than tentative propositions by the classical functionalists had been responsible for the ideological coloration which functionalism had come to acquire as a result of which it was criticized as conservative teleology. According to Merton, functional analysis must be seen and understood only as a methodology. The ideological tint of the functional approach can be done away with if one abandons the belief in the above mentioned postulates and does not treat them as self-evident truths. Merton, in fact, establishes three prevailing postulates in functional analysis to point-out the distinctive difficulties of structural functionalism. Merton summarized in these three (rejectable) postulates what he thought was flawed in classical functionalism.

1. **Postulate of the Functional Unity of Society**, the assumption that what matters is the contribution of some social element to the *whole* system, thus presupposing that there is such a unity. In other words, this postulate presupposes that every social system must have some minimum degree of functional unity for its survival.

   In this context, Merton cites the view of some of the noted sociologists and social anthropologists, such as, Radcliffe-Brown, Malinowski, etc. They had mainly discussed small-scale societies and this assumption has been valid only for such type of societies. The functional unity of society is, therefore, doubtful, argues Merton, particularly for complex and highly differentiated societies. For instance, it would be wrong

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to consider that religious ceremonies promoted solidarity throughout the Indian society, but it would be true to say that it contributes to the solidarity of subgroups within it.

According to Merton, functionalists so far have frequently transformed the hypothesis that social system may reveal social integration into necessary integration or need for social survival. While it is difficult to argue that human society does not possess some degree of integration, for otherwise they would not be systems, Merton views the degree of integration in a system as an issue to be empirically determined. To assume that a high degree of functional unity must exist in a social system is to preclude the possibility of its empirical verification. It is due to such a presumption regarding high degree of functional unity that the functional approach has come to acquire a conservative bias and an ideological coloration which can be derived from the works of the functionalists from Durkheim to Talcott Parsons. Thus the degree to which functional unity exists in the social system should be a matter subject to empirical investigation.

Merton argues that functional unity is a matter of observation and investigation. The entire fact of "functional unity" is that it is applicable only to small type of society in which a change in one part of the system will automatically result in a change in other parts. On the other hand, he suggests that a high degree of "functional autonomy" is found in highly differentiated societies, not a functional unity. Thus a change in any part of the system may have little or no effect on others.

2. **Postulate of Universal Functionalism**, the claim that *all* social or cultural forms have some (positive) function. Nineteenth century anthropologists, for instance, such as Radcliffe-Brown, Malinowski, Rivers, Tylor, Durkheim, assumed that every social and cultural element must have positive functions for the maintenance of the society. But the fact is that not every structure, custom, belief, and so forth has positive functions.

Merton suggests that if an examination of an actually existing system is undertaken, it would be clear that there is a wide range of empirical possibilities. Firstly, items may not be always functional for the whole system or a part of it, but can also be ***dysfunctional*** for either the part or the whole system. For instance, poverty may not be dysfunctional for society as

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a whole but only to the poor. Thus Merton suggests that functionalist should analyse any part of system from the point of view of its functional, dysfunctional or non-functional consequences.

Secondly, some consequences whether functional or dysfunctional are intended and recognized by the system and are thus ***manifest***, whereas other consequences are not intended or recognized and are therefore ***latent***.

Merton suggests that the postulate of universal functionalism should be replaced by "the provisional assumption that persisting cultural forms have a ***net balance of functional consequences*** either for the society considered as a unit or subgroups sufficiently powerful to retain these forms intact, by means of direct coercion or indirect persuasion."

3. **Postulate of Indispensability**, that the function performed by a social or cultural form is an *indispensable* precondition for the survival of the social system. In other words, this postulate states that certain institutions or social arrangements are indispensable to society. The postulate of indispensability is related to two assertions. Firstly, it is assumed that there are certain *functions* which are indispensable in the sense that, unless they are performed, the society (or group, or individual) will not persist. This, then, sets forth a concept of functional prerequisites, or preconditions functionally necessary for a society. Secondly, it is assumed that *certain cultural or social forms* are indispensable for fulfilling each of these functions.

Merton, in fact, raises questions on the assumption of indispensability and rejects it by arguing that: *"just as the same item may have multiple functions, so may the same function be diversely fulfilled by alternative items."* To replace the idea of indispensability, Merton suggests the concept of *functional alternatives* or *functional equivalents*. According to Merton, "The utility of this concept is not to identify various arrangements with identical consequences, but rather to identify arrangements with identical or similar functions (effectiveness) but reduced dysfunctions (increased efficiency)."

Merton, therefore, accepts the idea that certain function must be met for a society by a range of alternative means rather than the institutions that

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meet them are indispensable to survive. Furthermore, in looking for such functional alternatives attention is drawn to the questions about the range of the items that could serve as functional equivalents within the existing *structural constraints* of the social system.

In a nut shell, these postulates are debatable and unnecessary. Merton argues that none of these postulates was empirically justifiable. Merton emphasized that functionalist should examine the situation at empirical level. Merton's belief that empirical tests are crucial to functional analysis led his to develop his **'paradigm'** of functional analysis as a guide to the integration of theory and research.

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Merton is concerned to deal with the necessity of a paradigm which contains a set of concepts without which the sociologist cannot adequately carry out a functional analysis. Through his paradigm, Merton clarified and refocused some major aspects of functionalist theory. Some of the distinguishing features of his paradigm of functional analysis are discussed below:

Firstly, Merton made it clear that functional analysis focuses on groups, organizations, societies, and cultures. He stated that any object that can be subjected to functional analysis must "represent a *standardized* (i.e. patterned and repetitive) item." These items are, according to Merton, "social roles, institutional patterns, social processes, cultural patterns, culturally patterned emotions, social norms, group organizations, social structures, devices for social control, etc." In addition, Merton argues that any social item which is being subjected to functional analysis must be described in detail on the basis of *empirical observation*. According to Merton, analysis of sociological data is necessary in functional analysis.

Secondly, unlike Parsons's *assumption* of universal needs or functional prerequisites (AGIL), Merton favoured '*empirical identification of needs*.' In other words, the researcher should empirically identify the needs or functional requirements of the system under investigation and provide a detailed account of the mechanism by which these functional requirements are fulfilled.

Thirdly, after the detailed description of a given social item based on empirical observation, the social scientist should also try to distinguish between the concepts of subjective dispositions and concepts of objective consequences. In other words, the researcher should look for *subjective dispositions* (motives, purposes, etc.) of the actors involved and also to the *objective consequences* of the activity. The researcher must be careful that the subjective dispositions are not confused with the objective consequences.

Let me simplify this. Subjective dispositions may be understood in terms of the meanings that the actors ascribe to a given social item or social condition and the intended consequences (functions) thereof. In Merton's terminology, it is called as ***manifest functions***. In other words, manifest functions of a social item are the consequences that are intended, or of which the participants are aware.

From the concept of manifest functions follows Merton's another key contribution to sociology. It is the concept of ***latent functions***. Latent functions are the consequences that are neither intended nor recognized by the social actors. In other words, latent functions are the unintended and unrecognized consequences associated with a given social item or condition.

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As can be seen, Merton actually used two criteria, intentionality and awareness, thus opening up a more complex typology, with four types (intended and recognized, intended but not recognized, unintended but recognized later, unintended and not recognized). This distinction opens an interesting area for analysis and empirical study concerning the relationship between intended and unintended consequences, and concerning processes triggered when hitherto latent functions become manifest.

Please note that Parsons tends to emphasize the manifest functions of social behaviour, particularly in terms of those objective consequences which contribute to the adjustment or adaptation of the system and which are intended and recognized by participants in the system. Merton, on the other hand, pays particular attention to the latent functions of things and the increased understanding of society functionalist analysis can bring by uncovering them.

Thus, Merton's distinction between manifest and latent functions further clarifies functional analysis. However, the notion of latent functions is not a totally new one. Durkheim's discussion of social cohesion as a consequence of punishment was an analysis of the latent function of punishment (the manifest function being retribution). Similarly the functional analysis of religion as a social integrator is concerned with religion's latent function. Merton emphasizes both the distinction between manifest and latent and the way analysis of latent functions "precludes the substitutions of naive moral judgments for sociological analysis." This distinction forces sociologists to go beyond the reasons individuals give for their actions or for the existence of customs and institutions; it makes them look for other social consequences that allow these practices' survival and illuminate the way a society works.

As an example of the fruitfulness of such analysis, Merton cites Veblen's analysis of conspicuous consumption, the latent function being the enhancement of one's status in the eyes of the world. Merton cites yet another example of the rain-making ceremony of the Native American Hopi tribe to explain this. While the ceremonies are performed by tribe members in the belief that rain will be produced, an unintended consequence, or latent function, is that these ceremonies 'maintain the Hopi society by reinforcing the feelings of solidarity among its members'. The ceremonies don't actually produce rain (the manifest function), but they do help strengthen tribal bonds (a latent function).

For Merton, one cannot complete a functional analysis without considering both manifest and latent functions. He argues that this distinction between manifest and latent functions has various advantages for sociological enquiry. In the first

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place, the distinction aides the sociological interpretation of many social practices even though their manifest purpose is clearly not achieved. Here, Merton advises that sociologists should not dismiss them as mere superstitions or irrationalities and instead should try to look for the latent functions. The rain-making ceremony of the Native American Hopi tribe is an example of such a situation. Further, this distinction serves to direct attention of the sociologists to other fruitful fields of enquiry and opens new vistas of research.

Merton's own analysis of political machines shows how the distinction between manifest and latent functions can help explain the way institutions work and why they survive and thrive. Please note that by political machines (in USA) Merton implies the local political party organizations in American cites. The manifest function of political machines, especially in the context of ward politics, seems to be personal advancement through corruption as it involves vote buying and similar law breaking. However, because they were so firmly rooted in the local neighborhood, ward politics and political machines were highly functional for such disadvantaged groups as new immigrants. They humanized welfare assistance by providing information about hospitals, marshaling legal aid, and furnishing jobs; thus they kept families together and broke down some of the isolation of immigrant groups. Merton started with the hypothesis that in spite of obvious surface dysfunctions, to survive and be influential the machine must have served important functions for some social groups. By asking "Who benefits?" and uncovering the machine's latent functions, he created a classic piece of sociological analysis.

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Fourthly, regarding the study of objective consequences, Merton suggests that the functionalist should analyse any part of system from the point of view of its functional, dysfunctional or non-functional consequences. Talcott Parson's work tends to imply that all existing institutions are inherently good or functional for society, this tendency has been one the major points of attack on functionalism and the one arouses the most emotion among its critics. Merton explicitly dissociates himself from such a position. Instead he emphasizes the existence of **"dysfunctions"** and encourages sociologists to actively identify them.

Merton's concept of dysfunctions involves two complementary but distinct ideas:

The first is that something may have consequences that are generally dysfunctional; in his words, an item may have "consequences which lessen the adaptation or adjustment of the system."

The second is that these consequences may vary according to whom one is talking about; the sociologist must ask the crucial question, "Functional and dysfunctional for whom?" In other words, the researcher must seek to identify the range of units for which the item under study has consequences. Thus, the researcher should look for the consequences of the social item at various levels such as **at individual level**, **at sub-system level** (various groups), and **at system level** (i.e. society).

An excellent example of what Merton means by generally dysfunctional consequences can be found in his own discussion of bureaucracy. On the whole, bureaucracy appears as a functional institution for industrial society in that bureaucratic specialization means better utilization of talent and more effective response to the exigencies of the environment. However, Merton's understanding of dysfunctions makes him aware of what may happen when adherence to bureaucratic rules becomes an end in itself – a situation he calls "ritualism" in his theory of deviance. Although adherence to the rules is ordinarily a moral and social good and therefore functional for society, but in some cases overemphasis on the adherence to the rules may prove to be dysfunctional for a particular section of society or society as a whole.

Merton's knowledge of general dysfunction thus makes him aware of the "dark underside" of bureaucracy in a way not generally associated with functionalism. He is close to Weber, who saw bureaucracy as an efficient, rational way of dealing with problems, necessary to a modern state and to the end of feudalism and yet prospectively tyrannical because of its inflexible ritualism, its insistence on rules for everything. Merton is even close to the neo-Marxist conflict

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theorist, Habermas, who sees rationalistic bureaucracy as an impressive technical development that threatens human freedom.

Merton's second point – that an institution need not be generally functional or generally dysfunctional but may instead be functional for some people and groups and dysfunctional for others – is an even clearer shift away from a functionalism that implies approval of the status quo. In some ways it approaches conflict theory. Merton talks in terms of whether institutions and practices are functional or dysfunctional for people, whereas conflict theorists generally refer to people's interests and the degree to which these are served. However, they share a concern with the differing benefits that various groups obtain from the social order and with the way these benefits explain the origin, persistence, or decline of social institutions.

We can see what Merton means by dysfunctions and why it is important for sociologists to bear them in mind by looking at such supposedly indispensable institutions as marriage and family living. People commonly think of these institutions as crucial to the health of society. Yet marriage and family life may not be functional for some types of individuals at all. They may be happier with such functional alternatives as joining collectives, renting in singles' apartment complexes, living together as unmarried couples, or living in religious communities. Only by recognizing the dysfunctional aspects of marriage and family living can we explain the development and persistence of these alternatives. Again, as functionalists from Durkheim on have tended to emphasize, an institutionalized and established religion may help to integrate a society by creating common values and identification with the group. However, Merton points out, such a religion is hardly functional for dissidents who are victims of an inquisition, and religious conflicts and wars are dysfunctional for large segments of the societies involved.

In *Social Theory and Social Structure* Merton asks, "What are the consequences, functional and dysfunctional, of positive orientation to the values of a group other than one's own?" His interest in this phenomenon, labeled *anticipatory socialization*, is exemplified in a recent study by a student of Merton's Helen Rose Ebaugh. Ebaugh explores the process of role exit – disengagement from a role that is central to one's self-identity and the reestablishment of an identity in a new role that takes into account one's ex-role." Her study concerns a variety of social groups, including ex-convicts, ex-nuns, ex-alcoholics, divorced men and women, mothers without custody, ex-prostitutes, ex-air traffic controllers, and transsexuals.

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Anticipatory socialization is functional for both the aspiring individual and for the group he or she eventually enters. This is true when the seeking and weighing of role alternatives is taking place and, especially, as individuals come closer to a final decision to exit a role. Prior identification with a group serves as a kind of bridge to membership in the group. Ebaugh found, for instance, that transsexuals identified with members of the opposite sex by cross-dressing and taking on the mannerisms of the opposite sex long before they underwent sex-change surgery. She states, "In addition to shifts in orientation, attitudes, and values, individuals at this point in the process also began rehearsing the roles they were anticipating."

Herbert Gans's analysis of poverty (in his paper "The Positive Functions of Poverty") demonstrates how a Mertonian functionalist approach can produce analyses that would generally be associated with radical left conflict theory rather than conservative functionalism. Gans points out that when one distinguishes between different groups in a society, one can see that the existence of poverty serves a number of positive functions for different groups. For example, he argues, poverty ensures the existence of a group willing to serve in a peacetime army, provides the upper classes with an outlet for charity and the gratification it brings, creates jobs for people in professions and occupations that serve the poor, and makes it possible for wealthier people to get dirty jobs and personal services performed at a slight cost. These functions, he suggests, help explain why poverty exists in technologically advanced societies: those who benefit from it with the preserve it.

Merton's concept of dysfunctions is also central to his argument that functionalism is not intrinsically conservative. It appears to be only when functionalists imply that everything is generally functional in its consequences – something his concept of general dysfunctions denies – and when analysts treat society and its members as one and the same thing, a view he sets out to demolish by asking, "Functional for whom?"

At the same time Merton does retain a distinctively functional perspective. Unlike most conflict theorists, Merton believes that institutions and values can be functional (or dysfunctional) for society as a whole, not just for particular groups. He suggests that researchers should start with the hypothesis that persisting cultural forms may have a "net balance of functional consequences" for society as a unit as well as for subgroups. Merton's emphasis on dysfunctions balances Parson's concern with social functions.

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Fifthly, with the concept of dysfunctions, Merton could also silence the critics to some extent who labeled functional approach as status quoist. Critics, particularly the Marxists, had argued that with it's over emphasis on certain postulates, the functional approach manifests conservative bias by overlooking the conflict present in society and hence, fails to account for conflict led change. In other words, critics argued that the functional approach focused on the static aspects of the social structure, and has neglected the study of structural change.

Merton, however, argued that the concept of dysfunctions provides an analytical approach to the study of dynamics or change. As stated earlier, Merton suggests that functionalist should analyse any part of system from the point of view of its functional, dysfunctional or non-functional consequences. Further, consequences should also be understood at both, manifest as well as latent levels. Then, the functionalist should arrive at "net balance of functional consequences."

Merton writes: "The concept of dysfunction, which implies the concept of strain, stress and tension on the structural level, provides an analytical approach to the study of dynamics and change." In other words, Merton argues that the dysfunctional consequences generate strain or tension in the system. Thus, Merton demands that the researcher, after observing dysfunctional consequences of an item, should investigate the strain or tension generated by those dysfunctional consequences.

Sixthly, Merton states that if the dysfunctional consequences are more conspicuous for a given social item than its **functional alternative** or **functional equivalent** must be explored within the given structural constraints. To replace the idea of indispensability, Merton suggests the concept of *functional alternatives* or *functional equivalents*. According to Merton, "The utility of this concept is not to identify various arrangements with identical consequences, but rather to identify arrangements with identical or similar functions (effectiveness) but reduced dysfunctions (increased efficiency)."

Thus, with the concepts of dysfunctions and functional alternatives, Merton armoured the functionalist with the conceptual tools to account for social tension and social change.

> **Important:** Functionalism's claim of providing specific propositions about how societies work, rather than simply general suggestions about how to set about analyzing and explaining things, rests in large part on its argument that in order to persist a society must have certain characteristics; and correspondingly, all societies will exhibit these characteristics. As we have seen, this argument is central to the work of Parsons who lists such

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characteristics in his AGIL schema, and it is also apparent in the work of Durkheim.

In much of Merton's work functionalism serves more as a way of orienting oneself to one's material than as a set of propositions about the structure of societies. But Merton does share this central view, and he puts forward the concept of functional prerequisites, or "*preconditions functionally necessary for a society*." At the same time, however, he emphasizes that particular, given institutions are not the only ones able to fulfill these functions; therefore, a given social structure is in no way sacrosanct. On the contrary, a wide range of what he terms "functional alternatives," or substitutes may be able to perform the same task.

Merton's concept of functional alternatives also clarifies functionalist analysis because it explicitly rejects the idea that existing institutions are necessary and, by implication, good. Therefore, it encourages sociologists using a functionalist approach to question the indispensability of an existing social structure. For example, most functional theorists believe that religion maintains and inculcates certain norms and values central to the group and thus combats the anomie that leads to both social disintegration and personal unhappiness. However this function may be served by structures other than organized religion, and movements that might be interpreted as functional alternatives to religion seem to be cropping up almost yearly in certain parts of America, particularly in California, the birthplace of many occult and therapeutic groups.

Hence the researcher should explore the possibility of functional alternatives or equivalents, which can be substituted for the item under investigation. This focuses attention on the range of possible variations in the items which can serve the same functional requirements. For example, religion may serve the function of promoting social solidarity and regulating social control in simple, homogenous societies but in complex, modern industrial societies it may act as a source of inter-group hostility and conflict, i.e. communal violence. Thus, in modern societies, which are marked by religious diversity, secularism may serve as the functional alternative to religious ideology.

Other functional alternatives can be found among the different types of higher education and vocational training existing in modern industrial societies. All of these sort people into the adult world of work and classify them as qualified for different types of occupations. But the different ways they do so may be more or less functional for different people.

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As Burton Clark points out, American society places great emphasis on encouraging people to achieve and on ensuring equal opportunity to do so, and it practices something close to an open-door admission to college. However, in practice, not everyone can become a nuclear physicist, veterinarian, or corporate executive. Colleges impose fairly strict criteria on performance, and many students would, if they entered a four-year college, inevitably encounter standards of performance they could not meet. Using terminology derived directly from Merton's work on deviance, Clark says there is "dissociation between culturally instilled goals and institutionally provided means of realization; discrepancy between ends and means is seen as a basic social source of individual frustration."

For students who would fail in a four-year college, the two-year or community college provides a functional alternative. It performs the same function of sorting students for the labour market, and it makes it clear to less academically oriented students that certain careers are not possible for them. It does so at much less personal cost to such students, for whom the straight academic failure of the conventional college might be personally dysfunctional. Clark describes the "cooling-out" function of these colleges, which permit transfer to four-year colleges but also redirect students through testing programs and extensive counseling that serve to reorient students who need to redefine their goals. Although a four-year college is both personally functional for those who succeed scholastically and an appropriate way to train people for some careers, Clark shows how the two-year college can be a functional alternative for others because it provides alternative achievements that alleviate the personal stress caused by failure. It may also function socially by helping to prevent discontentment and deviance and by directing people successfully into other occupations.

In the wake of the contemporary women's movement, many functional alternatives to traditional marriages have emerged, such as cohabitation and gay and lesbian families. The increasing use of day care facilities and, on a much smaller scale, househusbands are examples of functional alternatives to traditional families where the mother works as housewife at home, but not in the public sphere for a wage. Other examples of functional alternatives to traditional marriages are commuting relationships, equal parenting, and greater husband participation in household work.

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Merton's notion of functional alternatives is thus important because it alerts sociologists to the similar functions different institutions may perform, and it further reduces the tendency of functionalism to imply approval of the status quo. However, Merton makes little progress in specifying what the functional prerequisites are that can be served in a variety of ways. Merton apparently does not consider Parsons's schema to be the definitive statement on the subject, but neither does he provide any concrete alternative list of his own. He recognizes the idea of functional requirements as an essential part of any functional analysis, and he refers frequently in his analysis to the degree to which society is well or poorly adjusted. But he fails to define the functional requirements for such integration. Instead he refers to them as "one of the cloudiest and empirically most debatable concepts in functional theory".

As might be expected from his remarks on middle-range theory, in general, Merton's achievement is to provide an excellent clarification of the requirements of functionalist theory and to show how a general functionalist orientation can be used fruitfully in empirical analysis, rather than to provide further general propositions about social structure and equilibrium.

Seventhly, Merton argues that functional analysis must recognize the interdependence of the elements of the social structure as well as the limited range of variation in the items which can fulfill designated functions in the social system. As Merton puts it, "Failure to recognize the relevance of interdependence and attendant structural constraints leads to utopian thought in which it is tacitly assumed that certain elements of a social system can be eliminated without affecting the rest of that system." In other words, the researcher must take into account the **structural constraints** of a given social system. The interdependence of the elements of a social system limits the possibilities of the suitable functional alternatives.

Eighthly, Merton emphasizes on the problem of the validation of various functional assumptions, postulates, imputations and observations. Merton writes: "This requires, above all, a rigorous statement of the sociological procedures of analysis which most nearly approximate the *logic* of experimentation. It requires a systematic review of the possibilities and limitations of *comparative* (cross-cultural and cross-group) *analysis*." In other words, such a functional analysis should be repeatedly subjected to validation, through comparative studies.

Last but not the least, Merton asserts that functional analysis itself has no intrinsic commitment to any ideological position.

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Functional analysis of Merton, in fact, provides a new direction to mode of sociological interpretation that tries to find out the central problems of structural functionalism and its conceptual confusion by establishing some of the essential concepts. In this connection, Merton has identified three postulates of the functional approach and provides a detailed analysis of paradigm to remove the conceptual confusion.

Consequently, structural functionalism in the form Merton gave it became a conceptual framework and a set of guidelines to be used in empirical research, rather than a theory with general explanatory claims. As such, it became a very useful tool, and it is much easier to use in conducting empirical research than general and abstract theory of Parsons.

Dear Candidate, after giving at least three readings to these notes and making notes in the 'pointer form,' please go through the questions asked in previous years and try to attempt them. Always remember that without answer-writing practice, any amount of sociological knowledge would be of little use for you in qualifying civil services examination. Thus, along with understanding the sociological ideas discussed here, you must also master the art of expressing them in your own words as per the standards of the examination and expectations of the examiner, and that too, in the given Time-and-Word Limit.

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Ghurye's views on Caste:

Ghurye in his most famous work *Caste and Race in India* (1932) traces the evolution of caste system in India. For the convenience of such historical treatment, he classifies the history of India into four periods. First, **the Vedic period** ending about B.C. 600 and comprising the literary data of the Vedic *Samhitas* and the *Brahmanas*; second, **the post-Vedic period**, extending to about the third century of the Christian era. In this period, the sacred laws of the Aryans present the orthodox and the more or less idealistic standpoint while the epics testify to the contemporary practices. Buddhist literature, on the other hand, gives a glimpse of the institution as it appeared to those who rebelled against it and in part provides us with a natural picture of some aspects of caste. The third period may be styled **the period of the *Dharma-shastras*** and ends with the tenth or eleventh century A.D. Manu, Yajnavalkya and Vishnu are the chief exponents of the social ideals of this age. The fourth period may be called **the modern period** and it brings us down to the beginning of the nineteenth century. The customs and beliefs of contemporary Hindus are those that were mostly fixed and classified by the writers of this period. The idealistic point of view is provided by writers like Parashara, Hemadri and Madhava, while the inscriptions and travellers' accounts reveal some of the realities of the times. Let me now briefly summarize the evolution of caste system in India.

'It may be taken to be an historical fact that people calling themselves 'Arya' poured into India through the north-west somewhere about 2000 B.C. It is equally clear … that an institution closely akin to caste has been very often described in Sanskrit books, which are the work of either the Aryans or the Aryan-inspired aborigines. Can we trace a close connection between the immigration of the Aryans and the rise of the institution of caste?'

Ghurye, *Caste and Race in India*

It is difficult to say that all the earliest Aryans belonged to one race, but their culture was more or less of the same type. They were distinguished by their common language. They spoke the Indo-European/Indo-Aryan languages, which are current in changed forms all over Europe, Iran and the greater part of the Indian subcontinent. Sanskrit, Latin, Greek, German, English, Swedish, Russian, Polish, Italian, Spanish, French, etc., belong to the Aryan family. On the basis of similarity between these languages, it has been postulated that the original Aryans had a common homeland somewhere in the steppes stretching from southern Russia to Central Asia. From this region the Aryan-speaking peoples may have migrated to different parts of Europe and Asia. One of their branches migrated to Iran where they lived for a long time. From the Iranian tableland they moved in the south-eastern direction towards India where they encountered the city civilization of the Indus valley. The dispersal of the Aryans in India was not a single event. It took

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place in several stages, covering several centuries and involving many tribes. These tribes were often considerably different from each other but, at the same time, shared many cultural traits.

The chief source of information on the early history of the Aryans in India are the Vedas, perhaps the oldest literary remains of the Indo-European language group. The word 'Veda' means knowledge. Vedic literature has been traditionally held scared for it is believed to have divine source. The Vedas, according to the popular Indian perception, are eternal (*nitya*). The various sages (*rishis*) who were their authors no more than received them from god. Transmitted orally from generation to generation, the Vedas were not committed to writing until very late. The collection of the Vedic hymns or *mantras* were known as the Samhitas. The Vedic texts may be divided into two broad chronological strata: the early Vedic (*c*. 1500-1000 BC) when most of the hymns of the *Rigveda* were composed; the later Vedic (*c*. 1000-600 BC) to which belong the remaining Vedas and their branches.

There are four Vedas: *Rigveda*, *Yajurveda*, *Samaveda* and *Atharvaveda*. The *Rigveda* is a collection of 1028 hymns, mostly prayers to gods, for use at sacrifices. The *Rigveda Samhita* is the oldest Vedic text, on the basis of which the early Vedic age is described. The history of the later Vedic period is based mainly on the Vedic texts which were compiled after the age of the *Rigveda*. Thus, later, for the purposes of recitation, the prayers of the Rigveda were set to tune, and this modified collection was known as the *Samaveda Samhita*. The *Yajurveda* contains not only hymns but also rituals which have to accompany their recitation. The rituals reflect the social and political milieu in which they arose. The *Atharvaveda* consists mainly of magical spells and charms to ward off evils and diseases. Attached to each Veda are various explanatory prose manuals called Brahmanas, whose concluding portions are called the Aranyakas (forest books). Secret and dangerous owing to their magical power, the Aranyakas could be taught only in a forest. The Upanishads are commentaries appended to the Aranyakas, but of a more esoteric character.

As stated earlier, we know about the Aryans in India from the *Rigveda*. The *Rigveda* is the earliest text of the Indo-European languages. It consists of ten mandalas or books of which Book II to VII form its earliest portions. Books I and X seem to have been the latest additions. The term *Arya* occurs 36 times in this text, and generally indicates a cultural community. The Aryans migrated to India in several waves. The earliest wave is represented by the Rigvedic people, who appeared in the subcontinent in about 1500 B.C. they came into conflict with the indigenous inhabitants called the Dasas, Dasyus, etc. However, it has been suggested that the conflicts between the Rigvedic tribes and the Dasas and Dasyus were those between the two main branches of the Indo-Iranian/Indo-Aryan peoples who came to India in successive waves. The Dasas and Dasyus were most likely

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people who originally belonged to the Aryan speaking stock and in course of their migration into the subcontinent they acquired cultural traits very different from those of Rigvedic people. Not surprisingly, the *Rigveda* describes them as 'black-skinned' 'malignant', and 'nonsacrificing' and speaking a language totally different from that of the Aryans.

The early Aryans, who were essentially pastoral, did not develop any political structure which could measure up to a state in either the ancient or the modern sense. Kingship was the same as tribal chiefship, the term *rajan* being used for the tribal chief. Primarily a military leader, the chief of the tribe fought for cows and not territory. He ruled over his people or tribe (*jana*) and not over any specified area of land or territory (*janapada*). The Rig Vedic people may have occasionally occupied pieces of land for grazing, cultivation and settlement, but land did not form a well-established type of private property. The people were attached to the tribe, since the territory or the kingdom was not yet established.

It is likely that the early Aryans had some consciousness of their distinctive physical appearance. They were generally fair, and the indigenous people dark in complexion. The colour of the skin may have been an important mark of their identity. This provided the context for the use of the term '*varna*'. *Varna* was the term used for colour, and it seems that the Colour may have provided the identity mark for social orders but its importance has been exaggerated by those western writers who believe in racial distinctions. But the more important factor leading to the creation of social divisions was the conquest of the Dasas and Dasyus who were assigned the status of slaves and shudras. The early signs of social divisions first appear in the *Rigveda* where it mentions *arya varna* and *dasa varna*.

The tribal chiefs and the priests acquired a larger share of the booty, and they naturally grew at the cost of their kinsmen, which created social inequalities in the tribe. Gradually the tribal society was divided into three groups– priests (*Brahma*), warriors (*Kshatra*) and the common people (*Visha*), which was primarily a functional division. The fourth division called the *Shudra* appeared only towards the end of the Rig Vedic period, because it is mentioned for the first time in the *Purushasukta* hymn of the tenth mandala or book of the Rig Veda, which is the latest addition.

In the age of the *Rigveda* differentiation based on occupation had started. The *Rigveda* mentions such artisans as the carpenter, the chariot-maker, the weaver, the leather worker, the potter, etc. This indicates that they practiced all these crafts. But this division was not very sharp. We hear of a family in which a member says: "I am a poet, my father is a physician, and my mother is a grinder. Earning livelihood through different means we live together…" Unequal

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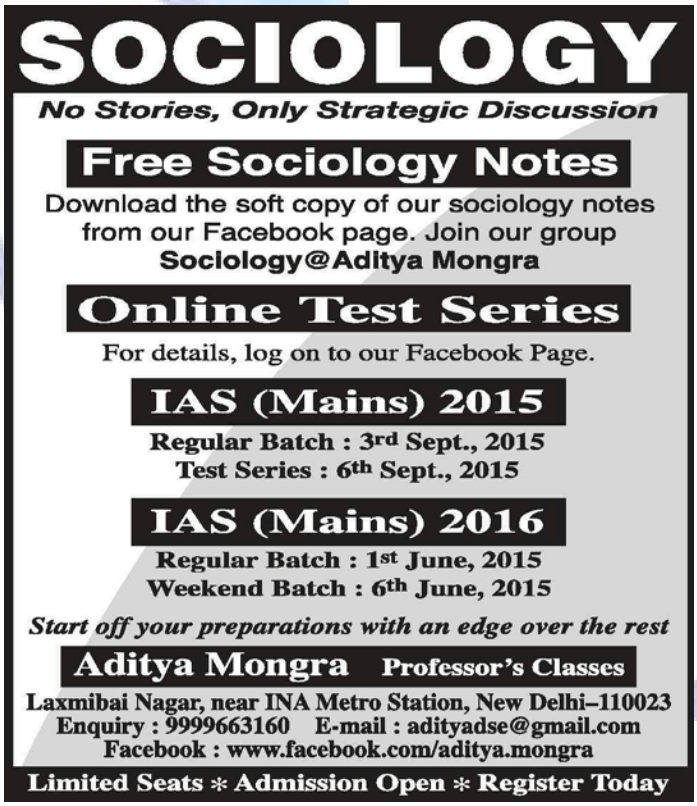
distribution of the spoils of war created social inequalities, and this helped the rise of princes and priests at the cost of the common tribal people. But since economy was mainly pastoral and subsistent in nature, the scope for collecting regular tributes from the people was very limited. We do not find gifts of land and even those of cereals are rare. Tribal elements in society were stronger and social divisions based on collection of taxes or accumulation of landed property were absent. The society was still tribal and largely egalitarian.

However, later, the fourfold social division into *brahmana*, *kshatriya*, *vaishya* and *shudra* was given religious sanction. The *Purushashukta* hymn of *Rigveda* tells us that the *brahmana* emanated from the mouth of the primeval man (*Brahma*), the *kshatriya* from his arms, the *vaishya* from his thighs and the *shudra* from his feet. The particular limbs associated with these divisions and the order in which they are mentioned probably indicate their status in the society of the time, though no such interpretation is directly given in the hymn. In this particular account of the creation not only is the origin of the classes interpreted theologically, but also a divine justification is sought to be given to their functions and status. This may be a *post facto* rationalization of the occupations and of the positions that the various groups came to occupy in the social hierarchy. Unequal distribution of the spoils of war was certainly the basic reason for the emergence of the fourfold division of society. But the phenomenon was also linked with the process of assimilation of the aboriginal non-Aryan people by the various sections of Aryan society.



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Great changes occurred in the Aryan mode of life during the later Vedic age, extending from 1000 to 600 BC when the three Vedas, *Yajur*, *Sama*, and *Atharva*, the Brahamanas and a few early Upanishads were composed. It would appear that during the period of the composition of the later Vedic texts the Aryans became generally familiar with the major portion of the Gangetic valley where they gradually settled. On the whole the later Vedic phase registered a great advance in the material life of the people. The pastoral and semi-nomadic forms of living were relegated to the background. Agriculture became the primary source of the livelihood, and life became settled and sedentary. Simultaneously with the transition from pastoral to agricultural economy there arose several new arts and crafts. Equipped with diverse arts and crafts the Vedic people now settled down permanently in the upper Gangetic plains. The peasants living in the plains produced enough to maintain themselves, and they could also spare a marginal part of their produce for the support of chiefs, prices and priests. As a result, the later Vedic period saw the beginning of territorial kingdoms. Wars were fought not only for the possession of cattle but also for that of territory. The famous Mahabharata battle, fought between the Kauravas and the Pandavas, is attributed to this period.

Settled life led to a further crystallization of the fourfold division of society. The *Shatapatha Brahmana* describes the four classes as the four *varnas*. Thus, the later Vedic society came to be divided into four *varnas* called *Brahmanas*, *Kshatriyas*, *Vaishyas* and *Shudras*. Initially one of the sixteen classes of priests, the *brahmanas* emerged as the most important class and claimed social and political privileges on account of the growing cult of sacrifice and ritual performed for their clients and patrons (mostly the rajanyas/kshatriyas). The *kshatriyas* constituted the warrior class and came to be looked on as protectors; the king was chosen from among them. The *vaishyas* devoted themselves to trade, agriculture and various crafts and were the tax-paying class. The *shudras* were supposed to serve the three higher *varnas* and formed the bulk of the laboring masses. The ideas of untouchability were first given literary expression in connection with the s*hudras* and the sacrifice. A *shudra* is declared to be unfit for sacrifice and not allowed even to be present in the hall where the sacrifice was being offered.

The priests became the chief beneficiaries of the sacrifices and gained in power. Cattle were slaughtered at sacrifices, often in large numbers. Public rituals, therefore, led to the decimation of the cattle wealth, whose importance for the developing agricultural economy can hardly be overestimated. The first reaction to the brahmanical dominance and the extremely ritualistic later Vedic religion can be seen in Upanishads, which reflect a wider spirit of enquiry prevalent towards the end of the Vedic period. Upanishadic thought centres around the idea of soul (*atman*) and not sacrifice (*yajna*). Creation is said to have grown out of the primeval desire of the World Soul. In the Upanishads we find the first clear

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exposition of belief in the passage of the soul from life to life. Souls were thought of as being born to happiness or sorrow according to their conduct in the previous life. From this evolved the theory of *karma* (action), which preached that the deeds of one life affected the next. This doctrine sought to provide an explanation of human suffering, and became fundamental to most later Indian thought.

By the time of Upanishads asceticism had become fairly widespread. Ascetics lived either as solitary hermits or in small groups away from society. Living off its resources, they could not have created a counter-culture in a real sense, as has been suggested by some scholars. Nevertheless through self-training the hermit acquired magical power, formerly ascribed to sacrifices. Asceticism thus challenged the supremacy of the Vedic sacrifice (*yajna*) and of the brahmanas who chiefly benefitted from it. The brahmanas by way of compromise invented a formula by which the life of an individual was divided into four stages (*ashramas*). First he was to be a *brahmacharin*, leading a celibate and austere life as a student at his teacher's house. Having learnt the Vedas or part of them he was married, and became a householder (*grihastha*). When well advanced in age, he withdrew from worldly life to become an ascetic (*vanaprastha*). Finally in the ultimate phase of life, having freed his soul from material ties by meditation and self-torture, he became a wandering ascetic (*sanyasin*). In this artificial scheme, asceticism was recommended at the end of a man's life so that he could discharge his social responsibilities before taking to it. The four *ashramas* were not meant for the shudras.

Education began with an investiture ceremony (*upanayana*), whereby a boy was initiated as a full member of the society. All the three higher *varnas* were entitled to *upanayana* or investiture with the sacred thread according to the Vedic mantras. The shudras were not entitled to it. Since the rite was thought of as accomplishing a second birth, members of the three higher *varnas* were described by the epithet *dvija* (twice-born). Theoretically education was open to all *dvijas*, though the Vedas tended to become an exclusive preserve of the brahmanas. With regard to shudras it was stated that a shudra trying to hear the Vedic texts shall have his ears filled with molten tin or lac; if recites the Veda his tongue shall be cut off, and if he remembers it he shall be dismembered.

We have seen that in the *Rigveda* a marked distinction was drawn between *arya varna* and *dasa varna*. In the later Vedic literature this demarcation tends to be drawn between the *dvijas* (twice-born) and *shudras*. This change is perhaps due to the increasing association between the Aryan people and the Indian aborigines resulting in illicit unions not only between Arya males and Shudra females but also between Shudra men and Arya women. Thus the primary distinction based on

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colour now gave way to the distinction based on various civil and religious disabilities.

Each order (varna) seems to have been habitually endogamous though occasionally Brahmins married Kshatriya females, and all the three higher orders now and then might have kept Shudra mistresses. Endogamy was rather a universal custom than a rigid rule of caste. The lawgivers looked upon marriage in one's own caste among the four orders as the most ideal and in a way the only recognized practice, though they were prepared to recognize marriages outside the caste as perfectly lawful. Thus, although the norms of caste endogamy were widely prevalent, Hindu scriptures by allowing ***anuloma*** and ***pratiloma*** marriages, institutionalized, to a limited extent, inter-caste marital alliances. The anuloma marriage permits an alliance between a lower class woman and higher caste man, while the pratiloma marriage is an alliance between higher caste woman and a lower caste man. The former is referred to by the sociologists as ***hypergamy*** and the latter as ***hypogamy***. In other words, hypergamy or anuloma is that form of marriage in which the ritual status of a man is higher than that of his prospective wife, while hypogamy or pratiloma is that form of marriage in which the ritual status of a woman is higher than that of her prospective husband. A*nuloma* marriages (hypergamy) though never preferred, were recognized and the offsprings treated as legitimate. But a *pratiloma* marriage was prohibited and condemned. But both forms of marriages were practiced and sometimes new castes or mixed emerged leading to confusion in social hierarchy. Both of these forms of marriages also led to caste mobility.

The institution of *gotra* appeared in later Vedic times. Literally it means the cow-pen or the place where cattle belonging to the whole clan are kept, but in course of time it signified descent from a common ancestor. People began to practice *gotra* exogamy. No marriage could take place between persons belonging to the same *gotra* or having the same lineage.

The post-Vedic period testifies to the rigid stratification and internal solidarity of the four varnas. Each group was recognized as distinct, almost complete in itself, for its social life. This period saw a great consolidation of the position of the Brahmin class, while the degradation of the Shudras comes out in marked contrast to the growing superiority of the Brahmins.

It may be inferred that many of the sub-divisions within each varna – and undoubtedly by now there must have existed in each varna numerous sub-divisions – had rules of their own for their internal management. Thus it is clear that other groups than the four traditional ones were not only in existence but had come to be recognized as *jatis*. The Brahmanic literature of the post-Vedic period, while

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reiterating that there are only four varnas, also mentions certain mixed castes (sankara jati).

In the subsequent period, the list of groups considered to have been the result of mixed unions becomes very large and includes almost all the groups, occupational or otherwise, as behaving like unit castes. Though the orthodox theory of caste is stated in terms of only the broad categories of occupations, yet there are enough indications that in daily life further distinctions based on specialization were recognized. It appears that in reality new occupational groups having the characteristics of castes had arisen, and the Brahmanic account of their origins was a mere theory based on permutations and combinations of the four original castes which bounded the Brahmin's mental horizon. Further, some of these specialized occupations seem to have been hereditary by custom.

Please note that *jatis*, depending upon their origins and the nature of their occupations, were fitted into one of these vertically graded levels. Each Varna had its own hierarchy of *jatis*. Rather than invent *jatis*, the pre-existing guilds of artisans and craftsmen and other organized occupational groups were assigned an appropriate level. Some new *jatis* were added to the system from time to time. The castes proliferated into numerous sub-castes as a result of two factors. A large number of foreigners had been assimilated into the Indian society, and each group of foreigners was considered a kind of caste. Since the foreigners mainly came as conquerors they were given the status of the kshatriya in society. The Hunas, who appeared in India towards the close of the fifth century, ultimately came to be recognized as one of the thirty-six clans of the Rajputs. Even now some Rajputs bear the title Huns. The other reason for the increase in the number of castes was the absorption of many tribal people into brahmanical society through the process of land grants. The tribal chiefs were given a respectable origin. But most of their ordinary kinsmen were given a low origin, and every tribe became a kind of caste in its new incarnation. This process continued in some ways until the present times.

As stated earlier, in the post-Vedic period, the importance of sacrifices and ritualism had been growing and with it the prestige of the priests, who were usually brahmanas. The theory of the divine origin of the four varnas is off and on repeated with the special stress on the origin of the Shudra from the feet of the Creator. Evidently this divine origin did not prove as comforting to the lower classes as could be desired in the interests of the social order. Salvation of self had come to be the outstanding problem of the philosophy of life. If the performance of the religious rites, as laid down by the sacred law, could alone lead to salvation, there was no hope for the Shudra nor even perhaps for the Vaishya, because the former was emphatically forbidden to perform these religious rites and the latter had progressively lost their practice. A philosophy of caste, guaranteeing individual

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salvation to all, through the performance of duties alone, had to be formulated. Such a theory was calculated to allay the unrest and quell the rebellion against caste that might arise owing to the unsatisfactory nature of the theory as far as salvation, which had become the most absorbing human interest, was concerned.

Buddhism, the newly emerging religion, was giving a tough challenge to orthodox Brahmanism. Buddhism was ready to incorporate people within its fold without any consideration of caste. Buddhism made an important impact on society by keeping its doors open to women and shudras. Further, Buddhism did not involve itself in the fruitless controversies regarding the soul (*atman*) and Brahma which raged strongly in those times. Buddhism advocated that salvation (*nirvana*) could be attained by an individual by his right conduct and right knowledge. With its emphasis on non-violence and the sanctity of animal life, Buddhism boosted the cattle wealth of the country. It stood in contrast to the practice of killing cattle indiscriminately in numerous Vedic sacrifices in Brahmanism. In comparison with Brahmanism, Buddhism was liberal and democratic.

To meet the Buddhist challenge, the orthodox Brahmanism formulated two slightly differing philosophies of caste. Firstly, through its *Guna* theory, Brahmanism seeks to justify the social hierarchy of varna system (hitherto taken for granted) in terms of different qualities and capacities of the individuals. In the *Bhagavadgita* the Creator is said to have apportioned the duties and functions of the four varnas according to the inherent qualities and capacities of the individuals. This theory claims that all existing things, animated and inanimated, inherent three qualities (*Gunas*) in different apportionment. *Sattva* qualities include wisdom, intelligence, honesty, goodness and other positive qualities. *Rajas* include qualities like passion, pride, valour and other passionate qualities. *Tamas* qualities include dullness, stupidity, lack of creativity and other negative qualities. Thus, brahmanas are predominated by *sattva guna*, kshatriyas by *rajas guna*, vaishyas by *rajas* and *tamas guna* and shudras by *tamas guna*. Of course, this theory fails to explain how the individuals at the very beginning of creation came to be possessed of peculiar qualities and capacities. This theory of origin, though it slurs over the above difficulty, tries to provide a rational sanction for the manifestly arbitrary divisions. God separated the people into four varnas, not merely because they were created from different limbs of his body nor again out of his will, but because he found them endowed with different qualities and capacities.

Secondly, with the doctrine of *Karma*, the lawgivers of the age propagated the view that the conscientious practice of the duties proper to one's own varna, led to a birth in a higher varna and thus to salvation. The concept of *Karma* is one of the hallmarks of Hindu social order. It refers to a belief in the efficacy of actions of a person either good or bad. *Karma* is action and the consequence of action. It is

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one of the social values stressing the individual responsibility for one's action. The doctrine of *Karma* enunciates the principle of the moral responsibility of man for his own deeds. It assumes that one's present condition is not the result of his present deeds but is also the consequence of his past life. Thus, it is closely linked to *punarjanm* (rebirth). In the *Mahabharata*, the upward march from one caste to another in succeeding births till a person is born a Brahmin is described in detail.

Popularly, Hindu religion came to be defined as *Varnashrama-dharma*. *Varnashrama-dharma*, is three words in one. *Varna* implies the caste, *ashrama* is the life stage and *dharma* is the religious duty. The whole three words translate to mean that an individual's duty depends on his caste and the respective life stage. And if an individual follows his caste duties, follows his life stage and completes his religious duties, it will bring him happiness and build up his good *Karma*. This further implies that good *Karma* individual will have a better re-birth (*samsara*). *Samsara* is a constant struggle to perfect to perfect a person's soul so that it will attain *moksha*. *Moksha* is salvation, liberation from the endless of cycle of births and deaths. It also refers to absorption of the self into eternal bliss. It is the most important goal for Hindus. It represents a spiritual perfection in which a person's soul is completely united with God.

According to Hindu texts, *Varnashrama-dharma* is not a man-made system but refers to natural classifications that appear to various degrees in all human societies. Individuals have different innate tendencies for work and exhibit a variety of personal qualities. There are also natural phases in life, when it is easier and more rewarding to perform certain activities. Hinduism teaches that individuals best realize their potential by taking into account such natural arrangements, and that society should be structured and organized accordingly.
Each *varna* and *ashrama* has its own specified *dharma*. What may be desirable for one section of society may be degrading for another. For example, absolute non-violence, which includes refraining from animal sacrifice, is essential for the priestly class but considered wholly unworthy of a *kshatriya* (warrior). Generating wealth and producing children are essential for householders, but intimate contact with money and women is spiritually suicidal for the renunciate.

Thus, according to Ghurye, caste and sub-caste integrated people into a ranked order based on norms of purity-pollution. The rules of endogamy and commensality marked off castes from each other. This was integrative instrument, which organized them into a totality or collectivity. The Hindu religion provided the conceptual and ritualistic guidelines for this integration. The Brahmins of India played a key role in legitimizing the caste ranks and orders through their interpretation of *Dharamashastras*, which were the compendia of sacred codes.

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In *Caste and Race in India* Ghurye also examines Herbert Risley's racial theory of caste in great detail through a reanalysis of the anthropometrical data. The racial theory of Indian society was promoted most notably by Risley (a colonial administrator, census officer and the first Director of Ethnography for India), who took the nasal index as an indicator of the proportion of Aryan blood, which supposedly varies along the caste gradient. Risley's racial theory of caste simply elaborated the earlier two-race theory of Indian history, in which the dark, 'snub-nosed' and primitive Dravidians were conquered by, and partially mixed with, the 'tall, fair, lepto-rhine' invading Aryans producing the caste system. This theory was encapsulated in Risley's famous formula: "The social position of a caste varies inversely as its nasal index".

Ghurye in his study found that outside the core area of Aryan settlement, 'Hindustan' (modern Punjab, Rajasthan and western Uttar Pradesh), physical type does not conform to caste rank, and that there is greater similarity between brahmins and other castes within a region than among brahmins across regions. His conclusion is that the "Brahmanic practice of endogamy must have been developed in Hindustan and thence conveyed as a cultural trait to the other areas without a large influx of the physical type of the Hindustan Brahmins". While Ghurye criticizes specific features of Risley's theory and methodology, he accepts the overall framework of racial categorization and in fact proposes new racial categories for the Indian population based on the nasal and cephalic indices. He bases his argument on the same assumptions employed by the Aryan race theory: that the 'Aryan type' is long-headed and fine-nosed, represented by the people of Punjab and Rajputana, while the 'aboriginal type', represented by the 'jungle-tribes', is broad-nosed. Ghurye adds a diffusionist element to his argument by suggesting that brahminism and caste spread throughout India as cultural traits rather than through large-scale physical migration of Aryan brahmins.

Thus we can see how Ghurye in his *Caste and Race in India* skillfully combined historical, anthropological and sociological approaches. Ghurye studied caste system from a historical, comparative and integrative perspective. Ghurye examined the caste system from both cultural and structural points of view. He not only explained the evolution of caste system but also tried to examine its contemporary features including changes in it because of the impact of British rule. Although Ghurye understood the caste system historically as the means by which diverse groups were integrated into Hindu society, he was critical of caste in its modern avatar. He was probably the first to point to the politicisation of caste groups as a result of colonial policies and practices. Ghurye condemned Risley in particular for the consolidation of caste groupings and for promoting the emergence of caste associations through his work as Census Commissioner.

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With a view to helping "us towards presenting an intelligible picture of the social grouping of that large proportion of the people of India which is organized, admittedly or tacitly, on the basis of caste" the Census Commissioner (Risley) changed the classification of 1891 into one based on "social precedence as recognized by the native public opinion at the present day and manifesting itself in the facts that particular castes are supposed to be the modern representatives of one or other of the castes of the theoretical Hindu system".

Ghurye, *Caste and Race in India*

As a result of this, Ghurye asserts, various ambitious castes quickly perceived the chances of raising their status. They invited conferences of their members, and formed councils to take steps to see that their status was recorded in the way they thought was honourable to them. Other castes that could not but resent this 'stealthy' procedure to advance, equally eagerly began to controvert their claims. Thus a campaign of mutual recrimination was set on foot. The leaders of all but the highest castes frankly looked upon the Census as an opportunity for pressing and perhaps obtaining some recognition of social claims which were denied by persons of castes higher than their own. For instance, in 1911 the Census-reporter for Madras wrote the following: "It has been pointed out to me by an Indian gentleman that the last few years, and especially the occasion of the present census, have witnessed an extraordinary revival of the caste spirit in certain aspects. For numerous caste 'Sabhas' have sprung up, each keen to assert the dignity of the social group which it represents." Ghurye argues that the result of the increasingly elaborate enumeration by caste and ranking of castes in the census was a "livening up of the caste-spirit".

Thus, on the basis of his detailed analysis, Ghurye identified six outstanding features of the Indian caste system. These features are:

1. Segmental division of society:

The segmental division of society refers to its division or compartmentalization into a number of segments or castes, each of which has a life of its own. Ghurye sees castes as social groupings or segments the membership of which is acquired and fixed by birth. Each caste provides a centre of its own regarding rules, regulations, standards of morality and justice.

2. Hierarchy:

The castes or segments are arranged in terms of a hierarchy. Hierarchy is a scheme, which arranges castes in terms of higher or superior and lower or inferior positions in relation to each other. The relative ranking of particular caste groups differed from one place to another. But, everywhere, the Brahmins

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were placed at the top and the untouchables were kept at the bottom of the hierarchy.

3. Restrictions on feeding and social intercourse:

The above two attributes reflect the separation or distance between castes. This fact of separation is reinforced by the principles of purity and pollution. The principles of purity and pollution find their expression in the codes regulating the acceptance of food or drink from other castes. In practice, most castes seem to take no objection to '*kachcha*' food or food cooked with water from a Brahmin. Higher castes (twice-born) take only '*pakka*' food or food cooked in 'ghee' from lower castes. But nobody will take food or water from an untouchable, whose even touch is considered to be polluting.

4. Civil and religious disabilities and privileges of different sections:

A result of the hierarchical division of society is that rights and obligation are unequally shared by different sections of the society. The ritual status of a caste vis-à-vis the Brahmins and the nature of occupation are the crucial determinants of the nature of these disabilities. The speech, dress and custom of the high castes could not be copied by the lower castes as by doing so they would go against the governing rule of the society. It is recorded that under the rule of the Marathas and the Peshwas, the Mahars and Mangs were not allowed within the gates of Poona after 3 p.m. and before 9 a.m. because before nine and after three their bodies cast too long a shadow, which falling on a member of the higher castes – especially Brahmin – defiles them. In the Maratha country a Mahar – one of the untouchables – might not spit on the road lest a pure-caste Hindu should be polluted by touching it with his foot, but had to carry an earthen pot, hung from his neck, in which to spit. Further, he had to drag a thorny branch with him to wipe put his footprints and to lie at a distance prostrate on the ground if a Brahmin passed by, so that his foul shadow might not defile the holy Brahmin. In the Punjab, where restrictions regarding pollution by proximity have been far less stringent than in other parts of India, a sweeper, while walking through the streets of the larger town, was supposed to carry a broom in his hand or under his armpit as a mark of his being a scavenger and had to shout out to the people warning them of his polluting presence. The schools, maintained at public cost, were practically closed to such impure caste as the Chamars and Mahars. Further, the impure castes were segregated and made to live on the outskirts of villages.

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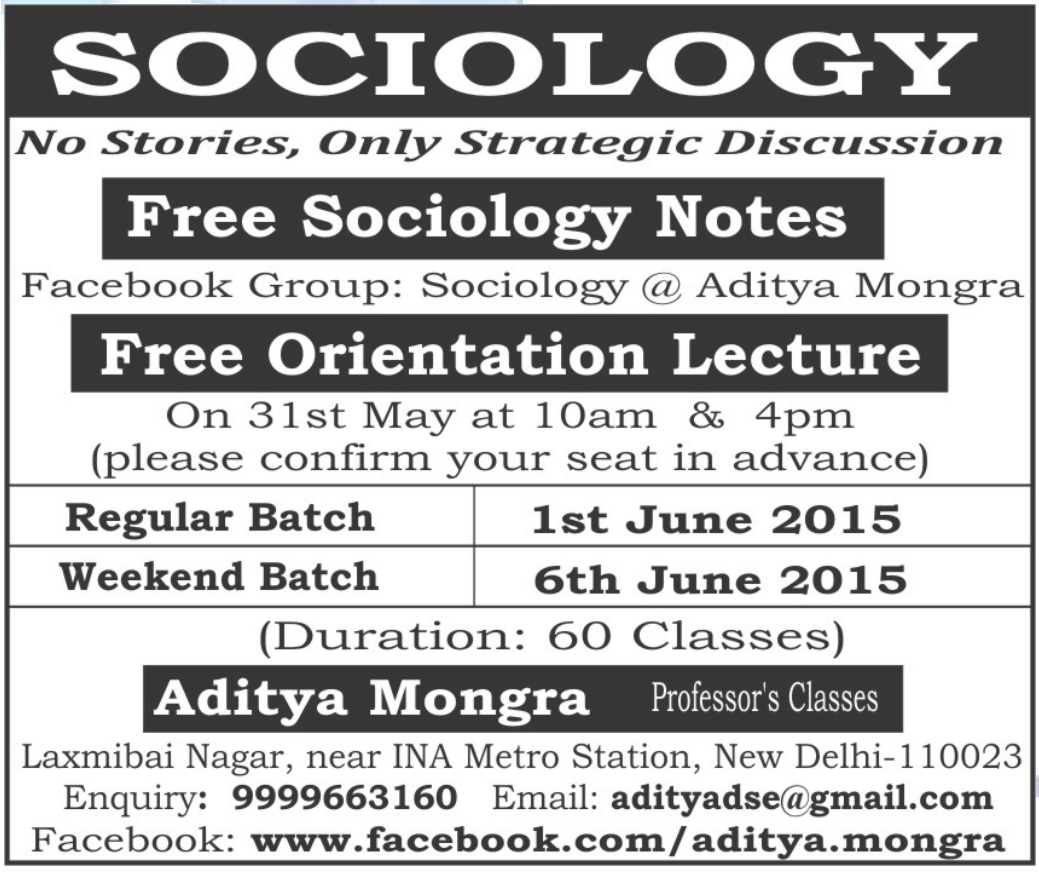
5. Lack of unrestricted choice of occupation:

Every caste or a group of allied castes was associated with a hereditary occupation. Since distinction was made between clean and unclean and therefore, between pure and impure occupations, the hereditary occupation of a caste reflected its status in society. For example, the Brahmins were engaged in priesthood, while the lower castes took up occupations such as those of barber, washer man and cobbler. The untouchable castes would be doing the most unclean jobs. Occupational differentiation has led to the birth of many sub castes. But the profession of priesthood and literary activities had remained the sole preserve of the Brahmins.

6. Restrictions on marriage:

Inter-marriage between castes was prohibited. Hence individuals married within their own caste grouping, i.e. they practiced endogamy. Every caste was segmented into smaller subdivisions or sub-castes and these were the units of endogamy. According to Ghurye, endogamy is the key factor behind the caste system.



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Major theoretical strands of research methodology

Positivism and its critique

Non-positivist methodologies

(Dear Candidate, since the above mentioned topics are conceptually interrelated, we have discussed these topics in an interlinked argument. This discussion would also help you to understand the underlying theme of ***methodological debate*** running through these topics and write an analytical answer.)

(Dear Candidate, this is the most important section in sociology. Kindly read it thoroughly. Read it as many times as possible. I guarantee that if you understand this section, you will play with sociology as most of the debates in sociological theory center around the arguments discussed in this section.)

Sociologists approach the study of human society in different ways. They can look at the "big picture" of society to see how it operates. This is a macro view focusing on the large social phenomena of society such as social institutions and inequality. Sociologists can also take a micro view, zeroing in on the immediate social situations in which people interact with one another. From these two views, sociologists have developed various theoretical perspectives, each a set of general assumptions about the nature of society.

To help understand the beginners, these major theoretical strands could broadly be classified into two major approaches in sociology. These are the **Structural approach** (also called as macro sociology) and the **Social Action approach** (also called as the interpretive, phenomenological, anti/non-positive or micro sociology). Structural and social action approaches to the study and research of society exhibit two major differences. One involves how they conceive of society, the social world itself. In other words, they completely disagree on the question of what society is. The second question follows from the first. It concerns the question of how we are to conduct our research into the social world. That is, because structural and social action sociology have very different ideas of what society in fact is, they also have very different ideas about research method which are most appropriate to the conduct of research into social life. This is why we can say that how we conceive of society cannot be separated from the question of how we should proceed in our study of it. (You must understand this point very clearly

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because this links the theoretical perspectives with the research methodology. It will become more clear as we proceed with our discussion.)

Let us now discuss these two major theoretical strands, and the various sociological perspectives and approaches that fall under their respective domain.

Structural approach is a macro-sociological analysis, with a broad focus on social structures that shape society as a whole. Structural approach analyses the way society as a whole fits together. Structural theory sees society as a system of relationships that creates the structure of the society in which we live. It is this structure that determines our lives and characters. Structured sets of social relationships are the 'reality' that lie below the appearance of 'the free individual'.

Important: Social structure refers to the pattern of interrelations between individuals. Every society has a social structure, a complex of major institutions, groups, and arrangements, relating to status and power. In a society individuals interact with one another for the fulfilment of their needs. In this process, they occupy certain status and roles in social life with accompanying rights and obligations. Their social behaviour is patterned and gets associated with certain norms and values which provide them guidance in social interaction. There emerge various social units, such as groups, community, association and institutions in society as a product of social intercourse in human life. In this scenario, social structure is conceived as the pattern of inter-related statuses and roles found in a society, constituting a relatively stable set of social relations. It is the organized pattern of the inter-related rights and obligations of persons and groups in a system of interaction.

In order to systematically understand the structure of a society, let us first assume the structure of a building. The structure of a human society is similar to the structure of a building. The structure of any given building primarily has three components viz. (i) the building material such as bricks, mortars, beams and pillars, (ii) all these are arranged in a definite order and are placed in relationship to one another, and (iii) all these put together make a building one unit. The same three sets of features can be used to describe the structure of a society as well. A human society also consists of (i) males and females, adults and children, various occupational and religious groups and so on, (ii) the interrelationship between various parts (such as relationship between husband and wife, between parents and children and between various groups), and (iii) all the parts of the society are put together to work as a unit.

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Philip Jones in his *Theory and Method in Sociology* (1987) argues that the structuralist sociologists look at society as 'a structure of (cultural) rules', guiding our behaviour and telling us how to behave appropriately in any given situation and what to expect in terms of the behaviour of others. Thus, the structural sociology is based on the premise that society comes before individuals. This general idea – that sociologists should study the way society impacts on individual behaviour – represents the main way structuralist sociologists differ from social action sociologists. Further, with these assumptions about the social reality, the structural theorists argue that there can be a sociology which is a science. In other words, sociology can be a science of society just as, for example, nuclear physics is the science of the structure of matter –of atoms, neutrons, electrons, and so on. Structural theorists conceive society as an objective phenomenon, a 'thing'. In other words, just as natural sciences study the structure and composition of matter, sociology too can identify and objectively study the social structure and its various constituents such as shared norms, values, attitudes and beliefs, etc. Hence the structural theorists argue that the study of the social world can be modeled on the study of natural phenomena and the scientific methodology of natural sciences can be adopted to study the social phenomena. Thus, we can conclude that structural approaches are **positivist** in nature. Before moving further, let us discuss the concept of Positivism and the positivist approach in sociology.

Many of the founding fathers of sociology believed that it would be possible to create a science of society such as chemistry and biology. This approach is known as positivism. Auguste Comte (1798-1857), who is credited with inventing the term sociology and regarded as one of the founders of the discipline, maintained that the application of the methods and assumptions of the natural sciences would produce a 'positive science of society'. He believed that this would reveal that the evolution of society followed 'invariable laws'. It would show that the behaviour of man was governed by principles of cause and effect which were just as invariable as the behaviour of matter, the subject of the natural sciences. In terms of sociology, the positive approach makes the following assumptions. The behaviour of man, like the behaviour of matter, can be objectively measured. Just as the behaviour of matter can be quantified by measures such as weight, temperature and pressure, methods of objective measurement can be devised for human behaviour. Observations of behaviour based on objective measurement will make it possible to produce statements of cause and effect. Theories may then be devised to explain observed behaviour. This emphasis on the objective measurement of human social behaviour forces the positivist scholars to rely more on the **quantitative methods** while conducting research. You will read more on 'Quantitative methods' in our subsequent discussion on Research Methods and Analysis.

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The positivist approach in sociology places particular emphasis on behaviour that can be directly observed. It argues that factors which are not directly observable, such as meanings, feelings and purposes, are not particularly important and can be misleading. The positivists' emphasis on observable 'facts' is due largely to the belief that human behaviour can be explained in much the same way as the behaviour of matter. Natural scientists do not inquire into the meanings and purposes of matter for the obvious reason of their absence. Atoms and molecules do not act in terms of meanings, they simply react to external stimuli. Thus if heat, an external stimulus, is applied to matter, that matter will react. The job of the natural scientist is to observe, measure, and then explain that reaction. The positivist approach to human behaviour applies a similar logic. Men react to external stimuli and their behaviour can be explained in terms of this reaction. For example they enter into marriage and produce children in response to the demands of society. Society requires such behaviour for its survival and its members simply respond to this requirement. The meanings and purposes they attach to this behaviour are largely inconsequential.

Thus, it has often been argued that the structural theory (also called systems theory) in sociology adopts a positivist approach. Once behaviour is seen as a response to some external stimulus, such as economic forces or the requirements of the social system, the methods and assumptions of the natural sciences appear appropriate to the study of man. Marxism has often been regarded as a positivist approach since it can be argued that it sees human behaviour as a reaction to the stimulus of the economic infrastructure. Functionalism has been viewed in a similar light. The behaviour of members of society can be seen as a response to the functional prerequisites of the social system. These views of the structural (or systems) theory represent a considerable oversimplification of complex theories; however, it is probably fair to say that they are closer to a positivist approach.

In sociology, there are two main structural approaches:

i. Consensus theory (Functionalism)
ii. Conflict theory (Marxism)

Functionalism: The consensus approach

Functional analysis also known as functionalism and structural functionalism is rooted in the origin of sociology. It is prominent in the work of Auguste Comte (1798-1857) and Herbert Spencer (1820-1903), two of the founding fathers of the discipline. It was developed by Emile Durkheim (1858-1917) and refined by Talcott Parsons (1902-79).

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Functionalism was the dominant theoretical perspective in sociology during the 1940s and 1950s. From the mid 1960s onwards, its popularity steadily declined due partly to damaging criticism and partly to competing perspectives which appeared to provide superior explanations.

The key points of the functionalist perspective may be summarized by a comparison drawn from biology. If a biologist wanted to know how an organism such as the human body worked, he might begin by examining the various parts such as the brain, lungs, heart and liver. However, if he simply analysed the parts in isolation from each other, he would be unable to explain how life was maintained. To do this, he would have to examine the parts in relation to each other since they work together to maintain the organism. Thus he would analyze the relationship between the heart, lungs, brain and so on to understand how they operated and appreciate their importance. From this viewpoint, any part of the organism must be seen in terms of the organism as a whole. Functionalism adopts a similar perspective. The various parts of society are seen to be interrelated and taken together, they form a complete system. To understand any part of society, such as the family or religion, the part must be seen in relation to society as a whole. Thus where a biologist will examine a part of the body, such as the heart, in terms of its contribution to the maintenance of the human organism, the functionalist will examine a part of society, such as the family, in terms of its contribution to the maintenance of the social system.

Functionalism begins with the observation that behaviour in society is structured. This means that relationships between members of society are organized in terms of rules. Social relationships are therefore patterned and recurrent. Values provide general guidelines for behaviour and they are translated into more specific directives in terms of roles and norms. The structure of society can be seen as the sum total of normative behaviour – the sum total of social relationships which are governed by norms. The main parts of society, its institutions, such as the family, the economy, the educational and political systems are major aspects of the social structure. Thus an institution can be seen as a structure made up of interconnected roles or interrelated norms. For example, the family is made up of the interconnected roles of husband, father, wife, mother, son and daughter. Social relationships within the family are structured in terms of a set of related norms.

Having established the existence of a social structure, functionalist analysis turns to a consideration of how that structure functions. This involves an examination of the relationship between the different parts of the structure and their relationship to society as a whole. From this examination, the functions of institutions are discovered. At its simplest, function means effect. Thus the

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function of the family is the effect it has on other parts of the social structure and on society as a whole. In practice the term function is usually used to indicate the contribution an institution makes to the maintenance and survival of the social system. Thus a major function of the family is the socialization of new members of society. This represents an important contribution to the maintenance of society since order, stability and cooperation largely depend on learned, shared norms and values.

In determining the function of various parts of the social structure, functionalists are guided by the following ideas. Societies have certain basic needs or requirements which must be met if they are to survive. These requirements are sometimes known as **functional prerequisites**. For example, a means of producing food and shelter may be seen as a functional prerequisite since without them members of society could not survive. A system for socializing new members of society may also be regarded as a functional prerequisite since without culture social life would not be possible. Having assumed a number of basic requirements for the survival of society, the next step is to look at the parts of the social structure to see how they meet such functional prerequisites. Thus a major function of the economic system is the production of food and shelter. An important function of the family is the socialization of new members of society.

From a functionalist perspective, society is regarded as a system. A system is an entity made up of interconnected and interrelated parts. From this viewpoint, it follows that each part will in some way affect every other part and the system as a whole. It also follows that if the system is to survive, its various parts must have some degree of fit or compatibility. Thus a functional prerequisite of society involves a minimal degree of integration between the parts. Many functionalists argue that this integration is based largely on **'value consensus'**, that is on agreement about values by members of society. Thus if the major values of society are expressed in the various parts of the social structure, those parts will be integrated. For example, it can be argued that the value of materialism integrates many parts of the social structure in Western industrial society. The economic system produces a large range of goods and ever increasing productivity is regarded as an important goal. The educational system is partly concerned with producing the skills and expertise to expand production and increase it efficiency. The family is an important unit of consumption with its steadily increasing demand for consumer durables such as washing machines, televisions and three-piece suits. The political system is partly concerned with improving material living standards and raising productivity. To the extent that these parts of the social structure are based on the same value, they may be said to be integrated.

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One of the main concerns of functionalist theory is to explain how social life is possible. The theory assumes that a certain degree of order and stability are essential for the survival of social systems. Functionalism is therefore concerned with society. Many functionalists see shared values as the key to this explanation. **Thus value consensus integrates the various parts of society.** It forms the basis of social unity or social solidarity since individuals will tend to identify and feel kinship with those who share the same values as themselves. Value consensus provides the foundation for cooperation since common values produce common goals. Members of society will tend to cooperate in pursuit of goals which they share. Having attributed such importance to value consensus, many functionalists then focus on the question of how this consensus is maintained. Indeed the American sociologist Talcott Parsons has stated that the main task of sociology is to examine 'the institutionalization of patterns of value orientation in the social system'. Emphasis is therefore placed on the process of socialization whereby values are internalized and transmitted from one generation to the next. In this respect, the family is regarded as a vital part of the social structure. Once learned, values must be maintained. In particular those who deviate from society's values must be brought back into line. Thus the mechanisms of social control are seen as essential to the maintenance of social order.

In summary, society, from a functionalist perspective, is a system made up of interrelated parts. The social system has certain basic needs which must be met if it is to survive. These needs are known as functional prerequisites. The function of any part of society is its contribution to maintenance of society. The major functions of social institutions are those which help to meet the functional prerequisites of society. Since society is a system, there must be some degree of integration between its parts. A minimal degree of integration is therefore a functional prerequisite of society. Many functionalists maintain that the order and stability they see as essential for the maintenance of the social system are largely provided by value consensus. An investigation of the source of value consensus is therefore a major concern of functionalist analysis.

However, with their concern for investigating how functional prerequisites are met, functionalists have concentrated on functions rather than dysfunctions. This emphasis has resulted in many institutions being seen as beneficial and useful to society. Indeed some institutions, such as the family, religion, and social stratification, have been seen as not only beneficial but indispensable. This view has led critics to argue that **functionalism has a built in conservative bias** which supports the status quo. The argument that certain social arrangements are beneficial or indispensable provides support for their retention and rejects proposals for radical change.

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Marxism: The conflict approach

The conflict perspective produces a portrait of society strikingly different from that offered by functionalism. Whereas functionalism emphasizes society's stability, the conflict perspective portrays society as always changing and always marked by conflict. Functionalists tend to focus on social order, to view social change as harmful, and to assume that the social order is based largely on people's willing cooperation. In contrast, proponents of the conflict perspective are inclined to concentrate on social conflict, to see social change as beneficial, and to assume that the social order is forcibly imposed by the powerful on the weak. They criticize the status quo.

The conflict theorists stress inequalities and regard society as a system made of individual and groups which are competing for scarce resources. These groups may form alliances or co-operate with one another, but underneath the surface harmony lies a basic competitive struggle to gain control over scarce resources. Conflict theorists also focus on macro level. In modern society, Karl Marx (1818-83) focused on struggle between the bourgeoisie (owners of production) and proletariat (those who worked for the owners), but today's conflict theorists have expanded this perspective to include smaller groups and even basic relationships.

The conflict perspective originated largely from Karl Marx's writings on class conflict between capitalists and the proletariat. For decades, U.S. sociologists tended to ignore Marx and the conflict perspective because the functionalist perspective dominated their view of society. Since the turbulent 1960s, however, the conflict perspective has gained popularity. Generally, conflict is now defined more broadly. Whereas Marx believed that conflict between *economic* classes was the key force in society, conflict theorists today define social conflict to mean conflict between any *unequal* groups or societies. Thus, they examine conflict between whites and blacks, men and women, one religious group and another, one society and another, and so on. They emphasize that groups or societies have conflicting interests and values and complete with each other for scarce resources. The more powerful groups gain more than the less powerful, but the former continue to seek more wealth and power, while the latter continue to struggle for more resources. Because of this perpetual competition, society or the world is always changing.

The conflict perspective leads sociologists to ask such questions as: which groups are more powerful and which are more weak? How do powerful group benefit from the existing social order, and how are weaker groups hurt? Consider, for example, how the conflict perspective can shed light on prostitution. According to this perspective, prostitution reflects the unequal social positions of men and

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women. In prostitution, members of a dominant group, men, benefit from the exploitation of a weaker group, women. This exploitation is made possible by the existence of a social order in which women are subordinate to men. If the sexes were treated equally – with women having full access to and being equally paid for more respectable types of work as men – women would be unlikely to become prostitutes. Prostitution further reinforces the general dominance of men over women because it helps perpetuate the sexist idea that women are inferior beings who can be used as mere objects for pleasure. In short, prostitution reflects and reinforces the power of one group over another. (You will read more on Marx and his ideas in our discussion on Sociological Thinkers.)

Until now we have discussed the Structural approach, one of the two major strands in sociological theory. While discussing structural approach, we have discussed two main structural approaches in sociology, viz. Consensus theory (Functionalism) and Conflict theory (Marxism). We have also discussed that how these structural approaches are largely positivist in nature. Now, let us discuss the other major strand in sociological theory, that is, the Social Action approach.

As a student of sociology, you must remember that not all sociological perspectives base their analysis upon an examination of the structure of society as a whole. Rather than seeing human behaviour as being largely determined by society, they see society as being the product of human activity. They stress the meaningfulness of human behaviour, denying that it is primarily determined by the structure of society. These approaches are known as social action theory. Max Weber was the first sociologist to advocate a social action approach. In contemporary sociology there are two main varieties of this type of sociology. These are **Symbolic Interactionism** and **Ethnomethodology**. However, before we discuss these approaches in detail, let us first try to understand the general assumptions about social reality that underlie the social action approach.

Social action approach (also called as the phenomenological, interpretive, anti/non-positive or micro sociology) in sociology rejects many of the assumptions of positivism. Social action theorists argue that the subject matter of the social and natural sciences is fundamentally different. As a result the methods and assumptions of the natural sciences are inappropriate to the study of man. The natural sciences deal with matter. To understand and explain the behaviour of matter it is sufficient to observe it from the outside. Atoms and molecules do not have consciousness. They do not have meanings and purposes which direct their behaviour. Matter simply reacts 'unconsciously' to external stimuli; in scientific language it behaves. As a result the natural scientist is able to observe, measure, and impose an external logic on that behaviour in order to explain it. He has no

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need to explore the internal logic of the consciousness of matter simply because it does not exist.

Unlike matter, man has consciousness – thoughts, feelings, meanings, intentions and an awareness of being. Because of this, his actions are meaningful, he defines situations and gives meaning to his actions and those of others. As a result, he does not merely react to external stimuli, he does not simply behave, he acts. Imagine the response of early man to fire caused by volcanoes or spontaneous combustion. He did not simply react in a uniform manner to the experience of heat. He attached a range of meanings to it and these meanings directed his actions. For example he defined fire as a means of warmth and used it to ward off wild animals; and as a means of transforming substance and employed it for cooking and hardening the points of wooden spears. Man does not just react to fire, he acts upon it in terms of the meanings he gives to it. If actions stems from subjective meanings, it follows that the sociologist must discover those meanings in order to understand action. He cannot simply observe action from the outside and impose an external logic upon it. He must interpret the internal logic which directs the actions of the actor.

Max Weber (1864-1920) was one of the first sociologists to outline this perspective in detail. He argued that sociological explanations of actions should begin with 'the observation and theoretical interpretation of the subjective "states of minds" of actors'. Interactionism adopts a similar approach with particular emphasis on the process of interaction. Where positivists emphasize facts and cause and effect relationships, interactionists emphasize insight and understanding. Since it is not possible to get inside the heads of actors, the discovery of meaning must be based on interpretation and intuition. For this reason objective measurement is not possible and the exactitude of the natural science cannot be duplicated. Since meanings are constantly negotiated in ongoing interaction process it is not possible to establish simple cause and effect relationships. Thus some sociologists argue that sociology is limited to an interpretation of social action and hence the social action approaches are also sometimes referred to as 'interpretive sociology'.

A number of sociologists have argued that the positivist approach has produced a distorted picture of social life. They see it as tending to portray man as a passive responder to external stimuli rather than an active creator of his own society. Man is pictured as reacting to various forces and pressures, to economic infrastructures and the requirements of social systems. Peter Berger argues that society has often been viewed as a puppet theatre with its members portrayed as 'little puppets jumping about on the ends of their invisible strings, cheerfully acting out the parts that have been assigned to them'. Society instills values, norms and

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roles, and men dutifully respond like puppets on a string. However, from a social action perspective, man does not merely react and respond to an external society, he is not simply acted upon, he acts. In his interaction with others he creates his own meanings and constructs his own reality and therefore directs his own actions.

The distinction between positivist and anti-positivist (or phenomenological) approaches is not as clear cut as this section has implied. There is considerable debate over whether or not a particular theory should be labeled positivist or anti-positivist (or phenomenological). Often it is a matter of degree since many theories lie somewhere between the two extremes.

Let us now discuss symbolic interactionism and ethnomethodology, the two major social action approaches in detail.

As discussed earlier, both functionalist and conflict perspectives focus on larger social forces of order and conflict, forces that simultaneously affect huge numbers of people across the country. In contract, the symbolic interactionist perspective directs our attention to the details of a specific situation and the interaction between individuals in that situation. The combination of these countless interactions in various situations is seen to constitute society. We can trace the origins of symbolic interactionism to Max Weber's argument that people act according to their interpretation of the meaning of their social world. But it was **George Herbert Mead** (1863-1931), an American philosopher, who introduced symbolic interactionism to sociology in the 1920s.

According to symbolic interactionism, people assign meanings to each other's words and actions. Our response to a person's action is therefore determined not by that person's action in itself but by our *subjective interpretation* of the action. When we speak to a friend, an observer can easily give an objective report of the words we have said. But friend's response will depend not on the words we spoke but on his or her interpretation of the entire interaction; at the same time, out friend's response is influencing what we are saying. If our friend perceives by the way we speak that we are intelligent, this interpretation may make our friend respect and admire us and, perhaps, respond more positively to what we are saying. If we, in turn, catch this interpretation, we may feel proud and speak more confidently. In other words, the exchange is a *symbolic interaction*. It is an interaction between individuals that is governed by their interpretation of the meaning of symbols. In this case, the symbols are primarily spoken words. But a symbol can be anything – an object, a sound, a gesture – that points to something beyond itself. The marks on this paper are symbols because they point to things – they have meanings – beyond black squiggles.

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The symbolic interactionist perspective suggests two things. First, people do not respond directly to physical things. Rather, they respond to their own interpretations of them. Second, because people constantly impose interpretations – on the world in general, on other people, themselves, and even their own interpretations – and then act accordingly, human behaviour is fluid, always changing. How we act is constantly being altered by how we interpret other people's actions and their reactions to our own behaviour. Human behaviour is thus not real in itself but becomes real only after it has been subjected to *reality construction*, the process by which we interpret what a given action means and respond to it in accordance with the interpretation. The symbolic interactionist perspective has been criticized, however, for ignoring the larger issues of national and international order and change. It has also been faulted for ignoring the influence of larger social forces, such as social institutions, groups, cultures, and societies, on individual interactions.

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Ethnomethodology is the most recent of all the theoretical perspectives discussed so far. The term was coined by the American sociologist Harold Garfinkel who is generally regarded as its founder. Garfinkel's book, *Studies in Ethnomethodology*, which provided the initial framework for the perspective was published in 1967. Roughly translated ethnomethodology means the study of the methods used by people. It is concerned with examining the methods and procedures employed by members of society to construct, account for and give meaning to their social world. Ethnomethodologists draw heavily on the European tradition of phenomenological philosophy and in particular acknowledge a debt to the ideas of the philosopher–sociologist Alfred Schutz (1899-1959). Many ethnomethodologists begin with the assumption that society exists only in so far as members perceive its existence. (The term member replaces the interactionist term actor.) With this emphasis on members' views of social reality, ethnomethodology is generally regarded as a phenomenological approach. Ethnomethodology is a developing perspective which contains a diversity of viewpoints. The following account provides a brief and partial introduction.

One of the major concerns of sociology is the explanation of social order. From the results of numerous investigations it appears that social life is ordered and regular and that social action is systematic and patterned. Typically the sociologist has assumed that social order has an objective reality. His research has apparently indicated that it actually exists. He then goes on to explain its origin, to provide causal explanations for its presence. Thus from a functionalist perspective, perspective, social order derives ultimately from the functional prerequisites of social systems which require its presence as a necessary condition of their existence. Social action assumes its systematic and regular nature from the fact that it is governed by values and norms which guide and direct behaviour. From a Marxian perspective social order is seen as precarious but its existence is recognized. It results from the constraints imposed on members of society by their position in the relations of production and from the reinforcement of these constraints by the superstructure. From an interactionist perspective, social order results from interpretive procedures employed by actors in interactions. It is a 'negotiated order' in that it derives from meanings which are negotiated in the process of interaction and involves the mutual adjustment of the actors concerned. The net result is the establishment of social order, of an orderly, regular and patterned process of interaction. Although the above perspectives provide very different explanations for social order, they nevertheless agree that some form of order actually exists and that it therefore has an objective reality.

Ethnomethodologists either suspend or abandon the belief that an actual or objective social order exists. Instead they proceed from the assumption that social life appears orderly to members of society. Thus in the eyes of members their

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everyday activities seem ordered and systematic but this order is not necessarily due to the intrinsic nature or inherent qualities of the social world. In other words it may not actually exist. Rather it may simply appear to exist because of the way members perceive and interpret social reality. Social order therefore becomes a convenient fiction, an appearance of order constructed by members of society. This appearance allows the social world to be described and explained and so made knowable, reasonable, understandable and 'accountable' to its members. The methods and accounting procedures used by members for creating a sense of order form the subject matter of ethnomethodological enquiry. Zimmerman and Wieder state that the ethnomethodologist is concerned with how members of society go about the task of *seeing*, *describing*, and *explaining* order in the world in which they live.

Garfinkel argues that members employ the 'documentary method' to make sense and account for the social world and to give it an appearance of order. This method consists of selecting certain aspects of the infinite number of features contained in any situation or context, of defining them in a particular way and seeing them as evidence of an underlying pattern. The process is then reversed and particular instances of the underlying pattern are then used as evidence for the existence of the pattern. Ethnomethodologists are highly critical of other branches of sociology. They argue that 'conventional' sociologists have misunderstood the nature of social reality. They have treated the social world as if it had an objective reality which is independent of members' accounts and interpretations. By contrast, ethnomethodologists argue that the social world consists of nothing more than the constructs, interpretations and accounts of its members. The job of the sociologist is therefore to explain the methods and accounting procedures which members employ to construct their social world. According to ethnomethodologists, this is the very job that mainstream sociology has failed to do.

Important: Dear students, after reading about these different perspectives, you may ask: Which one is right? The answer can be found in the following story from sociologist Elliot Liebow (1993):

Mr. Shapiro and Mr. Goldberg had an argument they were unable to resolve.
It was agreed that Mr. Shapiro would present the case to a rabbi.
The rabbi said to Mr. Shapiro, "You are right."
When Mr. Goldberg learned of this, he ran to the rabbi with his version of the argument. The rabbi said to him, "You are right."
Then the rabbi's wife said to the rabbi, "You told Mr. Shapiro he was right and you told Mr. Goldberg he was right. They can't both be right!"
The rabbi said to his wife, "You are right too."

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As the rabbi would say, each of the three perspectives in sociology is right in its own way. Each shows what our world looks like, but only when viewed from a certain angle. Although different, the three perspectives are not really incompatible. To some extent, they are like different perspectives on a house. Looked at from the front, the house has a door, windows, and a chimney on top. From the back, it has a door and a chimney on top but probably fewer windows and may be a porch. From the top, it has no doors or windows, but it has a chimney in the middle. It is the same house, but it looks very different, depending on perspective. Similarly, whether we see functions, conflict, or interaction depends on the position from which we are looking. Each perspective is useful because we cannot take everything about the complex social world into account at once. We need some vantage point. Each perspective tells us what to look for, and each brings some aspect of society and human behaviour into sharper focus. Brought together, these diverse perspectives can enrich our sociological knowledge of the world.

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Marriage

Marriage is an important and universal social institution of society. As a social institution, it provides a recognized form for entering into a relatively enduring heterosexual relationship for the bearing and rearing of children. It is thus primarily a way of regulating human reproduction. This reproduction, however, also has a sociological dimension. The right of sexual relationship, that universally accompanies marriage, provides legitimization to the children born in wedlock; this legitimacy is of great importance in the matter of inheritance and succession. Besides, through marriage there comes into existence the family, a relatively stable social group that is responsible for the care and training of children. In all these respects, then, marriage has historically provided the institutional mechanisms necessary for replacement of social members and thereby has been meeting the important prerequisites of human survival and society's continuance.

According to **Horton** and **Hunt**, "Marriage is the approved social pattern whereby two or more persons establish a family." **Edward Westermarck** defined marriage as "more or less durable connection between male and female, lasting beyond the mere act of propagation till after the birth of offspring." **Malinowski** defined marriage as "a contract for the production and maintenance of children." Various anthropologists have attempted to trace the history of this institution of marriage but there is no consensus among them. For example, **Lewis Morgan** in his evolutionary theory concludes that in the earlier form of groupings of people, sex was absolutely un-regulated and the institution of family was not known. Believing that human societies have evolved from lower to higher types, Morgan set forth certain hypothetical stages in the evolution of marriage. Accordingly, as he thought, from the hypothetical state of promiscuity society must have evolved into group marriage, then polygamy and lastly monogamy. **Westermark** on the other hand, is of the opinion that the history of marriage began with its monogamous form. He concludes this on the basis of his assumption that the male has by nature been an acquisitive and possessive creature. Another anthropologist **Robert Briffault** claims that at the initial stage of marital relationship, mother had the supreme authority. He rejects patriarchy as claimed by Morgan and monogamy as claimed by Westermark to be the initial forms of marriage and family.

All societies have prescriptions and proscriptions regarding who may or may not marry whom. In some societies these restrictions are subtle, while in some others, individuals who can or cannot be married are more explicitly and specifically defined. Forms of marriage based on rules governing eligibility/ineligibility of mates is classified as endogamy and exogamy. **Endogamy** requires an individual to marry within a culturally defined group of which he is already a member, as for example caste, religion or tribe, etc. Caste

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and religious endogamy are the most pervasive forms of endogamy. Most religious groups do not permit or like their members to marry individuals of other faiths. Endogamy is also a very important characteristic of the Indian caste system. **Exogamy**, on the other hand, requires the individual to marry outside of his own group. Exogamy refers to the rules of avoidance in marital relationship. Every community prohibits its members from having marital relationship with certain persons. The exogamy in one form or the other is practised in every community. Under this rule, marriage among close relative especially kins and same clan is prohibited. For example, in China, the individuals who bear the same surname may not inter-marry. In Hindu marriage, Gotra and Sapinda are such exogamous groups. Gotra refers to a group of families which trace their origin from a common mythical ancestor. Sapinda means that persons of seven generations on the father's side and five on the mother's side cannot inter-marrry.

Incest taboo is perhaps the most prominent feature of exogamic rule of mate-selection in almost every society. Marriage of father-daughter, mother-son, brother-sister is unknown the world over. Prohibition of sex relationship between such primary kins is called incest taboo. There are sociological, psychological and also scientific reasons for the institution of incest taboo. The exogamic rules are designed to restrict free marriage relationship. The incest taboos, according to **Kingsley Davis**, confine sexual relations and sentiments to the married pairs alone excluding such relationships as between parent and child, brother and sister etc. In this way the possibility of confusion in the organization of kinship is prevented and the family organization is maintained. Quite often, a scientific justification is also provided for keeping restrictions of incest taboo. Eugenically, there is a fear of a possibility that certain physiological inadequacies present among close kins such as cousins may be perpetuated and transferred to their off-springs in case the former inter-marry.

Generally, there are two forms of marriage prevalent in different parts of world: (i) monogamy and (ii) polygamy. **Monogamy** restricts the individual to one spouse at a time. Under this system, at any given time a man can have only one wife and a woman can have only one husband. Monogamy is prevalent in all societies and is almost the universal form in all modern industrial societies. In many societies, individuals are permitted to marry again often on the death of the first spouse or after divorce; but they cannot have more than one spouse at one and the same time. Such monogamy marriage is termed as ***serial monogamy***. A society may also practice ***straight monogamy***, in which remarriage is not allowed. Most upper caste Hindu females were obliged to follow the norm of straight monogamy prior to the enactment of **Widow Remarriage Act of 1856**, as until then widows were not allowed to marry again. With further modernisation societies are likely to

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move towards the conditions of serial monogamy, rather than maintain straight monogamy.

Polygamy is that arrangement of marriage in which either a woman has more than one husband or a man has more than one wife. The former arrangement is called **polyandry** and the latter **polygyny**. Of the two forms of polygamy, polygyny is much more prevalent than polyandry the world over. **Murdock's** research, based on an analysis of 283 societies, revealed that 193 of these were characterised by polygyny, 43 were monogamous and only 2 practiced polyandry.

The **Hindu Marriage Act** of **1955** established monogamy for all Hindus and others who came to be governed by this Act. Some of the 'other' communities covered by this Act are the **Sikhs**, **Jains** and **Buddhists**. Strict monogamy is also prescribed in Christian and Parsi communities. Islam, on the other hand, has allowed polygyny. A Muslim man can have as many as four wives at a time, provided all are treated as equals. However, it seems that even among the Muslims, polygynous unions are now restricted only to a small section of society. In India, polygyny is also found among the Naga tribes, the Gond, the Baiga, the Toda, the Lushei clans and most of the other Proto-Australoid tribes of Middle India. The Khasi, the Santhal and the Kadar are among those that are monogamous. Excessively high bride prices have forced monogamy on many, as e.g., on the Ho.

Polyandry is much restricted in distribution in comparison to other forms of marriage. Some argue that it is because polyandry leads to fewer children to every woman, more male children and a high incidence of sterility among women. Polyandry has two forms, **fraternal** or **adelphic polyandry** and **non-fraternal polyandry**. In fraternal polyandry, the woman is wife to all the brothers and in the non-fraternal one, the wife has several husbands who are not brothers. The paternity in case of polyandrous societies is more legal and social than biological. Ogburn and Nimkoff are of the opinion that the chief factor responsible for polyandry would seem to be the extreme poverty of the people. Fraternal polyandry is reported among the Todas of the Nilgiris of Tamil Nadu and Khasas of Jaunsar Bawar in Dehradun district of Uttar Pradesh while non-fraternal polyandry was practised by Nayars of Kerala. Please note that the **Khasas of Jaunsar Bawar** have evolved a very practical mode of polyandrous matrimony. Among them, when the eldest brother marries a girl, she automatically becomes the common wife of the rest of the brothers. If a brother is minor, he may, on becoming adult, marry another girl to match his age. Hence this leads to as situation where a number of brothers have more than one wife which is not the classical mode of polyandry. Observing polygyny-polyandry mixed up, **Majumdar** has coined an interesting phrase, **Polygynandry**, to describe this situation.

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In some polygamous societies certain preferential rules for the choice of wives/husbands are followed. In certain societies males marry the wife's sisters, and females their husband's brothers. Such marriages are termed as **sororal polygyny** and **fraternal polyandry**, respectively. In other words, while sororal polygyny implies the marriage of one man with several sisters, fraternal polyandry on the other hand implies the marriage of one woman with several brothers. Levirate, sororate, cross-cousin marriage and parallel-cousin marriage are some other forms of preferential marriages. **Levirate** is a custom in certain societies in which a widow marries one of her husband's brothers. **Sororate**, on the other hand, refers to the custom of a widower marrying the sister of his deceased wife. Often it is a younger sister who marries her deceased older sister's husband.

Cross-cousin marriage refers to the marriage of the children of siblings of the opposite sex, that is, the children of a brother and sister. Cross-cousin marriage in certain societies is often explained to be a device for avoiding payment of a high bride price, and also for maintaining property in the household. The Gonds of Madhya Pradesh call this form of marriage *dudhlautawa* ('return of milk'), implying thereby that the bride-price a person pays for his wife will be returned when his daughter marries her mother's brother's son. **Parallel cousin marriage** refers to the marriage of the children of siblings of the same sex, that is, two or more brother's children, or two or more sisters' children.

Marriage among Hindus is a sacred bond, a religious sacrament. This means that a Hindu marriage cannot be dissolved. It is a union for life. This is also reflected in the marital rites. Some of the essential rites are ***kanyadan*** (the giving off of the bride to the groom by the father), ***vivaha-homa*** (the lighting of fire as divine witness and sanctifier of the ceremony), ***panigrahana*** (the clasping of the bride's hand by the groom), ***agniparinaya*** (going around the sacred fire by the bride and the groom), ***lajahoma*** (offering of the parched grain to the sacrificial fire) and ***saptapadi*** (walking seven steps by the bride and the groom). Then the bride is carried away; ***vivaha***, the Hindi word for marriage means 'carrying away'.

In Hinduism the aim of marriage is not only to secure physical pleasure for the individuals but also to advance their spiritual development. **K.M. Kapadia** says that "Hindu marriage is a socially approved union of man and woman aiming at dharma, procreation, sexual pleasure, and observance of certain obligation. As a sacrament, Hindu marriage aims to fulfil certain religious obligations. A traditional Hindu passes through four Ashramas or stages of life called ***Brahamacharya*** (student life), ***Grihastha*** (family life), ***Vanaprastha*** (retired life) and ***Sannyasa*** (renunciation). At the commencement of each such Ashrama, a Hindu undergoes a sacrament and takes a vow. As a result of this, one becomes purified in body and mind. Marriage is a gateway to Grihastha Ashrama. Ancient Hindu texts point out

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three main aims of marriage. These are ***dharma*** (duty), ***praja*** (progeny) and ***rati*** (sensual pleasure).

The Hindus consider marriage as one of the *Sarir Samskara* or sacraments sanctifying the body. It is doubly essential for a woman because marriage is the first major and the only significant samskara (life cycle ritual) for her. Hindus believe in a concept of three religious debts or *Rinas*. These are *Pitr Rin*, *Daiv Rin* and *Guru Rin*. Marriage is essential for repaying *Pitr Rin* and the individual repays it by being the father of a son. Marriage is significant in that it provides children especially sons who would not only carry on the family name but also perform periodic rituals including the annual "shraddha" to propitiate the dead ancestors. Role of a wife is essential for the completion of Grihastha Dharma and performing religious rites.

Endogamy is a very important characteristic of the Indian caste system. Among Hindus, there are over three hundred castes and sub-castes and each one of them is endogamous. Thus caste endogamy is the central feature of traditional Hindu marriage. Although the norms of caste endogamy were widely prevalent, Hindu scriptures by allowing ***anuloma*** and ***pratiloma*** marriages, institutionalized, to a limited extent, inter-caste marital alliances. The anuloma marriage permits an alliance between a lower class woman and higher caste man, while the pratiloma marriage is an alliance between higher caste woman and a lower caste man. The former is referred to by the sociologists as ***hypergamy*** and the latter as ***hypogamy***. In other words, hypergamy or anuloma is that form of marriage in which the ritual status of a man is higher than that of his prospective wife, while hypogamy or pratiloma is that form of marriage in which the ritual status of a woman is higher than that of her prospective husband. Please note that in the context of South Indian or Dravidian system, **Dumont** has used the term '***isogamy***', i.e., the marriage between two equals. He argues that in south India, the principal marriage (usually a person's first marriage) links the persons of equal status.

However, rules of exogamy among Hindus are very specific. Hindus are traditionally prohibited from marrying in their own **gotra**, **pravara** and **sapinda** (gotra, pravara and sapinda refer to a group of individuals assumed to have descended from a paternal or maternal ancestor and are variously termed as clan, sib or lineage). *Sagotra exogamy* applies to those who trace descent from a common ancestor, usually a rishi or a sage. All these people cannot intermarry. The term gotra is commonly used to mean an exogamous category within a jati. One of its principal uses is to regulate marriage alliance. All members of a gotra are supposed to be descendants of or associated with the same ancestral figure. A four-clan rule or four gotra exogamous rule prevails among Hindu castes in North India. In accordance with this four clan (gotra) rule, a man cannot marry a girl

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from (i) his father's gotra or clan, (ii) his mother's gotra or clan, (iii) his dadi's, i.e. his father's mother's gotra or clan, and (iv) his nani's, i.e., his mother's mother's gotra or clan. In almost all castes in the northern zone, according to Karve (1953), the marriage between cousins is prohibited.

Sapinda exogamy indicates the prohibition placed on the inter-marriage between certain sets of relatives. Sapinda represents the relationship between the living member and their dead ancestors. The term sapinda means (i) those who share the particles of the same body, (ii) people who are united by offering 'pinda' or balls of cooked rice to the same dead ancestor. Hindu lawgivers do not give a uniform definition regarding the kinship groups within which marriage cannot take place. Some prohibit marriage of members within seven generations on the father's side and five generations of members from the mother's side. Some others have restricted the prohibited generations to five on the father's and three on the mother's side. Several others have permitted the marriage of cross-cousins (marriage of a person with his father's sister's children or mother's brother's children). The **Hindu Marriage Act of 1955** does not allow marriage within five generations on the father's side and three on the mother's side. However, it permits the marriage of cross- cousins where this is customary.

In Hindu scriptures eight forms of marriage have been described. When a father gifts his daughter to a learned man of good character, it is called ***brahma*** marriage. If it is a priest to whom the daughter is gifted, it is called ***daiva*** marriage. When a prospective son-in-law makes the gift of a bull and cow to the girl's father before receiving her as gift it is called ***arsha*** marriage. This should not be confused with marriage by purchase which is called ***asura*** and has been declared unlawful by Manu. Marriage based on mutual love is called ***gandharva*** and need not be based on the acceptance of the match by the kinsmen of the couple directly involved. When a father gifts his daughter to a man, after duly honouring him, and exhorts the couple to perform their dharma together, it is called ***prajapatya*** marriage. Marriage by capture or abduction is called ***rakshasa*** and regarded as lawful, but the seduction of a girl who is asleep, intoxicated or of unsound mind is unlawful: it is called ***paisacha*** marriage. However, these traditional forms of marriages are no more in practice.

Muslim marriage, on the other hand, is not a religious sacrament, but a secular bond. It is a social or civil contract, which can be terminated. Muslim marriage is called ***Nikah***. The ceremony is performed by the priest or the ***kazi***. The nikah is considered to be complete only when the consent of both the groom and the bride has been obtained. A formal document known as ***nikahnama*** bears the signatures of the couple. Among certain sections, the signatures of two witnesses are also included in the document and the document may also contain details of the

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payment to be made to the bride by the groom. This payment is called the ***Mehr*** which is a stipulated sum of money or other assets paid to the wife either immediately after the wedding or postponed till some future date.

Among the Muslims prohibited degrees of alliance are few and limited. Thus, marriage between even half-siblings and first parallel cousins can take place. Muslim men can be polygynous under the condition that two sisters or an aunt and niece cannot be taken as co-wives and one cannot have more than four wives at a time. A Muslim can marry his deceased wife's sister and also the parent-in-law of his/her children. A Muslim man can marry a non-Muslim but only a non-idolatrous woman like a Jew or a Christian; but a Muslim woman does not enjoy a similar right.

Marriage is solemnized by signing a legal document and can be dissolved. But divorce is almost only the husband's privilege; and he can have it even without assigning a cause. Divorce can be obtained by merely repeating three times the formula of repudiation (***talaq***) in the presence of at least two witnesses. But a husband has to pay '***dower***', which is a settlement made on the wife out of her husband's property, to compensate her in the event of death and divorce. A wife can obtain ***khula*** (release) from her marriage by giving consideration to the husband whose consent is essential. If wife and husband separate by mutual consent, it is called ***mubarat***. Under certain circumstances, Islamic law does give a wife the permission of unilateral action. Widow remarriage is commonly practised by Indian Muslims.

In theory Hindu marriage is a sacrament and thus irrevocable. However, in post-independent India several laws have been passed permitting divorce for Hindus as well as other communities. The Special Marriage Act of 1954 introduced and clarified the grounds for divorce. It has been available to all Indians who have chosen to register their marriages under this Act. The Hindu Marriage Act of 1955 was amended several times since 1955 to incorporate a wide range of grounds for divorce available to both men and women coming under the purview of this Act. Some of the important grounds for divorce outlined by law are: (i) impotency, (ii) lunacy (for a specified time period), (iii) disappearance for seven years, (iv) contagious disease, (v) rape, (vi) homo-sexuality, and (vii) bestiality (sexual relationship between a human being and a lower animal). Now adultery and cruelty have also become the grounds on which divorce may be sought. The condition that one can apply for divorce after three years of marriage has been reduced to one year. The waiting period of divorce by mutual consent is now only 6 months. The word 'Hindu' under the Act includes a Buddhist, Jain or Sikh by religion and any other person who is not a Muslim, Christian, Parsi or Jew.

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It is worth noting that as early as in the nineteenth century, social reformers like **Raja Ram Mohan Roy**, **Pandit Ishwara Chandra Vidyasagar, Jyotiba Phule** and others fought against the evil practices of sati, exploitation of widows and child marriage. As a result **Prevention of Sati Act, 1829** was passed and it made the burning or burying alive of widows culpable homicide, punishable with fine or imprisonment or both. Further, in 1856, the **Hindu Widows Remarriage Act, 1856** was passed and it legalised the marriage of widows of all castes. Later, in 1929, the **Child Marriage Restraint Act, 1929** was passed (popularly known as the **Sarda Act**) and the minimum age for marriage for girls and boys was fixed at 14 years and 17 years respectively. The Act was made applicable to all Indians. The latest amendment (in 1978) has raised the minimum age for marriage for girls and boys to 18 years and 21 years, respectively.

In contemporary India, inter-caste and inter-religious marriages are recognised by law and take place on a larger scale than before. However such marriages constitute only a very small proportion of the total number of marriages taking place. They are increasing at a slow rate. The inter-caste marriage have however, been legalised by legislations such as Special Marriage Act 1954, Hindu Marriage Act 1955, Hindu Marriage Laws (Amendment) Act 1976, etc. The **Special Marriage Act of 1954** provides for secular and civil marriage before a registrar. This Act applies to all Indian citizens who chose to make use of its provisions, irrespective of their caste or religious affiliations. Prior to this act, there was **Civil Marriage Act, 1872** which treated Hindu marriage as a 'civil marriage' – and provided legal permission for inter-caste, inter-religious and even 'registered' marriage. This Act was later repealed by the Special Marriage Act, 1954. The Government of India has also passed the **Dowry Prohibition Act**, **1961**. In 1984 and again in 1986, the Act was amended to make the law more stringent and effective. For instance, today, the husband and his family can be penalised for demanding dowry if his bride dies within seven years of the marriage in other than normal circumstances.

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Social Mobility

Mobility means movement, and social mobility refers to the movement from one social position to another in the given social structure of the society. This social position may be with reference to economic, occupation, income, and so on. In context of social stratification, social mobility implies an upward or downward movement of people from one social stratum to another within a stratification system.

Even though no actual system of stratification is completely rigid or flexible, yet on the basis of degree of **social mobility** that a system allows, systems of stratification have been classified into two types, viz., open and closed system.

In an **open system** of stratification, the boundaries between the social strata are relatively more flexible. Open systems are assumed to have greater degree of social mobility. A completely *open* society, which exists only in theory, would be one in which all individuals could achieve the status for which their natural talents, abilities, and inclinations best suited them. A person can achieve a higher status on the basis of individual ability and effort, or merit. Statuses that can be gained by the direct effort of the individual, often through competition, are called **achieved statuses**, the best examples being most occupational positions in modern societies. American class system is an example of open system of stratification. An open society would not be a society of equals; there would still be inequality stemming from unequal social positions. But these social positions would be gained solely by personal achievement and merit. However, as stated earlier, in reality, no absolute open society exists. Even in the so called open class societies of the west, restrictions and hindrances of various kinds are found to persist which restrict free social mobility. Though the modern industrial societies are increasingly becoming meritocratic and open yet the class of origin has a significant bearing on the life chances (for example, educational attainment, training in specialized skills) of an individual or group and its prospects for upward mobility.

In a **closed system**, on the other hand, the boundaries between social strata are rigid. A completely *closed* society, also purely hypothetical, would be one in which all individuals were assigned a status at birth or at a certain age, which could never be changed either for better or worse. Such statuses are called **ascriptive statuses**. Here status is ascribed to the individuals by society more or less arbitrarily and permanently on the basis of traits over which they have no control such as birth, skin colour, gender or age group etc. In a closed system social position is usually hereditary; individual ability and efforts generally do not count. Caste system in India and feudal society in Europe are the best examples of closed system of social stratification. But certain amount of mobility exists even in the

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closed systems. For example, in France, there were two kinds of nobles: the nobles of the sword and the nobles of the robe. The nobles of the robe were nobles not by birth but by title. Similarly, in the traditional Indian caste system, some degree of mobility was facilitated through the practices of hypergamy and sanskritisation. **Hypergamy** (or *anuloma*) is that form of marriage in which the ritual status of a man is higher than that of his prospective wife. Please note that although the norms of caste endogamy were widely prevalent in traditional Hindu society yet the practice of hypergamy or anuloma form of marriage provided one of the avenues of social mobility to the family and caste group of the girl from the lower caste when she gets married to a man from higher caste.

M. N. Srinivas argues that even in traditional India, caste system permitted some degree of mobility through the process of '**Sanskritisation**'. The term Sanskritisation was first used by M. N. Srinivas in the course of his study of the Coorgs in erstwhile State of Mysore. According to Srinivas, ***"Sanskritisation is a process by which a 'low' Hindu caste, or tribe or other group changes its customs, ritual, ideology, and way of life in the direction of a high, and frequently, 'twice-born' caste."*** Srinivas found that lower castes, in order to raise their position in caste hierarchy, adopted some of the practices of the Brahmins. At the same time, these castes gave up some of their own customs, which were considered impure such as meat-eating, consumption of alcohol and animal sacrifice to their deities. They also emulated life-styles of the high caste Brahmins in term of dress, food and rituals. By imitating these practices the lower castes claimed higher position over a period of time in the local hierarchy of castes. This process of mobility was initially called 'Brahmanisation'.

However, later it was realised that the process described by Brahmanisation was not a general trend and the lower castes in several cases adopted the practices of the non-Brahmin higher castes. Therefore, the term Brahmanisation was replaced by Sanskritisation which was considered more appropriate. Sanskritisation is an endogenous source of upward mobility for a caste. The mobility caused by this process, however, leads to only positional changes in the system. It does not result in structural change. Change occurs within the caste hierarchy. The caste system itself does not change.

Social mobility is primarily of two types, vertical mobility and horizontal mobility. **Vertical mobility** refers to the movement from one social position to another position of higher or lower rank. Thus, there can be upward vertical mobility or downward vertical mobility. **Horizontal mobility**, on the other hand, refers to movement of a person from one social position to another position of the same rank. It does not bring about a change in the social position of the individual or group that has moved. For example, if a teacher is transferred in the same rank

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from one school to another school, it is an instance of horizontal mobility. But if the teacher gets promotion in the school where he is working or where he is transferred, than it will be a case of vertical mobility.

While discussing the dimensions of vertical mobility, it is also important to note that mobility may be inter-generational or intra-generational. **Inter-generational mobility** refers to the mobility between generations. Here the measure of mobility would be whether and to what extent the children have achieved a social position higher than that of their parents in the case of upward mobility or lower in case of downward mobility. For example, when the son of a peon becomes an officer, it is a case of inter-generational upward mobility. However, if the son of an officer becomes a clerk, than it is a case of inter-generational downward mobility. **Intra-generational mobility** refers to the social mobility of an individual within his or her own life-time. In other words, it refers to the upward or downward mobility that the same individual experiences at different points in his lifetime. For example, when a clerk gets promoted to the rank of section officer, it is a case of intra-generational upward mobility. However, if a section officer is demote to clerk, than it is a case of intra-generational downward mobility.

Seymour M. Lipset and **Reinhard Bendix** in their study titled *Social Mobility in Industrial Society* (1959) indicated that fully industrialized, bureaucratically organized societies like the United States tend to be most open, while the most closed societies are preindustrial, especially agricultural, societies based on kinship.

Thomas Fox and **S.M. Miller** in their study *"Economic, Political and Social Determinants of Mobility: An International Cross-sectional Analysis"* (1965) sought to identify the determinates of upward mobility in many different nations. Their research uncovered two conditions that seem to encourage a high degree of upward social mobility: **an advanced stage of development of an industrial economy**, and **a large educational enrolment**. As societies become more and more industrialized, the unskilled, low-salaried jobs at the bottom of the occupational status ranking are slowly eliminated, for these are the jobs most easily performed by machines. Simultaneously, more jobs are added at the middle and upper levels, to manipulate and control the flow of machine-produced goods and information. The vertical mobility resulting from such system changes – rather than individual achievement – is called **structural mobility**. But the higher ranking job opportunities will not be fully utilized unless the children of lower-level parents are given the knowledge and training necessary to achieve them. Compulsory public education and the opportunity for low-cost, unrestricted higher education provide this necessary condition.

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Sources and causes of social mobility: (refer class notes)

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Studies on Social Mobility:

The first major study of intergenerational mobility in England and Wales was conducted by **David Glass** and his associates in 1949. In his study Glass developed a seven class model based on **occupational prestige** as the criterion and compared the status of sons with the status of their fathers. Overall, the study indicated a fairly high level of intergenerational mobility. However, for the most part, the change in status is not very great. **Most mobility is short range**, sons generally moving to a category either adjacent or close to that of their fathers. There is little long range mobility either from top to bottom or vice versa. In the higher status categories there is a considerable degree of self-recruitment – a process by which members of a stratum are recruited from the sons of those who already belong to that stratum. Family background appears to have an important influence on life chances. The higher the occupational status of the father, the more likely the son is to obtain a high status position. Glass's study therefore reveals a significant degree of inequality of opportunity.

After 1949, the next major study of social mobility in England and Wales was conducted in 1972, popularly known as the **Oxford Mobility Study**. The results cannot be compared in detail with those of the 1949 study since different criteria were used as a basis for constructing the various strata. Where Glass used a classification based on occupational prestige, the Oxford study categorized occupations largely in terms of their market rewards. One of the most striking differences between the 1972 and 1949 surveys is the amount of long range mobility, particularly, mobility out of the manual working class. For example, the study indicated that 7.1% of the sons of class 7 fathers are in class 1 in 1972. However, despite the **relatively high rate of long range upward mobility**, a large proportion (45.7%) of the sons of class 1 fathers are themselves in class 1 in 1972. The combination of a fairly high degree of inheritance of privileged positions and a relatively high rate of long range upward mobility is probably due to the fact that there is literally more room at the top. The occupations which make up class 1 expanded rapidly in the twenty or so years before 1972. They have grown at such a rate that they can only be filled by recruitment from below. Class 1 father simply do not produce sufficient sons to fill class 1 occupations in the next generation.

The following reasons have been given to account for the rate of social mobility in industrial society. Firstly, there is considerable change in the occupational structure. For example, in Britain, the proportion of manual workers in the male labour force has declined from 70% in 1921 to 55% in 1971. Thus, for each succeeding generation, there are more white-collar and fewer blue-collar and fewer blue-collar jobs available. This helps to account for the finding of the Oxford study that upward mobility considerably exceeds downward mobility. Secondly,

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manual and non-manual fertility rates differ. In particular, working-class fathers have generally had more children than middle-class fathers. This differential fertility can also be seen as a reason for the relatively high rate of upward mobility. As the Oxford study indicated, class 1 fathers did not produce sufficient sons to fill the rapidly growing numbers of class 1 occupations. As a result recruitment from lower strata was essential to fill those positions. Thirdly, many sociologists have argued that occupational status in industrial society is increasingly achieved on the basis of merit. Jobs are allocated in terms of talent and ability rather than through family and friendship connections. Education is seen to play a key part in this process. The educational system grades people in terms of ability, and educational qualifications have a growing influence on occupational status and reward. Since educational opportunities are increasingly available to all young people, no matter what their social background, the result in more open society and a higher rate of social mobility. [Social mobility, therefore, can be seen as an index of economic development.]

Consequences of social mobility:

Sociologists are interested in social mobility for a number of reasons. Firstly, the rate of social mobility may have an important effect on class formation. For example, Anthony Giddens suggests that if the rate of social mobility is low, class solidarity and cohesion will be high. Most individuals will remain in their class of origin and this will 'provide for the reproduction of common life experiences over generations'. As a result distinctive class subcultures and strong class identifications will tend to develop. Secondly, a study of social mobility can provide an indication of the life chances of members of society. For example, it can show the degree to which a person's class of origin influences his chances of obtaining a high status occupation. Thirdly, it is important to know how people respond to the experience of social mobility. For example, do the downwardly mobile resent their misfortune and form a pool of dissatisfaction which might threaten the stability of society?

The nature and extent of social mobility in Western industrial societies pose a number of questions concerning class formation and class conflict. Marx believed that a high rate of social mobility would tend to weaken class solidarity. Classes would become increasingly heterogeneous as their members ceased to share similar backgrounds. Distinctive class subcultures would tend to disintegrate since norms, attitudes and values would no longer be passed from generation to generation within a single stratum. Class identification and loyalty would weaken since it would be difficult for mobile individuals to feel a strong consciousness of kind with other members of the class in which they found themselves. As a result,

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the intensity of class conflict and the potential for class consciousness would be reduced.

Ralf Dahrendorf believes that this situation has arrived in modern Western societies. He argues that as a result of the high rate of social mobility, the nature of conflict has changed. In an open society, there are considerable opportunities for individual advancement. There is therefore less need for people to join together as members of a social class in order to improve their situation. In Dahrendorf's words, 'instead of advancing their claims as members of homogeneous groups, people are more likely to compete with each other as individuals for a place in the sun'. As a result class solidarity and the intensity of specifically class conflict will be reduced. Dahrendorf then goes a step further and questions whether the rather loose strata of mobile individuals can still be called social classes. But he stops short of rejecting the concept of class, arguing that, 'although mobility diminishes the coherence of groups as well as the intensity of class conflict, it does not eliminate either.'

A number of sociologists have attempted to assess the effects of mobility on social order. Frank Parkin has seen the relatively high rate of upward mobility as a 'political safety valve'. It provides opportunities for many able and ambitious members of the working class to improve their situation. As a result, the frustration which might result, if opportunities for upward mobility were absent, is prevented from developing. To some degree this will weaken the working class. Research from a number of Western societies indicates that upwardly mobile individuals tend to take on the social and political outlooks of the class into which they move. American studies in particular suggest that those who move upward into the middle class often become more conservative than those born into it. Thus the upwardly mobile pose no threat to social stability. Indeed, they can be seen to reinforce it.

Similar conclusions have been drawn from studies of downward mobility. American sociologists Harold Wilensky and Hugh Edwards examined the response of 'skidders' – persons moving down into the working class – to the experience of social demotion. They found that the downwardly mobile tend to be more politically conservative than those born into and remaining within the working class. The experience of downward mobility did not lead them to reject the social order and so threaten the stability of society. Instead they clung to middle class values, anticipating upward mobility and a restoration of their former status. Their presence in the working class tends to weaken that class since they are not really a part of it. Thus both upward and downward mobility tend to reinforce the status quo. Both introduce conservative elements into social strata, both appear to weaken working-class solidarity and therefore reduce the intensity of class conflict.

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Further, studies substantiate the fact that downward mobility can cause great personal stress and psychological disruption. Warren Breed, for example, found that suicide rates are markedly higher among the downwardly mobile than either the nonmobile or the upwardly mobile. But it is not always realized that upward mobility can also cause stress and disruption along with many other undesirable consequences. Upward mobility has been linked to schizophrenia and psychoneurosis; persons who are upwardly mobile exhibit more prejudice against low status people than do nonmobile individuals at the same level; and upward mobility often puts a great strain on the relationship between parents and children.

Upward mobility is not always advantageous for the society at large. High rates of mobility may mean that individuals are moving too fast and too frequently to be easily assimilated into their new levels. Moreover, in a society such as that of the United States in which upward mobility is both valued and highly visible, expectations may be over aroused. Although many want to be upwardly mobile, not everyone can succeed. This phenomenon of rising expectations is frequently cited as a source of social discontent and civil strife.

The more closed society, however, operating with low mobility and ascribed statuses, has problems that are far more serious. Parentage is no guarantee of capability, as the history of any hereditary monarchy will verify. A father of extraordinary ability may have sons and daughters of only mediocre talents, and vice versa. Yet social efficiency demands that high born undesirables sink into obscurity and talented persons of lower classes rise to positions of power and influence. In addition to being inefficient in its assignment of people to jobs, a closed society is extravagant with human resources: it does not encourage achievement from everyone.

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It is interesting to speculate about a future society based almost entirely on achievement or merit. We can only imagine the psychological consequences on those persons of lowest status who were at the bottom knowing, as would everyone else, that they truly lacked merit. In a brilliant satire entitled *The Rise of the Meritocracy*, Michael Young imagines a future British society in which talent and social roles would be perfectly matched, in which the most able individuals would fill the functionally most important positions. Social status would be achieved on the basis of merit in a society where all members have an equal opportunity to realize their talents. Following Michael Young's usage of the term, such a system of role allocation has come to be known as a meritocracy.

Young questions the proposition that a stratification system based on meritocratic principles would be functional for society. He notes the following dysfunctional possibilities. Firstly, members of the lower strata may become totally demoralized. In all previous stratification systems they have been able to divert blame from themselves for their lowly status by providing reasons for their failure. They could claim that they never had the opportunity to be successful whereas those who filled the top jobs owed their position to their relatives, friends and the advantages of birth. However, in a meritocracy, those at the bottom are clearly inferior. As a result they may become demoralized. Since all members of a meritocracy are socialized to compete for the top jobs and instilled with ambition, failure could be particularly frustrating. In a meritocracy, talent and ability are efficiently syphoned out of the lower strata. As a result these groups are in a particularly vulnerable position because they have no able members to represent their interests.

Members of the upper strata in a meritocracy deserve their position; their privileges are based on merit. In the past they had a degree of self doubt because many realized that they owed their position to factors other than merit. Since they could recognize 'intelligence, wit and wisdom' in members of the lower strata, they appreciated that their social inferiors were at least their equal in certain respects. As a result they would accord the lower orders some respect and the arrogance which high status tends to encourage would be tempered with a degree of humility. All this may change in a meritocracy. Social inferiors really are inferior, those who occupy the top positions are undoubtedly superior. Young argues that this may result in an upper stratum free from self-doubt and the restraining influence of humility. Its members may rule society with arrogance and haughty self assurance. They may despise the lower strata whose members may well find such behavior offensive. This may result in conflict between the ruling minority and the rest of society.

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Although Young's picture of a meritocracy is fictional, it indicates many of the possible dysfunctional elements of such a system. It suggests that a society based on meritocratic principles may not be well integrated. It indicates that a stratification system which operates in this way may, on balance, be dysfunctional. Young's ideas are important because they cast serious doubt on liberal views of a just society. Many liberal reforms have aimed to create greater equality of opportunity, to give every member of society an equal chance of becoming unequal. Michael Young's picture of a fully operative meritocracy suggests that the liberal dream of a fair and just society may produce far from perfect reality.

The United States, however, is not moving toward that state of affairs very rapidly. Several studies have indicated that in recent decades the United States has moved slowly, if at all, toward a more open society. Indeed, the amount of vertical mobility in the United States today is only a small percentage of what it would be if people born at all levels had a truly equal chance to attain any given status.

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Techniques of data collection

(including Sampling, Reliability and Validity)

Dear Candidate, in the previous section, we had discussed some of the fundamental characteristics of quantitative (positivist) and qualitative (anti-positivist) research methodologies. However, in practice, the distinctions between positivist and anti-positivist research methodologies are not as clear cut as the previous sections have implied. They have been placed at opposite ends of the spectrum for purposes of emphasis and illustration. A large body of sociological research falls somewhere between the two extremes. In the same way, the methods of data collection discussed in the following sections cannot be neatly categorized as aspects of positivist or anti-positivist methodologies. However, certain methods are regarded as more appropriate by supporters of one or other of these perspectives.

Let us now discuss some of the important techniques employed by the social scientists for collecting data from the field. The need for adequate and reliable data is ever increasing for taking policy decisions in different fields of human activity. There are two ways in which the required information may be obtained:

1. Complete enumeration survey (also known as the census method).
2. Sampling technique.

Under complete enumeration survey method, data are collected for each and every unit (person, household, field, shop, factory etc., as the case may be) belonging to the population or universe which is the complete set of items which are of interest in any particular situation. The advantage of this type of survey will be that no unit is left out and hence greater accuracy may be ensured. However, the effort, money and time required for carrying out complete enumeration will generally be extremely large and in many cases cost may be so prohibitive that the very idea of collecting information may be dropped. Hence in modern times very little use is made of complete enumeration survey. How to collect the data then? It is through the adoption of *sampling technique* that a large mass of data pertaining to different aspects of human activity are collected these days.

Sampling:

In the sampling technique instead of every unit of the universe only a part of the universe is studied and the conclusions are drawn on that basis for the entire universe. A sample is not studied for its own sake. The basic objective of the sample study is to draw inference about the entire population which it claims to

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represent. In other words, sampling is only a tool which helps to know the characteristics of the universe or population by examining only a small part of it.

There are basically two types of sampling: **probability sampling** and **non-probability sampling**. *Probability sampling* is one in which every unit of the population has an equal probability of being selected for the sample. It offers a high degree of representativeness. However, this method is expensive, time-consuming and relatively complicated since it requires a large sample size and the units selected are usually widely scattered. *Non-probability sampling* makes no claim for representativeness, as every unit does not get the chance of being selected. It is the researcher who decides which sample units should be chosen.

Probability sampling today remains the primary method for selecting large, representative samples for social science and business researches. Some of the important sampling designs or methods under this category are simple random sampling, stratified random sampling, systematic (or interval) sampling, cluster sampling, and multi-stage sampling.

i. Simple Random Sampling:

Random sampling refers to the sampling technique in which each and every item of the population is given an equal chance of being included in the sample. The selection is thus free form personal bias because the investigator does not exercise his discretion or preference in the choice of items. Since selection of items in the sample depends entirely on chance this method is also known as the method of chance selection. Some people believe that randomness of selection can be achieved by unsystematic and haphazard procedures. But this is quite wrong. However, the point to be emphasized is that unless precaution is taken to avoid bias and a conscious effort is made to ensure the operation of chance factors, the resulting sample shall not be a random sample. Random sampling is sometimes referred to as 'representative sampling'. If the sample is chosen at random and if the size of the sample is sufficiently large, it will represent all groups in the universe. A random sample is also known as a 'probability sample' because every item of the universe has an equal opportunity of being selected in the sample. To ensure randomness of selection one may adopt any of the following methods:

a) Lottery Method: This is a very popular method of taking a random sample. Under this method, all items of the universe are numbered on separate slips of paper of identical size and shape. These slips are then folded and mixed up in a container or drum. A blindfold selection is then made of the number of slips required to constitute the desired sample size. The selection of items thus depends entirely on chance.

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b) Table of Random Numbers: The lottery method discussed above becomes quite cumbersome to use as the size of population increases. An alternative method of random selection is that of using the table of random numbers. Three such tables are available, namely (i) Tippett's table of random numbers, (ii) Fisher and Yate's numbers, and (iii) Kendall and Babington Smith numbers.

The merits of random sampling lies in the fact that since the selection of items in the sample depends entirely on chance there is no possibility of personal bias affecting the results. Further, as the size of the sample increases, it becomes increasingly representative of the population. However, the use of random sampling necessitates a completely catalogued universe from which to draw the sample. But it is often difficult for the investigator to have up-to-date lists of all the items of the population to be sampled. This restricts the use of random sampling method.

ii. Stratified Random Sampling:

In this sampling method, the population is divided into various stratas or classes and a sample is drawn from each stratum at random. For example, if we are interested in studying the consumption pattern of the people of Delhi, the city of Delhi may be divided into various parts or zones and from each part a sample may be taken at random. However, the selection of cases from each stratum must be done with great care and in accordance with a carefully designed plan as otherwise random selection from the various strata may not be accomplished.

Stratified sampling may be either *proportional* or *disproportional*. In proportional stratified sampling, the cases are drawn from each stratum in the same proportion as they occur in the universe. For example, if we divide the city of Delhi into four zones A, B, C, and D with 40%, 30%, 20% and 10% of the total population respectively and if the sample size is one thousand then we should draw 400, 300, 200 and 100 cases respectively from zones A, B, C and D, *i.e.*, sample is proportional to the size in the universe. In disproportional stratified sampling, an equal number of cases is taken from each stratum, regardless of how the stratum is represented in the universe. Thus, in the above example, an equal number of items from each zone may be drawn, that is, 250. This approach is obviously inferior to the proportional stratified sampling.

The most important merit of the stratified random sampling is that it is more representative. Since the population is first divided into various stratas and then a sample is drawn from each stratum, there is little possibility of any essential group of the population being completely excluded. A more representative sample is thus

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secured. Stratified sampling is frequently regarded as the most efficient system of sampling. However, utmost care must be exercised in dividing the population into various stratas. Each stratum must contain, as far as possible, homogenous items as otherwise the results may not be reliable. However, this is a very difficult task and may involve considerable time and expense.

iii. Systematic or Interval Sampling:

This method is popularly used in those cases where a complete list of the population from which sample is to be drawn is available. It involves obtaining a sample of items by drawing every n^{th} item from a predetermined list of items. In simple words, it involves randomly selecting the first respondent and then every n^{th} person after that; '*n*' is the sampling interval. For example, if a complete list of 1000 students of a college is available and if we want to draw a sample of 200 this means we must take every fifth item (*i.e.*, $n = 5$). The first item between one and five shall be selected at random. Suppose it comes out to be three. Now we shall go on adding five and obtain numbers of the desired sample. Thus, the second item would be the 8^{th} student, the third, 13^{th} student and so on.

Systematic sampling differs from simple random sampling in that in the latter, the selections are independent of each other; in the former the selection of sample units is dependent on the selection of a previous one. The systematic sampling is more convenient to adopt than the random sampling or the stratified sampling method. The time and work involved in sampling by this method are relatively smaller. It is a rapid method and eliminates several steps otherwise taken in probability sampling. However, critics of this method argue that it ignore all persons between two n^{th} numbers with the result that the possibility of over representation and under representation of several groups is greater.

iv. Cluster Sampling:

This sampling implies dividing population into clusters and drawing random sample either from all clusters or selected clusters. This method is used when (a) cluster criteria are significant for the study, and (b) economic considerations are significant. In cluster sampling, initial clusters are called *primary* sampling units; clusters within the primary clusters are called *secondary* sampling units; and clusters within the secondary clusters are called *multi-stage* clusters. When clusters are geographic units, it is called *area sampling*. For example, dividing one city into various wards, each ward into areas, each area into neighbourhoods and each neighbourhood into lanes. We can take an example of a hospital. The issue is to ascertain the problems faced by doctors, patients and visitors in different units and to introduce some reformative programmes. Administratively, it will not be viable to call all doctors from all units nor a large number of patients admitted in different

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units like cardiology, neurology, orthopaedic, gynaecology, and so on. Treating each unit as a cluster, randomly selected doctors and patients – say two doctors and three patients or about 50 people all together – from all units may be invited for discussions. Arriving at a consensus for immediate reforms needed, a plan can be chalked out for seeking grant from the government.

The advantages of cluster sampling are that it is much easier to apply this sampling design when large populations are studied or when large geographical area is studied. Further, the cost involved in this method is much less than in other methods of sampling. The disadvantages of this sampling method are that each cluster may not be of equal size and hence the comparison so done would not be on equal basis. The chances of sampling error are greater as there could be homogeneity in one cluster but heterogeneity in other.

v. Multi-Stage Sampling:

As the name implies this method refers to a sampling procedure which is carried out in several stages, but only the last sample of subjects is studied. Suppose, it is decided to take a sample of 5,000 households from the State of Uttar Pradesh. At the first stage, the State may be divided into number of districts and a few districts selected at random. At the second stage, each district may be sub-divided into a number of villages and a sample of villages may be taken at random. At the third stage, a number of households may be selected from each of the villages selected at the second stage. In this way, at each stage the sample size becomes smaller and smaller. The merit of multi-stage sampling is that it introduces flexibility in the sampling method which is lacking in the other methods. It enables existing divisions and sub-divisions of the population to be used as units at various stages, and permits the field work so be concentrated and yet large area to be covered. Another important advantage in this sampling design is that is more representative. Further, in all cases, complete listing of population is not necessary. This saves cost. However, a multi-stage sample is in general less accurate than a sample containing the same number of final stage units which have been selected by some suitable single stages process.

Let's now discuss about the non-probability sampling. In many research situations, particularly those where there is no list of persons to be studied (e.g., widows, alcoholics, migrant workers, etc.) probability sampling is difficult and inappropriate to use. In such research, non-probability sampling is the most appropriate one. Non-probability sampling procedures do not employ the rules of probability theory, do not claim representativeness, and are usually used for qualitative exploratory analysis. Some of the important sampling designs under this category are convenience sampling, purposive or judgement sampling, quota sampling, snowball sampling and volunteer sampling.

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i. Convenience Sampling:

This is also known an 'accidental' or 'haphazard' sampling. In this sampling, the researcher studies all those persons who are most conveniently available or who accidentally come in his contact during a certain period of time in the research. For example, the researcher engaged in the study of university students might visit the university canteen, library, some departments, play-grounds, verandahs and interview certain number of students. Another example is of election study. During election times, media personnel often present man-on-the-street interviews that are presumed to reflect public opinion. In such sampling, representativeness is not significant. The most obvious advantages of convenience sample is that it is quick and economical. But it may be a very biased sample. The possible sources of bias could be: (i) the respondents may have a vested interest to serve in cooperating with the interviewer, and (ii) the respondents may be those who are vocal and/or want to brag. Convenience samples are best utilised for exploratory research when additional research will subsequently be conducted with a probability sample.

ii. Purposive Sampling:

Purposive sampling is also known as judgement sampling. In this, the choice of sample items depends exclusively on the discretion of the investigator. In other words, the investigator exercises his judgement in the choice and includes those items in the sample which he thinks are most typical of the universe with regard to the characteristics under investigation. For example, if a sample of ten students is to be selected from a class of sixty for analysing the spending habits of students, the investigator would select 10 students who, in his opinion, are representative of the class. This method, though simple, is not scientific because there is a big possibility of the results being affected by the personal prejudice or bias of the investigator. Thus judgement sampling involves the risk that the investigator may establish foregone conclusions by including those items in the sample which conform to his preconceived notions. For example, if an investigator holds the view that the wages of workers in a certain establishment are very low, and if he adopts the judgment sampling method, he may include only those workers in the sample whose wages are low and thereby establish his point of view which may be far from the truth. Since an element of subjectiveness is possible, this method cannot be recommended for general use. (Please remember this argument. You would need it as one of the criticisms against Karl Marx.) However, because of simplicity and easy adaptability this method is quite often used by businessmen in the solution of everyday problems. Indeed, if applied with skill and care, the judgement method can be of great help to businessmen. At least, it helps deriving somewhat better solutions to the problems than could be obtained without it.

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iii. Quota Sampling:

Quota sampling is a type of judgement sampling. In a quota sample, quotas are set up according to given criteria but, within the quotas, the selection of sample items depends on personal judgement. For example, in a radio listening survey, the interviewers may be told to interview 500 people living in a certain area and that out of every 100 persons interviewed 60 are to be housewives, 25 farmers, and 15 children. Within these quotas the interviewer is to free to select the people to be interviewed. The cost per person interviewed may be relatively small for a quota sample but there are numerous opportunities for bias which may invalidate results. Because of the risk of personal prejudice and bias entering the process of selection, the quota sampling is rarely used in practical work.

iv. Snowball Sampling:

In this technique, the researcher begins the research with the few respondents who are known and available to him. Subsequently, these respondents give other names who meet the criteria of research, who in turn give more new names. This process is continued until 'adequate' number of persons are interviewed or until no more respondents are discovered. For instance, in studying wife battering, the researcher may first interview those cases whom he knows, who may later on give additional names, and who in turn may give still new names. This method is employed when the target population is unknown or when it is difficult to approach the respondents in any other way. Reduced sample sizes and costs are a clear advantage of snowball sampling. Bias enters because a person known to someone (also in the sample) has a higher probability of being similar to the first person. If there are major differences between those who are widely known by others and those who are not, there may be serious problems with snowball sampling.

v. Volunteer Sampling:

This is the technique in which the respondent himself volunteers to give information he holds. The success of the research is dependent on the 'rich' information given by the respondents. However, there is a possibility that the informants may not truly represent the population, i.e., they may not have the aggregate characteristics of the population. Further, the personal leanings of the researcher of being prejudiced against certain types of persons, say, untouchables or religious minorities, may also affect the validity of the findings.

On a review of the pros and cons of the various methods of sampling, it is clear that stratified sampling and systematic sampling methods based on random

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principle are more reliable, and hence these methods are more widely used than others.

Let's now briefly discuss the merits of the sampling procedure in general. The sampling technique has the following merits over the complete enumeration survey:

1. Less time: Since sampling is a study of a part of the population, considerable time and labour are saved when a sample survey is carried out. Time is saved not only in collecting data but also in processing it. For these reasons a sample often provides more timely data in practice than a census.

2. Less cost: Sampling also edges out other techniques of data collection in terms of the cost involved. This is a great advantage particularly in an underdeveloped economy where much of the information would be difficult to collect by the census method for lack of adequate resources.

3. More reliable results: Although the sampling technique involves certain inaccuracies owing to sampling errors, the result obtained is generally more reliable than that obtained from a complete count. This is because more effective precautions can be taken in a sample survey to ensure that the information is accurate and complete. Moreover, it is possible to avail of the services of experts and to impart thorough training to the investigators in a sample survey which further reduces the possibility of errors. Follow-up work can also be undertaken much more effectively in the sampling method.

4. More detailed information: Since the sampling technique saves time and money, it is possible to collect more detailed information in a sample survey. For example, if the population consists of 1,000 persons in a survey of the consumption pattern of the people, the two alternative techniques available are as follows:

   (a) We may collect the necessary data from each one of the 1,000 people through a questionnaire containing, say, 10 questions (census method),

   Or

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(b) We may take a sample of 100 persons (i.e. 10% of population and prepare a questionnaire containing as many as 100 questions. The expenses involved in the latter case almost be the same as in the former but it will enable nine times more information to be obtained.

However, despite the various advantages of sampling, it is not altogether free from limitations. Some of the difficulties involved in sampling are stated below:

1. A sample survey must be carefully planned and executed otherwise the results obtained may be inaccurate and misleading.
2. Sampling generally requires the services of experts for the proper planning and execution of the survey. In the absence of qualified and experienced persons, the information obtained from sample surveys cannot be relied upon.
3. If the information is required for each and every unit in the domain of study, sample method cannot be adopted.

Dear Candidate, it would be useful here to discuss the various types of errors that often are committed while collecting the data. Though it is less likely that a question would be asked on this but given the unpredictability of UPSC, I would suggest you to just glance through it.

To appreciate the need for sample surveys, it is necessary to understand clearly the role of ***sampling*** and ***non-sampling errors*** in complete enumeration and sample surveys. The errors arising due to drawing inferences about the population on the basis of few observations (sample) is termed as *sampling errors*. Clearly, the sampling error, in this sense is non-existent in a complete enumeration survey, since the whole population is surveyed. However, the errors mainly arising at the stages of ascertainment and processing of data which are termed *non-sampling errors* are common both in complete enumeration and sample surveys.

Sampling Errors:

Even if utmost care has been taken in selecting a sample, the results derived from the sample may not be representative of the population from which it is drawn, because samples are seldom, if ever, perfect miniatures of the population. This gives rise to sampling errors. Sampling errors are thus due to the fact that samples are used and to the particular method used in selecting the items from the

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population. Sampling errors are of two types – biased and unbiased. Biased errors are those which arise from any kind of bias in selection, estimation, etc. Bias may arise either due to a faulty process of selection or faulty method of analysis. Unbiased errors, on the other hand, arise due to chance differences between the members of population included in the sample and those not included. The simplest and the only certain way of avoiding bias in the selection process is for the sample to be drawn either entirely at random or at random, subject to restrictions, which, while improving the accuracy, are of such a nature that they do not introduce bias in the results.

Non-sampling Errors:

When a complete enumeration of units in the universe is made one would expect that it would give rise to data free from errors. However, in practice it is not so. For example, it is difficult to completely avoid errors of observation or ascertainment. So also in the processing of data tabulation errors may be committed affecting the final results. Errors arising in this manner are termed non-sampling errors, as they are due to factors other than the inductive process of inferring about the population from a sample. Thus, the data obtained in a census by complete enumeration, although free from sampling errors, would still be subject to non-sampling errors, whereas the results of a sample survey would be subject to sampling errors as well as non-sampling errors.

Non-sampling errors can occur at every stage of planning and execution of the census or survey. Such errors can arise due to a number of causes such as defective methods of data collection and tabulation, faulty definitions, incomplete coverage of the population or sample, etc. More specifically, non-sampling errors may arise from one or more of the following factors:

1. Data specification being inadequate and inconsistent with respect to the objectives of the census or sample survey.
2. Inappropriate statistical unit.
3. Inaccurate or inappropriate methods of interviews, observation or measurement with inadequate or ambiguous schedules, definitions or instructions.
4. Lack of trained and experienced investigators.
5. Lack of adequate inspection and supervision of primary staff.
6. Errors due to non-response, *i.e.*, incomplete coverage in respect of units.
7. Errors in data processing operations such as coding, punching, verification, tabulation, etc.
8. Errors committed during presentation and printing of tabulated results.

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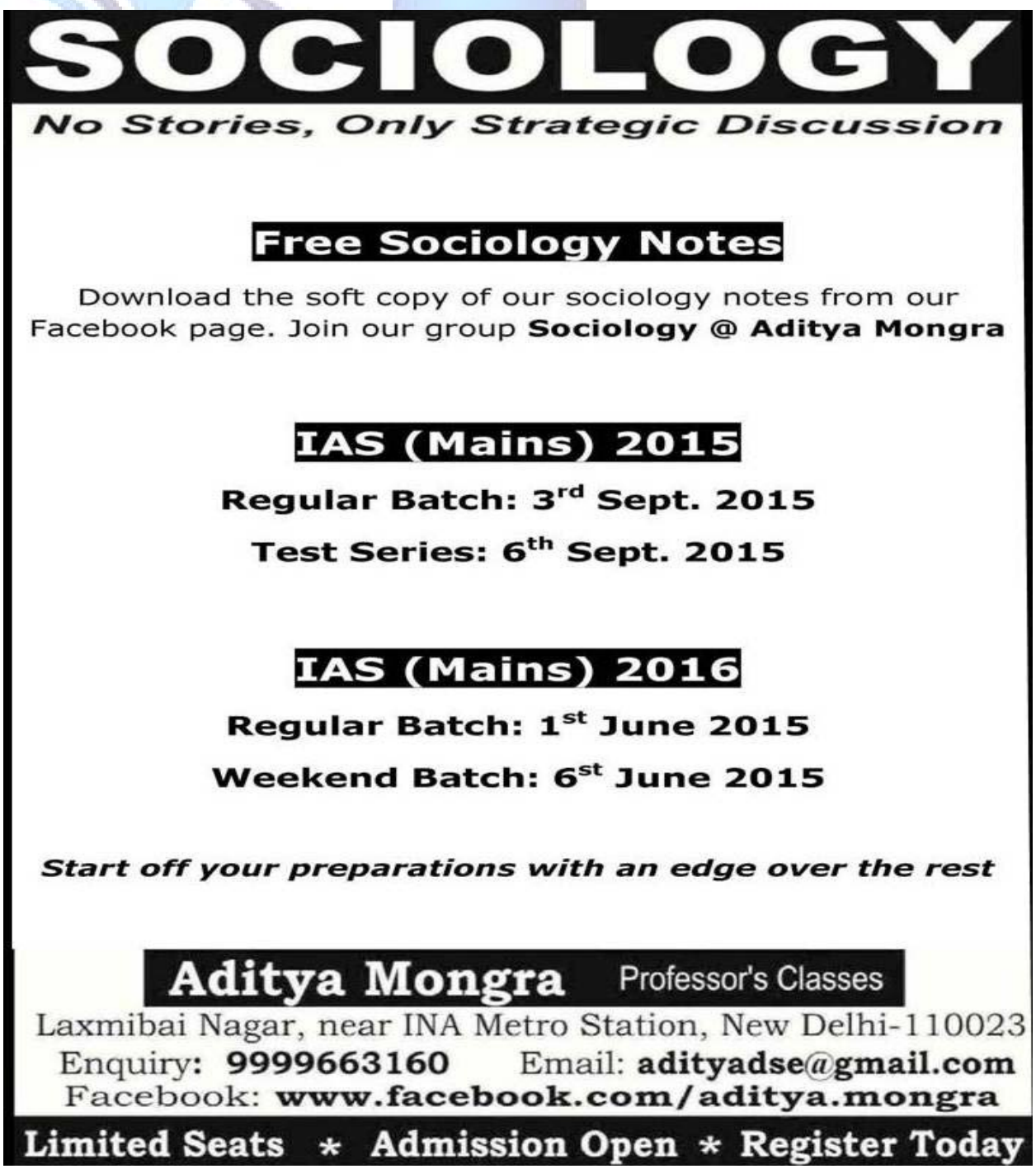
These sources are not exhaustive, but are given to indicate some of the possible sources of error. In some situations the non-sampling errors may be large and deserve greater attention than the sampling error. While, in general, sampling error decreases with increase in sample size, non-sampling error tends to increase with the sample size. In the case of complete enumeration, non-sampling error and in the case of sample surveys both sampling and non-sampling errors require to be controlled and reduced to a level at which their presence does not vitiate the use of final results.



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Survey:

The most common type of empirical, or quantitative, research in sociology is the survey, which consists of systematically questioning people about their opinions, attitudes, or behaviour. Questionnaires and structured interviews are the usual methods employed to gather data for a research design known as the 'social survey'.

Social surveys may be roughly divided into two categories, 'descriptive' and 'analytical'. A descriptive survey, as its name suggests, is concerned with description rather than explanation. It aims to provide an accurate measurement of the distribution of certain characteristics in a given population. For example, a survey may be conducted in a city or town to measure the extent of poverty in the given population. Here the researcher and his team would be interested in collecting the data on average per capita income of the working class stratum or population below poverty line, etc. In other words, they aim to measure the extent of poverty in a given population rather than to explain the causes of poverty. Analytic surveys, on the other hand, are concerned with explanation. They are designed to test hypotheses about the relationships between a number of factors or variables. Thus an analytic survey may seek to discover possible relationships between social class and religious behaviour, ethnicity and mental health, family size and educational attainment or age and voting behaviour. Analytic surveys are not simply concerned with discovering relationship but also with explaining them.

Analytic surveys are usually designed to test the effects of a number of variables or factors on some other variable. The researcher often begins with a hypothesis which postulates a relationship between variables and the direction of cause and effect. For example, he may suggest that social class differences in some way cause or determine variations in mental health. There may be other factors affecting mental health, however, and these must also be considered if the influence of social class is to be accurately assessed. For example, variables such as age, ethnicity and gender may account for some variation in mental health. As a result researchers usually gather data on a range of factors which might influence the variable in question. The method used to analyse relationships between variables is known as 'multivariate' or 'variable analysis'. With the aid of various statistical techniques, the analyst attempts to measure the effects of a number of variables upon another. This method was pioneered in sociology by Durkheim in his study of suicide. Official statistics revealed significant variations in suicide rate between European societies. Durkheim's research indicated that predominantly Protestant societies had a higher rate of suicide than societies in which Catholicism was the majority faith. But before a causal relationship could be claimed between religion and suicide rates, it was necessary to eliminate other possibilities. For

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example, could variations in suicide rates be the result of differences in national cultures? To test this possibility, Durkheim held the variable of national culture constant by examining differences in suicide rates between Catholics and Protestants within the same society. The relationship still held. Within the same society Protestants had higher suicide rates than Catholics.

Durkheim then went a step further and examined the possibility that regional differences rather than religion might account for variations in suicide rates. He found, for example, that Bavaria had the lowest suicide rate of all the states in Germany and it also had the highest proportion of Catholics. Yet might the suicide rate be due to the peculiarities of Bavaria as a region rather than its predominantly Catholic population? To test this possibility Durkheim compared the suicide rates and the religious composition of the various provinces within Bavaria. He found that the higher the proportion of Protestants in each province, the higher the suicide rate. Again the relationship between religion and rates of suicide was confirmed. By eliminating variables such as national culture and region, Durkheim was able to strengthen the relationship between religion and suicide rates and provide increasing support for his claim that the relationship is a causal one.

A social survey involves the collection of standardized information from a sample selected as being representative of a particular group or population. The group from which the sample is drawn may be the population as whole, a particular class, ethnic, gender or age group, or individuals with certain characteristics in common such as married or divorced persons, manual workers or professionals. The group selected for study will, of course, depend on what the researcher wishes to investigate. Standardized information is obtained by asking the same set of questions to all members of the sample.

Let's briefly discuss some of the major steps normally involved in survey research.

Firstly, before a survey is begun, the issues to be explored must be clearly defined. At the same time, the target population to be interviewed is selected. The target population might be identified on the basis of the characteristics that the researcher is interested in examining. It could either be a particular gender or age group, or any specific socio-economic section of the society, etc. This first step is crucial, for if the population is not correctly specified, the results of the survey may be meaningless. For example, if the aim of the research is to predict the results of an election, it is very important that the population chosen consist only of those persons who will actually vote in that election.

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Secondly, if the population is large, time and cost will almost always make it impractical to interview the entire population. So, the second step in surveying is to pick an appropriate sample of the population to interview. A sample is a limited number of selected cases drawn from a large group. Careful procedures have been established for selecting samples. The better the sampling procedure, the more closely the sample will resemble the entire population and the more accurate will be the generalizations or predictions. In other words, if generalizations are to be made from the findings of a social survey, it is essential that the sample is representative. This is often accomplished by means of a 'random sample'. We have already discussed the various types of sampling techniques and their merits and limitations. Once the researcher is satisfied that he has obtained a representative sample, he can begin the survey proper and feel some justification in generalizing from its findings.

Once the sample is selected, the third step in survey research is to interview or administer the questionnaire to the selected people and to collect the data. At this point a major consideration is the precision of the questions. Do the questions really pinpoint the issue concerned? Are they phrased in such a way that they will be interpreted correctly and similarly by each person interviewed *i.e.*, the respondents. In addition to being precise and unambiguous in meaning, a survey question must also be neutrally stated.

Please note that for the most accurate results, the entire sample must be interviewed, particularly if the sample is small. If some people refuse to answer or are unavailable for interviewing, the sample is no longer representative and, consequently, the accuracy of the data may be reduced. Non-response is frequently a serious problem when questionnaires are sent by mail, for refusals to respond to mailed questionnaires tend to be high. Replies often come only from those who have some interest in the particular issue, thus introducing a bias into the survey findings. To assure maximum response, most major attitude surveys and public opinion polls are conducted through personal interviews. These interviews range from the highly structured to be highly unstructured. A structured interview consists of a set of questions and answers are always stated in the same way and in the same sequence. The answers are thus easily compiled and generalized. Most public opinion polls use structured interviews. For other research purposes, where more extensive information about individual attitudes or behaviour is desired, the unstructured interview has many advantages. An unstructured interview may consist of open ended questions (How do you feel about the inter-caste marriages or caste-based reservations?) or even just a list of topics to be discussed. It is possible for the interviewer to introduce bias into the survey. He may, for example, use expressions or make comments that encourage the respondent to answer in a certain way. In an unstructured interview he may influence the answers by the way

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he phrases the questions. It is important that interviewers be suited to their task and that they be well trained in the techniques of interviewing.

The final step in survey research is the tabulation, analysis, and interpretation of the data. In all but the smallest surveys, this step normally involves the use of computers.

There are several possible sources of error in survey results. Sampling error is the degree to which the selected sample misrepresents the population as a whole. Other major sources of error arise from problems in observation and measurement, processing the data, and analyzing the findings. A basic problem, with all surveys is that what people say may not always agree with how they act. People sometimes conceal their attitude purposely. An individual prejudiced against lower castes in India, for example, may act in a discriminatory fashion toward them, but because he knows that this prejudice is socially disapproved of, he will not admit it to an interviewer. Research that is well designed and carried out can help to overcome these difficulties, but the sociologist must be constantly aware that attitudes expressed in interviews are not always perfect expressions of underlying values, and that actions do not always reflect stated attitudes.

The success of any survey is, however, ultimately dependent on the quality of its data. At the end of the day a social survey stands or falls on the validity of its data.

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Case Study:

Case study method is an ideal methodology when a holistic, in-depth investigation is needed. Frederic Le Play is reputed to have introduced the *case study* method into social science. He used it as a handmaiden to statistics in his studies of family budgets. Herbert Spencer was one of the first sociologists to use case materials in his ethnographic studies.

Case study is an intensive study of a case which may be an individual, an institution, a system, a community, an organisation, an event, or even the entire culture. Robert K. Yin has defined case study as "an empirical inquiry that investigates a contemporary phenomenon within its real-life context, when the boundaries between phenomenon and context are not clearly evident, and in which multiple sources of evidence are used". It is, thus, a kind of research design which usually involves the qualitative method of selecting the sources of data. It presents the holistic account that offers insights into the case under study. Please note that while a case study can either be quantitative or qualitative, or even both, but most case studies lie within the realm of qualitative methodology. It is the preferred strategy when "how, who, why and what" questions are being asked or when the focus is on a contemporary phenomenon within a real-life context.

Case studies have been used in varied social investigations, particularly, in sociological studies, and are designed to bring out the details from the viewpoint of the participants by using multiple sources of data. It is, therefore, an approach to explore and analyze the life of social unit, be it a person, a family, an institution, a culture group or even an entire community. Its aim is to determine the factors that account for the complex behaviour patterns of the unit and the relationships of the unit to its surroundings. Case-data may be gathered, exhaustively, on the entire life cycle or on a definite section of the cycle of a unit but always with a view to ascertain the natural history of social unit and its relationship to the social factors and forces involved in its environment. In other words, through case study, researchers attempt to see the variety of factors within a social unit as an integrated whole. When attention is focussed on the development of the case, it is called 'case history'. For example, how a particular boy became a juvenile delinquent because of lack of parental control, impact of peers, lack of attention by teachers, and money earned through cheap means, and then became an adolescent thief and a sex criminal and ultimately a professional pickpocket is tracing criminality through case history method.

Data, for case studies, can be collected by primary as well as secondary sources. Two main sources of primary data collection are interviews and observation. Interviews may be structured or unstructured. Most commonly, it is

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the unstructured interview which is used by the investigators. The observation method used could either be participant or non-participant. While the secondary data can be collected through a variety of sources like reports, records, newspapers, magazines, books, files, diaries, etc.

Sjoberg has identified some essential characteristics of case study method which are as follows:

- The case study 'strives towards a holistic understanding of cultural systems of action'. Cultural systems of action refer to sets of inter-related activities engaged in by the actors in a social situation.
- Case study research is not sampling research. However, selection of the items or sources must be done so as to maximize what can be learned, in the limited period of time available for the study.
- Because they are intensive in nature, case studies tend to be selective, focusing on one or two issues that are fundamental to understanding the system being examined.
- 'Case studies are multi-perspectival analyses.' This means that the researcher considers not just the voice and perspective of the actors but also of the relevant groups of actors and the interaction between them.

According to Black and Champion, some of the advantages of case study design are:

- Case study makes holistic and in-depth study of the phenomenon possible.
- It offers flexibility with respect to using methods for collecting data, e.g., questionnaire, interview, observation, etc.
- It could be used for studying any specific dimension of the topic in detail.
- It can be conducted in practically any kind of social setting.
- Case studies are relatively inexpensive.

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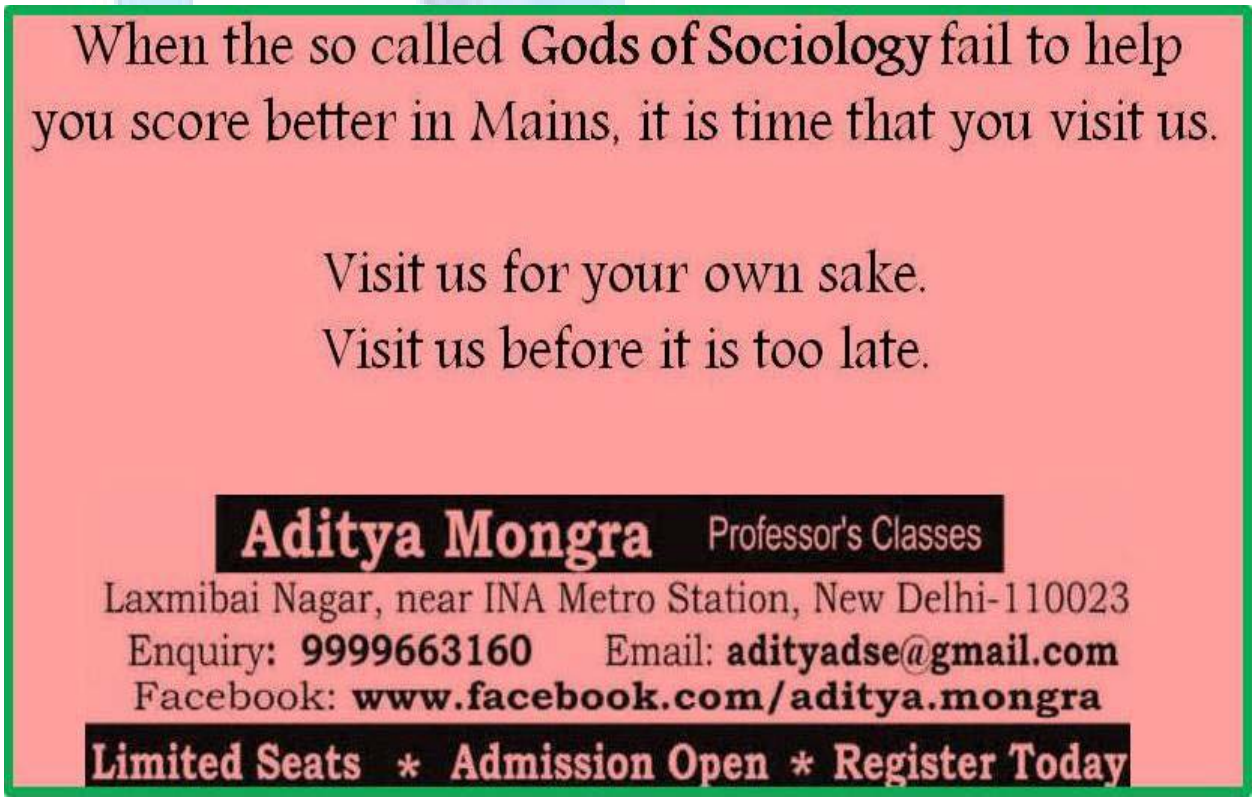
However, practically, the case study method is very time consuming and very demanding of the researcher. The possibility of becoming involved emotionally is much greater than in survey research, thus, making detached and objective observation difficult and sometimes, impossible. Another problem in the use of case study method is that, since, only one example of a social situation or group is being studied the results may not be representative of all groups or situations in the category. In other words, the particular mental hospital ward, slum, or suburb may not be typical of all mental hospital wards, slums or suburbs. Critics of the case study method believe that the study of a small number of cases can offer no grounds for establishing reliability or generality of findings. Some dismiss case study research as useful only as an exploratory tool. Yet, researchers continue to use the case study research method with success in carefully planned and crafted studies of real life situations, issues and problems.

Please note that in comparison to survey, case study method is more intensive while survey research is more extensive in nature. In other words, surveys are usually conducted on a fairly large scale as contrasted with case studies which tend to be more intensive but on a smaller scale. Case study is done in terms of limited space and broader time, whereas survey is done in terms of limited time with broader space. Case study is inward looking while survey method is outward looking.



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Interviews:

Interviews are one of the most widely used methods of gathering data in sociology. They consist of the researcher asking the interviewee or respondent a series of questions. Interviews can be classified as '***structured***' or '***unstructured***' though many fall somewhere between these two extremes. In a structured interview, the wording of the questions and the order in which they are asked remains the same in every case. The result is a fairly formal question and answer session. Unstructured interviews are more like an informal conversation. The interviewer usually has particular topics in mind to cover but few if any preset questions. He has the freedom to phrase questions as he likes, ask the respondent to develop his answers and probe responses which might be unclear and ambiguous. This freedom is often extended to the respondent who may be allowed to direct the interview into areas which interest him.

Data from structured interviews are generally regarded as more reliable. Since the order and wording of questions are the same for all respondents, it is more likely that they will be responding to the same stimuli. Thus different answers to the same set of questions will indicate real differences between the respondents. Different answers will not therefore simply reflect differences in the way questions are phrased. Thus the more structured or standardized an interview, the more easily its results can be tested by researchers investigating other groups. By comparison data from unstructured interviews are seen as less reliable. Questions are phrased in a variety of ways and the relationship between interviewer and respondent is likely to be more intimate. It is unclear to what degree answers are influenced by these factors. Differences between respondents may simply reflect differences in the nature of the interviews. It is therefore more difficult to replicate an unstructured interview but the greater flexibility of unstructured interviews may strengthen the validity of the data. They provide more opportunity to discover what the respondent 'really means'. Ambiguities in questions and answers can be clarified and the interviewers can probe for shades of meaning. In general, structured interviews are regarded as appropriate for obtaining answers to questions of 'fact' such as the age, sex and job of the respondent. Unstructured interviews after seen as more appropriate for eliciting attitudes and opinions. Interview data are often taken as indications of respondents' attitudes and behaviour in everyday life although what a person says in an interview may have little to do with his normal routines. Even if the respondent does his best to provide honest answers, he may be unaware of the taken-for-granted assumptions which he employs in everyday life.

Various studies have suggested, though, that interviews pose serious problems of reliability and validity. This is partly due to the fact that interviews are

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interaction situations. Thus the results of an interview will depend in part on the way the participants define the situation, their perceptions of each other and so on. Most studies have been concerned about the effects of interviewers on respondents. The significance of what has come to be known as '*interviewer bias*' can be seen from research conducted by J. Allan Williams Jr. He suggests that the greater the status differences between interviewer and respondent, the less likely the respondent will be to express his true feelings. To test this proposition, Williams organized a series of interviews with 840 Blacks in North Carolina during the early 1960s. All the interviewers were female, thirteen were Black and nine White. Important differences were revealed between the results obtained by Black and White interviewers. For example, a significantly higher proportion of those interviewed by Black said they approved of civil rights demonstrations and school desegregation. In addition more respondents refused to give any answers to these questions when faced with a White interviewer. Williams argues that Blacks often tended to give the answers they felt that White interviewers wanted to hear. He sees this as due to the nature of the power structure in the American South at the time of the research. Williams's findings suggest that when status differences are wide, as is often the case with middle-class sociologists interviewing members of the lower working class, interview data should be regarded with caution.

Interviewers, like everybody else, have values, attitudes and expectations. However much the interviewer tries to disguise his views they may well be communicated to the respondent. This is particularly likely in the more informal situation of the unstructured interview. As a result the interviewer may 'lead' the respondent whose answer will then reflect something of the interviewer's attitudes and expectations. This can be seen from a study conducted by Stuart A. Rice in 1914. Two thousand destitute men were asked, among other things, to explain their situation. There was a strong tendency for those interviewed by a supporter of prohibition to blame their demise on alcohol but those interviewed by a committed socialist were much more likely to explain their plight in terms of the industrial situation. To counter this problem, interviewers are often advised to be 'non-directive', to refrain from offering opinions, to avoid expressions of approval and disapproval. It is suggested they establish 'rapport' with their respondents, that is a warm, friendly relationship which implies sympathy and understanding, while at the same time guard against communicating their own attitudes and expectations.

However, despite these limitations, interviews do have certain advantages. They are less costly and time consuming and can cover much larger samples. Interviews can fill in the picture by providing data on the respondent's past and his activities in a range of contexts. Further, the response rate of the interview method is high, particularly when compared to mailed questionnaires. Most importantly, the validity of the information can be checked. Since the respondent's confidence

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can be sought through personal rapport, in-depth probing is possible. Interviewer can explain difficult terms and remove confusion and misunderstandings. Interviewer gets opportunity to observe the non-verbal behaviour of the respondent and hence enables him to record the responses in the right perspective.

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Questionnaires:

A questionnaire consists of a list of preset questions to which respondents are asked to supply answers. Questionnaire poses a structured and standardized set of questions, either to one person or to a small population, or most commonly to respondents in a sample survey. Structure here refers to questions appearing in a consistent, predetermined sequence and form. Researcher who use questionnaires regard them as a comparatively cheap, fast and efficient method for obtaining large amounts of quantifiable data on relatively large numbers of people.

Questionnaires may either be distributed by mail or by hand, through arrangements such as the 'drop-off', where a fieldworker leaves the questionnaire for respondents to complete by themselves, with provision either for mailing the complete form back to the research office, or for a return call by the fieldworker to collect the questionnaire. A questionnaire administered in a face-to-face interview, or over the telephone (growing in popularity among researchers) is generally termed a 'schedule'. In deciding upon one of these methods, researcher balances the cost, probable response rate and the nature of the questions to be posed.

Please note that the set of structured questions in which answers are recorded by the interviewer himself is called ***interview schedule*** or simply the ***schedule***. It is distinguished from the questionnaire in the sense that in the later (questionnaire) the answers are filled in by the respondent himself or herself. Though the questionnaire is used when the respondents are educated, schedule can be used both for the illiterate and the educated respondents. The questionnaire is especially useful when the respondents are scattered in a large geographical area but the schedule is used when the respondents are located in a small area so that they can be personally contacted. The wording of the questions in the questionnaire has to be simple. Since the interviewer is not present to explain the meaning and importance of the question to the respondent. In the schedule, the investigator gets the opportunity to explain whatever the respondent needs to know.

Questionnaires could broadly be classified into three types, *standardized questionnaire*, *open-ended questionnaire* and *close-ended questionnaire*. Standardized questionnaires are those in which there are definite, concrete and pre-ordained questions with additional questions limited to those necessary to clarify inadequate answers or to elicit more detailed responses. The questions are presented with exactly the same wording and in the same order to all the respondents. The reason for standardized questions is to ensure that all the respondents are replying to the same set of questions. Here the respondents or the researcher mark certain categories of reply to the questions asked for instance, 'yes/no/don't know' or 'very likely/likely/unlikely/very unlikely'. Standardized

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questionnaires have the advantage that responses are easy to compare and tabulate, since only a small number of categories are involved. On the other hand, because the standardized questions do not allow for subtleties of opinion or verbal expressions, the information they yield is likely to be restricted in scope.

Open-ended questions allow the respondent to compose his own answer rather than choosing between a number of given answers. For example, 'What's your view on the reservation policy in India?' Open-ended questionnaires are designed to permit a free response from the subject rather than one limited to certain alternatives. This may provide more valid data since he can say what he means in his own words. However, this kind of response may be difficult to classify and quantify. Answers must be carefully interpreted before the researcher is able to arrive at certain conclusion.

Close-ended or fixed-choice questions, on the other hand require the respondent to make a choice between a number of given answers. For example, 'Do you agree with the reservation policy in India?' The answer choices given are, 'yes', 'no', 'partly'. From the point of view of the interpretation of questionnaires the closed question is preferable. The results are unambiguous and comparable. With an open question, the heterogeneous answers must first be ordered into classes (codified) before they can be interpreted. Constructing classes in this way is sometimes very laborious and a challenging task. From the point of view of the reliability of interview-data also the closed question is preferable. This is because that the response to an open-ended question is subjected to the perception and linguistic ability of the respondent and under certain circumstances this can produce serious distortions.

Please note that questionnaires may be administered in a number of ways. Often they are given to individuals by interviewers, in which case they take the form of structured interviews. This method was used by Goldthorpe and Lockwood in the affluent worker study and by Young and Willmott in their survey of family life in London conducted in 1970.

Although the content of questionnaires is governed by the purpose of the study, many problems of communication may still arise on all surveys regardless of content. Much careful attention and experimentation are needed to produce effectively worded questions. The language should be concise and directed toward producing uniformity of understanding among the respondents. Great care is therefore need in the design of a questionnaire. Sometimes the main survey is preceded by a 'pilot study' which involves giving the questionnaire to a group similar to the population to be surveyed. This helps to clear up any ambiguity in the wording of questions and to ensure their relevance to future respondents.

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Ideally the questions should mean the same thing to all respondents. As earlier discussed, this is extremely difficult to ensure, particularly if respondents are drawn from different social classes and ethnic groups. In addition, the researcher must be aware of the meaning respondents give to the question. He cannot simply assume that they will share his interpretation.

More importantly, questions must not only elicit stable or reliable answers but they must also provide the kind of information, which the researcher wants. More often, the problem of truth is a much more complex one. A good questionnaire will contain some 'check questions' on crucial issues, variously placed within the document, designed to parallel or confirm each other. Sometimes, these will explore other facets of the same behaviour. Usually, the cross-check question is a kind of *specification*. That is, a general question is checked by specific reference.

Questionnaires provide data which can be easily quantified. They are largely designed for this purpose. Those who adopt a positivist approach insist that this kind of measurement is essential if sociology is to progress. They argue that only when the social world is expressed in numerical terms can precise relationships be established between its parts. Only when data are quantified by means of reliable measuring instruments can the results of different studies be directly compared. Without quantification sociology will remain on the level of impressionistic guesswork and unsupported insight. It will therefore be impossible to replicate studies, establish causal relationships and support generalizations. The questionnaire is one of the main tools of measurement in positivist sociology.

Please note that in the construction of a questionnaire concepts are operationalized. This means they are put into a form which can be measured. Sociologists classify the social world in terms of a variety of concepts. For example, social class, power, family, religion, alienation and anomie are concepts used to identify and categorize social relationships, beliefs, attitudes and experiences which are seen to have certain characteristics in common. In order to transpose these rather vague concepts into measuring instruments, a number of steps are taken. Firstly, an operational definition is established. This involves breaking the concept down into various 'components' or 'dimensions' in order to specify exactly what is to be measured. Thus when Robert Blauner attempted to operationalize the concept of alienation, he divided it into four components – powerlessness, meaninglessness, isolation and self-estrangement. Once the concept has been operationally defined in terms of a number of components, the next step involves the selection of 'indicators' for each component. Thus an indicator of Blauner's component of powerlessness might be an absence of opportunities for workers to make decisions about the organization of work tasks. Finally, indicators

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of each dimension are put into the form of a series of questions, which will provide quantifiable data for measuring each dimension.

However, whether such procedures succeed in producing valid measurements of human behaviour is open to question. Those who adopt phenomenological perspectives often reject the entire procedure of operational definitions, selecting indicators, constructing questionnaires and quantifying the results. They argue that rather than providing a valid picture of the social world, such operations merely serve to distort it. Since the social world is constructed by its members, the job of the sociologist is to investigate members' constructs. Positivist research procedures merely impose sociological constructs, categories and logic on that world.

There is little doubt that questionnaires are rather inexpensive and for that reason quite attractive. This is not merely a question of saving money but also of saving administrative time and talent, e.g. by using the mail system instead of a costly *ad hoc* staff of interviewers. One special advantage lies in the simultaneity of access. If it is important to reach all respondents at the same time, this is probably easier by means of questionnaires than interviews.

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Having described the basic building blocks of his theoretical grand design by developing the descriptive analytical concept of the *unit act*, Parsons proceeds in his later key works (*The Social System* and *Towards a General Theory of Action*), to discuss a theoretical framework of the overall social system where action takes place. I repeat that, for Parsons, a single social act does not exist in isolation. Each action is a response to some previous action and, in turn, gives rise to a further action. So what exists in reality is a chain of interconnected actions – social interactions. These social interactions get patterned and institutionalized over a period of time. Such institutionalized patterns can be, in Parsons' view, conceptualized as a social system.

So, the next problem that Parsons was concerned with was: How are *unit acts* connected to each other, and how can this connectedness be conceptually represented? After all, Parsons' unit of analysis in *The Structure of Social Action* remained the individual actor. What was needed was an elaboration on the properties of actors in interaction with other actors, and on the properties of the social systems constituted by these interactions. This indicates the shift in Parsons to the perspective of social systems. **In other words, this marks a transition in Parsonian works from a microscopic analysis of the structure of social action (voluntarism) to the macroscopic systemic analysis of the social reality.**

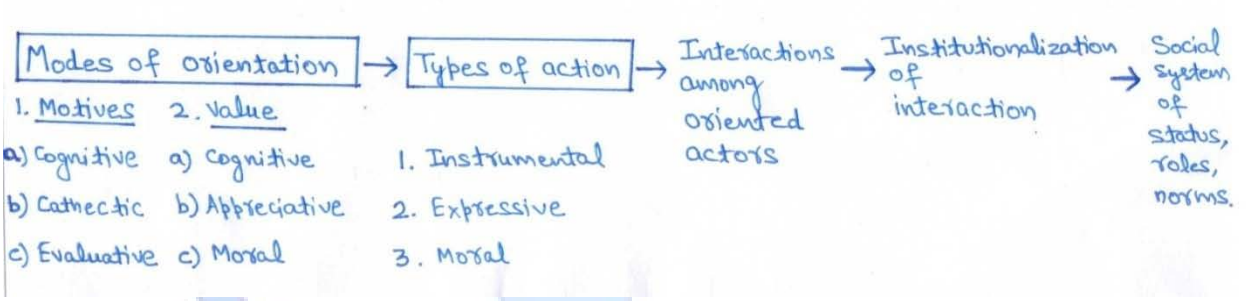

Figure: Parson' conception of Action, Interaction, and Institutionalisation

The figure above summarizes the transition from unit acts to social system. This transition occupies the early parts of Parsons' next significant work, *The Social System.*

However, before proceeding further, I would like to briefly introduce you to Parsons' conception of the system. Now, if you remember the third guiding principle of Parsons' theory of voluntaristic action stated that social reality must be viewed as a system. Here, system is only a way of understanding or looking at reality. System, by itself, is not real. It is only a methodological tool to understand the reality. So, the reality must be viewed as a system. In other words, we should

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try to understand social reality in terms of the concept of system. According to Parsons, if sociology has to be a science, it must resort to systemic analysis as has been done in natural sciences like biology.

Parsons' concept of system implies certain attributes that are ascribed to the reality when we try to understand it as a system. Parsons enumerated several characteristics of a system which are as follows:

Firstly, the chief characteristic of any system is that it is a 'unified whole' made up of interconnected and interdependent parts. These parts are called subsystems. Each sub-system can also be treated as a system by itself.

Secondly, system is structured, which implies that there exists a definite pattern of relationships between sub-systems.

Thirdly, system has goals and based upon the goals there is a boundary and beyond the boundary there is the environment. The system exists in a symbiotic relationship with the environment which implies that there is a continuous interaction between the two.

Fourthly, the system has, according to Parsons, a 'self-equilibrating tendency'. However, the equilibrium is not a fixed state, it is a dynamic process. It implies that, continuously, the equilibrium of the system tends to get disturbed and continuously the system tries to restore the state of equilibrium.

Fifthly, system has internal dynamics. System goes through a process of constant change either owing to internal dynamics (i.e. changes within various sub-systems) or due to changes in its environment with which it is in continuous interaction. But despite these challenges, the system is able to restore equilibrium due to its highly adaptive character. There is a continuous process of adjustment and modification within the system in order to restore equilibrium. Thus, for Parsons, equilibrium is not a fixed state, rather it is a dynamic and continuous process. But how this equilibrium is maintained? Parsons explains this with his notion of needs.

Sixthly, System has needs. Parsons argues that if a system is to exist and maintain itself certain elementary needs of the system must be met. These needs are of two types namely, universal needs and derived needs. Universal needs are those which are universal to all systems. They have been termed as '***imperatives***' (later, Parsons used the term '***functional pre-requisites***'). Then there are other needs which are unique to each system. Therefore, they vary from system to system. They are known as '***derived needs***'. For example, all societies have to

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fulfill the need of arranging food for their members, which is a universal need. But an agrarian society, which has a special mode of food getting, will have its own unique needs (fertile land, division of labour, plough technology) different from those of a society based on hunting and fishing (hunting skills, etc.). We will return to the discussion on 'functional pre-requisites' later.

Let us now try to understand the transition in Parsons from the study of the structure of social action to the study of social action(s) in terms of action systems. As stated earlier, Parsons viewed actors as goal seeking. Now, how does an actor arrives at his goal(s)?

Parsons argues that the actor has certain needs and thus his action is guided by certain '*need-dispositions*'. [Parsons described need-dispositions as the "most significant units of motivation of action." He differentiated need-dispositions from drives. Drives refer to the innate tendencies of any biological organism. On the contrary, he argued that need-dispositions are drives that are shaped by the social setting. For example, need for food is the innate need for every living organism, however, in case human beings (eg., in agrarian society), the need for food gets transformed into need-disposition for cultivation of crops.]

Parsons further argues that guided by need-dispositions, motives arise or, in other words, *motivational orientations* develop. There are three types of motives: (1) **cognitive** (need for information), (2) **cathectic** (need for emotional attachment), and (3) **evaluative** (need for assessment). He further states that corresponding to these three motivational orientations, culture offers three value standards or *value orientations*. There three corresponding value orientations are: (1) **cognitive** (evaluation by objective standards), (2) **appreciative** (evaluation by aesthetic standards), and (3) **moral** (evaluation by absolute rightness and wrongness).

Parsons called these *modes of orientation*. Although this discussion of Parsons is somewhat vague, the general idea seems to be that the relative salience of these motives and values for any actor creates a composite type of action, which can be one of three types: (1) **instrumental** (action oriented to realize explicit goals efficiently), (2) **expressive** (action directed at realizing emotional satisfactions), and (3) **moral** (action concerned with realizing standards of right and wrong). That is, depending on which modes of motivational and value orientation are strongest, an actor will act in one of these basic ways. For example, if cognitive motives are strong and cognitive values are most salient, then action will be primarily instrumental, although the action will also have expressive and moral content. Thus, the various combinations and permutations of the modes of orientation – that is, motives and values – produce action geared in one of these

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general directions. [Thus, drawing inspiration from Weber's typology of social action, Parsons too develops his own typology of social action in terms of instrumental action, expressive action, and moral action.]

For Parsons, "unit acts" therefore involve motivational and value orientations and have a general direction as a consequence of the combination of value and motives that prevails for an actor. Thus far Parsons had elaborated only on his conceptualization of the unit act. The critical next step, which was only hinted at in the closing pages of *The Structure of Social Action*: As variously oriented actors (in the configuration of motivational and value orientations) interact, they develop agreements and sustain patterns of interactions, which become "institutionalized." Such institutionalized patterns can be, in Parsons' view, conceptualized as a **social system**. Such a system represents an emergent phenomenon that requires its own conceptual edifice.

Parsons recognized that the actors are motivationally and value oriented; thus, as with patterns of interaction, the task now becomes one of conceptualizing these dimensions of action in systemic terms. The result is the conceptualization of action as composed of three "interpenetrating action systems": the cultural, the social and the personality. That is, the organization of unit acts into social systems requires a parallel conceptualization of motives and values that becomes, respectively, the personality and cultural systems. The goal of action theory now becomes understanding how institutionalized patterns of interaction (**the social system**) are circumscribed by complexes of norms, values, beliefs, and other ideas (**the cultural system**) and by configurations of motives and role-playing skills (**the personality system**). Later Parsons also added the organismic (subsequently called **behavioral organism**) system. Behavioral organism simply refers to man as a biological being, underlying and conditioning the other systems of action.

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In his work "*Toward a General Theory of Action"* Parsons argued that even a single social action can be analysed as a system.

Thus Parsons argues that when we look at social action as an action system, we can identify the structural components of the action system in terms of four subsystems viz. social system, cultural system, personality system and behavioral organism.

Now the question arises that if we look at social action as an action system, then how equilibrium is maintained in such a system. As stated earlier, according to Parsons, one of the characteristics of the system is its self-equilibrating tendency. For Parsons, the tendency of a given social system to maintain itself is 'the first law of social process.'

Parsons argues that every system has certain needs. As long as the needs of a system are fulfilled by the various parts (structural components) of the system, equilibrium would result. The contribution of parts towards fulfillment of needs is called *function*.

According to Parsons, there are four 'functional pre-requisites' that are necessary for (characteristic of) all systems – **adaptation** (A), **goal attainment** (G), **integration** (I) and **latency** (L). Together these four functional pre-requisites are known as the **AGIL** scheme. In order to survive, a system must perform these four functions:

1. *Adaptation*: A system must cope with external situational exigencies. It must adapt to its environment and adapt the environment to its needs.
2. *Goal Attainment*: A system must define and achieve its primary goals.
3. *Integration*: A system must regulate the interrelationship of its component parts. It must also manage the relationship among the other three functional pre-requisites (A, G, L).
4. *Latency (pattern maintenance and tension management)*: A system must furnish, maintain, and renew both the motivation of individuals and the cultural patterns that create and sustain that motivation. (Latency means existing, but not very noticeable, 'hidden'. By this Parsons implies that cultural values are internalized by the various parts of the system and it is this internalization of values that facilitates pattern maintenance. Tension management concerns

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dealing with the internal tensions and strains of actors in the social system.)

[With the introduction of A, G, I, and L, however, a subtle shift away from the analysis of structures to the analysis of functions occurs in Parsons' theory. Structures are now evaluated explicitly by their functional consequences for meeting the four requisites.]

The next step is to connect each of these four functional pre-requisites to the four action systems. Parsons argues that the *behavioral organism* is the action system that handles the adaptation function by adjusting to and transforming the external environment. The *personality system* performs the goal-attainment function by defining system goals and mobilizing resources to attain them. In other words, the individual's goals as well as the motivational energy to pursue those goals, is mobilized by the personality system. The *social system* copes with the integration function by controlling its component parts. Finally, the *cultural system* performs the latency function by providing actors with the norms and values that motivate them for action.

The following diagram summarizes the structure of the action system in terms of the AGIL schema.

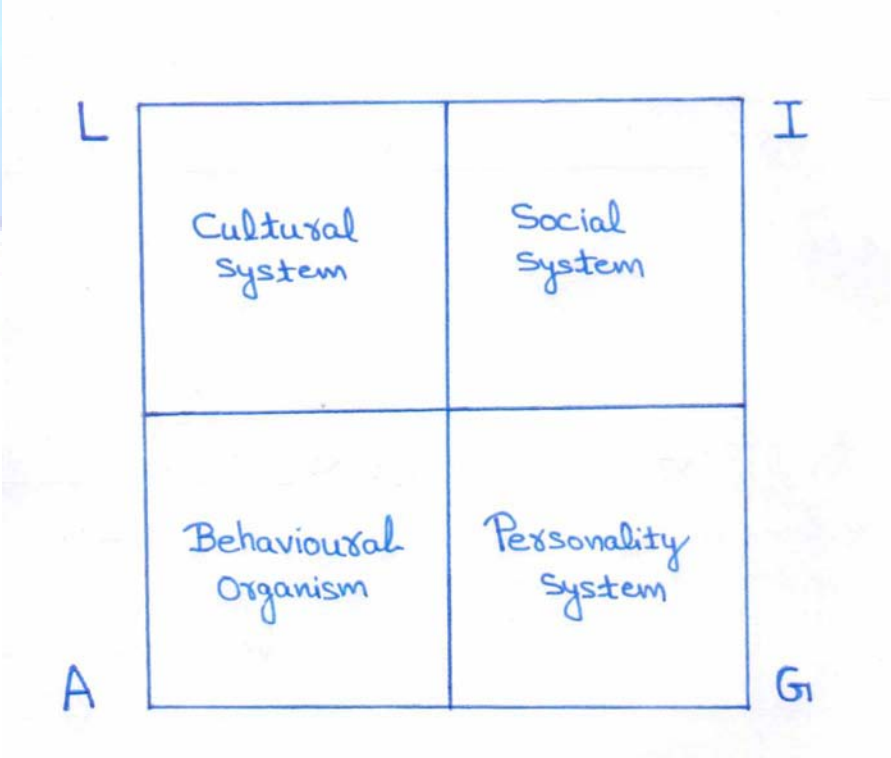

Figure: Structure of the General Action System
(also known as **Functional Paradigm of System of Social Action**)

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So, that is how the equilibrium in the general action system is maintained.

Parsons states that it is the social system (in its plurality of patterns of social interaction) that constitutes the subject matter of sociology and the other subsystems constitute the environment of the social system. So, the sciences that are concerned with the study of other subsystems constitute the ecology of sociology. For example, organismic system is studied by biology, personality system is studied by psychology, and cultural system is studied by anthropology and other disciplines like linguistics etc. so, these sciences constitute, according to Parsons, the ecology of sociology.

The next question that arises is that if the social system is nothing but the institutionalized patterns of interactions, then how these patterns are maintained. In answering this, Parsons argued that value orientations (cultural system) circumscribe the norms of the social system and the decisions of the personality system. Thus, the structure of the personality and social systems reflects the dominant patterns of value orientations in culture. This implicit emphasis on the impact of cultural patterns on regulating and controlling other systems of action became even more explicit in his later work. In other words, what Parsons is implying here is that when looking at social action as a system, the social action (in terms of social interaction) must be understood as being largely shaped by the value orientations (culture).

As you can see here that Parsons very cleverly moves away from his earlier conception of social action in terms of its 'voluntaristic' aspect to the one where it is understood as being largely culturally shaped. At this stage Parsons is interested in the study of social action only in so far as it is patterned or culturally shaped. He seems to be least bothered about the conscious action choice of the actor, which was one of the guiding principles of his social theorizing (that the sociological theory must be a 'voluntaristic' theory of social action). [This is how he moves away from the study of the structure of social action to study of the structure of general action system.]

Since social action is conceived as patterned, social interaction also gets patterned. How social action gets patterned? Because it is culturally shaped and culture itself is patterned, thus giving rise to patterned social interactions in society. Thus culture is seen as a patterned, ordered system of symbols that are objects of orientation to actors, internalized aspects of the personality system, and institutionalized patterns in the social system.

Let me elaborate on this.

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For Parsons, the social system is the key subsystem (which is why Parsons writes a whole book about it), as its function is to hold all the other subsystems together (integration). Parsons was now asking that how systems resolve their integrative problems. The answer is provided by the elaboration of additional concepts that point to how personality systems and culture are integrated into the social system, thereby providing some degree of normative coherence and a minimal amount of commitment by actors to conform to norms and play their respective roles.

The figure below delineates the key ideas in Parsons' reasoning.

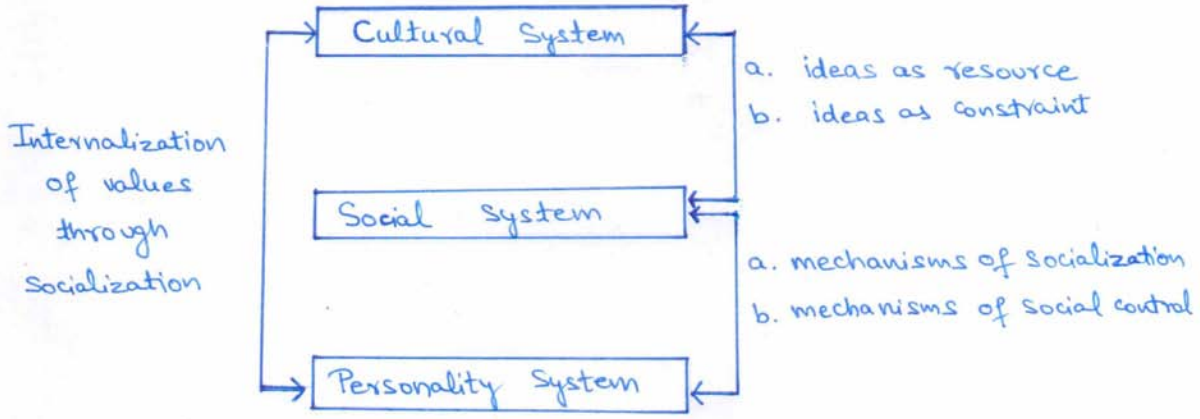

Figure: Parsons' early conception of integration among Systems of Action

Just how are personality systems integrated into the social system, thereby promoting equilibrium? At the most abstract level, Parsons conceptualized two mechanisms that integrate the personality into the social system: (1) mechanisms of socialization and (2) mechanisms of social control.

1. *Mechanisms of socialization* are the means through which cultural patterns – values, beliefs, languages and other symbols – are internalized into the personality system, thereby circumscribing its need structure. That is, Parsons was interested in the ways in which the norms and values of a system are transferred to the actors within the system. In a successful socialization process these norms and values are internalized; that is, they become part of the actors' "consciences." As a result, in pursuing their own interests, the actors are in fact serving the interests of the system as a whole. [In general, Parsons assumed that actors usually are passive recipients in the socialization process. Children learn not only how to act but also the norms and values, the morality, of society. Socialization is conceptualized as a

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conservative process in which need-dispositions (which are themselves largely molded by society) bind children to the social system, and it provides the means by which the need-dispositions can be satisfied. There is little or no room for creativity.]

2. *Mechanisms of social control* involve those ways in which *status-roles* are organized in social systems to reduce strain and deviance. *Status* refers to a structural position within the social system, and *role* refers to the 'normatively-defined' expectations from the actor occupying a certain status. Role is the behavioral aspect of status. There can be no status without a corresponding role attached to it. Role is, thus, the dynamic aspect of status and consists of rights and duties attached to it. Thus, an individual occupying the status of a father/teacher, simultaneously, has some rights over his children/students, as well as some responsibilities towards them. Statuses and roles are, thus, two sides of the same coin. [As you can notice that Parsons here is looking at the actor not in terms of thoughts and actions but instead as nothing more than a bundle of statuses and roles. In other words, he is looking only at social action only to the extent it is culturally patterned.]

Parsons further argues since single social action does not exist in isolation, the social situation is marked by the presence and interaction among plurality of 'actors-in-role'. This gives rise to '*role-reciprocity*', that is, each role exists in relation to its corresponding role, eg., father-son, teacher-student, doctor-patient, etc. Roles are thus backed by internalized *mutual normative expectations* concerning what are considered proper actions in particular situations, furthered by mechanisms of social control (i.e., sanctions in the form of punishments, etc.). Subjective meaning and legitimacy of role expectations are derived from the value pattern, and supported by institutionalized systems of sanctions. Thus, although culture is separate from its social system, cultural values interpenetrate the social system by setting normative standards for evaluating role performance. Similarly, roles also represent interpenetration between social system and personality, where interpenetration results from processes of socialization, internalization of norms and values, and social control.

It should be obvious how these concepts and assumptions influence the problem of social order, also known as the problem of "*double contingency*." In every interaction, the outcome for each actor is dependent not only upon his or her own choices, but also upon those of other actors as well. Thus, social order becomes a problem of coordination, focusing attention on how harmony can be

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achieved between personalities from differentiated role systems, each with their own internalized norms, expectations, value orientations, and sets of moral standards. The key element, according to Parsons, is culture. Internalization of common cultural values in the personality is basic to norms and evaluative standards that bring about coordination of action orientations and motivation, and thereby the harmonious functioning of the social system.

A tendency towards attributing primacy to culture over the individual volition can be observed here, which later became one of the main targets of criticism of Parsons. Parson's model presents a very passive image of actors. They seem to be impelled by drives, dominated by the culture, or, more usually, shaped by a combination of drives and culture (that is, by need-disposition). The dominant impression that emerges from Parsons' works is one of a 'passive personality system.'

But Parsons was after all Parsons.

Parsons tried to sort out this ambivalence concerning the relationship between action and culture through his famous *pattern variables*. Thus again showing the significance of the voluntaristic dimension of the action frame of reference.

How he did this?

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As stated earlier, Parsons has stated that value orientations (cultural system) circumscribe the norms of the social system and the decisions of the personality system. Thus, the structure of the personality and social systems reflects the dominant patterns of value orientations in culture. In other words, at this stage, Parsons is interested in the study of social action only in so far as it is patterned or culturally shaped. Since social action is conceived as patterned, social interaction also gets patterned. How social action gets patterned? Because it is culturally shaped and culture itself is patterned, thus giving rise to patterned social interactions in society.

Moving forward Parsons argued that though culture is patterned but not monolithically, but rather dualistically. Further, this duality of cultural patterns is manifested at four or five levels, the number depending on the context. Parsons calls this duality of cultural patterns (or value orientations) as *pattern variables*. Thus, pattern variables, according to Parsons, represent basic values or types of action orientation between which actors have to choose in every action situation. In other words, this duality of cultural patterns (pattern variables) offers a range of choice to the actor. [This is how Parsons tried to bring back 'voluntarism'.]

The five pattern variables are:

1. ***Affectivity*** versus ***Affective Neutrality*** concerns the amount of emotion or affect that is appropriate in a given interaction situation. Should a great deal or little affect be expressed? If the actor, while defining his relationship with the object, choose to set aside his own feelings and emotions for the benefit of an instrumental relationship oriented to the ends (goals), then, it is a case of affective neutrality. Relationships in the occupational sphere are characterized by affective neutrality like in case of civil servant and mercenary soldiers. The other possibility is that the actor allows his feelings and emotions to dominate his relationship with a physical or social object, which is a case of affectivity. The relations in a family or peer group are characterized by affectivity.

2. ***Diffuseness*** versus ***Specificity*** denotes the issue of how far-reaching obligations in an interaction situation are to be. Should the obligations be narrow and specific, or should they be extensive and diffuse? If the actor orients himself in a diffused manner than he is involved as a total person as in the case with one's spouse or children. On the other hand, one might relate with the others in a highly specific for a limited purpose as in case of doctor-patient relationship.

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3. ***Particularism*** versus ***Universalism*** points to the problem of whether 'evaluative standards' (i.e. evaluation of 'others' in an interaction situation) are based on universal criteria or the beliefs only of a particular society. This is the dilemma which relates to the criteria to be adopted in judging a physical or social object. Whether someone is a good student or beautiful woman can be judged according to criteria applicable to a whole range of objects. If one adopts such criteria one has opted of universalism. Alternately, while judging the object one can look at the ways in which the respective physical or social object is unique like a father looks at his son or a man looks at his girl friend. To look at things in this way is to opt of particularism.

4. ***Ascription*** versus ***Achievement*** deals with the issue of how to assess an actor, whether by inborn qualities, such as sex, age, race, and family status or by performance. Should an actor treat another in a certain way because of achievements or ascriptive qualities that are unrelated to performance? This pattern variable can also be understood in terms of *quality* versus *performance*. The actor can judge a physical or social object according to what it does or achieves; his judgement in this case is based on the object's performance (achievement). On the other hand, the actor might attribute importance to the object in itself independently of its achievement. In this case, the actor's judgement is based on the quality of the object.

5. ***Self*** versus ***Collectivity*** denotes the extent to which action is to be oriented to self-interest and individual goals or to group interests and goals. Should actors consider their personal or self-related goals over those of the group or large collectivity in which they are involved? [Please note that Parsons later dropped some of these concepts from the action scheme such as *self* versus *collectivity*, because he believed that these are implied or covered in the other four pattern variables.]

Important: Please note that Parsons considered the pattern variables to be a kind of specification of Ferdinand Tonnies's *Gemeinschaft* and *Gesellschaft*, but they can also be connected with Max Weber's ideal types of action and authority, related to traditional versus modern societies.

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Ferdinand Tonnies (1855-1936): Tonnies was a German scholar. In his most famous work "***Gemeinschaft and Gesellschaft***" (1887), he argued that all social relations are creations of *human will*, of which there are two types. The first is ***essential will***, the basic instinctive organic tendencies which drive human activity from behind. The second is ***arbitrary will***, the deliberative and purposive form of volition, which determines human activity with regard to the future. Thus, by emphasizing the importance of will or volition in the human behaviour, Tonnies made a significant departure from the then dominant classical evolutionist approach.

He further argued that these two modes of will explain the existence of two basic types of social groups. A social group may be willed into being because sympathies among the members make them feel that this relationship is a value in itself. On the other hand, a social group may arise as an instrument to attain a definite end. The first type of group, the expression of essential will, is called Gemeinschaft, while the other is called Gesellschaft. The term ***Gemeinschaft*** means "***community***" in German and refers to a society characterized by the predominance of intimate primary relationships and by emphasis upon tradition, consensus, informality, and kinship. This pattern of society is most closely approximated by rural-agricultural societies. The term ***Gesellschaft*** means "***society***" in German, and by this term he referred to a type of society in which secondary relations predominate, that is, in which social relationships are formal, contractual, expedient, impersonal and specialized. ***In current terminology, the term Gemeinschaft approximates to community, while Gesellschaft refers to association***. For Tonnies, the concepts of Gemeinschaft and Gesellschaft refers not only to types of human groupings but also to stages of growth whereby Gemeinschaft type of society, over time gives way to Gesellschaft type of society. Here, one can find the influence of evolutionism in his ideas.

Thus, *affectivity*, *diffuseness*, *particularism*, and *ascription* (quality) comprise Tonnies' Gemeinschaft relationship, while *affective neutrality*, *specificity*, *universalism*, and *achievement* (performance) are typical patterns in Gesellschaft relationship.

Further, Parsons also related these pattern variables with his paradigm of 'functional pre-requisites.' He argued that systems engaged in Adaptation largely follow the Gesellschaft pattern, the systems engaged in Integration largely follow Gemeinschaft pattern while the systems engaged in the Goal-Attainment and Latency follow partly Gesellschaft and partly Gemeinschaft pattern. This linkage reflects the cognitive consonance between 'pattern variables' and 'paradigm'.

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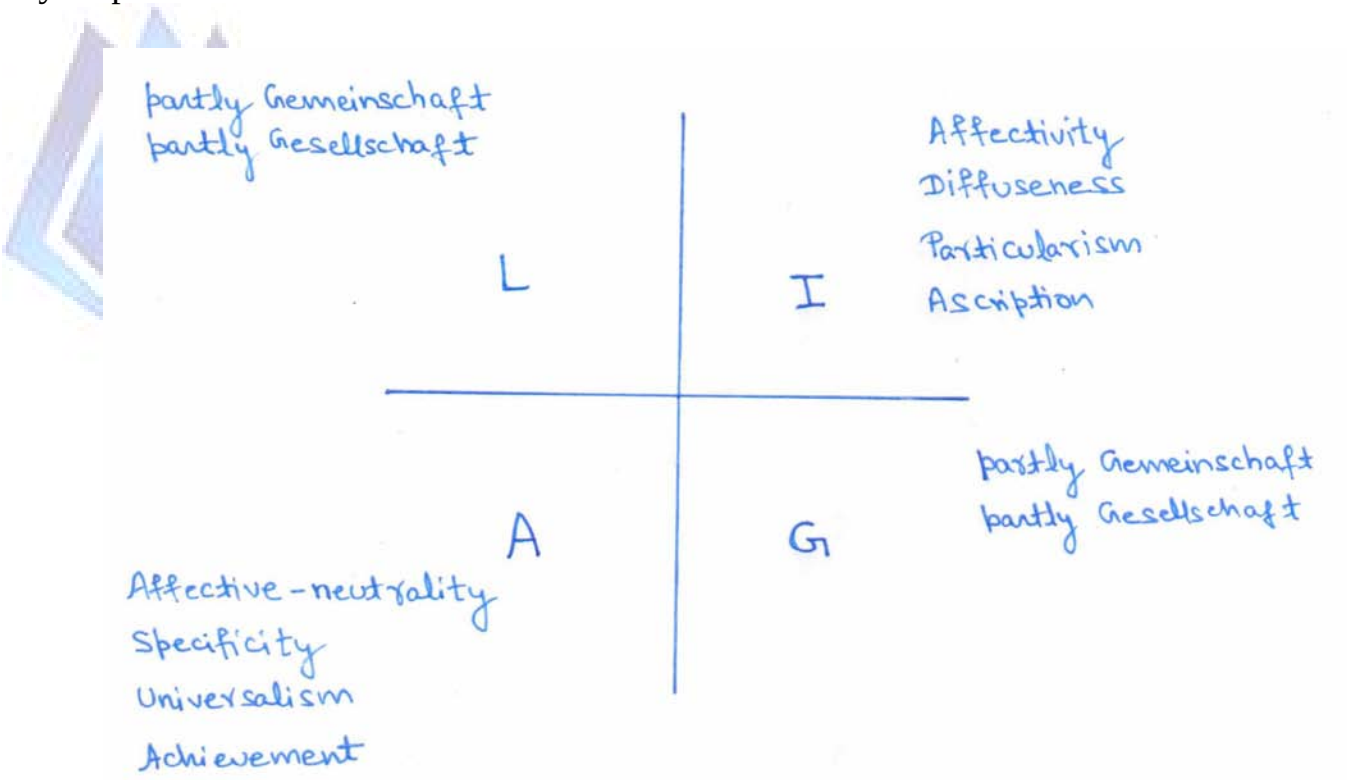
Please note that this was only a speculative exercise on his part, not based on any empirical research.



He further argued that these four patterns variables represent dilemmas or choices of orientation which have to be resolved before an action is performed. Referring to the way those dilemmas get resolved, Parsons emphasizes on the fact that the choice of one pattern over other in different situations has been defined by culture and institutionalized as normative patterns (since he presumed that the values-choices that guide social action become embedded in the institutions of society). In other words, having accorded primacy to the culture (value orientations) over the other subsystems, Parsons tends to imply that even the actors' choices with regard to the pattern variables is largely culturally shaped.

The implication of pattern variables for Parsons and his followers was that it appeared that American society of the 1950s had reached the highest level of social and institutional sophistication yet achieved. Society operated on the principles of rational detachment, which characterized the modern approach to life in general. Social action was also relatively specified (rather than diffuse) in the sense that it was focused on and regulated by the functional requirements of specific social roles. The general value system exhibited high levels of universalism (rather than particularism) as it tried to enact the basic civic principles of 'life, liberty and the pursuit of happiness'. The irrational claims of selfish individuals and particular groups were prevented from eclipsing the collective interest of American society as a whole. Finally, society had become fully meritocratic in the sense that actors

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could be rewarded for their own achievements in society rather than being pigeonholed into ascribed categories over which they had no control. Using the technical jargon of Parsons' theory, America in the 1950s could be described as having reached the advanced and sophisticated pattern of 'universalistic-achievement'.

It is worth noting that the cultural prescriptions (as stated by Parsons in the form of *pattern variables*) are unambiguous and clear only in large stabilized social systems of developed industrial societies. In third World countries which are in the process of transition from Gemeinschaft type of relations to Gesellschaft relations one can often comes across conflicting cultural prescriptions, because cultural patterns of both Gemeinschaft and Gesellschaft coexist. In such situations it is not easy to resolve the dilemma. For example, in a country like India, where caste, religious and regional identities and affinities coexist with modern values of rationality, secularism and democracy, an individual may find it hard negotiating with traditional as well as modern values.

This completes Parsons' transition from the structure of social action to the structure of general action system.

Now he moves on to an even higher level of social theorizing. Here we will witness the transition in Parsonian writings from the analysis of the structure of social action as such to the structural-functional analysis of social systems.

Remember that for Parsons, a single social act does not exist in isolation. Each action is a response to some previous action and, in turn, gives rise to a further action. So what exists in reality is a chain of interconnected actions – social interactions. These social interactions get patterned and institutionalized over a period of time. Such institutionalized patterns can be, in Parsons' view, conceptualized as a social system. So, in reality there could be many social systems coexisting. For example, patterns of interactions among father, mother and their children could be understood as a social system, namely, family system. Similarly, patterns of interactions relating to the production, distribution and consumption could be understood as yet another social system, namely, economic system. Likewise, patterns of interactions related to political affairs constitute another social system, namely, political system. Since all these systems coexist with a society, so the entire society in itself could also be viewed as a system.So, now Parsons moves on to explain that how society (as a whole) maintains itself as a system and how the equilibrium results in the society.

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As stated earlier, although the idea of a social system encompasses all types of collectivities, one specific and particularly important social system is *society*, "a relatively self-sufficient collectivity the members of which are able to satisfy all their individual and collective needs and to live entirely within its framework." As a structural functionalist, Parsons distinguished among four structures, or subsystems, in society in terms of the functions (AGIL) they perform. The ***economy*** is the subsystem that performs the function for society of adapting to the environment through labor, production, and allocation. Through such work, the economy adapts the environment to society's needs, and it helps society adapt to these external realities. The economy represents the interface between the social system and the physical environment. The ***polity*** (or political system) performs the function of goal attainment by pursuing societal objectives and mobilizing actors and resources to that end. The ***fiduciary system*** (for example, in the schools, the family) handles the latency function by transmitting culture (norms and values) to actors and allowing it to be internalized by them. "Fiduciary system" is the name that Parsons preferred for the social subsystem that performs the pattern-maintaining function of reproducing, legitimizing, and maintaining commitment to beliefs, moral values, and expressive symbols. Its primary link is to the cultural action system. Finally, the integration function is performed by the ***societal community*** (for example, nation, law) which coordinates the various components of society.

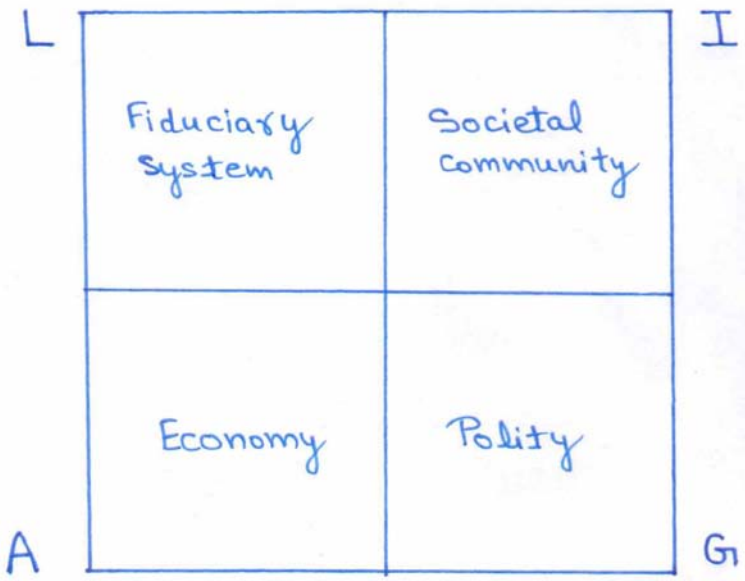

Figure: Society, its subsystems and the functional imperatives (also called **Functional Paradigm of Social System**)

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Parsons further argues that these subsystems of society are interconnected and interdependent. Hence, for equilibrium in society, it is necessary that these subsystems exist in harmony with each other. Thus every society must ensure compatibility at its subsystem level. Since society is dynamic in nature, changes in one subsystem without corresponding changes in other subsystems give rise to subsystem incompatibility. Subsystem incompatibility would result in social disorder. Through internal dynamics, subsystem incompatibility in society is resolved and equilibrium is restored. Please also remember that Parsons in his discussion on action systems had given primacy to cultural system (value orientations) over and above personality and social system. This implied that actors' needs, motives and his action choices are largely determined by the cultural norms and values. [This resolves the motivational problem of order.] Since culture is ordered, patterned and shared by all members of society, conformity to cultural norms and values gives rise to order and equilibrium in society. In other words, for Parsons, a general ***value consensus*** among the members of a given society along with the ***subsystem compatibility*** is essential for social order and equilibrium in society. Parsons thus addresses the problem of order in society.

However his paradigm of structural-functional analysis came under severe criticism, particularly by conflict theorists. Critics argued that Parsons' paradigm has a *status quoist* bias and it is unable to account for conflict and change. So much so that Parsons' theory of social system was criticized as 'veiled status quoist ideology'.

In the light of these criticisms Parsons, taking a cue from the advances in biology, adopted the idea of **cybernetic hierarchy of control** in his theory of social system and social change. After viewing each action system as a subsystem of a more inclusive, overall system, Parsons explored the interrelations among the four subsystems in terms of exchange of information and energy. What emerged is a hierarchy of informational controls, with culture informationally circumscribing the social system, social system informationally regulating the personality system, and personality system informationally regulating the organismic system. For example, cultural value orientations would be seen as circumscribing or limiting the range of variation in the norms of the social system; in turn, these norms, as translated into expectations for actors playing roles, would be viewed as limiting the kinds of motives and decision-making processes in personality systems; these features of the personality system would then be seen as circumscribing biochemical processes in the organism. Conversely, each system in the hierarchy is also viewed as providing the "energic conditions" necessary for action at the next higher system. That is, the organism provides the energy necessary for the personality system, the personality system provides the energic conditions for the social system, and the organization of personality systems into a social system

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provides the conditions necessary for a cultural system. Thus, the input/output relations among action systems are reciprocal, with systems exchanging information and energy. Systems high in information circumscribe the utilization of energy at the next lower system level, and each lower system provides the conditions and facilities necessary for action in the next higher system.

This scheme has been termed a *cybernetic hierarchy* of control and is diagrammed in figure below.

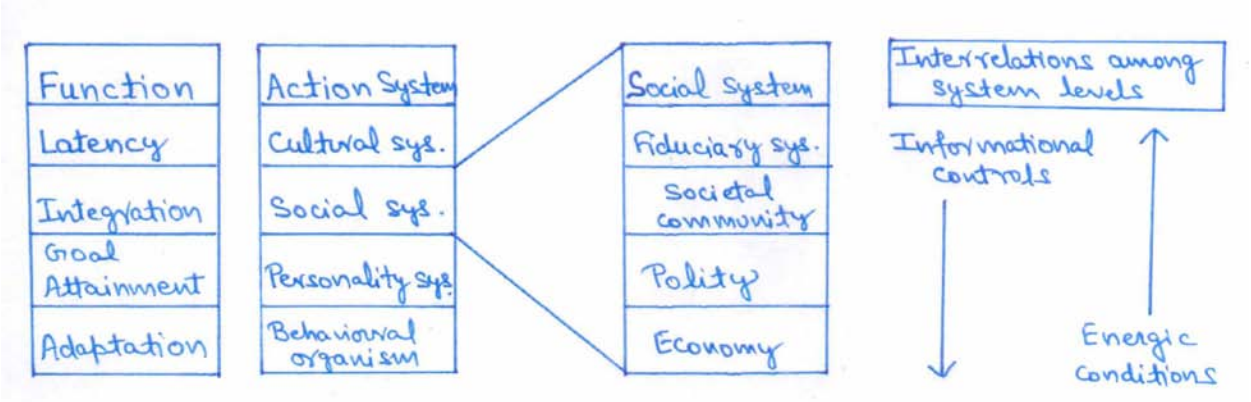

Figure: Parsons' Cybernetic Hierarchy of Control

To explain how the social subsystems and their interchange work and how the functional control is mediated, Parsons introduced his concept of *generalized symbolic media of interchange*. This idea was fostered by his studies in the fifties, together with Neil Smelser, of the economic subsystem (Parsons and Smelser 1956), where he dealt with the function of money as a symbolic medium, carrying information on needs (as purchasing power) from potential buyers to potential sellers, thus allocating productive efforts according to purchase power in the economy. Money symbolizes economic goods. Money is a symbolic medium because the money is not worth by itself; its value is evident only for what it says symbolically in an exchange relationship. By looking in the other subsystems for analogies to money as a steering medium in the economic subsystem, he constructed three other symbolic media, characteristic of each of the other subsystems. In the polity, the medium of interchange is power, in the societal community, the medium is influence, and in the fiduciary system, the medium is value commitment.

Thus, power is seen as a generalized symbolic medium in the sense that a power position in an institutional structure implies entitlement to make certain decisions that are binding and obligatory on the collectivity and its members. Under representative democratic rule, it can be said that voters exchange their votes for expected benefits from political system, implying an obligation, enforced

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by law, to obedience to legitimate decisions made by government. Power symbolizes a capacity for instrumentally effective and organized, collective efforts. By analogy, influence means a capacity to bring about desired decisions in the interest of collectivities, though in this case by persuasion and appealing to loyalty on behalf of common interests, based on position in a prestige hierarchy in a societal community. Influence thus symbolizes the will to act according to principles of solidarity. Finally, the generalized medium of value commitment operates through a general conviction of legitimacy of norms and moral values, and a readiness to implement them into action. Thus, value commitment appeals to concepts of moral duty, honor, and guilt.

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After having discussed Weber's perspective and subject matter, let us now move on to his methodology. As stated earlier, the aim of sociology, according to Weber, is different from those of natural sciences. Natural sciences are primarily interested in search for the underlying patterns or laws governing the physical matter. Sociology, on the other hand, seeks to understand social behaviour in terms of meanings and motives, though sociology also attempts to arrive at limited generalizations. Therefore, social sciences cannot rely on positive science methods alone. According to Weber, since the cognitive aim of sociology is to understand human behaviour, therefore, a sociological explanation should be adequate both at the level of meanings as well as at the level of causality. Therefore Weber suggests *Verstehen* method for sociological enquiry. This expression is taken from Dilthey, but Weber used it in a somewhat different sense. The Verstehen approach is usually translated as 'interpretive understanding'.

According to Weber, the Verstehen method involves the interpretive understanding of social action through empathetic liaison in order to build a sequence of motives to trace the course and effect of social action. In other words, this method seeks to understand social action at the 'level of meanings' and then tries to build a sequence of motives which underlie the social action. Thus a sociological explanation becomes adequate both at the level of meanings as well as at the level of causality.

According to Weber, the Verstehen method involves two steps:

1. Direct observational understanding
2. Explanatory understanding

The first step involved in the Verstehen method is 'direct observational understanding' of the obvious subjective meanings of actor's behaviour. At this stage, the social scientist looks at the social phenomenon from outside and attributes natural meanings to what he observes. Direct observational understanding is obtained directly, either because one knows the rules for a certain behavior (in church, for example) or by empathy when someone expresses his feelings. We understand most every day events in this intuitive manner. For example, through direct observation, we can know the meanings of an obviously hungry man or a man aiming a gun at an animal. We can grasp these meanings because we are aware of the subjective intentions which we attach to our like actions.

Second step involves, establishing an empathetic liaison with the actor. Here, the observer identifies himself with the actor by imaginatively placing himself in the actor's situation and then tries to interpret the likely meanings which

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the actor might have had given to the situation and the consequent motives which would have given rise to the action. We gain an explanatory understanding when we know the motives behind a person's actions. In this case, the action is explained precisely by the intent behind it: what the person wanted to achieve with the action. It is this type of explanatory understanding that science should work with, according to Weber. In order to trace the course and effect of social action, the sociologists should try to build a sequence of motives linking one with the other and finally linking them to the effect or consequences of social action. Weber wanted the interpretation of social action to be adequate both at the level of meanings as well as at the level of causality. An interpretation of a sequence of events is causally adequate, if careful observations lead to the generalization that it is probable that the sequence will always occur in the same way. Such a generalization should be derived statistically, as far as possible.

Illustration – Describing Social Action

How might we go about studying a person riding a bicycle? Adopting the techniques of a natural scientist we can measure how fast he is going, in what direction, how often he changed gear. We can say how tall or heavy he is, what the conditions are like and what kinds of materials the bike is made from. What we cannot determine just by looking at the cyclist, however, is *why* he is cycling. For this we need to adopt the approach of the social scientist, going beyond bare description in order to develop theories of action and motivation. Is the cyclist peddling quickly because he is late for a lecture in social theory or because he is trying to improve his fitness? Is he getting pleasure from cycling voluntarily, or is he having to do so because somebody has stolen his car? The full picture of cycling requires more than observation; it also requires interpretation.

However, according to some sociologists, it is not clear as to what Weber really meant when he wished to reconcile the interpretation of action by the Verstehen with the causal explanation. Interpreters of Weber have variously suggested that Verstehen merely generates causal hypotheses of meanings that can function as causes. The use of Verstehen has been criticized severely on the ground that there is no way of validating Verstehen interpretations. However, the advantage of Verstehen lies in the fact that it can be applied with equal ease to study contemporary social phenomena as well as to study the past historical phenomena. As Weber states, '*One does not have to be a Caesar to know Caesar*'.

According to Weber, social and historical reality consists of manifold actions and interests. When the investigator studies this "chaos of facts" he does so from certain points of view. The statement of the problem and the selection of facts the researcher makes are always related, consciously or unconsciously, to "cultural

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values." He studies what is important for him to study. Thus, according to Weber, there can never be any objective scientific analysis of cultural life, since the investigator always ascribes cultural significance to the phenomena he studies. Attempts to write an objective history are also based on certain cultural values. The problem, then, is that this also opens the door for various other kinds of value judgments.

While social science is value-relevant, it must also be value-neutral, according to Weber. Science can speak only of facts, never of values. Weber strongly stresses that there is a fundamental difference between "existential knowledge," that is, knowledge of what "is," and "normative knowledge," that is, what "should be". Every person has his values and the choice of these values is always subjective. Consequently, science can never state an opinion on "true" values, but must rather limit itself to analyzing the effects of various actions. But it can never say what action should be chosen. There is always an insurmountable chasm between empirical knowledge and value judgments. This difference between "is" and "ought" must prevent the scientist from using his prestige and knowledge to assert his own values at the expense of others.

To solve the problem of the relationship of science to values and the value-neutrality of science, Weber developed his *ideal-type* methodology. Further, Weber states that social reality by its very nature is infinitely complex and cannot be comprehended in its totality by the human mind. Therefore, selectivity is unavoidable and in order to exercise selectivity sociologists should build "*ideal types*". This also implies that *Verstehen* cannot be applied directly to social reality. The social scientist must first build the ideal type and then apply Verstehen method to the ideal type.

Although social theorists are always faced with the dilemma that there is a reality gap between the ideas and concepts they use and the really real world 'out there' , which they hope to explain by using them, Weber suggested that his could sometimes be turned into an advantage. Given that we are free to make up whatever concepts we like, it might be useful for social theorists to develop concepts that represent the purest form, or 'ideal type', of a particular phenomenon. Although there is no expectation that any particular instance of that phenomenon can match the ideal type, it nonetheless provides a useful intellectual tool for thinking about what the most essential or typical characteristics of a particular event or action might be. For example, in making sociological comparisons between different types of family in a particular society it can be useful to refer to different general types of family rather than attempting the impossible task of describing each and every family individually. Sociologists have developed the ideal-typical descriptions of 'nuclear family' and 'extended family'

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as part of their methodology. Ideal types provide a way of conceptualising differences even if the ideal type is never observed in its pure form. Weber uses the technique of ideal type in his own analysis of social action, religious ideology, and authority, in particular, bureaucracy.

An ideal type is a mental construct – a mental picture – that the investigator uses to approach the complex reality. The ideal type has nothing to do with "ideals," but is ideal only in a purely logical sense. The investigator can create ideal types of anything and none of them assesses any value. The ideal type is an instrument for the investigator to use as he attempts to capture the manifold nature of reality, and its utility lies in its "success in revealing concrete phenomena in their interdependence, their causal conditions and their *significance*". The investigator arrives at the ideal type through "the one-sided *accentuation* of one or more point of view and by the synthesis of a great many diffuse, discrete, more or less present and occasionally absent concrete individual phenomena, which are arranged according to those one-sidedly emphasized viewpoints into a unified *analytical* construct".

An ideal type is an analytical construct that serves the investigator as a measuring rod to ascertain similarities as well as deviations in concrete cases. It is neither a statistical average nor an hypothesis; rather it is a mental construct, an organization of intelligible relations within a historical entity, formed by exaggerating certain essential features of a given phenomenon so that no one case of that phenomenon corresponds exactly to the constructed type but every case of that phenomenon falls within the definitional framework. Thus an ideal type is never an accurate representation of the real thing. For example, as constructed by Weber, the ideal type of capitalism did not fully describe any of the various types of capitalism - mercantile capitalism, entrepreneurial capitalism (characteristic of the 18th and 19th century), matured industrial capitalism, etc. From the point of view of his study only some of the features of early entrepreneurial capitalism were relevant which depicted the spirit of capitalism. Therefore Weber isolated these elements and ideally represented these elements alone. Now these elements were not necessarily present in the later forms of capitalism, especially in mature industrial capitalism and finance capitalism. Thus ideal types do not and cannot mirror the reality faithfully.

The ideal type as Weber understood it had nothing to do with moral ideal, for the type of perfection implied in the ideal is purely a logical one and not to be found in pure form in any socio-historical situation. Any social phenomenon has an ideal type, be it a brothel, a house of worship or a market place. For Weber, an ideal type is strictly a "methodological device". The ideal type is a rational grid for logical observation and analysis. In other words, an ideal type is a rational construction for the purpose of research.

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Weber uses his ideal-type methodology in part to reject the idea that science can capture reality "as it is objectively." As a Neo-Kantian, Weber believed that concepts (ideal types) are always creations of human reason that never have a counterpart in reality. This also applies to the "laws" investigators believe they find in social reality. For example, when Weber discusses Marx he says the laws Marx and the Marxists thought they had found in history and in bourgeois society were actually nothing but ideal types. As ideal types, they have a very important significance if they are used in a comparison with reality, but according to Weber they are actually dangerous if we believe they are empirically valid or express actual forces in reality.

Ideal type is a one-sided view of social reality which takes into account certain aspects of social life while ignoring others. Which aspects are to be given importance to, and which are to be ignored depends upon the object of study. Thus, an ideal type is a way of exercising selectivity.

Ideal type formulation also helps in the developing the classificatory typology of the social phenomenon, thus facilitating a comprehensive understanding of the infinite social reality. For example, Weber developed classificatory typologies of social action, religious ideology and authority.

Ideal type can also help in establishing logical interconnections between different social constellations. For example, Weber in his work, *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*, builds ideal types of *the protestant ethic* and *the spirit of capitalism* and establishes the relationship between the two.

Ideal type also serves the investigator as a measuring rod to ascertain similarities as well as deviations in concrete cases, thus helpful in comparison with reality.

Ideal type also has a limited utility as a source of prediction. As discussed earlier, Weber argues that the laws Marx and the Marxists thought they had found in history and in bourgeois society were actually nothing but ideal types. As ideal types, they have a very important significance if they are used in a comparison with reality.

Further, although ideal type is rooted in reality, it does not represent reality in totality. It is a mental construct. Weber claims that ideal type is a social science equivalent of experimentation in physical and natural sciences. Experimentation is an essential element of scientific method to check the validity and reliability of the research findings in natural sciences. Since due to moral and ethical reasons experimentation is not possible in social sciences which are involved in the study of human behaviour, ideal type can serve as an equivalent of

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experimentation in social sciences. As experimentation is conducted under the controlled conditions, likewise an ideal type is also a rational construction based on selectivity.

Thus, according to Weber, the methodology of sociology consists in building ideal types of social behaviour and applying Verstehen method to explain this. Weber's thesis on "*The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*" is a very good example of the application of this methodology. Besides contributing directly to the development of sociology by suggesting the 'Verstehen' approach and 'ideal types', Weber's general conception of the nature of social reality influenced the emergence of other approaches in sociology. For example, we can trace the origins of symbolic interactionism to Max Weber's argument that people act according to their interpretation of the meaning of their social world. But it was George Herbert Mead (1863-1931), a U.S. philosopher, who introduced symbolic interactionism to sociology in the 1920s. Similarly, ethnomethodologists draw heavily on the European tradition of phenomenological philosophy and in particular acknowledge a debt to the ideas of the philosopher–sociologist Alfred Schutz (1899-1959). Alfred Schutz, a German Social Philosopher was inspired by the ideas of Max Weber. He contributed to the rise of phenomenological approach which in turn gave rise to ethnomethodological approach in sociology.

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Another important element of Weber's methodology is *causal pluralism*. According to Weber, the social reality is extremely complex and therefore no social phenomena can be explained adequately in terms of a single cause. An adequate sociological explanation must therefore be based on the principle of causal pluralism.

Weber also stresses on the *value-neutrality* of social science methodology. He argues that since social science deals with phenomena that are value-laden, the researcher, both in choosing what to study and in reporting his findings, has to be aware of his own value and of the value-content of the phenomenon she is researching. Beginning with the problem of choice, for Weber, and again following Rickert, all observations, whether as part of a deductive or of an inductive procedure, is necessarily preceded by a judgement on the part of the observer about what is worth observing. Scientific knowledge, therefore, does not come about in an orderly fashion and following some carefully planned strategy that all the scientists in the world agree upon, but is a much more haphazard affair that reflects subjective judgements made by members or the scientific community. What we know is essentially a product of what we want to find out. Weber takes this line of reasoning a little further and argues that since it is impossible to grasp every tiny detail about a particular phenomenon, social scientists also have to be very selective when making more immediate decisions about which aspects of a phenomenon to study and in how much detail. Social- scientific knowledge can in fact only even be partial and selective.

Further, looking at value-neutrality in terms or how the observer handles the value-content of the research, Weber notes that values are not objective material entities and cannot be assessed, measured or compared in an entirely logical and dispassionate way. Adopting a rationalist approach to things, since knowledge is actually only a representation of some phenomenon or other in the mind, this representation is always arbitrary. The thing itself is not identical with the idea one has about it. Although conceptual arbitrariness is not so much of a problems when conducting experiments among things that have known and invariable properties, it makes quite a big difference when idea, values and beliefs are the objects of the analysis. The social researcher cannot disregard his own value, nor can he avoid studying values as they present themselves as social phenomena and as the motivators of social action. Being aware of the value-content of social-scientific methodology and of the subject matter itself, what the social research must strive to do is remain neutral in respect of the values that are in play. Social-scientific research fails and social-scientific knowledge is critically undermined if social researchers fail to keep their opinions to themselves. Social-theoretical knowledge, then, is the product of subjective judgement, is partial and selective, and, in at least some respects, arbitrary.

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To summarize, according to Weber, while social science is value-relevant, it must also be value-neutral. Weber admitted that at the level of technical competence values are unavoidable, for example, the very choice of the topic of research is influence by the values of the researcher. However still, the researcher must try to check his ideological assumptions from influencing his research. Further, the researcher should not pass any value judgements on the finding of his research. In other words, the researcher should remain indifferent to the moral implications of his research. Further, in order to ensure objectivity and value-neutrality in sociological research, Weber suggested that the researcher should make his value-preference clear in the research monograph. In other words, the researcher should be value-frank.

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Dear Candidate, until now we have discussed some of the key ideas of Marx. We have discussed historical materialism as a perspective as well as a method. We have also seen that how Marx applied the historical materialism methodology in explaining class conflict and social change in society. We have also discussed the concept of mode of production and its centrality in Marxian theory. However, when we come to the discussion of Paper II, you will also learn that how an Indian Marxist sociologist A.R. Desai has applied this methodology to explain the rise of Indian nationalism in his book '*Social Background of Indian Nationalism*.'

Let us now briefly discuss the various stages of human society which Marx talked about, each being characterized by a particular mode of production. Marx believed that Western society had developed through four main epochs: *primitive communism, ancient society*, *feudal society* and *capitalist society*.

Primitive communism is represented by the societies of pre-history and provides the only example of a classless society according to Marx. Primitive communism represents the earliest stage where forces of production were extremely simple and were commonly owned. For example, in a hunting and gathering band, the earliest form of human society, the land and its products were communally owned. The men hunted and the woman gathered plant food, and the produce was shared by members of the band. Classes did not exist since all members of society shared the same relationship to the forces of production. Every member was both producer and owner, all provided labour power and shared the products of their labour. Hunting and gathering is a subsistence economy which means that production only meets basic survival needs. Classes emerge when the productive capacity of society expands beyond the level required for subsistence. This occurs when agriculture becomes the dominant mode of production.

Next stage was represented by ancient Greece and Rome where the society was divided into masters, those who owned the forces of production, and slaves, who were themselves owned by the masters. In other words, slavery is the very essence of the ancient mode of production. In this system of production the master has the right of ownership over the slave and appropriates the products of the slave's labour. So much so, that the slave is not even allowed to reproduce. The slave is deprived of his own means of reproduction. The ruling classes in these societies acquired their wealth from slave labour. In Roman Italy, slavery on the land (agricultural slavery) assumed an importance beyond anything experienced

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before. In the western half of the Roman Empire, the ancient mode of production gradually transformed into the feudal mode of production.

As discussed earlier, society of medieval Europe (before fourteenth century) was largely feudal in character. Feudalism was the dominant system of social-economic and political organization in Western Europe from tenth to fifteenth century. It had emerged on account of downfall and decentralization of Roman Empire and absence of any central authority. The word 'feudal' comes from *feud* which originally meant a *fief* or land held on condition or service. In a feudal society, land was the source of the power. Thus, feudal system was based on allocation of land in return for service. Feudal society was essentially an agrarian society consisting of land owning nobility and the landless serfs who enjoyed the right to work in the lord's land.

Finally, capitalist society emerged fully with the growth of industrial mode of production and consisted of bourgeoisie who owned the forces of production and the proletariat who contributed their labour. According to Marx, capitalist society was inherently unstable and would eventually transform into a communist society.

Please note that when Marx worked on Asian countries, he used the term *Asiatic mode of production* for the primitive communism stage. The theory of the Asiatic mode of production was devised by Karl Marx around the early 1850s. It is concluded that Marx at first regarded Asian society as a special society which was stagnant and devoid of history, but that at length he overcame this view, considered that the Asiatic mode of production was begotten out of the dissolution of primitive society and was the earliest form of class society and the specific mode of production preceding the ancient mode of production, and placed this mode of production in the series of historical stages of development.

The essence of the theory has been described as "*[the] suggestion ... that Asiatic societies were held in thrall by a despotic ruling clique, residing in central cities and directly expropriating surplus from largely autarkic and generally undifferentiated village communities*". The Asiatic mode of production is characteristic of primitive communities in which ownership of land is communal. These communities are still partly organized on the basis of kinship relations. State controls the use of essential economic resources, and directly appropriates part of the labour and production of the community.

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Sometimes, Marx and Engels stressed the dominant role the state played in Asiatic societies because of either its monopoly of land ownership, its control over irrigation systems, or its sheer political and military power. At other times, they suggested that it was the communal nature of landholding that isolated the inhabitants of different villages from one another and so made them prey to state domination.

The Asiatic mode of production does not seem to be distinguished by the subordination of slaves or serfs, but by the subordination of all workers to the State. The Asiatic mode of production constitutes one of the possible forms of transition from classless to class societies; it is also perhaps the most ancient form of this transition. It contains the contradiction of this transition, i.e. the combination of communal relations of production with emerging forms of the exploiting classes and of the State. Marx did not leave behind any systematic presentation of the history of India. He set down his observations on certain current Indian questions which attracted public attention, or drew materials from India's past and contemporary conditions of his times to illustrate parts of his more general arguments. The concept of Asiatic mode of production is therefore inadequate for an understanding of Indian history and society.

The Asiatic mode of production is a notion that has been the subject of much deliberation on the part of Marxist and non-Marxist commentators alike. The Asiatic mode of production has endured much controversy and contest from many scholars and is the most disputed mode of production outlined in the works of Marx and Engels. Questions regarding the validity of the concept of the Asiatic mode of production were raised in terms of whether or not it corresponds to the reality of certain given societies. Some have rejected the whole concept on the grounds that the socio-economic formations of pre-capitalist Asia did not differ enough from those of feudal Europe to warrant special designation. Some argue that the Asiatic mode of production is not compatible with archaeological evidence.

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Fact, Value and Objectivity

The word **fact** derives from the Latin *factum*. A fact is something that has really occurred or is actually the case. The usual test for a statement of fact is its verifiability, that is, whether it can be proven to correspond to experience. Scientific facts are verified by repeatable experiments. Thus, a fact is regarded as an empirically verifiable observation. A **theory**, on the other hand, is a set of ideas which provides an explanation for something. It is an abstract and generalized statement which tends to establish a logical interrelationship between facts (concepts or variables). Theories involve constructing abstract interpretations that can be used to explain a wide variety of empirical situations.

Thus, in sociology, we can say that a sociological theory is a set of ideas which provides an explanation for human society. As discussed earlier, sociology is a scientific study of society and as we know that scientific research is a guided search for facts based on the formulated hypothesis. A hypothesis is a tentative statement asserting a relationship between certain facts. It is the hypothesis that guides the researcher what data to look for. A social scientist or researcher conducts a field research and collects data (facts) in order to test the hypothesis. After data collection, data is processed. Thereafter, the researcher tests the hypothesis against the processed data. If the hypothesis is proved (i.e. supported by data) then it becomes **thesis** – if it is repeatedly proved, it becomes a **theory** and if it is almost universally true, then if becomes the **law**.

Thesis → Theory → Law

Thesis, Theory and Law, they all are generalizations. They represent different degrees of generalizations. In natural sciences, we hear about several laws but in social sciences we only have theories. Social sciences study social behaviour of man which is guided by unique meanings and motives, values and beliefs, etc. Hence, given the diversity and dynamism of human society in general, it is nearly impossible to arrive at a universally valid generalization or law of human society.

Let us now discuss the interrelationship of theory and facts (empirical research). Robert K. Merton, the American sociologist, has elaborated on this aspect in detail in his essays. In his essay '*The bearing of sociological theory on empirical research*' he argues that without a theoretical approach, we would not know what facts to look for in beginning a study or in interpreting the results of research. Often, existing theories serve as a source for hypothesis formulation and thus stimulate and guide further research resulting in discovery of new facts. For example, Marxian theory suggests that increasing economic inequalities are the primary cause of alienation and class conflict in modern capitalist societies. This

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theory can serve as a source for our hypothesis to understand the rising discontentment among masses in the contemporary Indian society. Thus you may start exploring that to what extent economic inequality is a factor in the rise of Naxalism or caste conflicts in rural India, etc. Thus theory helps to define which kinds of facts are relevant. Secondly, theory establishes a rational link between two or more variables and thus can act as a tool for prediction and control. For example, various theories have highlighted female education as a critical factor in the overall social development. Thus, in order to improve their ranking on the social development index, countries with low female education can initiate female education programmes at national level because we now know that female education has direct bearing on the social development of a society. Thirdly, as stated earlier, theory is an abstract and generalized statement which tends to establish a logical interrelationship between facts (concepts or variables). Theories involve constructing abstract interpretations and thus make the knowledge cross-culturally useful. For example, Weber's ideal type of bureaucracy is nothing but an abstraction which can serve as tool for a comparative study of bureaucratic models across societies.

Merton in his another essay '*The bearing of empirical research on sociological theory*' argues that empirical research is generally assigned a rather passive role: the testing or verification of hypotheses. Merton argues that empirical research goes far beyond the passive role of verifying and testing theory: it does more than confirm or refute hypotheses. According to Merton, research plays an active role: it performs at least four major functions which help shape the development of theory. It *initiates*, it *reformulates*, it *deflects* and it *clarifies* theory. Merton explain in his essay that how under certain conditions, a research finding gives rise to social theory. He calls it ***'serendipity pattern'***. Merton argues that fruitful empirical research not only tests theoretically derived hypothesis, it also originates new hypothesis. This might be termed the 'serendipity' component of research, *i.e.*, the discovery, by chance or sagacity, of valid results which were not sought for. In simpler words, it implies that during the course of research some unanticipated but strategic data may come to light, which may initiate a new theory altogether. For example, Elton Mayo, a professor at the Harvard Business School, in his investigation at the Hawthorne plant of Western Electric Company in Chicago, conducted a series of experiments designed to investigate the relationship between working conditions and productivity. Mayo began with the assumptions of scientific management believing that the physical conditions of the work environment, the aptitude of the worker and the financial incentives were the main determinants of productivity. However, during the course of his research Mayo struck upon the role of informal groups and group norms in determining the productivity. From the Hawthorne studies, developed the human relations school, which challenged and led to the reformulation of the conventional scientific

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management approach. It stated that scientific management provided too narrow a view of man and that financial incentives alone were insufficient to motivate workers and ensure their cooperation. The Hawthorne studies moved the emphasis from the individual worker to the worker as a member of a social group. The behaviour of the worker was seen as a response to group norms rather than simply being directed by economic incentives and management designed work schemes. It was found that the informal work groups develop their own norms and values which are enforced by the application of group sanctions. The power of such sanctions derives from the dependence of the individual upon the group. He has a basic need to belong, to feel part of a social group. He needs approval, recognition and status, needs which cannot be satisfied if he fails to conform to group norms.

Thus there is an intricate relation between theory and fact. Facts (empirical research) and theory are inherently dependent on each other. Factual research and theories can never completely be separated. We can only develop valid theoretical approaches if we are able to test them out by means of factual research.

Important: Dear candidate, since the topic mentioned in the syllabus is '*Fact, Value and Objectivity*', I wish to give you a few hints in case the examiner asks you the role or significance of facts and values in sociology. As you know that a fact is an empirically verifiable observation. It is objective in nature. A value, on the other hand, is subjective in nature. Values are socially accepted standards of desirability. In other words, a value is a belief that something is good and desirable. It defines what is important and worthwhile. Values differ from society to society and culture to culture.

The significance of facts was asserted by the early founding fathers of sociology, be it Comte, Spencer or Durkheim. Remember? We had discussed earlier that how these scholars advocated a positivist approach to study society i.e. they emphasised on the study of only those aspects of social reality which could be empirically observed and hence quantified. Anti-positivist scholars, on the other hand, argued that the subject matter of sociology is the study of human behaviour in society and all human behaviour is guided by values. Hence, these scholars, be it Max Weber, Mead, etc. suggested social action approach to study society.

In this manner, with the limited content, you can easily formulate a good analytical answer. But you must support all your arguments with suitable examples to score better than the others.

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Now we will discuss the role of values in sociological enquiry and associated with it is the problem of objectivity.

As stated earlier, the subject matter of sociology is the study of human behaviour in society. All human behaviour is guided by values. Moreover, social research is in itself a type of social behaviour guided by the value of 'search for true knowledge.' Values are socially accepted standards of desirability. In other words, a value is a belief that something is good and desirable. It defines what is important and worthwhile. Values differ from society to society and culture to culture. For example, in West, the dominant values are individualism and materialism which are this-wordly in nature. While in India, *moksha* had been a long cherished goal of human life which is other-wordly in nature.

In order to have a complete understanding of man's social behaviour it is not only important but also necessary to take into account the unique meanings, motives and values that underlie such behaviour. Initially this view was advocated by anti-positivists scholars (also known as neo-Kantian scholars in Germany) like Wilhelm Dilthey (1833-1911), Wilhelm Windelband (1848-1915) and Heinrich Rikert (1863-1936). Later, Weber also argued that behaviour of man in society is qualitatively different from that of physical objects and biological organisms. He argued that unlike matter, man has consciousness – thoughts, feelings, meanings, intentions and an awareness of being. Because of this, his actions are meaningful. He defines situations and gives meaning to his actions and those of others. As a result, he does not merely react to external stimuli, he does not simply behave, he acts. Thus, if action stems from subjective meanings, it follows that the sociologist must discover those meanings in order to understand action. He cannot simply observe action from the outside and impose an external logic upon it. He must interpret the internal logic which directs the actions of the actor.

However, the views mentioned above are quite antithetical to the propositions of positivist tradition in sociology. Auguste Comte, who is credited with inventing the term sociology and regarded as one of the founders of the discipline, maintained that the application of the methods and assumptions of the natural sciences would produce a 'positive science of society'. In terms of sociology, the positivist approach makes the following assumptions. The behaviour of man, like the behaviour of matter, can be objectively measured. Just as the behaviour of matter can be quantified by measures such as weight, temperature and pressure, methods of objective measurement can also be devised for human behaviour. The positivist approach in sociology places particular emphasis on behaviour that can be directly observed. It argues that factors which are not directly observable such as meanings, feelings, motives, etc. are not particularly important and can be misleading. This is best manifested in the works of

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Durkheim. Durkheim in his *"Rules of Sociological Method"* states that social facts must be treated as 'things' and all the preconceived notions about the social facts must be abandoned.

On the basis of the above discussed ideas of both positivist and anti-positivist scholars, one thing is clear that without taking into account the values that underlie human behaviour, a comprehensive understanding of man's social behaviour would not be possible. Our reliance on positivist approach alone would produce a partial picture of social reality. But if we undertake study of values as well in the course of sociological research then the problem of objectivity raises its head (because we know that values are subjective). Let us now discuss what does objectivity means and how different scholars have tried to address the problem of objectivity in sociology.

Objectivity is a 'frame of mind' so that the personal prejudices or preferences of the social scientists do not contaminate the collection and analysis of data. Objectivity is the goal of scientific investigation. Sociology also being a science aspires for the goal of objectivity. Thus, scientific investigations should be free from the prejudices of race, colour, religion, sex or ideological biases. The need of objectivity in sociological research has been emphasized by all important sociologists. For example, Durkheim, in this '*Rules of the Sociological Method*' stated that 'social facts' must be treated as 'things' and all preconceived notions about the social facts must be abandoned. Even Max Weber emphasized the need of objectivity when he said that sociology must be value-free. According to Radcliffe-Brown, the social scientist must abandon or transcend his ethnocentric and egocentric biases while carrying out researches. Similarly, Malinowski advocated 'cultural relativism' while conducting anthropological field work in order to ensure objectivity.

However, objectivity continues to be an elusive goal at the practical level. In fact, one school of thought represented by Gunnar Myrdal states that complete objectivity in social sciences is a myth. Gunnar Myrdal in his book 'Objectivity in Social Research' argues that total objectivity is an illusion which can never be achieved. Because all research is always guided by certain viewpoints and viewpoints involve subjectivity. Myrdal argues that subjectivity creeps in at various stages in the course of sociological research. For example, the very choice of topic of research is influenced by personal preferences and ideological biases of the researcher. How personal preferences influence the choice of topic of research can be illustrated from a study made by Prof. Schwab. In his study he analyzed 4000 scientific papers produced over a span of centuries. He found that the choice made by scientists in pursuing their research was based on their personal preferences as determined by personality factors and social circumstances.

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Besides personal preferences, the ideological biases, acquired in the course of education and training also have a bearing on the choice of the topic of research. The impact of ideological biases on social research can be very far reaching as can be seen from the study of Tepostalan village in Mexico. Robert Redfield studied it with a functionalist perspective and concluded that there exists total harmony between various groups in the village while Oscar Lewis studied this village at almost the same time from Marxist perspective, and found that the society was conflict ridden. Here we can see that how the differences of ideological perspectives had a bearing on the research findings even though the society studied was the same.

Subjectivity can also creep in at the time of formulation of hypothesis. Normally hypotheses are deducted from existing body of theory. Now all sociological theories are produced by and limited to particular groups whose view points and interests they represent. Thus formulation of hypotheses will automatically introduce a bias in the sociological research.

The fourth stage at which subjectivity creeps in the course of research is that of collection of empirical data. No technique of data collection is perfect. Each technique may lead to subjectivity in one way or the other. For example, in case of participant observation, the observer as a result of *'nativisation'* acquires a bias in favour of the group he is studying. While in non-participant observation, the sociologist belongs to a different group than that under study. He is likely to impose his values and prejudices. In all societies there are certain prejudices. For e.g., in America, people have prejudices against the Blacks and in India, people have prejudices against untouchables or women. Such prejudices of the observer may influence his observation. Further, in case of interview as a technique of data collection, the data may be influenced by (i) context of the interview; (ii) interaction of the participants; (iii) participants' definition of the situation; (iv) and if adequate rapport does not extend between them there might be communication barriers. Thus, according to P.V. Young, interview sometimes carries a double dose of subjectivity.

Finally subjectivity can also creep in due to field limitations as was found in case of Andre Beteille's study of Sripuram village in Tanjore where the Brahmins did not allow him to visit the untouchable locality and study their point of view.

Thus complete objectivity continues to be an elusive goal. Myrdal argues that sociology at best could aspire for the goal of value-neutrality on the part of the researcher. This could be attained by either of the following ways:

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i. The researcher should exclude all ideological or non-scientific assumptions from his research;

ii. The researcher should make his value-preference clear in the research monograph. As Weber has also stated that the researcher should be value-frank;

iii. The researcher should not make any evaluative judgement about empirical evidence;

iv. The researcher should remain indifferent to the moral implication of his research;

v. Highly trained and skilled research workers should be employed.

vi. Various methods of data collection should be used and the result obtained from one should be cross checked with those from the other.

vii. Field limitations must be clearly stated in the research monograph.

Eminent sociologist T. K. Oommen in his book *Knowledge and Society* emphasizes the importance of 'contextualization' in sociological enquiry. Oommen argues that while objectivity in natural sciences is *generalizing objectivity*, in social sciences it is *particularizing objectivity*. He suggests that objectivity in social sciences has to be *contextual objectivity*. Contextual objectivity, according to Oommen, can be determined by intra-subjectivity and inter-subjectivity. Intra-subjectivity is one where the same researcher (with his given value orientation) studies the same object (the social group) at two different points of time and arrives at the similar conclusions. Inter-subjectivity, on the other hand, is one when two researchers (with similar value orientations) study the same object at the same time and arrive at similar conclusions.

Of late, a group of American sociologists who have come to be known as 'radical sociologists', have advocated that total value-neutrality is not desirable. Commitment to total political neutrality reduces the sociologist to the status of a mere spectator and sociologists can play no creative role in the society. After all the basic purpose of sociological knowledge is social welfare. But, given such excessive preoccupation with value-neutrality, the role of sociologists has been like, to use W.H. Auden's phrase, "Lecturing on navigation while the ship is going down." C. Wright Mills has also complained that sociology has lost its 'reforming push'. Alvin W. Gouldner, most remembered for his work *The Coming Crisis of Western Sociology* (1970), argued that sociology must turn away from producing

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objective truths and understand the subjective nature of sociology and knowledge in general and how it is bound up with the context of the times. He called for a *reflexive sociology* in which there would be no forgetting of the idea that the sociologist was part of society and played a social role. As the commonplace has it, sociology cannot be practiced outside its historical and social context. Thus, according to C. Wright Mills, Alvin W. Gouldner and others, sociology must have commitment to certain basic human values and sociologists should be ready to defend human freedom and the pursuit of reason.

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The Family

Family is one of the most important social institutions. It is the very basic unit of the social structure in any society. It is a universal social institution and has existed throughout the history of human society in some form or the other. This is as true among simple societies as within the complex modern societies. However, it varies in its internal organisation, in its degree of autonomy and in the sanctions and taboos by which it is protected and perpetuated. Horton and Hunt argue that sociologically family may be defined as 'a kinship grouping which provides for the rearing of children and for certain other human needs.' According to MacIver and Page, family is by far the most important primary group in society. They describe family as 'a group defined by a sex relationship sufficiently precise and enduring to provide for the production and upbringing of children.' According to Kingsley Davis, family is 'a group of persons whose relations to one another are based upon consanguinity and who are, therefore, kin to another.' Eliott and Merrill define family as 'the biological social unit composed of husband wife and children.' According to Green, 'family is the institutionalized social group charged with duty of population replacement.'

In a study entitled *Social Structure*, **George Peter Murdock** examined the institution of the family in a wide range of societies. Murdock took a sample of 250 societies ranging from small hunting and gathering bands to large-scale industrial societies. He claimed that some form of family existed in every society and concluded, on the evidence of his sample, that the family is universal. Murdock defines the family as follows, 'The family is a social group characterized by common residence, economic co-operation and reproduction. It includes adults of both sexes, at least two of whom maintain a socially approved sexual relationship, and one or more children, own or adopted, of the sexually co-habiting adults'. The parent-child relationship is not necessarily a biological one. Its importance is primarily social, children being recognized as members of a particular family whether or not the adult spouses have biologically produced them.

Either on its own or as the basic unit within an extended family, Murdock found that the nuclear family was present in every society in his sample. This led him to conclude that, 'The nuclear family is a universal human social grouping. Either as the sole prevailing form of the family or as the basic unit from which more complex forms are compounded, it exists as a distinct and strongly functional group in every known society.'

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Another scholar R. H. Lowie in his work *Primitive Society* argues that, 'It does not matter whether marital relations are permanent or temporary; whether there is polygyny or polyandry or sexual license; whether conditions are complicated by the addition of members not included in our family circle; the one fact stands out beyond all others that everywhere the husband, wife, and immature children constitute a unit apart from the remainder of the community.'

Much anthropological research and speculation has gone into examining the historical origins of the family. Some authors have put forward the theory that the 'original state of mankind' was one of sexual promiscuity. It is also popularly known as the theory of early sex communism or primitive promiscuism. The theory of primeval promiscuity appears, for example, in L.H. Morgan's *Ancient Society* and R. Briffault's *The Mothers*. But this doctrine has been weakened by the weight of anthropological evidence. In fact, among the primates and other non-human species, family life is often found to be highly developed.

Morgan in his evolutionary theory concludes that in the earlier form of groupings of people, sex was absolutely un-regulated and the institution of family was not known. His picture of primitive society was one of atomistic existence, the only form of groupings existent being sibs. He further held that due to free sex relations and ignorance of the role of paternity, fathers were unimportant, and mother-sibs were the earliest groupings. His conclusions, however, were more logical and academic than actual and historical. He postulated a sequential growth of the institution of the family. Morgan listed five different and successive forms of family, each being associated with a corresponding and distinctive type of marriage. They were, in succession, as follows:

1. The ***consanguine*** family, consisted of a group which was founded upon the intermarriage, in a group, of siblings, own and collateral, i.e. of brothers and sisters and of cousins.

2. The ***punaluan*** family was founded upon the intermarriage of several sisters, own and collateral, with each other's husbands in a group. The joint husbands were not necessarily related to each other. Such a family was also founded upon the intermarriage of several brothers, own and collateral, with each other's wives, in a group, these wives not being necessarily related to each other. However, in actual practice, the husbands as a group, and the wives as a group, must have been kin of each other. In each case, one group was conjointly married to another such group of members of the opposite sex.

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3. The ***syndyasmian*** or pairing family was founded upon marriage between single pairs, without giving the right of exclusive cohabitation to any person over another. Consequently such a marriage continued during the pleasure of the parties.

4. The ***patriarchal*** family was founded upon the marriage of one man with several wives, each wife being secluded from every other.

5. The ***monogamian*** family was founded upon marriage between single pairs, with the married couple having exclusive cohabitation with one another.

The first significant denial of Morgan's scheme, and its basis particularly, came from Westermarck. On the basis of a detailed study of the institution of marriage, Westermarck, in his famous work *History of Human Marriage*, concluded that the family was the outcome of male possessiveness and jealousy, and a growth in property and of the sense of property. So man, and not woman, becomes the central figure in the scheme of development here. He traced monogamy back to mammals and birds, and opined the man had inherited it from the earlier stages of the ladder of evolution. Any further evolution which had taken place was essentially in moral ideas evolved by man with regard to marriage and not in the institution itself. However, it is also true that Morgan also dated the origin of the family only after man's role in begetting children became known, and the right of passing property to his own, rather than to his sister's or mother's children, had been recognized and accepted.

Briffault in his famous work *The Mothers* has challenged Westermarck's position. Briffault argues that man originally lived in a state of social promiscuity and that the earliest human family consisted of a mother and her child. It was only after the mother began realizing the economic advantages of having a man attached to her that she tried to turn the casual attachment of the male into a more permanent relationship. He roots the institution of the family in yet another institution, viz., the *mother-right*, that is, the supreme authority of the mothers. Consequently he argues that the earliest form of the family was matriarchal and that only with the development of higher agriculture and the economic dominance of men could the patriarchal type emerge. Thus, the patriarchal and monogamian families are regarded by him as later in point of time and development.

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Various sociologists and social anthropologists have identified various types and forms of families based on different-different criteria. Firstly, **on the basis of marriage**, family may be classified into monogamous and polygamous family. In **monogamous family**, at any given time a man can have only one wife and a woman can have only one husband. The married couple has the exclusive right of cohabitation with one another. Monogamy is prevalent in all societies and is almost the universal form in all modern industrial societies. Polygamy is that arrangement of marriage in which either a man or woman can have more than one spouse. A **polygamous family** could be of two types, polygynous and polyandrous. When a man marries more than one wife, the family organization which is formed is of **polygynous** type. On the other hand, a **polyandrous** family is one in which a woman has more than one husbands.

Secondly, **on the basis of descent or ancestry**, family can be classified into two types, viz., patrilineal and matrilineal family. In **patrilineal** family the descent (and sometimes inheritance) is traced unilaterally through the father and the male line, while in **matrilineal** family, it is traced unilaterally through the mother and the female line. In India, Khasi and Garo tribes of north-east and the Nayars of Kerala are the matrilineal groups. The Khasi follow the rule of ultimogeniture and thus being a matrilineal society the youngest daughter inherits the property. Please note that **Ultimogeniture** refers to the rule of inheritance or succession which favours the 'last born' or the youngest child (son in patrilineal societies and daughter in matrilineal societies). **Primogeniture**, on the other hand, is the rule of inheritance or succession which favours the 'first born' or the eldest child. The principle of primogeniture was widely prevalent among the Nambudri brahmans. Please also note that among the Sema Naga tribe there is a practice of inheritance of widows. Among the Sema Naga, one is often obliged to marry one's father's widows, other than one's own mother. The reason for this lies in the fact than on a person's death his property goes to his widow(s) and if his son(s) want/wants that property he (they) can get it only if he (they) marries/marry the widow(s), other than his (their) own mother.

Thirdly, **on the basis of nature of authority**, a family may be either patriarchal or matriarchal. Under the **patriarchal** family the male head of the family is possessed of inclusive powers. He is the owner and administrator of the family property and rights. He presides over the religious rites of the family. In short, the family father or the eldest male descendant is the protector and ruler of the family enjoying full authority over the family members. In **matriarchal** family, the authority vests in the woman head of the family with the males being subordinate. She is the owner of the family property and rules over the family.

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Fourthly, **on the basis of rules of residence**, family can be classified into various forms. The term **'Virilocal'** is used to denote a residence pattern or rule in which after marriage a couple resides with or near the man's family or kin group. In Latin it means 'in the man's place'. The term Virilocal is usually preferred in modern anthropology to Patrilocal or Patrivirilocal. In sociological and anthropological literature these terms have been used interchangeably. In this residence pattern, it is worth making a reference to Avunculocal and Amitalocal. In **Avunculocal** residence, the custom prescribes that a married couple reside with or in the locality of the husband's maternal uncle, while in **Amitalocal** residence, the custom prescribes that a married couple reside with or in the locality of the husband's paternal aunt (husband's father's sister). The term 'amitate' however refers to a pattern of special relationships between a child and his or her paternal aunt (the child's father's sister) found in certain societies. Another related term is **Matri-patrilocal** residence. It is a type of patrilocal residence distinguished by **George P. Murdock**, in which the bride and groom first live with the bride's family, with the groom contributing his services to her family for specified period of time. Later, the couple moves and stays permanently at the groom's parental home or community.

On the other hand, the term **'Uxorilocal'** is used to denote a residence pattern or rule whereby on marriage the couple goes to live with or near the woman's family or kin group. In Latin it means 'in the woman's place'. It is generally preferred in modern anthropology to the term Matrilocal. Both these terms are often used interchangeably in sociological and anthropological literature. Other related terms are Unilocal residence, Ambilocal or Bilocal residence. **Unilocal** residence refers to a custom prescribing that married couple reside in or near the household of one of the spouse's relatives. Tradition dictates whether within a particular culture the pair live with the husband's or the wife's family. **Ambilocal** or **Bilocal** residence implies a residence pattern which allows a choice of Virilocal or Uxorilocal residence. In other words, it refers to a custom that allows married couples to have the choice to living with or in the locality of either the husband's or the wife's family. While on the other hand, in **Neolocal** residence, the married couple are normally expected not to live with either of the family of origin, but to establish a new residence for themselves. In other words, the married couple neither stays at groom's house nor in bride's house, but settles a new house for themselves. In some societies **Duolocal** residence has also been reported. Duolocal residence implies that the husband and the wife reside separately. In this context it means that the husband visits his wife's home at night. Duolocal residence has been reported among the matrilineal Muslim community of Lakshadweep.

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Fifthly, **on the basis of nature of relations (kinship ties) among the family members**, the family can be classified into two main types, viz., conjugal family and consanguine family. **Conjugal family** is a type of family organization in which primary emphasis is placed upon the husband-wife relationship (marital bond), rather than upon the blood relationships. The conjugal family centres about a husband and wife and their unmarried children. The conjugal family usually does not form an extended family. **Consanguine family**, on the other hand, refers to a type of family organization in which the primary emphasis is upon the blood relationship of parents and children or brother and sister's, rather than upon the marital relationship of husband and wife. Thus the position of blood relatives is central while the position of spouses tends to be peripheral. The consanguine family normally forms an extended family, usually with two or three generations living together.

Sixthly, **on the basis of membership**, family can be classified in terms of family of orientation and family of procreation. **Family of orientation** is the family into which an individual is born and in which he is socialized. It includes his father, mother, brothers and sisters. **Family of procreation**, on the other hand, is one which an individual establishes by his marriage and which includes his or her spouse and children.

Further, **Carle C. Zimmerman** in his work *Family and Civilization* has described three types of family viz., atomistic family, domestic family and trusteeship family. **Atomistic family** is a type of family which is characterized by a higher degree of individuation than either the domestic family or trusteeship family. Individual family members have more freedom from family control, and the welfare of the individual is considered more important than the welfare of the family as a whole. The atomistic family typically is small in size, and centre about a husband, wife, and unmarried children. Usually parents do not live with their married children. **Domestic family** is intermediate between the atomistic family and the trusteeship family. The domestic family has more group unity and less individuation than the atomistic family. Considerable emphasis is placed on the relationship between parents and children even after the children are married, and close contact is maintained between parents and married children and among families of married brothers and sisters. **Trusteeship family**, on the other hand, is a type of family characterized by a higher degree of group unity than either the atomistic family or domestic family. In the trusteeship family the individual's self-interests are subordinated to the welfare of the family as whole. Living members are regarded as trustees of the family's "blood, rights, property, name and position for their lifetimes". The trusteeship family is usually an extended family (including several living generation) and is typically found in rural cultures where the family forms an economic unit.

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Burgess and **Locke** have classified family on the basis of the behaviour of the individual members in terms of **institutional** and **companionship** families. In the former family, the behaviour of the members is controlled by mores and public opinion, while in the latter family, behaviour arises from mutual affection and consensus. **K.P. Chattopadhyay** has identified three types of family: **simple** (man, wife, and unmarried children), **compound** (two simple families, say, ego, his wife and unmarried children, and ego's parents and unmarried brothers and sisters), and **composite** (i.e. lineal and collateral joint families).

Finally, forms of family have also been distinguished on the basis of its size and structure. As stated earlier the structure of the family varies from society to society. The smallest family unit is known as the ***nuclear family*** and consists of a husband and wife and their immature or unmarried offspring. **Pauline Kolenda**, while discussing the nature of nuclear family in India, has identified various forms of the nuclear family structure which may be summarised as follows:

i) **nuclear family** refers to a couple with or without children

ii) **supplemented nuclear family** indicates a nuclear family plus one or more unmarried, separated, or widowed relatives of the parents, other than their unmarried children

iii) **sub-nuclear family** is identified as a fragment of a former nuclear family, for instance, a widow/widower with his/her unmarried children or siblings (unmarried or widowed or separated or divorced) living together

iv) **single person household**

v) **supplemented sub-nuclear family** refers to a group of relatives, members of a formerly complete nuclear family along with some other unmarried, divorced or widowed relative who was not a member of the nuclear family. For instance, a widow and her unmarried children may be living together with her widowed mother-in-law.

Talcott Parsons argues that the ***'isolated nuclear family'*** is the typical family form in modern industrial society. It is 'structurally isolated' because it does not form an integral part of a wider system of kinship relationships. Parsons concludes that given the universalistic, achievement oriented values of industrial society, the isolated nuclear family is the most suitable family structure.

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Units larger than the nuclear family are usually known as ***extended families***. Such families can be seen as extension of the basic nuclear unit, either vertical or horizontal. Vertically extended family is based on the extension of the parent-child relationship. Thus, the patrilineally extended family is based on an extension of the father-son relationship, while the matrilineally extended family is based on the mother-daughter relationship. The extended family may also be extended horizontally to include a group consisting of two or more brothers, their wives and children. This horizontally extended family is called as the fraternal or collateral family. **Bell** and **Vogel** define the extended family as 'any grouping broader than the nuclear family which is related by descent, marriage or adoption'. These extended families across the globe are known by different-different names. For example, in Europe, the Yugoslav form of the extended family is known as ***zadruga***. In India, the patrilineal extended families among Coorgs of south India is popularly known as ***okka***, while among Nambudiri Brahmins it is known as ***illom***. Further, the matrilineal extended family among the Nayars of Kerala is known as ***taravad***.

In India, the family whether extended vertically and/or horizontally is called the joint family, which is strictly speaking also a property-sharing unit. The term **'joint family'** was coined by **Sir Henry Maine** to describe the patrilineal type of extended family in India where all the male members of the family hold joint ownership rights in the family property. It is largely patrilineal, patriarchal and **patrivirilocal** (residence of the couple after marriage in husband's father's home) in nature with a few exceptions. Joint family, which is a typical feature of Indian society is characterised by commensality, common residence, coparcenary (joint ownership of property among the male members of the family in a patrilineal society), co-operation sentiment and ritual bonds. Please note that in case of Hindu joint family the authority to take decision and maintain peace and discipline in the family lies in the hand of the *Karta*. All the earning members keep their earnings with him and the entire property is kept under his control. Family ceremonies and celebrations are held under his guidance and direction. He also settles the disputes within the household. In a nutshell, the *Karta* is the trustee of the family and enjoys unquestionable authority.

According to **Iravati Karve**, the joint family may be defined as "a group of people who generally live under one roof, who eat food cooked at one hearth, who hold property in common, and who participate in common family worship and are related to each other as some particular type of kindred." Scholars like **I.P. Desai** emphasise that the number of generations present in a family is important for identifying a joint family. According to him, 'we call that household a joint family which has greater generation depth than the nuclear family and members of which are related to one another by property, income and mutual right and authority.' A

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joint family is commonly defined as a three generational family. For instance a man, his married son and his grand children constitute a joint family. I.P. Desai suggested that there are five types of family life in India which may be summarised as follows:

i) **Nuclear Family:** The smallest family which consists of wife, husband and their unmarried children.

ii) **Functional Joint Family:** When two families having blood relationship are living separately but function under one common authority, it is called functional joint family.

iii) **Functional and Substantial Joint Family:** When a functional joint family is also joint in terms of property it is called functional and substantial joint family.

iv) **Marginal Joint Family:** When two generations of family members live together functionally and substantially it is called marginal joint family.

v) **Traditional Joint Family:** It consists of three or more generations of people living together in one household, own property in one commonly and participate in the family rituals.

Researchers, like **F.G. Bailey** and **T.N. Madan**, on the other hand have advocated the limitation of the term joint family to a group of relatives who form a property owning group, the coparcenary family. **M.S. Gore**, for instance, defines a joint family as a group consisting of adult male coparceners and their dependants. The wives and young children of these male members are the dependents.

Pauline Kolenda presents the following types of joint family on the basis of the relatives who are its members:

i) **Collateral joint family:** It comprises two or more married couples between whom there is a sibling bond. In this type, usually a brother and his wife and another brother and his wife live together with unmarried children.

ii) **Supplemented collateral joint family:** It is a collateral joint family along with unmarried, divorced or widowed relatives. The supplemented relatives are generally the widowed mother of the married brothers or the widower father, or an unmarried sibling.

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iii) **Lineal joint family:** Two couples, between whom there is a lineal link, like between a parent and his married son or some times between a parent and his married daughter, live together.

iv) **Supplemented lineal joint family:** It is a lineal joint family together with unmarried, divorced or widowed relatives who do not belong to either of the lineally linked nuclear families. For example, the father's widower brother or the son's wife's unmarried brother or sister.

v) **Lineal collateral joint family:** In this type three or more couples are linked lineally and collaterally. For instance we can have a family consisting of parents and their two or more married sons together with the unmarried children of the couples.

vi) **Supplemented lineal-collateral joint family:** In this type are found a lineal collateral joint family plus unmarried, widowed, separated relatives who belong to none of the nuclear families (lineally and collaterally linked). For example, the father's widowed sister or brother or an unmarried nephew of the father.

Another type of extended family found in India is the matrilineal family among the Nayars of Kerala. The Nayars called this matrilineal extended family as ***'Taravad'***. Among the Nayars, the term *Taravad* was applied for the clan, and the lineage. It also referred to the property group. *Taravad* was an exogamous unit, i.e., its members marry outside the *Taravad*. The composition of this matrilineal joint family was entirely different from the patrilineal joint family. All members of this family were consanguinely related men and women only. In relation to the male ego, the members of such a family included his mother and her sisters and brothers, his own brothers and sisters, mother's sister's sons and daughters and the children of the ego's sisters. Thus, there was no relation by marriage in *Taravad*. The married women with their children lived with their mothers and other siblings. The men in the family were only occasional visitors to their wives in other *Tarvad* at night but permanently resided with their own mother. That is why this system is also popularly known as the '***visiting husband system***'.

Please note that since the Nayars practiced non-fraternal polyandry, a Nayar woman had a number of husbands at a time. The children born of such unions belonged to woman's *Taravad* only and were looked after by their mother's brother. The property is inherited by women and managed by their brothers. Though theoretically woman is the nominal head of the family but it is the eldest male member of the family, known as **Karnavan**, who looks after the affairs of the family. He is the custodian of property and the manager of family matters. He also

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played the role of the social father for the children born in the *Taravad*. In this system the bond between brother and sister was strongly emphasized, and the bond between husband and wife correspondingly de-emphasized, the more so because Nayar women could legitimately have a number of visiting husbands, provided they were of higher status (hypergamy) i.e., higher caste Nayars or Namboodiri Brahmins. Also, Nayar men too could have a number of wives (polygyny). In fact, the marital bond was so minimised among the Nayars that anthropologists have debated endlessly whether Nayar society has the institution of marriage at all. Anthropologists have also cited that the Nayar system disproves the proposition that the elementary or nuclear family is a 'universal' human institution. Please note that the emphasis being on the solidarity of the lineage group, marriage was the weakest institution among the Nayars. The strong descent ties and weak affinal links in this case are related to the kind of private ownership of land in Kerala.

When *Taravad* becomes too large in size it is divided into ***'Tavazhis'***, whereby one of the women members of the *Taravad* is given a share of the property and provided with a house to start a new *Taravad*. A *Tavazhi* in relation to a woman is 'a group of persons consisting of a female, her children, and all her descendants in the female line'. In a *Taravad* there is always a potential conflict between a mother's sons and her brother. Mother's sons suspect their maternal uncle of diverting the *Taravad* property to his own children. This often leads to conflict and tension. Of late these *Taravads* have further started breaking down into smaller familial units known as the ***'Veedus'***.

Similarly, among the Coorgs of south India, the patrilineal and patrilocal joint family is called as ***'okka'***. Eminent sociologist **M.N. Srinivas** in his study *'Religion and Society Among the Coorgs of South India'* found the *okka* as the basic group among Coorgs. It is impossible to imagine a Coorg apart from the *okka* of which he is a member. People who do not belong to an *okka* have no social existence at all, and the elders always bring pressure on the parties concerned to see that children born out of wedlock obtain membership in their father's or mother's *okka*. Member of an *okka* is acquired by birth, and the outside world always identifies a man with his *okka*. His association with his *okka* does not cease even after death, because he then becomes one of a body of apotheosized ancestors (karanava) who are believed to look after the *okka* of which they were members when alive. The ancestors are worshipped, and offerings of food and drink (bharani) are occasionally made to them.

Membership of an *okka* determines to a very large extent the choice of a spouse. First of all, marital relations are forbidden between members of the same *okka*. Where agnation overflows the *okka*, the taboo extends to agnatic relatives who are not members of the *okka*. Again, children of sisters may not intermarry. In

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recent times the importance of the joint family has gradually declined. As Srinivas points out, the Coorg *okka* 'is a very much stronger institution then the joint family of the higher castes of south India. The theory of the impartibility of its traditional property and preference for leviratic unions buttress it strongly against fission. Add to this the fact that a cross cousin is commonly chosen for marriage and it becomes almost impregnable'. Even here, however, the joint family is said to weakening.

In yet another example from south India, there is Nambudari joint family. Nambudiri Brahmins lived in patrilineages or patrilineal families which were called ***'Illom'***. The Nambudiris were landowners. Land was considered indivisible, and indivisibility was ensured by the rule of primogeniture. Primogeniture refers to the rule of inheritance according to which only the eldest son is entitled to inherit the ancestral property of the family. Only the eldest son was permitted to marry a Nambudiri girl and the younger sons had "liaison" (*sambandham*) with girl belonging to the higher Nayar castes. The younger sons visited their life partners at night and the children born of the union become members of their mother's *taravads*. Such a Nambudiri Brahmin, who forms sambandham with a Nayar woman, is called her 'ritual husband'. Since the children from these unions always belonged to the lineage of Nayar women only, thus, in this way the Nambudiri men could check their children by Nayar women from claiming a share in their lineage property. Here we find that both the Nambudiri patrilineal group and the Nayar matrilineal group insist on maintaining their autonomy. Further, kinship relationships within respective lineages remain strong. The result is that affinal relationships arising out of sambandham alliances are quite weak. The strong descent ties and weak affinal links in this case are related to the kind of private ownership of land in Kerala. The Nambudiri *Illom* consisted of a man, his wife or wives, his children and his younger brothers. Sometimes, the *Illom* included his old parents or his eldest son's children. Please note that with the rapid advancement of the forces of modernisation these traditional forms of extended families are rapidly undergoing change.

The family institution in the whole world is undergoing change. In the developed societies of the West, this change is quite fundamental in nature, so that the very existence of family is threatened. Industrialization and development of material culture have mainly led to this change. In India too drastic changes in the family in India are taking place though slowly. Contemporary western society is characterized, among other things, by the declining importance of all primary groups, including the family, and their supersession by secondary groups. Most of those functions which the family used to satisfy are now fulfilled by various commercial and state operated institutions like crèches, kindergartens, schools, trade unions, clubs, hotels, and restaurants. The disintegration of the family has been hastened by freer sex relations made possible by changing notions about

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morals and by birth control techniques. With the decline of religion, the religious sanctions behind family and marriage have also vanished, making dissolution easier to obtain. The changed notions about the status and role of women have also aided this break up. Individualism is the basis of all contemporary Western culture. Individual happiness is often possible only at the cost of the family as a whole.

In India, generally the factors leading to changes in the family are discussed in the context of the issue of disintegration of the joint family. A host of interrelated factors, economic, educational, legal, demographic, have affected the family in India. Among the economic factors, industrialization and urbanization have significantly affected the structure and composition of the traditional family system. The family which was a principle unit of production has been transformed into a consumption unit. Industrialisation has also separated the place of work from home. Due to diversification of occupational opportunities members of a family are no more dependent on the traditional family occupation. Further, the processes of industrialization and urbanization, particularly in India, have led to a demographic change in terms of heavy migration of rural people to cities. Residential separation due to mobility of members from one place to another affects the size and composition of the family. A man may take his wife and children along with him to establish a nuclear family in the city. There have been many studies, which show that migration to cities from villages and small towns has contributed to the rapid disintegration of large size family units. In the city, with problems of finding accommodation and limited space available for living, it becomes difficult for an average urbanite to maintain and support a large family.

Modern system of education has also brought about a significant change in the attitudes, beliefs and values of the young generation. Due to increasing literacy child marriages are lessening in number leading to marriage between mature individuals. Further, educated women tend to be more liberal, autonomous and economically independent. Couples are not interested in having more than two or three children. As a result of which the family size is getting smaller and the number of nuclear families is fast increasing.

Legislations regarding education, marriage, employment, and property, have also affected the family system in many ways. For example, Constitution of India has made 'right to free and compulsory education to all children in the age group of six to fourteen years' a fundamental right under **Article 21A** which was introduced by Eighty Sixth Amendment Act, 2002. Similarly, labour laws passed for the benefit of employees like the **Indian Workmen Compensation Act, 1923** and the **Minimum Wages Act, 1948**, helped to reduce the economic reliance of members on the joint family for economic support. Further, **Hindu Gains of Learning Act, 1930** declared that the property acquired by a Hindu out of his

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education was his personal property though his education was paid for by the joint family. The distinction between self-acquired property and joint family property was drawn. After Independence, the **Hindu Succession Act, 1956** was passed which gave a daughter and son equal rights to the father's property. These legislations challenged the inheritance patterns that prevailed in joint families prior to the passing of this Act and the dependent position of women within the family.

Some other important legislations in this regard have been discussed in brief in the following section:

The Married Women's Property Act, 1874: This Act confers ownership right to women not only on their *'Streedhan'* but also on the property which they have personally earned.

Gains of Learning Act, 1930: As a result of this Act, member of a joint family secures individual right over income or property which he or she has been able to earn by means of his or her educational attainment. This Act has made the individual members of family to develop personal interest in the property and this tendency has damaged the collective interest of the family.

The Hindu Women's Right to Property Act, 1937: This Act enables a woman to have equal share to that of a son in the property of her deceased husband. If the property was joint and unseparated at the time of her husband's death, she is entitled to have the same interest therein as her deceased husband was entitled.

The Hindu Succession Act, 1956: This Act confers on women right to property. As per this Act, not only a daughter is given a right in her father's property equal to her brothers, but also gets a share in her deceased husband's property equal to her sons and daughters. The legislation has removed the distinction between Stridhan and non-Stridhan. This Act, in course of time, led to the changes in the position of women in the family.

The Hindu Adoption and Maintenance Act, 1956: This Act permits the wife deserted by her husband to claim maintenance allowance from her husband; and it also permits women to adopt a child.

The Suppression of Immoral Traffic of Women and Girls' Act, 1956: This Act gives protection to women against kidnapping and pushing then to brothel homes to do prostitution.

The Maternity Benefit Act, 1961: This Act provides maternity benefits (2 months maternity leave with salary) to married women.

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Medical Termination of Pregnancy Act, 1971: This Act permits the termination of pregnancy by a registered doctor if it does not exceed 12 weeks on certain grounds (such as pregnancy causing risk to the life of pregnant woman, pregnancy caused by rape or failure of contraceptive device, etc.)

The Equal Remuneration Act, 1976 does not permit wage discrimination between male and female workers.]

The Family Court Act, 1984 assures women justice in family dispute and at the same time, preserves the secrecy of family matters.

Pre-Natal Diagnostic Techniques (Regulation and Prevention of Misuse) Act, 1994: An Act to provide for regulation of the use of pre-natal diagnostic techniques for the purpose of detecting genetic or metabolic disorders, chromosomal abnormalities or certain congenital malformations or sex-linked disorders and for the prevention of misuse of such techniques for the purpose of prenatal sex determination leading female foeticide and for matters connected therewith or incidental thereto.

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Many sociologists have regarded the family as the cornerstone of society. In pre-modern and modern societies alike it has been seen as the most basic unit of social organization and one which carries out vital tasks such as socializing children. It is difficult to imagine how human society could function without it. The composition of the family may vary from society to society. In general, therefore, the family has been seen as a universal social institution, as an inevitable part of human society. On balance, it has been regarded as a good thing, both for the individual and society as whole. This view has tended to divert attention from interesting and important questions. For example, it has discouraged serious and detailed consideration of alternatives to the family.

Until the 1960s few sociologists questioned the importance or the benefits of family life. Most sociologists assumed that family life was evolving as modernity progressed, and the changes involved made the family better-suited to meeting the needs of society and of family members. A particular type of family, the nuclear family (based around a two-generation household of parents and their children), was seen as well-adapted to the demands of modern societies. From the 1960s, an increasing number of critical thinkers began to question the assumption that the family was necessarily a beneficial institution. These new perspectives on the family have questioned many of the assumptions of the more traditional view. These approaches have not assumed that the family is inevitable. Often, they have been openly critical of the institution of the family. During the late 1960s the Women's Liberation Movement began shaking the foundations of the family by attacking the role of women within it. This attack was developed by some feminist writers into a condemnation of the family as an institution. Feminists, Marxists and critical psychologists began to highlight what they saw as some of the negative effects and the 'dark side' of family life.

In the following decades the family was not just under attack from academic writers – social changes also seemed to be undermining traditional families. Rising divorce rates, cohabitation before marriage, increasing numbers of single-parent families and single-person households, and other trends have all suggested that individuals may be basing their lives less and less around conventional families.

Some have seen these changes as a symptom of greater individualism within modern societies. They have welcomed what appears to be an increasing choice for individuals. People no longer have to base their lives around what may be outmoded and, for many, unsuitable, conventional family structures. Others, however, have lamented the changes and worried about their effect on society. Such changes were seen as both a symptom and a cause of instability and insecurity in people's lives and in society as a whole. This view was advocated by

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traditionalists who wanted a return to the ideal of the nuclear family. For them, many of society's problems were a result of the increased family instability.

Some postmodernists have begun to argue that there has been a fundamental break between the modern family and the postmodern family. They deny that any one type of family can be held up as the norm to which other family types can be compared. While modern societies might have had one central, dominant family type, this is no longer the case. As a result, it is no longer possible to produce a theory of 'the family'. Different explanations are needed for different types of family.

In short, the family has come to be seen as more problematic than it was in the past. The controversies that have come to surround families and households have been discussed subsequently. This chapter begins by examining the assumption of the universality of the family.

Is the family universal?

George Peter Murdock: the family – a universal social institution

In a study entitled *Social structure*, **George Peter Murdock** examined the institution of the family in wide range of societies. Murdock took a sample of 250 societies ranging from small hunting and gathering bands to large-scale industrial societies. He claimed that some form of family existed in every society and concluded, on the evidence of his sample, that the family is universal. Murdock defined the family as follows, 'The family is a social group characterized by common residence, economic co-operation and reproduction. It includes adults of both sexes, at least two of whom maintain a socially approved sexual relationship, and one or more children, own or adopted, of the sexually co-habiting adults'. Thus the family lives together, pools its resources and works together and produces offspring. At least two of the adult members conduct a sexual relationship according to the norms of their particular society. Such norms vary from society to society. For example, among the Banaro of New Guinea, the husband does not have sexual relations with his wife until she has borne a child buy a friend of his father. The parent-child relationship is not necessarily a biological one. Its importance is primarily social, children being recognized as members of a particular family whether or not the adult spouses have biologically produced them.

The structure of the family varies from society to society. The smallest family unit is known as the nuclear family and consists of a husband and wife and their immature offspring. Units larger than the nuclear family are usually known as

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extended families. Such families can be seen as extension of the basic nuclear unit, either vertical extensions – for example the addition of members of a third generation such as the spouses' parents – and/or horizontal extensions – for example the addition of members of the same generation as the spouses such as the husband's brother or an additional wife. Thus **Bell** and **Vogel** define the extended family as 'any grouping broader than the nuclear family which is related by descent, marriage or adoption'.

Either on its own or as the basic unit within an extended family, Murdock found that the nuclear family was present in every society in his sample. This led him to conclude that, 'The nuclear family is a universal human social grouping. Either as the sole prevailing form of the family or as the basic unit from which more complex forms are compounded, it exists as a distinct and strongly functional group in every known society'. However, as the following sections will indicate, Murdock's conclusions might not be well founded.

Kathleen Gough – the Nayar

Some societies have sets of relationships between kin which are quite different from those which are common in Britain. One such society was that of the Nayar of Kerala in southern India, prior to British rule being established in 1792. Sociologists disagree about whether this society had a family system or not, and thus whether or not it disproves Murdock's claim that the family is universal.

Kathleen Gough provided a detailed description of Nayar society. Before puberty all Nayar girls were ritually married to a suitable Nayar man in the *tali*-rite. After the ritual marriage had taken place, however, the *tali* husband did not live with wife, and was under no obligation to have any contact with her whatsoever. The wife owed only one duty to her *tali* husband: she had to attend his funeral to mourn his death.

Once a Nayar girl reached or neared puberty she began to take a number of visiting husbands, or '*sambandham*' husbands. The Nayar men were usually professional warriors who spent long periods of time away from their villages acting as mercenaries. During their time in the villages they were allowed to visit any number of Nayar women who had undergone the *tali*-rite and who were members of the same caste as themselves, or a lowers caste. With the agreement of the woman involved, the *sambandham* husband arrived at the home of one of his wives after supper, had sexual intercourse with her, and left before breakfast the next morning. During his stay he placed his weapons outside the building to show the other *sambandham* husbands that he was there. If they arrived too late, then they were free to sleep on the veranda, but could not stay the night with their wife.

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Men could have unlimited numbers of *sambandham* wives, although women seem to have been limited to no more than 12 visiting husbands.

An exception to the family?

Sambandham relationships were unlike marriages in most societies in a number of ways:

1. They were not a lifelong union: either party could terminate the relationship at any time.

2. *Sambandham* husband had no duty towards the offspring of their wives. When a woman became pregnant, it was essential according to Nayar custom that a man of appropriate caste declared himself to be the father of the child by paying a fee of cloth and vegetables to the midwife who attended the birth. However, it mattered little whether he was the biological parent or not, so long as someone claimed to be the father, because he did not help to maintain or socialize the child.

3. Husbands and wives did not form an economic unit. Although husbands might give wives token gifts, they were not expected to maintain them – indeed it was frowned upon if they attempted to. Instead, the economic unit consisted of a number of brothers and sisters, sisters' children, and their daughters' children. The eldest male was the leader of each group of kin.

Nayar society, then, was a matrilineal society. Kinship groupings were based on female biological relatives and marriage played no significant part in the formation of households, in the socializing of children, or in the way that the economic needs of the members of society were met.

In terms of Murdock's definition, no family existed in Nayar society, since those who maintained 'a sexually approved adult relationship' did not live together and cooperate economically. Only the women lived with the children. Murdock's definition of the family included at least one adult of each sex. But the Nayars of Kerala, a matrilineal society, are an exception to this rule. The Nayars called their matrilineal extended family as ***'Taravad'***. All members of this family were consanguinely related men and women only. In relation to the male ego, the members of such a family included his mother and her sisters and brothers, his own brothers and sisters, mother's sister's sons and daughters and the children of the ego's sisters. Thus, there was no relation by marriage in *Taravad*. The married

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women with their children lived with their mothers and other siblings. The men in the family were only occasional visitors to their wives in other *Tarvad* at night but permanently resided with their own mother. That is why this system is also popularly known as the '***visiting husband system***'.

Therefore, either Murdock's definition of the family is too narrow, or the family is not universal. Gough claimed that marriage, and by implication the family, existed in Nayar society. In order to make this claim, though, she had to broaden her definition of marriage beyond that implied in Murdock's definition of the family. She defined marriage as a relationship between a woman and one or more persons in which a child born to the woman 'is given full birth-status rights' common to the normal members of the society.

Matrifocal families – an exception to the rule?

Murdock's definition of the family includes at least one adult of each sex. However, both today and in the past, some children have been raised in households that do not contain adults of both sexes. Usually these households have been headed by women.

A significant proportion of black families in the islands of the West Indies, parts of Central America such as Guyana, and the USA do not include adult males. The 'family unit' often consists of a woman and her dependent children, sometimes with the addition of her mother. This may indicate that family is not universal as Murdock suggests, or that it is necessary to redefine the family and state that the minimal family unit consists of a woman and her dependent children, own or adopted, and that all other family types are additions to this unit.

Female-headed families are sometimes known as matriarchal families and sometimes as matrifocal families, although both of these terms have been used in a number of senses. We will use the term matrifocal family here to refer to female-headed families. Various scholars support the view that matrifocal family should be recognized as an alternative to the nuclear family.

The kibbutz – the abolition of the family?

The family is the Israeli kibbutz presents another possible exception to Murdock's claim for the universality of the nuclear family. About 4% of Israel's population live in some 240 kibbutzim settlements. Capital and property are collectively owned by kibbutzim members and the main economy is agriculture plus some light industry. The 'family' in the kibbutzim has been shaped by a number of ideological and economic factors. Particularly during the early days, all

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able-bodied adults were needed to get the settlements off the ground which left little time for intimate relationships between mothers and children. Kibbutzim ideology emphasized sexual equality and rejected the Western pattern of parental roles, specially the mother role. In particular there was a reaction against the traditional 'Jewish mamma', the supposedly overprotective Jewish mother, a well-known figure in American folklore and humour.

Although there are differences between kibbutzim, the general pattern of family life can be described as follows. Marriage is monogamous (one spouse of each sex), the married couple sharing a single bedroom cum living room. Common residence does not extend to their children live in communal dormitories where they are raised by child 'crackers' or 'educators'. They eat and sleep in the dormitories spending most of the day and all of the night away from their parents. They usually see their parents for an hour or two each day, often visiting them in their apartment. These visits are viewed as 'fun time' rather than occasions for specialization and child training. Bruno Bettelheim, who studied children caring practices in a kibbutz, states that 'parents have transferred their power to the community. All children are viewed and cared for as "children of the kibbutz"'. The collective method of childrearing represents a rejection of the family, with particular reference to parental roles'.

Economic cooperation between the married couple as such hardly exists. Neither works for the family but rather for the kibbutz as a whole. They receive the goods and services they require from the kibbutz as do their children. They eat in the communal dining room, food is cooked in communal kitchen and services such as laundering are provided for an entire kibbutz rather than being the responsibility of the family. Economic cooperation is on a community rather than a family level, each working for the kibbutz as a whole and receiving his or her share of the goods and services produced. In terms of Murdock's definition, the family does not exist in the kibbutz on two counts. Firstly, family members do not share a common residence. Secondly, their relationship is not characterized by economic operation.

In terms of Murdock's definition, it can be argued that the family is not universal. The case of *'Taravad'*, among the Nayars of Kerala, does not satisfy Murdock's criterion of at least one spouse of each sex. The kibbutz case does not satisfy the criteria of common residence and economic cooperation.

Gay families

Another type of household that may contradict Murdock's claims about the universality of the family, as defined by him, is gay and lesbian households. By definition, such households will not contain 'adults of both sexes, at least two of

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whom maintain a socially approved sexual relationship' (Murdock, 1949). Such households may, however, include children who are cared for by two adult females or two adult males. The children may have been adopted, be the result of a previous heterosexual relationship, or they may have been produced using new reproductive technologies involving sperm donation or surrogate motherhood. A lesbian may have sex with a man in order to conceive a child to be raised by her and her female partner.

Most children of gay couples result from a previous heterosexual relationship. Lesbian mothers are rather more common than gay fathers, due to the difficulties gay men are likely to have in being granted custody or given adopted children. However, **Mukti Jain Campion** quotes a study which claimed that over 1,000 children were born to gay or lesbian couples in San Francisco between 1985 and 1990, and that there were many more people living with gay partners who had conceived children in heterosexual relationships. Thus, while households consisting of gay partners and one or more children may not be very common, they do exist. This raises the question of whether such households should be regarded as families.

Rather like lone-parent families, households with gay parents are seen by some as not being 'proper' families. In most Western societies the gay couple will not be able to marry and any children will have a genetic connection with only one of the partners. However, **Sidney Callahan** (1997) argues that such households should still be seen as families. He argues that, if marriage were available, many gay and lesbian couples would marry. Furthermore, he believes that the relationships involved are no different in any fundamental way from those in heterosexual households. Callahan therefore claims that gay and lesbian households with children should be regarded as a type of family, at least where the gay or lesbian relationship is intended to be permanent. He concludes, 'I would argue that gay or lesbian households that consist of intimate communities of mutual support and that display permanent shared commitments to intergenerational nurturing share the kinship bonding we observe and name as family'(Callahan, 1997)

The universality of the family – conclusion

Whether the family is regarded as universal ultimately depends on how the family is defined. Clearly, though, a wide variety of domestic arrangements have been devised by human beings which are quite distinctive from the 'conventional' families of modern industrial societies. As Diana Gittins puts it 'Relationships are universal, so is some form of co-residence, of intimacy, sexuality and emotional

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bonds. But the *forms* these can take are infinitely variable and can be changed and challenged as well as embraced'.

It may be a somewhat pointless exercise to try to find a single definition that embraces all the types of household and relationship which can reasonably be called families.

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Having examined whether the family is universal, we will now examine various perspectives on the role of families in society.

The family – a functionalist perspective

The analysis of the family from a functionalist perspective involves three main questions. Firstly, 'What are the functions of the family?' Answers to this question deal with the contributions made by the family to the maintenance of the social system. It is assumed that society has certain functional prerequisites or basic needs that must be met if it is to survive and operate efficiently. The family is examined in terms of the degree to which it meets these functional prerequisites. A second and related question asks, 'What are the functional relationships between the family and other parts of the social system?' It is assumed that there must be a certain degree of fit, integration and harmony between the parts of the social system if society is going to function efficiently. For example, the family must be integrated to some extent with the economic system. This question will be examined in detail in a later section when the relationships between the family and industrialization will be considered. The third question is concerned with the functions performed by an institution or a part of society for the individual. In the case of the family, this question considers the functions of the family for its individual members.

George Peter Murdock – the universal functions of the family

From his analysis of 250 societies, Murdock argues that the family performs four basic functions in all societies. These universal functions he terms the **sexual**, **reproductive**, **economic** and **educational**. They are essential for social life since without the sexual and reproductive functions there would be no members of society, without the economic function, for example the provision and preparation of food, life would cease, and without education, a term Murdock uses for socialization, there would be no culture. Human society without culture could not function.

In Murdock's scheme, the family is seen as a multi-functional institution which is indispensable to society. Its 'many-sided utility' accounts for its universality and its inevitability. In his enthusiasm for the family, however, Murdock does not seriously consider whether its functions could be performed by other social institutions. He does not examine alternatives to the family. Furthermore, Murdock's emphasis on harmony and integration is not shared by some researchers.

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Talcott Parsons – the 'basic and irreducible' functions of the family

Parsons concentrates his analysis on the family in modern American society. However, his ideas have a more general application since he argues that the American family retains two 'basic and irreducible functions' which are common to the family in all societies. These are the '**primary socialization of children**' and the '**stabilization of the adult personalities of the population of the society**'.

Primary socialization refers to socialization during the early years of childhood which takes place mainly within the family. Secondary socialization occurs during the later years when the family is less involved and other agencies such as the peer group and the school exert increasing influence. There are two basic processes involved in primary socialization: the internalization of society's culture and the structuring of the personality. Unless culture is internalized, society would cease to exist since without shared norms and values, social life would not be possible. However, culture is not simply learned, it is 'internalized as part of the personality structure'. The child's personality is moulded in terms of the central values of the culture to the point where they become a part of him. In the case of American society, his personality is shaped in terms of independence and achievement motivation which are two of the central values of American culture. Parsons argues that families 'are "factories" which produce human personalities'. He believes they are essential for this purpose since primary socialization requires a context which provides warmth, security and mutual support. He can conceive of no institution other than the family which could provide this context.

Once produced, the personality must be kept stable. This is the second basic function of the family, the 'stabilization of adult personalities'. The emphasis here is on the marriage relationship and the emotional security the couple provide for each other. This acts as a counterweight to the stresses and strains of everyday life which tend to make the personality unstable. This function is particularly important in Western industrial society since the nuclear family is largely isolated from kin. It does not have the security once provided by the close-knit extended family. Thus the married couple increasingly look to each other for emotional support. Adult personalities are also stabilized by the parents' role in the socialization process. This allows them to act out "childish" elements of their own personalities which they have retained from childhood but which cannot be indulged in adult society. For example, father is 'kept on the rails' by playing with his son's train set. The family therefore provides a context in which husband and wife can express their childish whims, give and receive emotional support, recharge their batteries and so stabilize their personalities.

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As with Murdock, Parsons has been accused of idealizing the family with his picture of well-adjusted children and sympathetic spouses caring for each other's every need. Secondly, his picture is based largely on the American middle class family which he treats as representative of American families in general. As D.H.J. Morgan states, 'there are no classes, no regions, no religious, ethnic or status groups, no communities' in Parsons's analysis of the family. For example, he fails to explore possible differences between middle and working-class families. Thirdly, like Murdock, Parsons largely fails to explore functional alternatives to the family. He does recognize that some functions are not necessarily tied to the family. For example he notes that the family's economic function has largely been taken over by other agencies in modern industrial society. However, his belief that its remaining functions are 'basic and irreducible' prevents him from examining alternatives to the family. Finally, Parsons's view of the socialization process may be criticized. He sees it as a one-way process with the child being pumped full of culture and its personality moulded by powerful parents. He tends to ignore the two-way interaction process between parents and children. There is no place in his scheme for the child who twists its parents round its little finger.

Ezra F. Vogel and Norman W. Bell – functions and dysfunctions of the family

In an article entitled, *The Emotionally Disturbed Child as the Family Scapegoat,* Vogel and Bell present a functional analysis of certain families which avoids the tendency of many functionalists to concentrate solely on the positive aspects of the family. When examining the functional significance of the family, they ask functional 'for whom?' and 'for what?' Vogel and Bell base their findings on an intensive study of a small number of American families containing an 'emotionally disturbed child'. They argue that the tension and hostility of unresolved conflicts between the parents are projected on the child. The child is thus used as an emotional scapegoat by the parents to relieve their tension. For example, in one case a son was criticized by his mother for all the characteristics she disliked in her husband. Clearly, the process of scapegoating is dysfunctional for the child. He becomes 'emotionally disturbed'. He is unable to adjust to life at school and in the neighbourhood. However, what is dysfunctional for the child can be seen as functional for the parents, for the family unit and for society as a whole. The parents release their tension and so control the conflict between them. As a result the family as a whole is stabilized and strengthened. Vogel and Bell argue that the cost to the child is 'low relative to the functional gains of the whole family'. Scapegoating the child serves as a 'personality-stabilizing process' for the parents which allows them to effectively perform their roles in the wider society as 'steady workers and relatively respectable community members'.

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Whether the costs to the child are indeed low, compared to the gains of family solidarity and effective role performance by the adults outside the family, is a matter of opinion. To some extent this judgment reflects the functionalist view of the vital importance of the family to society. However, Vogel and Bell's analysis does have the merit of dealing with dysfunctional aspects of the family within a functionalist framework.

Critical views of the family

Even Vogel and Bell's analysis suggests that, all things considered, the family is functional both for its members and society as a whole. Increasingly, this picture of the family is coming under strong criticism. Some observers are suggesting that, on balance, the family may well be dysfunctional both for society and its individual members. This criticism has mainly been directed at the family in Western industrial society.

Edmund Leach – A Runaway World?

In a study entitled *A Runaway World?* Edmund Leach presents a pessimistic view of the family in industrial society. Leach, an anthropologist, has spent many years studying small-scale pre-industrial societies. In such societies the family often forms a part of a wider kinship unit. An extensive network of social relationships between a large number of kin provides practical and psychological support for the individual. This support is reinforced by the closely-knit texture of relationships in the small-scale community as a whole. By comparison, in modern industrial society, the nuclear family is largely isolated from kin and the wider community. Leach summarizes this situation and its consequences as follows, ' In the past kinsfolk and neighbours gave the individual continuous moral support throughout his life. Today the domestic household is isolated. The family looks inward upon itself; there is an intensification of emotional stress between husband and wife and parents and children. The strain is greater than most of us can bear'. Thrown back almost entirely on its own resources, the nuclear family becomes like an overloaded electrical circuit. The demands made upon it are too great and fuses below. In their isolation, family members expect and demand too much from each other. The result is conflict. In Leach's words, 'The parents and children huddled together in their loneliness take too much out of each other. The parents fight; the children rebel'.

Problems are not confined to the family. The tension and hostility produced within the family find expression throughout society. Leach argues that the 'isolation and the close-knit nature of contemporary family life incubates hate which finds expression in conflict in the wider community'. The families in which

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people huddle together create barriers between them and the wider society. The privatized family breeds suspicion and fear of the outside world. Leach argues that, 'Privacy is the source of fear and violence. The violence in the world comes about because we human beings are forever creating barriers between men who are like us and men who are not like us'. Only when individuals can break out of the prison of the nuclear family, rejoin their fellows, and give and receive support will the ills of society begin to diminish. Leach's conclusion is diametrically opposed to the functionalist view of the family. He states, 'Far from being the basis of the good society, the family, with its narrow privacy and tawdry secrets is the source of all our discontents'.

R.D. Laing – The politics of the family

In *The Politics of the Family* and a number of other publications, R.D. Laing presents a radial alternative to the functionalist picture of the 'happy family'. Laing is a phenomenological psychiatrist. He is concerned with interaction within the family and the meanings which develop in that context. His work is largely based on the study of families in which one member has been defined as schizophrenic. Laing argues that the behavior of so-called schizophrenics can only be understood in terms of relationships within the family. Far from viewing schizophrenia as madness, he argues that it makes sense in terms of the meanings and interactions which develop within the family. As such it can be seen as reasonable behaviour. Laing maintains that the difference between so-called 'normal' and 'abnormal' families is small. It therefore follows that a lot can be learned about families in general by studying those labeled as abnormal.

Laing views the family in terms of sets of interactions. Individuals form alliances, adopt various strategies and play one or more individuals off against others in a complex tactical game. Laing is preoccupied with interaction situations which he regards as harmful and destructive. Throughout his work he concentrates on exploitive aspects of family relationships.

Laing refers to the family group as a 'nexus'. He argues that 'the highest concern of the nexus is reciprocal concern. Each partner is concerned about what the other thinks, feels, does'. Within the nexus there is a constant, unremitting demand for mutual concern and attention. As a result there is considerable potential for harm; family members are in an extremely vulnerable position. Thus if a father is ashamed of his son, given the nature of the nexus, his son is deeply affected. As he is emotionally locked into the nexus, he is concerned about his father's opinion and cannot brush it off lightly. In self-defence he may run to his mother who offers protection. In this way Laing argues that, 'A family can act as gangsters, offering each other mutual protection against each other's violence.

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From interaction within the nexus, 'reciprocal interiorization' develops. Family members become a part of each other and the family as a whole. They interiorize or internalize the family. Laing argues that, 'To be in the same family is to feel the same "family" inside'. Laing regards the process of interiorization as psychologically damaging since it restricts the development of the self. The individual carries the blueprint of his family with him for the rest of his life. This prevents any real autonomy or freedom of self, it prevents the development of the individual in his own right. Self-awareness is smothered under the blanket of the family.

Like Leach, Ling argues that problems in the family create problems in society. Due to the nature of the nexus and the process of interiorization, a boundary or even a defensive barrier is drawn between the family and the world outside. This can reach the point where, 'some families live in perpetual anxiety of what, to them, is an external persecuting world. The members of the family live in a family ghetto as it were'. The barrier erected between the family and the world outside may have important consequences. According to Laing it leads family members, particularly children, to see the world in terms of 'us and them'. From this basic division stem the harmful and dangerous distinctions between Gentile and Jew, Black and White and the separation of others into 'people like us' and 'people like them'.

Within the family children learn to obey their parents. Laing regards this as the primary link in a dangerous chain. Patterns of obedience laid down in early childhood form the basis for obedience to authority in later life. They lead to soldiers and officials blindly and unquestioningly following orders. Laing implies that without family obedience training, people would question orders, follow their own judgment and make their own decisions. If this were so, American soldiers might not have marched off to fight what Laing regards as a senseless war in Vietnam.

David Cooper – The Death of the Family

David Cooper is a phenomenological psychiatrist who has worked closely with Laing. His book, *The Death of the Family* is an outright condemnation of the family as an institution. Like Laing, he sees the family as a stultifying institution which stunts the self and largely denies people the freedom to develop their own individuality. To develop an autonomous self, the child must be free to be alone, free from the constant demands made upon him in the family, free from the 'imprisoning and ambiguous love' which engulfs him. Like Laing, Cooper argues that individuals interiorize the family. Because of this the self can never be free sine it is made up of other family members. In the process of interiorization, 'one

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glues bits of other people onto oneself' and for most people, this results in 'the chronic murder of their selves'.

Cooper develops his ideas along Marxian lines. He argues that the family operates 'as an ideological conditioning device in an exploitive society – slave society, feudal society, capitalist society. The behaviour patterns and controls laid down within the family produce the 'well-conditioned, endlessly obedient citizen' who is easily manipulated by ruling classes. As a result of the social controls implanted into the child by family socialization, 'The child is in fact primarily taught not how to survive in society but how to submit to it'. Each child has the potential to be an artist, a visionary and a revolutionary but this potential is crushed in the family. Artists, visionaries and revolutionaries tend to think for themselves and to see through ruling class ideologies. However, the opportunity to develop in this way is stifled by the submission of the self to the demands of the family.

Cooper argues that 'the family specializes in the formation of roles for its members rather than laying down conditions for the free assumption of identity'. Thus children are taught to play the roles of son and daughter, male and female. Such roles are constricting. They confine behaviour within narrow limits and restrict the development of self. They lay the groundwork for 'indoctrination' into roles at school, work and in society generally. The family prepares the individual for his induction into the role he is to play in an exploitive society, the role of 'the endlessly obedient citizen'. Cooper's view of the relationship between the family and society is summarized in the following quotation, 'So the family goes on and is externally reflected in all our relationships'. An exploitive family produces an exploitive society.

Leach, Laing and Cooper in their different ways have presented a radical alternative to the functionalist perspective on the family. Their work is open to a number of criticisms. None have conducted detailed field work on the family in contemporary industrial society. Laing and Cooper's research is limited to investigations of families in which one member has been defined as schizophrenic. All talk about 'the family' with little reference to its position in the social structure.

For example, there is no reference to social class in either Laing or Cooper's work and therefore no indication of the relationship between class and family life. Leach examines the family over time, but apart from vague references to capitalism and previous eras in Cooper's writings, the work of both Cooper and Laing lacks any historical perspective. All three authors examine the Western family from their particular specialized knowledge, Leach from his work on family and kinship in small-scale non-western societies, Laing and Cooper from their

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studies of schizophrenia and family life. This inevitably colours their views. In itself, this is not a criticism, but it is important to be aware of the source of their perspectives. To some degree Leach, Laing and Cooper begin with a picture of a society out of control or even gone mad. Leach in *A Runaway World?* implies that society has got out of hand, Laing and Cooper go even further by suggesting that many aspects of contemporary society are insane. Such views of society will produce what many consider to be an extreme and unbalanced picture of the family. However, it is possible to accuse the functionalists of the opposite bias. For example, Parsons gives the impression of an immensely reasonable society ticking over like clock-work. In this context a well adjusted, contented family is to be expected.

Leach, Laing and Cooper have provided a balance to the functionalist view which has dominated sociological thinking on the family for many years. Laing in particular, has given important insights into interaction patterns within the family.

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The family – a Marxian perspective

Marxian sociologists have tended to bypass the family in their preoccupation with social class. Apart from **Friedrich Engels**, who wrote an important work on the origin and evolution of the family entitled ***The Origin of the Family, Private Property and the State***, (first published in 1984), until the late 1960s few writers attempted to apply Marxian theory to the family.

Like many nineteenth-century scholars, Engels took an evolutionary view of the family, attempting to trace its origin and evolution through time. He combined an evolutionary approach with Marxian theory arguing that as the mode of production changed, so did the family. During the early stages of human evolution, Engels believed that the forces of production were communally owned and the family as such did not exist. This era of 'primitive communism' was characterized by promiscuity. There were no rules limiting sexual relationships and society was, in effect, the family. Although Engels has been criticized for this type of speculation, the anthropologist Kathleen Gough argues that his picture may not be that far from the truth. She notes that man's nearest relatives, the chimpanzees, live in 'promiscuous hordes' and this may have been the pattern for early man.

Engels argued that throughout man's history, more and more restrictions were placed on sexual relationships and the production of children. He speculated that from the promiscuous horde, marriage and the family evolved through a series of stages which included polygyny to its present stage, the monogamous nuclear family. Each successive stage placed greater restrictions on the number of mates available to the individual. The monogamous nuclear family developed with the emergence of private property, in particular the private ownership of the forces of production, and the advent of the state. The state instituted laws to protect the system of private property and to enforce the rules of monogamous marriage. This form of marriage and the family developed to solve the problems of the inheritance of private property. Property was owned by males and in order for them to pass it on to their heirs, they must be certain of the legitimacy of those heirs. They therefore needed greater control over women so there would be no doubt about the paternity of their offspring. The monogamous family provided the most efficient device for this purpose. In Engels's words, 'It is based on the supremacy of the man, the express purpose being to produce children of undisputed paternity; such paternity is demanded because these children are later to come into their father's property as his natural heirs'.

Engels's scheme of the evolution of the family is much more elaborate than the brief outline described above. It was largely based on *Ancient Society*, an erroneous interpretation of the evolution of the family by the nineteenth century

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American anthropologist, Lewis Henry Morgan. Modern research has suggested that many of its details are incorrect. For example, monogamous marriage and the nuclear family are often found in hunting and gathering bands. Since humanity has lived in hunting and gathering bands for the vast majority of its existence, the various forms of group marriage postulated by Engels, such as the promiscuous horde, may well be figments of his imagination. However, Kathleen Gough argues that 'the general trend of Engels's argument still appears sound'. Although nuclear families and monogamous marriage exist in small-scale societies, they form a part of a larger kinship group. When individuals marry they take on a series of duties and obligations to their spouse's kin. Communities are united by kinship ties and the result is like a large extended family. Gough argues that, 'It is true that although it is not a group marriage in Engels's sense, marriage has a group character in many hunting bands and in most of the more complex tribal societies that have developed with the domestication of plants and animals. With the development of privately owned, heritable property, and especially with the rise of the state, this group character gradually disappears'.

Eli Zaretsky – personal life and capitalism

Eli Zaretsky has analysed more recent developments in the family from a Marxist perspective. He argues that the family in modern capitalist society creates the illusion that the 'private life' of the family is quite separate from the economy. Before the early nineteenth century the family was the basic unit of production. For example, in the early capitalist textile industry, production of cloth took place in the home and involved all family members. Only with the development of factory-based production were work and family life separated.

In a society in which work was alienating, Zaretsky claims that the family was put on a pedestal because it apparently 'stood in opposition to the terrible anonymous world of commerce and industry'. The private life of the family provided opportunities for satisfactions that were unavailable outside the walls of the home.

Zaretsky welcomes the increased possibilities for a personal life for the proletariat offered by the reduction in working hours since the nineteenth century. However, he believes that the family is unable to provide for the psychological and personal needs of individuals. He says 'it simply cannot meet the pressures of being the only refuge in a brutal society'. The family artificially separates and isolates personal life from other aspects of life. It might cushion the effects of capitalism but it perpetuates the system and cannot compensate for the general alienation produced by such a society.

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Furthermore, Zaretsky sees the family as major prop to the capitalist economy. The capitalist system is based upon the domestic labour of housewives who reproduce future generations of workers. He also believes that the family has become a vital unit of consumption. The family consumes the products of capitalism and this allows the bourgeoisie to continue producing surplus value. To Zaretsky, only socialism will end the artificial separation of family private life and public life, and produce the possibility of personal fulfillment.

Next we will examine the family from a feminist viewpoint.

Feminist perspectives on the family

The influence of feminism

In recent decades feminism has probably had more influence on the study of the family than any other approach to understanding society. Like Laing, Leach and Marxists, feminists have been highly critical of the family. However, unlike other critics, they have tended to emphasize the harmful effects of family life upon women. In doing so they have developed new perspectives and highlighted new issues.

Feminists have, for example, introduced the study of areas of family life such as housework and domestic violence into sociology. They have challenged some widely-held views about the inevitability of male dominance in families and have questioned the view that family life is becoming more egalitarian. Feminists have also highlighted the economic contribution to society made by women's domestic labour within the family. Above all, feminist theory has encouraged sociologists to see the family as an institution involving power relationships. It has challenged the image of family life as being based upon cooperation, shared interests and love, and has tried to show that some family members, in particular men, obtain greater benefits from families than others.

Recently, some feminists have questioned the tendency of other feminists to make blanket condemnations of family life and have emphasized the different experiences of women in families. Some have rejected the idea that there is such a thing as 'the family' rather than simply different domestic arrangements. They have, however, continued to identify ways in which domestic life can disadvantage women.

In later sections of this chapter we will consider the impact of feminism on the study of conjugal roles, domestic labour, social policy and marriage. In the next

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section, however, we will examine some of the feminist theoretical approaches to understanding the family.

Marxist feminist perspectives on the family

Marxian analysis of the family in capitalist society developed mainly in the late 1960s and 1970s, when several feminist writers employed Marxian concepts in their criticism of the family. From this perspective, the family is seen as a unit which produces one of the basic commodities of capitalism, labour. It produces it cheaply from the point of view of the capitalists, since they do not have to pay for the production of children or their upkeep. In particular, the wife is not paid for producing and rearing children.

Please note that Marxists such as Engels and Zaretsky have acknowledged that women are exploited in marriage and family life but they have emphasized the relationship between capitalism and the family, rather than the family's effects on women. Marxists feminists use Marxist concepts but see the exploitation of women as a key feature of family life. The next few sections will examine how these theories have been applied to the family.

The production of labour power

Margaret Benston (1972) states that 'the amount of unpaid labour performed by women is very large and very profitable to those who own the means of production. To pay women for their work, even at minimum wage scales, would involve a massive redistribution of wealth. At present, the support of the family is a hidden tax on the wage earner – his wage buys the labour power of two people'. The fact that the husband must pay for the production and upkeep of future labour acts as a strong discipline on his behaviour at work. He cannot easily withdraw his labour with a wife and children to support. These responsibilities weaken his bargaining power and commit him to wage labour. Benston argues that, 'As an economic unit, the nuclear family is a valuable stabilizing force in capitalist society. Since the production which is done in the home is paid for by the husband –father's earnings, his ability to withhold labour from the market is much reduced'.

Not only does the family produce and rear cheap labour, it also maintains it in good order at no cost to the employer. In her role as housewife, the woman attends to her husband's needs thus keeping him in good running order to perform his role as a wage labourer.

Fran Ansley translates Parsons's view, that the family functions to stabilize adult personalities, into a Marxian framework. She sees the emotional support

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provided by the wife as a safety valve for the frustration produced in the husband by working in a capitalist system. Rather than being turned against the system which produced it, this frustration is absorbed by the comforting wife. In this way the system is not threatened. In Ansley's words, 'when wives play their traditional role as takers of shit, they often absorb their husband's legitimate anger and frustration at their own powerlessness and oppression. With every worker provided with a sponge to soak up his possibly revolutionary ire, the bosses rest more secure'. Kathy McAfee and Myrna Wood make a similar point in their discussion of male dominance in the family. They claim that, 'The petty dictatorship which most men exercise over their wives and families enables them to vent their anger and frustration in a way which poses no challenge to the system'.

Ideological conditioning

The social reproduction of labour power does not simply involve producing children and maintaining them in good health. It also involves the reproduction of the attitudes essential for an efficient workforce under the capitalism. Thus **David Cooper** argues that the family is 'an ideological conditioning device in an exploitive society'. Within the family children learn to conform, to submit to authority. The foundation is therefore laid for the obedient and submissive workforce required by capitalism.

A similar point is made by **Diane Feeley** who argues that the structure of family relationships socializes the young to accept their place in a class stratified society. She sees the family as an authoritarian unit dominated by the husband in particular and adults in general. Feeley claims that the family with its 'authoritarian ideology is designed to teach passivity, not rebellion'. Thus children learn to submit to parental authority and emerge from the family pre-conditioned to accept their place in the hierarchy of power and control in capitalist society. Marxian views on the role of the family in capitalist society mirror Marxian analysis of the role of education.

Criticisms

Some of the criticisms of previous views of the family also apply to Marxian approaches. There is a tendency to talk about 'the family' in capitalist society without regard to possible variations in family life between social classes, ethnic groups, heterosexual and gay and lesbian families, lone-parent families, and over time. As D.H.J. Morgan notes in his criticism of both functionalist and Marxian approaches, both 'presuppose a traditional model of the nuclear family where there is a married couple with children, where the husband is the breadwinner and where the wife stays at home to deal with the housework'. Although there is some justice

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to this criticism, Marxian views of the family have developed to include families in which the wife is also a wife earner. In other words, this pattern is becoming less common and the critique of this type of family may therefore be becoming less important.

Marxist feminists may therefore exaggerate the harm caused to women by families and may neglect the effects of non-family relationships (apart from class) on exploitation within marriage. Thus, for example they say little about how the experience of racism might influence families. They also tend to portray female family members as the passive victims of capitalist and patriarchal exploitation. They ignore the possibility that women may have fought back against such exploitation and had some success in changing the nature of family relationships. Furthermore, they are not usually prepared to concede that there may be positive elements to family life. As we shall see, **difference feminists** are more prepared to accept that there may be some positive advantages for some women, in some families.

Radical feminist perspectives on the family

There are many varieties of radical feminism. As Valerie Bryson says, 'the radical feminist label has been applied in recent years to a confusingly diverse range of theories'. She says 'it is the site for far ranging disagreements at all levels of theory and practice'. However, Bryson does identify some key characteristics which distinguish radical feminists from other feminists:

1. 'It is essentially a theory of, by and for women' and therefore 'sees no need to compromise with existing perspectives and agenda'. Radical feminist ideas tend to be novel rather than adaptations of other theories such as Marxism.

2. 'It sees the oppression of women as the most fundamental and universal form of domination'. Society is seen as patriarchal, or male-dominated, rather than capitalist, and women are held to have different interests to those of men.

Radical feminists do not agree on the source of male domination, but most do see the family as important in maintaining male power. We will now analyse one major radical feminist theory of the family.

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Christine Delphy and Diana Leonard – Familial Exploitation

Delphy and Leonard (1992) are unlike most radical feminists in that they attach considerable importance to material factors in causing women's oppression. In this respect they have some similarity with Marxist feminist theories. In particular, Delphy and Leonard attach special importance to work and say that their approach 'uses Marxist methodology'. Nevertheless, they see themselves as radical feminists since they believe that it is men, rather than capitalists or capitalism, who are the primary beneficiaries of the exploitation of women's labour. To them, the family has a central role in maintaining patriarchy. They say:

> *We see the familial basis of domestic groups*
> *as an important element in continuing*
> *the patriarchal nature of our society:*
> *that is, in the continuance of men's dominance*
> *over women and children.*

The family as an economic system

Delphy and Leonard see the family as an economic system. It involves a particular set of 'labour relations in which men benefit from, and exploit, the work of women'. The key to this explanation is that family members work not for themselves but for the head of the household. Women in particular are oppressed, not because they are socialized into being passive, nor because they are ideologically conditioned into subservience, but because their work is appropriated within the family. Delphy and Leonard argue that 'It is primarily the *work* women do, the uses to which our bodies can be put, which constitutes the reason for our oppression'.

Delphy and Leonard argue that every family-based household has a social structure that involves two types of role. These are head of household and their dependents. Family households have members who are connected by kinship or marriage. Female heads of household are uncommon. Where a male adult relative is present it is usually he who takes over as head of household. He holds the ultimate authority and makes the final decisions in the household. Further, the type and amount of work family members have to do are related to sex and marital status. Female relatives have to do unpaid domestic work; wives in addition have to carry out 'sexual and reproductive work'. Although the precise allocation of tasks varies from household to household, domestic work remains a female responsibility. Moreover, the relations of production within the family often, therefore, involve payment in kind (such as a new coat or a holiday) rather than payment in money.

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To conclude Delphy and Leonard believe that the family is a patriarchal and hierarchical institution through which men dominate and exploit women. Men are usually the head of household, and it is the head who benefits from the work that gets done. Women provide '57 varieties of unpaid service' for men, including providing them with a 'pliant sexual partner and children if he wants them'. Wives do sometimes resist their husband's dominance – they are not always passive victims – but 'economic and social constraints' make it difficult for women to escape from the patriarchal family.

Delphy and Leonard do not think that there are simple solutions to the problems created by the family. Individual men may love their wives, but that does not stop them from exploiting them. Single mothers cannot escape from patriarchy 'because they are often poor and their situation is always difficult'. Lesbians 'may be downright ostracized and physically attacked'. In the end, they admit that they do not know what strategy feminists should use to change the family, but they believe that women should continue to struggle to improve their lives, both inside and outside family life.

Evaluation

Delphy and Leonard provide a comprehensive analysis of the family from a radical feminist perspective. They highlight many ways in which the family can reinforce inequalities between women and men. However, their work can be criticized both theoretically and empirically. Theoretically, Delphy and Leonard do not succeed in demonstrating that inequality is built into the structure of the family. Their argument is based upon the assumption that *all* families have a head, usually a man, and it is the head who ultimately benefits from family life. However, they do not show theoretically or empirically that all families have a head who has more power than other family members. They fail to acknowledge that there may be some families in which power is shared. It may well be possible to find inequalities in every household, but that does not necessarily mean that one person is dominant. Ironically, they make similar, false assumptions to those found in the work of the functionalist George Peter Murdock. Empirically, their work is based upon unrepresentative data. The three British studies used are all of manual workers. Most researchers have found less gender inequality in middle-class families than in working-class families, so these studies may have an in-built bias towards supporting their theory.

Delphy and Leonard tend to make rather sweeping statements about inequality which may not apply equally to all families. In doing so they perhaps overstate their case by denying the possibility of exceptions.

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Laura M. Purdy – 'Babystrike !'

Feminism and motherhood

Like Delphy and Leonard, Laura M. Purdy (1997) believes that women are disadvantaged and exploited in family relationships. Unlike Delphy and Leonard, she believes that these disadvantages largely result from childcare responsibilities rather than from material inequalities. Purdy argues that in recent years feminists have placed less emphasis on criticisms of families and marriage, while issues such as pornography and sexual harassment have come to be seen as more important. She says, 'critiques of marriage and family seem almost forgotten as feminists, like society at large, now seem generally to assume that all women – including lesbians – will pair up and have children'. Some recent accounts of the family in the popular media suggest that it is possible for women to 'have it all'. They can combine a successful career with a rewarding family life and successful and satisfying child-rearing. Purdy question whether it is really possible to 'have it all' and whether family life in general, and child-rearing in particular, are really the paths to female self-fulfilment.

Purdy suggest that it is generally assumed that women should want to form couples (whether heterosexual or lesbian) and have children. Couples who choose not to have children are thought of as eccentric and selfish. Young women never 'hear that some people shouldn't have children, either because they do not really want them, because they are not able to care for them well, or because they have other projects that are incompatible with good child-rearing'. Purdy believes that feminism should try to counter the assumption that having children is necessarily desirable.

The disadvantages of motherhood

According to Purdy, there are a number of disadvantages for women in having children. Having children is extremely expensive and can increase the burden of poverty on women who are already poor. Having children represents a commitment for women for the rest of their lives, and a particularly onerous commitment during first 18 years. According to an American study quoted by Purdy, men still do only 20 per cent of domestic work, despite big increases in female employment. This makes it very difficult for women to compete on equal terms in the labour market or to try to fight for greater equality. She asks, 'How can women energetically fight the entrenched sexism in society and pursue positions of power and prestige if their time and energy is mostly taken up with children's needs, needs that cannot and ought not be ignored?'

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Purdy believes that society in general takes it for granted that women will have children and therefore perform the vital function of reproducing the species. The only way to bring home to men the sacrifices of child-rearing is for women to stop having children. In other words, Purdy advocates a babystrike. Only then would men take women's demands for equality within families seriously. Only then would social arrangements change so that women were able to combine having children with successful careers.

Evaluation

The idea of a babystrike is a novel suggestion for focusing male attention on the disadvantages suffered by women. Purdy makes an important point in drawing attention to the particular problems posed for women by the responsibilities of childcare. However, she places perhaps too much emphasis on one factor – that of child-rearing – in creating and perpetuating women's disadvantages in families. Other feminists, perhaps with some justification, would not accept that children are the only, or even the main, reason for women being unequal within families. They certainly would not accept that women only start to suffer inequality once they have children. Like a number of other theorists of the family, Purdy may exaggerate the effects of one particular source of inequality while neglecting others.

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Difference feminism

Neither Marxist nor radical feminism is particularly sensitive to variations between families. Both approaches tend to assume that families in general disadvantage women and benefit men (and, in the case of Marxist approaches, benefit capitalism). Both can be criticized for failing to acknowledge the variety of domestic arrangements produced by different groups, and the range of effects that family life can have.

Increasingly, however, feminists have begun to highlight the differences between groups of women in different family situations. Thus, they have argued that women in single-parent families are in a different situation to women in two-parent families; women in lesbian families are in a different position to women in heterosexual families; black women are often in a different family position to white women; poor women are in a different position to middle-class women, and so on. Feminists who analyse the family in these terms have sometimes been referred to as '**difference feminists**'. Difference feminists have been influenced by a range of feminist theories including liberal feminism, Marxist feminism and radical feminism. Their work often has affinities with postmodern theories of the family and with ideas relating to family diversity. However, they share a sufficiently distinctive approach to be considered a separate feminist perspective on the family.

Michelle Barrett and Mary McIntosh – The Anti-social Family

One of the earliest examples of a theory of the family put forward by difference feminists is provided by the work of Michelle Barrett and Mary McIntosh (1982). Their work was influenced by Marxist feminism but moves beyond the kinds of Marxist views discussed earlier. Barrett and McIntosh believe that **the idea of 'the family' is misleading**, given the wide variations that exist in life within families and varieties of household types in which people live. (Family and household diversity is discussed later). If there is no one normal or typical family type, then it may be impossible to claim that the family always performs particulars functions either for men or for capitalism.

The 'anti-social' family

Barrett and McIntosh do believe that there is a very strong ideology supporting family life. To them 'the family' is 'anti-social' not just because it exploits women, and benefits capitalists, but also because the ideology of the family destroys life outside the family. They say 'the family ideal makes everything else seem pale and unsatisfactory'. People outside families suffer as a consequence. Family members are so wrapped up in family life that they neglect

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social contact with others. 'Couples mix with other couples, finding it difficult to fit single people in'.

Life in other institutions (such as children's homes, old people's homes and students' residences) comes to be seen as shallow and lacking in meaning. Barrett and McIntosh argue that homes for the handicapped could be far more stimulating for, say, Down's syndrome sufferers, if it were not for life in institution being devalued by the ideology of the family.

Like other feminists, they point out that the image of the family as involving love and mutual care tends to ignore the amount of violent and sexual crime that takes place within a family context. They note that 25 percent of reported violent crimes consist of assaults by husbands on their wives, and many rapes take place within marriage.

They do not deny that there can be caring relationships within families, but equally they do not think that families are the only places in which such relationships can develop. In their view, the ideology that idealizes family life:

has made the outside world cold and friendless,
and made it harder to maintain relationships of
security and trust except with kin. Caring,
sharing and loving would be more
widespread if the family did not claim them
for its own.

Linda Nicholson – 'The myth of the traditional family'

Like Barrett and McIntosh, Linda Nicholson (1997) believes that there is a powerful ideology which gives support to a positive image of family life. She argues that this ideology only supports certain types of family while devaluing other types. Nicholson contrasts what she calls the 'traditional' family with 'alternative' families. She is an American feminist and her comments largely refer to the USA, but they may be applicable more generally to Western societies.

The 'traditional' family

Nicholson defines the traditional family as 'the unit of parents with children who live together'. The bond between husband and wife is seen as particularly important, and the family feels itself to be separate from other kin. This family group is often referred to as the nuclear family. When conservative social commentators express concern about the decline of the family, it is this sort of

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family they are concerned about. They tend to be less worried about any decline of wider kinship links involving grandparents, aunts, uncles and so on.

According to Nicholson, the nuclear family is a comparatively recent phenomenon. It first developed among upper classes in the eighteenth century. For middle-class groups this type of family only became popular in the nineteenth century. Working class people often aspired to form nuclear families in the nineteenth century, but their low income usually prevented them from doing so. They frequently had to share accommodation with others from outside the nuclear family. Indeed, it was not really until the 1950s and the post-Second World War boom that nuclear family households became the norm for working class families. Thus Nicholson argues that the conventional family is actually a very recent phenomenon for most people.

However, even in the 1950s, some groups lacked the resources to form nuclear families. This was the case for people with few or outdated skills and for many African Americans who were the victims of racism in the labour market.

Alternative families

Alternative family forms were already developing even before the traditional family reached its zenith. Nicholson says that:

> *even as certain ideal of family was coming to define 'the American way of life', such trends as a rising divorce rate, increased participation of married women in the labour force, and the growth of female-headed households were making this way of life increasingly atypical. In all cases such trends preceded the 1950s.*
>
> Nicholson, 1997

Some of these changes actually altered what was perceived as a 'traditional' family. For example, it came to be seen as 'normal' for married women to work, even if they and their partners had small children. Other changes, though, were seen as producing alternative families. Alternatives to traditional families included, 'Not only gays and lesbians but heterosexuals living alone; marries couples with husbands at home caring for children', as well as stepfamilies, single parents, heterosexual couples living together outside marriage, and gay or lesbians couples with or without children.

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The merits of different family types

Alternative families, or alternatives to traditional families, tend to be devalued. They are seen as less worthy than traditional families. However, Nicholson rejects this view. Alternative families are often better than traditional ones for the women who live in them. For example, poor black women in the USA derive some benefits when they live in mother-centred families, often without men. They develop strong support networks with other friends and kin, who act as a kind of social insurance system. They help out the families who are most in need at a particular time if they are in a position to do so. Such families do have disadvantages. If they have some good fortune and come into money, each family is expected to share resources. This makes it difficult for individual families to escape poverty. Furthermore, the lack of stable heterosexual partnerships means that 'children frequently do not have the type of long-term relationships with father figures which is normative within middle-class households'.

Traditional families also have advantages and disadvantages. Because both partners now tend to work, they have tremendous time pressures, making it difficult to carry out satisfactory and rewarding childcare. Children who are the victims of abuse by parents have relatively little opportunity to turn to other relatives for help. Traditional families place a heavy burden of expectation on the partners, and, with work and childcare commitments, it may be difficult for them to provide the love and companionship each partner expects. The traditional family also precludes and excludes gay and lesbian relationships.

However, traditional families do have some advantages. Their small size tends to encourage intimacy between family members, and when the relationships work, they can be rewarding and long-lasting. Traditional families can be economically successful because they are not under strong requirements to share their resources with others.

Conclusion

The fact that they have some advantages does not mean that traditional families are better than alternative types. From Nicholson's point of view, different types of family suit different women in different circumstances. She believes that the distinction between traditional and alternative families should be abandoned. The distinction implies that traditional families are better, when this is often not true. In any case, the idea of the traditional family misleadingly implies that such families have long been the norm, when in fact they have only become popular in recent times, and have never been totally dominant. By the late 1990s so many people lives in alternatives to traditional families that the idea of the traditional

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family had become totally outdated. Nicholson therefore concludes that all types of family and household should be acknowledged and accepted because they could suit women in different circumstances. She advocates the celebration of greater choice for people in deciding on their own living arrangements.

Cheshire Calhoun – lesbian as family outlaws

Like Linda Nicholson, Cheshire Calhoun develops a type of difference feminism influenced by postmodernism (Calhoun, 1997). Unlike Nicholson, she focuses on lesbian families rather than looking at the merits of a variety of family forms for women. Calhoun is a postmodern, difference feminist from the United States.

Calhoun argues that feminist theories have generally neglected sexual orientation as a source of oppression distinct from gender oppression. However, Nicholson believes that sexual orientation can be an important source of oppression and that family ideology contributes to that oppression.

Conventional feminist views

Calhoun starts by noting conventional feminist views on the family. Such views see the family as an important source of female oppression for a variety of reasons. These include the ways in which families make women financially dependent upon men, the way family ideology encourages women to put the family before their own interests, inequalities in the amount of domestic work done by men and women, and the way in which family ideology 'often masks gender injustice within the family including battery, rape and child abuse'.

Calhoun accepts that this sort of feminist analysis is accurate but says that 'This picture…..is not, in fact, a picture of *women's* relation to the family, but is more narrowly a picture of *heterosexual* women's relation to the family, marriage and mothering'. Lesbians who live outside heterosexual families can hardly be directly exploited by relationships within such families. Indeed lesbian are uniquely placed to avoid dependence on men within families. However, Calhoun does believe that they are disadvantaged by the ideology of the heterosexual family.

Some lesbian feminists have argued that lesbians should avoid forming families. They have argued that, because women are exploited in heterosexual marriages, marriage and family life are inevitably patriarchal. Similarly they have argued that, because mothering disadvantages heterosexual women - by, for example, limiting their opportunities in the labour market - lesbian women should

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also avoid becoming mothers. Calhoun disagrees. She believes that it is not family life itself that leads to the exploitation of women, rather it is family life within patriarchal, heterosexual marriages that is the problem. Lesbian marriage and mothering can avoid the exploitative relationships typical of heterosexual marriage. Indeed, lesbian partners may be able to develop forms of marriage and family life which can point the way to creating more egalitarian domestic relationships.

This view is in stark contrast to a more conventional view that lesbians and gay cannot develop proper marriages or construct genuine families. According to Calhoun, gays and lesbian have historically been portrayed as 'family outlaws'. Their sexuality has been seen as threatening to the family. They have been portrayed as 'outsiders to the family and as displaying the most virulent forms of family-disrupting behaviour'. However, Calhoun believes that the anxiety among heterosexuals about gays and lesbian has in fact been caused by anxiety about the state of the heterosexual nuclear family. Rather than recognizing and acknowledging the problems with such families, heterosexuals have tried to attribute the problems to corrupting outsiders or outlaws: that is, gay and lesbians.

Calhoun further argues that extended kinship networks have become increasingly important for the urban poor, and the idea of the family headed by a heterosexual couple with their offspring has been undermined by new reproductive technology. Calhoun says:

> *Increasingly sophisticated birth control methods and technologically assisted reproduction using in-vitro fertilization, artificial insemination, contract pregnancy, fertility therapies, and the like undermine cultural understandings of the marital couple as a naturally reproductive unit, introduce nonrelated others into the reproductive process, and make it possible for women and men to have children without a heterosexual partner.*
>
> Calhoun, 1997

According to Calhoun, modern family life is essentially characterized by choice. Lesbians and gays introduced the idea of chosen families. You can choose who to include in your family without the restrictions of blood ties or the expectation of settling down with and marrying an opposite-sex partner. Now, however, heterosexuals also construct 'chosen families' as they divorce, remarry, separate, choose new partners, adopt children, gain stepchildren and so on.

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Rather than seeing the above changes in a positive light, many commentators have seen them as a threat to families and the institution of marriage. This time there have been two main types of family outlaw who have been scapegoated and blamed for the changes. These are 'the unwed welfare mother and…..the lesbian or gay whose mere public visibility threatens to undermine family values and destroy the family'. In Britain, for example, the Local Government Act of the late 1980s made illegal 'the teaching in any maintained school of the acceptability of homosexuality as pretended family relationship'. Similarly, in 1990, the US Congress passed a law prohibiting the federal government from using funds to promote homosexuality.

Conclusion

Calhoun concludes that such scapegoating of lesbians and gays is used to disguise the increasingly frequent departures from the norms of family life by heterosexuals. She says:

> *claiming that gay and lesbian families are (or should be) distinctively queer and distinctively deviant helps conceal the deviancy in heterosexual families, and thereby helps to sustain the illusion that heterosexuals are specially entitled to access to a protective private sphere because they, unlike their gay and lesbian counterparts are, supporters of the family.*
>
> Calhoun, 1997

Thus the ideology of the heterosexual family has played an important part in encouraging discrimination and prejudice against gays and lesbian.

To Calhoun, gay and lesbian relationships, with or without children, are just as much family relationships as those of heterosexual couples. She does not believe that arguing for them to be accepted as such in any way legitimates the heterosexual, patriarchal family that has been so criticized by radical and Marxist feminists. In the contemporary world, heterosexual families engage in 'multiple deviations from norms governing the family'. A wide variety of behaviours and family forms have become common and widely accepted. Accepting gays and lesbians as forming families involves the acceptance of just one more variation from traditional conventional families. It has the potential benefit of reducing the anti-gay and anti-lesbian prejudice that has been promoted in the name of preserving the family.

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Difference feminism – conclusion

The feminists in this section all avoid the mistake of making sweeping generalizations about the effects of family life on women. They tend to be sensitive to the different experiences of family life experienced by women of different sexual orientations, ethnic groups, classes and so on (although each writer does not necessarily discuss all the sources of difference that affect how families influence women's lives). In these respects they can be seen as representing theoretical advances upon some of the Marxist and radical theories discussed earlier.

However, *some* difference feminists do sometimes lose sight of the inequalities between men and women in families by stressing the range of choices open to people when they are forming families. By stressing the different experiences of women they tend to neglect the common experiences shared by most women in families. Nevertheless, this general approach may be right to suggest that it is possible (if not common) for both men and women to develop rewarding and fulfilling family relationships.

This section has examined the family from a variety of perspectives. The focus now changes to various themes that are significant to our understanding of the family as a unit of social organization. The first theme is the effect of industrialization and modernization the family.

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The family, industrialization and modernization

A major theme in sociological studies of the family is the relationship between the structure of the family and the related processes of industrialization and modernization. Industrialization refers to the mass production of goods in a factory system which involves some degree of mechanized production technology. Modernization refers to the development of social, cultural, economic and political practices and institutions which are thought to be typical of modern societies. Such developments include the replacement of religious belief systems with scientific and rational ones, the growth of bureaucratic institutions, and the replacement of monarchies with representative democracies.

Some sociologists regard industrialization as the central process involved in changes in Western societies since the eighteenth century; others attach more importance to broader processes of modernization. However, there are a number of problems which arise from relating the family to industrialization or modernization:

1. The processes of industrialization and modernization do not follow the same course in every society.

2. Industrialization and modernization are not fixed states but developing processes. Thus the industrial system in nineteenth-century Britain was different in important respects from that of today. Similarly, British culture, society and politics are very different at the turn of the millennium from how they were two hundred years earlier.

3. Some writers dispute that we still live in modern industrial societies and believe that we have moved into a phase of postmodernity. The issue of the family and postmodernity will be examined later.

Further difficulties arise from the fact that there is not one form of pre-industrial, or pre-modern, family, but many. Much of the research on the family, industrialization and modernization has led to considerable confusion because it is not always clear what the family in industrial society is being compared to. In addition, within modern industrial society there are variations in family structure. As a starting point, therefore, it is necessary for us to examine the family in pre-modern, pre-industrial societies in order to establish a standard for comparison.

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The family in non-literate societies

In many small-scale, non-literate societies, the family and kinship relationships in general are the basic organizing principles of social life. Societies are often divided into a number of kinship groups, such as **lineages**, which are groups descended from a common ancestor. The family is embedded in a web of kinship relationships. Kinship groups are responsible for the production of important goods and services. For example, a lineage may own agricultural land which is worked, and its produce shared, by members of the lineage.

Members of kinship groups are united by a network of mutual rights and obligations. In some cases, if individuals are insulted or injured by someone from outside the group, they have the right to call on the support of members of the group in seeking reparation or revenge. Many areas of an individual's behaviour are shaped by his or her status as kin. An uncle, for example, may have binding obligations to be involved with aspects of his nephew's socialization and may be responsible for the welfare of his nieces and nephews should their father die.

In this brief description of the family in small-scale, pre-industrial society we have glossed over the wide variations in family and kinship patterns which are found in such societies. Even so, it does serve to highlight some of the more important differences between the family in kinship-based society and the family in industrial society.

The 'classic' extended family

A second form of pre-industrial, pre-modern family, sometimes known as the classic extended family, is found in some traditional peasant societies. This family type has been made famous by C.M. Arensberg and S.T. Kimball's study of Irish farmers, entitled *Family and Community in Ireland* (1968).

As in kinship-based societies, kinship ties dominate life, but in this case the basic unit is the extended family rather than the wider kinship grouping. The traditional Irish farming family is a patriarchal extended family, so-called because of the considerable authority of the male head. It is also patrilineal because property is passed down through the male line. Within the family, social and economic roles are welded together, status being ascribed by family membership.

Typically, the classic extended family consists of the male head, his wife and children, his ageing parents, and any unmarried brothers and sisters. Together they work as a 'production unit', producing the goods necessary for the family's survival.

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Some people have argued that, as industrialization and modernization proceed, kinship-based society and the classic extended family tend to break up, and the nuclear family – or some form of modified extended family – emerges as the predominant family form.

Talcott Parsons – the 'isolated nuclear family'

Talcott Parsons argues that the 'isolated nuclear family' is the typical family form in modern industrial society. It is 'structurally isolated' because it does not form an integral part of a wider system of kinship relationships. Obviously there are social relationships between members of nuclear families and their kin but these relationships are more a matter of choice than binding obligations. Parsons sees the emergence of the isolated nuclear family in terms of his theory of social evolution. The evolution of society involves a process of 'structural differentiation'. This means that institutions evolve which specialize in fewer functions. In this sense, no longer do the family and kinship groups perform a wide range of functions. Instead specialist institutions such as business firms, schools, hospitals, police forces and churches take over many of their functions. This process of differentiation and specialization involves the 'transfer of a variety of functions from the nuclear family to other structures of the society'. Thus in industrial society, with the transfer of the production of goods to factories, specialized economic institutions became differentiated from the family. The family ceases to be an economic unit of production.

Functionalist analysis emphasizes the importance of integration and harmony between the parts of society. An efficient social system requires the parts to fit smoothly rather than abrade. The parts of society are functionally related when they contribute to the integration and harmony of the social system. Parsons argues that there is a functional relationship between the isolated nuclear family and the economic system in industrial society. In particular, the isolated nuclear family is shaped to meet the requirements of the economic system. A modern industrial system with a specialized division of labour demands considerable geographical mobility from its labour force. Individuals with specialized skills are required to move to places where those skills are in demand. The isolated nuclear family is suited to the need for geographical mobility. It is not tied down by binding obligations to a wide range of kin, and compared to the pre-industrial families, it is a small, streamlined unit.

Status in industrial society is achieved rather than ascribed. An individual's occupational status is not automatically fixed by his ascribed status in the family or kinship group. Parsons argues that the isolated nuclear family is the best form of family structure for a society based on achieved status. In industrial society,

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individuals are judged in terms of the status they achieve. Such judgements are based on what Parsons terms 'universalistic values', that is values that are universally applied to all members of society. However, within the family, status is ascribed and, as such, based on particularistic values', that is values that are applied only to particular individuals. Thus a son's relationship with his father is conducted primarily in terms of their ascribed statuses of father and son. The father's achieved status as bricklayer, schoolteacher or lawyer has relatively little influence on their relationship since his son does not judge him primarily in terms of universalistic values. Parson argues that in a society based on achieved status conflict would tend to arise in a family unit larger than the isolated nuclear family. In a three generation extended family in which the children remained as part of the family unit, the following situation could produce conflict. If the son became a doctor and the father was a labourer, the particularistic values of family life would give the father a higher status than his son. Yet the universalistic values of society as a whole would award his son higher social status. Conflict may result from this situation which could undermine the authority of the father and threaten the solidarity of the family. The same conflict of values may occur if the nuclear family were extended horizontally. Relationships between a man and his brother may be problematic if they held jobs of widely differing prestige.

The isolated nuclear family largely prevents these problems from arising. There is one main breadwinner, the husband–father. His wife is mainly responsible for raising the children and the latter have yet to achieve their status in the world of work. No member of the family is in a position to threaten the ascribed authority structure by achieving a status outside the family which is higher than the achieved status of the family head. These problems do not occur in pre-industrial society. There, occupational status is largely ascribed since an individual's position in the family and kinship group usually determines his job. Parsons concludes that given the universalistic, achievement oriented values of industrial society, the isolated nuclear family is the most suitable family structure. Any extension of this basic unit may well create conflict which would threaten the solidarity of the family.

As a consequence of the structural isolation of the nuclear family, the conjugal bond – the relationship between husband and wife – is strengthened. Without the support of kin beyond the nuclear family, spouses are increasingly depended on each other, particularly for emotional support. As outlined in a previous section, Parsons argues that the stabilization of adult personalities is a major function of the family in industrial society. This is largely accomplished in terms of the husband-wife relationship.

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William J. Goode

In *World Revolution and the Family* William J. Goode surveys the relationship between family structure and industrialization in various parts of the world. Like Parsons, he argues that industrialization tends to undermine the extended family and larger kinship groupings. Goode offers the following explanations for this process. The high rate of geographical mobility in industrial society decreases 'the frequency and intimacy of contact among members of the kin network'. The relatively high level of social mobility also tends to weaken kinship ties. For example, if a member of a working-class family becomes upwardly mobile, he may adopt the life style, attitudes and values of his new social class. This would tend to cut him off from his working-class kin. Many of the functions once performed by the family have been taken over by outside agencies such as schools, business and welfare organizations. This reduces the dependency of the individual on his family and kin. The importance of achieved status in industrial society means that the family and kinship group have less to offer their members. The family cannot guarantee its members a job or directly provide the necessary education and training to obtain one. The highly specialized division of labour in industrial society makes it even more difficult for an individual to obtain a job for a relative. As Goode states, 'He may not be in a suitable sector of the occupational sphere, or at a level where his influence is useful'.

However, Goode does not regard the pressures of industrialization as the only reason for the breakdown of extended family ties. He argues that the move to nuclear families has been 'far more rapid than could be supposed or predicted from the degree of industrialization alone'. Goode believes that the ideology of the nuclear family has encouraged its growth, particularly in non-Western societies. This is due partly to the prestige of Western ideas and life styles. Since the nuclear family is found 'in many areas where the rate of industrialization is slight' Goode recognizes 'the independent power of *ideological* variables'. He also argues that the spread of the nuclear family is due in part to the freedom it affords its members. Kenneth Little supports this point in his study of migration from rural kinship based societies to urban industrial centers in West Africa. Many migrants welcomed the freedom from obligations to their kinsmen which they experienced in the towns.

Goode applies the concept of role bargaining to his study of the family. This means that the individual attempts to obtain the best possible 'bargain' in his relationships with others. He will attempt to maximize his gains. In terms of family relationships, this means he will maintain relationships with kin and submit to their control if he feels he is getting a good return on his investment of time, energy and emotion. With respect to the extended family and industrialization, Goode argues

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that, 'It is not so much that the new system is incompatible, as it offers an alternative pattern of payments'. In other words, extended family patterns can operate in industrial society. Although it costs time and money, the rapid transport system in modern society means that 'the individual can maintain an extended kin network if he *wishes* to do so'. However, the 'alternative pattern of payments' offered by industrial society provides a better bargain for many people. They gain more by rejecting close and frequent contacts with kin beyond the nuclear family than by retaining them.

Goode uses the concept of role bargaining to explain social class differences in family structure. From his world survey, Goode finds that extended family patterns are most likely to occur in the upper classes. Since members of ruling class and elites have an important influence on appointments to top jobs, the retention of family ties makes economic sense. In Goode's terms it is an effective role bargain. Lupton and Wilson's study of the kinship connections of 'top decision makers' gives some indication of the importance of family connections in the British upper class. By comparison, members of the lower strata 'have little to offer the younger generation to counteract their normal tendency to independence'. Goode concludes that extended kinship ties are retained if individuals feel they have more to gain than to lose by maintaining them.

Peter Laslett - the family in pre-industrial England

The family in kinship based society and the classic extended family represent only two possible forms of family structure in pre-industrial society. Historical research in Britain and America suggests that neither was typical of those countries in pre-industrial era. Peter Laslett, a Cambridge historian, has studied family size and composition in pre-industrial England. From 1564 to 1821 he found that only about 10% of households contained kin beyond the nuclear family. This percentage is the same as for England in 1966. Evidence from America presents a similar picture. This surprisingly low figure may be due in part to the fact that people in pre-industrial England and America married relatively late in life and life expectancy was short. On average, there were only a few years between the marriage of a couple and the death of their parents. However, Laslett found no evidence to support the formerly accepted view that the classic extended family was widespread in pre-industrial England. He states that, 'There is no sign of the large, extended coresidential family group of the traditional peasant world giving way to the small, nuclear conjugal household of modern industrial society'.

It is now possible to suggest that it was not industrialization that produced the nuclear family but rather the reverse. The nuclear family may have been one of the factors encouraging the development of the industrial

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revolution in England. As the predominant form of family structure, it was pre-adapted to the requirements of industrial society.

Michael Anderson – Household Structure and the Industrial Revolution

Further historical evidence suggests that far from encouraging the formation of nuclear families, the early stages of industrialization in England may well have strengthened kinship ties beyond the nuclear family. Using data from the 1851 census of Preston, Michael Anderson found that some 23% of households contained kin other than the nuclear family, a large increase over Laslett's figures and those for today. The bulk of this 'co-residence' occurred among the poor. Anderson argues that co-residence occurs when the parties involved received net gains from the arrangement.

Preston in 1851 was largely dependent on the cotton industry. Life for many working-class families was characterized by severe hardship resulting from low wages, periods of high unemployment, large families, a high death rate and overcrowded housing. In these circumstances, the maintenance of a large kinship network could be advantageous to all concerned. In the absence of a welfare state, individuals were largely dependent on kin in times of hardship and need. Aging parents often lived with their married children, a situation which benefitted both parties. It provided support for the aged and allowed the mother to work in the factory since grandparents could care for the dependent children. The high death rate led to a large number of orphans, many of whom found a home with relatives. Again the situation benefitted both parties. It provided support for the children who would soon, in a age of child labour, make an important contribution to household income. A high rate of sickness and unemployment encouraged a wide network of kin as a means of mutual support. In the absence of sickness and unemployment benefits, individuals were forced to rely on their kin in times of hardship. Co-residence also provided direct economic advantage to those concerned. Additional members of the household would lower the share of the rent paid by each individual. Finally, the practice of recruiting for jobs through kin encouraged the establishment of a wide kinship network. Anderson notes that the system of "Asking for" a job for kin was normal in the factory towns, and the employers used the kinship system to recruit labour from the country.

Anderson's study of Preston indicates that in the mid nineteenth century, the working-class family functioned as a mutual aid organization. It provided an insurance policy against hardship and crisis. This function encouraged the extension of kinship bonds beyond the nuclear family. Such links would be retained as long as they provided net gains to those involved. **Anderson concludes**

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that the early stages of industrialization increased rather than decreased the extension of the working-class family.

Michael Young and Peter Willmott – four stages of family life

Michael Young and Peter Willmott have been conducting studies of family life in London for over twenty years. In their latest book, ***The Symmetrical family***, they attempt to trace the development of the family from pre-industrial England to the present day. Using a combination of historical research and social surveys – large-scale surveys based on random samples within a particular area – they suggest that the family is moving through four main stages. This section will concentrate on their analysis of the working class family.

Stage 1 is represented by the pre-industrial family. The family is a unit of production, the husband, wife and unmarried children working as a team, typically in agriculture or textiles. This type of family was gradually supplanted by the industrial revolution. However, it continued well into the nineteenth century and is still represented in a small minority of families today.

The Stage 2 family began with the industrial revolution, developed throughout the nineteenth century and reached its peak in the early years of the twentieth. The family ceased to be a unit of production since individual members were employed as wage earners. Throughout the nineteenth century working-class poverty was widespread, wages were low and unemployment high. Like Anderson, Young and Willmott argue that the family responded to this situation by extending its network to include relatives beyond the nuclear family. This provided an insurance policy against the insecurity and hardship of poverty. The extension of the nuclear family was largely conducted by women who 'eventually built up an organization in their own defence and in defence of their children'. The basic tie was between a mother and her married daughter and in comparison, the conjugal bond – the husband-wife relationship – was weak. Women created an 'informal trade union' which largely excluded men. Young and Willmott claim that, 'Husband were often squeezed out of the warmth of the female circle and took to the pub as their defence'. Compared to later stages, the stage 2 family was often headed by a female.

The Stage 2 family began to decline in the early years of the twentieth century but it is still found in many low-income, long established working-class areas. Its survival is documented in Young and Willmott's famous study entitled *Family and Kinship in East London*. The study was conducted in the mid 1950s in **Bethnal Green**, a low-income borough in London's East End. Bethnal Green is a long settled, traditional working-class area. Children usually remain in the same

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locality on marriage. At the time of the research, two out of three married people had parents living within two to three miles of their residence. There was a close tie between female relatives. Over 50% of the married women in the sample had seen their mothers during the previous day, over 80% within the previous week. There was a constant exchange of services such as washing, shopping and babysitting, between female relatives. Young and Willmott argue that in many families, the households of mother and married daughter are 'to some extent merged'. As such they can be termed **extended families** which Young and Willmott define as 'a combination of families who to some degree form one domestic unit'. Although many aspects of the state 2 family were present in Bethnal Green, there were also indications of a transition to Stage 3. For example, fathers were increasingly involved in the rearing of their children.

In the early 1970s, Young and Willmott conducted a large-scale social survey in which 1,928 people were interviewed in Greater London and the outer Metropolitan area. The results formed the basis of their book, *The Symmetrical Family*. Young and Willmott argue that the Stage 2 family has largely disappeared. **For all social classes, but particularly the working class, the Stage 3 family predominates.** This family is characterized by 'the separation of the immediate, or nuclear family from the extended family'. The trade union of women is disbanded and the husband returns to the family circle.

Life for the Stage 3 nuclear family is largely home-centred, particularly when the children are young. Free time is spent doing chores and odd jobs around the house and leisure is mainly 'home-based', for example watching television. The conjugal bond is strong and relationships between husband and wife are increasingly 'companionate'. In the home, 'They shared their work; they shared their time'. The nuclear family has become a largely self-contained, self-reliant unit. **The stage 3 family is very similar to the privatized home-centered affluent worker family described by Goldthorpe and Lockwood and the isolated nuclear family which Talcott Parsons sees as typical of modern industrial society.**

Young and Willmott use the term 'symmetrical family' to describe the nuclear family of Stage 3. Symmetry refers to an arrangement in which the opposite parts are similar in shape and size. With respect to the symmetrical family, conjugal roles, although not the same - wives still have the main responsibility for raising the children, although husbands help – are similar in terms of the contribution made by each spouse to the running of the household. They share many of the chores, they share decisions, they work together, yet there is still men's work and women's work. Conjugal roles are not interchangeable but they are symmetrical in important respects.

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Young and Willmott give the following reasons for the rise of symmetrical family.

1. A number of factors have reduced the need for kinship-based mutual aid groups. They include an increase in the real wages of the male breadwinner, a decrease in unemployment and the male mortality rate, and increased employment opportunities for women. Various provisions of the welfare state such as family allowances, sickness and unemployment benefits and old age pensions have reduced the need for dependence on the kinship network.

2. Increasing geographical mobility has tended to sever kinship ties. In their study of Bethnal Green (London), Young and Willmott showed how the extended kinship network largely ceased to operate when young couples with children moved some 20 miles away to a new council housing estate.

3. The reduction in the number of children, from an average of five or six per family in the nineteenth century to just over two in 1970s, provided greater opportunities for wives to work. This in turn leads to greater symmetry within the family since both spouses are more likely to be wage earners and to share financial responsibility for the household.

4. As living standards rose, the husband was drawn more closely into the family circle since the home was a more attractive place. It became more comfortable with better amenities and a greater range of home entertainments.

To the above points can be added Goldthorpe and Lockwood's conclusions from the affluent worker study. They argue that the privatized nuclear family stems largely from the values placed by the affluent worker on home-centredness and materialism. The major concern of the affluent worker was to raise the living standards of himself and his immediate family, a concern that largely shapes his family structure and domestic life.

Young and Willmott found that the home-centered symmetrical family was more typical of the working class than the middle class. They argue that members of the working class are 'more fully home-centered because they are less fully work-centered'. Partly as compensation for boring and uninvolving work, and partly because relatively little interest and energy are expended at work, manual workers tend to focus their attention on family life. Young and Willmott therefore see the nature of work at a major influence on family life.

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In *The Symmetrical Family*, Young and Willmott devise a general theory which they term the 'Principle of Stratified Diffusion'. They claim that this theory explains much of the change in family life in industrial society. Put simply, the theory states that what the top of the stratification system does today, the bottom will do tomorrow. Life styles, patterns of consumption, attitudes and expectations will diffuse from the top of the stratification system downwards. They argue that industrialization is the 'source of momentum', it provides the opportunities for higher living standards and so on. However, industrialization alone cannot account for the changes in family life. For example it cannot fully explain why the mass of the population has chosen to adopt the life style of Stage 3 families. To complete the explanation, Young and Willmott maintain that the Principal of Stratified Diffusion is required. Industrialization provides the opportunity for a certain degree of choice for the mass of the population. This choice will be largely determined by the behavior of those at the top of the stratification system. Values, attitudes and expectations permeate down the class system; those at the bottom copy those at the top. There are a number of problems with this theory. In particular, it largely ignores the possibility that working-class subculture can direct behaviour. In the Luton study, Goldthorpe and Lockwood argue that behaviour of the affluent worker can be understood in terms of the adaptation of working-class norms and values to a new situation. They reject the view that the affluent worker simply absorbs the norms and values of higher social strata and acts accordingly.

Applying the Principle of Stratified Diffusion to the future, Young and Willmott postulate a possible Stage 4 family. They examine in detail the family life of managing directors, which in terms of their theory, should diffuse downwards in years to come. Managing directors are work-centred rather than home-centred, 'my business is my life' being a typical quote from those in the sample. Their leisure activities are less home-centred and less likely to involve their wives than those of Stage 3 families. Sport was an important area of recreation, particularly swimming and golf. The wife's role was to look after the children and the home. As such the managing director's family was more asymmetrical than the Stage 3 family. Young and Willmott suggest that changes in production technology may provide the opportunity for the Stage 4 family to diffuse throughout the stratification system. As technology reduces routine work, larger numbers of people may have more interesting and involving jobs and become increasingly work-centered. Young and Willmott admit that, 'We cannot claim that our 190 managing directors were representative of managing directors generally'. However, given the evidence available, they predict that the asymmetrical Stage 4 family represents the next major development.

A number of features of Willmott and Young's work are open to criticism. Many feminists have attacked the concept of the 'symmetrical family', arguing that

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there has been little progress towards equality between husband and wife. There is also little evidence that the 'Principle of Stratified Diffusion' has led to the 'Stage 4 family' becoming typical of all strata. Married women have continued to take paid employment and few working-class families can afford to adopt the lifestyle and family arrangements of managing directors. Later research by Peter Willmott also has not used or supported the concept of the 'Stage 4 family'. Further, several studies indicate that changes in production technology have done little, if anything, to increase work involvement for manual workers. For example, Duncan Gallie's study of workers in automated industry, which employs the most advanced form of production technology, shows that the typical attitude towards work was one of indifference.

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The middle-class family

Many of the arguments examined in preceding sections suggest that the middle-class family should be less attached to kin beyond the nuclear unit than its working-class counterpart. Given the nature of the middle class job market, it is more geographically mobile. It is also more financially secure. There is therefore less opportunity and less need to maintain a wide kinship network. However, a number of studies have shown that middle class families maintain close contacts with kin beyond the family. Research conducted in the late 1950s by **Willmott and Young** in **Woodford**, a largely middle-class London suburb, shows that, despite the fact that kin were more geographically dispersed compared to Bethnal Green, fairly regular contacts were maintained. In Bethnal Green 43% of husbands and wives had seen their mothers in the previous twenty-four hours, compared to 30% in Woodford. Although in Woodford there was less frequent contact with parents while the latter were employed, the frequency of contact was much the same as Bethnal Green when parents retired. On retirement, middle-class parents often moved to Woodford to live near their married children.

In their study of **Swansea**, conducted in the early 1960s, **Rosser and Harris** found that levels of contact between parents and married children were similar to those in Bethnal Green. The applied both to middle and working class families. Despite the wider dispersal of kin in Swansea, improved transportation facilities, particularly the family car, made frequent contact possible. Rosser and Harris state that, 'The picture that emerges, then, is of a vigorous kinship grouping wider than the elementary (nuclear) family, similar to the described in the Bethnal Green studies'. As in Bethnal Green, the Swansea families exchanged services with kin beyond the nuclear family and provided each other with support in times of need. Rosser and Harris conclude that, 'In Swansea, a high level of industrialization, social mobility and a wider dispersal of the family has not prevented the maintenance of high levels of contact and the interchange of services between related households'.

Quantity and quality of contacts

A major problem in studies of the family is the difficulty of measuring the importance of kin beyond the nuclear family. In a study of middle-class family life in Swansea, **Colin Bell** questions whether the frequency of actual face-to-face contacts between kin provides an accurate assessment. Bell points to the importance of contact by telephone and mail. He also distinguished between the quantity and quality of contacts. For example, bumping into mum on a street corner in Bethnal Green may have far less significance than a formal visit to mother by her middle-class daughter.

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In his study, Bell found a lower level of direct face-to-face contact with kin beyond the nuclear family than in either the Woodford sample or Rosser and Harris's middle class sample. Despite this relatively low level of contact, he argues that compared with the working class, 'Middle-class kin network may have fewer day-to-day demands but I think that there is little evidence to suggest that they necessarily show any different affective quality'. Thus direct contact may be less frequent but the emotional bonds are the same.

Bell makes a similar point about the provision of services for kin beyond the nuclear family. They may not be as numerous as those provided in the working class, but they may be just as significant. He found that aid from parents, especially the son's father, was particularly important during the early years of marriage. It often took the form of loans or gifts to help with the deposit on a house or the expenses of the first baby. Bell concludes that kin beyond the nuclear family still play an important part in the lives of many middle-class families.

Similar conclusions were reached by **Graham Allan** in research conducted in a commuter village in East Anglia in the early 1970s (Allan, 1985). He found that relationships were characterized by a 'positive concern' for the welfare of the kin regardless of the frequency of face-to-face contacts.

Evidence from America provides a similar picture. Studies from a number of cities in the USA show that for middle and working classes, the degree of contact and the exchange of services with kin beyond the nuclear family is similar to the British pattern.

Contemporary family networks

Peter Willmott – networks in London

As stated earlier, Young and Willmott had suggested that changes in production technology may provide the opportunity for the Stage 4 family to diffuse throughout the stratification system. However, in a later research conducted during the 1980s in a north London suburb, **Peter Willmott found that contacts with kin remained important in both the middle and working class.** In the area he studied, about a third of the couples had moved to the district in the previous five years. Only a third of all the couples had parents or parents-in-law living within ten minutes travelling distance. **However, despite the distance between their homes, two thirds of the couples saw relatives at least weekly.** Working class couples saw relatives more frequently than middle class couples, but the difference were not great. Maintaining contact was relatively easy for most families because so many had access to cars. Most also had homes that were

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sufficiently spacious for relatives to come and stay. Some 90 percent had telephones which enables them to keep in touch with relatives even if they did not meet face-to-face. **Peter Willmott also found that 'relatives continue to be the main source of informal support and care, and that again the class differences are not marked'**. For example, nearly 75 percent had relatives who sometimes helped with babysitting and 80 percent looked to relatives to help them when they needed to borrow money.

Margaret O'Brien and Deborah Jones – families and kinship in East London

Margaret O'Brien and Deborah Jones conducted research in Barking and Dagenham, East London, in the early 1990s. They collected survey data on 600 young people and their parents in this predominantly working-class area. They compared their findings with a 1950s study of the same area conducted by Peter Willmott. They found that, compared with the 1950s, this area had developed **a greater variety of types of family and household**. Of the young people surveyed, 14 percent lived with a step-parent, and 14 percent lived in lone-parent families. According to census statistics, over one-third of births in the area took place outside marriage. There were many dual-earner families, with 62 percent of women in their sample working in paid employment, and 79 percent of men. In Willmott's 1950s study, family life was much more homogeneous. Then, 78 percent of people were married, and just 1 percent were divorced. Most single people were young and lived with their parents.

Despite the move towards a greater plurality of family and household types, O'Brien and Jones did not find that there had been any major erosion in the importance attached to kinship. In both Willmott's and O'Brien and Jones's research, over 40 percent of the sample had grandparents living locally. In the 1990s, 72 percent of those studied had been visited by a relative in the previous week, and over half the sample saw their maternal grandparent at least weekly. Twenty percent had large network of local kin numbering over ten relatives.

O'Brien and Jones conclude that there has been a pluralisation of lifestyles, an increase in marital breakdowns and a big rise in dual-earner households. However, they also found that kin contact and association do not appear to have changed significantly since Willmott's study of the borough in the 1950s. This suggests a greater continuity in kin relationships, at least among the working class in London, than that implied by some other studies.

All the above studies have been based upon specific geographical areas at a particular point in time. However, in 1980s and 1990s, ***British Social Attitude Surveys*** were conducted at national level. The surveys used large representative

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samples of the British population. The results of these surveys have been analysed by Francis McGlone, Alison Park and Kate Smith (1998).

McGlone *et al.* conclude that family members remain the most important source of practical help. While people tend to turn first to a spouse or partner, after that they turn to other relatives, with friends of neighbours being less important. McGlone *et al.* found that 'the majority of the adult population are very family-centred'. The vast majority thought that parents should continue to help children after they had left home, and around 70 percent thought that people should keep in touch with close family members. A majority thought that you should try to keep in touch with relatives like aunts, uncles and cousins, even if you did not have much in common with them.

McGlone *et al.* found that families remain very important to people in contemporary Britain. They argue that their study confirms the results of earlier research showing that families remain an important source of help and support, and that family contacts are still maintained even though family members tend to live further apart. Their research suggests that the 'core' of the family does not just include parents and children - in most households grandparents are part of the core as well. They also found that differences between social classes remained significant, with the working class still more likely to have frequent contacts than the middle class. **Despite all the social changes affecting families between 1986 and 1995, kinship networks beyond the nuclear family remain important to people.**

Similarly **Janet Finch** too argues that although the circumstances in which family relationships are made have changes enormously since pre-industrial times, there is no evidence that in general there is less sense of obligation to kin than there was in the past.

The isolated nuclear family?

The evidence so far presented under the heading of 'The family and industrialization' provides a somewhat confusing picture. On the one hand there is Talcott Parson's isolated nuclear family, on the other a large body of evidence suggesting that kin beyond the nuclear family play an important part in family life. To make matters more confusing, Young and Willmott do not provide sufficient data to allow an assessment of the importance of kin to the Stage 3 family. In America a number of researchers have rejected Parson's concept of the isolated nuclear family. For example, Sussman and Burchinal argue that the weight of evidence from a large body of research indicates that the modern American family

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is far from isolated. They maintain that the family can only be properly understood 'by rejection of the isolated nuclear family concept'.

Parsons replied to his critics in an article entitled *The Normal American Family*. He argues that close relationship with kin outside the nuclear family are in no way inconsistent with the concept of the isolated nuclear family. Parsons states that 'the very psychological importance for the individual of the nuclear family in which he was born and brought up would make any such conception impossible'. However, he maintains that the nuclear family is structurally isolated. It is isolated from other parts of the social structure such as the economic system. For example, it does not form an integral part of the economic system as in the case of the peasant farming family in traditional Ireland. In addition, the so-called 'extended families' of modern industrial society 'do not form firmly structured units of the social system'. Relationships with kin beyond the nuclear family are not obligatory; they are a matter of individual choice. In this sense, 'extended kin constitute a resource which may be selectively taken advantage of within considerable limits'. Thus extended families do not form 'firmly structured units' as in the case of the classic extended family or the family in kinship based societies. **Evidence from Rosser and Harris's Swansea research supports Parson's arguments**. Rosser and Harris maintain that the nuclear family is 'a basic structural unit of the society' and though kinship relationships beyond the nuclear family are important to individuals, in terms of the social structure as a whole they are 'not of major and critical importance'. The Swansea study revealed a 'vast variation' in kinship relationships. Members of some families were in daily contact with kin beyond the nuclear family, members of other families rarely saw their relatives. This is the expected finding in view of Parson's emphasis upon individual choice. It supports his claim that extended families are not 'firmly structured units of the social system'.

The 'modified extended family'

In order to clear up the confusion surrounding the term 'isolated nuclear family', **Eugene Litwak** argues that a new term, the '**modified extended family**' should be introduced to describe the typical family in modern industrial society. Litwak defines the modified extended family as **'a coalition of nuclear families in a state of partial dependence. Such partial dependence means that nuclear family members exchange significant services with each other, thus differing from the isolated nuclear family, as well as retain considerable autonomy (that is not bound economically or geographically) therefore differing from the classical extended family'**.

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The 'modified elementary family'

Graham Allan accepts Litwak's view that kin outside the nuclear family continue to be important in industrial society. On the basis of this own research in a commuter village in East Anglia, he argues that in normal circumstances non-nuclear kin do not rely on each other. In many families there may be little exchange of significant services most of the time. However, in most families the members do feel an obligation to keep in touch. For example, very few married children break off relationships with their parents altogether, and brothers and sisters usually maintain contact. Although significant services are not usually exchanged as a matter of course, kin frequently recognize an obligation to help each other in times of difficulty or crisis.

Unlike Litwak, Allan believes that these kinds of relationships are confined to an inner or 'elementary' family, consisting of wives and husbands, their parents, children, brothers and sisters. The obligations do not extend to uncles, aunts, nephews, nieces, cousins or more distant kin. Allan therefore prefers the term **modified elementary family** to 'modified extended family', since to him it more accurately describes the range of kin who are important to an individual.

The 'dispersed extended family'

On the basis of research carried out in London in the 1980s, **Peter Willmott** reached broadly similar conclusions to Litwak and Allan. He claims that the **dispersed extended family** is becoming dominant in Britain. It consists of two or more related families who cooperate with each other even though they live some distance apart. Contacts are fairly frequent, taking place on average perhaps once a week, but less frequent than they were amongst extended families who lived close together. Cars, public transport and telephones make it possible for dispersed extended families to keep in touch. Members of dispersed extended families do not rely on each other on a day-to-day basis.

Like Litwak, Willmott sees each nuclear family unit as only partially dependent upon extended kin. Much of the time the nuclear family is fairly self-sufficient but in times of emergency the existence of extended kin might prove invaluable. Thus Willmott argues that, in modern Britain, 'although kinship is largely chosen, it not only survives but most of the time flourishes'.

The research discussed by **McGlone *et al.*** reaches broadly similar conclusions. Kinship networks outside the nuclear family are still important. Indeed they argue that the core families with dependent children include not just the nuclear family but also grandparents. Despite all the social changes that could

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have weakened kinship, people still value kinship ties and for the most part try to retain them even when they live some distance from their relatives. In this section we have focused on the changes in household composition and kinship networks that have accompanied industrialization in Britain. We will now examine the extent to which the idea of a 'typical family' is accurate.

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Family diversity

Although some historians such as Michael Anderson have pointed to a variety of household types in pre-industrial times and during industrialization, it has generally been assumed that a single type of family is dominant in any particular era. Whether the modern family is regarded as nuclear, modified extended, modified elementary or dispersed extended, the assumption has been that this type of family is central to people's experiences in modern industrial societies. **However, recent research has suggested that such societies are characterized by a plurality of household and family types, and that the idea of a typical family is misleading.**

The 'cereal packet image' of the family

Ann Oakley (1982) has described the image of the typical or 'conventional' family. She says, 'conventional families are nuclear families composed of legally married couples, voluntarily choosing the parenthood of one or more (but not too many) children'.

Leach called this the 'cereal packet image of the family'. The image of the happily married couple with two children is prominent in advertising, and the 'family-sized' packets of cereals and their types of product are aimed at just this type of grouping. It tends also to be taken for granted that this type of family has its material needs met by the male breadwinner, while the wife has a predominantly domestic role.

The monolithic image of the family

The American feminist **Barrie Thorne** has attacked the image of the 'monolithic family'. She argues that 'Feminists have challenged the ideology of "the monolithic family", which has elevated the nuclear family with a breadwinner husband and a full-time wife and mother as the only legitimate family form'. She argues that the focus on the family unit neglects structures of society that lead to variations in families. She says, 'Structures of gender, generation, race and class result in widely varying experiences of family life, which are obscured by the glorification of the nuclear family, motherhood, and the family as a loving refuge'. The idea of 'The Family' involves 'falsifying the actual variety of household forms'. In fact, according to Thorne, 'Households have always varied in composition, even in the 1950s and early 1960s when the ideology of The Family was at its peak'. By the 1990s, such an ideology was more obviously inappropriate since changes in society had resulted in ever more diverse family forms.

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Households in Britain

The view that such images equate with reality has been attacked by **Robert** and **Rhona Rapoport** (1982). They drew attention to the fact that in 1978, for example, just 20 percent of families consisted of married couples with children in which there was a single breadwinner. Rapoports found that there has been a steady decline in the proportion of households in Great Britain consisting of married couples, with dependent children, from 38 percent in 1961 to just 23 percent in 1998. There has been a corresponding increase in single-person households in the same period, with the proportion of households of this type rising from 11 percent in 1961 to 28 percent in 1998. Furthermore, the proportion of households that were single-parent households with dependent children more than tripled, from 2 percent in 1961 to 7 percent in 1998. The total number of lone-parent households rose from 6 percent to 10 percent over the same period. Single-parent families are discussed in more detail later.

Types of diversity

The fact that the 'conventional family' no longer makes up a majority of households or families is only one aspect of diversity identified by the **Rapoports**. In their survey, they found a variety of family forms that are emerging in Britain. The findings of their survey have been summarized below:

- that there has been a steady decline in the proportion of 'conventional families' consisting of married heterosexual couples and their dependent children.
- that there is a rising trend towards 'organizational diversity'. By this, they mean there are variations in family structure, household type, patterns of kinship network, and differences in the division of labour within home. For example, there are the differences between conventional families, one-parent families, and dual-worker families, in which husband and wife both work.
- that there are also increasing numbers of 'reconstituted families'. These families are formed after divorce and remarriage. This situation can lead to a variety of family forms. The children from the previous marriages of the new spouses may live together in the newly reconstituted family, or they may live with the original spouses of the new couple.
- that the variety of family forms is also influenced by 'cultural diversity'. There are differences in the lifestyles of families of different ethnic origins

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and different religious beliefs. Differences in lifestyle between Catholic and Protestant families may also be an important element of diversity.

- that there are differences between middle- and working-class families in terms of relationships between adults and the way in which children are socialized.
- that the variety of family forms is also influenced by 'regional diversity'. For example, in what they term 'the sun belt' (the affluent southern parts of England) Rapoports found two-parent upwardly mobile families are typical. On the other hand, in rural regions, the family-based farm tends to produce strong kinship networks.
- that there is an increasing trend towards cohabitation without marriage (live-in relationships).
- that 'gay and lesbian households' have become more common. Many sociologists believe that such households, where they incorporate long-term gay or lesbian relationships, should be seen as constituting families.

New reproductive technologies

New reproductive technologies have added an entirely new dimension to family diversity. It was not until 1978 that the first 'test-tube baby', Louise Brown, was born. The process is called *in vitro* fertilization and involves fertilizing an egg with a sperm in a test-tube, before implanting in a women's womb. The woman may or may not be the woman who produced the egg.

Surrogate motherhood involves one woman carrying a foetus produced by the egg of another woman. This raises question about who the parents of a child are, and questions about what constitutes a family. Calhoun sees this as undermining the centrality of the reproductive couple as the core of the family, and it introduces a greater range of choices into families than was previously available. John Macionis and Ken Plummer show how new reproductive technologies can create previously impossible sets of family relationships. They quote the case of Arlette Schweitzer, who in 1991 gave birth in South Dakota in the USA to her own grandchild. Her daughter was unable to carry a baby and Arlette Schweitzer acted as a surrogate mother. She gave birth to twins, a boy and a girl. Macionis and Plummer ask, 'is Arlette Schweitzer the mother of the twins she bore? Grandmother? Both?' Such examples, they say, 'force us to consider the adequacy of conventional kinship terms'. They note that such technologies have largely been

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made available to heterosexual couples of normal child-rearing age, but they have also been used by lesbian, homosexual, and single and older women. The implication of new reproductive technologies is that biology will no longer restrict the possibilities for forming or enlarging families by having children. They therefore add considerably to the range of potential family types and thus contribute to growing diversity.

A global trend

According to Rhona Rapoport, the decline of conventional family forms and the increasing diversity are part of a global trend. She quotes figures showing movement toward diverse family structure in very different European countries. In Finland, the percentage of household consisting of a nuclear family declined from 63.8 per cent in 1950 to 60 per cent in 1980. In Sweden, the decline was from 52.4 per cent in 1960 to 42.6 percent in 1980, in East Germany from 56.7per cent in 1957 to 48.7 per cent in 1977. She also points to an enormous increase throughout Europe in the proportion of married women who have paid employment, which suggests that men's and women's roles within marriage are changing and consequently new family forms are developing. These conclusions are broadly shared by a study of diversity in Europe.

Diversity and European family life

At the end of the 1980s the European Co-ordination Centre for Research and Documentation in Social Sciences organized a cross-cultural study of family life in 14 European nations (Boh, 1989). These were Belgium, Finland, France, the German Democratic Republic and Federal Republic of Germany (the study was carried out before re-unification), Great Britain, Hungary, Italy, the Netherlands, Norway, Poland, Sweden, and the then Soviet Union and Yugoslavia.

The findings of individual national studies were analysed and compared by **Katja Boh**. She tried to 'trace the tendencies in changes of family patterns' and found that although most of the evidence showed that family life was very different in different European countries, some evidence did point to certain trends being widespread. All European countries had experienced rising divorce rates and many had made it easier to get divorced. Cohabitation appeared to have become more common in most countries, and the birth rate had declined everywhere.

Further, Boh argues that the existence of diverse patterns of family life in Europe, but with some common trends, seems at first sight to be contradictory. However, together, they produce a consistent pattern of **convergence in diversity**. While family life retains considerable variations from country to country,

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throughout Europe a greater range of family types is being accepted as legitimate and normal. This has been caused by increasing gender symmetry in work patterns, more freedom in conjugal choice and a more hedonistic view of marriage and love, premarital and experimental sexuality, higher marriage instability and alternative forms of 'living together', decreasing fertility and change in forms of parenting.

Boh concludes that whatever the existing patterns are, they are characterized by the acceptance of diversity that has given men and women the possibility to choose inside the boundaries of available options the life pattern that is best adapted to their own needs and aspirations (Boh, 1989).

The increase in single parenthood

As mentioned earlier, single-parent families have become increasingly common in Britain. According to government statistics, in1961, 2 percent of the population lived in households consisting of a lone parent with dependent children, but by 1998 this had more than tripled to 7 per cent. Between 1972 and 1997 the percentage of children living in single-parent families increased from 7 per cent to 19 per cent. According to Hantrais and Letablier (1996), Britain has the second highest rate of lone parenthood in Europe. It is exceeded only by Denmark, and rates in countries such as Greece, Portugal and France are much lower than those in Britain. Nevertheless, throughout Europe and in advanced industrial countries such as Japan and the USA, the proportions have generally been increasing since at least the 1980s. Further, as per the *General Household Survey* (1996) it was found that only 1 percent of the family households were headed by lone fathers, compared to 18 percent that were headed by lone mothers.

Clearly, then, the rise in lone motherhood is closely related both to increase in the divorce rate and to an increase in births outside marriage. The causes of the rise in divorces are discussed later. The increase in single lone mothers may partly result from a reduction in the number of 'shotgun weddings' – that is, getting married to legitimate a pregnancy. Mark Brown suggests that in previous eras it was more common for parents to get married, rather than simply cohabiting, if they discovered that the woman was pregnant. Marriages that resulted from pregnancy were often unstable and could end up producing lone motherhood through an eventual divorce or separation. Now, the partners may choose to cohabit rather than marry and, if their relationship breaks up, they end up appearing in the statistics as a single, never-married, parent.

Some writers see the rise of single parenthood as a symptom of increased tolerance of diverse family forms. For example, the Rapoports claim that the single-parent family is an important 'emerging form' of the family which is

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becoming accepted as a legitimate alternative to other family structures.

However, there is little evidence that a large number of single-parents see their situation as ideal and actively choose it as an alternative to dual parenthood. Burghes and Brown conducted research into 31 lone mothers and found that only a minority of the pregnancies were planned. None of the mothers had actively set out to become lone mothers and all of them attributed the break-up of their relationship to 'violence in the relationship or the father's unwillingness to settle down'. In this small sample, all aspired to forming a two-parent households, but they had failed to achieve it despite their preference.

David Morgan (1994) suggests that the rise in lone parenthood could partly be due to changing relationships between men and women. He says important factors causing the rise could include 'the expectations that women and men have of marriage and the growing opportunities for women to develop a life for themselves outside marriage or long-term cohabitations'.

A longer-term trend that helps to account for the increase could be a decline in the stigma attached to single parenthood. This is reflected in the decreasing use of terms such as 'illegitimate children' and 'unmarried mothers', which seems to imply some deviation from the norms of family life, and their replacement by concepts such as 'single-parent families' and 'lone-parent families', which do not carry such negative connotations. The reduction in the stigma of single parenthood could relate to 'the weakening of religious or community controls over women' (Morgan, 1994).

The consequences of single parenthood

Single parenthood has increasingly become a contentious issue, with some arguing that it has become a serious problem for society. For example, in a letter to *The Times* in 1985, Lady Scott said:

"A vast majority of the population would still agree, I think, that the normal family is an influence for good in society and that one-parent families are bad news. Since not many single parents can both earn a living and give children the love and care they need, society has to support them; the children suffer through lacking one parent."

Sociologists such as Charles Murray have even gone so far as to claim that single parenthood has contributed to creating a whole new stratum of society, the underclass. Mary McIntosh says that 'over recent years, the media in the United Kingdom have been reflecting a concern about lone mothers that amounts to a

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moral panic'. She claim that, as a group, lone mothers have been stigmatized and blamed for problems such as youth crime, high taxation to pay for welfare benefits, encouraging a culture of dependency on the state, and producing children who grow up to be unemployable. She says, 'perhaps the most serious charge is that they are ineffective in bringing up their children'.

However, while most commentators agree that single parenthood can create problems for individual parent, many sociologists do not see it as social problem, and some believe that it is a sign of social progress. As Sarah McLanahan and Karen Booth have said:

"Some view the mother-only family as an indicator of social disorganization, signaling the 'demise of the family'. Others regard it as an alternative family form consistent with the emerging economic independence of women".

Single parenthood and living standards

Single parenthood tends to be associated with low living standards. The *General Household Survey* of 1996 found that single-parent families were disadvantaged in comparison to other British families.

More controversial than the low average living standards of lone parents is the question of the psychological and social effects on children raised in such families. McLanahan and Booth have listed the findings of a number of American studies which seem to indicate that children are harmed by single-parenthood. These studies have claimed that such children have lower earnings and experience more poverty as adults; children of mother-only families are more likely to become lone parents themselves; and they are more likely to become delinquent and engage in drug abuse.

The findings of such studies must be treated with caution. As McLanahan and Booth themselves point out, the differences outlined above stem partly from the low income of lone-parent families and not directly from the absence of the second parent from the household.

In a review of research on lone parenthood, Louie Burghes notes that some research into the relationship between educational attainment and divorce suggests that children in families where the parents divorce start to do more poorly in education before the divorce takes place. Burghes argues that this implies that 'it is the quality of the family relationships, of which the divorce is only a part, that are influential' (Burghes, 1996).

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The more sophisticated research into the effects of lone parenthood tries to take account of factors such as social class and low income. These studies find that 'the gap in outcomes between children who have and have not experienced family change narrows. In some cases they disappear; in others, statistically significant differences may remain. Some of these differences are small'.

E.E Cashmore has questioned the assumption that children brought up by one parent are worse off than those brought up by two. Cashmore argue that it is often preferable for a child to live with one caring parent than with one caring and one uncaring parent, particularly if the parents are constantly quarrelling and the marriage has all but broken down.

Cashmore also suggests that single parenthood can have attractions for the parent, particularly for mothers, since conventional family life may benefit men more than women. He says:

Given the 'darker side of family life' and the unseen ways in which the nuclear unit serves 'male power' rather than the interests of women, the idea of parents breaking free of marriage and raising children single-handed has its appeals.

It can give women greater independence than they have in other family situations. However, Cashmore does acknowledge that many lone mothers who are freed from dependence on a male partner end up becoming dependent on the state and facing financial hardship. He concludes that 'Lone parents do not need a partner so much as a partner's income'.

David Morgan does believe that the evidence suggests that the children of single parents fare less well than those from two-parent households. He qualifies this by saying that 'we still do not know enough about what causes these differences'. As with the effects of financial hardship, the children could be affected by the stigma attached to coming from a single-parent family. Morgan argues that 'it is possible, for example, that school teacher may be more likely to label a child as difficult if they have the knowledge that a particular child comes from a single-parent household'. For Morgan, it is very difficult to disentangle the direct and indirect effects on children of being brought up in a single-parent household, and therefore dangerous to make generalizations about such effects.

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Ethnicity and family diversity

Ethnicity can be seen as one of the most important sources of family diversity in Britain. Ethnic groups with different cultural backgrounds may introduce family forms that differ significantly from those of the ethnic majority. Statistical evidence does suggest that there are some differences in the prevalence of different household types in different ethnic groups.

The general picture, provided by various empirical studies, suggests that immigrants and their descendants have adapted their family life to fit British circumstances, but have not fundamentally altered the relationships on which their traditional family life was based. This would suggest that the existence of a variety of ethnic groups has indeed contributed to the diversity of family types to be found in Britain. These ethnic minorities have succeeded in retaining many of the culturally distinctive features of their family life.

Nevertheless, there is also evidence of changes taking place in the families of ethnic minorities, and British culture may have more effect on future generations. Each ethnic group contains a variety of different family types, which are influenced by factors such as class and stage in the life cycle, which relate to diversity in white families. Thus ethnic minorities families have not just contributed to family diversity through each group having its own distinctive family pattern, they have also contributed to it through developing diverse family patterns within each ethnic group.

Robert Chester – the British neo-conventional family

In a strong attack upon the idea that fundamental changes are taking place in British family life, Robert Chester (1985) argued that the changes had been only minor. He claimed that the evidence advanced by writers such as the Rapoports was misleading, and that the basic features of family life had remained largely unchanged for the vast majority of the British population since the Second World War. He argued:

Most adults still marry and have children.
Most children are reared by their natural parents.
Most people live in a household headed by a married couple.
Most marriages continue until parted by death.
No great change seems currently in prospect.

Chester, 1985

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Percentage of people versus percentage of households

Chester believed that a snapshot of household types at a particular time does not provide a valid picture of the British family. The first point that Chester made is that a very different picture is produced if the percentage of people in various types of households is calculated, instead of the percentage of households of various types. Households containing parents and children contain greater percentage of the population than the percentage of households they make up. This is because family households tend to have more members than other types of household.

Chester's arguments were based upon figures from 1981. It was noted that the way the figures are calculated does make a difference. In 1981, 40 per cent of households were made up of two parents and children, but over 59 per cent of people lived in such households. In 1998, 30 per cent of households consisted of two parents plus children, but 49 per cent of people lived in such households. Despite the decline, very nearly half were still living in nuclear, two-generation households, with a further 24 per cent living in couple households.

The nuclear family and the life cycle

The second point made by Chester was that life cycles make it inevitable that at any one time some people will not be a member of a nuclear family household. Many of those who lived in other types of household would either have experienced living in a nuclear family in the past, or would do so in the future. He said, 'The 8 per cent living alone are mostly the elderly widowed, or else younger people who are likely to marry'. He described the parents-children household as 'one which is normal and still experienced by the vast majority'.

The 'neo-conventional family'

According to Chester, there was little evidence that people were choosing to live on a long-term basis in alternatives to the nuclear family. However, he did accept that some changes were taking place in family life. In particular, many families were no longer 'conventional' in the sense that the husband is the sole breadwinner. He accepted that women were increasingly making a contribution to household finances by taking paid employment outside the home.

However, he argued that, although 58 per cent of wives, according to his figures, worked, often they only did so for part of their married lives, and frequently on a part-time basis. Many gave up work for the period when their children were young; a minority of married mothers (49 per cent) were employed,

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and only 14 per cent of working married mothers had full-time jobs. Because of such figures he argued that 'The pattern is of married women withdrawing from the labour force to become mothers, and some of them taking (mostly part-time) work as their children mature.'

Although he recognized that this was an important change in family life compared to the past, he did not see it as a fundamental alteration in the family. He called this new family form – in which wives have some involvement in the labour market – the neo-conventional family. It was little different from the conventional family apart from the increasing numbers of wives working for at least part of their married lives.

Family diversity – conclusion

While Chester makes an important point in stressing that nuclear families remained very common and feature in most people's lives, he perhaps overstated his case. Empirical evidence suggests that there has been a continuing reduction in the proportion of people living in parents-and-children households, from 59 per cent in 1981 to 49 per cent in 1998. The percentages of people living alone or in lone-parent households have increased. Thus, since Chester was writing, there has been a slow but steady drift away from living in nuclear families in Britain.

In 1990, the position was summed up by Kathleen Kiernan and Malcolm Wicks who said that 'Although still the most prominent form, the nuclear family is for increasing numbers of individuals only one of several possible family types that they experience during their lives'. Similarly, in 1999, Elizabeth Silva and Carol Smart argue that fairly traditional family forms remain important. They note that:

> *in 1996, 73 per cent of households were composed of heterosexual couples (with just under 90 per cent of these being married), 50 per cent of these households had children, and 40 per cent had dependent children….*
> *only 9 per cent of households with dependent children were headed by lone parents.*
>
> Silva and Smart, 1999

Nevertheless, they argue that 'personal choices appear as increasingly autonomous and fluid'. The idea that family diversity indicates a new era of choice was first advanced by Rapoports in 1982. They argued that it was increasingly acceptable to form alternative households and families to conventional nuclear ones. They said:

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Families in Britain today are in a transition from coping in a society in which there was a single overriding norm of what family life should be like to a society in which a plurality of norms are recognized as legitimate, indeed, desirable.

Rapoport and Rapoport, 1982

The passage of time does not seem to have made their argument less valid. Indeed, a growing number of sociologists have tried to link ideas of choice and diversity with their particular views on modernity and postmodernity. These views will be examined later.

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The changing functions of the family

Many sociologists argue that the family has lost a numbers of its functions in modern industrial society. Institutions such as businesses, political parties, schools, and welfare organizations now specialize in functions formerly performed by the family. Talcott Parsons argued that the family has become:

> *on the 'macroscopic' levels, almost completely functionless. It does not itself, except here and there, engage in much economic production; it is not a significant unit in the political power system; it is not a major direct agency of integration of the larger society. Its individual members participate in all these functions, but they do so as individuals, not in their roles as family members.*
>
> Parsons, 1955

However, this does not mean that the family is declining in importance – it has simply become more specialized. Parsons maintained that its role is still vital. By structuring the personalities of the young and stabilizing the personalities of adults, the family provides its members with the psychological training and support necessary to meet the requirements of the social system. Parsons concluded that, 'the family is more specialized than before, but not in any general sense less important, because society is dependent more exclusively on it for the performance of certain of its vital functions' . Thus the loss of certain functions by the family has made its remaining functions more important.

This view is supported by N. Dennis (1975) who argues that impersonal bureaucratic agencies have taken over many of the family's functions. As a result, the warmth and close supportive relationships which existed when the family performed a large range of functions have largely disappeared. Dennis argues that in the impersonal setting of modern industrial society, the family provides the only opportunity 'to participate in a relationship where people are perceived and valued as whole persons'. Outside the family, individuals must often interact with strangers in terms of a number of roles. Adopting roles such as employee, customer, teacher and student, they are unable to express many aspects of themselves or develop deep and supportive relationships. Dennis argues that:

> *'marriage has become the only institution in which the individual can expect esteem and love. Adults have no one on whom they have the right to lean for this sort of support at all comparable with their right to lean on their spouse'.*

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Young and Willmott (1973) make a similar point arguing that the emotional support provided by family relationships grows in importance as the family loses many of its functions. They claim that the family:

> *can provide some sense of wholeness and permanence*
> *to set against the more restricted and transitory roles*
> *imposed by the specialized institutions which have flourished*
> *outside the home. The upshot is that, as the disadvantages of the new*
> *industrial and impersonal societies have become more pronounced,*
> *so the family has become more prized for its power to counteract them.*

The maintenance and improvement of functions

Not all sociologists would agree, however, that the family has lost many of its functions in modern industrial society. Ronald Fletcher, a British sociologist and a staunch supporter of the family, maintained that just the opposite has happened. In *The Family and Marriage in Britain* (1966), Fletcher argued that not only has the family retained its functions but those functions have 'increased in detail and importance'. Specialized institutions such as schools and hospitals have added to and improved the family's functions, rather than superseded them.

1. Fletcher maintained that the family's responsibility for socializing the young is as important as it ever was. State education has added to, rather than removed, this responsibility since 'Parents are expected to do their best to guide, encourage and support their children in their educational and occupational choices and careers'.

2. In the same way, the state has not removed the family's responsibility for the physical welfare of its members. Fletchers argued that, 'The family is still centrally concerned with maintaining the health of its members, but it is now aided by wider provisions which have been added to the family's situation since pre-industrial times'.

   Rather than removing this function from the family, state provision of health services has served to expand and improve it. Compared to the past, parents are preoccupied with their children's health. State health and welfare provision has provided additional support for the family and made its members more aware of the importance of health and hygiene in the home.

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3. Even though Fletcher admitted that the family has largely lost its function as a unit of production, he argues that it still maintains a vital economic function as a unit of consumption. Particularly in the case of the modern home-centered family, money is spent on, and in the name of, the family rather than the individual. Thus the modern family demands fitted carpets, three-piece suits, washing machines, television sets and 'family' cars.

   Young and Willmott make a similar point with respect to their symmetrical Stage 3 family. They argue that, 'In its capacity as a consumer the family has also made a crucial alliance with technology'. Industry needs both a market for its goods and a motivated workforce. The symmetrical family provides both. Workers are motivated to work by their desire for consumer durables. This desire stems from the high value they place on the family and a privatized lifestyle in the family home. This provides a ready market for the products of industry.

   In this way the family performs an important economic function and is functionally related to the economic system. In Young and Willmott's words, 'The family and technology have achieved a mutual adaptation'.

Neo-Marxist views

This economic function looks rather different from a neo-Marxist perspective. Writers such as Marcuse (1972) and Gorz (1965) argue that alienation at work leads to a search for fulfillment outside work. However, the capitalist controlled mass media, with its advertisements that proclaim the virtues of family life and associate the products of industry with those virtues, simply creates 'false needs'. With pictures of the 'Persil mum' and the happy family in the midst of its consumer durables, the myth that material possessions bring happiness and fulfillment is promoted. This myth produces the obedient, motivated worker and the receptive consumer that capitalism requires. The family man or woman is therefore ideal material for exploitation.

Feminism and economic functions

Feminist writers have tended to disagree with the view shared by many sociologists of the family that the family has lost its economic role as a unit of production and has become simply a unit of consumption. They tend to argue that much of the work that takes place in the family is productive but it is not recognized as such because it is unpaid and it is usually done by women. The contribution to economic life made by women is frequently underestimated.

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The radical feminists Christine Delphy and Diana Leonard (1992) accept that industrialization created new units of production such as factories, but deny that it removed the productive function from the family. Some productive functions have been lost, but others are performed to a much higher standard than in the past. They cite as examples 'warm and tidy rooms with attention to décor, and more complex meals with a variety of forms of cooking'. The family has taken on some new productive functions, such as giving pre-school reading tuition to children, and functions such as washing clothes and freezing food have been reintroduced to the household with the advent of new consumer products. They also point out that there are still a fair number of families which continue to act as an economic unit producing goods for the market. French farming families, which have been studied by Christine Delphy, are a case in point.

Summary and conclusions

In summary, most sociologists who adopt a functionalist perspective argue that the family has lost several of its functions in modern industrial society but they maintain that the importance of the family has not declined. Rather, the family has adapted and is adapting to a developing industrial society. It remains a vital and basic institution in society.

Others dispute the claim that some of these functions have been lost, or argue that new functions have replaced the old ones. From all these viewpoints the family remains a key institution.

All the writers examined here have a tendency to think in terms of 'the family' without differentiating between different types of family. They may not, therefore, appreciate the range of effects family life can have or the range of functions it may perform. Postmodernists and difference feminists certainly reject the view that there is any single type of family which always performs certain functions.

The writers discussed also tend to assume that families reproduce the existing social structure, whether this is seen as a functioning mechanism, an exploitative capitalist system, or as a patriarchal society. Yet families are not necessarily supportive of or instrumental in reproducing existing societies. With increasing family diversity, some individual families and even some types of family may be radical forces in society. For example, gay and lesbian families sometimes see themselves as challenging the inegalitarian relationships in heterosexual families.

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Ghurye's views on Tribe:

Ghurye's works on the tribes were general as well as specific. He wrote a general book on scheduled tribes in which he dealt with the historical, administrative and social dimensions of Indian tribes. He also wrote on specific tribes such as the Kolis in Maharashtra. Ghurye presented his thesis on tribes at a time when a majority of the established anthropologists and administrators were of the opinion that the separate identity of the tribes is to be maintained at any cost.
The background to this was the scheduling of tribes by the colonial administrators and the debate that ensued between government anthropologists, who favoured a protectionist policy, and nationalists who viewed the creation of 'Excluded' and 'Partially Excluded' areas as yet another attempt to 'divide and rule'.

There had been fierce debate between G.S. Ghurye and Verrier Elwin. Elwin in his book *Loss of Nerve* said that tribes should be allowed to live in isolation, whereas Ghurye argued that tribals should be assimilated into Hindu castes. Ghurye believed that most of the tribes have been Hinduized after a long period of contact with Hindus. He holds that it is futile to search for the separate identity of the tribes. They are nothing but the 'backward caste Hindus'. Their backwardness was due to their imperfect integration into Hindu society. The Santhals, Bhils, Gonds, etc., who live in South-Central India are its example. In 1943 Ghurye published *The Aboriginals, So-called and their Future* (republished as *The Scheduled Tribes* [1959]), in which he attacked Elwin for his advocacy of the preservation of the 'tribal way of life' through state-enforced isolation from Hindu society.

Elwin's writings on the Indian tribes, like Ghurye's on Hindu society, reproduced the Aryan invasion theory, but his interpretation was geared to a different conclusion. Contemporary tribals are the descendants of the indigenous inhabitants of India, those who were not overcome by the Aryan invaders. The 'tribes' were marginalized and pushed into inaccessible forested and hilly tracts and therefore remained culturally distinct from Hindus. Elwin believed that contact with Hindu 'civilisation' invariably led to the exploitation of tribals and loss of their culture, hence the need for protection.

This argument was challenged by Ghurye, who pointed to the complex history of migrations on the subcontinent as well as the close relations and cultural similarities between various tribal groups and their Hindu neighbours. He hotly contested the tribe/caste distinction itself and the view of tribes as culturally separate from Hindu society, preferring to designate them as "imperfectly integrated classes of Hindu society" or "Backward Hindus" rather than aborigines. For him, the cause of the tribals' immiseration was not contact with civilisation but

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the economic and legal changes ushered in by British colonial rule. He argued that tribals faced the same problems as caste Hindu cultivators: rapacious moneylenders, ignorance, short-sighted government policies and inefficient legal machinery together produced the typical pattern found in tribal areas of exploitation, land alienation, and bonded labour. The solution to this problem lay in "... strengthening the ties of the tribals with the other backward classes through their integration," not in separatism or isolation. Against Elwin's plea for preservation of tribal culture, Ghurye maintained that the interests and welfare of the tribals would be better served by adaptation to the wider society, for example by giving up 'wasteful' shifting cultivation in favour of settled agriculture. Ghurye suggests that the economic motivation behind the adoption of Hinduism was very strong among the tribes. They could come out of the narrow confines of their tribal crafts of a rudimentary nature and adopt specialized types of occupation, which were in demand in society. Ghurye also argued that the administrative separation of tribal areas was motivated by imperial economic interests rather than any concern for the welfare of the people. He refers here to the exploitation of forests, opening of coal fields in 'tribal' areas, and recruitment of tribal labour for tea plantations and mines.

Ghurye also argued against Elwin's proposal to codify tribal customs in civil matters on the ground that this would simply 'fossilize' them. Ghurye pointed out that "customs ... are plastic, and thus have an advantage over law which is rigid. Once we codify them we make them more rigid than law ... After the customs are codified, whatever little authority the tribal elders may have in their interpretation today will cease."

Ghurye also criticized Elwin's opposition to social reform movements among tribals. He believed that there were certain 'customs' such as drinking and sexual permissiveness that needed to be eradicated. Under Hindu influence, the tribes gave up liquor drinking, received education and improved their agriculture. In this context, Hindu voluntary organizations, such as Ramakrishna Mission and Arya Samraj, played a constructive role for the development of the tribes. Ghurye presents a huge data on the thoughts, practices and habits of the tribes inhabiting the Central Indian region. He quotes extensively from various writings and reports to show that Katauris, Bhuiyas, Oraons, Khonds, Gonds, Korkus etc. have substantially adopted Hinduism as their religion. Ghurye considers the incorporation of Hindu values and norms into tribal life was a positive step in the process of development. The tribes in India had slowly absorbed certain Hindu values and style of life through contact with the Hindu social groups. Today, it is being considered a part of Hindu society.

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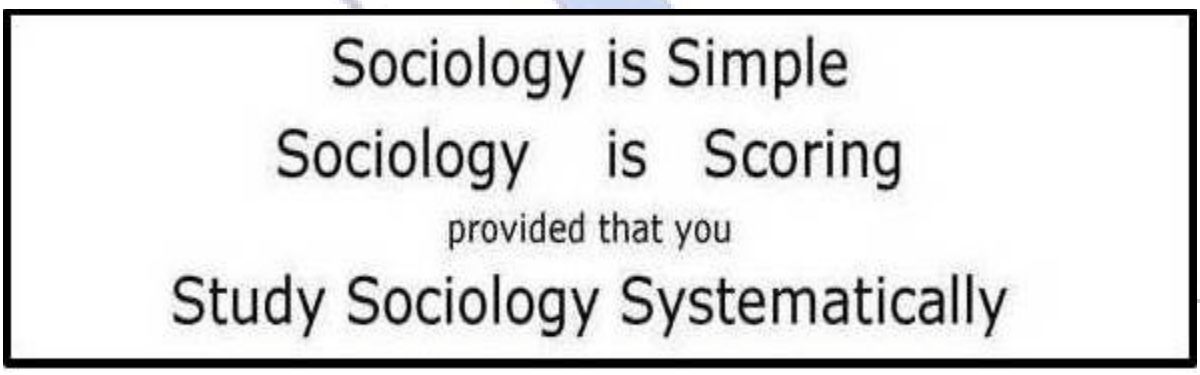
While Ghurye was in favour of a certain kind of 'uplift', mainly economic, he believed that the promotion of cultural pluralism by certain anthropologists and through official policies would lead to social disintegration. He cited as proof of this danger the emergence of cultural revival movements among some tribal groups, and he opposed tribal and regional autonomy movements as divisive. Thus Ghurye in many ways had a more realistic and progressive understanding of the history and problems of 'tribals' than many of his contemporaries, and his critique of Elwin's paternalism is refreshing. It appears that his nationalism, despite its inherent conservatism, led him to be quite perceptive on some issues: he recognized the economic and political roots of the adivasi situation and was quite prescient to recognize the colonial origin of the caste-tribe distinction. But in the end, Ghurye's own position was hardly more progressive than Elwin's, for his understanding of the tribal 'problem' was based on his view of Indian history as an ongoing process of "...assimilation of smaller groups of different cultures into larger ones." He regarded this as a natural process that was upset by colonialism: groups that had not been 'properly assimilated' appeared to the British to be different from the rest and were therefore designated as tribals. Here was the origin of the 'tribal problem', whose solution lay in assimilation rather than in the preservation of cultural diversity.

Driven by his nationalist concerns, Ghurye argued that civilisation is what gives Indian history its structure and logic, and the spread of Hindu civilisation necessitates the absorption of diverse groups. The underlying cause of the 'backward' condition of the tribes, then, is not contact with Hindu culture but insufficient assimilation to it.



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Observation

Observation is a method that employs vision as its main means of data collection. It implies the use of eyes rather than of ears and the voice. It is accurate watching and noting of phenomena as they occur with regard to the cause and effect or mutual relations. It is watching other persons' behaviour as it actually happens without controlling it. For example, observing the life of street-children or a religious ceremony in any community.

Lindzey Gardner has defined observation as "selection, provocation, recording and encoding of that set of behaviours and settings concerning organisms '*in situ*' (naturalistic settings) which are consistent with empirical aims". In this definition, *selection* means that there is a focus in observation and also editing before, during and after the observations are made. *Provocation* means that though observers do not destroy natural settings but they can make subtle changes in natural settings which increase clarity. *Recording* means that observed incidents/events are recorded for subsequent analysis. *Encoding* involves simplification of records.

According to Black and Champion, the major purpose of observation is to capture human conduct as it actually happens. In other methods, we get a static comprehension of people's activity. In actual situation, they sometimes modify their views, sometimes contradict themselves, and sometimes are so swayed by the situation that they react differently altogether. They further argue that observation can be used as a tool of collecting information in situations where methods other than observation cannot prove to be useful, e.g., voter's behaviour during election time or worker's behaviour during strike.

A significant number of sociologists choose not to use the more scientific approaches to the study of human behaviour. They prefer to sacrifice a certain precision of measurement and objectivity in order to get closer to their subjects, to examine the social world through the perspective of the people they are investigating. These sociologists sometimes refer to quantitative researchers as those who "measure everything and understand nothing."

By far the most important of the so-called qualitative methodologies is **participant observation**, in which the researcher participates in the daily life of the population under study, observing things that happen, listening to conversations, informally questioning people. This may be done covertly, as when a sociologist becomes a prison inmate in order to study the effectiveness of rehabilitation programs. It may also be done openly, by joining a group in the formal role of observer.

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In simple words, participant observation is a method in which the investigator becomes a part of the situation he is studying. He involves himself in the setting and group life of the research subjects. He shares the activities of the community observing what is going on around him, supplementing this by conversations and interview. One of the pioneering uses of participant observation by sociologists in a modern setting is recorded in William Foote Whyte's *Street Corner Society: The Social Structure of an Italian Slum*.

Street Corner Society by William Foote Whyte is a study of an Italian American streetcorner gang in a low-income district of south Boston. Whyte spent three and a half years living in the area as a participant observer. Whyte studied lower class "slum" street-corner groups by joining and talking informally with the members. He gained access to the first group through a social worker, became friendly with the group's leader, was introduced to other groups, and finally was accepted as "one of them" although he did not have to "play their game all the way." By "hanging out" on the street corner for a period of time, Whyte gained much valuable information about the group's goals and structure and the motivations of its members.

Supporters of participants observation have argued that, compared to other research techniques, it is least likely to lead to the sociologist imposing his reality on the social world he seeks to understand. It therefore provides the best means of obtaining a valid picture of social reality. With a structured interview – a predetermined set of questions which the interviewee is requested to answer – or a questionnaire – a set of printed questions to which the respondent is asked to provide written answer – the sociologist has already decided what is important. With preset questions he imposes his framework and priorities on those he wishes to study. By assuming the questions are relevant to his respondents he has already made many assumptions about their social world. Although the participant observer begins his work with some preconceived ideas, for example he will usually have studied the existing literature on the topic he is to investigate, he at least has the opportunity to directly observe the social world.

However, the success of participant observation depends initially upon the acceptance of the observer by the group he wishes to study. Once accepted, the participant observer must gain the trust of those he observes to be successful. Further, there are also the challenges of objectivity and value-neutrality. Since the observer participates in the events, sometimes he becomes so involved that he loses objectivity in observation. He may start interpreting events subjectively. Further, his presence may sensitise the subjects that they do not act in a natural way. In other words, his presence will to some degree influence the actions of those he

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observes. In this way he may modify or change the social world he wishes to investigate.

Those who argue that research methods in sociology should be drawn from the natural sciences (positivists) are often highly critical of participant observation. In particular they argue that the data obtained from participant observation lack 'reliability'. In the natural sciences data are seen to be reliable, if other researchers using the same methods of investigation on the same material produce the same results. By replicating an experiment it is possible to check for errors in observation and measurement. Once reliable data have been obtained, generalizations can then be made about the behaviour observed. No sociologist would claim that the social sciences can attain the standards of reliability employed in the natural sciences. Many would argue, however, that sociological data can attain a certain standard of reliability. They criticize participant observation for its failure to approach this standard. The data obtained by participant observation are seen to be unreliable because, as a method, its procedures are not made explicit, its observations are unsystematic and its results are rarely quantified. Thus there is no way of replicating a study and checking the reliability of its findings. Since participant observation relies heavily on the sensitivity, interpretive skills and personality of the observer, precise replication of studies using this method are difficult if not impossible. As a result it is not possible to generalize from such studies. Their value is seen to lie in providing useful insights which can then be tested on larger samples using more rigorous and systematic methods.

The above criticisms derive mainly from those who adopt a strongly positivist approach. Others would argue that what the findings of participant observation lack in reliability, they often more than make up for in validity. By coming face to face with social reality, the participant observer at least has the opportunity to make valid observations. Many would argue that the systematic questionnaire surveys favoured by many positivists have little or no chance of tapping the real social world.

Please note that in non-participant observation, the observer remains detached and does not participate or intervene in the activities of those who are being observed. He merely observes their behaviour. Sometimes, this places the persons being observed in an awkward position and their conduct becomes unnatural. But some say that though initially the observer's behaviour may affect the behaviour of the observed but after a little while, less and less attention is paid to his presence. This type of observation is more useful as a tool of data collection because the observer can choose the situations to be observed and can record the data freely. This is because the observer is not required to participate actively in the social processes at work in the social field he is observing. Since, he is not

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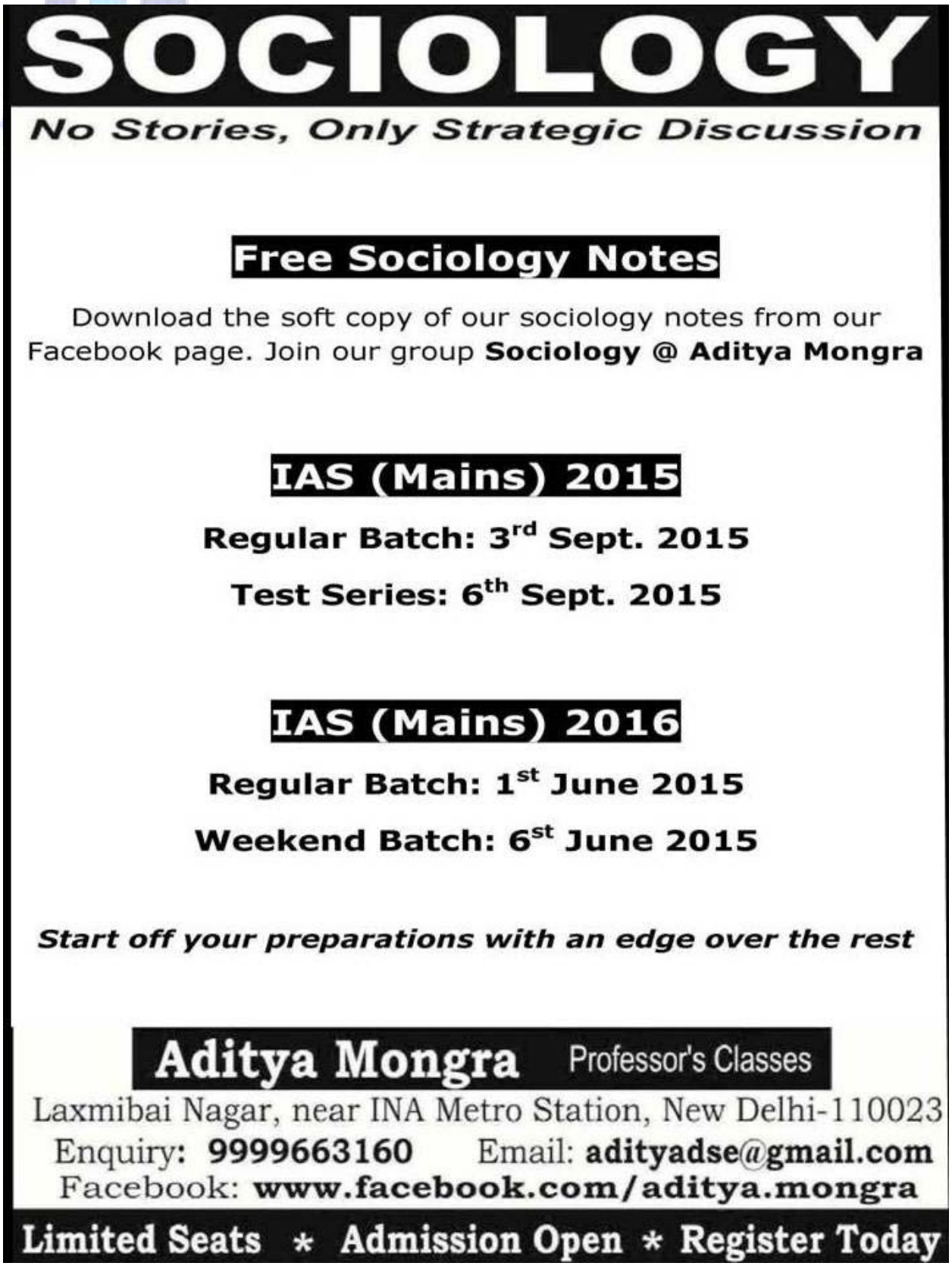
himself immediately affected by the demands of the situation, he can concentrate his whole attention more easily on systematic observation of the situation and what is happening in it.



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In the last decade of his career, Parsons became increasingly concerned with social change. Built into the cybernetic hierarchy of control is a conceptual scheme for classifying the locus of such social change. What Parsons visualized was that the information and energic interchanges among action systems (or social systems at societal level) provide the potential for change within or between the action systems. One source of change can be excesses in either information or energy in the exchange among action systems. In turn, these excesses alter the informational or energic outputs across systems and within any system. For example, excesses of motivation (energy) would have consequences for the enactment of roles and perhaps ultimately for the reorganization of these roles or the normative structure and eventually of cultural value orientations. Another source of change comes from an insufficient supply of either energy or information, again causing external and internal readjustments in the structure of action systems. For example, value (informational) conflict would cause normative conflict (or anomie), which in turn would have consequences for the personality and organismic systems. Thus, concepts that point to the sources of both stasis and change are inherent in the cybernetic hierarchy of control. To augment this new macro emphasis on change, Parsons used the action scheme to analyze social evolution in historical societies. In this context, the first line of *The Structure of Social Action* is of interest: "Who now reads Spencer?" Parsons then answered the question by delineating some of the reasons why Spencer's evolutionary doctrine had been so thoroughly rejected by 1937. Yet, after some forty years, after some forty years, Parsons chose to reexamine the issue of social evolution that he had so easily dismissed in the beginning. And in so doing, he reintroduced Spencer's and Durkheim's evolutionary models back into functional theory.

As earlier stated, Parsons' general orientation to the study of social change was shaped by biology. To deal with this process, Parsons developed what he called "a paradigm of evolutionary change." According to Parsons, social change involves the twin processes of differentiation and integration. The first component of that paradigm is the process of ***differentiation***. Parsons assumed that any society is composed of a series of subsystems that differ in both their structure and their functional significance for the larger society. As society evolves, new subsystems are differentiated. This is not enough, however; they also must be more adaptive than earlier subsystems. Thus, the essential aspect of Parsons' evolutionary paradigm was the idea of *adaptive upgrading*. This is a highly positive model of social change. It assumes that as society evolves, it grows generally better able to cope with its problems. In contrast, in Marxian theory social change leads to the eventual destruction of capitalist society. For this reason, among others, Parsons often is thought of as a very conservative sociological theorist. In addition, while he did deal with change, he tended to focus on the positive aspects of social change in the modern world rather than on its negative side.

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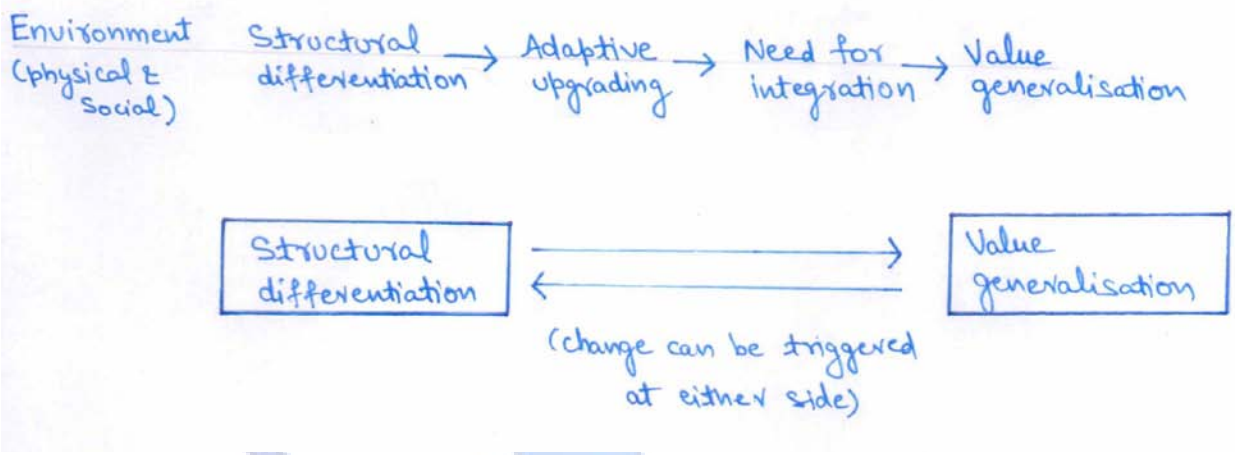
Next, Parsons argued that the process of differentiation leads to a new set of problems of ***integration*** for society. As subsystems proliferate, the society is confronted with new problems in coordinating the operations of these units. A society undergoing evolution must move from a system of ascription to one of achievement. A wider array of skills and abilities is needed to handle the more diffuse subsystems. The generalized abilities of people must be freed from their ascriptive bonds so that they can be utilized by society. Most generally, this means that groups formerly excluded from contributing to the system must be freed for inclusion as full members of the society.

Finally, the ***value system*** of the society as a whole must undergo change as social structures and functions grow increasingly differentiated. However, since the new system is more diverse, it is harder for the value system to encompass it. Thus a more differentiated society requires a value system that is "couched at a higher level of generality in order to legitimize the wider variety of goals and functions of its subunits". However, this process of generalization of values often does not proceed smoothly as it meets resistance from groups committed to their own narrow value systems.



He further argues that evolution proceeds through a variety of cycles, but no general process affects all societies equally. Some societies may foster evolution, whereas others may "be so beset with internal conflicts or other handicaps" that they impede the process of evolution, or they may even "deteriorate". What most interested Parsons were those societies in which developmental "breakthroughs" (**evolutionary universals**) occur, since he believed that once they occurred, the process of evolution would follow his general evolutionary model. Although Parsons conceived of evolution as occurring in stages, he was careful to avoid a unilinear evolutionary theory: "We do not conceive societal evolution to be either a continuous or a simple linear process, but we can distinguish between broad levels of advancement without overlooking the considerable variability found in each". Making it clear that he was simplifying matters, Parsons distinguished three broad

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evolutionary stages—primitive, archaic and modern. Characteristically, he differentiated among these stages primarily on the basis of cultural dimensions. The crucial development in the transition from primitive to archaic is the development of language, primarily written language. The key development in the shift from archaic to modern is "the institutionalized codes of normative order," or law. [Please note that in his theory of social change, Parsons uses the concept of 'evolutionary universals' – *"any organizational development sufficiently important to further evolution that rather than emerging only once is likely to be hit upon by various systems operating under different conditions"*.]

One particular point is worth underscoring here: Parsons turned to evolutionary theory, at least in part, because he was accused of being unable to deal with social change. However, his analysis of evolution is not in terms of process; rather, it is an attempt to "order structural types and relate them sequentially". This is comparative structural analysis, not really a study of the processes of social change. Thus, even when he was supposed to be looking at change, Parsons remained committed to the study of structures and functions.

Dear Candidate, after giving at least three readings to these notes and making notes in the 'pointer form,' please go through the questions asked in previous years and try to attempt them. Always remember that without answer-writing practice, any amount of sociological knowledge would be of little use for you in qualifying civil services examination. Thus, along with understanding the sociological ideas discussed here, you must also master the art of expressing them in your own words as per the standards of the examination and expectations of the examiner, and that too, in the given Time-and-Word Limit.

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Weber's account of the rise of modern, rational, capitalist society: 'rationality', ***The Protestant Ethic and Spirit of Capitalism*** **and bureaucracy**

As we noted in the introduction, it has become standard procedure in learning about social theory to compare Weber's explanation of the emergence of modern industrial capitalist society with Marx's account. We have to be interested in this comparison because the question of the causes and consequences of historical development remains a central part of the subject matter of social theory. Notwithstanding the fact, as already noted, that Weber was only familiar with a portion of Marx's work and was undoubtedly influenced by the simplified German Social Democratic Party reading of Marx, there were very few modern accounts to choose between and certainly Marx's historical-materialist analysis was a leading contender. Weber was, however, unhappy about the historical-materialist account for a number of reasons. A number of necessarily simplistic comparisons can be made.

First, Weber thought that it was highly unlikely that history develops according to any kind of grand plan, let alone the one that Marx describes. For Weber, human action is much more contingent than this in the sense that nobody can predict what all the circumstances and contexts of action will be. If you cannot specify the context, then there is little chance of foreseeing the action that will take place within it. The basic inability to specify what will happen next also applies to the consequences of action, many of which are quite unintended. Just because social actors hope that things will turn out in one way rather than another does not guarantee that they will. Regarding Marx's idea, for example, that capitalism must follow feudalism, Weber pointed out that capitalism is not in fact unique to modern society. Much of his historical analysis to concerned with showing that different forms of capitalistic or profit-making behaviour have characterised earlier forms of society. Modern industrial capitalism, in other words, is just one type, one variety of the different kinds of capitalism that, under different historical circumstances, could have developed. Weber is therefore inclined to be cautious about the contribution to social theory of the historical-materialist method.

A second weakness or the historical-materialist approach, as Weber saw it, was that it gave too much attention to the economic realm and thus underestimated what goes on in other aspects of social life. In trying to understand the origins of modern capitalism it is necessary to look at developments in the political, legal and religious spheres as well as in the economic sphere. Rather than accepting Marx's topographical representation of society as a pyramid with the broad economic base providing a foundation for all other superstructural phenomena, Weber is more inclined to see society as a series of overlapping realms, none of which has the power to control or dominate all of the others. He accepts the very great

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significance and influence of the economic sphere but does not see this as causative of all other phenomena in the way that Marx does.

A related weakness, according to Weber at least, is that while materialist theories inevitably give priority to material phenomena, ideational phenomena, including ideas, values and beliefs, but also the way social actors construct intellectual representations of reality in their minds, also need to be taken into account. One could press this point and suggest that at the point ideas become realised through practice, they also take on a material existence.

Having made these criticisms of the historical-materialist approach, Weber felt compelled to offer an alternative. After all, history had to develop in one way or another, and just because historical materialism fell short in its explanation this did not mean that other social theorists should not give it a try.

We will look at Weber's alternative under three headings:

- his comments about the development of a new kind of **rationality**, which became integral to the Western world view from the 16th century onwards;
- his detailed description in ***The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*** of how as new variant of the business or commercial spirit of capitalism coincided with the emergence of a particular kind of Protestant religious ethic in Northern Europe at around the same time;
- his comments about the inevitable spread of **bureaucracy.**

Rationality

Weber agreed with Marx that modern capitalism had become the dominant characteristic of modern industrial society. It was (and in fact still is) not possible to think of modern society without also thinking about the capitalist business enterprise that lies at the heat if it. Where he disagreed with Marx was over the explanation of how this state of affairs had come about. For Weber the originating cause, the fundamental root of this development, was not 'men making history' or 'the class struggle' but the emergence of a new approach to life based around a new kind of **rational** outlook. Thus new rationality had its roots in the various intellectual currents that emerged during the European Enlightenment.

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The main intention of the new rationality was to replace vagueness and speculation with precision and calculation. This was a profoundly practical kind of rationality in which social actors no longer behaved spontaneously or emotionally but only after making a careful consideration of the various alternatives available to them. The new rationality took the Enlightenment idea that people could control their own destiny and turned it into a strategy for action. It was all about controlling the outcomes of action, of eliminating fate and chance, through the application of **reason**. Weber called the new outlook **instrumental rationality** because it took the degree to which it enabled social actors to achieve the ends they had identified as its main criteria for judging whether an action was or was not rational. A characteristic of modern society is that actions are defined as rational as long as they are effective in achieving particular ends. The new instrumental rationality was also a 'universal rationality' in the sense that it affected the way in which decisions to act were made, not just in economic affairs, but across the full spectrum of activity. Weber argued that instrumental rationality had become a foundation for a new and highly rationalistic way of life or world view.

Rationalisation

In the same way that the term industrialisation describes what happens when economies take on industrial techniques, Weber used the term rationalisation to describe what happens when the different institutions and practices that surround social action take on the techniques of instrumental rationality. Modern society is modern because it has undergone this process of rationalisation. Although, as we have already noted, Weber agreed with Marx about the great significance for historical development of developments in the economic sphere, he argued that the massive expansion of the economic sphere as it entered its industrial stage was itself a consequence and not a cause of the spread of the new instrumental rationality. Weber noted, for example, that instrumental rationality was not confined to the economic sphere but also affected the development of democratic systems for electing governments, the rationalisation of government into different departments and the increasing use of bureaucracy as the most instrumentally rational way of organising complex organisations. The legal and medical professions, universities and research institutions and so on, are all similarly drawn under the influence of instrumental rationality. The uptake of instrumental rationality through rationalisation can be seen to be a driving force behind all forms of modernisation in modern society.

While factors identified by Marx, such as property relations, class conflict and developments in the means of production, clearly play an important part in how, at a lower and more descriptive level of analysis, the specific

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consequences are worked out, each of these is, according to Weber, an outlet for the underling urge to become increasingly rational. Recalling Durkheim's analysis of social solidarity and the new individualism, one might say that the instrumental rationality identified by Weber provides an important source of collective consciousness in modern society. Rationalisation and its consequences regulate the behaviour of social actor and thus contribute to social order.

Formal and substantive rationality

Before moving on to look at two detailed examples Weber provides of the actual impact of rationalisation on real situations (the capitalist business enterprise and the rise of bureaucracy), we should pause to make one further point about the new instrumental rationality. As ever, this requires some preliminary philosophical reflection on the qualitative dimensions of instrumental rationality. This concerns the distinction between **formal rationality** and **substantive rationality**. There is a tendency to assume that in describing the new instrumental rationality Weber somehow approves of it and of its effects on social life. This is partly unavoidable precisely because Weber goes to great lengths not to offer his own opinion (he would regard this as a serious transgression of the principle of value-neutrality discussed earlier). Nor does he wish to offer any suggestions about how things could be organised differently (although he is generally critical of the socialist alternative as he thinks the mode of bureaucratised social organisation it envisages would restrict individual freedom).

He does, however, make an important distinction between the rationality of something in terms of *how useful it is in a purely practical sense* (its formal rationality), and *how rational it is in terms of the ends it serves* (its substantive rationality). For example, it is clear the industrial division of labour is a more technically efficient, a more rational way of producing things than feudal agriculture. What is less clear is whether the decision to apply this type of organisation is an entirely rational one given that there is no guarantee that the general quality of life is also bound to improve. Just because social actors make sensible choices between the various techniques for doing something this does not necessarily help us decide if the ends they want to achieve are, in a more substantive sense, also rational. The atomic bomb is the most effective means of mass destruction but mass destruction is hardly a rational objective.

This dilemma runs parallel to the issue of value-neutrality discussed in the previous section. For Weber, one of the most difficult challenges of social theory is to account for the judgements social actors make, not so much over

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the best means for achieving something, but over which ends they feel are worth pursuing. The potential conflict between formal and substantive rationality is itself a consequence of the modernist perspective that emerged from the European Enlightenment. In pre-modernity crucial decisions about ultimate ends simply did not arise because the originating force in the universe was taken to be either nature or God. Having displaced nature with society and having marginalised the notion of the divine presence with the introduction of a strong concept of human self-determination, social actors in modern society have to make choices without reference to supra-human forces; choices that have been created by the powerful new technical means at their disposal.

It was the apparently indissoluble nature of these tensions between the formal and substantive rationalities of modern society, and between the rationalities of the different spheres of social action, that caused Weber to be extremely pessimistic about what the future might hold. If bureaucratic procedures cause a loss of liberty, or if, as Marx showed, the division of labour in industry cause alienation, would it be better not to use these techniques? Most fundamentally, and reflecting the instrumentality of the new outlook, Weber felt that as social actors become more and more obsessed with expressing formal rationality by improving the techniques they have for doing things, they become less and less interested in why they are doing them. The connection between means and ends becomes increasingly weakened even to the extent that ends come to be defined in terms of the unquestioned desirability of developing yet more means.

The ways in which these underlying tensions in the concept of instrumental rationality played themselves out in society provided Weber with a powerful way of theorising the sources of social conflict. Whereas Marx had correctly defined social conflict in terms of the struggle for economic resources, Weber added that important struggles also took place between one value system and another. The resources, in other words, over which social actors come into conflict, are not just economic ones but ideational and conceptual one as well. Capitalism dominated modern society not just because it is red hot at developing new techniques for producing things (it expresses very high levels of formal rationality, or in Marx's terms is very dynamic in developing the means of production), but because it engages sufficiently at the level of ideas for social actors to believe that this is a rational way to proceed.

The rational iron cage

Weber regrets the loss of high ideals and of meaning in existence that resulted from rationalization. The paradox and tragedy of our time is that rationalization has taught people to master nature, to develop technology for

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producing the means of survival, and to create administrative bureaucratic systems for regulating social life, while the existential basis of life – the choice of values and ideals and the search for meaning beyond soulless calculation of effective means for achieving a certain goal – is disappearing more and more. Modern man is trapped in a rational "iron cage of commodities and regulations" and he has lost his humanity. At the same time, he believes he has achieved the highest stage of development.

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The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism

Dropping down a level from Weber's more abstract development of the concept of rationality to describe the general causes of the process by which modern society develops, we can look at two examples of how Weber thought these principles worked themselves out in practice. The first is his influential description in *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism* (otherwise known as 'the Protestant ethic thesis') of how a particular set of business interests coincided with a specific religious orientation to produce the modern rational variant of capitalism (the second is his critical analysis of bureaucracy, which we will be looking at shortly). Along with his influential contribution to methodological issues in the social sciences, and of his analysis of rationality and social action, Weber's reputation as a major social theorist rest heavily on the two extended essays he published under this title in 1904 and 1905. In them, and drawing on the ideas and argument as we have just been looking at, he offers his description of the origins of modern capitalism:

> In the last analysis the factor which produces capitalism is the rational permanent enterprise with its rational accounting, rational technology and rational law, [complemented by] the rational spirit, the rationalisation of the conduct of life in general and a rationalistic economic ethic.
>
> Max Weber, *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*

This brief quotation usefully summarises Weber's analysis of what is peculiar about *modern* capitalism. In contrast to earlier forms of profit making, the modern form is profoundly *rational* in the sense that its advocates try to keep risks to a minimum, behave in a highly calculating way when making business and investment decisions, and, perhaps most essentially, continue to make profits even when they have already passed the point of satisfying their own immediate needs. Reflecting the problematic nature of instrumental rationality as discussed in the previous section, profit making within modern capitalism becomes *an end in itself* rather than a means to an end. Recalling Marx's description, this amounts to a shift from the production of commodities that are valuable because of their practical use [or **use value**], to the production of commodities whose value lies in their abstract capacity for exchangeability [**exchange value**]. The production of use values is limited by the needs they satisfy, whereas the production of exchange values is unlimited.

In his sociology of religion, Weber used his ideal types to try to answer his fundamental question: Why was it in Europe that capitalism had its breakthrough and later became a dominant force in the world? This question cannot be answered as the Marxists did, simply by pointing to the initial accumulation of capital and

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the creation of a "free" class of wage laborers. Even though these institutional factors were important to the origin of capitalism, they do not explain why certain people in history began to act in a capitalist manner. According to Weber, Marxian view on the development of capitalism can at best be regarded as an ideal type construction highlighting the role of economic factor which contributed to the rise of capitalism.

Weber also rejected Engel's view that Protestantism rose in Europe as a legitimizing ideology to nascent capitalism which had already come into existence. Instead he emphasized the role of ideas as an independent source of change. Refuting Engel's argument he further states that capitalism existed in an embryo in Babylon, Roman, Chinese and Indian societies and in China and India other material conditions propitious for the development of capitalism also existed at certain stages in their history. But nowhere did it led to the development of modern capitalism. This phenomenon is peculiar to western society alone. The question arises as to why these embryos developed into the modern form of capitalism only in the west and nowhere else. An explanation in terms of the internal dynamics of economic forces alone is unable to account for this peculiarity. It is necessary to take into account specific ethos of the early European capitalistic entrepreneurs and realize that this was precisely what was absent in other civilizations.

After all, according to Weber, any explanation of a historical phenomenon must be traced back to human social action and, thus, the investigator must try to gain an explanatory understanding of why certain people acted as they did, based on those people's own conditions. It was this that Weber attempted to do in his famous study on the connection between the Protestant ethic and the spirit of capitalism.

Early capitalism emerged in a part of Europe that had also undergone a religious reformation. What meaningful link was there between Protestantism and the appearance of capitalism?

Weber created two ideal types, the Protestant ethic and the spirit of capitalism, to examine this question.

In his ideal type on the Protestant ethic, Weber dwells on the values and beliefs that arose within a particularly vigorous and **ascetic** variety of the Protestant faith, which developed in Northern Europe, and later in North America, during the 16th and 17th centuries. 'Asceticism' is an attitude of self-restraint, even self-denial, which imposes strict limits on the kind of enjoyment a person may take in the products of his or her work. For Weber, it was the historically fortunate coming together of this religious code of conduct or 'ethic', and the 'spirit' of the

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newly emerging and instrumentally oriented variety of capitalism, that launched rational capitalism into the modern world.

Weber argues that the originality of this new ascetic Protestantism lay not so much in ideas about living a good earthly life and having faith in the possibility of spiritual salvation, principles that had been around for quite a while already, but in the self-administered and thus psychological nature of the fear of not achieving spiritual salvation. Central to the Protestant faith is the idea that it is the individual and not the Church who carries responsibility for spiritual destiny (individual responsibility). The concept of individual conscience and individual responsibility was built around the idea of 'the calling' developed by the initiator of the Protestant faith, the German theologian Martin Luther (1483-1546). As Weber interprets it; 'The only way of living acceptably to God was through the fulfilment of the obligations imposed upon the individual by his position in the world. That was his calling'.

This key principle was supplemented soon after by the idea of 'predestination', put forward in the teaching of another Protestant theologian John Calvin (1509-64). Calvin in his doctrine of predestination argued that God, in his omnipotence, has determined the fate of every man long before that man is born. Thus God has decided which people will gain salvation and which are condemned to eternal damnation. Those who had not been chosen were destined never to achieve spiritual salvation. At first sight this position seems paradoxical. If spiritual salvation has been settled in advance then what is to be gained from pursuing earthly toil in a godly manner, why not simply lead a life of pleasure and idleness?

Calvin emphasised, however, that precisely since there can be no certainty of salvation individuals must prove their spiritual salvation by leading an exemplary life on earth. Moreover, this proof could not simply be demonstrated abstractly by believing in the possibility of salvation hereafter, but through concrete action in the present. Intense worldly activity thus became indispensable 'as a sign of election': '[It is] the technical means, not of purchasing salvation, but of getting rid of the fear of damnation'. Through frenetic devotion to one's calling, the individual is provided with a means of demonstrating how certain they are about being saved. Conveniently, 'the earning of money within the modern economic order is, so long as it is done legally, the result and the expression of virtue and proficiency in a calling'. Ascetic Protestantism thus unequivocally ties spiritual destiny to profoundly practical and energetic ethic of hard work.

Weber constructs the other ideal type, the spirit of capitalism, on the book *Advice to a Young Tradesman* written in 1748 by Benjamin Franklin (1706-90). In

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this book Franklin offers advice to those who would like to succeed in business. He believes they must remember that time is money, that credit is money, and that money, with hard work, can produce more money. This focus on the multiplication of money is also linked to a call for a moral and ascetic life in which those who have provided credit would rather hear the sound of a hammer at five o' clock in the morning then see the borrower at the pool table.

Irrespective of whether salvation is actually achieved through hard work, the practical outcome of the idea that it might gave rise to a work-obsessed class of entrepreneurs and business people whose earthly desire for commercial success ran parallel with their religious desire for spiritual redemption. Since the enjoyment of wealth is considered sinful, the only legitimate use for the increasing revenue is to reinvest it in the business itself. The pragmatic saving of capital is justified by the higher substantive aim of the saving of souls. For Weber, it is this coincidence within the Protestant ethic between obsessive hard work and an ascetic attitude towards the wealth it generates that lies at the heart of the 'elective affinity' or sympathetic association between Protestantism and capitalism:

'When the limitation of consumption is combined with the release of acquisitive activity, the inevitable practical result is obvious: accumulation of capital through ascetic compulsion to save. The restraints imposed upon the consumption of wealth naturally served to increase it by making possible the productive investment of capital.'

- Max Weber

The hard-working, hard-saving, soul-searching mentality embedded within the Protestant work ethic filtered down the social hierarchy eventually establishing itself as the most practical and legitimate way of achieving prosperity in modern society. Making good use of time, being busy not idle, avoiding frivolity, self-indulgence and wastefulness, are common principles of behaviour that have undoubtedly shaped the mentality of modern Western society.

In summary, then, the argument Weber puts forward in his Protestant ethic thesis tries to provide a multidimensional explanation of how modern capitalism really got going. The basic point he wants to get across is that although the very large amounts of capital that capitalism needed to get started did, from a technical point of view, come by way of developments in the versatility of the division of labour and the efficiency of the means of production, these developments were themselves a result of a qualitative change in the general approach to life and work; a general approach based on new ideas, values and beliefs. Weber's explanation can be much more precise about the timing of the whole modern capitalist adventure (Northern Europe in the period 1650-1750), because the release of spare capital is tied to a specific coming together of commercial attitudes and the religious teaching of Luther and Calvin. Unlike the historical-materialist

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account, which relies on the theoretical construct of developments in the means and relations of production to predict the emergence of capitalism from feudalism, Weber's thesis gives the whole event a real sense of historical actuality. Modern rational capitalism emerged because of the collision at a particular time and place of a particular set of real but unpredictable circumstances. Some of these circumstances were material ones (technical innovation, new commercial opportunities), but others came from the realm of ideas.

Getting back to Weber's underlying argument that the whole ethos of modern society changed with the emergence of the new rationality, he felt that what the twin beliefs in saving one's capital and saving one's soul had in common was the fact that they both defined rationality in highly instrumental terms. If by working hard it is possible to achieve earthly comfort, and enhance one's sense of having spiritual future thereafter, then hard work becomes the pivotal activity of one's life. Hard work is legitimately regarded as having very high levels of formal rationality because it is the practical means of achieving the substantively rational goals of prosperity and salvation. Nobody in the West is ever criticised for working too hard because hard work is the best means of achieving these highest ends.

Weber believes that even though the content of the two cultures, the Protestant ethic and the spirit of capitalism, were different and based on different assumptions, they lead to similar actions. Protestant action was value-rational action, that is, it attempted, to live up to the value of being saved and to find signs of salvation. Capitalist action is purposive rational action, that is, it attempts to find effective means of achieving an end, the multiplication of money. To the Protestant, the ascetic life and diligence were part of a life lived in the glory of God and were not directed toward the multiplication of money. Despite this, however, it broke with what Weber calls the "feudal spirit," which contained an irrational use of wealth in the form of a life of luxury. In order for capitalism to rise, this form of the luxurious use of wealth had to give way to an accumulation and reinvestment of accumulated money. The Protestant ethic played a key role in this transition. According to Weber, early modern capitalism was characterized by the institutionalization of "gain spirit" where the ethical and religious ideas regulated and provided legitimization and justification of the pursuit of economic goals.

Asceticism contributed to a rational moulding of every aspect of life. Constant control through a systematic effort resulted in a rationalization of individual conduct even in the conduct of business. Thus the adherents to the Protestant ideology became adept in rationalizing economic action while leading an austere and ascetic life. This entrepreneurial attitude, hard work, rational organization of conduct and frugal living together constituted the spirit of capitalism, which according to Weber was fostered through the Protestant ethic. To

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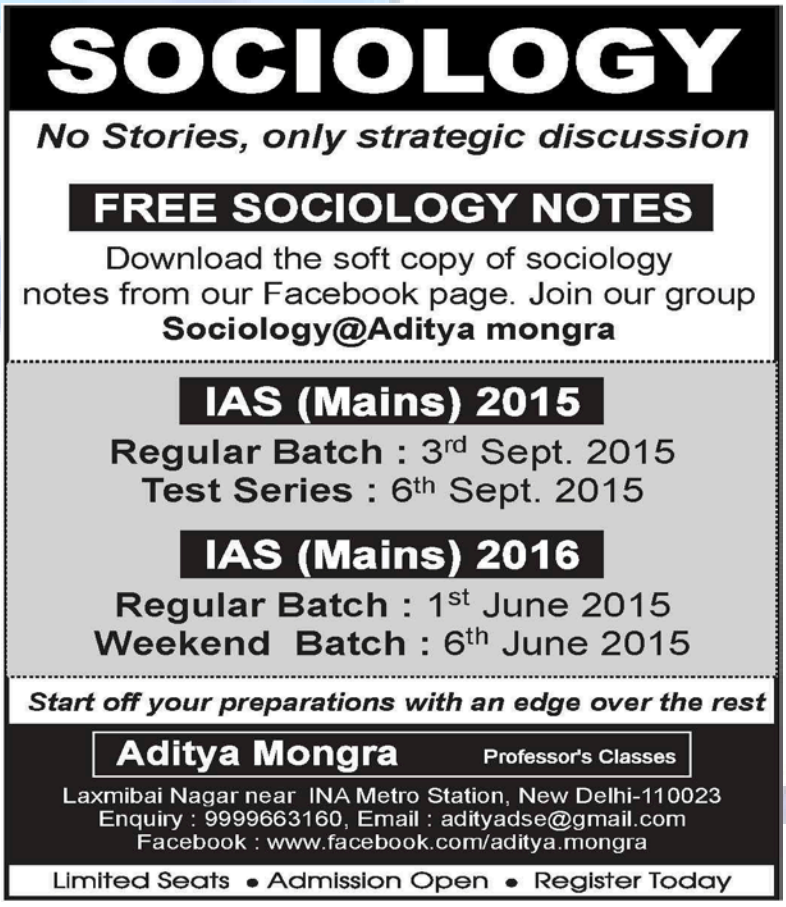
avoid misunderstanding, Weber specified that the causal relationship between Protestantism and capitalism should not be taken in the sense of a mechanical relationship. Due to his belief in causal pluralism, Weber states that the Protestant ethos was some of the sources of rationalization of life which helped to create what is known as the *spirit of capitalism*. It was not the sole cause, not even a sufficient cause of capitalism. Raymond Aron makes Weber's position clear when he writes, 'Protestantism is not the cause but one of the causes of capitalism or rather it is one of the causes of certain aspects of capitalism'.

Thus Weber has clearly stated that only the spirit of capitalism was created by the Protestant ethos. While there were number of other contributory factors which along with the spirit of capitalism helped in the growth of capitalism. Further Weber made a comparative study of world religions in terms of their beliefs and practices and their repercussions on social life. Weber analyzed Confucianism and Taoism in China, Hinduism and Buddhism in India, and finally ancient Judaism. He also planned, but was unable to complete, studies on Islam, Talmudic Judaism, early Christianity, and various religious sects within the Reformation. The studies Weber carried out deal with the various social conditions in which the different religions operated, the social stratification, the links of various groups to different religious, and the importance of various religious leaders.



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With the help of comparative study he built a typology of religions. He pointed that religious activity can be classified into two categories:

1) Asceticism, and

2) Mysticism

Asceticism consists of the belief that God direct religious activity, so that the believer sees himself to be the instrument of the divine will. Therefore the purpose of this life is not to waste it in luxuries and pleasures of flesh, rather one should lead a disciplined life to realize the glory of God.

Mysticism, on the other hand, consists of a consciousness not so much of being an instrument of God but of what Weber calls a *vassal* of God. Religious activity, in this case, is a question of achieving a condition akin to the divine. This is accomplished by contemplation on truths than those which can be demonstrated in this world.

Next, according to Weber, asceticism can manifest itself in two forms – inner worldly asceticism and other worldly asceticism. Inner worldly asceticism is where individuals not only feel themselves to be the instrument of God's will, but seek to glorify God's name through performing good work in the world. Here success in this world itself becomes a sign of divine approval. Other worldly asceticism, on the other hand, is where the individuals renounce the world so that they may be of service to God alone, as in the case of monastic orders.

Here, Weber pointed out that only inner worldly ascetic types of religious beliefs which make the believer treat day to day working as the calling of God will foster the spirit of capitalism. The other worldly asceticism and mysticism will not be conducive to the growth of the spirit of capitalism. Certain sets of Protestantism alone were the inner worldly ascetic type and hence contributed to the rise of modern capitalism. On the other hand, other religions like Hinduism, Confucianism, and Buddhism etc., were either other worldly ascetic or had a preponderance of the mysticism and therefore failed to foster the spirit of capitalism, although material conditions propitious for the development of capitalism were present in Indian and Chinese societies.

Weber did not believe that Protestantism "caused" capitalism or that the early Protestants were cynical money-worshipers (although there were isolated examples of this). Instead, using his fundamental methodology, he attempted to understand acting people so that, on the basis of this knowledge, he could explain historical events. Once capitalism had become established, it no longer needed this value-based foundation as a criterion for action. It was sufficient that purposive

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rational action had become institutionalized, as it was in the modern capitalist company. But in the transition from precapitalist to capitalist action, some justification was needed for the first capitalist to begin acting in an ascetic and world-oriented manner. According to Weber, the Protestant ethic contributed just this kind of strong force that could make people begin acting differently and not simply on the basis of tradition.

As stated earlier, in addition to analyzing the role of Protestantism in the rise of early capitalism, Weber also worked on a major comparative study of world religions. This study did not deal with the metaphysical "essence" of the various religions, rather Weber analyzed the importance religion had for the "the conditions and effects of a particular type of social action". Weber was particularly interested in how various religions hindered or promoted a special sort of economic rationality and, in this sense, the study of world religions was part of Weber's overall investigation of what specific factors led to the rational capitalism of the Western world.

Weber summarized his results in a brief introduction when his collected studies on religion were published. The fundamental question he asks is "to what combination of circumstances the fact should be attributed that in Western civilization, and in Western civilization only, cultural phenomena have appeared which (as we like to think) lie in a line of development having universal significance and value". As a result of his analysis of the various religions of the world and their respective social conditions, Weber distinguished a number of factors that separated the West from other societies. These factors are:

1 Science. To be sure, empirical knowledge, consideration of the problems of the world and of life, and philosophical and ideological wisdom have developed in other cultures as well, but they lack the systematic development of knowledge based on natural science and experimentation that is found in the West. The West has also developed systematic forms of thought and rational concepts within historical research and law.

2 Art. In music the West has developed a rational harmony-based music with counter-point and chordal harmony, a notation system that allows the composition and performance of modern musical works, and a number of instruments such as the organ, piano, violin, etc. In architecture, only the West has developed a rational use of the Gothic arch to distribute weight to reach over all kinds of rooms. Only in the West has a printing art appeared that is aimed solely at literature.

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3 Administration. Although other cultures have also had institutions of higher learning similar on the surface to the Western university, it is only here that there is a rational, systematic, and specialized practice of science by trained experts. This has led to the development of professionally trained organizations of officials and to the fact that the "most important functions of the everyday life of society have come to be in the hands of technically, commercially, and above all legally trained government officials".

4 The State. Of course, there is a form of "state" in all cultures, but "the State itself, in the sense of a political association with a rational, written constitution, rationally ordained law, and an administration bound to rational rules or laws, administrated by trained officials, is known, in this combination of characteristics, only in the Occident".

5 Economics. In all cultures and in all groups there is and has always been a "lust for money" and it is not that distinguishes Western capitalism from the economies of other cultures. Rather, it is the rational bridling of this irrational impulse that makes possible the appearance of a rational capitalism. This capitalism is based on the "expectation of profit by utilization of opportunities for exchange, that is on (formally) peaceful chances of profit". In addition, it is only here that the specifically capitalist organization of labour has developed with rational calculation, based on a free labour force. Only here has the economy developed a systematic use of technology and, moreover, "modern rational capitalism needs… a calculable legal system and administration in terms of formal rules".

The final result of this comparative sociology of religion is that the specific nature of Western development is that there is a "specific and peculiar rationalism of Western culture". Thus, according to Weber, the basis of this unique Western development is not to be found in the economy, but in its unique rationalization process. Weber believed inner worldly asceticism to be a crucial factor in the rationalisation of social life. Capitalism is simply an expression of this rationalization, just as the modern state with its administration and armies, bureaucracy, legitimatization of power, science, and art all are. It is the discovery of this rationalization process that is perhaps Weber's most important contribution to social science. This argument of Weber implies that any religious (or secular) ideology which emphasises on the inner worldly ascetic attitude towards life would lead to rationalisation of social life.

Balwant Nevaskar, in his book, *Capitalist without Capitalism: Jains of India and the Quakers of the West* (1971), states that Max Weber was the first sociologist to have sociologically studied the major religions of India. These studies are

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contained in his book "*The Religion of India*" (by Max Weber, the original edition was in German and was published in 1916). Max Weber maintains that the Jains are an exclusive merchant sect and that there is apparently "a positive relationship between Jainism and economic motivation which is otherwise quite foreign in Hinduism". Weber seems to suggest that although Jainism is spiritualized in the direction of world renunciation, some features of inner worldly asceticism are also present in it. To begin with, it can be observed that the twin doctrines of "predestination" and the "calling" implied in Protestantism are only indirectly present in Jainism but they must be understood in the light of Karma, and not in relation to God. Many aspects of rational conduct promoting savings such as thriftiness, self-discipline, frugality and abstention as part of this worldly asceticism, however, are directly present in Jainism.

In "*The Protestant Ethic and the Parsis*," Robert Kennedy does just this and suggests that Zoroastrianism — an ancestral monotheism — set the stage for Modernity, which encompasses not only capitalism but also science. Kennedy identifies five abstract values associated with Modernity: (1) an underlying order in nature, (2) sensory standard of verification, (3) material work is intrinsically good, (4) maximization of material prosperity, and (5) accumulation rather than consumption of material goods. Using historical data on the Parsis or Zoroastrian Persians who fled from Iran to India after the Islamic conquest in the 8th century AD, Kennedy examines their beliefs, culture, and society for correspondences. Finding many, Kennedy suggests that modern economy and science may have roots in Zoroastrian religion.

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Similarly, Clifford Geertz carried out his study in East Java, Indonesia, in the early 1950s with an intention to find a local variant of the Protestant ethic in Muslim societies — inspired by Weber's famous "*The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*." Please note that the dominance of the Weberian perspective among US scholars in general at the time was one factor. Geertz was a student of Talcott Parsons, and Parsons was the one who introduced Weber to American academia by translating "The Protestant Ethic" into English. But of course Geertz's choice to use the Weberian perspective was not simply because of this teacher-student relation. The most important reason was because he tried to find the relation between religious ideas and human conduct, politics and economic development — between religion and social change. For this analytical endeavor, Weber provided very useful tools.

Weber study of "*The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*" opened up new vistas of research on the factors contributing to the rise of modern industrial capitalist society in Europe and elsewhere. Please note that Weber emphasized on the role of ideas in shaping the motivations and life styles of future capitalists. For him, it was an independent factor responsible of the rise of capitalism. He did not totally reject Marxian theory of rise of capitalism which sought to explain capitalist development in terms of economic forces. He regarded the Marxist view as an ideal type model highlighting the role of one set of factors i.e. economic factors. Weber advocated that the rise of modern capitalism can be explained only by taking into account the multiplicity of factors at work.

After Weber, a number of scholars have attempted to explain the development of capitalism and in the process have highlighted some new factors which contributed to the growth of modern capitalism. These later day theories of capitalism should be treated as complementary to those of Marx and Weber.

For example, Neil Joseph Smelser, an American sociologist, in his study of third world countries, found that the state played an important role in the rise of capitalism. He argued that nationalistic ideology (secular inner worldly asceticism) in the third world societies has played the same role which protestant ethos did in the case of Europe in the rise of capitalism.

Werner Sombart, a German economist and sociologist, was deeply influenced by the ideas of Marx and Weber. According to Sombart, the development of capitalism can be divided into three stages:

Early capitalism, ending before the industrial revolution;
High capitalism, beginning about 1760; and,
Late capitalism, beginning with World War I.

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The moving force during the first stage of capitalism was a small number of enterprising businessmen, emerging from all groups of population – noble men, adventurers, merchants and artisans. Here he also highlighted the importance of the flow of *precious metal* (Gold, Silver, etc.) into Europe from South America. Sombart, in his book *The Jews and Modern Capitalism*, also highlighted the role of Jews in the development of modern capitalism. In addition, he accepted Weber's views that Protestant ethic emphasized values of hard work while deferring gratification and such an attitude favoured creation of capital and its productive reinvestment rather than consumption.

Another scholar, Andre Gunder Frank (1929–2005), a German-American economic historian and sociologist, who promoted dependency theory after 1970s, has emphasized the role of colonial rule or imperial domination in the development of capitalism among imperial powers. The colonial expansion divided the world into two major zones and created an international division of labour. In such a division, the colonies supplied cheap raw materials to the European imperial powers to feed their manufacturing industries. The manufactured goods were exported back to the colonies which served also as markets. This colonial relationship helped in the rapid capitalist development in the European countries while destroying the handicraft industries of the colonies and suppressing economic growth there.

Weber's thesis on Protestant ethic and the rise of Spirit of Capitalism has also been criticized on various accounts. Famous English historian R H Tawney has pointed out that the empirical evidence on which Weber's interpretation of Protestantism was based was too narrow. According to him, England was the first country to develop capitalism. However, the English Puritans did not believe in the doctrine of predestination. However, sympathisers of Weber argue that this criticism is based on the narrow interpretation of his work. They argue that it was only an ideal type construction which sought to establish a connection between certain aspects of Protestantism with only some aspects of early entrepreneurial type of capitalism. All that Weber was trying to say was that Protestant ethic contributed to the rationalization which preceded modern capitalism. At no stage did Weber claim it to be the sole cause. In fact, Weber did admit to the possibility of building other ideal types linking other contributory factors to capitalism. Thus Weber's thesis should not be treated as a general theory of capitalism development. It is more ideographic in nature. Further Weber clearly states that the spirit of capitalism was only one component, albeit an important one. There are other components too which together with the spirit constituted the modern capitalism. These components are private ownership of the means of production, technological development such as mechanization or automation, formally free labour, organization of capitalist producers into joint stock companies, a universalistic

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legal system which applied to everyone and is administered equitably, etc. All these elements together form the basis of the ideal type of modern capitalism.

Critics also point out that modern capitalism is no longer guided by inner worldly asceticism but hedonism. In this regard it can be stated that Weber in his work was only concerned with one dimension of capitalism, that is, the emergence of early capitalism and it link to the protest ethos. Weber had stated in his methodology that since social reality is infinite we can study social reality scientifically only with the help of ideal types. Further, he stressed on the fact given the infinite and dynamic nature of social reality, the researcher should only aim at limited generalisations. As far as the challenges of late capitalism are concerned, Weber did express his concern for the predomination of formal or instrumental rationality at the expense of substantive rationality.

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The Rules of Sociological Method (1895)

The Rules of Sociological Method was Durkheim's second major work. It was published in 1895 while he was at the University of Bordeaux. Largely a methodological study, the primary aim of this study was to outline the nature of sociological subject matter and to set out the steps of sociological investigation. As discussed earlier, Durkheim described 'social facts' in term of their exteriority, generality and constraint. He further argued that social facts are amenable to be studied by methods of positive sciences. Some of the important observations of Durkheim with regard to the scientific procedure to be adopted while studying social facts have been listed below:

i) Rules for the Observation of Social Facts

- Durkheim said that social facts must be treated as '*things*.' As 'things' they have to be studied by the empirical method and not by intuition.

- While studying social facts as 'things' all preconceptions must be eradicated. Sociologists must emancipate themselves from the common place ideas that dominate the mind of the layperson and adopt an emotionally neutral attitude towards what they set out to investigate.

- Observation of social facts should be confined to their external attributes only which can be tested and verified.

  In other words, when sociologists undertake the investigation of some order of social facts they must consider them from an aspect that is independent of their individual manifestations. The objectivity of social facts depends on their being separated from individual facts, which express them. Social facts provide a common standard for members of the society. Social facts exist in the form of legal rules, moral regulations, proverbs, social conventions, etc. It is these that sociologists must study to gain an understanding of social life.

- The observation and study of social facts should be as definite as possible. Here, Durkheim insisted upon the clear definition of the range or area of observation. This would ensure that knowledge about social facts can be progressively ever more exact.

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ii) Rules for Distinguishing between the Normal and the Pathological Social Facts

Having given us rules for the observation of social facts, Durkheim makes a distinction between 'normal' and 'pathological' social facts. He considers these aspects important because, as he points out, the scientific study of human beings has been held back to a large degree by the tendency of many writers to consider as 'pathological' forms of behaviour, which were different from their own. But Durkheim explains that the social fact is considered to be normal when it is understood in the context of the society in which it exists. He further adds that a social fact, which is 'general' to a given type of society, is 'normal' when it has utility for that societal type. In other words, this means that a normal social fact shall also be functional in the society in which it exists, while an abnormal or a pathological social fact shall have harmful consequences for the society.

As an illustration he cites the case of crime. We consider crime as pathological. But Durkheim argues that though we may refer to crime as immoral because it flouts values we believe in, from a scientific viewpoint it would be incorrect to call it abnormal. Firstly because crime is present not only in the majority of societies of one particular type but in all societies of all types. Secondly, if there were not occasional deviances or floutings of norms, there would be no change in human behaviour and equally important, no opportunities through which a society can either reaffirm the existing norms, or else reassess such behaviour and modify the norm itself. To show that crime is useful to the normal evolution of morality and law, Durkheim cites the case of Socrates, who according to Athenian law was a criminal, his crime being the independence of his thought. But his crime rendered a service to his country because it served to prepare a new morality and faith, which the Athenians needed. It also rendered a service to humanity in the sense that freedom of thought enjoyed by people in many countries today was made possible by people like him.

Durkheim was impressed by the way study of medicine had become scientific. The doctors study the normal working of the body and its pathological features. The study of both of these features helps one identify the nature of the body. He applied this method to study social facts. In his study of division of labour in society, he explained both, the normal as well as the abnormal features. He considered crime and punishment both as normal.

How is a social fact normal? When the rate of crime exceeds what is more or less constant for a given social type, then it becomes an abnormal or pathological fact. Similarly, using the same criteria, suicide is a normal social fact (though it may be regarded as 'wrong' or 'immoral' because it goes against a set of values that makes preservation of life absolute). But the sudden rise in the suicide rate in

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Western Europe during the nineteenth century was a cause for concern for Durkheim and one of the reasons why he decided to study this phenomenon.

iii) Rules for the Classification of Social Types

There have been two opposing conceptions of collective life among scholars. Some historians hold that each society is unique and so we cannot compare societies. On the other hand philosophers hold that all societies belong to one species - the human species and it is from the general attributes of human nature that all social evolution flows. Durkheim takes an intermediary position. He speaks of social species or social types. Though there is so much of diversity in social facts, it does not mean that they cannot be treated scientifically i.e. compared, classified and explained. If on the other hand, we speak of only one species we will be missing out in important qualitative differences and it will be impossible to draw them together.

Classification of societies into types is an important step towards explanation as problems and their explanations will differ for each type. It is also needed to decide whether a social fact is normal or abnormal, since a social fact is normal or abnormal only in relation to a given social type. Thus Durkheim attempts to outline a system for classifying societies according to their structure and complexity, a process Durkheim referred to as 'social morphology.' Durkheim advocated the use of *comparative method* to classify societies into a typology. He himself presented one based on the type of solidarity, viz., mechanical and organic solidarity.

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iv) Rules for the Explanation of Social Facts

There are two approaches, which may be used in the explanation of social facts - the causal and the functional. The former is concerned with explaining 'why' the social phenomenon in question exists. The latter involves explaining the functions the social phenomenon in question performs for the existence and stability of the society as a whole. In other words, functional explanation involves explaining the social phenomenon in terms of the needs it fulfils of the given social type.

Let us take an example of 'punishment' from the same work. Crime offends collective sentiments in a society, while the function of punishment is to maintain these sentiments at the same degree of intensity. If offences against them were not punished, the strength of the sentiments necessary for social unity would not be preserved. (It may be pointed out here that functionalism which was dominant in Sociology, particularly in the USA in the 1940s and 50s owes a lot to Durkheim's conception of function)

Durkheim further argues that since the subject matter of sociology has a social character, it is collective in nature, the explanation should also have a social character. Durkheim draws a sharp line between individual and society. Society is a separate reality from the individuals who compose it. It has its own characteristics. There exists a line between psychology and sociology. Any attempt to explain social facts directly in terms of individual characteristics or in terms of psychology would make the explanation false. Therefore in the case of causal explanation "the determining cause of a social fact should be sought among the social facts preceding it and not among the states of the individual consciousness". In the case of functional explanation, "the function of a social fact ought always to be sought in its relation to some social end."

The final point about Durkheim's logic of explanation is his stress upon the comparative nature of social science. To show that a given fact is the cause of another "we have to compare cases in which they are simultaneously present or absent, to see if the variations they present in these different combinations of circumstances indicate that one depends on the other." According to Durkheim, experimentation is the crucial method for testing theories in science. However, experimentation is not possible in sociology. Therefore, the comparative method is the closest alternative to experimentation, for testing sociological explanations. Since sociologists normally do not conduct labouratory-controlled experiments but study reported facts or go to the field and observe social facts, which have been spontaneously produced, they use the method of indirect experiment or the comparative method. The comparative method must be based upon the principle of concomitant variations. The comparative method is the very framework of the science of society for Durkheim. According to Durkheim, "comparative sociology

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is not a particular branch of sociology; it is sociology itself, in-so-far as it ceases to be purely descriptive and aspires to account for fact."

As can be seen from the above discussion, Durkheim, in order to establish sociology as a distinct scientific discipline, takes an extreme stance. This is reflected in his advocacy of positive science methodology to study social facts and, the definition of social facts in itself reflects his extreme sociological realism position. However, the positivists' emphasis on explaining a social phenomenon exclusively on the basis of its outwardly observable characteristics ignores the human side of social behaviour. This view fails to take into account the subjective dimension of human behaviour manifested in the unique meanings, choices and motives of an individual.

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Let us now discuss another important concept of Marx, **alienation**.

The term alienation has had long and varied use in many fields besides sociology, including philosophy, theology, law, and psychiatry. Alienation is a socio-psychological condition which denotes a state of 'estrangement' of individuals from themselves or from others, or from a specific situation or process. This concept gained currency in the writings of Hegel and was later developed by Feuerbach before Marx adopted it in his early writings.

According to Hegel, the noted German idealist philosopher, the ultimate purpose of human existence was to express the highest form of what he called the human Geist or 'Spirit'. This Spirit was not a physical or material entity but an abstract expression of the moral and ethical qualities and capacities, the highest cultural ideals, which, he argued, were the ultimate expression of what it is to be a human being. For Hegel, material life was the practical means through which this quest for the ultimate realisation of human consciousness, the search for a really truthful awareness of reality, could be expressed. Material life, and this included such things as the economy, the political institutions of the state and other social organisations in civil society, are a means to this higher end and not an end in themselves.

As discussed earlier, Hegel uses the concepts of sublation and estrangement to describe the sense of insecurity or unease that people might experience at moments when they recognize the shortcomings of their mental understanding of reality. For Hegel, estrangement was a cognitive or psychological state of being whose resolution depends on acquiring a more thorough understanding of what reality is and how individual consciousness comes to terms with its place within it. Hegel links the term alienation to the terms estrangement and objectification in his theory of development of the human mind. In labour, man is alienated from his humanity and becomes an object for himself. Thus, he becomes estranged from the social world he has created. At the same time, however, this estrangement and objectification are necessary element for the mind to learn to know itself by becoming something else, and man can abolish this alienation if the sees himself in his own objectification. Thus for Hegel, as Marx puts it, 'all estrangement of human nature is therefore nothing but estrangement of self-consciousness.'

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Several years before Marx wrote about alienated labour, Ludwig Feuerbach published *The Essence of Christianity* (1841). In this book Feuerbach not only criticized religion (as did most of the young Hegelians, including Marx and Engels), but he went a step further and tried to explain why it exists. Feuerbach bases religion in man's worldly existence and believes that, in religion, man expresses his dream of a different and better world. It is not God who has created man, as religion teaches, but it is man who has created (the concepts of) God. Man has objectified his own being in God and then provided his creation with a creative force of his own. In this way the object, the concept of God which is created by man, has become the subject and the true subject, man, has made himself an object. In this way, man has become estranged – alienated – from himself and, according to Feuerbach, religion expresses this alienation of man from himself.

For Hegal, alienation was a meta-physical concept. Marx transformed it in to a sociological one in his *The Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts* (1844). Here, in his analysis of alienation, Marx takes up Hegel's theory of the importance of human labour, but he rejects the idea of the existence of a superhuman spirit and the process of its development.

According to Marx, the course of human history involves a progressive development of the forces of production, a steady increase in man's control over nature. This is paralleled by a corresponding increase in man's alienation, an increase which reaches its height in capitalist society. Alienation is a situation in which the creations of man appear to him as alien objects. They are seen as independent from their creator and invested with the power to control him. Man creates his own society but will remain alienated until he recognizes himself within his creation. Until that time he will assign an independent existence to objects, ideas and institutions and be controlled by them. In the process he loses himself, he becomes a stranger in the world he has created, he becomes alienated. Religion provides an example of men's alienation. In Marx's view, 'Man makes religion, religion does not make man'. However, members of society fail to recognize that religion is of their own making. They assign to the gods an independent power, a power to direct their actions and shape their destiny. The more man invests in religion, the more he loses himself. In Marx's words, 'The more man puts into God, the less he retains of himself'. In assigning his own powers to supernatural beings, man becomes alienated from himself. Religion appears as an external force controlling man's destiny whereas, in reality, it is man-made. Religion, though, is a reflection of a more fundamental source of alienation. It is essentially a projection

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of the social relationships involved in the process of production. If man is to find himself and abolish the illusions of religion, he must 'abandon a condition which requires illusions'. He must therefore eradicate the source of alienation in the economic infrastructure.

In Marx's view, productive labour is the primary, most vital human activity. History begins when men actually produce their means of subsistence, when they begin to control nature. At a minimum this involves the production of food and shelter. Marx argues that, 'The first historical act is, therefore, the production of material life'. Production is a social enterprise since it requires cooperation. Men must work together to produce the goods and services necessary for life. From the social relationships involved in production develops a 'mode of life' which can be seen as an expression of these relationships. This mode of life shapes man's nature. In Marx's words, 'As individuals express their life so they are. What they are, therefore, coincides with their production, with what they produce and how they produce it'. Thus the nature of man and the nature of society as a whole derive primarily from the production of material life.

In Marx's view, productive labour is the primary, most vital human activity. According to Marx, man is essentially a creative being who realizes his essence and affirms himself in labour or production, a creative activity carried out in cooperation with other and by which the external world is transformed. The process of production involves transformation of human power into material objects or 'objectification' of human creative power. In other words, in the production of objects man 'objectifies' himself, he expresses and externalizes his being. However, if the objects of man's creation come to control his being, then man loses himself in the object. The act of production then results in man's alienation. This occurs when man regards the products of his labour as commodities, as articles for sale in the market place. The objects of his creation are then seen to control his existence. They are seen to be subject to impersonal forces, such as the law of supply and demand, over which man has little or no control. In Marx's words, 'the object that labour produces, its product, confronts it as an alien being, as a power independent of the producer'. In this way man is estranged from the object he produces, he becomes alienated form the most vital human activity, productive labour.

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Marx saw into important characteristics of industrial society – the mechanization of production and a further specialization of the division of labour – as contributing to the alienation of the work-force. However, he stressed that the capitalist economic system, rather than industrialization as such, is the primary source of alienation. In the capitalist society, division of labour and the institution of private property develop to their highest level and relations become contractual, consequently alienation also reaches the highest level. According to Marx, alienation reaches its height in capitalist society where labour is dominated by the requirements of capital, the most important of which is the demand for profit. These requirements determine levels of employment and wages, the nature and quantity of goods produced and their method of manufacture. The worker sees himself as a prisoner of market forces over which he has no control. He is subject to the impersonal mechanisms of the law of supply and demand. He is at the mercy of the periodic booms and slumps which characterize capitalist economies. The worker therefore loses control over the objects he produces and becomes alienated from his product and the act of production. His work becomes a means to an end, a means of obtaining money to buy the goods and services necessary for his existence. Unable to fulfill his being in the products of his labour, the worker becomes alienated from himself in the act of production. Therefore the more the worker produces, the more he loses himself. In Marx's words, 'the greater this product the less he is himself'.

According to Marx, alienation manifests itself in four ways:

Firstly, the worker is alienated from the product of his labour, since what he produces is appropriated by the capitalist and the worker has no control over it.

Secondly, the worker is alienated from the act of production itself because all decisions as to how production is to be organized are taken by the capitalist. For the worker, labour ceases to offer an intrinsic satisfaction and instead becomes only a means for survival. It becomes a compulsion forced from without and is no more an end in itself. In fact, work becomes a commodity to be sold and its only value to the worker is its saleability. The labour therefore is not voluntary but forced, it is *forced* labour.

Thirdly, in addition to the fact that wage labour alienates man from his product and his productive activity, which distinguishes him from animals, he also becomes alienated from his species. After all, according to Marx (and Hegel) his "species-being" is determined by his conscious productive activity, which is also a

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goal in itself. Under conditions of wage labour, however, labour is not a goal in itself, but only a means of maintaining life. This too means that what distinguishes man from animals, the free, conscious activity of life, disappears. In other words, according to Marx, man is distinguished from the animal by his creative ability to do labour but due to above mentioned aspects of alienation, man looses his distinctly human quality and gets alienated from his real human nature or his "species-being." The capitalist system stratifies man, destroys the human qualities and renders man to a state worse than animal. No animal has to work for its survival at other's bidding while man has to do that in a capitalist system.

Fourthly, the form of wage labour prevalent in the capitalist society also leads to social alienation. Consequently, man ultimately becomes alienated from that which is a product of his actions: society, as in the case of Feuerbach's concept of God, society becomes estranged from the individual and directed against him. "Society" then becomes a force that lives its own life over which no one has control. In other words, the worker in a capitalist system is also socially alienated, because social relations became market relations, in which each man is judged by his position in the market, rather than his human qualities. Capital accumulation generates its own norms which reduces people to the level of commodities. Workers become merely factors in the operation of capital and their activities are dominated by the requirements of profitability rather than by their human needs.

In Marx's view, the market forces which are seen to control production are not impersonal mechanisms beyond the control of man, they are man-made. Alienation is therefore the result of human activity rather than external forces with an existence independent of man. If the products of labour are alien to the worker, they must therefore belong to somebody. Thus Marx argues that, 'The alien being to whom the labour and the product of the labour belongs, whom the labour serves and who enjoys its product, can only be man himself. If the product of labour does not belong to the worker but stands over against him as an alien power, this is only possible in that it belongs to another man apart from the worker'. This man is the capitalist who owns and controls the forces of production and the products of labour, who appropriates for himself the wealth that labour produces. Alienation therefore springs not from impersonal market forces but from relationships between men. An end to alienation thus involves a radical change in the pattern of these relationships. This will come when the contradiction between man's consciousness and objective reality is resolved. Then man will realize that the

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situation in which he finds himself is man-made and therefore subject to change by human action.

Given the priority Marx assigns to economic factors, an end to alienation involves a radical change in the economic infrastructure. In particular, it requires the abolition of private property and its replacement by communal ownership of the forces of production, that is the replacement of capitalism by communism. In communist society conflicts of interest will disappear and antagonistic groups such as capitalists and workers will be a thing of the past. The products of labour will no longer be appropriated by some at the expense of others. With divisions in society eradicated, man will be at one with his fellows, a truly social being. As such he will not lose himself in the products of his labour. He will produce both for himself and others at one and the same time. In this situation 'each of us would have doubly affirmed himself and his fellow man'. Since he is at one with his fellows, the products of man's labour in which he objectifies himself will not result in the loss of self. In productive labour each member of society contributes to the well-being of all and so expresses both his individual and social being. The objects which he produces are owned and controlled at once by himself and his fellow man.

The critique of capitalism developed by the American economists Samuel Bowles and Herbert Gintis is strongly influenced by Marx's views. Like Marx they see capitalism as a repressive and exploitive system concerned with the maximization of profit rather than the satisfaction of human need. Following Marx, they argue that an understanding of the nature of work in capitalist society is only possible by seeing it in relation to the economic and social system in which it is set. Thus, what goes on in the workplace, the social organization of work, can only be explained by reference to the structure of class and power relationships in society as a whole. Bowles and Gintis's major contribution is their rejection of the view that the nature of work in capitalist society is shaped by the demands of efficiency and the requirements of technology. They claim that 'the alienated character of work as a social activity cannot be ascribed to the nature of "modern technology", but is, rather, a product of the class and power relations of economic life'.

Please note that the theory of alienation was unknown until the 1930s but, particularly since the 1960s, it has become extremely important and much discussed and used in so-called humanistic Marxism. It was used to criticize the

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"affluent society' of the Western world, but it was also used by many opposition figures in Western Europe who analyzed and criticized "actually existing socialism." Since Marx, 'alienation' has undergone a lot of change of meaning. It has become one of the important concepts in mainstream sociology, especially in the writings of the American sociologists of 50's and 60's. Let us now discuss the view of other scholars on alienation.

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Max Weber disagreed with Marx regarding the factors leading to alienation and believed that alienation was an inevitable feature of modern industrial society irrespective of whether the means of production are owned privately or collectively. For Weber the cause of alienation lies in the rationalization of social life and predominance of bureaucratic organizations in modern industrial societies. The compulsive conformity to impersonal rules in bureaucratic organizations renders people into mere cogs in giant machines and destroys their human qualities.

The American sociologist C. Wright Mills, in a study of the American middle classes entitled *White Collar*, applies Marx's concept of alienation to non-manual (white-collar) workers. Mills states that the expansion of the tertiary sector of the economy in advanced capitalist societies has led to a 'shift from skills with things to skills with persons'. Just as manual workers become like commodities by selling their 'skills with things', a similar process occurs when non-manual workers sell their 'skills with persons' on the open market. Mills refers to this sector of the economy as the 'personality market'. A market value is attached to personality characteristics and as a result people sell pieces of their personality. Therefore managers and executives are employed not simply because of their academic qualifications and experience but for their ability to get on with people. The salesman is given a job for his apparent warmth, friendliness and sincerity. However, because aspects of personality are bought and sold like any other commodity, individuals are alienated from their true selves. Their expression of personality at work is false and insincere. Mills gives the example of a girl working in a department store, smiling, concerned and attentive to the whims of the customer. He states, 'in the course of her work, because her personality becomes, the instrument of an alien purpose, the salesgirl becomes self-alienated'. At work she is not herself. In the salesroom, in the boardroom, in the staffroom, in the conference room, men and women are prostituting their personalities in pursuit of personal gain. Mills regards American society as a 'great salesroom' filled with hypocrisy, deceit insincerity. Rather than expressing their true personalities and feelings, people assume masks of friendliness, concern and interest in order to manipulate others to earn a living.

Similarly, the French sociologist and journalist Andre Gorz argues that alienation at work leads the worker to seek fulfillment in leisure. However, just as the capitalist system shapes his working day, it also shapes his leisure activities. It creates the passive consumer who finds satisfaction in the consumption of the

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product of the manufacturing and entertainment industries. Leisure simply provides a 'means of escape and oblivion', a means of living with the problem rather than an active solution to it. Thus in capitalist society, man is alienated from both work and leisure. The two spheres of life reinforce each other.

A similar picture is painted by Herbert Marcuse in *One Dimensional Man*, though his remarks apply to both capitalist and East European communist societies. Marcuse sees the potential for personal development crushed in advanced industrial society. Work is 'exhausting, stupefying, inhuman slavery'. Leisure simply involves 'modes of relaxation which soothe and prolong this stupefaction'. It is based on and directed by 'false needs' which are largely imposed by a mass media controlled by the establishment. Needs are false if they do not result in true self-fulfillment and real satisfaction. Marcuse claims that, 'Most of the prevailing needs to relax, to have fun, to behave and consume in accordance with the advertisements, to love and hate what others love and hate belong to this category of false needs'. Members of society no longer seek fulfillment in themselves and in their relationships with others. Instead, 'The people recognize themselves in their commodities; they find their soul in their automobile, hi-fi set, split-level home, kitchen equipment'. The circle is now complete: industrial man is alienated from every sphere of his life.

Marxian perspectives on the nature of work and leisure are open to a number of criticisms. Firstly, they are based partly on a rather vague picture of what man could and ought to be. It can be argued that this view says more about the values of particular sociologists than it does about man's essential being. Secondly, they tend to ignore the meanings held by members of society. If people claim fulfillment in work and/or leisure, there is a tendency to dismiss their views as a product of false class consciousness. Thirdly, Marxian perspectives are very general. As Alasdair Clayre notes, they tend to lump together diverse occupations and leisure activities and create a simple model of 'man in industrial society'.

Where Marx was pessimistic about the division of labour in society, Emile Durkheim (a functionalist) was cautiously optimistic. Marx saw the specialized division of labour trapping the worker in his occupational role and dividing society into antagonistic social classes. Durkheim saw a number of problems arising from specialization of industrial society but believed the promise of the division of labour outweighed the problems. Whereas Marx's solution to the problem of alienation was radical – the abolition of capitalism and its replacement by

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socialism – Durkheim believed that the solution to anomie can be provided within the existing framework of industrial society. He outlined his views in *The Division of Labour in Society*, first published in 1893. Durkheim saw alienation as a consequence of the condition of *anomie*, which refers to the breakdown of norms in society leading to experienced normlessness. You will learn about it more when we'll discuss the ideas of Emile Durkheim.

Another sociologist Melvin Seeman used the insights of Marx, Emile Durkheim and others to construct what is often considered a model to recognize the five prominent features of alienation: powerlessness, meaninglessness, normlessness, isolation and self-estrangement. However, Seeman simply treats them as subjective dispositions which can be measured with the help of attitude scales. Seeman later added a sixth element (cultural estrangement), although this element does not feature prominently in later discussions of his work. Seeman was part of a surge in alienation research during the mid-20th century when he published his paper, "*On the Meaning of Alienation*", in 1959.

An American sociologist, Robert Blauner, in his famous study entitled *Alienation and Freedom*, examines the behaviour and attitudes of manual workers in the printing, textile, automobile and chemical industries. He sees production technology as the major factor influencing the degree of alienation that workers experience. Blauner defines alienation as 'a general syndrome made up of different objective conditions and subjective feelings and states which emerge from certain relationships between workers and socio-technical settings of employment'. 'Objective conditions' refer mainly to the technology employed in particular industries. Blauner argues that technology largely determines the amount of judgement and initiative required from workers and the degree of control they have over their work. From an analysis of various forms of technology, he assesses the degree of alienation they produce. 'Subjective feelings and states' refer to the attitudes and feeling that workers have towards their work. This information is obtained from questionnaires.

Blauner considers workers' attitudes as a valid measure of their level of alienation. Thus if workers express satisfaction with their work, they are not alienated. He thus rejects Marxian views which argue that workers in capitalist society are automatically alienated because of their objective position in the relations of production. From a Marxian perspective, if workers express satisfaction with their jobs, this is an indication of false consciousness. Blauner

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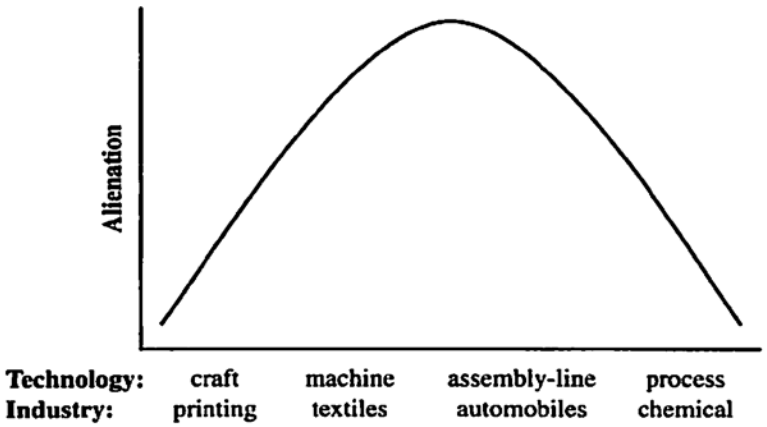
divides the concept of alienation into four dimensions: the degree of control workers have over their work; the degree of meaning and sense of purpose they find in work; the degree to which they are socially integrated into their work; and the degree to which they are involved in their work. In terms of these four dimensions, the alienated worker has a sense of powerlessness, meaninglessness, isolation and self estrangement.

Robert Blauner, on the basis of his findings, presented the relationship between technology and alienation in the form of an **inverted U-curve**. According to him, level of alienation is low in craft industries like printing but it increases in the machine-based textile industry. Blauner saw alienation reaching its height with mass production industry based on mechanized assembly line technology like automobile industry but in process industries with high degree of automation, alienation tends to decline because workers feel more involved and responsible.



Blauner's Model of Alienation

Please note that Blauner believes that automation reverses the 'historic trend' towards increasing alienation in manufacturing industry. It restores control, meaning, integration and involvement to the worker. Blauner examines work in the chemical industry which involves the most recent development in production technology. The oil and chemical industries employ automated continuous process technology whereby the raw materials enter the production process, the various stages of manufacture are automatically controlled and conducted by machinery, and the finished product emerges 'untouched by human hand'. Although the product is manufactured automatically, the worker has considerable control over and responsibility for production. Work in chemical plants involves monitoring and checking control dials which measure factors such as temperature and pressure. Readings indicate whether or not adjustments must be made to the

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process. Blauner states that these decisions require 'considerable discretion and initiative'. Work also involves the maintenance and repair of expensive and complicated machinery. Skilled technicians range freely over the factory floor; there is considerable variety in their work compared to the routine machine minding and assembly line production. In direct contrast to assembly line workers, none of the process workers felt they were controlled or dominated by their technology.

Compared to craft work, Blauner argues that in continuous process technology, 'the dominant job requirement is no longer manual skill but responsibility'. This emphasis on responsibility restores meaning and purpose to work; it is an 'important source of satisfaction and accomplishment'. Process technology halts the increasingly specialized division of labour. It integrates the entire production process and since workers are responsible for the overall process, they can see and appreciate their contribution to the finished product. Their sense of purpose is increased by the fact that process workers operate in teams with collective responsibility for the smooth running of the machinery. Again, this encourages the individual worker to feel a part of the overall production process.

However, as can be seen from the discussion above the latter-day meaning of alienation has undergone change. It is no longer based upon objective conditions alone rather it has come to be identified with subjective dispositions.

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Bureaucracy

As previously discussed, Max Weber has defined power as, "the chance of a man or a number of men to realize their own will in a communal action even against the resistance of others who are participating in the action." Power is therefore an aspect of social relationships. An individual or group do not hold power in isolation, they hold it in relation to others. Power is therefore power over others.

Depending on the circumstances surrounding its use, sociologists classify power in two categories. When power is used in a way that is generally recognized as socially right and necessary, it is called legitimate power. Power used to control others without the support of social approval is referred to as illegitimate power. Thus from legal point of view, power has been classified into legitimate and illegitimate power. **Authority** is that form of power which is accepted as legitimate, that is as right and just, and therefore obeyed on that basis. In other words, when the power is legitimized it becomes authority and only then it is accepted by people voluntarily. **Coercion** is that form of power which is not regarded as legitimate by those subject to it. For example, government agents demanding and receiving sales tax from a shopkeeper are using legitimate power; gangsters demanding and receiving protection money from the same shopkeeper by threat of violence are using illegitimate power.

Thus when power gets institutionalized and comes to be accepted as legitimate by those on whom it is being exercised, it is termed authority. Weber's study of authority has to be understood in the context of his general typology of social action. As discussed earlier, Weber built various ideal types of social action which are distinguished by the meanings on which they are based. These include traditional action, affective action, and rational action (both goal-rational and value rational).

Max Weber further argues that the nature of authority is shaped by the manner in which the legitimacy is acquired. Thus, Weber identifies three ideal types of authority systems viz., the traditional authority, the charismatic authority and the legal-rational authority.

The traditional authority is the characteristic of those societies where the 'traditional action' is predominant. Traditional action is based on established custom. An individual acts in a certain way because of an ingrained habit, because things have always been done that way. In those societies where traditional action is a predominant mode of behaviour, exercise of power is seen as legitimate when it is consonance with the tradition and conforms to the customary rules. Such type

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of authority was termed by Weber as traditional authority. Weber identified two forms of traditional authority i.e. patriarchalism and patrimonialism. In patriarchalism, authority is distributed on the basis of gerentocratic principles. Thus the right to exercise authority is vested in the eldest male member. This type of authority is to be found in case of very small scale societies like the Bushmen of Kalahari desert or in case of extended kin groups in agrarian societies like lineage or joint families in India.

When the patriarchal domination has developed by having certain subordinate sons of the patriarch or other dependents take over land and authority from the ruler, Weber calls this patrimonial domination and a patrimonial state can develop from it. In the patrimonial state, such as Egypt under the Pharaohs, ancient China, the Inca state, the Jesuit state in Paraguay, or Russia under the czars, the ruler controls his country like a giant princely estate. The master exercises unlimited power over his subjects, the military force, and the legal system. Patrimonial dominance is a typical example of the traditional exercise of power in which the legitimacy of the ruler and the relationships between him and his subjects are derived from tradition. Patrimonialism is characterized by the existence of hereditary office of a king or a chief and an administrative staff consisting of courtiers and favourites who together form a nascent bureaucracy. The king or the chief exercises absolute and arbitrary power, subject only to customary rules.

Second type of authority is charismatic authority which corresponds to affective action. Charisma refers to a certain quality of an individual's personality by virtue of which, he is set apart from ordinary men and treated as endowed with the supernatural, superhuman or at least specifically exceptional power or qualities. These qualities are not accessible to an ordinary person but are regarded as of divine origin and on the basis of them the individual concerned is treated as a leader and is revered. Charismatic type to authority can exist in all types of societies. Charismatic authority gains prominence in the times of crisis where other forms of authority prove inadequate to deal with the situation. Thus heroes who help to win the war or people with the reputation for therapeutic wisdom who come to regarded as saviours in times of epidemics and prophets in times of general moral crisis come to acquire charismatic authority.

Please note that the administrative staff of a charismatic leader does not consist of officials at least its members are not technically trained. It is not chosen to the basis of social privilege nor from the point of view of personal loyalty. It is rather chosen in terms of the charismatic qualities of its members. The prophet has his disciples, the war lord his selected henchmen, the leader generally his followers. There is no such thing as appointment, no career, no promotion. There is only a call at the instance of the leader on the basis of his charismatic qualities.

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There is no hierarchy, the leader merely intervenes in general or in individual cases when he considerers the members of his staff inadequate to a task which they have been entrusted with. Often there is no definite sphere of authority and of competence though there may be territorial mission. Also there is no such thing as salary or benefit. Disciplines or followers tend to live primarily in a communal relationship with their leader, means for which have been provided for by voluntary gifts. There is no system of formal rules or legal principles, or judicial process oriented to them.

Charismatic authority lies outside the realism of everyday routine and the profane sphere. In this respect it is sharply opposed, both to rational or bureaucratic authority and to traditional authority. Both bureaucratic and traditional authorities are bound by certain type of rules, while charismatic authority is foreign to all rules. Due to this freedom from established rules, charismatic authority can act as a great revolutionary force.

The charismatic movement, with its charismatic authority, differs on several important points from both traditional organizations and bureaucracies. Charisma is a force that is fundamentally outside everyday life and, whether it be religious or political charisma, it is a revolutionary force in history that is capable of breaking down both traditional and rational patterns of living; but charismatic domination is unstable in nature. The authority of the charismatic leader stems from "the supernatural, superhuman, or, at least, specifically exceptional powers" he possesses, at least in the eyes of his followers. This force lies outside the routines of everyday life, and the problem arises when this extraordinary force is to be incorporated into a routine everyday life. Weber calls this process the "routinization of charisma," which means that the leader (or if he is dead, his successor) and the followers want to make "it possible to participate in normal family relations or at least to enjoy a secure social position." When this happens, the charismatic message is changed into dogma, doctrine, regulations, law, or rigid tradition. The charismatic movement develops into either a traditional or a bureaucratic organization, "or a combination of both".

As stated earlier, charismatic authority is inherently unstable. This is on account of several reasons. Firstly, charismatic authority is the product of a crisis situation and therefore lasts so long as the crisis lasts. Once the crisis is over the charismatic authority has to be adapted to everyday matters. This is called the process of routinization of charisma. Thus charismatic authority may be transformed into either traditional or legal-rational authority. Secondly, one of the decisive motives underlying all cases of routinization of charisma is naturally the striving for security. This means legitimizing on one hand of the position of authority and on the other hand of the economic advantages enjoyed by the followers of the leader. Thirdly, another important motive, however, lies in the

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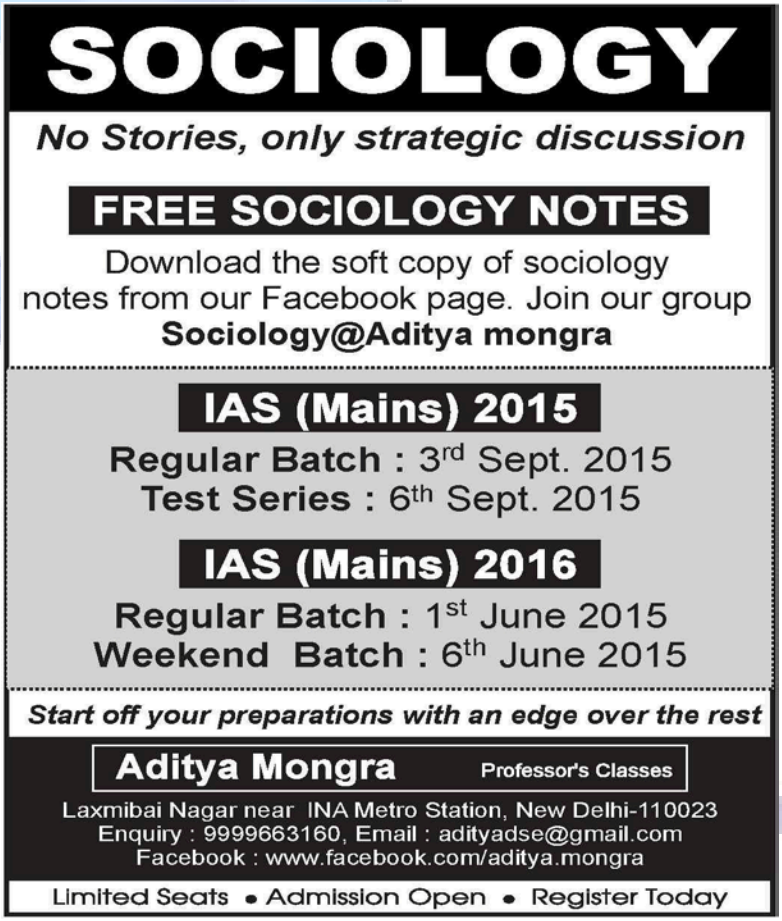
objective necessity of adaptation of the patterns of order, of the organization, and of the administrative staff to the normal, everyday needs and conditions of carrying on the administration. Finally, there is the problem of succession which renders charismatic authority unstable since basis of authority is the personal charisma of the leader. It is not easy to find a successor who also possesses those charismatic qualities. Thus in charismatic authority, discontinuity is inevitable. One of the solutions to the problem of discontinuity is to transform the charisma of the individual into the charisma of the office which can be translated to every incumbent of the office by ritual means. Most important example is the transmission of the charisma of a royal authority by anointing and by coronation. This ideal type of charismatic authority is extremely helpful in the study of radical transformation of traditional societies like Russia, China, India, Egypt and other Third World countries. All these societies had charismatic leaders to meet the crisis of transition. Thus you can understand the significance and nature of the authority exercised by Gandhi in India, Lenin in Russia, Mao in China and Nasser in Egypt.



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The third ideal type of authority, which corresponds to rational action, is legal-rational authority or bureaucracy. Having begun to define modern society in terms of the spread of instrumental rationality, Weber goes on to argue that as society becomes more and more complex (both in terms of its economics arrangements, and in terms of its increasing institutional sophistication), the quest for an appropriately rational means of organisation also becomes increasingly urgent. Since the most rational means of organisation is bureaucratic organisation, he felt it was inevitable that bureaucracy would become an ever more dominant feature of modern society. The importance of this development for Weber's social theory is that bureaucracy provides a fine example of a technique of formal rationality that is found in all spheres of social life. In fact, whether in the economy or in the legislative and administrative functions of the state, progress comes to depend on the availability of bureaucratic means of organisation and administration.

In other words, according to Weber, all societies are gradually moving away from traditional type of authority to legal-rational type of authority. Europe was the first to experience this transformation. But, Weber regarded those processes as inevitable in all societies advancing towards industrial civilization. In industrial societies, rational action becomes the most predominant form of social behaviour. Weber has termed this process of increasing preponderance of rational action as rationalization. With increasing rationalization, legal-rational authority becomes the most common form of authority system.

Legal-rational authority differs sharply from its charismatic and traditional counterparts. Legitimacy and control stem neither from the perceived personal qualities of the leader and the devotion they exercise, nor from a commitment to traditional wisdom. Authority is based on the acceptance of a set of impersonal rules. Those who possess authority are able to issue commands and have them obeyed because other accepts the legal framework which supports their authority. Thus a judge, a tax inspector or military commander are obeyed not on the basis of tradition or as a result of their charisma but because of the acceptance of legal statuses and rules which grant them authority and define the limits of that authority. These rules are rational in the sense that they are consciously constructed for the attainment of a particular goal and they specify the means by which that goal is to be attained. As Weber's view of rational action suggested, precise calculation and systematic assessment of the various means of attaining a goal are involved in the construction of rules form the basis of legal- rational authority.

Like other forms of authority, legal-rational authority produces a particular kind of organizational structure – the bureaucracy. Weber defined bureaucracy as, "a hierarchical organization designed rationally to coordinate work of many individuals in the pursuit of large-scale administrative tasks and organizational

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goals. Weber constructed an ideal type of the rational-legal bureaucratic organization. He argued that bureaucracies in modern industrial societies are steadily moving towards his pure type.

The main characteristics of the ideal-type bureaucracy as envisaged by Weber can be summarised as follows:

- Bureaucracy is an expert system of administration based on detailed documentation and record-keeping. The regular activities required for the purposes of the organizations are distributed in a fixed way as **official duties**. Each administrative official has a clearly defined area of competence and responsibility.
- Bureaucracies have a rigidly **hierarchical organisational structure** with clear lines of communication and responsibility.
- The operation of bureaucracy is governed by a **legalistic framework** of formal rules and regulations.
- Decisions are made through the application of specific procedures designed to **eliminate subjective judgements**. The legitimacy of bureaucracy and of bureaucrats is based on a strict separation of individual personality from the task being done. The ideal official performs his duties in a spirit of formalistic impersonality, without hatred or passion. The activities of a bureaucrat are governed by the rules, not by personal consideration such as his feeling towards colleagues or clients. His actions are therefore rational rather than affective. Business is conducted according to calculable rules and without regard for persons.
- Authority is a characteristic of the post not of the post holder.
- It is not possible to become a bureaucrat without the correct formal qualifications and credentials. Officials are appointed on the basis of **technical knowledge** and **expertise**. Weber states, "Bureaucratic administration means fundamentally the exercise of control on the basis of knowledge. This is the feature which makes it specifically rational." Thus official are selected in terms of the contribution their particular knowledge and skills can make to the realization of organizational goals. Once appointed, the official is full time paid employee and his occupation constitutes a career. Promotion being based on seniority or achievement or a combination of both.
- Finally, bureaucratic administration involves **a strict separation between private and official incomes**. The official does not own any part of the organization for which he works nor can he use his position for private gain. In Weber's words, bureaucracy segregates official activity as something distinct from the sphere of private life.

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The ideal type is most closely approximated in capitalist industrial society where it becomes the major form of organization control. The development of bureaucracy is due to its 'technical superiority' compared to organizations based on charismatic and traditional authority. In Weber's words, "the decisive reason for the advance of bureaucratic organization has always been its purely technical superiority over any other form of organisation". This superiority stems from the combination of specialist skills being subordinated to the goals of the organization. It drives from the exclusion of personal emotions and interests which might detract from the attainment of those goals. It results from a set of rational rules designed explicitly to further the objectives of the organization. Compared to other forms of organizations, tasks in a bureaucracy are performed with greater precision and speed, with less friction and lower costs.

Although Weber appreciated the technical advantages of bureaucratic organization, he was also aware of its disadvantages. He saw the strict control of human freedom and the uniform and rational procedures of bureaucratic practice as preventing spontaneity, creativity and individual initiative. The impersonality of official conduct tends to produce specialists without spirit. Weber foresaw the possibility of men trapped in their specialized routines with little awareness of the relationship between their jobs and the organization as a whole. Weber saw the danger of bureaucrats becoming preoccupied with uniformity and order, of losing sight of all else, becoming dependent on the security provided by their highly structured niche in the bureaucratic machine.

Even the level of formal rationality, however, Weber felt problems were likely to arise because few bureaucracies ever match up to the ideal type. The substance of many decisions is likely to be based on subjective judgement, even if the process is intended to prevent this. Sometimes rule-governed procedures can become rule-bound in the sense that too much red tape prevents decisions being made quickly. Even more seriously, to the extent that the personal career interests of bureaucrats depend on the status of the bureaucracy itself, they have a vested interest in putting the particular aim of increasing the power and authority of the bureaucracy ahead of the universal ends that were supposed to be served by the bureaucracy. Civil servants might become more concerned with protecting the status of the civil service, even of one government department against another, than with delivering a decent service to the public.

In terms of its political and cultural impact, Weber was also very concerned that bureaucracy has irrational tendencies in the sense that it might override individual freedom and integrity. Based on his own analysis of what was happening in German society during the 1890s, he feared that as more and more aspects of the decision-making process became gathered into fewer and fewer hands, bureaucracies, and the bureaucrats who ran them, would smother personal

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freedoms resulting in the emergence of what he famously called 'a new iron cage of serfdom'. In the political sphere, the turn towards democracy also meant the spread of detailed procedures for conducting democratic elections, which in turn entailed greater reliance on the electoral process and electoral officials. Consequently, democratization of a state also means bureaucratization, particularly since modern political parties themselves are developing more and more into bureaucratic organizations. This tension between the wider purposes (substantive rationality) of the political process, and the narrow functional priorities (formal rationality) of bureaucracy, is a good example of the kind of value conflict we discussed earlier.

Weber was greatly concerned that aided by the increasing centralisation of authority, a new class of professional bureaucrats might be tempted to subvert bureaucratic authority for their own ends. His major reservations about the prospects of a socialist Germany were less to do with the values of the socialist belief system, than with the practical problems it would create through the yet further bureaucratisation of society. As it turned out, the concerns expressed by Weber were amply substantiated in respect of the version of socialist/communist society that emerged as the Soviet Union during the 20th century. This society was profoundly criticised because of the way the bureaucracies of party, state and military contrived, so it seemed, to deprived citizens of representation, right and liberty.

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Despite his foreboding, Weber believes that bureaucracy was essential to the operation of large scale industrial societies. In particular, he believed that the state and economic enterprise could not function effectively without bureaucratic control. It therefore made little sense to try and dispense with bureaucracy. However, Weber was fearful to the end to which bureaucratic organizations could be directed. They represented the most complete and effective institutionalization of power so far created. In Weber's view, bureaucracy has been and is a powerful instrument of the first order, for the one who controls the state bureaucratic administration. He saw two main dangers if this control was left in the hands of bureaucrats themselves. Firstly, particularly in times of crisis bureaucratic leadership would be ineffective. Bureaucrats are trained to follow order and conduct routine operations rather than to make policy decisions and take initiatives in response to a crisis. Secondly, in capitalist society, top bureaucrats may be swayed by the pressure of capitalist interests and tailor their administrative practices to fit the demands of capital.

Weber believed that these dangers could only be avoided by the strong parliamentary control of the state bureaucracy. In particular, professional politicians must hold the top positions in various departments of the state. This will encourage strong and effective leadership since politicians are trained to take decisions. In addition, it will help to open the bureaucracy to public view and reveal any behind the scenes wheeling and dealing between bureaucrats and powerful interests. Politicians are public figures, open to public scrutiny and the criticism of opposition parties. They are therefore accountable for their actions.

But even with politicians at the head of state bureaucracies, problems remain. The professional politician lacks the technical knowledge controlled by the bureaucracy and may have little awareness of its inner working and procedures. He is largely dependent on information supplied to him by bureaucrats and upon their advice as to the feasibility of the measures he wishes to take. He may well end up being directed by the bureaucrats. **Seymour M. Lipset** shows that it is possible for government bureaucracy to exercise considerable control over its 'political masters' in his study of the Cooperative Commonwealth Federation (CCF), a socialist government, in the Canadian province of Saskatchewan. Lipset found that the entrenched bureaucracy was successfully able to scuttle the reformist policies of this new socialist government. People's representatives appointed as ministers to control the bureaucracy proved ineffective.

Lipset's study illustrates Weber's fears of the power of bureaucrats to act independently from their "political masters". Weber believed that only strong parliamentary government could control state bureaucracy. He suggested that state bureaucrats should be made directly and regularly accountable to parliament for their action. The procedure for doing this is the parliamentary committee which

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would systematically cross-examine top civil servants. In Weber's view, 'This alone guarantees public supervision and a through inquiry.

Weber's view of bureaucracy is ambivalent. He recognized its 'technical superiority' over all other forms of organization. He believed that it was essential for the effective operation of large-scale industrial society. While he saw it as a threat to responsible government, he believed that this threat could be countered by strong political control. However, he remained pessimistic about the consequences of bureaucracy for human freedom and happiness.

Much of the later research on organizations can be seen as a debate with Weber. Students of organizations have refined, elaborated and criticized his views. In particular, they question the proposition that bureaucracy organized on the lines of the Weber's ideal type is the most efficient way of realizing organizational goals. It has been argued that certain aspects of the ideal type bureaucracy may in practice, reduce organizational efficiency. The critical remarks of some of the important scholars have been discussed below.

For example, in contrast to Weber's ideal type of bureaucracy and his stress on formal and contractual relationships, **Robert E. Cole** in his study *Japanese Blue Collar: The Changing Tradition* states that Japan has been able to achieve high industrial growth by harmonically synthesising the traditional familial structures, loyalty and paternalistic attitude of the management with the demands of the industry.

In an article entitled, *Bureaucratic Structure and Personality*, **Robert K. Merton** argues that certain aspects of bureaucratic procedure may be dysfunctional to the organization. In particular, they may encourage behaviour which inhibits the realization of organizational goals.

Firstly, the bureaucrat is trained to comply strictly with the rules but, when situations arise which are not covered by the rules this training may lead to inflexibility and timidity. The bureaucrat has not been taught to improvise and innovate and in addition he may well be afraid to do so. His career incentives such as promotions are designed to reward conformity. Thus he may not be inclined to bend the rules even when such actions might further the realization of organizational goals.

Secondly, the devotion to the rules encouraged in bureaucratic organization may lead to a displacement of goals. There is a tendency for conformity to official regulation to become an end in itself rather than the means to an end. That in this way, so called bureaucratic red tape may stand in the way of providing and efficient service for the clients of the organization.

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Thirdly, the emphasis on impersonality in bureaucratic procedures may lead to friction between officials and the public. For example, patients in a hospital or unemployed youth in an employment exchange may expect concern and sympathy for their particular problems. The businesslike and impartial treatment they might receive can lead to bureaucrats being seen as cold, unsympathetic, abrupt and even arrogant. As a result, clients sometimes feel that they have been badly served by bureaucracies. While agreeing that the various elements of bureaucracy outlined in Weber's ideal type serve to further organizational efficiency, Merton maintains that they inevitably produce dysfunctional consequences. He suggests that 'the very elements which conduce towards efficiency in general produce inefficiency in specific instances'.

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Weber presented an ideal type bureaucracy and argued that organizations in modern industrial society were increasingly moving towards that model. However, he had little to say about why actual organizations varied in terms of their approximation of the ideal type apart from suggesting that bureaucracy was particularly suited to the administration of routine tasks. Alvin W. Gouldner's study of gypsum plant in the USA seeks to explore this problem. It is concerned to 'clarify some of the social processes leading to different degrees of bureaucratization'.

Alvin Ward Gouldner (1920 – 1980), an American sociologist, carried out an intensive analysis of one plant owned and operated by the General Gypsum Company. The plant consisted of two parts, a gypsum mine and a factory making wallboards for which gypsum is a major ingredient. There was a significant difference in the degree of bureaucratization between the mine and the factory. In the mine the hierarchy of authority was less developed, the division of labour and spheres of competence were less explicit, there was less emphasis on official rules and procedures and less impersonality both in relationships between workers and between them and the supervisors. Since, in Gouldner's view, these elements are 'the stuff of which bureaucracy is made', then 'bureaucratic organization was more fully developed on the surface than in the mine'. The following example illustrates this point.

In the mine, supervisors usually issued only general instructions leaving it to the miners to decide who was to do the job and how it was to be done. If a miner wanted assistance, he rarely went through the 'proper channels' to obtain orders to direct others to assist him. He simply asked his workmates for help. Official duties were not clearly defined. Miners rotated jobs amongst themselves and often repaired machinery, a job which in the factory was the clear prerogative of the maintenance engineer. Lunch hours were irregular, varying in length and the time at which they were taken. Supervisors accepted and worked within this informal organization. They were 'one of the lads' and placed little emphasis on their officially superior status. One miner summarized the situation as follows, 'Down here we have no rules. We are our own bosses'. By comparison, the factory was considerably more bureaucratic. The hierarchy of authority, the division of labour, official rules and procedures and impersonality, were more widespread and developed.

Gouldner gives the following reasons for the difference in degrees of bureaucratization between mine and surface. Work in the mine was less predictable. The miners had no control over the amount of gypsum available and could not predict various dangers such as cave-ins. No amount of official procedures could control such factors. Miners often had to make their own

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decisions on matters which could not be strictly governed by official rules, for example, strategies for digging out the gypsum and propping up the roof. Since the problems they encountered did not follow a standard pattern, a predetermined set of rules was not suitable for their solution. By comparison, the machine production of wallboard in the factory followed a standard routine and could therefore be 'rationalized' in terms of a bureaucratic system. Fixed rules and a clearly defined division of labour are more suited to predictable operations. The ever present danger in the mine produced strong work group solidarity which in turn encouraged informal organization. Miners depended on their workmates to warn them of loose rocks and to dig them out in the event of a cave-in. In the words of one old miner, 'Friends or no friends, you *got* all to be friends'. A cohesive work group will tend to resist control from above and to institute its own informal work norms.

Part of Gouldner's study is concerned with the arrival of a new manager at the gypsum plant. He came with instructions from head office to cut costs and raise productivity. From the start he attempted to abolish unofficial practices, insisted on the rigorous application of formal rules and instituted a set of new rules which severely limited the workers' autonomy – for example they were not allowed to move round the factory at will. Rule breaking was to be reported to the appropriate authorities, official reports of the details were to be passed up the administrative hierarchy and punishments were to be strictly imposed in accordance with the rules. The new manager thus attempted to increase the degree of bureaucratization in the plant. Gouldner argues that management will tend to do this when it believes that workers are not fulfilling their work roles. The degree to which it achieves this will depend on the 'degree of bureaucratic striving on management's part' and the 'degree of resistance to bureaucratic administration among the workers.'

Despite the forceful attempts of the new manager to impose a strongly bureaucratic system, it was effectively opposed by the miners. Gouldner attributes their success to strong work groups solidarity. They were able to present a united front to management and frustrate many of its demands. In addition, the miners' immediate supervisors, who worked with them underground, were also opposed to the new system. They believed that the miners should be exempt from certain rules and that this privilege was justified by the dangers of the job.

A number of tentative conclusions may be drawn from Gouldner's study. Firstly, bureaucratic administration is more suited to some tasks than others. In particular, it is not well suited to non-routine, unpredictable operations. Secondly, the advance of bureaucracy is not inevitable as Weber and others have implied. As the case of the gypsum miners indicates, it can be successfully resisted. Thirdly, Gouldner suggests that sociologists who are concerned with a utopian vision which

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involves the abolition of bureaucracy would be more fruitfully employed in identifying 'these social processes creating variations in the amount and types of bureaucracy. For these variations do make a vital difference in the lives of men'. By directing their research to this area, sociologists may be able to give direction to those who wish to create organizations with greater democracy and freedom.

In his major work, *Patterns of Industrial Bureaucracy* (1954), Gouldner lead an ethnographic study in a mine and identified there various patterns of bureaucracy and bureaucratization. He analyzed how, after the appointment of a new manager the bureaucratization process emerged. Gouldner identified three types of bureaucracy in his studies, with very specific patterns. These are:

- Mock bureaucracy
- Representative bureaucracy
- Punishment-centered bureaucracy.

Mock bureaucracy: This type comes from outside agency and is implemented officially, but not in daily behaviors. Both management and workers agree in this case to act the same way. The rules are not enforced in this case, neither by management, nor by the workers. No conflict seem to emerge in this case. "Smoking" is in this case seen as inevitable. The "no-smoking rule" is an example of mock-bureaucracy.

Representative bureaucracy: Both management and workers enforced this rule and it generated very few tensions. In this context, the focus was on the education of workers as management considered them as ignorant and careless regarding security rules. The safety program is an example of representative. Meetings happened regularly to implement this program and it was as well the occasion to voice some concerns for workers. For the management, this program was a way to tighten the control over workers.

Punishment-centered bureaucracy: This type of program was initiated by management and generated many tensions. Management viewed workers as deliberately willing to be absent. Therefore, punishment was installed in order to force the workers not to be absent. For example, the "no-absenteeism" rule is an example of the punishment-centered bureaucracy.

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Summary of factors associated with the three patterns of bureaucracy:

1. *Who Usually Initiates the Rules?*

Mock bureaucracy: The rule or rules are imposed on the group by some "outside" agency. Neither workers nor management, neither superiors nor subordinates, identify themselves with or participate in the establishment of the rules or view them as their own. For example, the "no-smoking" rule was initiated by the insurance company.

Representative bureaucracy: Both groups initiate the rules and view them as their own. For example, pressure was exerted by union and management to initiate and develop the safety programme. Workers and supervisors could make modifications of the program at periodic meetings.

Punishment-centered bureaucracy: The rule arises in response to the pressure of either workers or management, but is not jointly initiated by them. The group which does not initiate the rule views it as imposed upon it by the other. For example, through their union the workers initiated the bidding system. Supervisors viewed it as something to which the Company was forced to adhere.

2. *Whose Values Legitimate the Rules?*

Mock bureaucracy: Neither superiors nor subordinated can, ordinarily, legitimate the rule in terms of their own values.

Representative bureaucracy: Usually, both workers and management can legitimate the rules in terms of their own key values. For example, management legitimated the safety program by tying it to production. Workers legitimized it via their values on personal and bodily welfare, maintenance of income, and cleanliness.

Punishment-centered bureaucracy: Either superiors or subordinates alone consider the rule legitimate; the other may concede on grounds of expediency, but does not define the rule as legitimate. For example, workers considered the bidding system "fair", since they viewed it as minimizing personal favoritism in the distribution of jobs. Supervisors conformed to it largely because they feared the consequences of deviation.

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3. *Whose Values Are Violated by Enforcement of the Rules?*

Mock bureaucracy: Enforcement of the rule violates the values of both groups. For example, if the no-smoking rule were put into effect, it would violate the value on "personal equality" held by workers and supervisors, since office workers would still be privileged to smoke.

Representative bureaucracy: Under most conditions, enforcement of the rules entails violations of neither group's values. For example, it is only under comparatively exceptional circumstances that enforcement of the safety rules interfered with a value held by management, say, a value on production.

Punishment-centered bureaucracy: Enforcement of the rules violates the values of only one group, either superiors or subordinates. For example, the bidding rules threatened management's value on the use of skill and ability as criteria for occupational recruitment.

4. *What Are the Standard Explanations of Deviations from the Rules?*

Mock bureaucracy: The deviant pattern is viewed as an expression of "uncontrollable" needs or of "human nature". For example, people were held to smoke because of "nervousness."

Representative bureaucracy: Deviance is attributed to ignorance or well-intentioned carelessness – i.e. it is an unanticipated byproduct of behaviour oriented to some other end and thus an "accident". This we call a "utilitarian" conception of deviance. For example, violation of the safety rule might be seen as motivated by concern for production, rather than by a deliberate intention to have accidents. If, for example, a worker got a hernia, this might be attributed to his ignorance of proper lifting technique.

Punishment-centered bureaucracy: In the main, deviance is attributed to deliberate intent. Deviance is thought to be the deviant's end. This we call a "voluntaristic" conception of deviance. For example, when a worker was absent without an excuse, this was not viewed as an expression of an uncontrollable impulse, or as unanticipated consequence of other interests. It was believed to be willful.

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5. *What Effect Do the Rules Have Upon the Status of the Participants?*

Mock bureaucracy: Ordinarily, deviation from the rule is status-enhancing for workers and management both. Conformance to the rule would be status impairing for both. For example, violation of the no-smoking rule tended to minimize the visibility of status differentials, by preventing the emergence of a privileged stratum of smokers.

Representative bureaucracy: Usually, deviation from the rules impairs the status of superiors and subordinates, while conformance ordinarily permits both a measure of status improvement. For example, the safety program increased the prestige of workers' job by improving the cleanliness of the plant (the "good housekeeping" component), as well as enabling workers to initiate action for their superiors through the safety meetings. It also facilitated management's ability to realize its production obligations, and provided it with legitimations for extended control over the worker.

Punishment-centered bureaucracy: Conformance to or deviation from the rules leads to status gains either for workers or supervisors, but not for both, and to status losses for the other. For example, workers' conformance to the bidding system allowed them to escape from tense relations with certain supervisors or to secure jobs and promotions without dependence upon supervisory favors. It deprived supers of the customary prerogative of recommending workers for promotion or for hiring.

6. *Summary of Defining Characteristics or Symptoms*

Mock bureaucracy:

(a) Rules are neither enforced by management nor obeyed by workers.

(b) Usually entails little conflict between the two groups.

(c) Joint violation and evasion of rules is buttressed by the informal sentiments of the participants.

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Representative bureaucracy:

(a) Rules are both enforced by management and obeyed by workers.

(b) Generates a few tensions, but little overt conflict.

(c) Joint support for rules buttressed by informal sentiments, mutual participation initiation, and education of workers and management.

Punishment-centered bureaucracy:

(a) Rules either enforced by workers or management, and evaded by the other.

(b) Entails relatively great tension and conflict.

(c) Enforced by punishment and supported by the informal sentiments of either workers or management.

This completes our discussion on Gouldner's contributions in facilitating our understanding of the various patterns of industrial bureaucracy. In response to Weber's ideal type of bureaucracy, Gouldner argued that bureaucracy may manifest different patterns under different contexts.

Gouldner's conclusions are supported by the findings of research by **Tom Burns** and **G.M. Stalker**. From a study of twenty Scottish and English firms, mainly in the electronics industry, Burns and Stalker argue that bureaucratic organizations are best suited to dealing with predictable, familiar and routine situations. They are not well suited to the rapidly changing technical and commercial situation of many sectors of modern industry such as the electronics industry. Since change is the hallmark of modern society, bureaucratic organizations may well be untypical of the future.

Burns and Stalker construct two ideal types of organization which they term '**mechanistic**' and '**organic**'. The firms in their research range between these extremes. The mechanistic organization is very similar to Weber's model of bureaucracy. It includes a specialized division of labour with the rights and duties of each employee being precisely defined. Specialized tasks are coordinated by a management hierarchy which directs operations and takes major decisions. Communication is mainly vertical: instructions flow downward through a chain of command, information flows upward and is processed by various levels in the

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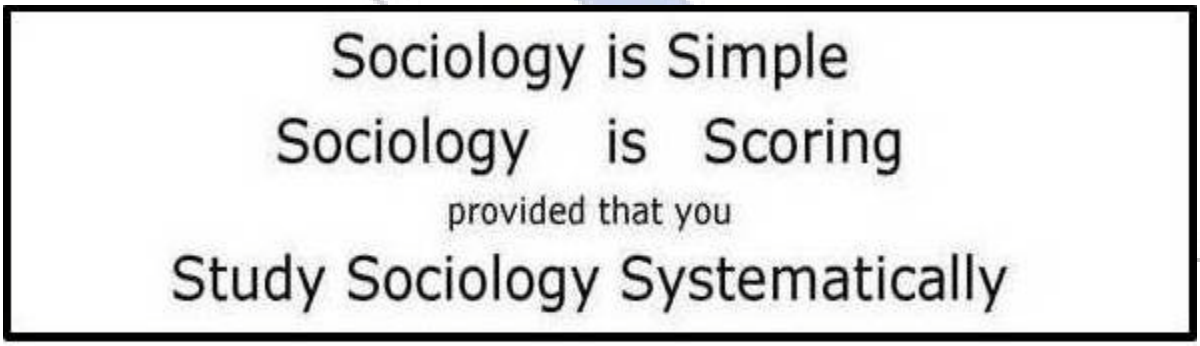
hierarchy before it reaches the top. Each individual in the organization is responsible for discharging his particular responsibility and no more.

By comparison, areas of responsibility are not clearly defined in organic organizations. The rigid hierarchies and specialized divisions of labour of mechanistic systems tend to disappear. The individual's job is to employ his skills to further the goals of the organization rather than simply carry out a predetermined operation. When a problem arises, all those who have knowledge and expertise to contribute to its solution meet and discuss. Tasks are shaped by the nature of the problem rather than being predefined. Communication consists of consultation rather than being predefined. Communication consists of consultation rather than command, of 'information and advice rather than instructions and decisions'. Although a hierarchy exists, it tends to become blurred as communication travels in all directions and top management no longer has the sole prerogative over important decisions nor is it seen to monopolize the knowledge necessary to make them. Burns and Stalker argue that mechanistic systems are best suited to stable conditions, organic systems to changing conditions.

Weber has often been criticized for focusing exclusively on the formal structure of bureaucracy, that is the official rules and procedures, the authorized hierarchy of offices and the official duties attached to them. His critics have argued that unofficial practices are an established part of the structure of all organizations. They must therefore be included in an explanation of the functioning of organizations. **Peter Blau** claims that Weber's approach 'implies that any deviation from the formal structure is detrimental to administrative efficiency'. However, on the basis of his study of the functioning of a federal law enforcement agency in Washington DC, Peter Blau argues that the presence of both formal and informal structures in the organization may together enhance the efficiency of the organization. On the other hand, the presence of formal structures alone, may act as a hindrance towards the attainment of organizational goals.



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Content Analysis

Bernard Berelson defined content analysis as "a research technique for the objective, systematic, and quantitative description of manifest content of communications." Content analysis is a research tool focused on the actual content and internal features of media. It is used to determine the presence of certain words, concepts, themes, phrases, characters, or sentences within texts or sets of texts and to quantify this presence in an objective manner.

Content analysis or textual analysis is a methodology in the social sciences for studying the content of communication. Earl Babbie defines it as "the study of recorded human communications, such as books, websites, paintings and laws". Harold Lasswell formulated the core questions of content analysis: "Who says what, to whom, why, to what extent and with what effect?" Ole Holsti offers a broad definition of content analysis as "any technique for making inferences by objectively and systematically identifying specified characteristics of messages."

In simple words, content analysis is a research tool used to determine the presence of certain words or concepts within texts or sets of texts. Researchers quantify and analyze the presence, meanings and relationships of such words and concepts, then make inferences about the messages within the texts, the writer(s), the audience, and even the culture and time of which these are a part. Texts can be defined broadly as books, book chapters, essays, interviews, discussions, newspaper headlines and articles, historical documents, speeches, conversations, advertising, theatre, informal conversation, or really any occurrence of communicative language. To conduct a content analysis on any such text, the text is coded, or broken down, into manageable categories on a variety of levels – word, word sense, phrase, sentence, or theme – and then examined using one of content analysis' basic methods: conceptual analysis or relational analysis. Conceptual analysis can be thought of as establishing the existence and frequency of concepts in a text. Relational analysis builds on conceptual analysis by examining the relationships among concepts in a text.

Content analysis is a product of the electronic age. Though content analysis was regularly performed in the 1940s, it became a more credible and frequently used research method since the mid-1950s, as researchers started to focus on concepts rather than simply words, and on semantic relationships rather than just presence. While both traditions still continue today, content analysis now is also utilized to explore mental models, and their linguistic, affective, cognitive, social, cultural and historical significance. Due to the fact that it can be applied to examine any piece of writing or occurrence of recorded communication, content

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analysis is used in large number of fields, ranging from marketing and media studies, to literature and rhetoric, ethnography and cultural studies, gender and age issues, sociology and political science, psychology and cognitive science, as well as other fields of inquiry.

For example, in a research project on gender issues, the content of the text books (particularly the stories) was analysed and it was found that how gender relations prevailing in our society manifested themselves as well as got reinforced by the gender roles described in the various stories. The girl child often was depicted as an obedient child, helping the mother in the household chores. On the other hand, the boy was often portrayed as school going, naughty, and aiming high in life. Similarly, the content analysis of the local newspapers in rural hinterland could throw light on the prevailing caste relations and the nature of the caste conflict.

Bernard Berelson has identified the various uses of content analysis. Some of them are listed below:

- Reveal international differences in communication content
- Detect the existence of propaganda
- Identify the intentions, focus or communication trends of an individual, group or institution
- Describe attitudinal and behavioural responses to communications
- Determine psychological or emotional state of persons or groups

Content analysis offers several advantages to researchers who consider using it. In particular, content analysis:

- is an unobtrusive means of analyzing interactions. One of the significant advantages of content analysis is that it is an *unobtrusive* method, *i.e.*, it has no effect on the subject being studied. In other methods (like interview, observation, experiment, etc.), the researcher is directly involved with persons. Content analysis eliminates the source of 'response bias' that threatens research whenever the respondents are directly questioned or observed.
- looks directly at communication via texts or transcripts, and hence gets at the central aspect of social interaction

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- can allow for both quantitative and qualitative operations
- can provide valuable historical/cultural insights over time through analysis of texts
- makes possible a variety of cross cultural studies that would likely be unfeasible using other methods.
- provides insight into complex models of human thought and language use

Content analysis suffers from several disadvantages, both theoretical and procedural. In particular, content analysis:

- Since content analysis is a heavily planned method, it lacks the spontaneity often required in the field research
- can be extremely time consuming
- is subject to increased error, particularly when relational analysis is used to attain a higher level of interpretation
- is often devoid of theoretical base, or attempts too liberally to draw meaningful inferences about the relationships and impacts implied in a study
- often disregards the context that produced the text, as well as the state of things after the text is produced
- Some required documents may not be available to the researcher which may affect the conclusions.
- It is susceptible to coder's bias.

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Dear Candidate, now just to clarify some of your queries that might have arised after reading this note on content analysis, I would like to throw some light on the debates with regard to the use of content analysis. This is not very important from the examination point of view and it will also not be possible for you to incorporate all such details in a short note given the time and word limit.

One of the leading debates among the users of content analysis is whether analysis should be quantitative or qualitative. Berelson, for example, suggests that content analysis is "objective, systematic, and quantitative." Similarly, Silverman dismisses content analysis from his discussion of qualitative data analysis "because it is a quantitative method." Selltiz et al. however, state that concerns over quantification in content analysis tend to emphasize "the procedures of analysis," rather than the "character of the data available." Selltiz et al. suggest also that heavy quantitative content analysis results in a somewhat arbitrary limitation in the field by excluding all accounts of communication that are not in the form of numbers as well as those that may lose meaning if reduced to a numeric form (definitions, symbols, detailed explanations, photographs, and so forth). Other proponents of the content analysis, notably Smith, suggest that some blend of both quantitative and qualitative analysis should be used. Smith explains that he has taken this position "because qualitative analysis deals with the forms and antecedent-consequent patterns of form, while quantitative analysis deals with duration and frequency of form." Abrahamson suggests that "content analysis can be fruitfully employed to examine virtually any type of communication." As a consequence, content analysis may focus on either quantitative or qualitative aspects of communication messages.

Another controversy concerning the use of content analysis is whether the analysis should be limited to *manifest content* (those elements that are physically present and countable) or extended to more *latent content*. In the latter case, the analysis is extended to an interpretive reading of the symbolism underlying the physical data. For example, an entire speech may be assessed for how radical it was, or a novel could be considered in terms of how violent the entire text was. Stated in different words, manifest content is comparable to the *surface structure* present in the message, and latent content is the *deep structural* meaning conveyed by the message. Holsti has tried to resolve this debate: "It is true that only the manifest attributes of text may be coded, but this limitation is already implied by the requirement of objectivity. Inferences about latent meanings of messages are therefore permitted but....they require corroboration by independent evidence." One reasonable interpretation of this passage, and a similar statement made by Berelson, suggests that although there are some dangers in directly inferring from latent symbolism, it is nonetheless possible to use it. To accomplish this sort of "deciphering" of latent symbolic meaning, researchers must first incorporate

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independent corroborative techniques (for example, agreement between independent coders concerning latent content or some noncontent analytic source). Finally, and especially when latent symbolism may be discussed, researchers should offer detailed excerpts from relevant statements (messages) that serve to document the researchers' interpretations.

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Ghurye's views on Indian culture:

Ghurye's search for the roots of Indian culture in the Vedic age is reflected in several of his later books including *Family and Kin in Indo-European Culture* (1955), *Two Brahmanical Institutions: Gotra and Charana* (1972), and *Vedic India* (1979). It is also evident in the fact that much of his work centres around traditional Hindu or brahminical knowledge systems, religious practices, social organisation, and law, as reflected in the classical Sanskrit texts. Ghurye made extensive use of these texts in his studies of phenomena as divergent as caste, costume, religion, and sexuality. In many of his books, references to ancient texts are brought in side by side with discussions of present-day practices, suggesting continuities between the present and the distant past.

In *Gotra and Charana* (1972) Ghurye investigates the origin, history and spread of these 'brahmanical institutions' of exogamy through an exhaustive study of Sanskrit literature and inscriptions from different periods, ending with contemporary information on exogamous practices in several communities. By comparing similar cultural traits among ancient Greeks and Indo-Iranians, he develops the theory that *gotras* originated in the "cosmographical and astronomical view and knowledge gained by Aryans in their new home in India" Here we see the influence of the Aryan invasion thesis, in which cultural elements have their ultimate origin in the original Aryan race, combined with the diffusionist tracking of culture traits across time and space.

The *gotra* and *charana* were kin categories of Indo-European cultures which systematized the rank and status of the people. These categories were derived from *rishis* (saints) of the past. These *rishis* were the real or eponymous founder of the *gotra* and *charana*. In India, descent has not always been traced to the blood tie. The lineages were often based on spiritual descent from sages of the past. Outside the kinship, one might notice the *guru-shishya* (teacher-student) relationship, which is also based on spiritual descent. A discipline is proud to trace his descent from a master.

In several other works Ghurye attempts to trace the origin of contemporary social practices to their Indo-Aryan roots. For example, through a close analysis of the Vedas, Brahmanas and other texts in *Family and Kin in Indo-European Culture* (1955), Ghurye tries to reconstruct ancient Vedic-Aryan family and kinship structures. He concludes that the family in ancient times was joint in form, with four generations living under one roof, sharing food and property. In other words, the ideal Hindu family, as constructed by British 'Hindu law' and reinforced by Indian sociology, has its origin in ancient India. He also finds evidence in the

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ancient texts for certain contemporary kinship practices, such as father-in-law – daughter-in-law avoidance.

Ghurye outlines the history of particular kinship rites, such as different forms of ancestor worship, from the time of the *Smritis* to the present, arguing that the *shraddha* "has remained the standard type of Hindu (Indian) ancestor-worship throughout the ages till today." In the conclusion of this chapter, he clearly states that present practices must he understood through their connections with the ancient past. In *Family and Kin* Ghurye offers a rare general statement of his perspective, suggesting that Indo-Aryan culture is "... known for formulation of its ends and for prescription of means for the guidance of society and its components in a clear and definite manner. The Indian theory and practice of life, its social philosophy, its laws and its customs have centred on the four social categories of *varna*, caste, *ashrama*, stage of life, *purusartha*, purpose of life, and *rina*, debt."

For Ghurye, as in the Orientalist view, religion is the guiding principle of Indian society, and specifically brahminical religion as given in the sacred texts provides the moral principles and prescriptions for the organisation of society.

Like the Orientalism on which he drew, Ghurye's perspective on Indian society was intensely brahminical. For him, Hinduism is at the centre of India's civilisational unity, and at the core of Hinduism are brahminical ideas and values, which are essential for the integration of society. Venugopal describes the underlying theme of Ghurye's work as 'normative Hinduism', defined as an "idealised version of Hinduism serving as a means to judge or analyse diverse social phenomena in Indian society". Brahmins are seen historically as the leaders of Indo-Aryan society and as the "standard bearers of Hindu civilisation"; they were the "moral guides and legislators of the immigrant Aryans." As in the Orientalist understanding, society is understood as a set of rules to be followed, and to be a Hindu is to obey brahminical prescriptions. Brahmin-centred Hinduism served as an 'acculturative model' for other groups because it provided an integrative value system. For Ghurye, 'acculturation' meant vertical integration into the "social structure dominated by Indo-Aryanism in general and brahminical Hinduism in particular", i.e., the caste system. The same vision of the absorptive power of Hinduism explains his argument that tribals are 'backward Hindus'. For Ghurye as for the early Orientalist writers, Indian social history is essentially the history of Hinduisation or the assimilation of non-Hindu groups into Hindu society.

If Hinduism and brahminism are the norm for Indian society, other religious groups *ipso facto* are regarded as deviations from the norm. As in Hindu nationalist thought, Ghurye believed that the continuity of Hindu civilisation was broken by

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the Islamic 'invasion', and he adopted uncritically the colonial construction of Indian history and society as a struggle between Hindus and Muslims. He also echoed the assumption that Muslims have a culture that is entirely separate from that of Hindus. Evidence of religious syncretism at the level of everyday practices was ignored by Ghurye, who argued against the secularist idea of Indian culture as a 'fusion' of Hindu, Muslim and other elements. Instead he regarded Indian culture as the product of acculturation between Vedic-Aryan and pre-Aryan cultural elements and argued that Muslims in India had always practiced separatism, except for short periods of attempted integration. In his terminology, although Hindu-Muslim 'syncretism' occurred in some contexts, this should not be construed as 'synthesis' or 'fusion'. In *Social Tensions in India*, Ghurye states that the "presence of Islamic cultural elements in the basic ancient Indian culture-fabric shows the process of *syncretization*, *not fusion*". Hindus and Muslims have remained distinct communities "... though there have been some meeting points across religious boundaries at certain stages of history".

"Though there appeared to be some commingling across religious boundaries for military purposes, the main currents kept the two communities separate and distinct, the native Hindu endeavouring to keep himself alive with honour and even to regain his lost dominion, and the incoming Muslim, albeit with a large influx of native converts, strenuously countering the moves, drawing upon his native store-house in foreign lands. There was hardly any rapprochement between the two cultures, the Hindu and Muslim, in spite of co-existence."

Similarly, in *Caste and Race in India* and *Social Tensions* (1968), Ghurye, like some of the British Orientalists, argued that Hinduism and Islam are fundamentally incompatible religious systems. Ghurye's understanding of Indian society as essentially Hindu society, and his negative view of Muslims in particular, is reflected in the almost complete neglect of non-Hindu communities within the extensive body of sociological writings that he produced, as well as those of his many students.

Thus, it appears that Ghurye adopted almost wholesale the Orientalist vision of Indian society as the product of Vedic civilisation and ultimately of the 'Aryan invasion', and of Indian civilisation as Hindu, brahminical civilisation, although he was somewhat more selective in his arguments about the connections between present India and the Vedic past than were Orientalists such as Muller. However we cannot attribute this perspective purely to the hegemony of colonial discourse. More important perhaps is the influence of cultural nationalism, an orientation that is never explicitly stated but which becomes apparent in Ghurye's writings on contemporary affairs.

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Parsons: An Assessment

Parsons was one of the first iconic figures in American sociology. He was instrumental in developing Harvard University's Sociology (then called Social Relations) Department into one of the top-ranked in the world. His theoretical formulations were influential not only within sociology, but throughout the social sciences, often associated with conservative political ideologies and free market capitalism.

Parsons' later work focused on a new theoretical synthesis around four functions common to all systems of action, from the behavioral to the cultural, and a set of symbolic media that enable communication across them. However, his attempt to structure the world of action according to only four concepts was difficult to accept for many American sociologists, who were at that time retreating from the grand pretensions of the 1960s to a more empirical, grounded approach. Thus, Parsons' influence waned rapidly in the U.S. after 1970. The most prominent attempt to revive Parsonian thinking, under the rubric "neofunctionalism," was made by sociologist Jeffrey Alexander, working at Yale University.

Parsons is at least partially responsible for Max Weber's popularity in the English speaking world, as he translated and compiled a number of Weber's key ideas. The impact of Parsons' work is also evidenced through his students at Harvard, of whom some of the most notable included Robert K. Merton and Kingsley Davis.

Parsons by 1950s to 1970s was the most influential sociologist in America. Parsons alongwith R.K. Merton provided a refreshing break from the over-empiricism tradition of Chicago school and contributed to its decline. Parsons' achievements lie in the fact that he made a successful break with the empiricist tradition of American sociology. He started with the ambitious objective of synthesising disparate elements into a single conceptual structure for the whole of sociology which would also serve to integrate all other social sciences. Constituent elements of this theoretical system were drawn from British utilitarian economics, French positivism and German historicism. While such an enterprise provided a corrective to over empiricism sociology, his theoretical model became too grand to be any empirical value. By 1960s and 1970s criticisms against Parsons started mounting.

In his theory of social action, Parsons wanted to harmonize idealists with positivists but in his later works he ended up subordinating agency to structure. He initially gave importance to individual meanings and motives but later restricted his study of social action only to the extent it is shaped by culture. His whole

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analysis is based upon an overly-socialized conception of man, thus subordinating voluntarism to culture.

Responding to the Structure-Agency debate, Anthony Giddens introduced the concept of "structuration." Anthony Giddens argues that society constrains as well as enables the individual at the same time. Thus, for Giddens, structuration is a process. Parsons' theory failed on this account. Parsons completely subordinated the individual (agency) to culture (structure). Parsons' theory is suitable only for macro analysis as it takes into account only the patterned aspects of social reality. Parsons' theory is not suitable for micro sociological analysis. Thus in response to this lacuna of Parsons' theory, various micro sociological traditions emerged which gave more importance to the subjective dimension of the individual's behaviour, his unique meanings and motives, such as, phenomenology , ethnomethodology, symbolic interactionism, etc.

Parsons was criticized by his contemporary, C. Wright Mills (1916-62), for his grand theory. Mills believed that a grand theory was not based on fact but was the product of sociologists attempting to impose their will and interpretation upon data. Mills' influential book, *The Sociological Imagination*, was highly critical of the Parsonian approach, and recommended that it should be replaced by a much more bottom-up style of social research. Mills' book certainly hastened the dramatic fall in the popularity of Parsons' work during the 1970s and prefigured a new trend in American and British sociology at this time, which was pretty much to avoid looking for 'the bigger picture' altogether. Whatever 'the whole' is, the general presumption has been that its discovery no longer provides the point of departure for the research process. The ground workers of the social research no longer felt they needed to justify their activities in terms of some grandiose theoretical project. This separation between theory work and grounded research has largely remained in place.

Taking to heart Weber's observation that social research is inherently selective and partial, and that there are whole areas of personal and subjective experience about which it is extremely difficult to give a coherent account, social theorists adopted the view that having a few pieces of the puzzle, especially if they can be related to a few others, is enough to be going on with. There is plenty of room for theorising at a relatively moderate level of abstraction ('middle range theory') without necessarily having to fit this into a grand scheme at all.

Merton questioned the theory building strategy of Parsons. He criticised Parsons' theory as premature, sterile and motivated by extra-scientific considerations. According to Merton, "a theory is a clearly formulated generalisation between specific variables". He argued that a theory can be

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productive when while being a general theory it is specific enough to produce a testable hypothesis. The most important criterion of a testable hypothesis is its potential falsifiability. Merton argued that Parsons' theory is too general that it cannot be falsified.

According to Merton, a truly scientific theory should be a grounded theory, that is, it must grow out of the empirical research. Merton argued that generalisation is the part of theory building in sociology but it should be limited generalisation unlike Parsons' universalistic generalisation. Merton suggested Middle Range Theories for limited generalisation in response to Parsons' universal and grand theory. Merton argued that social scientists should only aspire for limited generalisations (MRT) at the present stage of development of sociology.

In an attempt to base his theory on fact, Parsons traced societal development through history. He explored three stages of evolution: 1) "primitive", 2) "archaic" and 3) "modern" (where he defined archaic societies as having knowledge of writing and modern societies as knowledge of law). Viewing Western civilization as the pinnacle of modern society, Parsons declared the United States as the most dynamically developed society, and for this, he was attacked as an ethnocentrist.

In Parsons' theory, societal evolution parallels biological evolution, with modem societies evidencing greater "generalized adaptive capacity" than earlier ones. He postulated that all social systems tend toward a state of equilibrium, although never actually reaching a perfectly equilibrated state. However, his critics, particularly those like Mills who favoured the Marxist approach, maintained that the basic tendencies in social and cultural systems are toward social change rather than toward equilibrium. Critics argue that he has shown too such of a preoccupation with order and equilibrium. This has rendered his theory status-quo oriented. Social conflict and social change have not been given adequate importance in this scheme. As a result, Parsons' theory of social system is sometimes criticised as a veiled status quoist ideology.

Further, Parsons's notion of social system which was based on organismic analogy and its self-equilibrating tendency was also criticised. Critics argued that Parsons' idea of social system and its comparison with biological organism is flawed and is only a logical assumption. Organismic system might be self-equilibrating but not necessarily the social systems. Parsons didn't account for social pathology, conflict, etc. His theory is suitable only for the analysis of large and stable social systems like America, Scandinavian countries, etc. Parsons' theory fails to account for the developments taking place in third world countries of Asia and Africa which are marked with chaos and conflict. Parsons'

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assumptions were criticised as unscientific as they could not be empirically verified.

Parsons is credited with reviving as well as refining the evolutionary theory of social change. In his neo-evolutionary theory of social change he discarded some dogmas of the classical social evolutionism. Parsons incorporated the idea of diffusion as a source of social change and proposed a multi linear theory of social change. But critics argue that Parsons' theory of social change is inadequate as it does not take into account the process dimension of social change.

Please note that Neo-evolutionism is concerned with long-term, directional, evolutionary social change and with the regular patterns of development that may be seen in unrelated, widely separated cultures. Neo-evolutionism is objective and simply descriptive, eliminating any references to a moral or cultural system of values. Its theories are based on empirical evidence from fields such as archeology, paleontology, and historiography. While the 19th century evolutionism explained how culture develops by giving general principles of its evolutionary process, it was dismissed by Historical Particularism as unscientific in the early 20th century. It was the neo-evolutionary thinkers who brought back evolutionary thought and developed it to be acceptable to contemporary anthropology.

The neo-evolutionism discards many ideas of classical social evolutionism, namely that of social progress, so dominant in previous sociology evolution-related theories. Then neo-evolutionism discards the determinism argument and introduces probability, arguing that accidents and free will have much impact on the process of social evolution. It also supports the counterfactual history - asking '*what if*' and considering different possible paths that social evolution may (or might have) taken, and thus allows for the fact that various cultures may develop in different ways, some skipping entire stages others have passed through. The neo-evolutionism stresses the importance of empirical evidence. While 19th century evolutionism used value judgment and assumptions for interpreting data, the neo-evolutionism relied on measurable information for analyzing the process of cultural evolution.

Further, Parsons' writing style was difficult to understand and he was often vague and inconsistent with key terms. Thus, although initially well received, and his work in developing the sociology department at Harvard had lasting impact on the field, Parsons' theories were severely criticized.

Despite these criticisms there is no doubt that Parsons' work constituted a major contribution to the general body of material that social theory is made of.

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His ideas are now part of the intellectual stuff that social theorists who came after him have inevitably had to address. Even more deliberately than this, a number of social theorists have taken on the task of trying to identify the weaknesses within Parsonian functionalism in order to move functionalist theory into its next stage, for example, Jeffrey Alexander has made a very significant contribution to the development of neo-functionalist social theory during the 1990s.

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Reflexive Sociology

Dear Candidate, ***reflexive sociology*** in the newly emerging perspective in sociology. Though it is not explicitly mentioned in the syllabus but a short or long question can anytime be asked in the examination. So, it would be wise here to discuss some of the central arguments of reflexive sociology.

Reflexivity refers to the 'reflexive monitoring of action', that is, the way in which humans think about and reflect upon what they are doing in order to consider acting differently in future. Humans have always been reflexive up to a point, but in pre-industrial societies the importance of tradition limited reflexivity. Humans would do some things simply because they were the traditional things to do. However, with modernity, tradition loses much of its importance and reflexivity becomes the norm. Social reflexivity implies that social practices are constantly examined and reformed in the light of incoming information about those very practices, thus continuously altering their character.

Alvin W. Gouldner (1920-1980), an American sociologist, in his most influential work *The Coming Crisis of Western Sociology* offered a substantial and exhaustive argument for 'reflexive sociology'. Against the view that science in general and sociology in particular is concerned with producing objective truths, Gouldner argued that knowledge is not independent of the knower and that sociology is intimately bound up with the socio-economic and political context in which it exists.

Gouldner advocated 'reflexive sociology' in response to **Methodological Dualism** which was the dominant methodological assumption in early 20th century in American sociology. Methodological dualism was based on the elementary distinction of *subject* and *object*. Natural sciences in general were based on this premise. Since the subject matter of natural sciences was physical reality or matter, their prime concern was to discover the underlying pattern in nature and arrive at certain universal laws which can help in predicting and controlling natural phenomenon. In sociology, methodological dualism was emphasized by scholars belonging to the positivist tradition in France and America. They argued that like natural sciences, social sciences can also study social reality in an objective manner and information thus arrived could be used to predict and control man's social behaviour and social change. Methodological dualism in sociology implied a clear distinction between the *inquiring subject* (social scientist) and the *studied object* (the social group whom he observes). Methodological dualism enjoins the sociologist to be detached from the world he studies. It sees his involvement with his object of study primarily from the standpoint of its contaminating effect upon the information system.

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Gouldner rejects the assumption of methodological dualism in sociology. He argues that positivists who emphasize on methodological dualism in sociology do so primarily because they conceive of knowledge only as information. But, according to Gouldner, the ultimate goal of sociology is not to seek neutral information about social reality but rather such knowledge which facilitates a better understanding of social reality in terms of men's changing interests, expectations, values, etc. In this regard, Gouldner cites the example of Weber's *Verstehen* method. In contrast to positivists, Weber had emphasized the need for the interpretative understanding of social action. He argued that in order to have a better understanding of social action, it is necessary to take into account the unique meanings and motives that underlie such action. Weber suggests that this can be done by the sociologist by establishing empathetic liaison with the actor. In other words, it implies that the sociologist should imaginatively place himself in the actor's position and then try to understand the motives of the actor which guided his action.

Gouldner further extends this argument of Weber and argues that the knowledge of the world cannot be advanced apart from the sociologist's knowledge of himself and his position in the social world. He argues that to know others, a sociologist cannot simply study them but must also listen to and confront himself. Awareness of the self is seen as an indispensable avenue to awareness of the social world. Reflexive sociology aims at transforming the sociologist's relation to his work. It is characterized by the relationship it establishes between being a sociologist and being a person, between the role and the man performing it.

Reflexive sociology rejects the subject-object dichotomy, that is, sociologist who studies and those whom he studies or observes. Rather, the historical mission of sociology, according to Gouldner is to raise the sociologist's awareness of himself and his position in the social world. Thus, a reflexive sociologist must become aware of himself as both *knower* and as *agent of change*. He cannot know others unless he also knows his intentions toward and his effects upon them. He cannot know others without knowing himself, his place in the social world, and the forces – in society and in himself – to which he is subjected.

Gouldner argues that reflexive sociology is radical sociology. It is radical because in contrast to positivism, it rejects the assumption of methodological dualism i.e. subject-object dichotomy. It is radical because it is a historically sensitive sociology as it seeks to deepen the awareness of sociologists about themselves, of their own historically evolving character and of their place in a historically evolving society. It is radical because it embodies and advances certain specific values. As a work ethic, it affirms the creative potential of the sociologist and encourages him to take an independent stand of his own and resist the

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demands for conformity by the established authorities and institutions. Hence, according to Gouldner, a reflexive sociology would be a moral sociology.

Dear Candidate, the long question on reflexivity can also be asked in context of its comparison with positivist tradition, which I think you would be able to answer. But, the examiner may also ask a question on reflexivity in context of its implications on the changing landscape of 'field' and the practices of fieldwork in social anthropological research. This I will discuss in detail in the topic 'field' in our next section on *Research Methods and Analysis*.

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Suicide (1897)

Suicide was Durkheim's third book which was published in 1897. In broad historical terms, there are several reasons why Durkheim took up the theme of suicide when he did. First, suicide was a growing social problem in Europe by 1850 and many felt that it was associated with the development of industrial society. Industrialization had advanced individualism, accelerated social fragmentation, and weakened the social bonds tying individuals to society. Second, industrial society had made economic institutions dominant over other social institutions and this served to place individual self-interest and economic gain over the collective forces of society. As individual autonomy and political freedoms increased, the individual became the center of social life and this served to reduce the level of social restraint and to call into question the nature of collective social purposes. Third, the political crisis of the Dreyfus affair in 1894 was a serious blow to French national unity and drew attention to how much social fragmentation and egoistic forces had replaced the collective authority of society. This led Durkheim to believe that the theme of social dissolution brought about by industrial society could be examined sociologically by looking at the mechanisms in society which link individuals to social purposes outside themselves. Fourth, factual evidence made available by comparative mortality data from different societies linked suicide to social factors such as industrial change, occupation, family life and religion, and this served to focus attention on society and social institutions rather than on complex psychological factors. Durkheim found that the statistical data contained in the records of suicidal deaths for the period could be categorized according to age, religion, sex, occupation, military service and marital status, and this led directly to a search for the role played by social factors in the cause of suicide. Overall, Durkheim studied the records of 26,000 suicides, and his colleague, Marcel Mauss, helped assemble the maps contained in the study and aided in compiling the statistical tables on suicidal deaths relating to age and marital status.

One of the primary aims Durkheim had in pursuing a social theory of suicide was to look for the social causes of suicide within the existing framework of society rather than looking at the psychological states of individuals who take their own lives. This shift in perspective from a psychological to a sociological theory of suicide was disconcerting for many, and perhaps the best way to understand this shift is to look at the problem of suicide prior to Durkheim's work. At the time Durkheim began his study, suicide was largely treated as a nervous disorder and its causes were believed to derive from the psychological states of individuals. Many believed that suicide was the result of mental illness, depression, sudden tragedy, reversal of fortune and even personal setbacks and bankruptcy. In this light, suicide was seen by many as the result of a weak disposition and a psychological response

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to the burdens of life. Durkheim, however, called these views into question by shifting the focus from individual motives and psychological states to social causes in at least two distinct ways. First, by stating that the social causes of suicide precede individual causes, Durkheim eliminated the need to look at the various forms suicide assumed in individuals, including depression, personal setbacks, and psychiatric disorders. Second, in focusing his attention on the various social environments to which the individual was connected, including the family group, the religious group and the national group, Durkheim eliminated the necessity of looking at individual disposition or personality. He put this clearly when he pointed out that 'the causes of death are outside rather than within us, and are effective only if we venture into their sphere of activity.'

Durkheim defined Suicide as '*all cases of death resulting directly or indirectly from a positive or negative act of the victim himself, which he knows will produce this result.*'

Suicide is cited as a monumental landmark in which conceptual theory and empirical research are brought together. He used considerable statistical ingenuity considered remarkable for his times. His use of statistical analysis was for two primary reasons: (1) to refute theories based on psychology, biology, genetics, climatic, and geographical factors, and (2) to support with empirical evidence his own sociological explanation of suicide. In this study, Durkheim displayed an extreme form of sociological realism. He speaks of *suicidal currents* as collective tendencies that dominate some very susceptible individuals and catch them up in their sweep. The act of suicide at times, Durkheim believed, is interpreted as a product of these currents. Durkheim rejected the various extra-social factors such as heredity, climate, mental alienation, racial characteristics and imitation as the cause of suicide and arrived at the conclusion that suicide which appears to be a phenomenon relating to the individual is actually explicable aetiologically with reference to the social structure and its ramifying functions which may (a) induce, (b) perpetuate, or (c) aggravate the suicide potential.

Durkheim's central thesis is that suicide rate is a factual order, unified and definite, for each society has a collective inclination towards suicide, a rate of self-homicide which is fairly constant for each society so long as the basic conditions of its existence remain the same. No complete understanding of Durkheim's assertion that suicide had social causes is possible without looking at the concept of the '*social suicide rate*'. Durkheim arrived at the concept of the social suicide rate after a careful examination of the mortality data which had been obtained from public records of societies such as France, Germany, England, Denmark and Austria. These records contained information about cause of death, age, marital background, religion and the total number of deaths by suicide of the country from

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which they were gathered. The 'social suicide rate,' therefore, was a term used by Durkheim to refer to the number of suicidal deaths in a given society and the extent to which the 'suicide rates' themselves could be looked upon as establishing a pattern of suicide for a given society. But, what does this mean in relation to individual suicide? As we stated earlier, theories of suicide prevalent at the time had looked at individual motives and psychological causes. Suicide, many believed, was the desperate act of an individual who did not care to live or who could not face life's burdens. From this perspective, suicide was seen as an individual act dependent on factors which could only be explained psychologically.

Durkheim, however, took a completely different approach. Rather than looking at individual motives or psychological states, he began by looking at the 'social suicide rate' that existed in different countries. What he wanted to find out was whether individual suicides committed in a given society could be taken together as a whole and studied collectively. Durkheim's central question then was can the collective rates for a given society be studied independently of individual suicide? In order, therefore, to establish a theoretical footing, Durkheim began to look at the total number of suicidal deaths contained in public records of countries such as France, Germany, England and Denmark. The suicide rates for these countries had been collected between 1841 and 1872, and they contained a substantial amount of information related to social factors of suicide such as marital status, religion, occupation and military service.

After studying the rates, Durkheim made several key observations. First, he noticed that the rates varied from society to society. For example, they were higher in Germany in comparison to Italy; lower in Denmark in comparison to England and so on. Second, he observed that between 1841 and 1872, the number of suicidal deaths in each of the countries did not change dramatically and were considered to be stable. For example, between 1841-42 the number of suicidal deaths in France were 2814 and 2866 respectively; whereas in Germany for the same years they were 1630 and 1598. As far as Durkheim was concerned, the stability of the rates within a given society was crucial since it meant that each society not only produced a 'quota of suicidal deaths' but that certain social forces were operating to produce what Durkheim saw as the 'yearly precision of rates.' This turned out to be decisive because when considered collectively, the rates pointed in the direction of underlying social causes. This led Durkheim to reason that the predisposing cause of suicide lay not within the psychological motives of the individual but within the social framework of society. Third, the observed stability of the rates meant that each society was a distinct social environment with different social characteristics, different religions, different patterns of family life, different military obligations and thus different suicide characteristics. Under these circumstances, each produced rate of suicidal deaths distinct from the other.

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Fourth, when compared to the mortality rate, Durkheim noticed that the suicide rate demonstrated a far greater consistency than did the general mortality rate, which fluctuated randomly.

As a result, Durkheim drew three fundamental conclusions which turned on the question of the stability of the rates. First, he believed that the stability of the rates showed that, while individual motives for suicide vary from case to case, the regularity exhibited by the social suicide rate was consistently stable. Second, though the rates varied between societies, the stability of the rates within a particular society meant that each society produces a 'quota of suicidal deaths'. Third, Durkheim took the position that the social suicide rate must represent a 'factual order' that is separate from individual disposition and, therefore, he thought it had a regularity which could be studied in its own right. In that the 'social suicide rate' is independent of individual suicide and has a stability of its own, it should therefore be the subject of a special study whose purpose would be to discover the social causes leading to a definite number of people that take their own lives in a given society.

Durkheim believed that the social suicide rate was the clearest evidence he had for a social theory of suicide since what a study of the social suicide rate had established was that different societies had different suicide rates, and that these rates changed very little over time within any given society. For example, between 1841 and 1842 France had 2866 suicides while Germany had 1598 suicides. He went on to reason that if suicide were entirely the result of individual causes and individual psychology, it would be difficult to explain why the French would be almost twice as likely to commit suicide in comparison with the Germans. Durkheim then reasoned that once we shift the focus from the study of individual suicides to the study of the 'collective suicide rate' – France's suicide rate in relation to Germany's suicide rate – it became apparent that the collective rates pointed in the direction of underlying social causes, which in turn indicated fundamental differences in the social framework that caused France to have 2866 suicides each year, while Germany had only 1598.

Durkheim's theory of suicide is divided into two explanatory sections. In the first, Durkheim explains suicide by drawing on the concept of **social integration**, referring to the strength of the social bonds existing between the individual and society. In this case, **egoistic** and **altruistic** suicide form opposite poles of social integration. In the second part of the theory, Durkheim explained suicide by drawing on the concept of **social regulation**. Social regulation, in contrast to integration, refers to the restraints imposed by society on individual needs and wants and generally manifests itself through regulatory requirements that are imposed by society on individuals when their social needs and wants begin to

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exceed the means they have for attaining them. In the case of social regulation, **anomic** and **fatalistic** suicide form opposite poles in relation to the changes in the regulatory functions of industrial society that may lead to shifts in the suicide rate. Let us now discuss about these types of suicide in detail.

Egoistic Suicide: Egoistic suicide results from the lack of integration of the individual into his social group. Durkheim studied varying degrees of integration of individuals into their religion, family, political and national communities, and found that the stronger the forces throwing the individuals on to their own resources, the greater the suicide rate in society. For example, regardless of race and nationality, Catholics show far less suicides than Protestants. This is because, while both faiths prohibit suicide, Catholicism is able to integrate its members more fully into its fold. Protestantism fosters spirit of free inquiry, permits greater individual freedom, multiplies schism, lacks hierarchic organizations and has fewer common beliefs and practices. Catholicism, on the other hand, is an idealistic religion which accepts faith readymade, without scrutiny, has a hierarchical system of authority and prohibits variation. Thus "the superiority of Protestantism with respect to suicide results from its being a less strongly integrated church than the Catholic church."

Family, like religious group, is a powerful counter agent against suicide. Non-marriage increases the tendency to suicide, while marriage reduces the danger by half or more. This immunity even increases with the density of the family. In other words, contrary to the popular belief that suicide is due to life's burdens, Durkheim insists that it diminishes as these burdens increase. Small families are unstable and short-lived; their sentiments and consciences lack intensity. But large families are more solidly integrated and act as powerful safeguards against suicide. Again, contrary to the common belief that great political upheavals increase the number of suicides, Durkheim contends that great social disturbances and popular wars rouse collective sentiments, stimulate patriotism and national faith, and force men to close ranks and confront the danger, leading to a more powerful integration of the individual into his community, thus reducing the rate of suicide.

Altruistic Suicide: Altruistic suicide results from the over-integration of the individual into his social group. An individual's life is so rigorously governed by custom and habit that he takes his own life because of higher commandments. Examples are legion: women throwing themselves at the funeral pyre of their husbands (known as *sati* in India); Danish warriors killing themselves in old age; the Goths jumping to their death from high pinnacles to escape the ignominy of natural death; suicide of followers and servants on the death of their chiefs. As opposed to these obligatory altruistic suicides, there are optional varieties which do not require suicide but praise self-sacrifice or ultimate self-renunciation as a noble

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and praiseworthy act. Japanese Harakiri, self-immolation by Buddhist monks, self-homicide by army suicide squads and self-destruction in Nirvana under Brahminic influence (as in the case of ancient Hindu sages) illustrate other variants of altruistic suicide.

Durkheim believed that his analysis of military suicide lent support to his conclusion. He rejected the popular conception which attributes military suicide to the hardships of military life, disciplinary rigor and lack of liberty. While with longer service men might be expected to become accustomed to barrack life, their commitment to the army and aptitude for suicide seem to increase. While military life is much less hard for officers than for private soldiers, the former accounts for greater suicide rates than the latter. Above all, volunteers and re-enlisted men who choose military as a career are more inclined to commit suicide than men drafted against their will. This proves that where altruistic suicide is prevalent, man is always ready to sacrifice his life for a great cause, principle or a value.

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Anomic Suicide: Anomic suicide results from normlessness or deregulation in society. Although this kind of suicide occurs during industrial or financial crises, it is not because they cause poverty, since crises of prosperity have the same result, but because they are crises of the collective order. Every disturbance of social equilibrium whether on account of sudden prosperity or instant misfortune, results in a deregulation and a greater impulse to voluntary death. Durkheim attributed anomic suicide to unlimited aspirations and the breakdown of regulatory norms. Man's aspirations have consistently increased since the beginnings of history. There is nothing in man's organic structure or his psychological constitution which can regulate his overweening ambitions. Social desires can be regulated only by a moral force. Durkheim views the collective order as the only moral force that can effectively restrain the social and moral needs. However, occasionally this mechanism breaks down and normlessness ensues.

Thus any abrupt transitions such as economic disaster, industrial crisis or sudden prosperity can cause a deregulation of the normative structure. That is why, Durkheim reasons, anomie is a chronic state of affairs in the modern socio-economic system. Sudden changes upset the societal scale instantly but a new scale cannot be immediately improvised. Collective conscience requires time to reclassify men and things. During such periods of transition there is no restraint on aspirations which continue to rise unbridled. "The state of deregulation or anomie is thus further heightened by passions being less disciplined, precisely when they need more disciplining." Overweening ambition and the race for unattainable goals continue to heighten anomie.

In analyzing the consequences of anomie, Durkheim showed that there was a high rate of anomic suicide among those who are wealthy as well as among divorced persons. Sudden upward changes in the standard of living or the breakup of a marriage throws life out of gear and puts norms in a flux. Like economic anomie, domestic anomie resulting from the death of husband or wife is also the result of a catastrophe that upsets the scale of life. Durkheim also points to a number of factors that contributed to anomie in modern society. "Economic progress has largely freed industrial relations from all regulation, and there is no moral strong enough to exercise control in the sphere of trade and industry. Furthermore, religion has lost most of its power. And government, instead of regulating economic life, has become its tool and servant."

Fatalistic Suicide: There is a little mentioned fourth type of suicide – fatalistic – that Durkheim discussed only in a footnote in *Suicide*. Whereas anomic suicide is more likely to occur in situations in which regulation is too weak, fatalistic suicide is more likely to occur when regulation is excessive. While Durkheim had little to say about the characteristics of fatalistic suicide, he cited as an example the suicide

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of slaves who, seeing no alternative to life except enslavement under a master, take their own life.

Thus, to summarise, Durkheim argued that social currents cause changes in the rates of suicides. Individual suicides are affected by these currents of egoism, altruism, anomie, and fatalism. This proved, for Durkheim, that these currents are more than just the sum of individuals, but are *sui generis* forces, because they dominate the decisions of individuals. Without this assumption, the stability of the suicide rate for any particular society could not be explained.

Durkheim concludes his study of suicide with an examination of what reforms could be undertaken to prevent it. Most attempts to prevent suicide have failed because it has been seen as an individual problem. For Durkheim attempts to directly convince individuals not to commit suicide are futile, since its real causes are in society. Of course, the first question to be asked is whether suicide should be prevented or whether it counts among those social phenomena that Durkheim would call normal because of its widespread prevalence. This is an especially important question for Durkheim because his theory says that suicides results from social currents that, in a less exaggerated form, are good for society. We would not want to stop all economic booms because they lead to anomic suicides nor would we stop valuing individuality because leads to egoistic suicide. Similarly, altruistic suicide results from our virtuous tendency to sacrifice ourselves for the community. The pursuit of progress, the belief in the individual, and the spirit of sacrifice all have their place in society, and cannot exist without generating some suicides. Durkheim admits that some suicide is normal, but he argues that the modern society has seen a pathological increase in both egoistic and anomic suicide. Here his position can be traced back to *The Division of Labour*, where he argued that the anomie of modern culture is due to the abnormal way in which labour is divided so that it leads to isolation rather than interdependence. What is needed, then, is a way to preserve the benefits of modernity without unduly increasing suicides – a way of balancing these social currents. In our society, Durkheim believes, these currents are out of balance. In particular, social regulation and integration are too low, leading to an abnormal rate of anomic and egoistic suicides.

Many of the existing institutions for connecting the individual and society have failed, and Durkheim sees little hope of their success. The modern state is too distant from the individual to influence his or her life with enough force and continuity. The church cannot exert its integrating effect without at the same time repressing freedom of thought. Even the family, possibly the most integrative institution in modern society, will fail in this task since it is subject to the same corrosive conditions that are increasing suicide. Instead, what Durkheim, suggests

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is the need of a different institution based on occupational groups. Hence in the form of 'occupational associations' Durkheim proposes a social solution to a social problem.

As we discussed above, the primary problem that Durkheim saw in modern society was the lack of integration and regulation. Even though the cult of the individual provided a collective representation, Durkheim believed that there was a lack of social organizations that people could feel part of and that could tell people what they should and should not do. The modern state is too distant to influence most individuals. The church tends to integrate people by repressing freedom of thought. And the family is too particular and does not integrate individuals into society as a whole. As we've seen, the schools provided an excellent milieu for children. For adults, Durkheim proposed another institution: the *occupational association*. Genuine moral commitments require a concrete group which is tied to the basic organizing principle of modern society, the division of labour. Durkheim proposed the development of occupational associations. All the workers, managers, and owners involved in a particular industry should join together in an association that would be both professional and social. Durkheim did not believe that there was a basic conflict of interest among the owners, managers, and workers within an industry. In this, of course, he took a position diametrically opposed to that of Marx, who saw an essential conflict of interest between the owners and the workers. Durkheim believed that any such conflict occurred only because the various people involved lacked a common morality which was traceable to the lack of an integrative structure. He suggested that the structure that was needed to provide this integrative morality was the occupational association, which would encompass "all the agents of the same industry united and organized into a single group." Such an organization was deemed to be superior to such organizations as labour unions and employer association, which in Durkheim's view served only to intensify the differences between owners, managers, and workers. Involved in a common organization, people in these categories would recognize their common interests as well as their common need for an integrative moral system. That moral system, with its derived rules and laws, would serve to counteract the tendency toward atomization in modern society as well as help stop the decline in the significance of collective morality.

Durkheim's analysis has had an enormous influence on all subsequent research into suicide, and many aspects of his theory have been confirmed by a number of studies, although many of these have also served to modify the original theory. Bearing in mind that many of the statistical techniques commonly used today had not been developed at the time, his statistical approach was very advanced. Still, he has been criticized both for his social realism perspective as well as his positivist methodology. In his study of *Suicide* Durkheim displayed an

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extreme form of social realism and explained suicide as a product of suicidal currents. However, later day scholars criticized this extreme sociological realism approach of Durkheim, and rather advocated a more comprehensive 'causal pluralism' approach to explain the phenomenon of suicide. They argued that apart from social factors, biological and psychological factors must also be explored while explaining suicide. Further, British sociologist J. Maxwell Atkinson has criticized Durkheim on his positivist methodology. Atkinson has raised doubts over the reliability and validity of the very data used by Durkheim in study of *Suicide*. He maintains that the social world is a construction of actors' perceptions and subjective interpretations. As such it has no reality beyond the meanings given to it by social actors. Thus an act of suicide is simply that which is defined as suicide by social actors. Certain deaths come to be defined as suicide by coroners (investigating officers), medical practitioners, newspaper reporters, family and friends of the deceased and so on. Definitions of suicide depend on their interpretation of the event. For Atkinson, suicide is not an objective fact rather it is a subjective interpretation of the coroner. Thus, while some cases of unnatural death get classified as suicide and others are not, owing to the subjective interpretation by the coroner.

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Focus Group

Focus group is a qualitative research method of data collection in social sciences. Over the past decade, focus groups and group interviews have emerged as popular techniques for gathering qualitative data, both among sociologists and across a wide range of academic and applied research areas.

David L. Morgan has defined focus groups as 'a research technique that collects data through group interaction on a topic determined by the researcher'. This definition has three essential components. First, it clearly states that focus groups are a research method devoted to data collection. Second, it locates the interaction in a group discussion as the source of the data. Third, it acknowledges the researcher's active role in creating the group discussion for data collection purposes.

Thus, on the basis of this definition, focus groups should be distinguished from groups whose primary purpose is something other than research, for example, therapy, education, decision-making, etc. Further, it is useful to distinguish focus groups from procedures that utilize multiple participants but do not allow interactive discussions, such as nominal groups and Delphi groups. Finally, focus groups should be distinguished from methods that collect data from naturally occurring group discussions where no one acts as an interviewer. However, there is a difference of opinion among scholars on the issue whether focus groups should be distinguished from other types of group interviews. On one hand are the scholars who use an inclusive approach and treat most forms of group interviews as variants of focus groups. On the other hand, there are scholars who use an exclusive approach and treat focus group as a distinct technique which should not be confused with other types of group interviews. In this regard, Frey and Fontana argue that group interviews can be distinguished from focus groups on the basis of three features.

- Firstly, group interviews are conducted in informal settings;
- Secondly, group interviews use non-directive interviewing, and
- Thirdly, group interviews use unstructured question formats.

Similarly, Stewart and Shamdasani associate focus groups with more or less directive interviewing styles and structured question formats.

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However, applied demographers such as John Knodel, who have held focus group interviews throughout the world, concluded that focus groups can be adapted to a wide variety of settings and culture practices. Hence, in actual practice, it would be quite difficult to apply the above mentioned classification as the methodology of focus groups or group interviews is largely dependent on the purpose of a particular project as well as the socio-cultural context.

Today focus groups, like other qualitative methods, are being used across a wide variety of research areas including education, public health, marketing research, etc. In recent years, two specific areas where the applied use of focus groups has had a major and continuing link to sociology are family planning and HIV/AIDS. Studies conducted in these areas suggest that the use of focus groups facilitated better understanding of knowledge, attitudes, and practices with regard to contraception in the Third World countries. Further, an important aspect of focus group method is that it facilitates participatory research. Various studies have suggested that use of focus group method in HIV/AIDS research has not only facilitated a better understanding of the problems being faced by at-risk groups but it also serves to "give a voice" to such marginalized groups.

Uses of Focus Groups in combination with other methods:

Focus groups can be used as both either independently or in combination with other methods such as individual interviews, surveys, etc.

Focus Groups and Individual Interviews:

Focus groups and individual interviews, both are qualitative techniques of data collection. But while focus groups and group interviews provide greater breath to the research, individual interviews on the other hand provide greater depth.

Various researchers have often used in-depth individual interviews as a follow up to focus group studies in order to ascertain the degree of consistency or discrepancy in the responses of the participants.

Focus Groups and Surveys:

Morgan has described four ways of combining quantitative and qualitative methods using survey and focus groups as example. The four ways of combining the methods are based on, 'which method received the primary attention and whether the secondary method served as a preliminary or follow-up study'?

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First combination: *Survey as the primary method and focus group for preliminary study.*

The first combination contains studies in which surveys are the primary method and focus groups serve in a preliminary capacity. Survey researchers typically use this design to develop the context of their questionnaires. Because surveys are inherently limited by the questions they ask, it is increasingly common to use focus groups to provide data on how the respondents themselves talk about the topics of the survey.

For example, in order to carry out a survey on the factors that influence the voting behaviour of people in rural areas, a preliminary focus group study may be undertaken to list various important factors and issues that people take into account when voting such as caste, religion, socio-economic status of the contestants, etc. The data thus collected from this preliminary focus group study may be used to design the questionnaire for the survey study.

Second combination: *Focus groups as the primary method and survey for preliminary study.*

In the second combination, focus groups are the primary method while surveys provide preliminary inputs. Studies following this research design make use of the data obtained from survey in selecting samples for focus groups to carry out a detailed analysis.

For example, a preliminary survey study may be carried out to know about the opinion of students regarding implementation of semester system. After determining the general opinion of the students either for or against the semester system, a more intense and detailed focus group study may be carried out to find out the reasons that students give for their respective opinion.

Third combination: *Survey as the primary method and focus group as a follow up.*

The third combination uses survey as the primary method and focus group as a follow up study. This type of research design is increasingly being used for interpreting the survey results and in determining the degree to which the results of both methods are in conformity or at variance with each other. For example, if a survey study finds out that people in rural areas give high priority to caste factor during voting, it may be cross-checked by a follow-up focus group study.

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Fourth combination: *Focus group as the primary method and survey as a follow up.*

The fourth combination uses focus group as the primary method and survey as a follow up. For example, if a focus group study suggests caste factor as the most important factor determining the voting behaviour of people rural India, it may be cross checked by a follow up survey.

Survey Vs Focus Group:

Survey offers more breadth to research both in terms of coverage of area as well as coverage of issues. Focus Group offers more depth to research by means of in-depth and detailed investigation over a topic.

Strength and Weakness of Focus Groups:

Morgan and Krueger argue that compared to other methods the real strength of focus groups is not simply in exploring what people have to say, but in providing insights into the sources of complex behaviors and motivations. They view this advantage of focus groups as a direct outcome of the interaction in focus groups. What makes the discussion in focus groups more than the sum of separate individual interviews is the fact that the participants both query each other and explain themselves to each other. Morgan & Krueger argue that such interaction offers valuable data on the extent of consensus and diversity among the participants. This ability to observe the extent and nature of interviewees' agreement and disagreement is a unique strength of focus groups.

The weaknesses of focus groups, like their strengths, are linked to the process of producing focused interactions, raising issues about both the role of the moderator in generating the data and the impact of the group itself on the data. Agar and MacDonald, and Saferstein from their respective studies have concluded that the behaviour of the moderator has consequences for the nature of group interviews.

Sussman et al. in their study administered questionnaires before and after focus group discussion to find out if the focus group discussion changed the participants' attitudes. They found that the attitudes became more extreme after the group discussion. In other words, after the focus group discussion, there was a polarization effect on the attitudes of the participants. Thus it could be concluded that 'group effect' also influences the response of participants in a focus group.

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Further, critics argue that only a limited range of topics can be researched effectively in groups. It is argued that some sensitive issues may be unacceptable for discussion among some categories of research participants. However, this assumption is being questioned in the light of widespread use of group interviews to study various sensitive issues like sexual behaviour, etc.

Dear Candidate, many of the debates about the merits of particular research methods focus on questions of 'reliability' and 'validity'. In the natural sciences, data are seen to be 'reliable' if other researchers using the same methods of investigation on the same material produce the same results. By replicating an experiment it is possible to check for errors in observation and measurement. Once reliable data have been obtained, generalizations can then be made about the behaviour observed. No sociologist would claim that the social sciences can attain the standards of reliability employed in the natural sciences. Many would argue, however, that sociological data can attain a certain standard of reliability. Generally speaking, quantitative methods are seen to provide greater reliability. They usually produce standardized data in a statistical form: the research can be repeated and the results checked. Qualitative methods are often criticized for failing to meet the same standards of reliability. Such methods may be seen as unreliable because the procedures used to collect data can be unsystematic, the results are rarely quantified, and there is no way of replicating a qualitative study and checking the reliability of its findings.

Further, data are considered 'valid' if they provide a true picture of what is being studied. A valid statement gives a true measurement or description of what it claims to measure or describe. It is an accurate reflection of social reality. Data can be reliable without being valid. Studies can be replicated and produce the same results but those results may not be a valid measure of what the researcher intends to measure. For instance, statistics on church attendance may be reliable but they do not necessarily give a true picture of religious commitment.

Supporters of qualitative methods often argue that quantitative methods lack validity. Statistical research methods may be easy to replicate but they may not provide a true picture of social reality. They are seen to lack the depth to describe accurately the meanings and motives that form the basis of social action. They use categories imposed on the social world by sociologists, categories that may have little meaning or relevance to other members of society. To many interpretive sociologists, only qualitative methods can overcome these problems and provide a valid picture of social reality.

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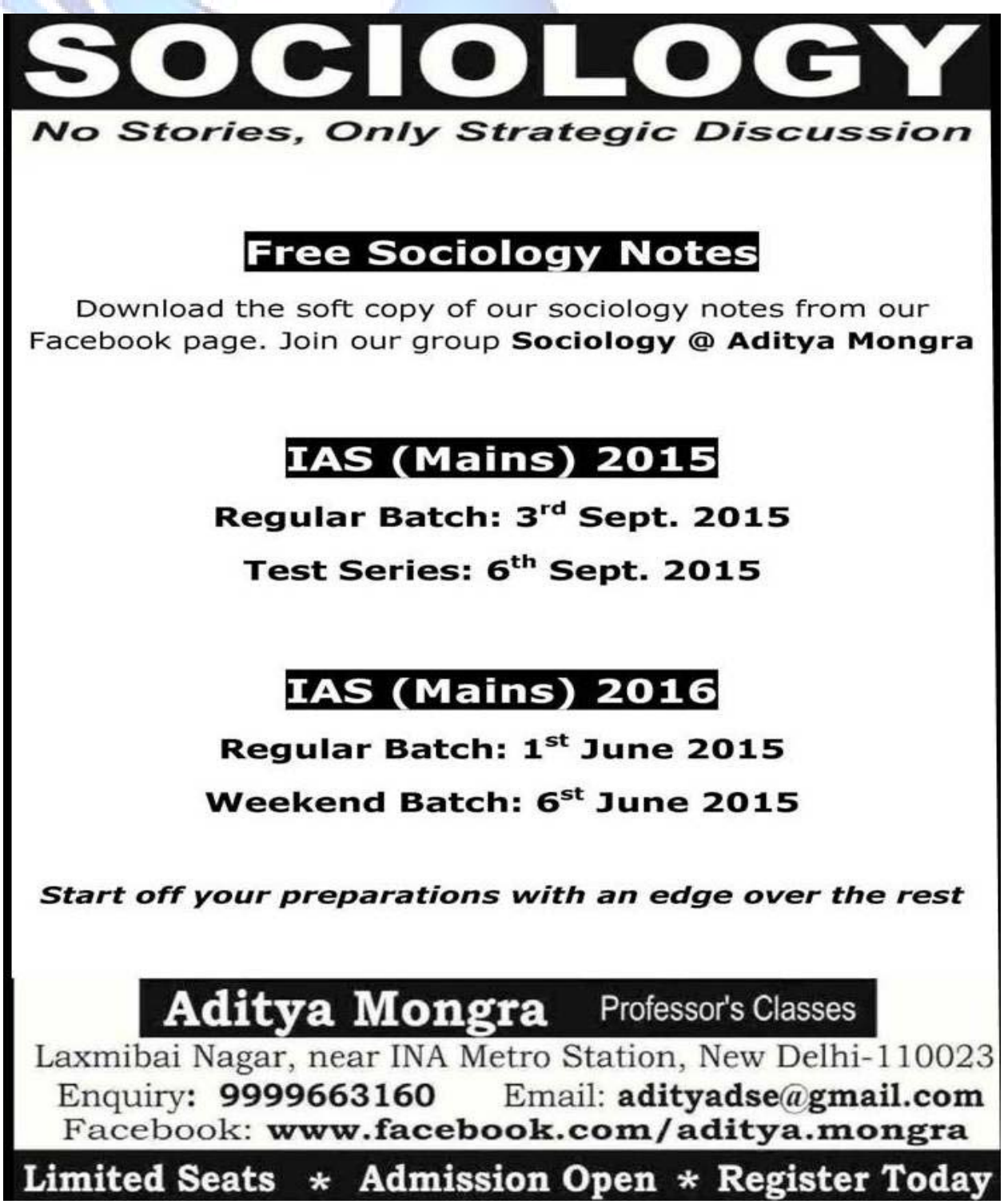
Researchers are sometimes attracted to quantitative methods because of their practicality. Quantitative methods are generally less time-consuming and require less personal commitment. It is usually possible to study larger and more representative samples which can provide an overall picture of society. Qualitative research often has to be confined to the study of small numbers because of practical limitations. It is more suited to providing an in-depth insight into a smaller sample of people.



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Ghurye - The Nationalist:

As a strong nationalist, Ghurye wanted India to be well-integrated. The failure of the secularists' idea of integration was demonstrated in continuing communal riots, demands for separate states, and other such divisive tendencies. Ghurye had no faith in the official ideology of secularism promoted by Nehru, nor in the idea that a composite, plural nation could be politically created. He hoped instead for the emergence of an 'integrated' nation, which he saw as the solution to 'social tensions'. Ghurye defines social integration as

"…a state in which individuals and groups have common values. This calls for, or is preceded by, psychological integration, which can take place only through communication ... Social integration when combined with its political aspect becomes national integration."

While he believed that some degree of tolerance is necessary for social integration, his study of the European experience convinced him that granting cultural autonomy to minority groups does not solve the problem of inter-group tensions. Hence he was opposed to the 'appeasement' of minorities in the name of secularism. For Ghurye a major source of division in the nation is the presence of Muslims. Because Islam failed to be absorbed into Hindu culture, Hindu-Muslim relations are fraught with tension, as is evident from the frequent recurrence of 'Hindu-Muslim riots'. "The mutual incompatibility of some religious practices of the two communities generally has been the proximate cause of these clashes". Ghurye also explains communal tension by reference to the history of razing of Hindu temples by Muslim rulers. According to him, other groups recognized the tolerance of Hinduism and adapted themselves to it, but Muslims never managed to integrate themselves into Indian society and hence have remained a threat to national unity.

Ghurye stressed on assimilation of diverse religious and 'backward' groups to mainstream Hindu society as the basis for national integration. He argues that the remedy for untouchability is the 'assimilation' of Untouchables into Hindu society.

Ghurye's opposition to enumeration by caste in the census, like his stress on the 'assimilation' of Untouchables, stemmed from his belief in the need for national unity based on cultural unity. Because of government policies, caste was becoming a divisive force in society, and this had to be opposed in the interest of national integration. Caste associations, reservation of posts and seats by caste, and even caste-based movements for equality are criticized by Ghurye on the same ground. Opposing the non-brahmin movement, Ghurye suggested that brahmin domination can be eradicated more effectively through education and social

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reform. Like several contemporary sociologists, he argued that reserved representation is

'…harmful in so far as it tends to perpetuate the distinction based on birth. Cooperation in the satisfaction of the needs of common social life through the machinery of Government is one of the potent factors that have dissolved tribal bonds and created nation-communities... Special representation for some castes ... means the negation of such co-operation.'

Ghurye argued that reservation of seats will induce more and more castes to 'clamour' for individual representation, reducing national life to an 'absurdity'. He further argues that the burgeoning of caste associations has led to an increase in 'caste-consciousness' and strengthened the 'community-aspect' of caste, creating a vicious circle. Ghurye stated that the feeling of caste-solidarity is now so strong that it is truly described as caste-patriotism. This, together with adverse economic conditions and competition for jobs, has led to 'caste-animosity', and contemporary society "presents the spectacle of self-centred groups more or less in conflict with one another." In order to kill 'caste-patriotism', the government should not recognize caste in any way. Instead, national feeling should be nurtured through inter-caste marriage, since "fusion of blood has been found to be an effective method of cementing alliances and nurturing nationalities." As another strategy for increasing social integration, Ghurye recommends that the priesthood, which traditionally has been a cohesive force in Hindu society, should be reformed and revitalized by doing away with brahmin monopoly and the distinction between Vedic and non-Vedic rites, and by training enlightened priests.

Ghurye was of the view that, free India, is in danger of disintegration due to divisions of religion, caste, language, and region, and it would have to seek its unity by rediscovering its true (Hindu) past. Hindu civilisation, with some modest reforms, would be the foundation of the nation, and any movement that works against national integration (reservations, regional autonomy) must be opposed.

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Marx: An Assessment

We conclude our discussion by making some observations about the impact of Marx's ideas on social theory and on the social theorists who came after him. As we know that Karl Marx never saw himself in the role of a sociologist, his prime concern being to bring about a revolutionary transformation in the then contemporary European society. Nevertheless, ideas of Karl Marx have greatly contributed to the development of modern sociology. In fact, he is the founder of the 'conflict tradition' in modern sociology and his ideas have stimulated a lively debate which has further enriched the discipline.

Firstly, Marx contributed a new perspective and a new methodology to study the social phenomena. He highlighted the role of economic factors in shaping various institutions of society. This has been accepted as an academic methodology in social sciences. The long-lasting significance of Marx's theory of historical materialism is that he goes far beyond the point of just adopting a materialist orientation in philosophical terms, but puts this approach to work in developing a detailed theory about the emergence of modern capitalist society. To the extent that Marx's theory accounts successfully for the emergence of capitalist society during the 19th century, this reinforces the general reliability, not only of his own theory of historical change, but of the materialist and realist approaches in social theory as a whole.

However, particular criticism has been directed towards the priority that Marx assigns to economic factors in his explanation of social structure and social change. Max Weber's study of ascetic Protestantism argued that religious beliefs provided the ethics, attitudes and motivations for the development of capitalism. Since ascetic Protestantism preceded the advent of capitalism, Weber maintained that at certain times and places aspects of the superstructure can play a primary role in directing change. The priority given to economic factors has also been criticized by elite theorists who have argued that control of the machinery of government rather than ownership of the forces of production provides the basis for power. They point to the example of communist societies where, despite the fact that the forces of production are communally owned, power is largely monopolized by a political and bureaucratic elite.

Secondly, having produced a painstaking account of how societies move on under pressure from developments in the means of production combined with changes in the nature of property relations, the simple message that Marx and Engels want to get across in *The Communist Manifesto* is that, as surely as night follows day, the capitalist mode of production is about to be replaced by a socialist or communist mode of production. The only remaining question was exactly *when*

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this might happen and whether some kind of intervention might be required to make sure it did. Marx and Engels certainly felt that by forming the Communist Party, and by spelling out the principles of historical change according to their own theory in the *Manifesto*, they could, as it were, give history a bit of a push in the right direction. The working class, it seemed, could not be relied upon to make history happen as it should, but would need the help of 'fresh elements of enlightenment and progress' supplied even by the bourgeoisie to show them the way. There are strong hints, at least in sections of the *Manifesto* drafted by Engels, that the overthrow of capitalism was unlikely to be a peaceful affair: the Communists 'openly declare that their ends can be attained only by the forcible overthrow of all existing social conditions. Let the ruling classes tremble at a Communist revolution. The proletarians have nothing to lose but their chains. They have a world to win'.

Equally certain, however, is the fact that the validity of Marx and Engel's theory would have been considerably strengthened if a revolution *had* occurred in modern society during the latter part of the 19th century. The fact that this has not yet happened rather suggests either that the theory was not complete or that they had a poor sense of timing. Critics argue that Marx's predictions about the downfall of capitalism have not come true. Contrary to his belief, socialism has triumphed in predominantly peasant societies whereas capitalist societies show no signs of destructive class war. And Marx's classless and stateless society is an utopia; there can be no society without an authority structure or a regulatory mechanism which inevitably leads to a crystallization of social relations between the rulers and the ruled, with inherent possibilities of internal contradiction and conflict. His theory of class conflict, even though no longer relevant to a present day society, has been an immensely valuable contribution. It has stimulated further debate and research which enriched sociology as a discipline.

Turning to his idea of '**communist society**', critics have argued that history has not borne out the promise of communism contained in Marx's writings. Socialist or communist societies are societies in which the forces of production are communally owned. Marx believed that public ownership of the forces of production is the first and fundamental step towards the creation of an egalitarian society. This would abolish at a stroke the antagonistic classes of capitalist society. Classes, defined in terms of the relationship of social groups to the forces of production, would now share the same relationship-that of ownership-to the forces of production. Social inequality would not, however, disappear overnight. There would be a period of transition during which the structures of inequality produced by capitalism would be dismantled. Marx was rather vague about the exact nature of the communist utopia which should eventually emerge from the abolition of private property. He believed that the state would eventually 'wither away' and

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that the consumption of goods and services would be based on the principle of 'to each according to his needs'. Whether he envisaged a disappearance of all forms of social inequality, such as prestige and power differentials, is not entirely clear. One thing that is clear, though, is that the reality of contemporary communism is a long way from Marx's dreams. Significant social inequalities are present in communist regimes and there are few, if any, signs of a movement towards equality. The dictatorship of the proletariat clings stubbornly to power and there is little indication of its eventual disappearance.

Eastern European communism has not resulted in the abolition of social stratification. Identifiable strata, which can be distinguished in terms of differential economic rewards, occupational prestige and power, are present in all socialist states. Frank Parkin identifies the following strata in East European communist societies: White-collar intelligentsia (professional, managerial and administrative positions), Skilled manual positions, Lower or unqualified white-collar positions, and Unskilled manual positions. Although income inequalities are not as great as in capitalist societies, they are still significant.

Milovan Djilas, a Yugoslavian writer, argues that those in positions of authority in communist societies use power to further their own interests. He claims that the bourgeoisie of the West have been replaced by a new ruling class in the East. This 'new class' is made up of 'political bureaucrats', many of whom are high ranking officials of the Communist Party. Although in legal terms, the forces of production are communally owned, Djilas argues that in practice they are controlled by the new class for its own benefit. Political bureaucrats direct and control the economy and monopolize decisions about the distribution of income and wealth. If anything, Djilas sees the new class as more exploitive than the bourgeoisie. Its power is even greater because it is unchecked by political parties. Djilas claims that in a single party state political bureaucrats monopolize power. In explaining the source of their power, Djilas maintains the Marxian emphasis on the forces of production. He argues that the new class owes its power to the fact it controls the forces of production. Others have reversed this argument claiming that in communist societies economic power derives from political power. Thus T.B. Bottomore argues that the new class 'controls the means of production because it has political power'.

The German sociologist Ralf Dahrendorf has modified the Marxian theory of class and class struggle to make it applicable to contemporary industrial societies. He examined the nature of conflict in industry with particular reference to the role of trade unions. He argues that by the latter half of 20th century trade unions were generally accepted as legitimate by employers and the state.

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Dahrendorf regards this as the major step towards industrial democracy and the institutionalization of industrial conflict.

Trade unions form the major groups representing the interests of employees in general and the manual working class in particular. A number of sociologists have argued that largely through trade unionism, the working class has been integrated into capitalist society. Conflict between employers and employees has been institutionalized in terms of an agreed upon set of rules and procedures. The net result is increasing stability in industrial society. No longer is the working class seen as a threat to social order a Marx believed; there is less and less chance of the kind of class conflict which Marx predicted.

Dahrendorf argues that the voice of the working class is growing louder through its formal associations. He sees a trend towards a more equal balance of power between employers and employees and the development of what he terms, 'industrial democracy'. He argues that with the formation of workers' interest groups a number of processes occurred which furthered the integration of the working class into the structure of capitalist society. Firstly, negotiating bodies were set up for formal negotiation between representatives of employer and workers. Such negotiation take place within a framework of agreed upon rules and procedures. Conflict is largely contained and resolved within this framework. Secondly, should negotiations break down, a machinery of arbitration has been institutionalized in terms of which outside bodies mediate between the parties in dispute. Thirdly, within each company workers are formally represented, for example by shop stewards, who represent their interest on a day-to-day basis. Finally, there is a tendency 'towards an institutionalization of workers participation in industrial management'.

The American sociologist Seymour M. Lipset has also argued that trade unions 'serve to integrate their members in the larger body politic and give them a basis for loyalty to the system'. Via trade unions, the interests of the working class are represented at the highest level and in this way the working class as a whole is integrated into 'the larger body politic'. The picture which emerges from this discussion is one of fully-fledged interest groups – trade unions – effectively representing workers' interests. Industrial conflict has been institutionalized and the working class has been integrated into both the capitalist enterprise and society as a whole.

However, although Marx's predictions regarding the future of capitalist societies have been largely disproved by the developments of history in 20th century, yet Marx's concepts of historical materialism, class and class conflict and his theory of social change (if shorn of the prophetic elements) remains a valuable

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contribution to social sciences in understanding the social structure and change in the society.

Thirdly, Marx's concept of alienation is another important contribution to sociology. The concept of alienation was further developed by other sociologists like C.Wright Mills, Herbert Marcuse, Seeman, Robert Blauner, etc., to adapt it to contemporary societies. However, critics argue that Marx misjudged the extent of alienation in the average worker. The great depth of alienation and frustration which Marx "witnessed" among the workers of his day is not "typical" of today's capitalism or its worker who tends to identify increasingly with a number of "meaningful" groups—religious, ethnic, occupational and local. This is not to deny the existence of alienation but to point out that alienation results more from the structure of bureaucracy and of mass society than from economic exploitation. Further, Robert Blauner believes that automation reverses the 'historic trend' towards increasing alienation in manufacturing industry and produced non-alienated worker.

Herbert Marcuse's *Re-examination of the Concept of Revolution* is a significant contribution to Marxist sociology. According to him, "the *Marxian concept of a revolution* carried by the majority of the exploited masses, culminating in the 'seizure of power' and in the setting up of a proletarian dictatorship which initiates socialization, *is 'over-taken' by the historical development*: it pertains to a stage of capitalist productivity and organization which has been overtaken. He argues that although the Marxian prophecy of the downfall of capitalism has not come true, Marx's concept of revolution which is at once a historical concept and a dialectical concept is relevant in two different contexts. Firstly, in the capitalist countries, there is a standing opposition whose members are drawn from the ghetto population and the middle-class intelligentsia, especially among students. These groups are vocal; they reject the system, form counter-cultures and profess adherence to radical political beliefs and new lifestyles. Yet, they cannot become agents of revolutionary change unless actively supported by a politically articulate working class freed from the shackles of bureaucratic trade unions and establishment-oriented party machinery. Secondly, in the predominantly agrarian countries of the Third World, there are peasant revolutions and national liberation movements.

Marcuse also perceives a "fateful link" between the two revolutionary movements. In the first place, the national liberation movements in the developing countries "are expressive of the internal contradictions of the global capitalist system"—the colonialism and economic exploitation perpetrated by the corporate capitalism. This position is actively endorsed by Andre Gunder Frank whose extensive research in Latin America has led him to conclude that the

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underdevelopment of the Third World countries is initiated and aggravated by the capitalist system of the developed countries which have satellized and exploited developing countries. Thus the radical protest in capitalist countries and the revolutionary tendencies in the developing nations are closely related—in their opposition to multinational corporate capitalism and their orientation to the imperatives of a global revolution.

A Note on Convergence Theory

Some scholars argue that in certain respects, the overall picture of stratification in communist societies is similar to that of the West. A number of American sociologists have argued that stratification systems in all industrial societies, whether capitalist or communist, are becoming increasingly similar. This view, sometimes known as '**convergence theory**', argues that modern industrial economies will necessarily produce similar systems of social stratification. In particular, modern industry requires particular types of workers. In the words of Clark Kerr, one of the main proponents of convergence theory, 'The same technology calls for the same occupational structure around the world - in steel, in textiles, in air transport'. Kerr assumes that technical skills and educational qualifications will be rewarded in proportion to their value to industry. Since the demands of industry are essentially the same in both East and West, the range of occupations and occupational rewards will become increasingly similar. As a result the stratification systems of capitalist and communist societies will converge.

Convergence theory has been the subject of strong criticism. Firstly, it has been argued that there are important differences between the stratification systems of East and West. Secondly, the factors which shape the two systems have been seen as basically different. Thirdly, it has been argued that the view that economic forces shape the rest of society ignores other important sources of change. Thus John. H. Goldthorpe claims that convergence theory fails to consider the influence of political and ideological forces. In the West market forces are the main factors generating social stratification. By comparison, in the East, social inequality is far more subject to political regulation. Frank Parkin makes similar points, seeking the bases of stratification in capitalist and communist societies as quality different. He argues that in the East, 'the rewards system is much more responsive to manipulation by the central authority than it is in a market based economy'. Parkin also notes a number of specific differences between the stratification systems of East and West. Firstly, income inequalities are considerably smaller in the East. Secondly the manual/non-manual distinction seems less marked in communist societies. In particular skilled manual workers are relatively highly placed and routine white-collar workers of now share the prestige and fringe benefits of their

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Western counterparts. Thirdly, the rate of upward mobility is higher in the East. In particular, there is far more recruitment from below to elite positions. However, convergence theory does not argue that the stratification systems of East and West are the same, only that they will be increasingly similar. On this particular point, only time will provide the final answer.

So far communism has failed to live up to the expectations of many of its supporters. It may be that Eastern European societies are still in the process of transition and are indeed moving towards an egalitarian goal. There is some evidence of a decline in income inequality within the mass of the population during the 1960s and early 1970s. However, there is little indication of a reduction in the privileges of the elite. From his study of elite life styles in the USSR, Mervyn Mathews concludes that not only is privilege accepted at the top, but it is 'actively promoted'. It is built into administrative practices and so institutionalized. While communal ownership of the forces of production may be essential for the creation of an egalitarian society, other changes are clearly necessary.

Dear Candidate, after giving at least three readings to these notes and making notes in the 'pointer form,' please go through the questions asked in previous years and try to attempt them. You must send your answers for evaluation to me either by email or post. You can also come and meet me to discuss your answers.

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The Elementary Forms of Religious Life (1912)

Durkheim wrote *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life* between 1902-1911, and first published it as a complete study in 1912. By the time it was published, Durkheim, was 54 years old and had become one of the leading thinkers in French social thought. While he had begun working on the problem of religion as early 1902, there were several reasons why he chose to study religion as a central subject of sociological interest at the time. First, religion had been one of the leading themes in Durkheim's sociological journal, the *Annee Sociologique* where many of the issues had focused on the question of tribal religions as a result of Roberson Davies ethnographic research during the period. Second, as early as 1890, anthropologists and ethnographers had come to view religion and religious practices as the central subject matter of social and historical interest. Studies such as Spencer and Gillen's *The Native Tribes of Central Australia* published in 1899, and Benjamin Howitt's *Native Tribes of South Eastern Australia* were among the first to carry out ethnographic studies of the religious practices of tribal societies that had not been studied previously. Third, Durkheim's colleague Marcel Mauss was pursuing anthropological interests at the time and many of his articles were featured in the *Annee Sociologique*, giving it a distinct anthropological focus. By 1895, Durkheim was persuaded that religion would be a fitting subject of sociological study because it seemed to be at the center of the social framework of society.

Durkheim's last major book, *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life* (1912), is often regarded as the most profound and the most original of his works. The book contains a description and a detailed analysis of the clan system and of totemism in the Arunta tribe of Australian aborigines, elabourates a general theory of religion derived from a study of the simplest and most "primitive" of religious institutions, and outlines a sociological interpretation of the forms of human thought which is at the heart of contemporary sociology of knowledge.

Durkheim began with a refutation of the reigning theories of the origin of religion. Edward B. Tylor, the distinguished English ethnologist, as well as Spencer himself supported the notion of '*animism*', i.e., spirit worship as the most basic form of religious expression. Animism means the belief in spirits. Tylor believes this to be the earliest form of religion. He argues that animism derives from man's attempts to answer two questions, 'What is it that makes the difference between a living body and a dead one?' and, 'What are those human shapes which appear in dreams and visions?' To make sense of these events, early philosophers invented the idea of soul. The soul is a spirit being which leaves the body temporarily during dreams and visions, and permanently at death. Once invented, the idea of spirits was applied not simply to man, but also to many aspects of the

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natural and social environment. Thus animals were invested with spirit, as were man-made objects. Tylor argues that religion, in the form of animism, originated to satisfy man's intellectual nature, to meet his need to make sense of death, dreams and visions.

Naturism, on the other hand, means the belief that the forces of nature have supernatural power. F. Max Mueller, the noted German linguist, believes this to be the earliest form of religion. He argues that naturism arose from man's experience of nature, in particular the effect of nature upon man's emotions. Nature contains surprise, terror, marvels and miracles, such as volcanoes, thunder and lightning. Awed by the power and wonder of nature, early man transformed abstract forces into personal agents. Man personified nature. The force of the wind became the spirit of the wind, the power of the sun became the spirit of the sun. Where animism seeks the origin of religion in man's intellectual needs, naturism seeks it in his emotional needs. Naturism is man's response to the effect of the power and wonder of nature upon his emotions.

Durkheim rejected both concepts because he felt that they failed to explain the universal key distinction between the sacred and the profane, and because they tended to explain religion away by interpreting it as an illusion, that is, the reductionistic fallacy. Moreover, to love spirits whose unreality one affirms or to love natural forces transfigured merely by man's fear would make religious experience a kind of collective hallucination. Nor is religion defined by the notion of mystery or of the supernatural. Nor is the belief in a transcendental god the essence of religion, for there are several religions such as Buddhism and Confucianism, without gods. Moreover, reliance on spirits and supernatural forces will make religion an illusion. To Durkheim it is inadmissible that systems of ideas like religion which have had such considerable place in history, to which people have turned in all ages for the energy they needed to live, and for which they were willing to sacrifice their lives, should be mere tissues of illusion. Rather, they should be viewed as so profound and so permanent as to correspond to a true reality. And, this true reality is not a transcendent God but society. Thus the central thesis of Durkheim's theory of religion is that throughout history men have never worshipped any other reality, whether in the form of the totem or of God, than the collective social reality transfigured by faith.

According to Durkheim, the essence of religion is a division of the world into two kinds of phenomena, the sacred and the profane. The sacred refers to things human beings set apart, including religious beliefs, rites, deities, or anything socially defined as requiring special religious treatment. Participation in the sacred order, such as in rituals or ceremonies, gives a special prestige, illustrating one of the social functions of religion. "The sacred thing," wrote Durkheim, "is *par*

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excellence that which the profane should not touch and cannot touch with impunity." The profane is the reverse of the sacred. "The circle of sacred objects," continued Durkheim, "cannot be determined once for all. Its existence varies infinitely, according to the different religions." The dichotomy of the sacred and the profane arises out of the dualistic nature of life experience itself. Sacredness is essentially a matter of attitude on the part of the people towards various animate and inanimate objects. But it is not an intrinsic characteristic of the objects themselves. It is the society which designates certain objects as sacred and expects its members to show an attitude of awe and reverence towards these objects. For example, the holy water from Ganges is regarded as sacred by the Hindus inspite of the fact that Ganges these days is highly polluted. Thus sacredness is a quality super imposed by society only. Further, according to Durkheim, the sacred is radically opposed to profane. Unlike the profane, the sacred is non-utilitarian and non-empirical, is strength giving and sustaining, elicits intense respect and makes an ethical demand on the believer.

Accordingly, Durkheim defines religion as a *"unified system of beliefs and practices relative to sacred things, that is to say, things set apart and forbidden—beliefs and practices which unite in one simple moral community called a Church, all those who adhere to it.*" Beliefs and practices unite people in a social community by relating them to sacred things. This collective sharing of beliefs, rituals, etc., is essential for the development of religion. The sacred symbols of religious belief and practice refer, not to the external environment or to individual human nature but only to the moral reality of society.

Durkheim uses the religion of various groups of Australian aborigines to develop his argument. He sees their religion, which he calls **totemism**, as the simplest and most basic form of religion. Aborigine society is divided into several clans. A clan is like a large extended family with its members sharing certain duties and obligations. For example, clans have a rule of exogamy – members may not marry within the clan. Clan members have duty to aid and assist each other; they join together to mourn the death of one of their number and to revenge a member who has been wronged by someone from another clan. Each clan has a totem, usually an animal or a plant. The totem is symbol. It is the emblem of the clan, 'It is its flag; it is the sign by which each clan distinguishes itself from all others'. However, the totem is more than this, it is a sacred symbol. The totem is 'The outward and visible form of the totemic principle or god'. Durkheim argues that if the totem, 'Is at once the symbol of god and of the society, is that not because the god and the society are only one?' Thus he suggests that in worshipping god, men are in fact worshipping society. Society is the real object of religious veneration.

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Thus, instead of animism or naturism, Durkheim took the "totemism" among the Australian tribes as the key concept to explain the origins of religion. Ordinary objects, whether pieces of wood, polished stones, plants or animals, are transfigured into sacred objects once they bear the emblem of the totem. Durkheim writes:

> Totemism is the religion, not of certain animals or of certain men or of certain images, but of a kind of anonymous and impersonal force which is found in each of these beings, without however being indentified with any one of them. None possesses it entirely, and all participate in it. So independent is it of the particular subjects in which it is embodied that it precedes them just as it is adequate to them. Individuals die, generations pass away and are replaced by others. But this force remains ever present, living, and true to itself. It quickens today's generation just as it quickened yesterday's and as it will quicken tomorrow's. Taking the word in a very broad sense, one might say that it is the god worshipped by each totemic cult; but it is an impersonal god, without a name, without a history, abiding in the world, diffused in a countless multitude of things.

Totem, Durkheim explained, refers to an implicit belief in a mysterious or sacred force or principle that provides sanctions for violations of taboos, inculcates moral responsibilities in the group, and animates the totem itself. The emphasis, in keeping with his overall emphasis upon social analysis of social phenomena, was upon the collective activities as the birthplace of religious sentiments and ideas. According to Durkheim, the essence of Totemism is the worship of an impersonal, anonymous forced, at once immanent and transcendent. This anonymous, diffuse force which is superior to men and very close to them is in reality society itself.

How does man come to worship society? Sacred things are 'considered superior in dignity and power to profane things and particularly to man'. In relation to the sacred, man's position is inferior and dependent. This relationship between man and sacred things is exactly the relationship between man and society. Society is more important and powerful than the individual. Durkheim argues that, 'Primitive man comes to view society as something sacred because he is utterly dependent on it'. But why does man not simply worship society itself? Why does he invent a sacred symbol like a totem? Because, Durkheim argues, 'it is easier for him to visualize and direct his feelings of awe toward a symbol than towards so complex a thing as a clan'.

Here in lies Durkheim's functional explanation of religion. He is trying to bring out the consequences of religion, which is a part of the society, for the society as a whole. The attitudes of reverence and respect which are expressed, through religious beliefs and rituals, towards the sacred objects are in fact an indirect expressions of reverence for the society. Participation in religious worship builds respect for society's values and norms, hence, acting as an agency of social control. Further, collective participation in common rituals and holding common

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beliefs creates a sense of 'We-ness' among the members of the society and thus strengthens solidarity in the society.

Durkheim argues that social life is impossible without the shared values and moral beliefs which form the 'collective conscience'. In their absence, there would be no social order, social control, social solidarity or cooperation. In short, there would be no society. Religion reinforces the collective conscience. The worship of society strengthens the values and moral beliefs which form the basis of social life. By defining them as sacred, religion provides them with greater power to direct human action. The attitude of respect towards the sacred is the same attitude applied to social duties and obligations. In worshipping society, men are, in effect, recognizing the importance of the social group and their dependence upon it. In this way religion strengthens the unity of the group, it promotes social solidarity. The social group comes together in religious rituals infused with drama and reverence. Together, its members express their faith in common values and beliefs. In this highly charged atmosphere of collective worship, the integration of society is strengthened. Members of society express, communicate and comprehend the moral bonds which unite them.

Moreover, Durkheim claims that just as societies in the past have created gods and religion, societies of the future are inclined to create new gods and new religions when they are in a state of exaltation. When societies are seized by the sacred frenzy, and when men, participating in ritualistic ceremonies, religious services, feasts and festivals, go into a trance, people are united by dancing and shouting and experience a kind of phantasmagoria. Men are compelled to participate by the force of the group which carries them outside of themselves and gives them a sensation of something that has no relation to every day experience. During such moments of sacred frenzy and collective trance, new gods and new religions will be born.

Durkheim believed he had solved the religious-moral dilemma of modern society. If religion is nothing but the indirect worship of society, modern people need only express their religious feelings directly toward the sacred symbolization of society. The source and object of religion, Durkheim pointed out, are the collective life—the sacred is at bottom 'society personified'. Therefore, a secular sociological explanation of religion could sound something like this—the individual who feels dependent on some external moral power is not a victim of hallucination but a responsive member of society. The substantial function of religion, said Durkheim, is the creation, reinforcement, and maintenance of social solidarity. He argued that religious phenomena emerges in any society when a separation is made between the sphere of the profane—the realm of everyday utilitarian activities—and the sphere of the sacred—the area that pertains to the numerous, the transcendental, the extraordinary.

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Religion, as Durkheim saw and explained it, is not only a social creation, but is in fact society divinized. Durkheim stated that the deities which men worship together are only projections of the power of society. If religion is essentially a transcendental representation of the powers of society, then the disappearance of traditional religion need not herald the dissolution of society. Furthermore, Durkheim reasoned that all that is required for modern men now was to realize directly that dependence on society, which before, they had recognized only through the medium of religious representation. "We must," he explained, "discover the rational substitute for these religious notions that for a long time have served as the vehicle for the most essential moral ideas". On the most general plane, religion as a social institution serves to give meaning to man's existential predicaments by tying the individual to that supra individual sphere of transcendent values which is ultimately rooted in his own society. Thus, he advocated a new humanistic religion for the modern society.

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With this study of religion, Durkheim successfully demonstrated the application of functionalist methodology in sociology and social anthropology which subsequently influenced the works of B. Malinowski and A.R. Radcliffe-Brown. Durkheim's ideas remain influential, though they are not without criticism. Some anthropologists have argued that he is not justified in seeing totemism as a religion. Most sociologists believe that Durkheim has overstated his case. Whilst agreeing that religion is important for promoting social solidarity and reinforcing social values, they would not support the view that religion is the worship of society. For example, like Durkheim, Malinowski uses data from small-scale non-literate societies to develop his thesis on religion. Many of his examples are drawn from his field work in the Trobriand Islands off the coast of New Guinea. Like Durkheim, Malinowski sees religion as reinforcing social norms and values and promoting social solidarity. Unlike Durkheim, however, he does not see religion reflecting society as a whole, nor does he see religious ritual as the worship of society itself. Malinowski identifies specific areas of social life with which religion is concerned, to which it is addressed. These are situations of emotional stress which threaten social solidarity.

Anxiety and tension tend to disrupt social life. Situations which produce these emotions include 'crises of life' such as birth, puberty, marriage and death. Malinowski notes that in all societies these life crises are surrounded with religious ritual. He sees death as the most disruptive of these events. Religion deals with the problem of death in the following manner. A funeral ceremony expresses the belief in immortality, which denies the fact of death, and so comforts the bereaved. Other mourners support the bereaved by their presence at the ceremony. This comfort and support checks the emotions which death produces, and controls the stress and anxiety which might disrupt society. Death is 'socially destructive' since it removes a member from society. At a funeral ceremony the social group unites to support the bereaved. This expression of social solidarity re-integrates society.

A second category of events, undertakings which cannot be fully controlled or predicted by practical means, also produces tension and anxiety. From his observations in the Trobriand Islands, Malinowski noted that such events were surrounded by ritual. Fishing is an important subsistence practice in the Trobriands. Malinowski observed that in the calm waters of the lagoon, 'fishing is done in an easy and absolutely reliable manner by the method of poisoning, yielding abundant results without danger and uncertainty'. However, beyond the barrier reef in the open sea there is danger and uncertainty. A storm may result in loss of life. The catch is dependent on the presence of a shoal of fish which cannot be predicted. In the lagoon, 'where man can rely completely on his knowledge and skill', there are no rituals associated with fishing whereas fishing in the open sea is preceded by rituals to ensure a good catch and protect the fishermen. Although Malinowski refers to these rituals as magic, others argue it is reasonable to regard

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them as religious practices. Again we see ritual addressed to specific situates which produce anxiety. Rituals reduce anxiety by providing confidence and a feeling of control. As with funeral ceremonies, fishing rituals are social events. The group unites to deal with situations of stress, and so the unity of the group is strengthened.

Here we can see that while Durkheim analysed the functional aspect of religion for the society as a whole, Malinowski, on the other hand, also talks of the functional consequences at the individual level, thus offering a critique to Durkheim's extreme social realism. Malinowski's distinctive contribution to the sociology of religion is his argument that religion promotes social solidarity by dealing with situations of emotional stress which threaten the stability of society.

In his essay, '*The Comparative Method in Social Anthropology*', Radcliffe-Brown further extended the argument of Durkheim to explain why a particular totem is chosen by a society or group as its totem. In a comparative analysis of various tribes of Australia and north-west America, he found various instances whereby a tribe was divided into two exogamous moieties and each moiety represented by particular natural specie as its totem. For example, in case of Australian aborigines in New South Wales, the two moieties were represented by eaglehawk and crow. On the basis of his comparative study, he concluded that the selection of a particular set of natural species as the totem by the two exogamous moieties of a tribe is also associated with their inter-group social relations. He found it common that natural species were placed in pairs of opposites, with certain degree of resemblances as well as differences. He interpreted the resemblances and differences of animal species in terms of social relationships of friendship and antagonism in human society.

Further, Robert K. Merton argues that Durkheim's views on religion are more relevant to small, non-literate societies, where there is a close integration of culture and social institutions, where work, leisure, education and family life tend to merge, and where members share a common belief and value system. They are less relevant to modern societies, which have many subcultures, social and ethnic groups, specialized organizations and a range of religious beliefs, practices and institutions. Merton asserts that Durkheim's view that religion act as an agency of social control and provided solidarity, is true only for simple small scale societies which practice a single common religion. In the case of modern industrial societies religion has lost both these function. Given the highly differentiated and diversified nature of modern societies, religion can no longer act as an agency of social control. Further, the existence of a plurality of religions, quite often lead to inter-religious conflicts and therefore endanger solidarity rather than enhancing it. This could be seen in terms of the increasing communal riots at local level and deepening religious divide at international level.

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Further, contrary to Durkheim's view that religion is in fact 'society divinized' and promotes solidarity in the society, Marx argues that religion is a part of the superstructure and thus it not only reflects but also reinforces the ruling class ideology. Marx further argues that religion acts as an opiate to dull the pain produced by oppression. In Marx's words, 'Religion is the sigh of the oppressed creature, the sentiment of a heartless world and the soul of soulless conditions. It is the opium of the people'. It does nothing to solve the problem, it is simply a misguided attempt to make life more bearable. As such, religion merely stupefies its adherents rather than bringing them true happiness and fulfillment. To Marx, religion is an illusion which eases the pain produced by exploitation and oppression. It is a series of myths which justify and legitimate the subordination of the subject class and the domination and privilege of the ruling class. It is a distortion of reality which provides many of the deceptions which form the basis of ruling class ideology and false class consciousness.

Durkheim, in his study of religion, pointed to two major functions of religion, viz. social solidarity and social control. However, as evident from Max Weber's study of *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*, religion may also serve as an agent of social change. Weber's study of ascetic Protestantism argued that religious beliefs provided the ethics, attitudes and motivations for the development of capitalism. Thus, leading to the transformation of a predominantly feudal European society into a capitalistic one.

More recently, some scholars have highlighted an altogether new role that religion is playing in the contemporary world politics, as an ideology of protest. They argue that with welfare state failing to deliver on the basic amenities of life and communism still a utopia, religion has emerged as a potent ideology of protest by the disenchanted masses. This phenomenon is far more explicit and rampant mainly in the third world developing countries. Rapidly spreading and powerful currents of Islamic fundamentalism could be cited as an example here. In Indian context, we can also cite the example of Dalit movement led by Dr. B.R. Ambedkar. In its later stage Dalit movement also made use of Buddhist ideology of egalitarianism to protest against the social inequalities and injustice perpetrated by the traditional caste system.

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Weber: An Assessment

Weber's importance as a classical sociologist did not begin until Talcott Parsons introduced him to the American public. Parson himself studied and defended a dissertation in Heidelberg during the latter half of the 1920s. And in 1930 he translated *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism* into English. Parsons later based much of his book *The Structure of Social Action* (1937) on Weber, and as Parsons's influence grew in American and later in international sociology, Weber also gained more and more status as a classic.

Weber's contribution to modern sociology is multi dimensional so much so that he can be legitimately considered as one of the founding fathers of modern sociology. He contributed a new perspective on the nature of subject matter of sociology and laid down the foundations of interpretative sociology. In addition, he carried out penetrating analysis of some of the crucial features of western society like social stratification, bureaucracy, rationality and growth of capitalism. As should be clear from this introduction to Weber's work his influence on social theory has been considerable.

Firstly, by viewing the subject matter of sociology in terms of social action, he highlighted the significance of subjective meanings and motives in understanding social behavior. This view of Weber presented an alternative and a corrective to the positivist approach in sociology. The positivists like Durkheim, by assuming a deterministic perspective had almost totally ignored the role of the individual's subjectivity in shaping social behavior. They had restricted the study of social behaviour to externally observable aspects only. Thus Weber's emphasis on exploring the subjective dimension provided a corrective to overly social determinist perspective of the positivist.

Secondly, in terms of methodology, Weber extends the conceptual tool kit of social theory by drawing attention to uniqueness of social phenomena and especially to their qualitative and subjective dimensions. While recognising the difficulty of doing so, he recommends that social phenomena need to be seen from the point of view of social actors themselves, and not just from the abstract vantage point of the social theorist. His discussions of *Verstehen*, ideal types, causal pluralism and value-neutrality are intended to assist in this process. Thus, Weber came to be seen as one of the founders of a "subjectivist" and phenomenological sociology.

Thirdly, Weber extends the analysis of social development offered by Marx in order to include not only material economic factors, but intellectual ones as well. It is the struggle over ideas that fuels social development not just technological innovation. Raising an issue that has been taken up by social theorists such as

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Anthony Giddens during the 20th century, Weber also draws attention to the fact that social events are much more contingent than we might like to think they are. He still tells us an interesting and persuasive story about the historical origins of modern capitalism, but all the while insists that things could have turned out quite differently. Social theory needs to work at the level of actual events rather than trying to interpret events in order to substantiate a general theory of how thing ought to or must have developed.

Fourthly, corresponding with his methodological recommendation of trying to understand social action from the point of view of the individual social actor Weber strongly supports the need for social theory to include non-material phenomena. He thus prepares the way for a much more forthright analysis of the importance of **hermeneutic** or meaning-laden aspects of social phenomena that was to follow later in the 20th century.

Further, Weber's methodological individualism also sets him apart from Durkheim and Marx, both of whom adopt a strongly collectivist interpretation of social action. Although Weber accepts that social actors often act together, and with shared ideas and common aims in mind, he resists the idea that individuals are drawn towards particular ways of acting by the pull of collective forces. Weber's social theory is more **voluntaristic** in the sense that social actors choose how to act rather than being compelled to do so by social forces beyond their control. For much the same reason, Weber concentrates on a theory of social action and not on a theory of society.

Finally, and in terms of his own sociological analyses of modern society, Weber identifies the crucial significance in social development of the general concept of rationality, which was central to Enlightenment thought and the idea of reason. He then refines this into a robust and thoroughly modern concept of instrumental rationality. Although opinion differs over the exact formula of instrumental rationality it is widely accepted that this is the kind of rationality that is most characteristic of modern society. One of the major preoccupations of critical social theory and the Frankfurt School, and of Jurgen Habermas, is to continue to explore the negative impact on modern society of the idea of instrumental rationality described by Max Weber.

During the past decade, in particular, with its debate over "postmodernism," Weber's critique of blind faith in science and rationality seems to have appealed to many. Thus, he is not just an early predecessor of modern sociology and social science, but he is definitely present, participating in the debate over the problems of modern society.

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A note on the conflict tradition after Marx and Weber:

Although the foundations of the conflict approach to the study of social phenomena were laid down by Karl Marx. However to adapt this approach to contemporary societies, it had to be interpreted in the light of the criticism and modification suggested by Weber. Thus, the imprint of Weber's ideas is clearly visible in the works of contemporary conflict theorists like C.W. Mills and Ralf Dahrendorf. Even those belonging to the Frankfurt School of thought namely Theodor Adorno, Herbert Marcuse, Jurgen Habermas etc. have also been influenced by Weber's ideas. However, Ralf Dahrendorf a contemporary German scholar has presented the conflict theory in a more systematized manner.

Ralf Dahrendorf in his book *Class and Class Conflict in Industrial Society* also examines the usefulness and applicability of Marx's sociological work to the study of modern industrial society. He argues that Marx's analysis of 19th century capitalist society was largely correct and his concepts and theories were valuable. However these concepts and theories require to be modified if they are to be applied to the modern industrial society because they refer to specifically to the 19th century capitalistic society. There have been highly significant changes in the social structure since Marx's time. In fact these changes have been great enough to produce a new type of society, that is, modern industrial or post-capitalist society. Dahrendorf wishes to generate a body of concepts and theory which will be general enough to explain both capitalist and post capitalist societies. He endeavors to generate his new theory directly out of Marx's analysis preserving, modifying and occasionally abandoning some concepts. Dahrendorf suggest that the following changes of the social structure have been sufficient to produce a post capitalist society.

- **Decomposition of capital** (stock holders and managers): This implies the separation of ownership and control over large corporations such as joint stock companies where the ownership (in the form of equity) lies with the public at large while the control is exercised by the management, professionals, technocrats and other experts. With the growth in the scale of business companies due to technological advances and due to the development of joint stock limited liability companies, the link between the ownership and control of industry has weakened. Much control is now exerted by salaried managers, who tend to legitimize their position in industry and in society rather differently than old style capitalist. Capitalists too play a somewhat different role as shareholders or as company directors.

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- **Decomposition of labour** (from homogeneous group of equally unskilled and impoverished people, to differentiated occupational groups, with differentiated attributes and status (prestige, responsibility, authority)): Dahrendorf believes that during the twentieth century there has been a 'decomposition of labour', a disintegrating of the manual working class. Contrary to Marx's prediction, the manual working class has become increasingly heterogeneous or dissimilar by the emergence of new differentiations of skill. He sees this resulting from changes in technology arguing that 'increasingly complex machines require increasingly qualified designers, builders, maintenance and repair men and even minders'. Dahrendorf claims that the working class is now divided into three distinct levels: unskilled, semi-skilled and skilled manual workers. Differences in economic and prestige rewards are linked to this hierarchy of skill. In view of the differences in skill, economic and status rewards and interests within the ranks of manual workers, Dahrendorf claims that 'it has become doubtful whether speaking of the working class still makes much sense'. He believes that during the twentieth century there has been a 'decomposition of labour', a disintegration of the manual working class. In other words, like the controlling groups, the workers have also become more differentiated. The proportions of both skilled and semi skilled workers have grown and the proportion of unskilled workers has fallen. Far from becoming homogenized in terms of class consciousness, the workers are becoming increasingly aware of the differences between themselves.

- **Institutionalisation of class conflict (**industrial bargaining): According to Dahrendorf, the tension between labour and capital is recognized as a principle of the structure of the labour market and has become a legal institution of society. As workers have become increasingly skilled, educated and better paid, they have become more integrated into the middle layers of society. The traditional sources of discontent and labour militancy have been dissolved. The basis for class struggle is gone. Conflicts now develop within imperatively coordinated associations (institutional structures such as business organizations, unions and so forth) and are resolved rationally and fairly through mediation, arbitration or adjudication.

- **Development of a new middle class:** This term is misleading in that it refers to a large and growing collection of different groups which have been created or have expanded with the industrialization of society. It is a category rather than a class in terms of Marx's use of this concept and is made up of white collar workers such as teachers, accountants, surveyors, nurses and clerks, etc.

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- **Growth of social mobility:** There is much more inter generation mobility between occupations and self recruitment – where the son follows the father's occupation – is great only in the very top and the very low occupations.
- **Growth of equality:** Over the last hundred years social and economic inequalities have been reduced as the state has guaranteed a minimum standard of living to its citizens and has heavily taxed those with the highest incomes and those with the greatest wealth.

Dahrendorf concludes that society can be characterized correctly in terms of conflict between competing interest groups. In a post-capitalist society, however conflicts have becomes institutionalized i.e. more orderly patterned, predictable and controllable. Workers have the right to express their interests legitimately through socially acceptable machinery like collective bargaining which is conducted through their own bona fide organisations like trade unions. Conflict is not now so bitter and as potentially destructive of the social system because the changes in social structure listed above give everyone some stake in the system. Interests are pursued according to the rules of the game. The rules require the use of the established machinery for dealing with conflicts created by competing interest groups.

In the light of these arguments Dahrendorf points out what he considers to be the weakness of Marx's theories and suggests ways in which they can be modified in order to give a useful basis for analyzing both capitalist and post-capitalist societies. For him, the basic weakness of Marx's approach is in the way Marx toes power – economic, social and political – to the ownership of the means of production. Dahrendorf argues that social classes are not necessarily and inevitably economic groups, that social conflict is not necessarily shaped or determined by the economic base. For Dahrendorf, authority relationships represent the key feature of a society. In any society some individuals have the right or authority to give commands to others. These others have in turn the duty to obey. Thus individuals who share identical interest of commanding or of obeying in some sphere of activity, whether it be political, economic and industrial, may be described as a quasi group i.e. a potential group. If these interests are articulated so that members become conscious of them, then these interests become manifest and become the basis of organized and self conscious interest groups. Dahrendorf defines social classes as organized or unorganized categories of people who share manifest or latent interests arising from their positions in the authority structures in which they find themselves. For him then conflict is merely any conflict of groups arising from authority relationships. Dahrendorf argues that most people in society are unlikely to be engaged in one mighty political, economic, social, and industrial

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conflict which is generated from one structural source, that is, property relationships. Instead changes in social structure (as listed above) create the social structural basis for a plurality of interest groups and hence a plurality of bases for control.

In this way, Dahrendorf attempts to refine and develop Marx's approach to understand the social world. However, not all writers share his view that a new type of society has succeeded capitalism. For example, John Westergaard, a British sociologist, in his ironically titled article *The Withering Away of Class – A Contemporary Myth* suggests that despite some changes modern industrial societies are still similar in their basic structure to capitalist societies. Though certain changes since Marx's time have obscured the visibility of the working of the social system and have made the growth of class consciousness harder to achieve, the system is still largely built around the private ownership of the means of production and social life is, therefore, shaped in most respects by this fact.

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A note on Marxian view of bureaucracy:

To Weber, bureaucracy is a response to the administrative requirements of all industrial societies, whether capitalist or communist. The nature of ownership of the forces of production makes relatively little difference to the need for bureaucratic control but from a Marxian perspective, bureaucracy can only be understood in relation to the forces of production. Thus in capitalist society, where the forces of production are owned by a minority, the ruling class, and state bureaucracy will inevitably represent the interest of that class. Many Marxists have seen the bureaucratic state apparatus as a specific creation of capitalist society. Weber believed that responsible government could be achieved by strong parliamentary control of the state bureaucracy. This would prevent the interests of capital from predominating. Lenin, though, maintained that Western parliaments were 'mere talking-shops' while the 'real work of government was conducted behind closed doors by the state bureaucracy'. In his view, 'The state is an organ of class rule, an organ for the oppression of one class by another'.

Since state bureaucracy is ultimately shaped by a capitalist infrastructure, its control can only be eliminated by a radical change in that infrastructure. In terms of Marxian theory, this requires the communal ownership of the forces of production. Since state bureaucracy is basically a repressive means of control, it must be smashed and replaced by new, truly democratic institutions. Lenin believed that after the dictatorship of the proletariat was established in the USSR in 1917, there would be a steady decline in state bureaucracy. He recognized that some form of administration was necessary but looked forward to the proposals outlined by Marx and Engels. Administrators would be directly appointed and subject to recall at any time. Their wages would not exceed those of any worker. Administrative tasks would be simplified to the point where basic literacy and numeracy were sufficient for their performance. In this way, everybody would have the skills necessary to participate in the administrative process. Members of a truly communist society would no longer be imprisoned in a specialized occupational role. Lenin looked forward to a future in which 'all may become "bureaucrats" for a time and that, therefore, nobody may be able to become a "bureaucrat"'. He envisaged mass participation in administration which would involve 'control and supervision by all'. In this way the repressive state bureaucracies of the West would be replaced by a truly democratic system.

Lenin offers little more than a vague and general blueprint for the future. He gives few specific details of how the democratization of state bureaucracy is to be accomplished and of how the new institutions will actually work. In practice, the 1917 revolution was not followed by the dismantling of state bureaucracy but by its expansion. Lenin puts this down to the 'immaturity of socialism', but there is no evidence that the increasing maturity of the USSR has reversed the trend of

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bureaucratization. In fact many observers have seen bureaucracy as the organizing principle of Soviet society. For example, Alfred Meyer argues that, 'The USSR is best understood as a large, complex bureaucracy comparable in its structure and functioning to giant corporations, armies, government agencies and similar institutions in the West'. Milovan Djilas draws a similar picture with particular emphasis on what he sees as the exploitive nature of bureaucratic control. According to Djilas, political bureaucrats in the USSR direct the economy for their own benefit. The mass of the population is seen to have little opportunity to participate in or control the state administration.

While admitting that 'bureaucratization does militate against democratic control', David Lane maintains that in the case of the USSR, 'this must not detract from the fact that a centralized administration has been a major instrument in ensuring industrialization and social change '. Lane claims that these changes have benefitted all members of society. He believes that the state bureaucracy is committed to the development of an industrial nation leading eventually to a classless society. As such it will operate in a very different way from state administrations in the west. Whatever the merits of these various viewpoints, one thing remains clear. Communal ownership of the forces of production has not resulted in the dismantling of bureaucratic structures.

Probably the most valiant attempt to remove bureaucratic control was made in China under the leadership of Mao Tse-tung. Ambrose Yeo-chi King gives the following details of the ideals and practice of administration during the 'Cultural Revolution'. While recognizing the need for some form of administrative organization, the Maoists rejected the model of bureaucracy provided by Weber's ideal type. They insisted that organizations must be controlled by and directly serve the 'masses', that is those at the base of the organizational hierarchy and the clientele of the organization. This is to be achieved not simply by the participation of the masses but by placing control of the organization directly in their hands.

The ideal organization is pictured as follows. The rigid hierarchy of officials will be abolished. Hierarchies are seen to block communication, to encourage 'buck passing' and to stifle the creative energies and initiative of the masses. Leaders will remain but they will lead rather than command. The specialized division of labour and the fragmentation of tasks are rejected in favour of a system whereby everyone should 'take care of everything' within the organization. The expert will become a figure of the past since his technical knowledge and expertise will be spread amongst the masses. The full-time professional administrator will disappear. All administrative leaders must spend some of their time involved in actual production in the fields and factories. Finally, the fixed rules and regulations which characterize the typical bureaucracy are seen as instruments to repress the

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masses. They should therefore be changed as the masses see fit. Yeo-chi King notes that these ideals were put into practice in the following ways. Firstly by means of the 'role shifting system' whereby leaders moved to the base of the organization. In theory, this would allow them to empathize with the masses and minimize, if not eliminate, status differences. Secondly by means of 'group-based decision making systems', where for example, workers directly participate in the various decisions required for running a factory.

While applauding the spirit of these measures, Yeo-chi King has serious doubts about their practicality. At best he believes they have 'a high tendency towards organizational instability'. He sees them offering little hope for the economic modernization of China on which the Maoists placed such emphasis. With China's more recent moves towards the West, it appears that the organizations by which 'the Masses take command' have been put to one side. Yeo-chi King suggests that 'Mao's intervention was a kind of charismatic breakthrough from the bureaucratic routinization'. If Weber is correct and charismatic authority is rapidly routinized into traditional or rational-legal authority structures, then the organizational experiments of the Cultural Revolution were necessarily shortlived.

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Durkheim: An Assessment

Durkheim has exerted a great influence on the social sciences, especially the functionalist and structuralist schools of anthropology and sociology. His was the dominant theory of social science in France from the beginning of the twentieth century. After his death in 1917, many of his students refined his core ideas. In anthropology, central theorists like Radcliff-Brown and Levi-Strauss have built on the Durkheim an inheritance. In sociology, the structural functionalist Talcott Parsons refined many of Durkheim's ideas. Parsons's central role in sociology from World War II until the 1970s contributed to maintaining an interest in Durkheim, and Parsons's heirs still consider Durkheim an important forerunner.

Durkheim's theories have also been subjected to harsh criticism by later social scientists. Most of his most important ideas (for example, those on social facts and holism) have been rejected by many supporters of individualist positions, such as rational choice theory, exchange theory, symbolic interactionism, and ethnomethodology. And his belief in integration and consensus, and his lack of concern with problems of power, have been criticized by supporters of more conflict-oriented theory, for example, Marxists.

Durkheim carved out a special field of study for sociology, established a sound empirical methodology and laid the foundation of structural functionalism, the dominant school of sociological theory today. It is a fact that despite some criticism to his concepts such as collective conscience and social facts, very few have surpassed his sociological realism or matched his substantive contribution to the many concerns of theoretical sociology.

One of the important contributions of Durkheim is that he delineated the subject matter of sociology with great precision and clarity. He was successful in distinguishing the phenomena studied by psychology and sociology. According to him, sociology must study social facts, those with are external to individual minds and which exercise coercive action on them. Durkheim showed convincingly that social facts are facts *sui generis*. In his *The Rules of Sociological Method*, he elabourated in detail the positivist methodology that a social scientist should adopt while studying a social phenomenon. Thus, to the main problems in sociological theory of his times, Durkheim gave clear answers, both for theory and method. Durkheim faced up to complex methodological problems and demonstrated by implementing in his works, the necessity of empirical research for a science of society.

Further, Durkheim was one of the first scholars to highlight the social consequences of division of labour. Prior to him, division of labour was explained

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in a narrow sense, limited only to its economic consequences. It was Durkheim who brought out vividly the social and cultural importance of division of labour. He analysed the nature and consequences of division of labour in terms of changing forms of social solidarity. In his book *The Division of Labour in Society* Durkheim analyses the individual-versus-society issue in terms of the different kinds of social solidarity that hold society and individuals together.

Durkheim's study of *Suicide* is also considered as a landmark study and the best demonstration of his application of social realism perspective and positivist methodology. It was for the first time that theoretical generalizations were arrived at on the basis of careful analysis of empirical data. This study gave sociology a firm footing among other social sciences and justified its claim of being a scientific discipline.

Durkheim also had emphasized that while studying any social phenomenon, a sociologist should seek for both causal as well as functional explanations. Durkheim's study of suicide is considered as the best demonstration of the causal explanation while his study of religion is cited as an example of functional explanation in the sociological world. He argued that it is the business of the sociologists to establish causal connections and causal laws. Although many are skeptical about this approach, a great number of causal connections and functional correlations have been established by sociology with a reasonable degree of probability. While pleading for causal explanations, Durkheim argued that since experimentation is impossible in sociology, we should go in for indirect experimentation, by using the *comparative method*. This particular method continues to be used by sociologists.

Durkheim is also considered the pioneer of functional approach in sociology. Functional approach was later pursued by Malinowski and Radcliffe-Brown in studying various small scale and pre-industrial societies. But it was Talcott Parsons and Robert K. Merton who revived functional approach and suitably modified classical functional approach to account for the dynamics unfolding in the modern industrial societies. Closely following Durkheim, Merton distinguished between 'manifest' and 'latent' functions. Also the idea of 'dysfunction' goes back to Durkheim's idea of pathological functions.

Without doubt, Durkheim shaped French sociology. His influence before the Second World War was insignificant, but following Talcott Parsons's *The Structure of Social Action* (1937) in which Durkheim was fully and admirably introduced to American sociology, his influence flourished. By the 1950s he had become along with Weber the major influence in America and all Europe.

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Dear Candidate, after giving at least three readings to these notes and making notes in the 'pointer form,' please go through the questions asked in previous years and try to attempt them. Always remember that without answer-writing practice, any amount of sociological knowledge would be of little use for you in qualifying civil services examination. Thus, along with understanding the sociological ideas discussed here, you must also master the art of expressing them in your own words as per the standards of the examination and expectations of the examiner, and that too, in the given Time-and-Word Limit.

all the best

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Ghurye: An Assessment

Critics argue that Ghurye's brand of sociology tends to reinforce the claims of Hindu nationalism by asserting the civilisational unity of India and centring it upon the culture of the Aryans, and by extension, Hinduism and brahminism. More important perhaps is the influence of cultural nationalism, an orientation that is never explicitly stated but which becomes apparent in Ghurye's writings on contemporary affairs. Ghurye's sociology revolves around the idea of Hindu civilisation. In Ghurye's writings, Indian 'tradition' was equated with Hindu norms, rituals and social organisation. Critics argue that evidence of religious syncretism at the level of everyday practices was ignored by Ghurye. For example, the contributions of Islam religion to the Indian culture were ignored by Ghurye.

Ghurye has also been accused of reproducing colonial narratives of caste and race as well as 'Oriental empiricism'. Ghurye accepted the racial theory of Risley and adopted the Orientalists' version of Indian culture and civilization, locating its roots in the Vedic scriptures. For Ghurye, Indian culture was Vedic culture and Indian religion was equated with Hinduism, particularly Brahminism. Although Ghurye's sociology is apparently historical in orientation, the idea of Indian culture deployed by him is homogenising, hegemonical, and denies the historicity and fluidity of Indian 'traditions'. Scholars criticize Ghurye's sociology as an *ahistorical* rather than a historical sociology; for its stress on social structure and cultural continuity; and its consequent failure to recognize conflict, oppression and hegemony.

Thus, Ghurye did not pay adequate attention to the problems of uneasy co-existence of religions of Indian and non-Indian origins in India and to the problems of *Brahminical* supremacy. Critics often argue that love for Sanskrit and a thorough acquaintance with the classical religious texts are so much characteristic of Ghurye that sometimes it even clouded the sociologist in him.

Being an indologist, most of Ghurye's works are based on textual and scriptural data. The choice of scriptures and the way of writing may have bias towards one section of society to another and offer a narrow vision about Indian society. Ghurye's own student M.N. Srinivas clearly highlighted the limitations of the 'book-view' of Indological approach and in its place advocate 'field-view'.

Carol Upadhya argues that a significant feature of Ghurye's cultural history is the almost complete neglect of economic/material content in his analysis. In his vast body of work we find few references to agriculture, crafts, trade, and so on, except in discussions of caste-based occupational specialisation. This is in stark contrast to the work of his contemporary D.D. Kosambi, for example, who also

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reproduced the Aryan invasion theory but reworked it through a materialist perspective. Ghurye's understanding of culture and civilisation dwells in the realm of ideas, beliefs, values and social practices – 'culture' in the narrow sense – and hardly encompasses questions of livelihood, control over resources, or ecological adaptation, which are so central to the modern anthropological understanding of human history and civilisation. In *Family and Kin*, Ghurye offers a rare explicit statement of this theoretical perspective when he states that his studies prove the "primacy of beliefs and ideas" (rather than material conditions) in bringing about social change. Similarly, he takes the survival of *gotra* exogamy over 2500 years as an example of the 'tyranny' of an idea, demonstrating the "role and power ... of certain ideas and beliefs in human behaviour and the social process". Within the ideational level, Ghurye emphasises religion and religious consciousness as the foundation of culture.

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Variables (Concepts) and Hypothesis

Dear Candidate, in our discussion on 'scientific method', we have learned that a social scientist starts his research by defining precisely what it is he wants to know. This he does by formulating a clear and verifiable hypothesis. Let us now discuss hypothesis and its relevance in sociological enquiry in detail.

According to Theodorson and Theodorson, a **hypothesis** is a tentative statement asserting a relationship between certain facts. Bailey has also said that a hypothesis is a proposition stated in a testable form which predicts a particular relationship between two or more variables. Since statements in hypothesis have to be put to empirical investigation, the definition of hypothesis excludes all such statements which are merely opinions or value judgements, for example, *'All politicians are corrupt'*. In other words, a hypothesis carries clear implications for testing the stated relationship, that is, it contains variables that are measurable and also specifies how they are related. A statement that lacks variables or that does not explain how the variables are related to each other is no hypothesis in scientific sense. **Variables** are measurable phenomena whose values can change. In social sciences, variables may be understood as the social characteristics that can be converted into measurable forms and analyzed. This point will be more clear in our subsequent discussion on operationalisation of concepts.

In social sciences, the social scientists tend to study and explore the various aspects of social reality and interrelationship among them. Since social reality is infinite, social scientists make sense of this infinite social reality through logical abstractions. These logical abstractions or mental constructs are nothing but the 'concepts'. Hence, when a social scientist is carrying out a research to test his hypothesis, he is actually exploring the relationship between the two concepts. Thus, in general, variables in social sciences are nothing but the concepts which are the part of the research. However, in particular, variables are described as the specific characteristics or attributes of the more general concepts. As you will learn soon that in order to carry out a research, the variables or the concepts used in hypothesis should be clearly defined and operationalised. This point will be discussed in detail with examples in our subsequent discussion on operationalisation of concepts. Further, the terms 'independent variable', 'dependent variable' and 'extraneous variable' used commonly in research have already been discussed in our earlier discussion on the 'scientific method.'

A few examples of hypothesis are cited below:

- Suicide rates vary inversely with social integration.
- Urbanisation leads to proliferation of nuclear families.

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- Literacy rate is directly related to average marital age.
- Children from broken homes more likely tend to be delinquents.

Hypothesis formulation is of fundamental importance in any research. A hypothesis looks forward. It provides direction to research. Without it, research is unfocussed and may be reduced to a random empirical wandering. Results of such an unguided research would be of little use. The hypothesis is the necessary link between theory and the investigation which leads to the discovery of additions to knowledge.

Goode and Hatt argue that the theory and hypothesis are very closely interrelated. Hypotheses are the deduced propositions from the existing theory. These hypotheses, when tested, by means of empirical investigations, are either proved or disproved. Hence, in turn, hypothesis testing leads to either revalidation or reformulation of the theory.

Let us now discuss a few essential characteristics of a good hypothesis. The most fundamental of them all is that a hypothesis must be conceptually clear. This means that the variables or the concepts used in hypothesis should be clearly defined and operationalised. **Operationalisation of concepts** refers to the process of defining concepts in terms of those attributes which could be empirically observed during research. In other words, operationalisation refers to the process of converting concepts in their empirical measurements. For example, the concept of anomie, in general terms, is defined as a 'state of normlessness' in society. Now, anomie could be observed in social, economic and political systems of a given society. For instance, the concept of anomie in social sphere may be operationalised by identifying the quantifiable attributes such as incidence of suicide, crime, honour killings, etc. on which empirical data can be collected. Similarly, in political sphere, the concept of anomie may be operationalised when it is explained in terms of the attributes like stability of the government, corruption in the government, people's perception about the government, etc. In economic sphere, the concept of anomie may be operationalised when it is defined in terms of attributes like economic inequality, poverty, unemployment, etc.

Secondly, the variables or the concepts used in hypothesis should be commonly accepted and communicable. In simpler words, it implies that there should be uniformity in the definition and meaning of the concepts used in hypothesis. Once the concepts have been clearly defined and operationalised by

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means of their empirical referents, a hypothesis must also specify the relationship between the variables. A hypothesis that does not explain how the concepts are related to each other is no hypothesis in scientific sense. For example, suicide rates *vary inversely* with social integration.

Another important characteristic of a good hypothesis is that it should be related to the available techniques of data collection and interpretation. In other words, a hypothesis must be so formulated keeping in mind the availability as well as applicability of the techniques of data collection in the respective field (socio-geographical area identified to carry out the research). Further, a good hypothesis must be related to a body of theory. As stated earlier that one of the key feature of any scientific discipline is its cumulative nature. Likewise, sociological theories are built upon one another, extending and refining the older ones and producing the new ones. This would be possible only if the hypotheses are related to a body of theory.

Dear Candidate, so far we have discussed the meaning of hypothesis, its relevance in sociological enquiry and some characteristics of a good hypothesis. We have discussed that a hypothesis is a tentative statement asserting a relationship between two or more concepts or variables. What do you understand by concept? What is the relevance of concepts in sociology? What are the problems associated in defining the concepts in sociology? Let us now try to understand and answer these questions. Though this topic has not been explicitly mentioned in the syllabus but it is a very important dimension of hypothesis formulation and theory building.

Concepts are the logical abstractions or mental constructs created from sense impressions, percepts or experiences. Concept formation is an essential step in the process of sociological reasoning. Concepts are the tools with which we think, criticise, argue, explain and analyse. We build up our knowledge of the social world not simply by looking at it but through developing and refining concepts which will help us make sense of it. Concepts, in that sense, are the building blocks of human knowledge. Concepts help in comprehending the reality that a science is engaged in studying. Concepts act as mediums of short-cut communication among those associated with the enquiry (social scientists).

Concepts and hypotheses are the core of social research. For any social research to be fruitful, it is important that the concepts or variables mentioned in the hypothesis are operationalised. As discussed earlier, operationalisation of

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concepts refers to the process of defining concepts in terms of those attributes which could be empirically observed during research. In other words, operationalisation refers to the process of converting concepts in their empirical measurements. For example, the concept of alienation is generally explained in terms of powerlessness, meaninglessness, normlessness, social isolation and self-estrangement. Now, in a given workplace, powerlessness could be empirically measured in terms of the indicators such as participation in the administration, degree of control over decision-making process, grievance redressal mechanism, etc.

Let us now discuss the various problems in defining concepts in sociology.

Social reality is dynamic in character and so are the concepts in sociology. Sociology being a relatively young discipline relies more and more on empirical research for verification and validation of the existing theories and concepts. Hence new findings lead to modification of the established concepts and theories. In other words, it leads to re-conceptualization or re-specification of a concept. For example, earlier the personality differences between men and women were explained in biological terms. However later day research by anthropologists like Margaret Mead who in her study "Sex and temperament in three primitive tribes" studied three tribes namely Arapesh, Mundugumor and Tchambuli (in the western Pacific) and concluded that personality patterns were culturally determined rather than biologically. In brief, her comparative study revealed a full range of contrasting gender roles. Among the Arapesh, both men and women were peaceful in temperament and neither men nor women made war. Among the Mundugumor, the opposite was true: both men and women were warlike in temperament. Among the Tchambuli, gender role reversal was found. While the men 'primped' and spent their time decorating themselves, the women worked and were the practical ones. Similarly, you can also discuss here that how the concepts of class, caste (jati), etc. have undergone changes with new findings put forward by later day researches.

Secondly, sociology as a discipline is rapidly attaining maturity with the contributions of several established and highly reputed schools like British school, American school, French school and German school, etc. But the contributions from diverse school of thoughts give rise to the problem of ensuring uniformity in the definition and meaning of the concepts. Concepts develop from a shared experience. Since each school of sociological thought puts forward its own set of concepts and defines the concept in the context of its unique social setting, it gives rise to the problem of communication. For example, the concepts of *Gemeinschaft* and *Gesellschaft*, which were coined by the German sociologist Ferdinand

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Tonnies, have no English equivalent. The terms *Community* and *Association* which are English translations of these words, do not convey the particular sociological meaning of these two German words.

Thirdly, due to the very subject matter of sociology, the terms used to denote scientific concepts may also have meanings in other frames of reference. For instance, the term 'bureaucracy' which implies a particular type of social structure may either be seen as a rationally designed authority structure or as an administrative institution characterised by red-tapism, corruption and official disregard for the public interest.

Another problem associated with defining the concepts in social sciences is that the same term may refer to different phenomena. For example, the term 'function' in one sense may be used to denote the contributions which a given practice or belief makes toward the continued existence of society. However, the term function may also be used to denote the causal relationship between two variables. For example, in determining that to what extent one variable (proliferation of nuclear families) is the function of another variable (industrialisation).

Further, in social sciences, different terms or concepts may be used to refer to the same or similar phenomena. For example, the terms like formal-informal, organic-mechanistic, primary-secondary, community-association, etc. overlap to a great degree in their meaning. Another problem with regard to concepts in social sciences is that a given concept may have no immediate empirical referent. For example, the concepts like social system, social structure, etc. have no immediate empirical referents or quantifiable attributes. At best they can be studied by observing the patterns of relations among the members of a given society.

Thus, a social scientist must define the concepts as precisely as possible and operationalise the concepts in order to conduct a meaningful and result-oriented research.

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Comparative Method

Dear Candidate, I would also like to discuss a few other topics which though not mentioned in the syllabus but are integral components of the topic 'Research Methods and Analysis' and hence very important. These topics are comparative method and historical method.

Comparative Method:

Comparative method refers to the study of different types of groups and societies in order to determine analytically the factors that lead to similarities and differences in specified patterns of behaviour.

Comparative method is an integral component of the positivist tradition in sociology. The founding fathers of sociology like Auguste Comte, Herbert Spencer and Emile Durkheim laid great emphasis on the use of 'comparative method' in any sociological enquiry. In the 19th century, when sociology as a discipline was still in its infancy stage, the principle attraction of the comparative method lay in the belief that it could be used for discovering scientific laws about human society and culture. The strong advocates of the comparative method believed in the possibility of a natural science of society that would establish regularities of coexistence and succession among the forms of social life by means of systematic comparisons. Unlike natural sciences, sociology cannot make proper use of experimental method in the study of any particular social phenomena in a laboratory due to certain moral and ethical reasons. But a sociologist can surely experiment in the laboratory of the world by employing the comparative method.

Not only was the early use of the comparative method tied to the idea of a natural science of society, it was, more specifically, tied to the theory of evolution. A large part of nineteenth-century anthropology was concerned with the origins of phenomena and the reconstruction of the stages through which they had evolved from simplest to their most complex forms. The classification and comparison of the forms of social life became an indispensable part of this process of reconstruction.

The central place assigned to comparison was signalled by Durkheim when he wrote: 'Comparative sociology is not a special branch of sociology; it is sociology itself'. Durkheim regarded the comparative method as the counterpart in the social sciences of the experimental method pursued in natural sciences. He recognized that social fact could only be observed, not artificially produced under experimental conditions. Therefore, Durkheim favoured a comparative-historical

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approach because sociologists could not carry out experiments and had to rely on the method of indirect experiment, that is, the comparison of similar cases in a systematic way. In this regard it is important to note that Durkheim, following J.S. Mill's *System of Logic*, refers appreciatively to the 'method of concomitant variations' as the procedure of the comparative method. He calls it 'instrument par excellence of sociological research'. Please note that concomitant variation simply refers to the method of establishing statistical correlation between two variables. For example, Durkheim in his study of suicide found that Germany, a Protestant-dominated country, reported high suicide rate whereas Spain, a Catholic-dominated country reported low suicide rate. Hence, he arrived at a conclusion that the rate of suicide is correlated with the religious faith in a society.

However, in this regard, S.F. Nadel in his work '*The Foundations of Social Anthropology*' argues that the notion of concomitant variations do not mean the same thing in J.S. Mill's *System of Logic* and in Durkheim's sociological treatise. Nadel argues that while for Mill, concomitant variations imply quantitative correlation, but Durkheim makes as well as advocates the use of comparative method with concomitant variations to arrive at qualitative correlations. For instance, after having arrived at a statistical correlation between the suicide rate and a particular religion, he further explores what makes people of a particular religious faith more or less prone to suicide. The answer he arrived was solidarity. The lower degree of solidarity or social integration among the Protestants prone them to greater suicidal tendencies while higher solidarity among the Catholics, affirmed by the age old institution of Church, resulted in relatively fewer suicides. Hence, Durkheim concluded that '*the rate of suicide is inversely proportional to the degree of solidarity*'.

A.R. Radcliffe-Brown (1881-1955), in Britain, was another strong advocate of the comparative method. Radcliffe-Brown borrowed a great deal from Durkheim, including the idea that societies were governed by laws that could be discovered by the application of the proper method. That method was the comparative method based on observation, description and comparison of societies as they actually existed. He often used the term 'comparative sociology' as a synonym for social anthropology. He argued that in comparative sociology or social anthropology, the purpose of comparison is to explore the varieties of forms of social life as a basis for the theoretical study of human social phenomena.

In his essay, '*The Comparative Method in Social Anthropology*', Radcliffe-Brown further extended the argument of Durkheim to explain why a particular totem is chosen by a society or group as its totem. In a comparative analysis of various tribes of Australia and north-west America, he found various instances whereby a tribe was divided into two exogamous moieties and each moiety

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represented by particular natural specie as its totem. For example, in case of Australian aborigines in New South Wales, the two moieties were represented by eaglehawk and crow. On the basis of his comparative study, he concluded that the selection of a particular set of natural species as the totem by the two exogamous moieties of a tribe is also associated with their inter-group social relations. He found it common that natural species were placed in pairs of opposites, with certain degree of resemblances as well as differences. He interpreted the resemblances and differences of animal species in terms of social relationships of friendship and antagonism in human society.

Thus on the basis of his comparative study he arrived at a higher order generalization that relationships of mutual alliance and antagonism are universal to human society. However, the manner in which these relationships of alliance and opposition get reflected may vary from society to society. For example, in his comparative study of the institution of marriage, he found that the expression of relationships of alliance and opposition may take the form of joking and avoidance relationship. In joking relationship, members of opposite divisions are permitted or expected to indulge in teasing each other, in verbal abuse or in exchange of insults. Joking relationships serve to protect the delicate relationships between persons who are bound together in one set of ties and yet separated by other ties. For example, the members of different lineages are socially separated from each other, but, if they marry each other, they are also allied. Joking, thus, is one way of defusing the tensions of certain delicate relationships. Another response is avoidance or extreme respect. It prevents conflict that might arise through divergence of interest. In many societies, a man is required to avoid any close social contact with the mother of his wife, etc.

However, Andre Beteille in his essay '*Some Observations on the Comparative Method*' argues that the great wave of enthusiasm for the comparative method belongs to the past, and today there are probably more sceptics than enthusiasts. Among the sceptics, Franz Boas, Goldenweiser and Evans-Pritchard are some of the important names. For example, Franz Boas objected to the sweeping generalizations made through the use of comparative method, and recommended studies on a more limited geographical scale. He clearly stated his preference for 'historical method' over and above the comparative method. Similarly, Evans-Pritchard recommended intensive comparative investigation in a limited area rather than going for universal generalisations. Similarly, scholars belonging to the phenomenological tradition argue that the application of this method is not as simple as it may appear because social units have different meanings in different societies. For instance, the institution of marriage among Hindus is regarded as an indissoluble and sacred bond between husband and wife. But, Muslim marriage, on the other hand, is not a

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religious sacrament but a secular bond. It is a social or civil contract, which can be terminated.

However, despite these criticisms and limitations of comparative method, its significance in sociology cannot be undermined. For example, Durkheim and Weber, in their respective works have clearly highlighted the importance of comparative method as a scientific for sociological enquiry for a comprehensive understanding of social reality.

Historical method:

As discussed earlier, inquiries in social sciences could be classified in two categories, the nomothetic and the ideographic. According to this classification, the ideographic sciences are those which study unique and unrepeatable events, while the nomothetic sciences attempt to make generalizations. We can, thus, call sociology as a nomothetic science and history as an ideographic science. Historians try to increase our accurate knowledge of unique phenomena of the past, whereas sociologists try to seek information about certain uniformities in social behaviour under specific conditions. This, in principle, is the difference between the two modes of inquiry. However, the data of history are also widely used now by sociologists. On the other hand, historians have also started using data generated by sociologists for their own writings.

Historical method is one of the important methods to analyse the process of social change that occurred in past. It involves the study of origins, development and transformation of social institutions over a period of time. The historical method in sociology has taken two principal forms. The first is that of early sociologists, initially influenced by the philosophy of history and later by biological theory of evolution. It concentrates upon the origin, development and transformation of social institutions, societies and civilizations. It is concerned with the whole span of human history with all the major institutions of society, as in the works of Comte, Spencer, Hobhouse, etc. It was also employed by Karl Marx in conjunction with dialectical materialism in understanding the human societies. Marx talked of dialectical materialism to explain change as a historical phenomenon. According to Marx, the history of all the hitherto societies is the history of class struggle. He classified the evolution of human society in terms the following stages, viz. primitive communism, ancient society, feudal society, capitalist society and communism.

Yet another form of historical method is characteristic of the works of Max Weber. This is exemplified, especially, in his studies of the origins of capitalism,

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the development of modern bureaucracy, and the economic influence of the world religions. The main methodological features of these studies are that particular historical changes of social structures and types of society are investigated; and are compared in certain respects with changes in other societies. In this manner, both causal explanation and historical interpretations find a place in the social explanation. A very convincing illustration of this approach of Weber is to be found in his treatment of the growth of capitalism in Europe, as he brings out in his book, *Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*.

P.V. Young, in her book *Scientific Social Surveys and Research*, describes sources of historical data highlighting both the adequacy and limitations of historical data. The social scientists generally confine themselves to three major sources of historical information, (i) Documents and various historical sources to which historians themselves have access, (ii) materials of cultural history and of analytical history, (iii) personal sources of authentic observers and witnesses. When, how and under what circumstances these sources are to be used depends upon the discretion of the researcher's interest, the scope of the study and the availability of the sources. Historical data have some limitations, which arise mainly because historians cannot describe all the happenings in time and space available at the time of writing history. Personal biases and private interpretations, often, enter unconsciously, even when, honest attempts are made to select and interpret pertinent facts.

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A.R. Desai (1915-1994)

A.R. Desai or Akshay Ramanlal Desai (1915-1994) was born on April 16, 1915 at Nadiad, central Gujarat, into a Nagar Brahmin family. Like the Kayastha of North India, the Nagar is a writer-professional caste whose members are largely administrators in public and private sectors, self employed professionals and intellectuals. Kailashben, his mother, died when he was very young. His father, 'Ramanlal Vasantlal Desai, was a renowned litterateur, whose novels motivated Gujarati youth in the thirties to undertake rural development work for social transformation. As an officer in the Baroda State, he was required to travel extensively to meet people from various strata. This turned out to be an advantage not only to Ramanlal in writing his novels, but also for his son who was sensitive and keen on learning about his own society.

A.R. Desai learned the lessons of Fabian socialism from his father in his formative years. He actively participated in student movements in Baroda, Surat and Bombay, where he pursued his college education. In fact, he was suspended from Baroda college for organizing a strike. He graduated with economics and politics from the University of Bombay. Later, he earned a law degree and Ph.D. in sociology under Professor G.S. Ghurye from the same university in 1946. Desai's studies did not deter him from taking part in political activities. He got involved in the labour front and organized a trade union of Bombay Electricity Supply and Transport workers, dock workers, glass workers in Bombay. During this period he came in contact with student activist Neera Desai. They married in 1947. Neera Desai, sociologist in her own right, has done pioneering work in developing feminist studies. Both of them have influenced each other in their political and academic life.

C.G. Shah, "the most learned Marxist in Bombay" during the thirties and forties, and one of the ideologues of the communist movement, influenced Desai the most. Desai had become a member of the Communist Party of India in 1934, but the inner bureaucratic structure of the Party suffocated him. Along with Shah, he opposed the change in the stand of the party towards supporting the British war effort in India when the Soviet Union was attacked by German Nazi forces. He resigned from the party in 1939. During this period, Leon Trotsky's writings, particularly *The History of the Russian Revolution* (1932) and The Revolution Betrayed (1937), and other works, along with the works of Marx, Engels, Plekhanov, Kautsky, Bukharin, Maurice Dobb, influenced his thinking. He became a Trotskyist and got involved with the Fourth International.

The Revolutionary Socialist Party (RSP) attracted him and he became a member of that Party in 1953. He regularly contributed to *The Call*, the party's

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journal, and tried to expound Trotskyist ideas in the context of the Indian situation. But slowly, his writings were 'censored' by the editor when they were inconvenient to the Party leadership. Having realized that the RSP had abjured its 'revolutionary' perspective and was pursuing 'reformist parliamentary' politics, and that it was difficult for him to pursue a Trotskyist line within the Party, he resigned from the Party in 1981.

While working in the student and trade union movements in the thirties, Desai realized a need not only for studying the Indian situation but also for writing in a widely known regional language to influence the masses. His first pamphlet was on agrarian indebtedness, published in 1938. And he had been editing and publishing booklets regularly, both in English and Gujarati, for which he taps his own meagre financial resources. He had written or edited and published more than two dozen booklets under the auspices of the C.G. Shah Memorial Trust. Along with C.G. Shah, he launched the journal *Red Star* in the late thirties, which continued for a year or so. Later he edited single handedly the Gujarati bi-monthly journal *Padkar*, meaning 'Challenge.

Desai began his academic career as a lecturer in sociology at Siddharth College in Bombay in 1946 and officially joined the Department of Sociology of Bombay University as a lecturer in 1951when the influence of the Bombay school of sociology under G.S. Ghurye was declining. By the time he became a Professor and Head of the Department of Sociology in the University of Bombay in 1969, the centre of academic power had shifted from Bombay to Delhi, as the subject became institutionalized in the context of post independence developments in higher education. He retired from the University in 1976. He was appointed as a Senior Fellow and a National Fellow of the Indian Council of Social Science Research, New Delhi from 1973 to 1975 and from 1981 to 1985, respectively. He was the president of the Indian Sociological Society (1980-1981) and the Gujarat Sociological Society (1988-90). He died on November 12, 1994 at Baroda in Gujarat.

Desai has an extensive bibliography and his work and his ideas are accessible in a variety of publications that range from books and edited works to pamphlets available also in regional languages. In these publications, he explores the relationship between nationalism and the growth of classes in India; the nature of the post independence Indian state and its role in fashioning capitalism; changes in agrarian society during colonialism and the post independence period; the nature and growth of the workers' movement; new forms of urbanisation with special reference to slums; new developments in Indian politics including the political use of caste and religion by communalism; and lastly, the growth of the Rights

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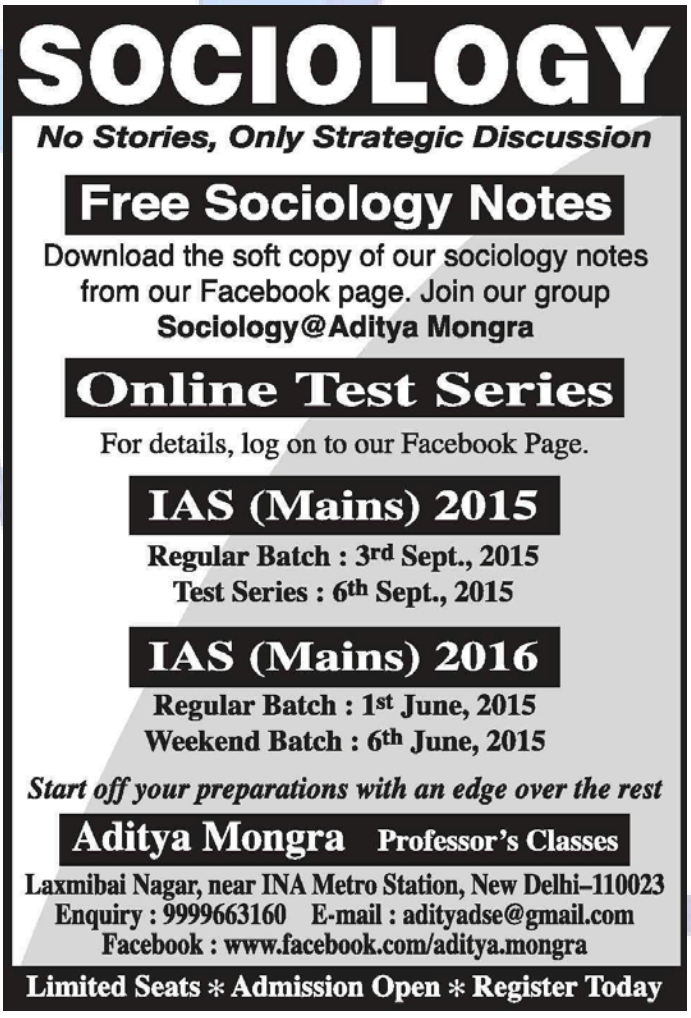
movement in India - in effect an entire range of issues and questions dealing with the transition from feudalism to capitalism in India.

A. R. Desai was first and foremost a Marxist and then a sociologist and a teacher. It was his interpretation of Marxism as a perspective that understands and explains the specific Indian context in relation to a general Marxist theory of classes that defined the contours of his sociology and his pedagogic practices. In his magnum opus *Social Background of Indian Nationalism*, Desai was concerned with understanding feudal production relations, their role and transformation, emergence of capitalist relationships and nationalist forces. The questions how and why nationalism developed in India led him to write this volume. [Please note that initially *Social Background of Indian Nationalism* was submitted as a doctoral thesis in 1946 and was first published in 1948 by the Bombay University Press as part of the Sociology Series under the general editorship of G.S. Ghurye.]



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Before proceeding further, I would like to recapitulate Karl Marx's concept of historical materialism as explained by Friedrich Engels. According to Friedrich Engels, historical materialism "designates that view of the course of history, which seeks the ultimate causes and the great moving power of all important historic events in the economic development of society, in the changes in the modes of production and exchange, with the consequent division of society into distinct classes and the struggles of these classes."

Historical materialism is thus both, a perspective as well as the methodology. As a perspective, it looks for the causes of development and change in human society in the material conditions or the economic structure of society. As a methodology, it seeks to examine the social structure and explain social change in terms of the dialectical movement of forces of production and relations of production in the mode of production of a given society.

Desai applied historical materialism approach to understand the emergence of nationalism in Indian society. In his historical materialistic interpretation of Indian society Desai examines the nature of feudal production relations in the pre-British Indian economy and their consequent change and transformation resulting from the colonial policies after the British conquest of India. He further argues that the political unification and capitalistic transformation of the predominantly rural and self-sufficient economy led to the emergence of new classes in Indian society whose interests were at variance and mutually opposed to the interests of British imperialism. This conflict of interests manifested itself in the freedom struggle of Indians against the British which got ultimately resolved with India gaining independence.

According to Desai, nationalism is a historical category. Its development has to be understood in the context of the social and cultural history of the respective country. Desai argues that nationalism emerged in the social world at a certain stage of evolution of the life of the community when certain socio-historical conditions, both objective and subjective, matured. Before national communities, national societies, national states, and national cultures came into existence, communities in various parts of the world generally lived through tribal, slave, and feudal phases of social existence. At a certain stage of social, economic, and cultural development, nations came into being. They were generally distinguished from non-national communities of previous periods of social existence by certain specific characteristics such as an organic welding of the members of the nation, living in a distinct territory within a single economy, so that they felt conscious of common economic existence; generally one common language used by them; and further, a similar psychological structure among its members and a common culture evolved by it. Though an ideal nation possessing all these traits in a state of

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fullest development remained an abstraction (since the elements of the past always survived, in varying degrees, in the economy, social structure, psychological habits, and culture, of any nation), still, from the sixteenth century onward, national communities, in different stages of national consolidation, have appeared in the amphitheatre of human history.

Indian nationalism, a modern phenomenon, is the product of a number of objective and subjective forces which have evolved since the beginning of the nineteenth century. It has emerged amidst social and religious diversities, territorial vastness and powerful traditions and institutions. The central thesis of his book is that British rule destroyed the pre-capitalist forms of production relations and introduced modem capitalist property relationships, which paved the way for the rise of nationalism. But Indian nationalism emerged, Desai argues,

> "under conditions of political subjection of the Indian people by the British. The advanced British nation, for its own purpose, radically changed the economic structure of the Indian society, established a centralized state, and introduced modern education, modern means of communications, and other institutions. This resulted in the growth of new social classes and the unleashing of new social forces, unique in themselves. These social forces by their very nature came into conflict with British Imperialism and became the basis of and provided motive power for the rise and development of Indian nationalism."
>
> A.R. Desai, *Social Background of Indian Nationalism*

According to Desai, the history of the rise of national sentiment in India is closely bound up with the growth of a unified national economy. This unification took place as a result of the destruction of former pre-capitalist forms of production prevailing in India and the substitution, in their place, of the modern capitalist economic forms. Thus Desai begins with elaborating the characteristic features of the pre-British, feudal and agrarian Indian economy.

Desai argues that a self-sufficient village, based on agriculture carried on with the primitive plough and bullock-power and handicrafts by means of simple instruments, was a basic feature of pre-British Indian society. The self-sufficient village as the basic economic unit had existed for centuries in India and, except for some minor modifications, had survived till the advent of the British rule, in spite of all political convulsions, religious upheavals and devastating wars. It stood impregnable in face of all foreign invasions, dynastic changes, all violent territorial shiftings in inter-state struggles. Kingdoms rose and collapsed but the self-sufficient village survived.

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"The village communities are little republics having nearly everything that they want within themselves, and almost independent of any foreign relations. They seem to last within themselves where nothing else lasts. Dynasty after dynasty tumbles down; revolution succeeds revolution; Hindu, Pathan, Mogul, Maratha, Sikh, English, are all masters in turn; but the village communities remain the same."

-Sir Charles Metcalfe

The village population was mainly composed of peasants. The village committee, representing the village community which was the *de facto* owner of the village land, distributed this land among the peasant families in the form of holdings. Each holding was cultivated by the peasant family by means of the collective labour of its members and with the aid of the primitive plough and bullocks. The peasant family enjoyed a traditional hereditary right to possess and cultivate its holding from generation to generation.

Desai, here, highlights a key distinguishing feature between Indian and European feudalism. Indian feudalism was distinguished from European feudalism by the fact that, under it, no private property in land existed. "In the Hindu period, the land belonged to the village community, and was never regarded as the property of the king." The king of his intermediary claimed only a part of the produce of the land, a claim which was met by the village committee as the representative of the village community. "The state had merely a right to a share always paid in kind. Under the Moslems, the existing tenures and tax system were adopted with some modifications." Since neither the king, nor the intermediaries were owners of the land, all conflicts which took place among rulers, or between them and the intermediaries or the village community; were only over the magnitude of the share of the village produce. Conforming to the traditional concept and practice, neither the king nor the intermediary expropriated the village community of the possession and control of the village land and established their property rights over it or concerned themselves with the methods of cultivation. They were conflicts for the right or power to get a payment from the peasant, not to seize his land.

European history, on the contrary, reveals a conflict between the peasantry and the manorial lords because the latter not only demanded a share of the produce, but desired to retain a particular method of cultivation—by forced labour—or to introduce new methods of cultivation (enclosure, large-scale farming). The Indian conflict was one between lords who were concerned not at all with methods of cultivation, but to draw an income from the peasantry. The issue was always between different claimants of the sword, the village and the peasantry remaining throughout the passive subject of conflict, the booty over which the rival powers fought each other. No emperor or his viceroy ever challenged the ultimate customary right over the village land by the village community.

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Further, village agriculture produced for the needs of the village and, excepting a share of this produce which the village had to surrender to the lord of the moment—may be the *suba* of the Delhi Emperor, or the *sardar* of the Poona Peshwa—the entire produce was almost locally consumed by the peasant and non-peasant village population. Besides the peasant families, the village population also included industrial workers (artisans and handicraftsmen) —such as a smith, a carpenter, a potter, a weaver, a cobbler, a washerman, an oilman, a barber, and others. They all worked almost exclusively for satisfying the needs of the village population. Thus the rural village economy was marked by low stage of division of labour based on insufficient differentiation of agriculture and industry and the absence of the phenomenon of a market.

Thus, economically, the village was predominantly autarchic. Local produce prepared mainly by means of local labour and resources was almost locally consumed. There was very little exchange between the village and the outside world. Whatever little trade existed, was carried on, generally, on a specific day of the week, at the market in a big village where a variety of goods from a number of centres was sold.

Desai then proceeds to explain the nature of urban economy in pre-British India. Amidst an ocean of tiny, autarchic villages, a few towns had sprung up and existed. These towns were of three kinds, those of political importance, those of religious significance and others of commercial value. Towns of political importance were capitals of kingdoms and empires. They were seats of governments, headquarters of princes or emperors with their courts of noblemen and satellites, army chiefs and state officials of various grades. They were also chief cantonments since the bulk of the army was stationed in capitals. There was another group of towns like Benares, Mathura, Puri, Nasik and others which were centres of religious worship and places of pilgrimage. Then there were towns which had commercial importance because they were situated on sea coasts or on the banks of navigable rivers or at the confluence of strategic trade routes. Handicraft industries, complex and diversified, flourished in these towns. As Calverton writes:

"The industries of India, far more advanced than those of the West, were the product of clever brains, fine abilities creative genius…In Hindustan the manufacture of textiles was the leading industry, and the goods produced which included diverse cloths, cotton, and silks, were internationally admired and craved. In addition, thirteenth, fourteenth-and fifteenth-century Hindustan had metalwork, stonework, sugar, indigo, and paper industries. In other parts of India, woodwork, pottery, and leather industries flourished... Dyeing was the leading industry in many parts of India, and, in a number of centres, gold threadwork and different forms of embroidery were developed to a high point of perfection...."

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It is worth noting here that in contrast to the artisan industry which had to supply the limited needs of a small village group, it was the urban industry which produced luxury articles for the aristocratic and wealthy merchant strata of the society; which produced equipment for the army, forged weapons of war and undertook the construction of military forts; which erected magnificent palaces, imposing temples and even such monuments of rare art or engineering as the world-celebrated Taj Mahal and Qutub Minar. It was the urban industry which undertook to construct canals.

However, Desai argues that the most striking feature of the urban industries was the extremely limited character of their market. This was due to the fact that they did not produce articles of daily use for the common people but functioned to meet the specific needs of the social strata and institutions mentioned above. Further, the requirements of the vast mass of the population living in autarchic villages were met by the local artisan industry of the villages themselves, thereby narrowing down the market of urban industries to extremely restricted zones.

Though there existed in pre-British India some of the pre-requisites for the capitalistic transformation of Indian economy, namely, commercial capital and urban industry, but these prerequisites could not mature so as to lead to such a transformation due to the extremely peculiar political and economic structure of pre-British Indian society. Among the obstacles to such consummation, the self sufficient village was perhaps the most formidable. Because each village being a closed system with very little social, economic or intellectual exchange with the outside world, remained cramped, did not grow. The almost complete absence of any appreciably developed economic exchange between the village and the outside world, together with the very weak means of transport which did not grow beyond the bullock-cart, isolated the village population, reducing it to a single small unit mainly living its life exclusively in the village. Since the economic life was constrained and exchange almost limited to the village, there was no necessity for travelling, except on a marriage occasion or a pilgrimage once in many years. There was, therefore, no stimulus for the development of means of transport. The bullock-cart was the chief means of transport in pre-British India.

Within the village, the economic life based on primitive agriculture and artisan industry was on a low and almost stationary level. For ages, the same primitive plough driven by the bullock, added to the elementary instruments of the artisan, constituted the sole productive forces of the village humanity. The productivity of labour being low as a result of this low level of technique of production, there hardly survived for the mass of people, either surplus of products (after satisfying the needs of self-preservation and the land-revenue claims of the

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often rapacious government) or time for organizing a high standard of material and cultural life.

The caste-stratified social organization of the village population was also not conducive to any development of individual initiative, adventure or striking out of new paths. The unit was not the individual but the family which regulated the relations of its members *inter se*. The inter-relations of different families were governed by the village community and the caste. All three, the family, the caste, and the village community, maintained ideological control over the individual who was bound to conform to their standards. As a result it smothered the mental initiative, experimenting impulse, investigating urge of the villagers for ages. The village population thus continued to live for centuries, the same sterile, superstitious, narrow, stereotyped social and intellectual existence. Desai argues that such autonomous, self-sufficient and self-absorbed villages over a period of time became the citadels of economic stagnation, social reaction and cultural blindness.

There could not, therefore, evolve any national consciousness among the people since the growth of this consciousness presupposes, as its material reason and prerequisite, unified and common political and economic life. Such an economic life comes into being only when productive forces have reached a high level of development, the division of labour has become universal and all embracing, and, as a result, there is an all-round economic exchange. The growth of means of transport and communications, arising out of the needs of such highly advanced economic life, further consolidates this economic life, and facilitates the mass movement and mass social and intellectual exchange among the people, thereby strengthening the feeling of solidarity among them.

In the epoch of the autarchic village, common economic life did not exist among the people as a whole, and hence there could not emerge any consciousness of a common economic existence. There did not exist, then, consciousness of a common political existence either, since the state did not exercise any fundamental influence on the social, ideological, economic and even administrative life of the village group. The political and administrative unity of the territory, achieved spasmodically by able and victorious monarchs, was surface unity. It did not penetrate and affect the anatomy of the social and economic structure of village life. Not only did the self-sufficient economy of the village remain unaffected by such political changes but also the social and legal processes of village life continued as before, being governed by ancient caste and village (panchayat) committees and codes.

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Thus, the objective and subjective prerequisites (such as a common economic, social and state existence, and the consciousness of such existence) for the emergence of a national culture did not exist in pre-British India. A national culture implies the welding of a community into a nation, which is consummated when, as a result of economic development (the growth of sufficient productive forces and division of labour so as to enmesh the community into a single system of exchange relations, the development of a well-ramified and rapid system of transport), it becomes economically and, in course of time socially and politically more or less integrated. The exigencies of a common economic life tend to accelerate the growth of a common language, which is a further instrument of consolidating the community into a well-knit nation. The nation, in different stages of its consolidation, evolves the consciousness of a single economic, and the urge for an independent state existence.

However, with the British conquest, the pre-British feudal economy of India underwent a drastic transformation and it was transformed into a capitalist economy. Desai remarks that the destruction of the economic disunity of India based on self-sufficient independent village economy and the transformation of India into a single economic unit by the introduction of capitalist forms were historically progressive results of British rule over India. However, to the extent that this transformation was subjected to the economic requirements of British trading, industrial and banking interests, the independent and untrammelled economic development of Indian society was impeded. Thus the British impact both helped as well as hindered the historical progress of Indian society.

Thus, the capitalistic transformation of feudal Indian economy destroyed the village self-sufficient economy and made village economy an integral part of a single unified Indian economy. It was this economic unification of India which became the objective material basis for the steady amalgamation of the disunited Indian people into a unified nation, for the growth of national sentiment and consciousness among them and for the rise and development of an all-India national movement for their political freedom, and social and cultural progress.

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Let me now explain this process of capitalistic transformation of Indian economy which was the result of the British conquest of India, the political and economic policies adopted by the British government and the economic penetration of India chiefly by British capitalism in its three phases of development—trading, industrial, and financial.

As stated earlier, there did not exist in pre-British India any form of private ownership of land. However, the British conquest of India led to a revolution in the existing land system. The new revenue system introduced by the British in India superseded the traditional right of the village community over the village land and created two forms of property in land; landlordism in some parts of the country and the individual peasant proprietorship in others. It was Lord Cornwallis who, during his term of office, created the first group of landlords in India by introducing the Permanent Land Settlement for Bengal, Bihar and Orissa in 1793. These landlords were created out of the tax farmers in the provinces who had been appointed by the political predecessors of the British rulers to collect revenue from these provinces on a commission basis. The Permanent Land Settlement converted these revenue collectors into so many landlords. Under the terms of the settlement, they had henceforth to make a fixed payment to the government of the East India Company. This was the first breach effected by the British conquest of India in her old land system based on village right over land.

Three principal reasons prompted a group of British administrators to introduce the landlord system in India. First, the East India Company in India adopted British juridico-economic conceptions for land settlements. The economic past of England was fundamentally different from that of India. The English landlord system was conceived and carried out in the spirit of the tradition of private property in land, in the past feudal period. In India, however, the creation of the landlord system had no precedent, in her economic history. Secondly, from the standpoint of administration, in earlier stages of British rule, it was found easier and more economical to gather land revenue from a few thousand landlords than from a legion of small peasant proprietors. Thirdly, for political-strategic reason, the young British Raj in India needed a social support in the country to maintain itself. It was expected that the new class of landlords, which owed its existence to the British rule, would naturally support it. This expectation of the East India Company was borne out by subsequent events. The British rule in India always found in landlord classes its staunch supporters.

The Permanent Zamindari Settlements prevailed in Bengal, Bihar and sections of North Madras and enveloped about twenty per cent of British India. While the British rule created large scale landed ownership in some parts of the country, in other parts, it created individual peasant proprietorship. The latter was

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known as the Ryotwari. Under the Ryotwari, the individual cultivator was transformed into the owner of the land he tilled. It was Sir Thomas Munro who initiated it in 1820, when he was the Governor of Madras, in the major part of that province. The Ryotwari was subsequently extended to a number of other provinces.

Thus private property in land came into being in India for the first time in its history. Land became private property, a commodity in the market, which could be mortgaged, purchased or sold. Thus the British conquest of India brought about an agrarian revolution. It created the prerequisite for the capitalist development of agriculture by introducing individual ownership of land, namely, peasant ownership and large-scale landlord ownership. This, together with the commercial and other new economic forces which invaded and penetrated the village, undermined both the agrarian economy and the autarchic village of India of the pre-British period. This transformation of the land relations was the most vital link in the chain of causes which transformed the whole pre-capitalist feudal economy of India into the existing capitalist economy.

Till the village ownership of land existed, the village was the unit of assessment. It was the village community which, through the headman or panchayat, paid the state or the intermediary a specific proportion of the annual agricultural produce as revenue. This proportion may have varied under different regimes, but it was, except in rare cases, the village which was the unit of assessment and the payer of revenue. The new land system eliminated the village as the unit of land assessment and revenue payment. By creating individual holders of land, it introduced the system of individual land assessment and revenue payment. Secondly, a new method of fixing the land revenue and its payment was introduced. Previously the revenue due to the state or its intermediary to whom the monarch had 'farmed' out the village, was a specified portion of the year's actual produce which varied from year to year. This was now replaced by the system of fixed money payments, assessed on land, regularly due in cash irrespective of the year's production, in good or bad harvests, and whether more or less of the land was cultivated or not, and in the overwhelming majority of settlements fixed on individual landholders, whether directly cultivators or landlords appointed by the state. In other words, under the new system, the land revenue was assessed on the basis of land, not on the proportion of the actual produce.

This new method and form of the land revenue assessment and payment had a far-reaching result. When previously a part of the actual annual produce constituted the revenue due to the state, the village possession of land was never in danger. If during any year the harvest failed, the land revenue automatically lapsed that year since it was dependent upon and was measured in terms of a portion of

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the actually realized harvest. The nonpayment of the revenue by the village however did not jeopardize its possession of land. But when, under the new system, fixed money payments assessed on land and not on the annual produce were introduced, the landlord or the peasant proprietor had to meet this revenue claim of the state irrespective of the failure of crop. The practice of the new land and revenue system logically and inevitably brought in its wake the phenomena of the mortgage, the sale and the purchase of land. When a landholder could not pay the land revenue due to the state out of the returns of his harvest or his resources, he was constrained to mortgage or sell his land. Thus, insecurity of possession and ownership of land—a phenomenon unknown to the pre-British agrarian society—came into existence. The new land system disastrously affected the communal character of the village, its self-sufficient economy and communal social life.

One of the consequences of the introduction of the system of new land relations and revenue payment in the form of fixed money payment was that the old objective of village agriculture, namely production for village use, was replaced by that for market. The production and produce were now determined by the new objective, that of sale, and, hence, changed their character. Under the new system, the peasant produced mainly for the market, which, with the steady improvement of means of transport and expanding operations of trading capital under the British rule, became available to him. He did so with a view to realizing maximum cash, primarily to pay the land revenue to the state which was fixed fairly high and, in course of time, to meet the claim of the moneylender in whose hands he progressively fell due to numerous causes. This led to the emergence of the phenomenon of what is known as the commercialization of agriculture. This also led to the practice of growing specialized crops by the peasants. The commercialization of agriculture, broadly speaking, might be described as a change from cultivation for home consumption to cultivation for the market.

With the rise of modern industries in England, the necessity of raw materials for these industries grew. The British government in India pursued economic policies which expanded the area of growth of such raw materials as needed by the British industries. It thereby accelerated the commercialization and specialization of Indian agriculture.

These developments also disrupted the ancient unity of agriculture and industry in the traditional Indian village. In addition to the two reasons which prompted the farmer to produce for market, namely, to realize maximum cash for the payment of the land revenue and meet the debt claim of the moneylender in whose hands he subsequently and generally fell, there was a third reason also why he produced for sale. The progressive improvement of the means of transport by the government made it possible for him to purchase the manufactured cloth and

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other necessary articles from the market organized at a village or district fair. Formerly, as a rule, he produced his own cloth and the village artisans met his other needs in return for a part of the annual produce. Now, he bought most of these things from the market. This was also one of the principal causes of the decline of village artisan and other village industries. The commercialization of village agriculture together with the decay of village industries due to the influx of the manufactured and later, cheap machine-made goods of Britain and subsequently of other countries and even of Indian industries, seriously affected the balanced village economy. Thus, the unity of village agriculture and industry, the basic pillar of the self-sufficient village economy, was disrupted. Competitive economic relations resulting out of private property and market replaced former cooperative socio-economic relations.

However Desai argues that from the standpoint of the growth of a single national Indian or world economy, this was a step forward in spite of the annihilation of self-sufficient village communities and economic misery consequent on this destruction through the capitalist transformation of the Indian economy. It contributed towards building the material foundation, namely, the economic welding together of India and of India with the world, for the national consolidation of the Indian people and the international economic unification of the world.

According to Desai, historically speaking, the destruction of the self-sufficient village was a progressive event though it involved much tragic destruction such as that of collective life among the village population, of tender human relations between them and of economic security among its members unless a war or a famine intervened. History moves dialectically. Progress is achieved not through the quantitative extension of the good aspects of the old but its qualitative transformation. Higher forms of co-operation and social existence emerge not through the quantitative expansion of old forms but by their dissolution. It is true that the capitalist transformation of the village economy was brought about by the destruction of village cooperation but its historical progressive role lies in the fact that it broke the self-sufficiency of the village economic life and made the village economy a part of the unified national economy. It was a historically necessary step towards integrating the Indian people economically. It simultaneously broke the physical, social and cultural isolation of the village people by creating the possibility of large-scale social exchange through the establishment of such means of mass transport as railways and automobiles.

How could a united nation evolve out of a people who are living an isolated existence in numerous centres, who are physically divided and between whom there is very little social and economic exchange? How can the consciousness of a

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people be elevated to a national plane when they live independent isolated lives in small groups? Like Marx, Desai concludes that the conditions of material existence determine the nature of consciousness.

Thus the capitalist unification of India based on the destruction of the village autarchy and co-operation on the narrow village scale paved the way for higher forms of economy and social collaboration. It paved the way for a national economy and nation-scale collaboration among the Indian people. It became the material premise for the emergence of the Indian nation out of the amorphous mass of the Indian people which, before this unification were scattered in numerous villages between which there was very little exchange, social or economic, and hence, which had hardly any positive common interests. However tragic, the destruction of the autarchic village and the collective life of the people living in it, it was historically necessary for the economic, social and political unification of the Indian people.

With the establishment of new land relations based on private property in land and the right of the individual landowner freely to dispose of his property in land, the agrarian economy of India entered a new and hitherto historically unknown stage of development and the agrarian population a new phase of social and economic existence. A national agriculture, as an integral dependent part of the total national Indian economy came into existence. The problems of Indian agriculture, consequently, acquired a national character. Under the British rule, Indian agriculture rose to the level of a national agriculture but it did not grow into a prosperous agriculture. In fact, the history of Indian agriculture, in spite of its becoming national in character, under the British rule was a history of its 'continuous and increasing disorganization'. It was also the history of the progressive impoverishment of the agricultural population, of the steady growth of their indebtedness, of the increasing expropriation of the peasants of their land and their transformation into paupers or the agricultural proletariat.

One of the most alarming and ruinous features of Indian agriculture was the extreme subdivision of land and its fragmentation. The amount of land available to each cultivator declined or, in other words, the holdings progressively became more and more uneconomic. There were a number of factors which brought about this state of things. The introduction of capitalist relations in agriculture in the European countries was paralleled by the creation of compact farms as units of cultivation. In India, on the other hand, no such reorganization of land was accomplished by the British. From the standpoint of ownership and individual cultivation, the land remained intermixed.

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However, the most decisive factor which accelerated the process of subdivision of land and its fragmentation was overpressure on agriculture brought about by the economic ruination of millions of urban and village handicraftsmen and artisans. This phenomenon was known as 'de-industrialization' of India, i.e. the destruction of the old handicraft industry without the proportional growth of modern industry. The result was increasing overcrowding on land. The overcrowding on land accelerated the process of subdivision and fragmentation of land.

Excessive land revenue, in the conditions of the growth of uneconomic holdings due to the subdivision of and overcrowding on land, was the prime cause of the impoverishment of the Indian agriculturist in the earlier stages of the British rule. The progressive inability of the agriculturist to meet the increasing revenue claims of the state from his declining income brought about his subsequent indebtedness.

There was another factor which adversely affected the agriculturist. It was the factor of the commercialization of agriculture under the British rule. The agriculturist now produced for the Indian and the world market. He became thereby subject to all the vicissitudes of the ever erratic market. He had to compete with formidable international rivals like the big agrarian trusts of America. Europe, and Australia, which produced on a mass scale and by means of tractors and other modern agricultural machinery while he himself cultivated his miserable strip of land by means of the labour power of a couple of famished bullocks and the primitive plough. Further, the commercialization made the agriculturist dependent, for sale of his product, on the middlemen, the merchants. The merchant, by his superior economic position, took full advantage of the poverty of the peasant. The poor peasant, having no economic reserves and confronted by the revenue claims of the government and increasingly also by the claim of the usurer, had to sell his product to the middleman at the harvest time. This transaction originating in sheer necessity brought a less amount to the peasant than it would have if he could have waited. The middleman thus appropriated a very large share of profit.

There were other factors which also contributed to the growth of poverty among the agriculturists. In addition to such economic earthquakes as the periodically occurring agrarian crises, there were such non-social causes as drought, or devastating rains which also brought economic misery to the agriculturists. The Indian peasant hardly had any economic reserves to fall back upon in bad times. A large proportion of Indian peasants got into debt due to their inability to pay land revenue as a result of bad monsoons. Famines were a feature of the economic existence of the Indian people.

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It was a vicious circle. Arising out of his poverty, the indebtedness of the agriculturist became, as it grew, the main cause of accentuating his poverty. Unable to pay his debt and even interest on it, the agriculturist not only lost his crops to the moneylenders but rapidly lost his land to him. This process of expropriation of the land of the agriculturists advanced during the present century at an accelerated rate.

As a result the number of cultivating owners and tenants steadily diminished while that of the non-cultivating landlords grew. This was the new type of absentee and non-cultivating landlord class which emerged in addition to the class of zamindars created and confirmed in permanent proprietory rights by the British government, such as the class of zamindars in Bengal, Bihar, Madras and other parts of the country.

Both these landlord classes, old and new, evinced no live interest in agriculture beyond that of gathering rent from their tenants. In a country like India where there were limited industrial avenues of capital investment and where there was excessive demand for land, investment in land was found more profitable. Agriculture was alien to this new non-agriculturist type of landlord, the merchant, the moneylender, or the wealthy city dweller. As a rule, he did not feel any urge to organize and look after agricultural production on his land, to improve its methods and technique. Since he had no vital interest in agriculture, he had purchased or secured land from the peasant debtor in a haphazard way, and not in a compact mass. Since land hunger was acute in the countryside, he leased out his land to tenants on the basis of heavy rent. Another feature of the zamindari agriculture was that, as a rule, there developed a host of intermediaries between the cultivating tenant and the zamindars, due to the widespread practice of renting and subrenting of land.

The practice of renting and sub-renting of land steadily grew also in the Ryotwari area with the land passing from the hands of the cultivating peasant proprietor to the non-cultivating owner. Thus the phenomenon of rackrenting, which was formerly confined to the zamindari areas, appeared with the growth of absentee landlordism in the Ryotwari areas also. The problem of rackrenting, like the problems of sub-division and fragmentation of land, of overpressure on agriculture, of the declining productivity and technical backwardness of agriculture, of the heavy growth of peasant indebtedness and of the general pauperization and proletarianization of the Indian agriculturists, became, by its very universality and by its being the effect of the same causes which brought about the other results, a national problem.

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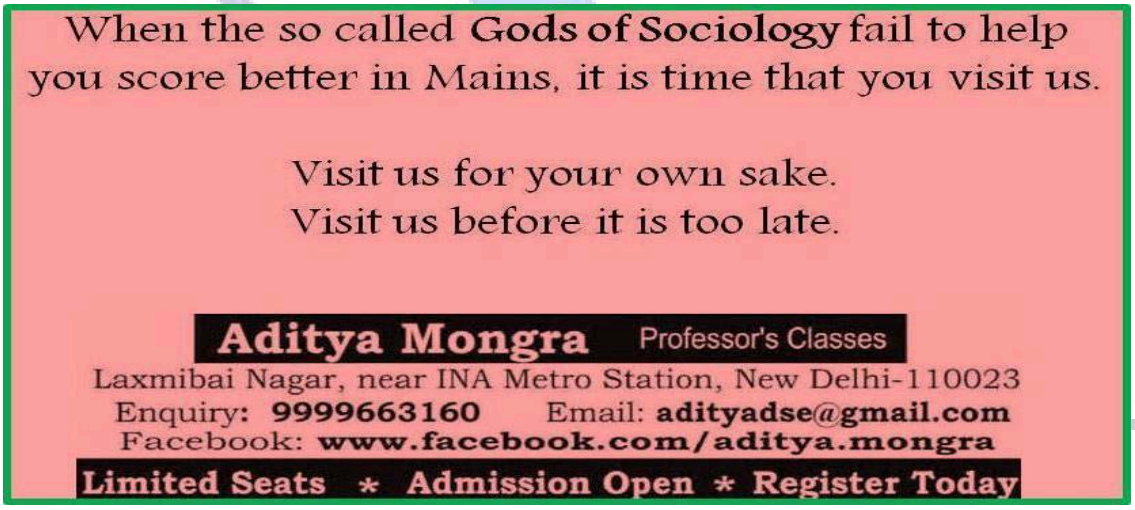
The passing of the land from the hands of the peasant proprietors into the hands of non-cultivating landlords brought about, increasing polarization of classes in agrarian areas. At one pole of the agrarian population the class of non-cultivating landlords grew increasingly; at the other, the rapidly swelling class of agricultural proletariat as well as of the poorest peasants and sub-tenants who were hardly distinguishable from land labourers.

Since the Indian people were not politically independent they could not formulate and put into action independent economic policies such as would aid the free development of Indian economy, its industry commerce and agriculture. The development of Indian agriculture was adjusted to be economic necessities of British capitalism which required India primarily as an agrarian colony for the production of raw materials for British industries. This prevented the independent development of Indian agriculture, fulfilling the economic requirements of the Indian people. Indian agriculture remained, therefore, distorted in its development—'lop-sided'.

In spite of this, it must be recognized that, by bringing the village agricultural production within the sphere of Indian and world markets, by making agriculture an organic part of Indian economy, the British rule over India elevated Indian agriculture to the status of a national agriculture. Desai considers this as a progressive aspect of the British conquest.

Since the problems of Indian agriculture became national and were conditioned by the same causes, these problems served as focal points for the mobilization of the people and its different sections on a national scale. Thus national agriculture built up by the British conquest and rule in India brought about a common material interest in agriculture among the Indian people. This paved way for the growth of a national sentiment among them to strive for a prosperous national agriculture.



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British rule also marked the decline of old handicrafts. The conquest of India by the East India Company resulted in the disappearance of native rulers in rapid succession. This disappearance and decline of states had a direct and immediate effect on the town handicrafts of India. As observed, the states were the biggest customers of the town handicraft products. The disappearance of the states also affected the industries which supplied the goods needed for the military and other purposes of these states. To take an instance, the production of military weapons like swords, spears, daggers, shields and other varieties of arms made of iron and steel, and the accompanying artistic industries like enamelling and damascening work had reached a high state of development in pre-British India. The disappearance of the states had a very ruinous effect on these industries.

Please note that in England and other capitalist European countries also, handicraft industries began to lose ground with the rise of modern manufacture and machine-based industry. But, in England and other European countries, the ruined mass of handicraftsmen was, on the whole, absorbed in the new indigenous modern industries. In India, the decline and decay of native handicrafts was not accomplished by any rise of indigenous manufacture or machine industry. The destruction of urban handicrafts, without the parallel growth of substitute modern industries, led to the disequilibrium of industry and agriculture in India. It brought about an overpressure on agriculture which was both disastrous for the economic condition of those living on the land as also for the efficiency of agriculture. The general economic policy of Britain, while it accomplished the destruction of the old handicrafts of India, did not aid the free development of modern industries in the country lest these industries should menace the British industries in the market. This mainly brought about the lack of balance between the agricultural and industrial parts of Indian economy. The second reason why Britain desired and strove to keep India predominantly agrarian was that it required the cheap agricultural raw materials of India for her industries. This made India, mainly, a colonial agrarian appendage of Britain.

Thus the class of Indian handicraftsmen, a class based on medieval handicrafts, steadily dissolved itself into and increased the class of the modern proletariat, of tenants and land labourers. They became integral parts of the new classes in India which arose on the basis of the new capitalist economic relations which developed in India during the British rule.

The establishment of modern machine-based industries in India during the period of the British rule played a significant role in the consolidation of the national economy of the country. It also generated social forces which gave impetus to the growth of Indian nationalism and the nationalist movement. It is true that the industrial development of India was insufficient and lopsided due to a

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number of reasons. Still, this industrial development created powerful social forces which helped national advance. To mention only the most important among them, the growth of modern industries brought into existence modern industrial cities which became the theatres of intense social, political, and cultural life and prime sources from which all progressive movements generally emanated. Further, the growth of modern industries led to the emergence of such new social groups as the class of the bourgeoisie and that of the proletariat, two basic classes whose specific weight in the movement of contemporary society was found great, even decisive.
The bourgeoisie and the proletariat are the basic classes of the modern capitalist society. As capitalist economy based on competition and commodity production develops, the intermediate classes of small producers such as artisans, and others, being unable to compete with powerful industrial rivals in the market, are ruined and increasingly fall into the ranks of the workers. In the countryside, too, the intermediate stratum of peasant proprietors, due to progressive impoverishment in the circumstances of capital economic environment, increasingly lose land to usurers and merchants and other capitalists and a good proportion of them become landless labourers or agricultural proletariat.

Desai argues that the establishment of railways in India, during the middle of the nineteenth century, created a condition for the growth of modern industries in India. The construction of railways in India was primarily undertaken to meet the raw material and market requirements of the British industries. Their construction also gave scope for the investment of British capital and sale of the products of the growing engineering industry of Britain in India. The establishment of railways and the accumulation of sufficient savings in the hands of the Indian merchant class to serve as basic capital, made possible the creation of the Indian-owned modern industries in India.

The Swadeshi movement which was started principally by the Indian National Congress in 1905 gave a momentum to the expansion of the Indian industries. In spite of this steady advance, the level of Indian industrial development remained low. Progress was achieved primarily in the cotton and the jute industries only. Heavy industries were absent. Engineering was only represented by repair workshops, chiefly for the railways; the barest beginning with iron and steel was just being made on the eve of the 1914 war; there was no production of machinery.

There were a number of reasons why the industrial development of India did not proceed at a greater rate. Young Indian industries required, for rapid growth, protection, aiding them thereby to compete successfully with the powerful, well established industries of countries like Britain, Germany and others. The Indian government did not grant such protection. Neither did it concretely help the Indian

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industries. Another handicap to rapid industrial development was insufficient cadres of technicians. The provision for technical education was meagre.

During the war of 1914-18, due to a considerable decline in the import of foreign goods and, further, due to war requirements, Indian industries developed further. However, the rapid industrial development of a country requires as a premise the presence of the basic heavy (metallurgical and machine-producing) industry in that country. The practical absence of such an industry in India set a limit to its industrial expansion in war-time. The absence of basic engineering and heavy chemical industries was the weakest spot in India's industrial system.

Desai argues that one of the characteristics of a colonial economy which makes it subservient to the interests of imperialist economy is that it does not possess, to a large extent, heavy industries. These industries are a vital precondition for free, balanced, and rapid industrial development of a modern society. "The real change comes in any country when the iron and steel industries begin to be successful... The development of the metallurgical industries means the real industrial revolution. England, Germany and the United States of America all started their iron and steel industries before they started their textile factories." The iron and steel industry founded by J. N. Tata in 1911 only partially met the requirements of the Indian industries.

The Second World War which broke out in 1939 gave a momentum to Indian industrial development. There was hardly any appreciable advance in shipping, aircraft and such other industries. "The progress registered even during the war has been almost all in the consumers' goods industries to the sad and striking neglect of production of capital goods industries. Cotton, sugar, paper, cement and even leather have all expanded, while the basic industries for the production of machine tools, automobiles, railway engines, ships and aeroplanes have been left out."

Since large masses of capital are necessary for starting the modern type of industries and as it is not possible to mobilize large sums from small investors, the aid of banks and big financial firms becomes indispensable. This resulted in the control of Indian industry by finance capital. India here exhibited the general feature of the economic life of all capitalist countries today, namely, the control of finance capital over almost all branches of economy. Finance capital, both British and Indian, operated through various agencies including the system of banks. The Reserve Bank of India was the strongest banking institution in the country. It had wide powers and was controlled by the Government through the right of appointment of its principal officials such as the Governor, Deputy Governors and a number of Directors of the Bank. A number of Indian nationalist economists and

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politicians declared that the substantial British domination of Indian banking was one of the decisive obstacles to the rapid as well as free industrial development of India. In the matter of financing the Indian-owned industries, both the British-controlled banks and the government pursued policies which were primarily determined from the standpoint of British economic interests and not those of Indian industrial expansion.

Another obstacle to the growth of Indian industries was the immense poverty of the agricultural population which constituted about four-fifths of the Indian people and who represented a formidable potential market for industrial goods. Further, Indian industries had entered the phase of concentration and monopoly. The disadvantages of the monopoly form of organization to industrial expansion were, therefore, inherent in the industrial situation in India.

The basic economic policy of the Indian government, though modified by the pressure of popular opinion, was moulded neither by the Indian people, nor by the Indian-owned monopolies but by the interests of British finance capital. India possessed the prerequisites, both human and material, for evolving powerful and prosperous industries which would have made the Indian people rich and an independent industrial national. Still, due to these handicaps, she remained predominantly a poor and agrarian community with insufficient industries. Industrialization of India was recognized as the main remedy for relieving the overpressure on agriculture which was one of the reasons of the impoverishment of the agriculturists. In such a situation, a programme of planned national economy, covering every branch of economic life, could have alone brought about an assured, rapid and symmetrical development of industries. Such a programme would have included the transformation of the poor and primitive agriculture into a prosperous modernized agriculture; modernization and extension of industries; development of metallurgical, chemical, electrical, machine producing and such other industries; extension of railway, bus and other means of transport; raising of technical and engineering cadres; training of agronomists on a mass scale and other vital items.

In spite of its insufficient and unbalanced character, industrialization played almost a revolutionary role in the life of the Indian people. It led to the consolidation of the unified national economy which evolved in India as a result of the introduction of capitalist economic forms in agriculture by the British government, penetration of India by the commercial forces of the world and spread of modern transport during the British rule. Industrialization made the Indian economy more unified, cohesive and organic. It raised the tone of the economic life of India. Further, it brought into existence modern cities which became the

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centres of modern culture and increasing democratic social life and from which all progressive movements, social, political, and cultural, emanated.

Desai further argues that the modern means of transport, the establishment and spread of railways and motor buses, appreciably contributed to the forging of the Indian people into a nation. In the first half of the nineteenth century, as a result of the unprecedented technological advance, together with the accumulation of capital from the trade during the previous period, powerful machine-based industries sprang into existence in England. The English industrialists were faced with the problem of rapid disposal of the products of these new and steadily expanding industries and securing raw materials for them from India and other parts of the world. The interests of the British industries urged the government of the East India Company to establish railways and construct roads in India. Lord Dalhousie, who initiated a programme of wide railway construction in India, in his famous Minute on Railways unambiguously defined the economic reason behind this construction.

Further, British capitalism was being steadily confronted with the accumulation of surplus capital which could not always be employed profitably in Britain. An outlet was needed for this surplus capital. If the Indian government were to adopt a programme of railway construction, it would require capital. A part of the surplus capital accumulated in Britain could be loaned to the Indian government and thus find an outlet. In addition to these economic reasons, there were political-administrative and military-strategic reasons for establishing railways in India. The British regime established in India had to be defended both against internal rebellion and from external invasion. For a rapid mobilization and transfer of troops at the required key strategic points, it was necessary to lay down adequate railway lines and construct modern metalled roads. Thus the military defence need of Britain also led to railway construction and, in general, to the extension of modern means of communications.

Railways and buses made mass migration of people from one part of the country to another possible. Railways also proved effective dissolvents of orthodox social habits regarding food, physical contact, and others. Railways and buses made it possible to spread progressive social and scientific ideas among the people. In the absence of the modern means of transport, scientific and progressive literature (books, magazines, papers), could not have been quickly distributed throughout the country. The intermixture of people made possible by the large-scale facilities of travel provided by modern means of transport, had profound results. This paved the way for the growth of a wider national consciousness and co-operation on a national basis.

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Further, with regard to modern education, Desai argues that in spite of the various defects, the introduction of modern education in India was a progressive act of the British rule. It was secular in character, liberal in essence, open to all, irrespective of caste or creed, unlike the education in the pre-British period. But above all, it was the key which opened the great treasures of rationalist and democratic thought of the modern West to the Indians. It was not a mere accident that the pioneers and all subsequent leaders of Indian nationalism came from the educated classes of the Indian society.

However, Desai challenged that the view of a number of British statesmen and writers who claimed that Indian nationalism was the product of the modern education which the Britishers introduced in India. They asserted that the urge for national freedom grew among the Indian people because modern education helped them to study and imbibe the doctrines of liberation propounded by western authors. While Desai recognizes the progressive role played by the introduction of modern education in India, but he argues that it would be incorrect to conclude that Indian nationalism was the child of this education.

According to Desai, Indian nationalism was, in fact, the outcome of the new social material conditions created in India and the new social forces which emerged within the Indian society, as a result of the British conquest. It was the outcome of the objective conflict of interests, the interests of Britain to keep India politically and economically subjected to her and the interests of the Indian people for a free political, economic, and cultural evolution of the Indian society unhindered by the British rule. Indian nationalism crystallized as a national movement in the latter half of the nineteenth century. By that time, educated classes grew in the country and, with the rise of Indian industries, the industrial bourgeoisie came into existence. These classes were the organizers of the national movement, which inscribed on its banner such demands as Indianization of Services, Protection for Indian Industries, Fiscal Autonomy. The movement arose out of the conflict of British and Indian interests in the economic and other spheres. This conflict of interests is the genetic cause of the Indian national movement.

Desai argues that different classes had their specific grievances against Britain. The industrialists desired freedom for unobstructed industrialization of India and protection for the native industries. The educated classes demanded the Indianization of Services, since the higher posts were mainly the preserve of the British. The agriculturists demanded reduction of the land tax. The workers demanded better conditions of work and a living wage. The nation as a whole demanded the freedom of association and press, assembly, elected legislatures, representative institutions, dominion status, home rule and finally complete

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Independence. It was out of these contradictions of interests of Britain and India that Indian nationalism grew.

It must however be recognized that the assimilation of modern democratic ideas of the west by many nationalist leaders, with the help of modern education prompted them to give the national movement democratic forms and aim. Under their leadership, the nationalist movement did not aim, after securing Swaraj, at the rehabilitation of the monarchic forms of rule and authoritarian social systems which prevailed in pre-British India. The nationalist movement organized itself, on the whole, on modern liberal principles such as elections, democratic committees, decisions reached by a majority vote etc. It also visualized for a free India, representative institutions based on democratic principles. Thus, modern education, indirectly if not directly gave a democratic direction to Indian nationalism.

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According to Desai, the emergence of the social classes in India was the direct consequence of the establishment of a new social economy, a new type of state system and a state administrative machinery, and the spread of new education during the British rule. These classes were unknown to past Indian society, since they were primarily the offspring of the new capitalist economic structure which developed in India as a result of the British conquest and the impact on her of the British and world economy. The Indian people were reshuffled into new social groupings, new classes, as a result of the basic capitalist economic transformation of Indian society. The process of the rise of new social classes in different parts of the country and among various communities was, however, an uneven one. This was due to the fact that the new social economy spread, both in time and tempo, unevenly, since this spread depended on the growth of political power of Britain in India.

For example, in agrarian areas, these new classes were principally (1) zamindars created by the British government; (2) absentee landlords; (3) tenants under zamindars and absentee landlords; (4) the class of peasant proprietors divided into upper, middle and lower strata; (5) agricultural labourers; (6) the modern class of merchants and (7) the modern class of money-lenders.

As stated earlier, the introduction of private property in land in the form of Zamindari and Ryotwari by the British government brought into being the new classes of large estate owners, the zamindars, and peasant proprietors. Further, the creation of the right to lease land brought into being such classes as tenants and sub-tenants; the creation of the right to purchase and sell land together with the right to hire and employ labour on land, created conditions for the growth of the class of absentee landlords and that of the agricultural proletariat. The creation of Zamindari simultaneously engendered the class of tenants in India. The tenants were rackrented, impoverished and suffered from oppression at the hands of the zamindars.

In the urban areas, these new classes were principally (1) the modern class of capitalists, industrial, commercial and financial; (2) the modern working class engaged in industrial, transport, mining, and such other enterprises; (3) the class of the petty traders and shopkeepers bound up with modern capitalist economy; (4) the professional classes such as technicians, doctors, lawyers, professors, journalists, managers, clerks and others, comprising the intelligentsia and the educated middle class.

Thus with the growth of modern industries in India, the new classes of the modern bourgeoisie and the working class came into existence. Indian industries were established and developed at a rapid rate only in the later decades of the

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nineteenth century and thereafter. The industrial bourgeoisie and the working class grew in number, in proportion as these industries developed. The professional classes comprising modern lawyers, doctors, teachers and professors associated with modern educational institutions, managers and clerks working in modern commercial and other enterprises, officials functioning in state administrative machinery, engineers, chemists, technologists, agronomists, journalists and others, formed another new social group which evolved in Indian society during the British period.

The main grievances of the Indian merchants was what they described as preferential treatment shown to European business by the British government in the sphere of trade and undue restrictions put on Indian trade with non-British countries. Further, the class of industrialists desired freedom for unobstructed industrialization of India and protection for the native industries.

Further, the growth of modern education in India was not paralleled by a proportional economic development of the country. As a result of this disparity, by the end of the nineteenth century, unemployment among the educated class had already assumed serious proportions. As a result, the educated classes demanded the Indianization of Services, since the higher posts were mainly the preserve of the British.

Please note that from 1880 onward, modern industries steadily developed in India and the industrial bourgeoisie grew in strength. The nationalist intelligentsia had already pioneered the nationalist movement in India and had set up the premier national political organization, the Indian National Congress, in 1885. The rising industrialist class had become sufficiently strong and conscious by 1905. From that time, it began to support the professional classes, who were already fighting for breaking the monopoly of the British in the services and professions. The industrial bourgeoisie entered the orbit of the Indian nationalist movement with their own slogans of protection, favourable exchange ratio, subsidies for the growing industries. The industrial capitalists began to enter the orbit of the nationalist movement during the first decade of the twentieth century. This class began to gravitate to the Indian National Congress during this period and enthusiastically supported the programme of Swadeshi and boycott of English goods, since it also served its own class interest. The Swadeshi Movement which was successful for some time, gave an impetus to the growth of Indian industries, especially the textile industry. The nationalist movement which was hitherto mainly restricted to the intelligentsia, sections of the commercial bourgeoisie and educated middle class, secured a broader social basis from 1905 as a result of the entry of large sections of the middle class and politically conscious industrialists.

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The modern working class or the Indian proletariat was the offspring of the modern industries, transport, and plantations, established in India during the British period. It was a class which grew in proportion as plantations, modern factories, mining industry, and transport developed in India. The Indian proletariat was formed predominantly out of the pauperized peasants and ruined artisans, who became wage earners. A large proportion of the workers had fallen into indebtedness due to their inability to maintain themselves and their families on the basis of the low wages they got. They demanded higher wages and better working conditions.

Thus, on one hand we had agrarian classes (peasants, tenants, landless agricultural labourers) and industrial classes (indigenous capitalist class, educated middle class, working class) whose interests broadly converged. Further, the pan-Indian organisation in the form of Indian National Congress under the leadership of Gandhi was able to accommodate the interest of these aggrieved classes in the national movement for independence at different stages of its development through various measures such as organisation of kisan sabhas, All-India Kisan Congress, Swadeshi movement, Non-Cooperation movement, All-India Trade Union Congress, etc.

On the other hand, we had British government with its own vested interests, zamindars and some Indian princes whose survival was contingent upon the British rule in India. As seen before, the class of zamindars had been largely the creation of the British government. The zamindars with whom the Permanent Settlement was made, were an aristocracy manufactured by Lord Cornwallis. They were entirely the creatures of the state. Due to such genesis, the zamindars, on the whole, always supported the British government. The class of Indian princes, petty and big, ruling over about one-third of the Indian territory, was another class perpetuated by the British government for political reasons.

Thus, we can see that the how these new classes emerged and how their economic interest clashed with that of British. This mutually opposed economic interest manifested itself in the form of freedom struggle for independence and got finally resolved with India attaining independence in 1947 and emerging as a nation.

This is how A.R. Desai applied the Marxian methodology to explain the rise of nationalism in India.

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Desai further summarized the rise of Indian nationalism in five stages. As stated earlier, according to Desai, Indian nationalism was the product of the action and interaction of the numerous objective and subjective social forces and factors which evolved in the historical process during the British period. He explained why the emotion of nationalism did not and could not evolve among the Indian people in the economic environs and cultural climate of pre-British India. He also delineated the fundamental economic transformation of Indian society during the British period, which was one of the most important material prerequisites for welding the disunited Indian people into a single nation. He also assessed the specific weight and described the role of other factors like modern transport, new education, press, and others, in contributing towards the unification of the Indian people and in engendering a nationalist consciousness among them.

According to Desai, Indian nationalism passed through various phases of development. As it advanced from one phase to another its social basis broadened, its objective became more clearly defined and bold, and its forms of expression more varied. As a result of the impact of forces of Indian and world development, increasing strata of the Indian people evolved a national consciousness and outlook and were drawn into the orbit of the nationalist movement. This national awakening found expression in varied spheres of national life, social, political, cultural. Further, we have seen how the nationalist movement grew and gathered strength as new classes, offsprings of the new economic structure and living under the same state regime, finding their free and full development thwarted under the extant social and political conditions, increasingly organized themselves on a national scale and started various movements to remove the obstacles impeding their growth.

In its first phase, Indian nationalism had a very narrow social basis. The intelligentsia were the product of the modern education imparted in the new educational institutions, established by the British in India in the first decades of the nineteenth century, and had studied western culture and greatly assimilated its democratic and nationalist ideas. They formed the first stratum of the Indian society to develop a national consciousness and aspirations. Raja Ram Mohan Roy and his group of enlightened Indians were the pioneers of Indian nationalism. They were the exponents of the concept of the Indian nation which they propagated among the people. They initiated socio-reform and religio-reform movements which represented endeavours to remould the Indian society and religion in the spirit of the new principles of democracy, rationalism, and nationalism. In fact, these movements were the expression of the rising national democratic consciousness among a section of the Indian people. These founders and first fighters of Indian nationalism stood up for democratic rights, such as the freedom of the Press, and put forth demands like the right of the nation to have a voice in

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the administration of the country. The first phase extended till 1885 and culminated in the rise of the Indian National Congress in that year.

The second phase roughly covered the period from 1885 to 1905. The Liberal intelligentsia who were at the helm of the Congress were the leaders of the Indian nationalist movement during the second phase. Their ideology and methods determined the programme and forms of the movement which reflected the interests of the development of the new bourgeois society in India. The social basis of the movement was extended during this period to the educated middle class which, by the end of nineteenth century, had appreciably grown as a result of the expansion of modern education, and to a section of the merchant class which had developed during this period as a result of the growth of Indian and international trade. Modern industries also grew steadily during this period as a result of which the class of industrialists emerged and began to gain strength. They started orienting towards the Congress which adopted the programme of industrialization of the country and in 1905 actively organized the Swadeshi campaign.

The Indian National Congress, under the leadership of the Liberals, mainly voiced the demands of the educated classes and the trading bourgeoisie such as the Indianization of Services, the association of the Indians with the administrative machinery of the state, the stoppage of economic drain, and others formulated in the resolutions of the Indian National Congress. It also set forth such democratic demands as those of representative institutions and civil liberties. Its methods of struggle dominated by Liberal conceptions were principally constitutional agitation, effective argument, and fervent appeal to the democratic conscience and traditions of the British people.

Since the British government did not satisfy the most vital demands of the Indian nationalist movement, disillusionment set in among a section of the nationalists regarding the ideology and methods of the Liberals. A group, with a new philosophy, political ideology and conception of the methods of struggle crystallized within the Congress. Increasing unemployment among the educated middle class youths due to the inability of the social and state apparatus to incorporate them, and further, economic misery among the people due to devastating epidemics and famines at the close of the nineteenth century, created favourable conditions for the growth of the influence of the new group, the Extremists.

The third phase in the development of the nationalist movement extended from 1905 to 1918. During this phase, the Liberals were supplanted by the Extremists as the leaders of the nationalist movement. In spite of the strong government repression, the nationalist movement registered an advance. The

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political propaganda of the Extremists instilled a feeling of national self-respect and self-confidence among the people who, instead of looking to the British for political freedom as counselled by the Liberals, began to rely on their own strength for achieving it. The movement, however, suffered from the defect that its leaders attempted to base it on a resurrected Hindu philosophy. This, to some extent, mystified the movement and weakened its secular character. It was also one of the reasons why it could not appeal to the Muslims.

During the third phase, the Indian nationalist movement became militant and challenging and acquired a wider social basis by the inclusion of sections of the lower-middle class. The agitation for Home Rule during wartime further strengthened the political consciousness of the people. It was during this phase that sections of upper class Muslims developed political consciousness and founded their all-India political organization in 1906, the Muslim League. Due to a number of reasons, the rising political consciousness of the Muslim upper and educated middle classes took a communal form, and resulted in the formation of their organization on a communal basis.

The fourth phase in the evolution of the Indian nationalist movement commenced from 1918 and extended roughly up to the Civil Disobedience Movement of 1930-4. One striking development during this phase was that the nationalist movement gained a broad mass basis and added to its arsenal, the weapon of direct mass action. The nationalist movement, which was hitherto restricted mainly to upper and middle classes, further extended, during this phase, to sections of the Indian masses. Gandhi's doctrine of class harmony and social peace and his support to the Swadeshi resolution at the Calcutta Congress in 1919 made sections of the Indian bourgeoisie support Gandhi, the Congress, and the nationalist movements organized by the Congress under Gandhi's leadership from this time onward. It was from 1918 that the Indian industrial bourgeoisie began to exert a powerful influence in determining the programme, policies, strategies, tactics and forms of struggle of the Indian nationalist movement led by the Congress of which Gandhi was the leader. Mass participation was witnessed in the Non-Cooperation movement and the Civil Disobedience Movement during this phase.

Another development during this phase was the growth of socialist and communist groups in the country. By 1928, these groups succeeded in initiating independent political and trade union movements of the working class based on the doctrine of class struggle. They further stood for a socialist state of India declaring it as the objective of the Indian national movement.

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Further, it was during this period that the Congress defined its political objective from the nebulous term Swaraj to that of Independence. Various Youth and Independence Leagues which sprang up in the country also adopted Independence as their political goal.

Parallel to these developments, reactionary communal forces also began to organize themselves during this period. The period witnessed a number of communal riots.

The principal gains to the Indian nationalist movement during this phase were the acquisition of a mass basis, the definition of its goal as Independence, the entry of a section of the working class into the movement as an independent political force, the growth of various Youth and Independence Leagues, and the wider participation of peasants in the movement.

The fifth phase covers the period from 1934 to 1939, the year of the outbreak of World War II. There were a number of new developments during this period. A section of Congressmen lost their confidence in the ideology, programmes and methods of Gandhi and formed the Congress Socialist Party which stood for the organization of the workers and peasants on class lines, and made them the motive force of the nationalist movement. The party, however, remained heterogeneous, being composed of groups who broke from Gandhism in varying degrees and having a petti-bourgeois social basis. There also grew up other dissident tendencies from Gandhism like the Forward Bloc led by Subhas Chandra Bose.

Another development was the steady growth of the movements of the depressed classes. The Muslim League also, organizationally and politically, grew stronger in the final years of this period. Further, a number of other Muslim organizations, both of nationalist and communal political hues, also sprang up.
The rapid growth of the Communist Party increasingly spreading its influence among students, workers, and kisans, also was another significant development. The rapid growth of the peasant movement was one of the striking developments during this period. Larger and larger sections of peasantry developed national and class consciousness.

However, Desai argues that the rise of an independent kisan movement, the growth of socialist forces, and other developments, however, still represented only minority tendencies within the nationalist movement. The national movement still remained essentially determined and dominated by the Gandhian outlook and Gandhi's political philosophy and leadership. It still, in the main, reflected the interests of the capitalists and others upper classes.

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Desai concludes with the assertion that the influx of new social forces with increasingly growing consciousness in the nationalist movement and their pressure on the leadership, however, did not weaken the movement. It brought more dynamic energy to the movement.

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Agitation

J.W. Bowers and **D.J. Ochs** in their book *The Rhetoric of Agitation and Control* (1971) argue that

"agitation exists when:

1. people outside the normal decision-making establishment
2. advocate significant (structural) social change and
3. encounter a degree of resistance within the establishment such as to require more than the normal discursive means of persuasion."

Agitation-Control Model:

The rhetoric of agitation can be viewed as a continuum of behaviours which range from persuasive speaking (normal argumentation) to outright revolution (instrumental action). According to Bowers and Ochs, agitation movements typically progress step by step through the continuum from the persuasive toward the confrontational. Their model is based on and describes protest movements including the Civil Rights Movement of the 1960s and Vietnam War Protest Movements.

Control, on the other hand, refers to the response of the decision-making establishment to the agitation.

Under this definition, those within the establishment cannot be agitators. For example, if a mother takes a vote from her kids on what they want for dinner and the daughter protests the choice, she is not considered an agitator because she participated in the decision-making process. Another key point of the definition is that agitation only occurs when steps are taken beyond "normal" persuasive rhetoric. For instance, distributing pamphlets that urge student to vote against an increase in fees is considered within ordinary persuasive means. However, if the students have a sit-in (dharna) or take out a march to oppose unfavorable measures taken by the administration, they are participating in a form of agitation.

Steps in the rhetoric of agitation:

1. **Petition:** Although they are not technically considered agitation, normal persuasive measures often precede agitation. This stage is referred to by Bowers and Ochs as petition. This stage is crucial to an agitation movement because it establishes credibility and gives the establishment an early opportunity to comply with their demands. This strategy includes normal

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discursive means of persuasion (speeches presenting "the case", reasoned discussion, petitioning, etc.).

2. **Promulgation:** Once step 1 has met with suppression or avoidance, step 2 is likely to occur. It involves tactics used to win social support for the movement and expand the base (informational picketing, handbills, protest meeting, exploitation of the media, etc.).

3. **Solidification:** The strategy of solidification occurs primarily within the agitation group. Its purpose is to unite the group and increase motivation. Solidification tactics produce or reinforce cohesiveness of members, thereby increasing responsiveness.

4. **Polarization:** If the movement is still being resisted substantially after solidification, tactics which polarize (that is, force people to clearly chose sides- "us or them") the relevant publics usually are adopted. Tactics include flag issues, derogatory jargon, non-violent resistance.

5. **Non-violent resistance:** The strategy of non-violent resistance is often referred to by the names of famous agitators who were known for this strategy – Martin Luther King, Jr. and Gandhi. Non-violent resistance places agitators in a position in which they are violating laws or customs they consider to be unjust or destructive of human dignity. This includes sit-ins and school boycotts. The agitators participate in activities that would be legal or accepted if the establishment conceded. An example of this is when Rosa Parks refused to give up her seat on a bus to a white man. She was non-violently protesting laws and customs that the civil rights movement wanted to see changed. When the protested laws are perceived to be very unjust, this stage often turns violent when the establishment continues to resist. The theory behind non-violent protest, according to Martin Luther King, Jr. is that all of the resister's energy is directed to the policy he is violating, and not in the destruction of the perpetrators. A second aspect is that the resistance does not seek to defeat or humiliate the opponent, rather to win its friendship and understanding.

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6. **Escalation:** Another strategy used is called escalation/confrontation and it is designed to make the establishment overreact to threats of disruption, and then looks foolish to the public. The agitators then hope this will lead to reforms instituted by the larger society witnessing the disproportionate action taken by the establishment.

7. **Revolution:** This strategy is not rhetorical.

Control responses from the establishment:

Typical responses to agitation from the establishment include (in roughly this order):

- **Avoidance** (counter-persuasion, evasion, secret rationale, denial of means);
- **Suppression** (leader harassment, denial of demands, banishment, murder);
- **Adjustment** (name change, sacrificial lambs, accepting means, co-opting);
- **Capitulation** (not a control response but surrender)

Bowers and Ochs came up with four rhetorical strategies for control – avoidance, suppression, adjustment and capitulation.

One of the most widely used avoidance tactics is counter-persuasion. This occurs when the establishment tries to convince the agitators that they are wrong. If they are successful, the threat is minimized. If they are unsuccessful, the establishment has still gained time without changing their ideology or structure.

The second strategy is **suppression**, which institutions usually do not resort to until all avoidance tactics have failed. This tactic focuses on weakening or removing the agitators' spokespersons. This is often done by harassment, denial of the agitators' demands, or banishment. Banishment can terminate a movement by removing its leaders and spokespersons.

A third control strategy is **adjustment**. Establishments may do this by adapting, modifying, or altering their structures, goals or personnel. One tactic is to accept some of the means of agitation. In essence this tactic serves to take away the

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attention received when the establishment instead reacts to the agitation. A movement may likely gain momentum if the establishment reacts to its agitation strategies by calling attention to its ideology.

The last strategy in the rhetoric of control is **capitulation**. This can be seen as the last resort of an establishment and has been known to be used when total destruction by the agitators is imminent.

In conclusion, the rhetoric of agitation and control as proposed by Bowers and Ochs analyzes the process of social change, specifically the messages generated by the participants in social change movements, the agitators and the targeted establishment. Many different strategies and tactics may be used on either side, which has proven to make each instance of social change unique. Bowers and Ochs identified agitation strategies to include the categories of petition, promulgation, solidification, non-violent resistance, and escalation/confrontation. The control strategies they identified fall into the categories of avoidance, suppression, adjustment, and capitulation.

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Citizenship

The term 'citizenship' is derived from the Latin word 'civis' and its Greek equivalent 'polites', which means member of the polis or city. Historically, the idea of citizenship was linked with the rise of democracy and modern nation-states in Europe, particularly in the Western European societies.

The manner in which citizenship is understood today as system of equal rights, as opposed to privileges ascribed by conditions of birth, took roots in the French Revolution (1789). With the development of capitalism and liberalism, the idea of the citizen as an individual bearing rights irrespective of his or her class, race, gender, ethnicity, etc., became further entrenched.

More often than not, citizenship is seen in terms of a legal/formal status – having a specific nationality and deriving from this status, entitlements and claims, right guaranteed by the constitution, as well as specific duties and responsibilities which the constitution may lay down. The idea of citizenship, however, goes beyond the legal-formal framework to denote **substantive membership in the political community**.

The commonly accepted definition of citizenship by **T.H. Marshall** in *Citizenship and Social Class* (1950) as 'full and equal membership in a political community' holds the promise of equality and integration within the political community. While citizenship may be defined with an ideal condition of equality, it may actually remain elusive and fettered, as societies are always marked by hierarchies of class, caste, sex, race, and religion rather than equality of status and belonging.

T.H. Marshall: Equal and universal citizenship

T.H. Marshall, in his influential account of the growth of citizenship in England, states that the concept developed in a peculiar relationship of conflict and collusion with capitalism. Marshall's widely accepted definition of citizens as 'free and equal members of a political community' comes primarily from the study of citizenship as a process of expanding equality against the inequality of social class, the latter being an integral element of capitalist society.

In *Citizenship and Social Class* (1950), Marshall distinguishes three strands or bundles of rights constituting citizenship, viz., civil, political and social. **Civil rights**, defined by Marshall as 'rights necessary for individual freedom', include freedoms of speech, movement, conscience, the rights to equality before

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law, and the right to own property. These were 'negative' rights in the sense that they limited or checked the exercise of government power. **Political rights**, viz., the right to vote, the right to contest elections and the right to hold public office, provided the individual with the opportunity to participate in political life. The provision of political rights required the development of universal suffrage, political equality, and democratic government. **Social rights**, argued Marshall, guaranteed the individual a minimum social status and provided the basis for the exercise of both civil and political rights. These were 'positive' rights 'to live the life of a civilized being according to the standards prevailing in society'. These standards of life and the social heritage of society are realized through active intervention by the state in the form of social services (the welfare state) and the educational system. Each of these three stands has, he suggests, a distinct history confined to a particular century—civil to the 18th, political to the 19th, and social to the 20th—and corresponds with the development of specific state structures—the judiciary, parliamentary institutions of governance, and the educational system and the welfare state, respectively.

Marshall was of the view that there was a permanent tension or contradiction between the principles of citizenship and the operation of the capitalist market. Capitalism inevitably involves inequalities between social classes, while citizenship involves some redistribution of resources, because of rights, which are shared equally by all. Eminent sociologist Talcott Parsons argues that the growth of citizenship is a measure of the modernization of society because it is based on the values of egalitarianism and universalism.

Marxist Critique of Bourgeois Citizenship

For Marx, the claims of liberal citizenship to equality and freedom were incompatible with capitalism. The explanation for this incompatibility has been sought in Marx's interpretation of the modern state as a bourgeois state, as a manifestation and guardian of bourgeois interests, incapable of delivering the promises of equal citizenship. 'Equal right' in a capitalist society is a bourgeois right consisting only in the application of an equal/uniform standard. This works out in effect as 'a right of inequality in its content', since with the application of an equal standard, people's (unequal) location in a hierarchized society, their needs, social contexts, relationships, etc., are ignored. In other words, equality before law and universal adult suffrage are aspects of formal equality. Marxist scholars argued that unless there is substantive equality in the form of socio-economic equality, legal equality and political equality would remain illusory (not real).

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Feminism and Citizenship

As discussed above, the idea of 'general' and 'uniform' citizenship has been criticized by Marxists for overlooking the inequalities that exist in real life. Feminists have shown how the idea of citizenship has been especially inimical to women. Feminists of all strands have criticized the dominant conceptions of citizenship on two counts. They argue that citizenship is gender-blind. By focusing on uniform and equal application, it fails to take cognizance of the fact that modern societies are steeped in patriarchal traditions, which make for male domination and privileges. Equality in such conditions remains a facade and the inequality of women is sustained by policies that work within the framework of formal equality.

Feminists have taken different routes to overcome their exclusion from the political community. One strand of feminists has focused on political participation, viewing citizenship as an aspect of public/political activity and as embodying the transformative potential of democracy. They have argued for women's inclusion in the public sphere as equals, laying emphasis on revitalizing/democratizing the public sphere through communication, speech, and action (which are seen as empowering), and through alliances for a shared common objective. Thus, it is the exercise of rights in the political sphere which is seen as crucial to the full development of women's citizenship as part of what **Rian Voet** (1998) calls 'an active and sex-equal citizenship'.

Globalization, World Citizenship and Human Rights

An influential strand of citizenship theorists argues that in an increasingly globalized, interdependent and interconnected world, marked by transnational movement of populations and multicultural national populations, one can no longer talk of citizenship in terms of membership in a territorially limited *nation-state*, the hitherto uncontested unit of membership. They propose the delinking of the relationship between citizenship and the nation-state, replacing it with **global** or **world citizenship** with its basis in human rights. **Yasemin Soysal** (1994), for example, argues that globalization has brought in a 'new and more universal' concept of citizenship that has 'universal personhood' rather than 'national belonging' as its core principle. Universal personhood delinks legal rights from citizenship status and national belonging and is reflected in the status of guest workers in Europe, who have lived in Europe for years without ever acquiring citizenship, primarily because the countries of residence assured their legal and social rights. These assurances, feels Soysal, are further augmented by the global system of human rights law, the United Nations network, regional governance, etc., that have ushered in the idea of a **global civil society**. The assurances guaranteed by membership of this global civil society make the securities of

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nation-state membership redundant. Much of this assurance, it is argued, has emanated from the high degree of agreement on the need for human rights, and the recognition that violations of human rights have global ramifications, and their protection must, therefore involve transnational efforts.

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Class

Class has formed one of the core concepts of sociological analysis since sociology took shape as a discipline. Yet despite, or perhaps even because of, this, it is a concept often struggled over by sociologists themselves. It can mean different things depending on context, and different again is the common usage by which people define their own and each other's class.

- **Marx's** view of class (on the basis of the ownership and non-ownership of the means of production)
- **Weber's** view of class (market situation)

However, in the later part of the 20th century, the concept of class was further refined in light of the changes in advanced industrial societies.

- **Ralf Dahrendorf's** view of class (decomposition of capital and decomposition of labour). Please note that Ralf Dahrendorf (1929-2009) was a German-British sociologist.

- **Anthony Giddens's** view of class: Anthony Giddens (1938 -) is a British sociologist. Giddens identifies three major classes in advanced capitalist society:

    1. **Upper class** – based on – 'ownership of property in the means of production'
    2. **Middle class** – based on – 'possession of educational or technical qualifications'
    3. **Lower class** – based on – 'possession of manual labour-power'

- **Erik Olin Wright's** view of class: Erik Olin Wright (1947 -) is an American Marxist sociologist. Wright has developed an influential theory of class which combines the aspects of both Marxian and Weberian approaches. He has identified three important criteria that determine the class position in modern industrial societies:

    1. **Ownership** – Wright argues that ownership of means of production still remains an important criterion in determining the class positions of individuals. As a result people do gain economic advantage and by virtue of which they command greater prestige

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and power in society. But it is only one of the criteria, not the sole criterion as Marx claimed.

2. **Credential skills** – Wright further argues that in modern complex societies, with greater division and specialization of labour, people have to undergo formal training in specialized fields for long duration. People acquire skills which are certified through credentials like diplomas and degrees. Wright argues that credential skills increases the bargaining power and enhances the market value of the individuals.

3. **Organisational asset** – According to Wright, the position that an individual occupies in the organisational structure is also an important factor in determining his class position. Please note that it is possible that an individual with low credential skills may occupy high position in the organisational structure or an individual with high credential skills may occupy low position in the organisational structure. For example, a graduate, on qualifying the Civil Services Examination in India, occupies a high position in the bureaucratic structure, and as a result enjoys higher authority. While a PhD holder, despite having high credential skills may still be working as a low ranking official in the government service, and thus has lesser authority in the organisational structure.

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- **Jan Pakulski and Malcom Waters:** "The Death of Class"

In recent years there has been a vigorous debate within sociology about the usefulness of the concept of 'class'. Some sociologists have even questioned whether it is still a useful concept in attempting to understand contemporary societies. Australian academicians Jan Pakulski and Malcom Waters have been prominent amongst those who argue that class is no longer the key to understanding contemporary societies. In their book, **The Death of Class** (1996), they argue that contemporary societies have undergone profound social changes and are no longer to be accurately seen as 'class societies'.

Pakulski and Waters argue that industrial societies are now undergoing a period of tremendous social change and the political, social and economic importance of class is in decline. Industrial societies have changed from being *organized class societies* to a new stage, which they call ***'status conventionalism'***. Pakulski and Waters use this term to indicate that inequalities, although they remain, are the result of differences in status (prestige) and in the lifestyle and consumption patterns favoured by such status groups. So, class has outlived its utility as a conceptual tool to describe pattern of inequality in society and to explain conflict and change in society. For Pakulski and Waters, contemporary societies are stratified, but this stratification is achieved through cultural consumption (lifestyle), not class position in the division of labour.

In the age of globalization, marked by greater geographical mobility, people now live in an "individualized society". Rather than see themselves as members of a social class, people nowadays tend to see themselves simply as individuals. Their identity will be more influenced by their status, through their consumption patterns and through factors such as their race, gender, regional or national identity, ethnicity, etc.

However, critics argue that in the theory of Pakulski and Waters, there is an implicit reference to the highly developed, industrially advanced societies where the class inequalities have significantly reduced on account of strong welfare state. But in the third world societies which are marked by gross economic inequalities, the concept of class is still a relevant and useful tool for the analysis of social stratification.

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- **John Scott and Lydia Morris**

More recently, John Scott and Lydia Morris have argued for a need to make a distinction between the class positions of individuals (their location in a division of labour) and the collective phenomena of social class through which people express a sense of belonging to a group and have a shared sense of identity and values. It is this latter aspect of class that appears to have diminished in recent years. This does not mean that status and the cultural aspects of stratification are now so dominant that the economic aspects of class are of no significance; indeed, mobility studies and inequalities of wealth indicate the opposite. Class is not dead – it is just becoming that bit more complex.

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Collective Action

Collective action refers to the action taken by a group (either directly or on its behalf through an organization) in pursuit of members' perceived shared interests. It seems logical to expect that people who have an interest in common will act on it – for example that pensioners will act for higher pensions or miners for greater underground safety. Similarly, auto-rickshaw or taxi drivers for increase in fare, and ad-hoc teachers for regularization of their services, etc.

However, experience shows that this is not always the case and that many people who stand to benefit from a given collective action will refuse to join in. This seems to run against the assumption of rationality in human behaviour, and presents a particular problem for students of politics and social movements.

In this book, *The Logic of Collective Action*, **Mancur Olson**, offered an explanation. Olson argued that rational self-interest often leads to inaction, in so far as individuals will benefit from concessions made to the whole group, whether they themselves have been active or not. For example, if pensions are raised after a campaign by senior citizens, all pensioners will gain, including those who did nothing. Olson called this the **free-rider problem**, and it is important because it undermines the ability of interest group and social movements to mobilize large numbers of citizens. If those citizens are poor, the costs of participation are relatively higher for them, and they are even more likely to remain passive. The only answer to the free rider problem is for the movement to offer extra incentives to participate, beyond the goals themselves. These incentives may take the form of recognition, prestige, or the psychological rewards of participation itself.

The term "collection action" is hopeless broad. Taken at face value, it could plausibly refer to all forms of human social action involving two or more people. However, in sociological terms, the term is used in a restricted sense. According to **Doug McAdam**, "collective action refers to emergent and minimally coordinated action by two or more people that is motivated by a desire to change some aspect of social life or to resist changes proposed by others." By "emergent" is meant innovative lines of action that depart from taken-for-granted normative routines. "Coordinated" simply means that the various parties to the emerging conflict are attuned to one another and acting in awareness of this fact. Finally, the emphasis on change or resistance to change is designed to capture the adversarial or potentially conflictual nature of "collective action."

All sociologists talk about collective behaviour but few attempt to define it. When they do, the definitions are not very useful. The study of collective behaviour includes the study of crowds, protests, agitations, social movements and

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revolutions, etc. There are a number of theoretical formulations of collective behaviour, none of them entirely adequate.

Turner and **Killian** note that there are at least three different theoretical approaches. The earliest were the ***contagion*** **theories** [**LeBon**, 1896], which described crowd behaviour as an irrational and uncritical response to the psychological temptation of the crowd situation. Social contagion is defined by **Blumer** as "the relatively rapid, unwitting, non rational dissemination of a mood, impulse, or form of conduct." Contagion theory thus emphasizes, and perhaps over emphasizes, the non rational aspects of collective behaviour. This theory reflects the elitist view of common people as childish, impulsive, and irresponsible.

Later came the ***convergence theories***, which focus upon the shared cultural and personality characteristics of the members of a collectivity and note how these similarities encourage a collective response to a situation [**Freud**, 1922; **Allport**, 1924; **Miller and Dollard**, 1941]. The convergence theories view collective as more than foolish impulse and admit that collective behaviour can be rational and goal-directed.

Finally, the **emergent norm theories** claim that in a behaviour situation which invites collective behaviour, a norm arises which governs the behaviour. It seems that, starting with the perceptions and grievances of the members, and fed by the contagion process, a norm eventually emerges which justifies and sets limits to the crowd behaviour. Crowds are never entirely like-minded and contagion theory does not explain why the crowd takes one action rather than another. Emergent norm theorists charge that contagion theory exaggerates the irrational and purposeless components of crowd behaviour.

An integrated synthesis of these theories is attempted by **Smelser**; however, it comes out as mainly an emergent norm theory. His determinants of collective behaviour are:

1. ***Structural conduciveness*****:** The structure of the society may encourage or discourage collective behaviour. Simple, traditional societies are less prone to collective behaviour than are modern societies.

2. ***Structural strain*****:** Deprivation and fears of deprivation lie at the base of much collective behaviour. Feelings of injustice prompt many to extreme action. Impoverished class, oppressed minorities, groups whose hard-won gain are threatened, even privileged groups who fear the loss of their privileges - all these are candidates for collective behaviour.

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3. ***Growth and spread of a generalized belief*** **:** Before any collective action, there must be a belief among the actors which identifies the source of the threat, the route of escape, or the avenue of fulfillment.

4. ***Precipitating factors*****:** Some dramatic event or rumor sets the stage for action. A cry of "police brutality" in a racially tense neighborhood may touch off a riot. One person starting to run may precipitate a panic.

5. ***Mobilization for action*****:** Leadership emerges and begins or proposes action and directs activity.

6. ***Operation of social control*****:** At any of the above points, the cycle can be interrupted by leadership, police power, propaganda, legislative and government policy changes, and other social controls.

Smelser's formulation has stimulated a good deal of criticism, and experimentation, yet it remains perhaps the most widely used theoretical approach in the study of collective behaviour today.

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SOCIOLOGY

PAPER-I: FUNDAMENTALS OF SOCIOLOGY

1. Sociology- The Discipline
2. Sociology as Science
3. Research Methods and Analysis
4. Sociological Thinkers
5. Stratification and Mobility
6. Works and Economic Life
7. Politics and Society
8. Religion and Society
9. System of Kinship
10. Social Change in Modern Society

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1. Sociology- The Discipline:

- Modernity and social changes in Europe and emergence of sociology
- Scope of the subject and comparison with other social sciences
- Sociology and common sense

Remarks: Online Notes are sufficient. No need to refer anything else.

Refer the following **PDF Files** in the given order:

1) Modernity and Emergence of Sociology
2) Scope of the subject and comparison with other social sciences
3) Sociology and Common Sense
4) Basic Concepts

2. Sociology as science:

- Science, scientific method and critique
- Major theoretical strands of research methodology
- Positivism and its critique
- Fact, value and objectivity
- Non-positivist methodologies

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Remarks: Online Notes are sufficient. No need to refer anything else.

Refer the following **PDF Files** in the given order:

1) Science, scientific method and critique
2) Major theoretical strands of research methodology
3) Fact, Value and Objectivity
4) Reflexive Sociology

3. Research Methods and Analysis:

- Qualitative and quantitative methods
- Techniques of data collection
- Variables, sampling, hypothesis, reliability and validity

Remarks: Online Notes are sufficient. No need to refer anything else. Refer the following **PDF Files** in the given order:

1) Qualitative and quantitative methods
2) Techniques of data collection
3) Observation
4) Content Analysis
5) Focus Group

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6) Variables and Hypothesis

7) Comparative Method

4. Sociological Thinkers:

- **Karl Marx** - Historical materialism, mode of production, alienation, class struggle

Remarks: Online Notes are sufficient. No need to refer anything else.

Refer the following **PDF Files** in the given order:

1) Historical Materialism

2) Class Struggle and Social Change

3) Asiatic Mode of Production

4) Alienation

5) Marx -An Assessment

- **Emile Durkheim** - Division of labour, social fact, suicide, religion and society

Remarks: Online Notes are sufficient. No need to refer anything else.

Refer the following **PDF Files** in the given order:

1) Social Fact

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2) Division of Labour

3) The Rules of Sociological Method

4) Suicide

5) Religion and Society

6) Durkheim - An Assessment

- **Max Weber** - Social action, ideal types, authority, bureaucracy, protestant ethic and the spirit of capitalism

Remarks: Online Notes are sufficient. No need to refer anything else.

Refer the following **PDF Files** in the given order:

1) Social Action

2) Verstehen

3) The Protestant Ethic and Spirit of Capitalism

4) Bureaucracy

5) Weber - An Assessment

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- **Talcott Parsons** - Social system, pattern variables

Remarks: Online Notes are sufficient. No need to refer anything else.

Refer the following **PDF Files** in the given order:

1) The Structure of Social Action
2) The Social System
3) Social Change
4) Parsons - An Assessment

- **Robert K. Merton** - Latent and manifest functions, conformity and deviance, reference groups

Remarks:

Refer the following online **PDF Files, Class Notes and Handouts** in the given order:

1) Middle Range Theory (online PDF)
2) Functional Analysis (along with online PDF, please also refer **Class Notes** on 'Critical Evaluation of Merton's Functional Paradigm')
3) Theories of Deviance (refer **Handout** on the edited chapter on Deviance from Haralambos and Holborn)

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4) Theory of Reference Group (refer **Class Notes** as well as the online **IGNOU** PDF)

- **Mead** – Self and identity

Remarks: Refer online **PDF**

5. Stratification and Mobility:

- Concepts – equality, inequality, hierarchy, exclusion, poverty and deprivation

Remarks:

Refer the following online **PDF Files** and **Handouts** in the given order:

1) Equality (refer online PDF)

2) Inequality and Hierarchy (refer online PDF)

3) Exclusion, Poverty and Deprivation

Refer online **PDF** on: 1. Social Exclusion, and 2. Social Exclusion in India

Refer **Class Notes** and the following **Handouts:** 1. Social exclusion, 2. Poverty, and 3. Social exclusion and minorities in India

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- Theories of social stratification - structural functionalist theory, Marxist theory, Weberian theory

Remarks:

Refer **Handout** on the edited chapter on Social Stratification from Haralambos and Holborn

- Dimensions - social stratification of class, status groups, gender, ethnicity and race

Remarks:

Refer the following online **PDF Files, Class Notes** and **Handouts** in the given order:

1) Class (refer online PDF)
2) Status Groups (refer **Class Notes**)
3) Gender (refer online PDF - Gender)
4) Race and Ethnicity (refer online PDF)

- Social mobility - open and closed systems, types of mobility, sources and causes of mobility

Remarks: Online Notes are sufficient. No need to refer anything else.

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6. Works and Economic Life:

- Social organization of work in different types of society - slave society, feudal society, industrial/capitalist society
- Formal and informal organization of work
- Labour and society

Remarks: Refer **Class Notes**

7. Politics and Society: (Read Paper I and Paper II together and interlink the two)

- Sociological theories of power

Remarks:

Refer **Handout** on the edited chapter on Power from Haralambos and Holborn

- Power elite, bureaucracy, pressure groups and political parties

Remarks:

Power elite: (refer **Class Notes** for Paper I and Paper II)

Bureaucracy: (refer online PDF on Max Weber)

Pressure groups: (refer online PDF and **Handouts:** 1. Interest/Pressure groups in India, 2. Pressure groups in India, and 3. Political participation

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Political parties: (refer online PDF and **Handouts:** 1. Role of political parties, 2. Voting behaviour, 3. Political socialization, 4. The changing nature of party system, and 5. The nature of coalition politics)

- Nation, state, citizenship, democracy, civil society, ideology

Remarks:

Nation: (refer online PDF)

State: (refer online PDF and the **Handouts:** 1. Utilitarian view – Liberal view [To add: Contemporary liberalism has been most exercised by the notion of social justice and social welfare [John Rawls (1921-2002), Ronald Dworkin)]] – Marxian view – Feminist view (Patriarchal state) – Globalization - a short note – Imported state and its consequences in the third world societies)

Citizenship: (refer online PDF)

Democracy: (refer **Class Notes** and **Handouts:** 1. Democracy, 2. Globalization and democracy, 3. Participatory democracy, and 4. Democratic Decentralization and Panchayati Raj)

Civil Society: (**refer Class Notes** and **Handouts:** 1. Civil society, 2. The state and civil society in India)

Ideology: (refer **Class Notes**)

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- Protest, agitation, social movements, collective, action, revolution

Remarks:

Protest: (refer online PDF)

Agitation: (refer online PDF)

Social Movements: (refer online PDF and **Handout** on Kinds of Social Movements)

Collective Action: (refer online PDF)

Revolution: (refer **Handouts:** 1. Revolution, 2. Rebellion, Revolution)

8. Religion and Society: (Read Paper I and Paper II together and interlink the two)

- Sociological theories of religion

Remarks:

Refer **Handout** on the edited chapter on Religion from Haralambos and Holborn

- Types of religious practices: animism, monism, pluralism, sects, cults

Remarks: (refer **Class Notes**)

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- Religion in modern society: religion and science, secularization, religious revivalism, fundamentalism

Remarks:

Religion and science: (refer online PDF)

Secularization: (refer online PDF)

Religious revivalism and fundamentalism: (refer online PDF)

Handouts: 1. Religion and society, 2. Religions of India

9. System of Kinship: (Read Paper I and Paper II together and interlink the two)

- Family, household, marriage

Remarks:

Refer online PDF on Family

Refer online PDF on Marriage

Refer **Class Notes** on Household

Refer **Handouts:** 1. Edited chapter on Family from Haralambos and Holborn, 2. Family in India (Patricia Uberoi), and 3. Emerging patterns of marriage and family

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- Types and forms of family

Remarks:

Refer online PDF on Family

- Lineage and descent

Remarks:

Refer online PDF on Kinship

Refer **Class Notes** and **Handout** on Kinship Usages

- Patriarchy and sexual division of labour

Remarks:

Refer online **PDF** on: 1. Gender Inequality: Approaches, and 2. Patriarchy and sexual division of labour

- Contemporary trends

Remarks:

Refer **Class Notes**

Handouts: 1. Evolution of Women's Legal Entitlements, 2. Statistical Profile of Women, and 3. Gender Scenario – Some Insights

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10. Social Change in Modern Society:

- Sociological theories of social change
- Development and dependency
- Agents of social change
- Education and social change (Refer **Class Notes** and **Handout:** Educational Institutions)
- Science, technology and social change

Remarks:

Refer **Class Notes**

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Sociology

PAPER – II: INDIAN SOCIETY: STRUCTURE AND CHANGE

(A) Introducing Indian Society:

- **(i) Perspectives on the study of Indian society**
- **(ii) Impact of colonial rule on Indian society**

(B) Social Structure:

- **(i) Rural and Agrarian Social Structure**
- **(ii) Caste System**
- **(iii) Tribal communities in India**
- **(iv) Social Classes in India**
- **(v) Systems of Kinship in India**
- **(vi) Religion and Society**

(C) Social Changes in India:

- **(i) Visions of Social Change in India**
- **(ii) Rural and Agrarian Transformation in India**
- **(iii) Industrialization and Urbanization in India**
- **(iv) Politics and Society**
- **(v) Social Movements in Modern India**
- **(vi) Population Dynamics**
- **(vii) Challenges of Social Transformation**

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(A) Introducing Indian Society:

(i) Perspectives on the study of Indian society:

(a) Indology (G S Ghurye) (refer online PDF on Ghurye)

(b) Structural functionalism (M N Srinivas)

Handouts: 1. M.N. Srinivas, 2. The Social Structure of Mysore Village, 3. Contributions of M.N. Srinivas to Village Studies, and 4. Structural functional perspective

(c) Marxist sociology (A R Desai) (refer online PDF on Desai, **Handout:** 1. Marxian perspective)

(ii) Impact of colonial rule on Indian society:

(a) Social background of Indian nationalism (refer online PDF on A.R. Desai)

(b) Modernization of Indian tradition (refer **Class Notes**)

(c) Protests and movements during the colonial period (**Handout:** Resistance to the British Rule: Early Uprisings and the Revolt of 1857)

(d) Social reforms (**Handouts: 1.** Jainism and Buddhism, 2. Socio-Religious Reform Movements, 3. Social and Cultural Awakening, and 4.Religious Movements in 15th and 16th centuries)

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(B) Social Structure:

(i) Rural and Agrarian Social Structure:

(a) The idea of Indian village and village studies

Handouts: 1. The Social Structure of Mysore Village, 2. Contributions of M.N. Srinivas to Village Studies

(b) Agrarian social structure - evolution of land tenure system, land reforms

Handouts: 1. Land tenure system and land reforms, 2. Agrarian structures and their transformations, and 3. Dimensions of agrarian structure and change: Issues in theory

(ii) Caste System:

(a) Perspectives on the study of caste system:

G.S. Ghurye

M.N. Srinivas

Louis Dumont (refer **Class Notes** and **Handouts: 1.** Louis Dumont, and 2. Indological perspective)

Andre Beteille (refer **Class Notes**)

(b) Feature of caste system

Refer online PDF on Ghurye, **Class Notes** and **Handout:** The caste system in India (M.N. Srinivas)

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(c) Untouchability - forms and perspectives (refer **Class Notes**)

(iii) Tribal communities in India:

(a) Definitional problems

(b) Geographical spread

(c) Colonial policies and tribes

(d) Issues of integration and autonomy

Handouts: 1. Tribal life in India, 2. Tribal resistance, violence, Left's role and state's response, 3. Indian tribals and search for an indigenous identity, and 4. Tribal movements

(iv) Social Classes in India:

(a) Agrarian class structure

(b) Industrial class structure

(c) Middle classes in India

Remarks: Refer **Class Notes** and **IGNOU**

(v) Systems of Kinship in India: (already covered along with Paper I)

(a) Lineage and descent in India

(b) Types of kinship systems

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(c) Family and marriage in India

(d) Household dimensions of the family

(e) Patriarchy, entitlements and sexual division of labour

(vi) Religion and Society: (already covered along with Paper I)

(a) Religious communities in India

(b) Problems of religious minorities

(C) <u>Social Changes in India:</u>

(i) Visions of Social Changes in India:

(a) Idea of development planning and mixed economy

Refer **Class Notes and Handout:** Economic institutions

(b) Constitution, law and social change

Refer **Class Notes**

(c) Education and social change (already covered along with Paper I - Topic 10)

(ii) Rural and Agrarian transformation in India.

(a) Programmes of rural development, Community Development Programme, cooperatives, poverty alleviation schemes

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Refer **Class Notes** and **Handouts:** 1. Rural development, 2. Rural life in India (I & II), 3. Village cooperatives, and 4. Adequacy and effectiveness of poverty alleviation programmes in India. (also refer Handout on Economic Institutions)

(b) Green revolution and social change

Refer **Class Notes** and **Handout:** Green revolution and social inequalities in rural India

(c) Changing modes of production in Indian agriculture (refer **Class Notes**)

(d) Problems of rural labour, bondage, migration

Refer **Class Notes** and **Handouts:** 1. Socio-economic conditions of agricultural labourers, and 2. Problem of bonded labour

(iii) Industrialization and Urbanisation in India:

(a) Evolution of modern industry in India

(b) Growth of urban settlements in India

(c) Working class: structure, growth, class mobilization

(d) Informal sector, child labour

(e) Slums and deprivation in urban areas

Refer **Class Notes**, **IGNOU** and **Handouts:** 1. Industrial working class movements, 2. Informal sector (Jan Breman), and 3. Housing the urban poor

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(iv) Politics and Society: (already covered along with Paper I)

(a) Nation, democracy and citizenship

(b) Political parties, pressure groups social and political elite

(c) Regionalism and decentralization of power.

(d) Secularization

(v) Social Movements in Modern India:

(a) Peasants and farmers movements

Refer **Class Notes** and **Handouts:** 1. Peasant movement, 2. Bhoodan-Gramdan movement, and 3. Naxalbari movement

(b) Women's movement (**Handout**)

(c) Backward classes (**Handout**) & Dalit movement (**Handout**)

(d) Environmental movements

Handouts: 1. Environment and ecological crisis, 2. State led Development-induced dispossession and displacement, and 3. Development and displacement

(e) Ethnicity and identity movements (refer **Class Notes**)

(vi) Population Dynamics:

(a) Population size, growth, composition and distribution

(b) Components of population growth: birth, death, migration

(c) Population policy and family planning

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(d) Emerging issues: ageing, sex ratios, child and infant mortality, reproductive health

Refer **Handouts:** 1. Population dynamics, 2. India's population – a perspective, 3. Demography, and 4. Reproductive health [(a) Dileep V. Mavalankar, (b) Saroj Pachauri]

(vii) Challenges of Social Trasnsformation:

(a) Crisis of development displacement, environmental problems and sustainability

(b) Poverty deprivation and inequalities

(c) Violence against women

(d) Caste conflicts

(e) Ethnic conflicts, communalism, religious revivalism

(f) Illiteracy and disparities in education

Remarks: already covered along with other topics of Paper I and II.

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SOCIOLOGY

PAPER-I: FUNDAMENTALS OF SOCIOLOGY

1. Sociology- The Discipline
2. Sociology as Science
3. Research Methods and Analysis
4. Sociological Thinkers
5. Stratification and Mobility
6. Works and Economic Life
7. Politics and Society
8. Religion and Society
9. System of Kinship
10. Social Change in Modern Society

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1. Sociology- The Discipline:

- Modernity and social changes in Europe and emergence of sociology
- Scope of the subject and comparison with other social sciences
- Sociology and common sense

Remarks: Online Notes are sufficient. No need to refer anything else.

Refer the following **PDF Files** in the given order:

1) Modernity and Emergence of Sociology
2) Scope of the subject and comparison with other social sciences
3) Sociology and Common Sense
4) Basic Concepts

2. Sociology as science:

- Science, scientific method and critique
- Major theoretical strands of research methodology
- Positivism and its critique
- Fact, value and objectivity
- Non-positivist methodologies

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Remarks: Online Notes are sufficient. No need to refer anything else.

Refer the following **PDF Files** in the given order:

1) Science, scientific method and critique
2) Major theoretical strands of research methodology
3) Fact, Value and Objectivity
4) Reflexive Sociology

3. Research Methods and Analysis:

- Qualitative and quantitative methods
- Techniques of data collection
- Variables, sampling, hypothesis, reliability and validity

Remarks: Online Notes are sufficient. No need to refer anything else. Refer the following **PDF Files** in the given order:

1) Qualitative and quantitative methods
2) Techniques of data collection
3) Observation
4) Content Analysis
5) Focus Group

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6) Variables and Hypothesis

7) Comparative Method

4. Sociological Thinkers:

- **Karl Marx** - Historical materialism, mode of production, alienation, class struggle

Remarks: Online Notes are sufficient. No need to refer anything else.

Refer the following **PDF Files** in the given order:

1) Historical Materialism

2) Class Struggle and Social Change

3) Asiatic Mode of Production

4) Alienation

5) Marx -An Assessment

- **Emile Durkheim** - Division of labour, social fact, suicide, religion and society

Remarks: Online Notes are sufficient. No need to refer anything else.

Refer the following **PDF Files** in the given order:

1) Social Fact

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2) Division of Labour

3) The Rules of Sociological Method

4) Suicide

5) Religion and Society

6) Durkheim - An Assessment

- **Max Weber** - Social action, ideal types, authority, bureaucracy, protestant ethic and the spirit of capitalism

Remarks: Online Notes are sufficient. No need to refer anything else.

Refer the following **PDF Files** in the given order:

1) Social Action

2) Verstehen

3) The Protestant Ethic and Spirit of Capitalism

4) Bureaucracy

5) Weber - An Assessment

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- **Talcott Parsons** - Social system, pattern variables

Remarks: Online Notes are sufficient. No need to refer anything else.

Refer the following **PDF Files** in the given order:

1) The Structure of Social Action
2) The Social System
3) Social Change
4) Parsons - An Assessment

- **Robert K. Merton** - Latent and manifest functions, conformity and deviance, reference groups

Remarks:

Refer the following online **PDF Files, Class Notes and Handouts** in the given order:

1) Middle Range Theory (online PDF)
2) Functional Analysis (along with online PDF, please also refer **Class Notes** on 'Critical Evaluation of Merton's Functional Paradigm')
3) Theories of Deviance (refer **Handout** on the edited chapter on Deviance from Haralambos and Holborn)

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4) Theory of Reference Group (refer **Class Notes** as well as the online **IGNOU** PDF)

- **Mead** – Self and identity

Remarks: Refer **Class Notes**

5. Stratification and Mobility:

- Concepts – equality, inequality, hierarchy, exclusion, poverty and deprivation

Remarks:

Refer the following online **PDF Files** and **Handouts** in the given order:

1) Equality (online PDF)

2) Inequality and Hierarchy (online PDF)

3) Exclusion, Poverty and Deprivation (refer online PDF on Social Exclusion, **Class Notes**, and the following **Handouts:** 1. Social exclusion, 2. Poverty, and 3. Social exclusion and minorities in India)

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- Theories of social stratification - structural functionalist theory, Marxist theory, Weberian theory

Remarks:

Refer **Handout** on the edited chapter on Social Stratification from Haralambos and Holborn

- Dimensions - social stratification of class, status groups, gender, ethnicity and race

Remarks:

Refer the following online **PDF Files, Class Notes** and **Handouts** in the given order:

1) Class (refer online PDF)
2) Status Groups (refer **Class Notes**)
3) Gender (refer Class Notes and **Handout** on Gender)
4) Race and Ethnicity (refer online PDF)

- Social mobility - open and closed systems, types of mobility, sources and causes of mobility

Remarks: Online Notes are sufficient. No need to refer anything else.

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6. Works and Economic Life:

- Social organization of work in different types of society - slave society, feudal society, industrial/capitalist society
- Formal and informal organization of work
- Labour and society

Remarks: Refer **Class Notes**

7. Politics and Society: (Read Paper I and Paper II together and interlink the two)

- Sociological theories of power

Remarks:

Refer **Handout** on the edited chapter on Power from Haralambos and Holborn

- Power elite, bureaucracy, pressure groups and political parties

Remarks:

Power elite: (refer **Class Notes** for Paper I and Paper II)

Bureaucracy: (refer online PDF on Max Weber)

Pressure groups: (refer online PDF and **Handouts:** 1. Interest/Pressure groups in India, 2. Pressure groups in India, and 3. Political participation

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Political parties: (refer online PDF and **Handouts:** 1. Role of political parties, 2. Voting behaviour, 3. Political socialization, 4. The changing nature of party system, and 5. The nature of coalition politics)

- Nation, state, citizenship, democracy, civil society, ideology

Remarks:

Nation: (refer online PDF)

State: (refer online PDF and the **Handouts:** 1. Utilitarian view – Liberal view [To add: Contemporary liberalism has been most exercised by the notion of social justice and social welfare [John Rawls (1921-2002), Ronald Dworkin)]] – Marxian view – Feminist view (Patriarchal state) – Globalization - a short note – Imported state and its consequences in the third world societies)

Citizenship: (refer online PDF)

Democracy: (refer **Class Notes** and **Handouts:** 1. Democracy, 2. Globalization and democracy, 3. Participatory democracy, and 4. Democratic Decentralization and Panchayati Raj)

Civil Society: (**refer Class Notes** and **Handouts:** 1. Civil society, 2. The state and civil society in India)

Ideology: (refer **Class Notes**)

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- Protest, agitation, social movements, collective, action, revolution

Remarks:

Protest: (refer online PDF)

Agitation: (refer online PDF)

Social Movements: (refer online PDF and **Handout** on Kinds of Social Movements)

Collective Action: (refer online PDF)

Revolution: (refer **Handouts:** 1. Revolution, 2. Rebellion, Revolution)

8. Religion and Society: (Read Paper I and Paper II together and interlink the two)

- Sociological theories of religion

Remarks:

Refer **Handout** on the edited chapter on Religion from Haralambos and Holborn

- Types of religious practices: animism, monism, pluralism, sects, cults

Remarks: (refer **Class Notes**)

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- Religion in modern society: religion and science, secularization, religious revivalism, fundamentalism

Remarks:

Religion and science: (refer online PDF)

Secularization: (refer online PDF)

Religious revivalism and fundamentalism: (refer online PDF)

Handouts: 1. Religion and society, 2. Religions of India

9. System of Kinship: (Read Paper I and Paper II together and interlink the two)

- Family, household, marriage

Remarks:

Refer online PDF on Family

Refer online PDF on Marriage

Refer **Class Notes** on Household

Refer **Handouts:** 1. Edited chapter on Family from Haralambos and Holborn, 2. Family in India (Patricia Uberoi), and 3. Emerging patterns of marriage and family

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- Types and forms of family

Remarks:

Refer online PDF on Family

- Lineage and descent

Remarks:

Refer online PDF on Kinship

Refer **Class Notes** and **Handout** on Kinship Usages

- Patriarchy and sexual division of labour

Remarks:

Refer **Class Notes**

- Contemporary trends

Remarks:

Refer **Class Notes**

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10. Social Change in Modern Society:

- Sociological theories of social change
- Development and dependency
- Agents of social change
- Education and social change

Refer **Class Notes** and **Handout:** Educational Institutions

- Science, technology and social change

Remarks:

Refer **Class Notes**

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Sociology

PAPER – II: INDIAN SOCIETY: STRUCTURE AND CHANGE

(A) Introducing Indian Society:

- **(i) Perspectives on the study of Indian society**
- **(ii) Impact of colonial rule on Indian society**

(B) Social Structure:

- **(i) Rural and Agrarian Social Structure**
- **(ii) Caste System**
- **(iii) Tribal communities in India**
- **(iv) Social Classes in India**
- **(v) Systems of Kinship in India**
- **(vi) Religion and Society**

(C) Social Changes in India:

- **(i) Visions of Social Change in India**
- **(ii) Rural and Agrarian Transformation in India**
- **(iii) Industrialization and Urbanization in India**
- **(iv) Politics and Society**
- **(v) Social Movements in Modern India**
- **(vi) Population Dynamics**
- **(vii) Challenges of Social Transformation**

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(A) Introducing Indian Society:

(i) Perspectives on the study of Indian society:

(a) Indology (G S Ghurye) (refer online PDF on Ghurye)

(b) Structural functionalism (M N Srinivas)

Handouts: 1. M.N. Srinivas, 2. The Social Structure of Mysore Village, 3. Contributions of M.N. Srinivas to Village Studies, and 4. Structural functional perspective

(c) Marxist sociology (A R Desai) (refer online PDF on Desai, **Handout:** 1. Marxian perspective)

(ii) Impact of colonial rule on Indian society:

(a) Social background of Indian nationalism (refer online PDF on A.R. Desai)

(b) Modernization of Indian tradition (refer **Class Notes**)

(c) Protests and movements during the colonial period (**Handout:** Resistance to the British Rule: Early Uprisings and the Revolt of 1857)

(d) Social reforms (**Handouts: 1.** Jainism and Buddhism, 2. Socio-Religious Reform Movements, 3. Social and Cultural Awakening, and 4.Religious Movements in 15^{th} and 16^{th} centuries)

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(B) Social Structure:

(i) Rural and Agrarian Social Structure:

(a) The idea of Indian village and village studies

Handouts: 1. The Social Structure of Mysore Village, 2. Contributions of M.N. Srinivas to Village Studies

(b) Agrarian social structure - evolution of land tenure system, land reforms

Handouts: 1. Land tenure system and land reforms, 2. Agrarian structures and their transformations, and 3. Dimensions of agrarian structure and change: Issues in theory

(ii) Caste System:

(a) Perspectives on the study of caste system:

G.S. Ghurye

M.N. Srinivas

Louis Dumont (refer **Class Notes** and **Handouts: 1.** Louis Dumont, and 2. Indological perspective)

Andre Beteille (refer **Class Notes**)

(b) Feature of caste system

Refer online PDF on Ghurye, **Class Notes** and **Handout:** The caste system in India (M.N. Srinivas)

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(c) Untouchability - forms and perspectives (refer **Class Notes**)

(iii) Tribal communities in India:

(a) Definitional problems

(b) Geographical spread

(c) Colonial policies and tribes

(d) Issues of integration and autonomy

Handouts: 1. Tribal life in India, 2. Tribal resistance, violence, Left's role and state's response, 3. Indian tribals and search for an indigenous identity, and 4. Tribal movements

(iv) Social Classes in India:

(a) Agrarian class structure

(b) Industrial class structure

(c) Middle classes in India

Remarks: Refer **Class Notes** and **IGNOU**

(v) Systems of Kinship in India: (already covered along with Paper I)

(a) Lineage and descent in India

(b) Types of kinship systems

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(c) Family and marriage in India

(d) Household dimensions of the family

(e) Patriarchy, entitlements and sexual division of labour

(vi) Religion and Society: (already covered along with Paper I)

(a) Religious communities in India

(b) Problems of religious minorities

(C) <u>Social Changes in India:</u>

(i) Visions of Social Changes in India:

(a) Idea of development planning and mixed economy

Refer **Class Notes and Handout:** Economic institutions

(b) Constitution, law and social change

Refer **Class Notes**

(c) Education and social change (already covered along with Paper I - Topic 10)

(ii) Rural and Agrarian transformation in India.

(a) Programmes of rural development, Community Development Programme, cooperatives, poverty alleviation schemes

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Refer **Class Notes** and **Handouts:** 1. Rural development, 2. Rural life in India (I & II), 3. Village cooperatives, and 4. Adequacy and effectiveness of poverty alleviation programmes in India. (also refer Handout on Economic Institutions)

(b) Green revolution and social change

Refer **Class Notes** and **Handout:** Green revolution and social inequalities in rural India

(c) Changing modes of production in Indian agriculture (refer **Class Notes**)

(d) Problems of rural labour, bondage, migration

Refer **Class Notes** and **Handouts:** 1. Socio-economic conditions of agricultural labourers, and 2. Problem of bonded labour

(iii) Industrialization and Urbanisation in India:

(a) Evolution of modern industry in India

(b) Growth of urban settlements in India

(c) Working class: structure, growth, class mobilization

(d) Informal sector, child labour

(e) Slums and deprivation in urban areas

Refer **Class Notes**, **IGNOU** and **Handouts:** 1. Industrial working class movements, 2. Informal sector (Jan Breman), and 3. Housing the urban poor

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(iv) Politics and Society: (already covered along with Paper I)

(a) Nation, democracy and citizenship

(b) Political parties, pressure groups social and political elite

(c) Regionalism and decentralization of power.

(d) Secularization

(v) Social Movements in Modern India:

(a) Peasants and farmers movements

Refer **Class Notes** and **Handouts:** 1. Peasant movement, 2. Bhoodan-Gramdan movement, and 3. Naxalbari movement

(b) Women's movement (**Handout**)

(c) Backward classes (**Handout**) & Dalit movement (**Handout**)

(d) Environmental movements

Handouts: 1. Environment and ecological crisis, 2. State led Development-induced dispossession and displacement, and 3. Development and displacement

(e) Ethnicity and identity movements (refer **Class Notes**)

(vi) Population Dynamics:

(a) Population size, growth, composition and distribution

(b) Components of population growth: birth, death, migration

(c) Population policy and family planning

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(d) Emerging issues: ageing, sex ratios, child and infant mortality, reproductive health

Refer **Handouts:** 1. Population dynamics, 2. India's population – a perspective, 3. Demography, and 4. Reproductive health [(a) Dileep V. Mavalankar, (b) Saroj Pachauri]

(vii) Challenges of Social Trasnsformation:

(a) Crisis of development displacement, environmental problems and sustainability

(b) Poverty deprivation and inequalities

(c) Violence against women

(d) Caste conflicts

(e) Ethnic conflicts, communalism, religious revivalism

(f) Illiteracy and disparities in education

Remarks: already covered along with other topics of Paper I and II.

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Kinship

Kinship is one of the main organizing principles of human society. Marriage is a link between the family of orientation and the family of procreation. This fact of individual membership in two nuclear families gives rise to kinship system. According to **Theodorson**, kinship may be defined as "a social relationship based upon family relatedness". The relationship which may be **consanguineal** (based on blood) or **affinal** (based on marriage), determines the rights and obligations of related persons.

As such, kinship system is referred to as "a structured system of statuses and roles and of relationship in which the kin (primary, secondary, tertiary and distant) are bound to one-another by complex interlocking ties". **G.P. Murdock** argues that kinship is merely a structured system or relationship in which individual are bound to one another by complex interlocking and ramifying ties. **Radcliffe-Brown** (*Structure and Function in Primitive Society*) looks at kinship system as a part of social structure and insists upon the study of kinship in terms of the rights and obligations of the individuals involved.

Every kinship system distinguish between blood relatives (biologically related, actually or by social fiction), who are technically called consanguineal relatives, and relatives by marriage, technically called affinal relatives. Married couples may in some systems be related by blood, but they are always regarded as affinal relatives since the marriage bond is socially the most important bond between them. The various types of family therefore always include some affinal relatives. The only exception we know of is the Nayar *Taravad*, which consists of brothers and sisters, with the children of the sisters and of the women in successive generations. All these consanguineal relatives can live in the same household only because among the Nayars husband and wife do not live together for more than three days.

According to the Oxford Dictionary of Sociology, 'Kinship systems establish relationships between individuals and groups on the model of biological relationships between parents and children, between siblings, and between marital partners.' Relationships established by marriage, which form alliances between groups of person related by blood (or consanguineous ties), are usually referred to as affinal relationship. Some social scientists make a distinction between the study of kinship and the study of affinity. It should be noted that actual biological relationships are not necessary for status within a kinship system to be established. For instance, it may be more important to establish that a child has a social father, who will take responsibility for its welfare and have a right to the product of its labour, than to find out who the biological father might be.

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For example, the **Todas** of Nilgiri Hills who practiced fraternal polyandry, used to observe an interesting ceremony called ***bow and arrow ceremony*** to declare the paternity socially. In this ceremony, all brothers and the common wife used to assemble amidst the rest of the villagers in the fourth or fifth month of pregnancy of the wife and as a result of consensus one of the brothers used to present a set of bow and arrow to the wife. This was taken as declaration that this particular brother would be accepted as father of the coming child. In this way, the 'social fatherhood' overrides the 'biological fatherhood'.

Kinship structure is a commonly used term in both sociological as well as anthropological literature. Structure means a more or less lasting pattern of social relationship. Thus, structure of kin groups refers to those persisting patterns of relations which form the basis of their organisation. **Robin Fox** in his major work *Kinship and Marriage* has identified certain conditions which have to be met by every kinship system in order to survive and sustain itself. He has called these conditions as **structural principles of kinship** because the manner in which these conditions are fulfilled shape the structure of the kinship system. These structural principles of kinship are: (i) men impregnate women, (ii) women bear the children, (iii) men control economic activity and (iv) incest taboo. According to Robin Fox, these four conditions have to be met by all kinship systems. He further argues that the way these conditions are met will determine the structure or pattern of relations in the kinship system.

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Kinship Terms and Usages:

Kinship terms are used to designate and address a kin. **A.R. Radcliffe Brown**, the famous anthropologist, has observed that kinship terms indicate, among other things, classification of ego's rights and duties. Prior to him, **L.H. Morgan**, pointed out that kinship terms provides the context and idiom for our social relationship. Kinship terms are technically classified in different ways, but there are two broad categories of the terms as given by Morgan: (i) Descriptive, and (ii) Classificatory.

The **Descriptive System** refers to a kinship system in which a single term refers to a particular relative and a specific kind of relationship of the ego (the person from whom the relationship is calculated) with her or him. For example, mother's brother is referred to as *mam*a, father's brother as *chacha* etc. The **Classificatory System** uses kinship terms that merge or equate relatives who are genealogically distinct from one another. Here the same term is used for different kin. For example, in English, the term 'grandfather' includes both father's father and mother's father, brother-in-law applies to both wife's and husband's brother and also sister's husband and so on. In Hindi, the term '*samdhi*' is used for both, daughter's father –in-law and son's father –in-law.

The North Indian kinship terminology is comparatively descriptive in the sense that it describes elementary relationships starting from the ego. In order to emphasise the patrilineal descent, the terms in the system make a clear-cut distinction between parallel and cross cousins, e.g., *bhatiji* - one's brother's daughter and *bhanji* - one's sister's daughter. In the South Indian kinship terminology there is relative stress on classificatory terminology. Here the same term *mama* includes mother's brother, father's sister's husband and wife's father. However, in most contemporary societies, both terms – descriptive and classificatory – are used.

Within each kin group there are certain reciprocal behavioural patterns. These behaviours, verbal or non-verbal constitute **kinship usages**. Relationships of avoidance, joking relationships and teknonymy are some of the usages which are almost universally practiced. In **relations of avoidance**, we find that certain relationships are of restricted nature. Such kins maintain a distance and avoid free interaction between themselves. A man's relationship with his son's wife or with his younger brother's wife is the example of this category of relationship. Certain other relationships are there in which opposite is the case. Interaction between them is intimate and frank and they have **joking relationship** including use to obscene and vulgar references. Joking relationship between a man and his wife's sister or between a woman and her husband's younger brother are very common.

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Teknonymy is yet another kinship usage. It was used in anthropology for the first time by Tylor. According to this usage, a kin is not referred to directly but he is referred to through another kin. A kin becomes the medium of reference between two kins. Thus, in traditional Hindu family a wife does not utter the name of her husband. She calls him through her son or daughter. For example, he is referred to by her as the father of Bittoo or Gudiya.

Kinship usages accomplish two major tasks. First, they create groups: special groupings of kin. Thus marriage assigns each mother a husband, and makes her children his children, thereby creating a special group of father, mother and children, which we call "family". The second major function of kinship usage is to govern the role relationships between kin: that is, how one kinsman should behave in a particular kinsman's presence, or what one kinsman owes to another. Kinship assigns guidelines for interactions between persons. It defines proper, acceptable role relationship between father and daughter, between brother and sister, between son-in-law and mother-in-law and between fellow lineage members and clansmen. Kinship thus acts as a regularizer of social life and maintains the solidarity of social system.

Lineage and Descent:

(Rules of Residence, Descent and Inheritance)

[Note: Rules of Residence have already been discussed under the topic 'Family'.]

As stated earlier, kinship is one of the main organizing principles of human society. Kinship includes all forms of social relationships based on consanguineal (related by blood, common descent) and affinal ties (related by marriage).

Sanguine means blood; Consanguine implies common blood.

Consanguinity: A consanguine relationship is a kin relationship based on descent from a common (male or female) ancestor. However, the common ancestor, in fact, may be a social fiction, as is often the case with clans.

Clan: A clan encompasses people who assume shared descent from a common ancestor without being able to enumerate all of these links.

For example, among the Pathans of Swat Valley, northern Pakistan, thousands of persons regard themselves as members of patrilineal Yusufzai clan, assuming by general consent that they are the descendants of the mythical Yusuf without being able to prove it. Thus, clans tend to be regarded as larger, less tightly incorporated groups than lineages.

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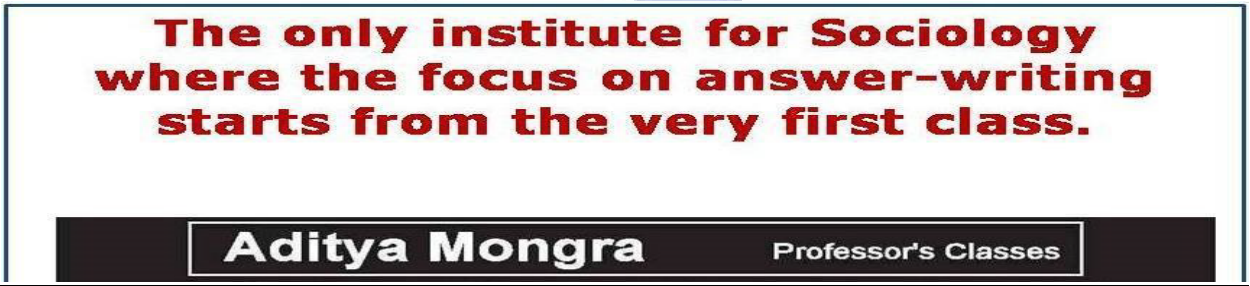
Lineage: A lineage may be described as a consanguineous unilineal decent group whose members trace themselves from a **known common ancestor**. A lineage is based on more precise and specific genealogy than a clan, of which it may be a subgroup. In other words, a lineage consists of persons who can indicate, by stating all the intermediate links, common descent from a shared ancestor. Thus, lineages are generally historically more shallow, and as a consequence small groups than clans.

Important: In this connection, it is necessary to point out that in determining consanguineous kinship it is not the biological fact that is important but social recognition. According to renowned social anthropologist W.H.R. Rivers, ***'kinship is the social recognition of biological ties.'***

Dear Candidate, please note that social recognition is more important than biological ties. Biological ties, if not socially recognized, then no kinship bond will exist, for example – in the case of illegitimate child. But, if social recognition is given to a relationship where no biological ties exist, even then kinship bond exists, for example – in the case of adopted child.

Among many primitive societies, the role of a father in birth of a child is unknown, as among the Trobriand Islanders of Malanesia. Among them it is the wife's husband who is conventionally accepted as father. Amongst the polyandrous Todas of Nilgiri, until another brother makes the ceremonial presentation of a bow and arrow to the common wife, all children born to her of several brothers are regarded as the children of that brother who last performed the ceremony, even though he may have been away or dead for a long time. Here is an instance where ignorance of the biological role of fatherhood is not implied; only social recognition is shown to override biological fact. Among some African primitives, in case a husband dies, a woman assumes the role of father to the expected child of the wife of the deceased.

A universal example of the overriding nature of social recognition is the practice of adoption. An adopted child is everywhere treated as if it were one's own biologically produced offspring. So, in kinship social recognition overrides biological facts.



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Important:

Lineage and descent are the two important concepts that help us to understand the social structure of a given society.

A **lineage** may be described as **a consanguineous unilineal descent group** whose members trace themselves from a known common ancestor. A lineage is based on more precise and specific genealogy than a clan, of which it may be a sub-group. In other words, a lineage consists of persons who can indicate, by stating all the intermediate links, common descent from shared ancestor. Thus lineages are generally historically more shallow, and as a consequence, smaller groups than clans.

Descent, in kinship terminology, implies a person's family origins. Descent concerns the tracing of relationships through succeeding generations, i.e., who has descended from whom. When social recognition is given to the biological descent, it gives rise to descent groups, for example, lineage, clan, etc.

In a given society, lineage can either be traced unilineally or otherwise. **Unilineal descent** implies that descent is determined exclusively by either the father's line (patrilineal) or by mother's line (matrilineal).

Non-unilineal descent groups are grouped as **cognatic descent**, which are of following types:

- **Bilineal (Double Unilineal) descent:**
  - both lines (father's as well as mother's lines are recognized but not symmetrically
  - some resources are transmitted from the father's lineage, others through the mother's lineage
  - the two lineages are kept separate. For example, Yako of Nigeria

- **Bilateral descent**
  - both lines are recognized equally and symmetrically
  - **it is a predominant feature of modern industrial societies**
  - both parents transmit to their child

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- **Ambilineal descent**
  - in this case, the individual has a choice to decide which line he/she wants to identify with.
  - for example, Samoan Islands in Pacific (studied by Margaret Mead)

- **Parallel descent**
  - men transmit to their sons and women to their daughters
  - for example, Saha tribe of Brazil (studied by James Safer)

- **Crossing/ Alternating descent**
  - men transmit to their daughters, women transmit to their sons

Significance of lineage and descent in kinship and family:

1. Reproduction of society (incest taboo, endogamy, exogamy)

   All human societies prohibit sexual relation between persons who are classified as closed blood kin, which includes at least the father-child, mother-child and siblings relationships. This does not of course mean that such relations do not occur, but rather that there is a norm prohibiting it. This universal rule is often spoken of as the **incest taboo**. Please note that the extension of incest taboos differ from society to society, and from religion to religion. Some anthropologists have pointed out the social advantages of the rule, including the expansion of the group through the inclusion of new members and the forging of alliances across kin boundaries. While others have pointed out that widespread incest would lead to biological degeneration through the transmission of inheritable disease.

   Further all societies have prescriptions and proscriptions regarding who may or may not marry whom. In some societies, these restrictions are subtle while in others individuals who can or cannot be married are more explicitly and specifically defined. Forms of marriage based on rules governing eligibility/ineligibility of mates is classified as endogamy and exogamy. **Endogamy** requires an individual to marry within a culturally defined group of which he is already a member, as for example caste, religion or tribe, etc.

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Caste and religious endogamy are the most pervasive forms of endogamy. Most religious groups do not permit or like their members to marry individuals of other faiths. Endogamy is also a very important characteristic of the Indian caste system. **Exogamy**, on the other hand, requires the individual to marry outside of his own group. Exogamy refers to the rules of avoidance in marital relationship. Every community prohibits its members from having marital relationship with certain persons. The exogamy in one form or the other is practised in every community. Under this rule, marriage among close relatives especially kins and within the same clan is prohibited. For example, in China, the individuals who bear the same surname may not inter-marry. In Hindu marriage, gotra and sapinda are such exogamous groups.

2. Group membership

Kinship concerns much more than the reproduction of society and the transmission of cultural values and knowledge between the generations, although these aspects are certainly important. Kinship also facilitates group formation. Thus, marriage assigns each mother a husband, and makes her children his children, thereby creating a special group of father, mother and children, which we call "family".

3. Political function

Kinship can also be important in politics and in the management of everyday affairs. In many societies, a man needs support from both consanguineal kin (blood kin) and from affines (in-laws) in order to follow a successful political career. In societies, specially stateless ones, the kin group usually forms, along with locality, the basis for political stability and for the promotion of political interests.

4. Economic function

In many societies, family members join forces in economic investments. Among the Hindus of Mauritius, for example, it is common for groups of brothers and cousins to set up a join business. Although there may be no formal rule to the effect that one has to be related to run a business together, kinship can give a practical advantage. One can usually trusts ones relatives, since they are tied to one self through webs of strong normative obligations.

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5. Social stability and social control

   Inside the kin group, norms specify roughly how one is to behave towards different categories of kin. In other words, kinship usages also govern the role relationships between kin: that is, how one kinsman should behave in a particular kinsman's presence, or what one kinsman owes to another. Kinship assigns guidelines for interaction between persons. It defines proper acceptable role relationship between father and daughter, between brother and sister, between son-in-law and mother-in-law, between fellow lineage members and clansmen. Kinship thus acts as a regularizer of social life and maintains the solidarity of social system. These norms prevent the dissolution of the group and ensure that people carry out their duties. The entire division of labour may thus be organized on kinship principle.

6. Inheritance and succession

   Group membership, politics, reproduction and social stability have been mentioned as important aspects of kinship. A further important dimension of the kinship institution is its connection with inheritance and succession. Both institutions are to do with the transmission of the resources from one generation to the next. Inheritance concerns the transmission of property, while succession refers to 'the transmission of office', transmission of specified rights and duties as ascribed statuses.

   All societies have rules regulating who is to inherit what when someone dies, although these rules are often contested or interpreted in varying ways. There is no universal link between the kinship systems and rules of inheritance in societies. There are patrilineal systems of descent where men and women are equals in terms of inheritance, and there are systems which give priority to one of the genders, usually the male. In some societies the eldest son receives a larger part of the inheritance than his siblings (primogeniture); others follow the opposite principle and give priority to the youngest son (ultimogeniture). Whereas the corporate principle functions in an integrating way, inheritance is a source of potential disruption, since it reveals conflict of interests among the relatives. Rules of succession are often closely linked with the principle of descent. In patrilineal systems, a son (or a younger brother) will frequently take over the commitments of the deceased; in matrilineal systems, a man commonly succeeds his mother's brother.

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Kinship serves two important and related purposes. Firstly, it serves to establish and maintain effective social group and secondly, it provides a way of transmitting status and property from one generation to the next. In most societies where kinship connections are important, the rules of descent affiliate individuals with different sets of kin. Descent concerns the tracing of relationships through succeeding generations, i.e., who has descended from whom. Different societies follow different-different rules of descent and inheritance. Some of the important ones are mentioned in the following section in brief.

In most societies a child is regarded as the offspring of both parents, and so has relationships of kinship traced through both. Those kin traced through the father are termed **paternal** or **patrilateral**; those traced through the mother, **maternal** or **matrilateral**. The totality of matrilateral and patrilateral kin recognized by a person within a certain degree is sometimes termed his **kindred**. It is also usual to distinguish lineal from collateral kin. **Lineal** kin are the direct ancestors and direct descendants of an individual: his parents, grandparents, great-grandparents, etc., and his children, grandchildren, etc. **Collaterals** are the other descendants of one's lineal kin (parents' siblings, cousins, etc.). Some writers consider a person's siblings and their descendant as lineal, others as collateral kin. Yet another distinction is made between primary, secondary and tertiary kin. **Primary kin** are one's parents, one's siblings and one's own offspring (father, mother, brother, sister, son, daughter). **Secondary kin** are the primary kin of these (father's father, mother's brother, brother's daughter, etc.). **Tertiary kin** are the primary kin of secondary kin, and so on.

The classic way of defining consanguinity is in terms of common descent from ancestor. All the descendants of a common ancestor may be termed as **stock**. Thus an individual is a member of as many stocks as he recognizes ultimate lineal ancestors. Through his parents he is a member of two stocks, through his grandparents of four…. etc. A person is said to be a **cognate** of, or related cognatically to, all those people with whom he shares a common ancestor.

For some purposes, however, the descent criterion may be restricted to males, and only those descendants of a common ancestor in the male line will be recognized as kin. These are known as **agnatic** or **patrilineal** kin. If descent is traced through female exclusively for some purposes, then the descendants would be called **uterine** or **matrilineal** kin. These two modes of tracing descent are called unilineal: that is, they select one 'line' only, either the male or the female. These principles are not necessarily mutually exclusive within a society. It is possible, for example, for an individual to recognize all cognates as kin for some purposes, but to restrict recognition to agnates for some other purposes. Indeed, almost all kinship systems recognize bilateral relationship, i.e relationship to both

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maternal and paternal kin. Some societies, such as the Yako of Nigeria, utilize matrilineal descent for some purposes and patrilineal for other, thus achieving a system of **double unilineal descent**, known usually as **double-descent** for short.

Rules of inheritance tend to coordinate with the reckoning of descent in most societies, but not necessarily in a one- to- one manner. In fact, it is quite often the case that certain types of property pass from father to son, and other types from mother to daughter. In most parts of India, in the past, immovable property such as land and housing was inherited only by sons. In the absence of sons, except under rare circumstances, by the nearest male relatives on the father's side. On the other hand, movable property in the form of cash and jewellery was given to the daughter at the time of her marriage, with a certain amount of jewellery also passing from the mother-in-law to the daughter-in-law.

Until the passing of the **Hindu Succession Act**, **1956**, two systems of inheritance dominated among patrilineal Hindus. In one system (called the **Mitakshara** school, adopted in most regions) a son has a vested interest in his father's ancestral property from the moment of his birth. The father cannot give away any part of this property to the detriment of his son's interest. Under the other system (the **Dayabaga** school, adopted in Bengal and Assam) the father is the absolute owner of his share and has a right to alienate his property the way he wants.

However with the passing of the Hindu Succession Act of 1956, a uniform system of inheritance has been established. The individual property of a male Hindu, dying intestate (having made no will), passes in equal shares between his son, daughter, widow and mother. Male and female heirs have come to be treated as equal in matters of inheritance and succession. Another important feature of the Act is that any property possessed by a female Hindu is held by her as her absolute property and she has full power to deal with it the way she likes. This Act has also given a woman the right to inherit from the father as well as from the husband. However the benefit conferred on a woman is limited when compared to the right of the male members who still have rights to coparcenary ancestral property by birth. Daughters are not part of the coparcenary and have no birthrights.

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The Kinship Map of India: Irawati Karve

Prof. Irawati Karve was the first sociologist who contributed to our understanding of the kinship structure o f Indian society. In her monumental work "Kinship Organisation in India", published in 1953, Irawati Karve found a correlation between the languages spoken in a particular region and the type of kinship system that existed in that region.

Irawati Karve divided India into three major linguistic zones and she found that kinship practices within each of these zones showed high degree of similarity while remarkable differences were to be found between the kinship systems of different zones. Please note that a linguistic region is one in which several languages belonging to one language family are spoken. She distinguished three linguistic regions in India. These regions are

1. **Indo- European Linguistic Region** (where languages derived from Sanskrit are spoken, for example, Sindhi, Punjabi, Kashmir, Hindi, Bihari, Bengali, Assamese, and Nepalese, etc.)

2. **Dravidian Linguistic Region** (where dravidian languages such as Kannada. Telugu, Tamil, and Malyalam are spoken)

3. **Austro-Asiatic Linguistic Region** (constitutes of Mundari family of languages and Monkhmer family of languages)

*** Mundari family of languages:** those who speak Mundari are found in central and Eastern India, particularly the Chota Nagpur plateau region, for example, Orissa, North-West Andhra Pradesh, Chattisgarh, Jharkhand etc.

*** Monkhmer family of languages:** it is found mostly outside India (except "Khasi" tribe), for example, Cambodia, Thailand, Vietnam, etc.

Based on these linguistic regions, Irawati Karve divided India into four kinship zones viz. (i) Northern Zone (ii) Central Zone, (iii) Southern Zone and (iv) Eastern Zone.

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Northern Zone (Zone of Indo-European Languages)

The Northern zone comprises that part of India which lies between the Himalayas in the north and the Vindhya ranges in the south. Linguistically, it is the region where languages derived from Sanskrit are spoken by a large majority of people. The northern zone includes Sindh (part of Pakistan), Jammu and Kashmir, Punjab, Delhi, Uttar Pradesh, part of Madhya Pradesh, Bihar, Bengal, Assam and Nepal. The languages spoken are Sindhi, Kashmiri, Punjabi, Hindi, Bengali, Assami and Nepali.

Features of kinship system in Northern Zone (generally found common among a majority of castes)

- To a large extent the north India kinship organization is characterised by **patrilineal descent**, **patrilocal residence**, and **patriarchalism**. In other words, descent is traced through the father (male line), and after marriage, the couple resides with the groom's family. Further, in the patriarchal family, the authority vests in the male head of the family.

- North Indian kinship system is characterised by **extensive kinship practices** on account of various rules of exogamy, for example, **gotra exogamy**, **village exogamy**, etc. In north India, **'the four gotra rule'** is widely prevalent, which states that a man must not marry into

  i) his father's gotra (i.e. his own gotra)
  ii) his mother's gotra
  iii) his father's mother gotra
  iv) his mother's mother's gotra

Besides this there is also a **taboo on marriage with cousins**. Further in some parts there is **local exogamy** whereby certain caste groups of the same village, even if they are of different gotras, do not intermarry.

- The custom of **local exogamy** divides the women of a local group into two sharp divisions: **the daughters of the village** and **the brides of the village**. The north has separate words for daughters and brides in each regional language.

- North Indian kinship system is characterized by the practices of **hypergamy** and **kulinism**. Hypergamy refers to the practice in which women belonging to lower castes can marry men of higher castes (In Vedic literature, it has

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been prescribed and called as *anuloma*: alliance between a lower caste woman and a higher caste man). Similar practice among Brahmins of Bengal is referred to as *kulinism*. In such hypergamous bonds the male enjoys a higher status vis-a-vis female on account of his higher ritual status.

- In northern India, marriage generally takes place at an early age (child marriage). However, the marriage takes place in two stages, viz. *Vivah* and *Gauna*. **Vivah** is nothing but a ceremonial marriage of a boy with a girl of below puberty age. However, the bride is not finally sent to groom's house until she reaches puberty. After the girl has reached puberty, a ceremony called **Gauna** is performed and the groom is called to take away the bride.
- Another key feature of north Indian kinship organisation is the widespread practice of **levirate**, **polygyny** and **remarriage**. Levirate is a custom of marriage of a widow to the husband's brother. Polygyny is that arrangement of marriage where a man can have more than one wife. Irawati Karve in her study found that the most powerful motive for polygyny besides the display of social status and wealth is the desire for male progeny (male child).

Central Zone (Zone of Transition)

The central zone comprises of Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Gujarat, Maharashtra and Orissa. The salient features of kinship organization of central India are not much different from those of northern India.

- Many castes are divided into exogamous clans.
- Among some castes, the exogamous clans are arranged in a hypergamous hierarchy i.e. a girl in a lower clan can marry a man of a higher clan but a girl in a higher clan may not marry a man in a lower clan.
- It has also been noted that a majority of caste groups practiced one type of cross cousin marriage as a permissive form of marriage i.e. a marriage of a man to his mother's brother's daughter. There is a definite taboo or aversion towards the other type of cross-cousin marriage i.e. marriage of a man to his father's sister's daughter.
- Practice of levirate has also been observed among some groups in central India.

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Irawati Karve describes the central zone as a zone of transition from the north to the south. She describes the state of Maharashtra as a region of cultural borrowings and cultural synthesis.

Southern Zone (Zone of Dravidian Languages)

The southern zone comprises those areas where the languages of the Dravidian family are spoken. It comprises of Karnataka, Andhra, Tamil Nadu and Kerala.

The southern zone presents a very complicated pattern of kinship systems and family organization. Though the patrilineal and patrilocal family is the dominant family type for the greater no of castes and communities, there are important sections of the population which are matrilineal and matrilocal. In Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu and among certain important castes of Kerala, the predominant form of family organization is patrilineal and patrilocal join family (e.g. Okkaligas of Karnataka, Nambudiri Brahmins of Tamil Nadu). However, among certain other groups in Kerala like Nayars, Tiyans, Moplas, etc., the family is matrilineal and matrilocal.

Further, as in the rest of India, most castes in this zone also allow the practice of polygyny while at the same time there are certain castes who practice both polygyny and polyandry. For example, Nambudiris, Nayars, Asari, etc., practice polygyny while Todas of Nilgiris (Tamil Nadu) practice fraternal polyandry and Nayars of Kerala practice non-fraternal polyandry.

Marriage preferences and taboos in southern zone:

- **Clan exogamy** is the key feature of southern marriages.
- There is a system of **preferential mating** in the south. In a large number of castes, the first preference is given to the elder sister's daughter (a consanguine, who is now affine), second preference is to father's sister's daughter and the third preference to mother's brother's daughter.
- The taboos prescribed for marriage are:
    i. a man cannot marry his younger sister's daughter.

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ii. though widow remarriage is practiced among almost all castes, a widow is not allowed to marry either the elder or younger brother of her husband (i.e. levirate is not practiced).

iii. a man cannot marry his mother's sister's daughter. In other words, marriage between maternal parallel cousins is not permissible.

The southern kinship organization is thus fundamentally different from that of northern zone. In the south, there is a definite bias for marriage within a very small kin group which implies that a man does not bring a stranger as a bride to his home. Marriage within a small kin group thus strengthens existing bonds. The emphasis is on knitting families closer together and narrowing the circle of kin group, a policy exactly the opposite of the one followed in the north. **The north represents the principle of extended exchange**, a policy of expansion (gotra and village exogamy) and incorporation of outsiders as wives into the family. **The south, on the other hand, represents the principle of immediate exchange** and a policy of consolidation. The distinction between the father's house and father-in-law's house is not as sharp as in north. The distinction between 'daughter' and 'bride' is not as deep as in north. **Thus, south Indian kinship organization can be called as intensive kinship organization and north Indian kinship organization can be best described as extensive kinship organization.**

In southern family, there is no clear-cut distinction between the family of birth (*family of orientation*) and family of marriage (*family of procreation*) as found in the northern family. In north, no member from ego's family of orientation (that is, father, mother, brother, sister) can become a member of his family of marriage, but this is possible in south.

The North Indian kinship terminology is comparatively descriptive in the sense that it describes elementary relationships starting from the ego. In order to emphasize the patrilineal descent, the terms in the system make a clear-cut distinction between parallel and cross cousins, e.g., *bhatiji* - one's brother's daughter and *bhanji* - one's sister's daughter. In the South Indian kinship terminology there is relative stress on classificatory terminology. Here the same term *mama* includes mother's brother, father's sister's husband and wife's father. However, in most contemporary societies, both terms – descriptive and classificatory – are used.

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Eastern Zone (Zone of Austro - Asiatic Languages)

According to Irawati Karve, eastern zone is the zone of Austro-Asiatic languages. The Austro-Asiatic languages are divided into two groups of languages, the Monkhmer and the Mundari. Of these the people who speak the Monkhmer languages are all, with the exception of Khasi tribe, outside and to the east of India; those who speak Mundari are found in central and eastern India, such as in parts of Orissa, north-west Andhra Pradesh, Chattishgarh, Jharkhand, etc.

The kinship organization in the eastern zone has no one pattern. There are more tribes than caste Hindus in eastern India. The important tribes are Khasi, Birhor, Ho, Munda and Oraon. People speaking Mundari languages have patrilineal- patrilocal families, while **Khasi and Garo tribes have matrilineal joint family system.** Practice of bride-price is common in various tribes. Institution of youth-dormitories have also been reported from various tribal groups. Tribal endogamy and clan exogamy is the general rule observed in marital relations.

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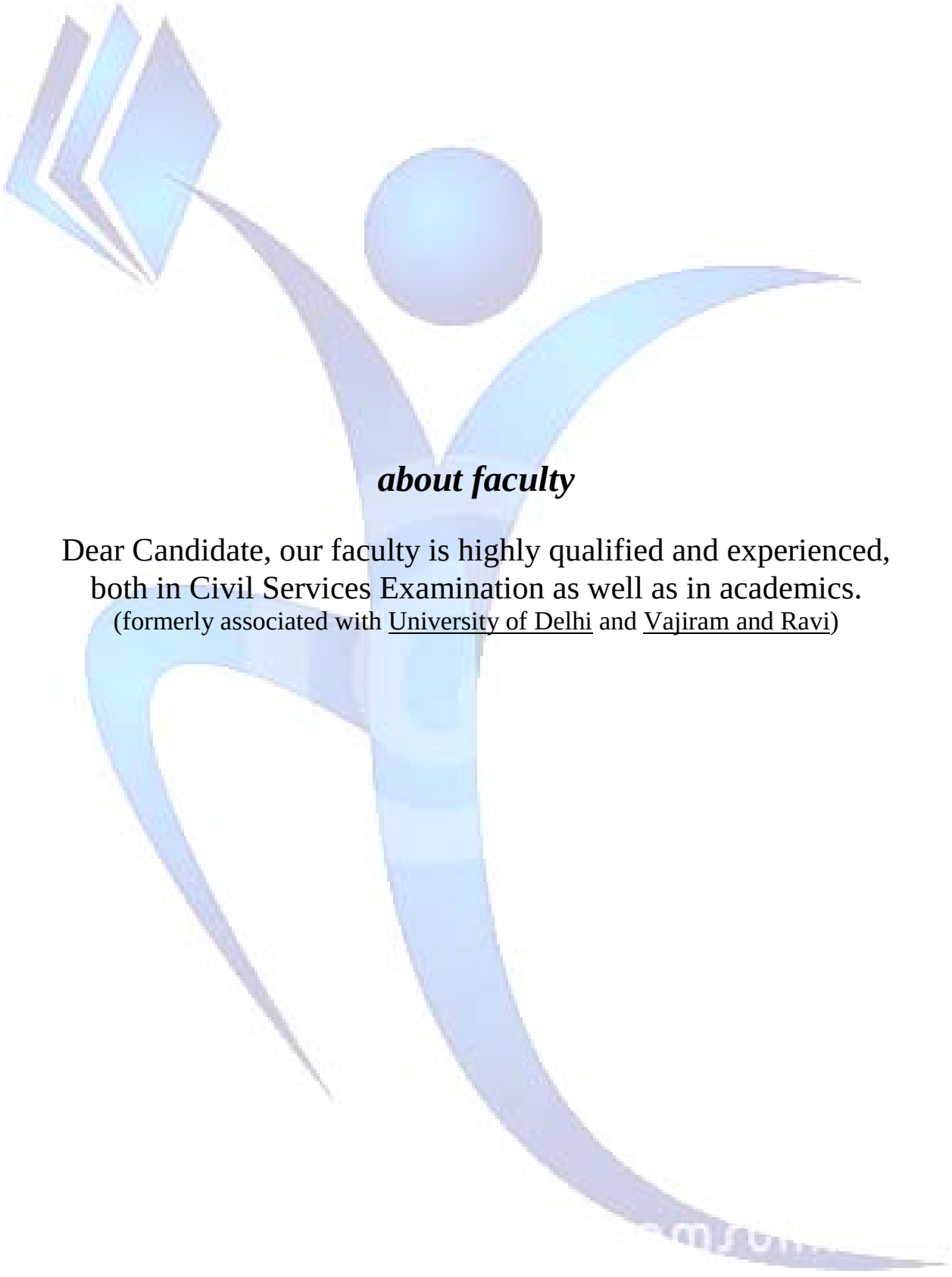

about faculty

Dear Candidate, our faculty is highly qualified and experienced, both in Civil Services Examination as well as in academics.
(formerly associated with University of Delhi and Vajiram and Ravi)

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about Civil Services as a career

Dear Candidate, before I introduce you to this work I would like to share a few things with you. As you know Civil Services Examination is considered to be one of the toughest examinations. But I believe that there is no such thing as EASY or DIFFICULT per se because I feel that it is our thinking that makes it so. Therefore, if you begin your journey to IAS with a positive attitude that **'YES, I CAN DO IT'**, then trust me your journey would become not only a pleasant and enjoyful learning experience but also far more easier than otherwise. Further, before you decide to take Civil Services Examination or any other examination, make sure that your decision is well thought of. For that, firstly, you must take time and introspect and see whether your aptitude and interest matches with the career that you are planning to choose. Since it is the most important step for anyone, any amount of time spent on this is worth.

Secondly, whatever decision you take must be your own independent decision and must be taken with the conviction that whatever may be the outcome you will never regret having taken such decision. Thirdly, one must also make a comparative analysis of the requirements or the level of preparation that an examination demands and the ability or level of preparation one actually has. This is important because it will not only help you in placing the examination in right perspective but also enable you to set realistic expectations from yourself. It will go a long way in guarding you from negative thoughts often arising out of self-doubts during the course of preparation. Thus, saving you both, time as well as energy.

Last, but not the least, I would like to caution those students who go on a shopping spree collecting study material from various coaching institutes during the course of their preparation for this examination. I wish to make it clear that this examination does not require too much of content. Rather, on the basis of my personal experience as well as that of toppers, I can confidently say that ***this examination is less about content and more about analysis, both comparative as well as contemporary***.

That's why in light of the changing pattern of the Civil Services Examination, I always suggest my students to:

Read Adequately * Think Logically * Write Relevantly

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how to prepare Sociology

Dear Candidate, given the **Limited Time** that you have and the **Infinite Syllabus** that you have to prepare for the Civil Services Examination, it becomes very important to manage your time wisely and utilize your energy efficiently. It becomes all the more important in light of the fierce competition that you face ahead. Here, I recall a line from the book *You Can Win* by Shiv Khera, that,

"Winners don't do different things, they do things differently".

Now, I would like to brief you about how our approach is different from the rest, and also the best, for preparing Sociology optional for the Civil Services Examination.

Firstly and foremostly, you must understand that no matter how many sleepless nights you may spend preparing for this examination, ultimately, it is only those 3 hours (at the examination hall during the Mains (Written) Examination) that are going to decide your fate. So it is very important for the candidates to prepare their subject strictly in an **Exam Oriented** manner. What is important here is not how much you have studied for the exam but how much you would be able to write at the time of the exam? So, what is important here is not to master the subject in all its possible details but rather, one should prepare the subject strictly in a professional manner keeping in mind the demands for 'conceptual clarity', 'analytical reasoning' and 'correct writing expression' as set forth by Union Public Service Commission. Only then one can hope to cover the syllabus for this exam in a time-bound manner with better chances of success. This you would realize step-by-step as you move along these notes and with vital inputs from my side at regular intervals.

Secondly, one must follow a **Theme-Based Approach** instead of Topic-Based Approach, whereby one should identify the major theme that underlies a given topic and runs through several other related sub-topics. Particularly, in light of the revised syllabus and the changing orientation of the Civil Services Examination, it has become all the more important to adopt theme-based approach because many a times questions are also asked on topics which are not mentioned in the syllabus. Though at the outset such questions may appear to be out of syllabus to the candidate but actually they are not. Questions on such topics are basically of implied nature and thus very much a part of the major theme that underlie the mentioned topic. So by following a theme-based approach we can

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cover not only the topics that are mentioned in the syllabus but also those which are implied in nature.

Thus, following a theme-based approach you would not only realize the depth of understanding that is expected from candidates at this examination but also it would keep you focused throughout your preparation. Please note that the theme-based approach would help you develop **Mental Framework** of the entire syllabus. Further, once you are confident that you have understood the broader dimensions of the theme then it would also resist your temptation to collect more and more material on the same topic. Thus, saving you both time as well as energy. You will learn this art as we proceed with the syllabus.

So, when I say **Read Relevantly**, I simply imply that given the limitations of time and energy, one should focus only on the important themes that underlie a given topic. Otherwise, given the vastness of the syllabus it would be impossible to do justice with all the topics mentioned in the syllabus in a time span of 3-4 months. Students must understand that just any information on the topic mentioned in the syllabus may not be equally important from the examination point of view. Hence we have to exercise selectivity.

To **Think Logically** implies that you must correlate your arguments in a logical manner. This will happen only if you have a thorough grasp of the concepts. So, **Conceptual Understanding** and **Conceptual Interlinking** both are very important. But equally important is its practical application in the contemporary scenario. So, whatever concepts or theories you study in the syllabus, you must also try to relate them with the contemporary society and changes therein. Please remember that conceptual clarity and its practical application is equally important at the Interview stage as well, as you may be asked to define or explain any sociological concept and to contextualize it in the light of contemporary developments, both in national and international arena.

Write Relevantly is the most critical stage of all. As I mentioned in the beginning that no matter how much you might have studied and what all sources you might have referred, ultimately it is your answer sheet that determines your destiny. Thus, your written answer must be a perfect blend of *conceptual clarity*, *conceptual interlinking* and *sociological language*. More importantly, such an answer needs to be produced on paper within the Time-and-Word Limit.

Dear Candidate, ultimately, you get only those 3 hours to convince the examiner that how dedicated you are about Civil Services and what importance does it carry in your life. So, with our **Dialectical Approach** (see page. 48) to answer writing we will make sure that all your efforts and sacrifices made

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during the course of preparation for this exam find a reflection in our answers. So along with working hard **(Hard Work)**, we also need to work smartly **(Smart Work)**. As you would proceed with the chapters you would be guided about note-making and answer-writing. Please follow the instructions sincerely.

Thank You

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Dear Candidate, after years of experience gained while preparing for this exam as well as in academics, I can say with firm conviction that this exam requires only **one and a half year** of dedicated and focused preparation. Generally those who take more time than this are the ones who either do not have the right guidance or realize the significance of these crucial aspects when it is already too late. In my view, an intensive but focused study of 3-4 months is more than sufficient to prepare Sociology optional for the civil services exam. I would also like to say that with regular answer-writing practice, a sincere candidate can easily score 250-300 marks, particularly in the new format of the Sociology Paper. I am sure that with these notes and with this approach you will start your preparations with an edge over other candidates. How far and how well you carry this advantage would largely depend upon the consistency and sincerity of your effort. Hence I request you to go through these notes step by step and follow the instructions sincerely.

all the best

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a word of caution

Dear Candidate, you just need to sincerely follow the topic-specific instructions that would be provided during the course. You will never find yourself alone while preparing this subject because I will always be there beside you with some useful tips and vital inputs. If at any stage you need some clarification, you can freely contact me on phone, email, or Facebook.

Now, you need to give at least three readings to the entire syllabus. But, these readings need to be done in a proper and professional manner. Remember, your aim is to qualify Civil Services Examination, not to master the subject. If you keep this thing in mind, I assure you that you will never waste even a single minute on unnecessary pursuits for collecting unnecessary and irrelevant material available in the market. In order to qualify this examination, all you need to do is that you must focus upon understanding the principle arguments related to the mentioned topic in the syllabus and develop you own understanding out of it. This is what I had already mentioned that conceptual clarity combined with its practical application in our daily life is the key to your success in Civil Services Examination.

As far as these three readings are concerned, I want to you to follow a very simple approach. In your first reading, just read these notes as a story. In your second reading, please underline, mark or highlight the important points and attempt the **Notes-Making Assignment** and **Writing-Skill Assignment** with a pencil. It is only in your third reading that you will refer to the suggested readings (that too only selectively), that I have mentioned wherever necessary and attempt the test given at the end of each topic in **Test Yourself** section. Please make sure that you get each and every test evaluated so that I can suggest you the corrective course of action before it is too late.

Just do this and see the difference in your preparation. You will not only be able to complete the entire syllabus in the shortest possible time but that too with conceptual clarity and good writing skills.

Wish you all the best

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Oath

- I believe that **Life** is the most beautiful gift bestowed upon us by **Mother Nature**. Mother Nature has blessed us all with Life so that we live happily and spread happiness all around. Mother Nature has empowered us all with its supreme divine power to realize our dreams. It is entirely up to us how we take care of our lives and what we make of it. We must respect Life and Mother Nature.

- I believe that there is no substitute for **Hard Work** and there is no shortcut to success. Those who tend to opt for shortcuts, their march to success is often cut short.

- I will place highest value on time and will try my best for its optimum utilization. I believe that **Time Management** is the key to success.

- I will set **Realistic Goals** and will make my best effort to achieve them.

- I believe that no success is final and no failure is fatal. It is the **Courage** to continue that counts.

- I will never, never, never, **Never Give Up**.

- I will adhere to the **Six Ethics of Life:**

Before you Pray	-	Believe
Before you Speak	-	Listen
Before you Spend	-	Earn
Before you Write	-	Think
Before you Quit	-	Try
Before you Die	-	Live

- I will be **Honest** and **Truthful** in my daily life.

- I will abide by the **Discipline**, code of conduct, terms and conditions of my institute.

(signature)

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Dear Candidate, I am also enclosing two sheets, one for your **Monthly Schedule** and another for your **Weekly Schedule** to facilitate better Time Management. You can get these sheets printed and photocopied and with regular practice you can yourself evaluate your performance.

Rule: While recording the numbers of hours in your Weekly Schedule, make sure that you deduct half an hour from each of your sitting. For example, if in one sitting you have studied for 2 hours, then, record only one and a half hours in the Weekly Schedule. If in the next sitting, you have studied for 3 hours, then, record two and a half hours only.

Dear Candidate, by following this method, you can tentatively arrive at the amount of qualitative time you are devoting to your preparations for the Civil Services Examination. By following this method, if any sincere candidate is devoting 8-10 hours per day on a regular basis, he is doing justice with his time, labour and above all, his aim.

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1. Sociology – The Discipline
Modernity and social changes in Europe and emergence of sociology
Scope of the subject and comparison with other social sciences
Sociology and common sense

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Modernity and social changes in Europe and emergence of sociology

Instructions: Dear Candidate, in this topic the examiner is primarily interested in testing your overall understanding about the process of transformation that took place in Europe in the eighteenth and nineteenth century. Further, he is interested to know that why this process of transformation, which included large-scale social, economic and political changes, is associated with the idea of modernity or why this transformation came to be identified as modernization. Last, but not the least, he wants to know that how the prevailing social conditions of those times created the need for a new discipline and how the intellectual conditions of those times contributed to the emergence of Sociology as a distinct discipline.

Theme: *Process of modernization in Europe (in the eighteenth and nineteenth century) and its impact on the emergence of sociology.*

Related Concepts: Feudalism, Renaissance, Commercial Revolution, Scientific Revolution, Reformation, Industrial Revolution, Enlightenment, French Revolution and Modernity.

Important: Dear Candidate, I have discussed this topic in detail here only to facilitate your thorough understanding and command over related concepts. But while writing an answer in the examination it would not be possible for you to incorporate each and every detail mentioned here. Hence, I suggest you to exercise selectivity in picking up only the relevant content as per the demand of the question. Given the Time and Word Limit in the examination, you will be able to write a concise and precise answer only if you remain focused on the theme.

My advice to you here is to understand and focus on the theme rather than the topic. I believe that given the changing pattern and focus of the Civil Services Examination, the topic-based approach is an outdated one because it leaves the candidate with a fragmented knowledge. While, on the other hand, a theme-based approach would help the candidate to interlink the concepts more easily. Thus, it would not only give the candidate a comprehensive understanding of the subject but also help him perform well both at the written as well as the interview stage of the examination.

To facilitate your better understanding and to enable you to interlink the concepts, these notes have been written in a continuing series of interlinked concepts and theories.

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Modernity has often been viewed as being in opposition to and representing a break from tradition. If tradition looked to the past, modernity presumably turned its eye to the future. Modern culture is frequently associated, as Swedish social theorist Goran Therborn (1995) notes, "with words like progress, advance, development, emancipation, liberation, growth, accumulation and enlightenment". One might add to this the idea that modernism is often depicted as an expansive, and thus global, phenomenon. The association with these terms suggests that modern culture possesses an optimistic orientation about our ability to collectively resolve problems, to remedy human suffering, and to enrich social life. It presupposes our ability to acquire knowledge of both the natural and the social worlds and to use this knowledge to beneficially control and mold these worlds. As Wagner (2008) sees it, "modernity is associated with the open horizon of the future, with unending progress towards a better human condition brought about by a radically novel and unique institutional arrangement". Historians as well as social theorists generally agree that from the fourteenth century to the sixteenth century A.D., Europe had been witnessing changes in its political, social and economic structures, which marked the beginning of what we call the modern period.

Before proceeding further with our discussion on modernity, we must understand that if modernity is viewed as being in opposition to and representing a break from tradition, then what was tradition like? In other words, what were the features of society of medieval Europe? [Note: Medieval period, also sometimes called as Middle Ages, roughly refers to the period from A.D. 600 to about A.D. 1500]

Society of medieval Europe (before fourteenth century) was largely feudal in character. Feudalism was the dominant system of social-economic and political organization in Western Europe from tenth to fifteenth century. It had emerged on account of downfall and decentralization of Roman Empire and absence of any central authority. The word 'feudal' comes from *feud* which originally meant a *fief* or land held on condition or service. In a feudal society, land was the source of the power. Thus, feudal system was based on allocation of land in return for service.

Feudalism was based upon a system of land tenure in which land estates of various sizes (fiefs) were given to hold (not to own) by an overlord to his vassals (knights) in return for military service. The fiefs may further be subdivided by a vassal among other knights who would then be his vassals. Such fiefs consisted of one or more *manors*, that is, *estates* with serfs whose agricultural production provided the economic basis for the existence of the feudal class. When receiving a fief a vassal took an oath of homage and fealty (fidelity) to his lord and owed him loyalty as well as a specified amount of military service. Upon the death of a vassal the fief would technically revert to the overlord, but it was a common practice for

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the eldest son to take his father's place as vassal of the lord, and thus, in effect, fiefs were passed on through primogeniture.

Estate system of social stratification was the characteristic feature of feudal European societies. Estates are defined as a system of stratification found in feudal European societies whereby one section or estate is distinguished from the other in terms of status, privileges and restrictions accorded to that estate. The feudal estates of medieval Europe had three important characteristics. Firstly, estates were legally defined. In other words, each estate had a status, in the precise sense of a legal complex of rights and duties, of privileges and obligations. The differences between estates can also be seen in the different penalties imposed for similar offences. Secondly, the estates represented a broad division of labour, and were regarded in the contemporary literature as having definite functions. 'The nobility were ordained to defend all, the clergy to pray for all, and the commons to provide food for all.' Thirdly, the feudal estates also acted as political groups.

Thus, the feudal society in Europe was a hierarchical and graded organization in which every person was allotted a position. At the top stood the king. He bestowed fiefs or estates on a number of lords who were known as dukes and earls. These lords in turn distributed a part of their fiefs among a number of lesser lords who were called barons and, in return, secured their military support. Thus the dukes and earls were the king's vassals, that is to say, they owed allegiance directly to the king. The barons were the vassals of the dukes and earls. The knights formed the lowest category of feudal lords. Usually they were the vassals of barons for whom they performed military service. Knights did not have any vassals of their own. Every feudal lord was expected to pay homage to his overlord and could then be in vested with some formal rights. Every feudal lord, except the knight, was first a vassal and then an overlord with a number of vassals under him. The relationship from top to bottom was one of allegiance. No vassal owned any land; he only held the land as of his overlord. The vassal was in every way his lord's man. He recognized no other authority than of his overlord. In time of need, for example, when the kind fought a war, he could demand military assistance from his vassals, these vassals - the dukes and the earls - demanded the same assistance from their vassals, the barons, and the barons from their vassals, the knights. Every feudal lord contributed a detachment of warriors, and thus a fighting army would be formed.

Feudal life, as explained in the previous section, was based on agriculture. The village farm was the *manor*, the size of which varied from place to place. Its centre was the manor house of the lord where he lived or which he visited, for the lords often possessed several manors. The manor included a large farm which supported all those who worked on it, a pasture area where the manor cattle grazed,

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and common woods which supplied fuel and timber. A manor always had a number of cottages where the common people lived, some workshops to provide for manor needs, and a chapel. *Manorialism* was an essential element of feudal society. It was a system of land tenure and the organizing principle of rural economy. It was characterized by the vesting of legal and economic power in a lord, supported economically from his own direct landholding and from the obligatory contributions of a legally subject part of the peasant population under his jurisdiction. These obligations could be payable in several ways, in labour, in kind or in coin, etc. *Manor* was the lowest unit of territorial organization in the feudal system in Europe. It may also be referred as the land tenure unit under manorialism. Country people often lived on a manor. On a manor there was a village, church, lord's house or castle, and the farmland upon which the people worked.

Please note that the Roman Catholic Church was as powerful an institution as feudalism in western Europe during medieval times. At the head of the Church was the Pope, who was accepted as the vicar of Christ. Popes were often stronger than the kings and could force them to obey their orders. Christianity taught that man's life on earth was not the end of existence, and that he should give up pleasures in this life in order to have a life of the spirit after death. Many Christian monks - St. Francis, St. Benedict, St. Augustine - laid great stress on purity, resistance to temptation and the pursuit of 'goodness'. Some people withdrew from worldly life and led a life of virtue and penance. Some men became monks and took the vows of obedience, poverty and chastity. Some women became nuns and lived in nunneries. The institutions where the monks lived together were called monasteries. This may remind you of the Budddhist *bhikshus* and their *viharas*. Life in monastery was well organized. Monks and nuns had to observe rigid rules of discipline. They could not marry or own property. They either worked or prayed. The slightest disobedience brought hard punishment. Some monasteries, like those funded by St. Benedict, were centres of learning and assured the members a well-ordered life. Through their strict rules of discipline, they trained groups who by their example and preaching, sought to uplift the moral life of the people, educate the laity and tend the sick. Gradually, however corruption crept into the monasteries. They acquired land and amassed wealth, helping to make the Church one of the biggest land-owners in medieval times. With cultivation and other work done by serfs, the life of many monks and nuns was no longer frugal and austere. Luxury, good food and drink, and idleness became common. Some great leaders sought to reform this state of affairs by introducing a new religious order - that of wandering monks. Members of this order had no homes but moved among the people, living on charity and setting an example of a life of chastity and self-sacrifice.

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During the early Middle Ages, Churches were the only centres of education and learning. The kinds of schools to which parents sent their children, when the Greek and Roman civilizations were still flourishing, had disappeared. The education that churches could provide was like a drop in the ocean. For a long time, monks and priests were the only literate men in Europe. Learning was kept alive by the Church and the monks in the monasteries. However, the learning fostered by the Church was a narrow type. Subjects that it taught were grammar, logic, arithmetic and theology. The only calling for which this education was suitable was that of a monk or a priest. The language of learning was Latin, which only churchmen could read. Everything was dominated by faith and anybody who appealed to reason against dogma was punished. Science had come to standstill. Magic and superstition held the day. Belief in witches was common and the punishment for witches was to burn them alive.

However, by the end of the Middle Ages (fourteenth century onwards), some changes started taking place in European societies which marked the decline of feudal system.

The revival of trade (discussed later under 'commercial revolution') was accompanied by the growth of towns. Old towns became larger and many new towns emerged, mainly as centres of manufacture and trade. Towns, often walled, gradually freed themselves from feudal control. They had their own governments and the townsmen elected their officials. They had their own militia and their own courts. Unlike the serfs, there were no restrictions on their movements. They could come and go as they pleased and buy and sell property. Towns provided asylum to serfs who escaped from feudal oppression. The towns encouraged the cultivation of cash crops needed for manufactures, and peasants received their payments in money. The peasants could now pay their dues to the lord in cash rather than by labour.

With the growth of trade, there was increasing use of money. Money had little use in feudal societies. A feudal manor was more or less self-sufficient for its needs. There was very little of buying and selling and whatever there was, was done through barter. The use of money indicated far-reaching changes in economy. In feudal societies, the indictor of a man's wealth was land. Some people had wealth, particularly the Church and sometimes the nobles, in the form of gold and silver, but it was idle wealth. It could not be used to make more wealth. With the growth of trade and manufactures, this changed, marking the beginning of the transition from feudal economy to capitalist economy in which wealth is used to make a profit. This is done by investing money in business, in trade and industry. The profits made are re-invested to make further profits. Such wealth or money is called 'capital'. Money, not the landed property, increasingly became the measure

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of man's wealth. In feudal societies, there were three classes of people: the prayers, that is, the clergy who prayed, the soldiers or the knights who fought, and workers or the peasants who worked for both the prayers and the soldiers. With the growth of trade a new class emerged - the 'middle class' - comprising mainly the merchants. Even though small in number, they began to play an important role in society because of the wealth they possessed. This early phase of capitalism is known as 'mercantile capitalism'. Thus mercantile capitalism is a system of trading for profit, typically in commodities produced by non-capitalist production methods.

Simultaneous with these developments changes took place in the system of manufacturing goods. In the early medieval period, most of the non-agricultural products required by the peasants were produced in the household of the peasant and by serfs, who were skilled craftsmen, for the lord. With the growth of towns, many of these activities shifted to towns where people skilled in particular crafts organized themselves into 'guilds'. Each craft guild had master craftsmen, journeyman and apprentices. To learn a craft, a person joined a master as an apprentice or learner. After having learned the craft, he worked as a journeyman with the master on a wage or, if he had mastered the craft, he would himself become a master craftsman. The units of production were small, consisting of three or four people, and each unit had a shop to sell its produce. There were no inequalities within a unit or between units of the same guild. The guild system, was not suited to the requirements of large scale production required by an expanding market for goods, and the system began to decline. Inequities appeared with the system, with masters refusing to let journeymen become masters and paying them low wages. With the introduction of 'the putting out system', their independence declined. The merchant, under this system, would bring the master craftsmen the raw materials, the craftsmen would work with their tools as before in their homes and the produce would be taken away by the merchant who had supplied them with raw materials. Thus, in effect, unlike before, the craftsmen did not own what they produced. They were increasingly reduced to the position of wage-earners, except that they still owned the tools used by them and worked at home.

Subsequently, this system gave way to the factory system (discussed later under 'industrial revolution') under which the production was carried out in a building owned by the capitalist with the help of machines also owned by him. The workers, owing nothing, worked only for wages. In industries, such as mining and metal-working, the new system came into being early. The period saw tremendous expansion of manufactures. This was accompanied by a growing differentiation in towns and the emergence of working class.

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As a result of these developments, the feudal system broke down. The towns which were free from the control of the lords began to undermine the stability of the feudal society. In course of time, towns became very prosperous. Kings who were quite powerless in the feudal system began to take the help and support of townsmen to increase their power and to enforce their will over the lords. The kings also started having their own armies and thus freed themselves from their earlier dependence on the lords for soldiers. This led to the emergence of strong nation-states. Thus, feudalism began to decline although it was finally ended in most countries only in the 18th and 19th centuries. In its place, a new system of society (Capitalist Society) began to emerge.

However, feudalism served its purpose of bringing a measure of orderliness, safety and security to medieval life. It allowed social and economic activity to run its normal course. But feudalism had also another side to it. It developed, and was dependent on, a rigid class system. Man was divided from man, class from class, and this stood in the way of political unity. The nobles looked down upon the common man, and their inherited authority brought with it one-man rule and oppression. The lords were often too powerful for the kings to control and fought among themselves for small selfish ends. The king had no contact with the common man, who was left entirely to the mercy of his lord, and the lord was usually irresponsible and unmindful of the welfare of common people. The feudal system also led to economic stagnation. The wealth produced by the peasants and the artisans was wastefully consumed by the feudal lords, in luxurious living and in wars. Individual enterprise and initiative were all but unknown. Further, the desire for the new lands and riches encouraged the lords and leaders of the Church to fight the 'holy wars', or the Crusades.

The medieval period, lasting roughly from fifth through the thirteenth centuries A.D. have often been called the "Dark Ages" and to some extent it was truly so. The helplessness of the common man, the arbitrary rule of the king and the barons and the absence of national unity were some of the aspects of the darker side of those times. Education was very uncommon and people led a miserable life. The prevailing European view of the "Dark Ages" was that civilization had stagnated. Not only were scientific and artistic advances rare, but much of the knowledge of the classical period was lost. Cultural activities came to an end with the arrival of invading "barbarians", and the western Roman Empire disintegrated into thousands of isolated villages where there was little interest in, or time for, study. Memory of the classical period faded except in a few sequestered monasteries, where ancient texts were stored and in the Islamic world, where scholars translated Greek texts into Arabic. During the "Dark Ages" the overwhelming majority of Europeans were crude illiterates, and even educated

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people knew less about science, medicine, and art than their counterparts in the classical period.

Task:

1. Notes-Making Assignment

Please note that in the notes-making assignment you have to identify only those points which constitute the central theme of the given topic. To gain an edge over other candidates, you need to continuously enrich your notes with vital but relevant inputs. For this you may also include here some recent data, case studies or examples. For this you may refer newspapers (*The Hindu*, *The Times of India*, *The Indian Express*), magazines (*Yojana*, *Kurushetra*, *Frontline*, *The Economic and Political Weekly*, *Mainstream*) and government publications (*India Year Book*, *The Economic Survey*, *The Census of India*) etc.

Please take this exercise seriously because you would need to refer these self-made notes only just a couple of days before exam. So, be as brief and precise as possible. The first exercise is done for you to help you understand the approach as well as the methodology better.

Identify five important features of feudal society (only in the form of Pointers).

- Dominant system of social-economic and political organization in Medieval Europe
- Based upon a system of land tenure (King → Dukes and Earls→ Barons → Knights → Peasants)
- Characterized by estate system of stratification (Clergy, Nobility and Commoners)
- Largely subsistent economy characterized by the absence of a strong central authority
- Started declining fourteenth century onwards on account of revival of trade and commerce and emergence of urban centres (Commercial Revolution)

2. Writing-Skill Assignment

Now, once you have made your notes on the given topic in the pointers form, it is time to practice writing short notes so as to sharpen your answer-writing skills. Dear Candidate, I repeat that no matter for how many hours or years you may have studied but ultimately it is only those 3 hours in the examination hall that would decide your fate. Hence I always suggest my students to continuously monitor their

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progress in writing-skills by regularly writing answers and getting it evaluated by me.

The first exercise is done for you.

Write a short note on feudalism. (100-120 words)

Feudalism was the dominant system of social-economic and political organization in Medieval Europe. It was based upon a system of land tenure in which land estates of various sizes (fiefs) were given to hold (not to own) by an overlord to his vassals (knights) in return for military service. Estate system of social stratification was the characteristic feature of feudal European societies whereby one section or estate was distinguished from the other in terms of status, privileges and restrictions accorded to that estate. Feudal society was largely subsistent and stagnant economy characterized by the absence of a strong central authority. However, feudal social order started declining fourteenth century onwards on account of revival of trade and commerce and emergence of urban centres in western European societies. (Total Words: 126)

3. For Interview

Questions may be asked on the following to test your conceptual clarity and grasp of the subject.

Feudalism * Estate system of stratification * Manorialism * Factors responsible for the decline of feudalism * Karl Marx on feudalism

However, fourteenth century onwards the society in Europe started changing. A number of interrelated developments took place in the period from about fourteenth to seventeenth century which marked the beginning of modern age.

Anthony Giddens also states in *The Consequences of Modernity* (1990) that modernity refers to 'modes of social life or organization which emerged in Europe from about the seventeenth century onwards and which subsequently became more or less worldwide in their influence'. According to Giddens, modernity represents a sharp qualitative break from previous traditional social orders.

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Let us first understand that what were these changes which took place from about fourteenth to seventeenth century in Europe and marked the beginning of modern age? How the new social order which emerged in Europe from about the seventeenth century onwards was qualitatively different from the previous traditional social orders.

Historians generally agree that from fourteenth to sixteenth centuries, Europe had been witnessing changes in its social, economic and political structures, which marked the beginning of the modern period. In the next section, we will learn about the various social, economic and political changes that Europe witnessed in the form of Renaissance, Commercial Revolution, Scientific Revolution, Reformation, Enlightenment, Industrial Revolution, French Revolution, etc.

One of the first developments that marked the beginning of a new era was the *Renaissance*. The medieval Dark Age was followed by the Renaissance, coming in the fourteenth century and lasting to the end of the sixteenth century. The Renaissance refers, in a literal sense, to the intellectual rebirth of Europe as people tried to recapture the artistic, philosophical, scientific, and commercial glory of the 'classical period'. It is important to emphasize that the conventional nineteenth-century assessment was that the Renaissance had been a period of rediscovery. There was a great appreciation for the cultural accomplishments of the Greeks and Romans and a genuine desire to replicate those accomplishments and, hence, to recapture the cultural glory of earlier times. [Please note that the "Classical Period" of Western history, the era of Greece and, later, Rome, lasted roughly from the eighth century B.C. until the fourth century A.D. Many note-worthy scientific and artistic advances were made during that period. To name just a few: geometry was developed; money came into circulation; trade expanded; accounting practices emerged; shipbuilding improved; the Phoenician alphabet was made more precise with the inclusion of vowels; literature was born; comedies and tragedies were written; amphitheaters were constructed; great philosophical debates raged; engineers achieved wondrous feats (literally, the "wonders of the ancient world"); monuments were built; medicine advanced; libraries were constructed; elements of democratic governmental forms came into being; and education expanded. In short, civilization flowered. Advances were intermittent, to be sure, but over time the total stock of knowledge increased and diffused widely to other parts of the world. At least it was the nineteenth-century European view that the classical period of the Greeks and Romans marked such a flowering of civilization.]

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The term 'Renaissance' literally means rebirth and is, in a narrow sense, used to describe the revival of interest in the learning of the classical civilizations of Greece and Rome. This revival first began in Italy when a number of scholars from Constantinople migrated to Italy and a number of Italian scholars went to Constantinople and other cities of the old Byzantine empire in search of Greek classics. The Renaissance emerged in Italy roughly between A.D. 1300 and A.D. 1550 and then spread to northern Europe during the first half of the 16th century. The renaissance started in Italy because of several factors. First, Italy always had a cultural advantage over the rest of Europe because its geography made it the natural gateway between the East and the West. Venice, Genoa, Milan, Pisa and Florence traded uninterruptedly with the Asian countries and maintained a vibrant urban society. The Italian cities had grown up in an atmosphere of freedom from feudal control. Freedom encouraged thinking and a spirit of adventure. The rulers of the Italian states were patrons of learning and the arts.

During the 13th and the 14th centuries, mercantile cities expanded to become powerful city states dominating the political and economic life of the surrounding countryside. Italian aristocrats customarily lived in urban centres rather than in rural castles unlike their counterparts in northern Europe and consequently became fully involved in urban public affairs. The neo-rich mercantile communities which came to be known as the *bourgeoisie* tried to gain the status of aristocracy. Merchant families tried to imitate an aristocratic life-style. Their wealth and profession became an important factor for the development of education in Italy. There was not only a demand for education for the development of skills in reading and accountancy, necessary to become successful merchants, but also the richest and most prominent families looked for able teachers who would impart to their offspring the knowledge and skills necessary to argue well in the public arena. Consequently Italy produced a large number of educators, many of whom not only taught students but also demonstrated their learning in the production of political and ethical treaties and works of literature.

Another reason, why the late medieval Italy became the birthplace of an intellectual and artistic renaissance, was because it had a far greater sense of rapport with the classical past than any other region of Europe. In Italy the classical past appeared immensely relevant as ancient Roman monuments were present all over the peninsula and the ancient Latin literature referred to cities and sites that Italians recognized as their own. Further, Italian renaissance was also facilitated by the patronage that it received in abundance. The wealthy cities of Italy vied with each other to construct splendid public monuments and support writers whose role was to glorify the urban republic in their writing and speeches. As a result, hundreds of classical writings, unknown to Europeans for centuries, were circulating first in Italy and then other parts of Europe. The interest in classical

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learning and in other achievements of the civilizations of Greece and Rome deeply influenced Europeans. The Renaissance, however, was not, as mentioned earlier, a mere revival of ancient learning and knowledge of the achievements of ancient Greece and Rome. It was marked by a series of new developments in the field of art, literature, religion, philosophy, science and politics.

The early phase of Renaissance was described as a period of revival as it concentrated in reviving the old learning which was disseminated through the traditional methods. The latter phase was described as a period of innovation as much new knowledge was generated during this period, which laid the foundation for the growth of modern thought. This new knowledge was spread by a new medium, i.e print. This meant that a large number of people and countries could share the knowledge and debate the changes. Though, the study of classical and Christian antiquity existed before the renaissance, there was a significant difference between the learning of the middle age scholars and the renaissance thinkers. The renaissance thinkers recovered the works of lesser-known scholars and made them popular along side the more famous ones. The Greek scientific and the philosophical treatises were made available to the westerners in Latin translations. The renaissance thinkers used classical texts in new ways such as to reconsider their preconceived notions and alter their mode of expression.

So, rational thinking tempered with a spirit of scientific enquiry about the universe and the existence of humanity in it, became the important characteristic of the renaissance outlook. These rational ideas also helped in developing a society that was increasingly non-ecclesiastical in comparison to the culture of the Middle ages. The intellectual and cultural life of Europe for centuries had been dominated by the Catholic Church. The renaissance undermined this domination. The revival of pre-Christian classical learning and of interest in the cultural achievements of ancient Greece and Rome were, in themselves, also an important factor in undermining the domination of the Church.

The chief characteristic of the Renaissance way of thinking was *humanism*. It was the heart and soul of the Renaissance. Basically, it meant a decisive shift in concern for human as distinct from divine matters. Humanism was a system of views which extolled man, stressed his essential worth and dignity, expressed deep faith in his tremendous creative potential, and proclaimed freedom of the individual and inalienable rights of the individual. It was centered on the man of flesh and blood with all his earthly joys and sorrows, opposed to religious asceticism and defended his right to pleasure and the satisfaction of earthly desires and requirements. It meant the glorification of the human and natural as opposed to the divine and other-worldly. The humanists rejected and even ridiculed religious asceticism, mortification of the flesh and withdrawal from the world. They urged

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man to seek joy on this earth rather than in an afterlife which the Church advocated. Their works were permeated with the faith that a man with an active mind and body was capable of knowing and controlling the world, of performing miracles and fashioning his own happiness. The proper study of Mankind, it was asserted, is Man, Humanity rather than Divinity. The Renaissance men, hungered after more knowledge. They came to feel that human life is important, that man is worthy of study and respect, that there should be efforts to improve life on this earth. Because of this interest in human affairs, the study of literature and history became major areas of study. Literature and history came to be called the 'humanities' which were primarily concerned with understanding the affairs of man in his earthly life, not with life after death.

Task:

1. Notes-Making Assignment

Identify the main characteristics of Renaissance. (only Pointers)

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2. Writing-Skill Assignment

'Renaissance marked a qualitative shift in the history of western European society'. Discuss. (150 words)

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3. For Interview

Renaissance	*	Factors responsible for its origin in Italy

Another development which marked the beginning of the modern age was the 'commercial revolution', fostered by a series of 'voyages of discovery'. The "Commercial revolution" refers to the expansion of trade and commerce that took place from the 15th century onwards. It was of such a large scale and organized manner that it is called a Revolution. The Commercial revolution signaled a shift from the largely subsistence and stagnant economy of medieval Europe to a more dynamic and world wide system. This expansion was as a result of the initiative taken by certain European countries to develop and consolidate their economic and political power. These countries were Portugal, Spain, Holland and England.

The same spirit of curiosity that led some of Europe's Renaissance men to effect new developments in art, literature, science, and religion led others to adventure and the discovery of new lands. The main motivation behind these adventures was the profits that trade with the East would bring. Earlier, Europe trade with the Oriental or Eastern countries like India and China was transacted by land routes. The northern Italian cities of Venice and Genoa were the major centres of trade. The result of the Italian monopoly was that the prices of goods like spices and silks imported form the East was extremely high. For example, after his first voyage to India, Vasco Da Gama found that the price of pepper in Calicut was one-

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twenty sixth of the price prevailing in Venice. The prosperity of the Italian cities that had grown rich from their trade with eastern countries aroused the envy of the other European nations; they longed to have a share in the trade.

But after 1453, the Turks cut off this trade through Asia Minor and if the Europeans were to continue to have spices, these products had to be brought by a different route. Finding new routes was a challenge to the adventurous sailors of the Renaissance. Thus, a shift from land routes to sea-routes began. Helped by some remarkable inventions, daring sailors sailed for distant lands. Invention of mariner's compass, astrolabe and newly prepared maps and guidebooks greatly facilitated these voyages. With the help of the compass, navigators determined the directions on high seas. The Astrolabe helped in determining the latitude of a particular area. These voyages were financed by rulers and merchants who sponsored the costly voyages of the sea-farers for the profits that the voyages would bring. The discoveries of the sea-farers extended the knowledge about the world and the old maps which were both inaccurate and incomplete had to be redrawn.

The voyages and discoveries of Columbus, Vasco da Gama and Magellan changed man's idea of the world, revolutionized trade and started waves of colonization that have determined the course of world history ever since. Portugal and Spain were among the first Europe countries, which financed these explorations and discoveries. Britain, France and Holland soon followed Spain and Portugal. Soon parts of Asia, Africa, Malacca, the Spice Islands, West Indies, N. America and S. America came under the control of Spain, Portugal, Britain, France and Holland. Commerce expanded into a world enterprise. The monopoly of the Italian cities was destroyed. European markets were flooded with new commodities; spice & textiles from the East, tobacco from N. America, Cocoa, Chocolate & quinine from S. America, ivory and, above all, human slaves from Africa. With the discovery of Americas, the range of trade widened. Formerly, the items sought for were spices and cloth, but later, gold and silver were added to the list. As the commercial revolution progressed, the position of Portugal and Spain declined. Britain, France and Holland came to dominate Europe and the world. This marked the early phase of capitalism known as 'mercantile capitalism'. It was characterized by growth of trade and commerce and generating profits through trade.

Subsequently, this accumulated wealth or capital was further reinvested in land & agriculture (scientific farming and sheep-rearing) to generate further profits. This led to the transformation of agriculture in Europe, called as 'agricultural revolution'. The agrarian revolution saw the transformation of a system of subsistence into a system of surplus by production of cash crops for the

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market, the surplus being made possible by reformed and mechanized cultivation. So, mercantile capitalism was followed by the capitalistic transformation of agriculture or agrarian capitalism. The first sign of capitalistic transformation of agriculture manifested itself in England in the form of land enclosures which began to occur in the rural economy as early as 1560, when landholders began to assert rights of private property over feudal land. It has been called by the historians as Enclosure Movement. Essentially, the enclosure movement can be described as a system whereby tenant holdings in feudal land and agriculture became enclosed and made available for the private use of landholder. As, a result peasant families were evicted from their holdings and in many cases thrown off the land. While many of the first enclosures were initiated by landlords in order to appropriate tenant holdings, in latter stages of change they were used to make way for sheep pastures. However, by 1710 the first Enclosure Bill appeared which legalized the enclosure of tenant holdings by Parliamentary Acts. With parliamentary approval, enclosures could proceed at a more advanced rate and eventually became commonplace by mid century as conversions became more rapid. By 1800, 4000 Parliamentary Acts had been passed and in excess of six million acres of land had been enclosed.

As the pace of economic change began to intensify, the rate of enclosures accelerated to the point where the displaced population of agricultural workers began to increase dramatically and this began to mobilize a transfer of the population to the centers of industry. As statutory enactments gave the power of eviction to landlords, legal proceedings multiplied the rate of local evictions and at the same time restricted the use of pastures from domestic animals, prohibited the use of arable land from tenant agriculture, and displaced agricultural workers and hereditary tenants. In practice, enclosures became a society-wide depopulation movement fueled by mass evictions and foreclosures which coercively separated peasants from their means of livelihood by removing them from their own agricultural holdings. As serfs were forced off the land, landlords were able to assert rights of modern private property over land to which they previously held only feudal title. This hastened the transformation of land into a commercial commodity, first by subjecting it to buying and selling, and second by extending its capacity to produce money rent. Under these circumstances, customary rights and obligations in land began to be forcibly dissolved, and with this went the bonds connecting peasants to the land through heredity tenure and leasehold. As soon as money rents replaced labour rent, peasants were forced to focus their attention on their own holdings, making money rent a precondition to economic survival. Those who were unable to pay were eventually ruined or evicted. At this point it became possible to express the value of land in money, and this led to the transformation of land into private property and eventually a commercial commodity. As land became subject to buying and selling, the economic balance between serfs and

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landlords was upset and feudal obligations in land and livelihood began to deteriorate.

As the breakdown of feudal obligations in land continued, it began to place the serf population under new forces of social differentiation and fragmentation. This put the serf population at the disposal of the new forces of production, which put into play a massive demographic transfer of the agricultural population into the industrial centers, bringing about a more complete transition to a new category of labour based on wages. At this stage, the flow of population from the old feudal economies to the new economies of industry became a more urgent fact of economic change, and this began to complete the process of transforming the agricultural worker of previous centuries into the wage labourer of the industrial economy. By 1840 the transition to an industrial economy was more or less complete. Several consequences ensued as a result of the displacement of the serf population from the rural economies. Firstly, as the transfer of the population proceeded, it brought about a massive social displacement which dispersed families, uprooted local economies and undermined regional modes of life and livelihood. Secondly, it dissolved the serf's relationship to the land and altered the system of economic livelihood, forcing serfs to sell their labour for a wage, and severing the serf's feudal relation to the agricultural means of production. Thirdly, the shift to an industrial economy meant that wage labourers were unable to employ the means of production on their own as they once did in a feudal economy, and as a result they lost control over the ability to put the means of production to work. Further, as the shift to an industrial economy became finalized, the old class structure of feudal society was replaced by the formation of a new commercial class who were at the center of power and industry. This began to bring about the transfer of the ownership of the means of production to the commercial classes and, consequently, as the means of production fell into private hands, it became the property of one class.

During much of the eighteenth century, the last remnants of the old economic order were crumbling under the impact of the industrial revolution. In historical terminology, industrial revolution means primarily the period of British History from the middle of the eighteenth century to the middle of nineteenth century. England in the 18^{th} century was in the most favourable position for an industrial revolution. Through her overseas trade, including trade in slaves, she had accumulated vast profits which could provide the necessary capital. In the trade rivalries of European countries, she had emerged as an unrivalled power. She had acquired colonies which ensured a regular supply of raw materials. The term 'industrial revolution' was first used in the 1880s to denote the sudden acceleration of technical developments by the application of steam power to machines which replaced tools. The term got popularized when Arnold Toynbee's

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Industrial Revolution appeared in 1884. As discussed earlier, the new system of society which had been emerging in Europe from the 15th century was called *capitalism.* Under capitalism, the instruments and the means by which goods are produced are owned by private individuals and the production is carried out for making profit. The workers under this system do not own anything but work for a wage. The owners of wealth under capitalism who are called capitalists do not keep their wealth or consume it or use it for purposes of display but invest it to make profit. Goods are produced for sale in the market with a view to making profit. This system is in marked contrast with the feudal system in which goods were produced for local use and the investment of wealth for making profit did not take place. Economic life under feudalism was static as goods were produced for local consumption and there was no incentive to produce more by employing better means of producing goods for a bigger market. In contrast, the economy under capitalism was fast moving with the aim of producing more and more goods for bigger markets so that more profits could be made.

The desire to produce more goods at low cost to make higher profits led to the Industrial Revolution and further growth of capitalism. The Industrial Revolution began in England in about 1750. It was then that machines began to take over some of the works of men and animals in the production of goods and commodities. That is why we often say that the Industrial Revolution was the beginning of a 'machine age'. You have read before that the guild system had given way to the 'domestic' or the 'putting-out' system. In the 18th century, the domestic system had become obsolete. It started giving way to a new system called the 'factory system'. In place of simple tools and the use of animal and manual power, new machines and steam power came to be increasingly used. Many new cities sprang up and artisans and dispossessed peasants went there to work. Production was now carried on in a factory (in place of workshops in homes), with the help of machines (in place of simple tools). Facilities for production were owned and managed by *capitalists*, the people with money to invest in further production. Everything required for production was provided by the capitalists for the workers who were brought together under one roof. Everything belonged to the owner of the factory, including the finished product, and workers worked for wages. This system, known as the factory system, brought on the *Industrial Revolution.* This phase of capitalism is known as industrial capitalism. Industrial capitalism is capitalism's classical or stereotypical form.

The eighteenth century saw the growth of free labour and more competitive manufacturing. The cotton industry was the first to break the hold of the guilds and chartered corporations, but with each decade, other industries were subjected to the liberating effects of free labour, free trade, and free production. By the time large-scale industry emerged – first in England, then in France, and later in

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Germany – the economic reorganization of Europe had been achieved. Large-scale industry and manufacture simply accelerated the transformations in society that had been occurring for decades. These transformations involved a profound organization of society. Labour was liberated from the land; wealth and capital existed independently of the large noble estates; large-scale industry accelerated urbanization of the population; the extension of competitive industry hastened the development of new technologies; increased production encouraged the expansion of markets and world trade for securing raw resources and selling finished goods; religious organizations lost much of their authority in the face of secular economic activities; family structure was altered as people moved from rural to urban areas; law became as concerned with regularizing the new economic processes as with preserving the privilege of the nobility; and the old political regimes legitimated by "divine right" successively became less tenable.

Thus, the emergence of a capitalist economic system inexorably destroyed the last remnant of the feudal order and the transitional mercantile order of restrictive guilds and chartered corporations. Such economic changes greatly altered the way people lived, created new social classes (such as the bourgeoisie and urban proletariat), and led not only to a revolution of ideas but also to a series of political revolutions. These changes were less traumatic in England than in France, where the full brunt of these economic forces clashed with the Old Regime. It was in this volatile mixture of economic changes, coupled with the scientific revolution of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, that political and intellectual revolutions were to be spawned. And out of these combined revolutions, sociology emerged.

The 'Renaissance' period also saw the beginning of the 'Scientific Revolution'. It is an undeniable fact that, if we want to seek out the cause of the Scientific Revolution, we must look for them among the wider changes taking place in that sea-change of European history known as the Renaissance. The Scientific Revolution cannot be explained without reference to the Renaissance. The Scientific Revolution, like the Protestant Reformation, can and should be seen as one of the outcomes of the Renaissance. The Scientific Revolution marked an era of description and criticism in the field of science. It was a clear break from the past, a challenge to old authority. The impact of the scientific revolution was crucial not just in changing material life, but also man's ideas about Nature and Society. It is worth noting that science does not develop independent of society, rather, it develops in response to human needs. For example, various vaccines were developed out of the necessity to cure diseases. Apart from influencing the physical or material life of society, science is intimately connected with ideas. The general intellectual atmosphere existing in society influences the development of science. Similarly, new developments in science can also change the attitudes and

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beliefs of people about nature and society. New scientific ideas influenced scholars to think about society in new ways. The emergence of sociology in Europe owes a great deal to the ideas and discoveries contributed by science.

As stated earlier, the medieval society was characterized by the feudal system. The Church was the epicenter of authority and learning. Knowledge was largely religious in nature. Nothing could challenge the 'dogmas' or rigid beliefs of the Church. New, daring ideas could not flower in such an atmosphere. Thus the development of science was restricted mainly to improvement in the techniques of production. However, the renaissance thinkers rejected the blind acceptance of authority. They asserted that knowledge could be gained 'by going out and studying mentally and manually the Book of Nature', and not by speculation. This new outlook marked a break with the past and prepared the way for the advancement of science. It was summed up by **Francis Bacon**, an English philosopher, who said that knowledge could be gained only by observation and experimentation. According to Bacon, he who seeks knowledge should *first look at things that happen in the world around him*. He should then ask himself *what causes these things to happen* and, after he has formed a theory or belief, as to the possible cause, he should experiment. *The experiment is to test his belief* and see whether the assumed cause does, in fact, produce the result he has observed. Bacon believed that the 'true and lawful end of the sciences is that human life be enriched by new discoveries and powers.'

One of the first achievements of the Renaissance in science was in astronomy. The year 1543 marked the development of modern astronomical studies with the publication of Copernicus' *Six Books Concerning the Revolutions of the Heavenly Spheres*. **Copernicus** (1473-1543) was a polish scholar who lived in Italy for many years. His work in mathematics and astronomy demolished the hypothesis of the geocentric (Earth-centred) universe derived from Ptolemy and other astronomers of the past. In its place he advanced the revolutionary new hypothesis of the heliocentric (Sun-centred) universe. This meant that the earth moved round a fixed Sun and not the other way round. The Copernican hypothesis had radical implications. It destroyed the idea of the earth's uniqueness by suggesting that it acted like other heavenly bodies. More importantly, his theory contradicted the earlier notions about the centrality of the earth to the cosmic order. The very idea of an open universe of which the earth was but a small part shattered the earlier view of a closed universe created and maintained in motion by God. This was an important break with the ancient system of thought. For over a thousands years, it was believed that the earth was the centre of the universe. It was one of the basic dogmas of the philosophers of the time. Its refutation was an attack on the conception of the universe held by the Church. This was, therefore, condemned as a heresy. Copernicus' book was published in 1543, the year in

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which he died. He had hesitated from publishing it for fear of the hostility of the Church. About half a century after the publication of Copernicus' book, in 1600, Giordano Bruno was burnt at the stake on the charge of heresy. He had advocated ideas which were based on Copernicus' view of the universe.

The next major steps toward the conception of a heliocentric system were taken by the Danish astronomer **Tycho Brahe** (1546-1601) and the German astronomer **Johannes Kepler** (1571-1630). Tycho Brahe constructed the most accurate tables of astronomical observations. After his death, these observations came into the possession of Kepler, who after much work, agreed to the heliocentric theory, though he abandoned the Copernican concept of circular orbits. The mathematical relationship that emerged from a consideration of Brahe's observations suggested that the orbits of the planets were elliptical. Kepler published his findings in 1609 in a book entitled *On the Motion of Mars*. Thus, he solved the problems of planetary orbits by using the Copernican theory and Brahe's empirical data. However, in the same year when Kepler published his book, an Italian scientist **Galileo Galilei** (1564-1642), first turned a telescope invented by him on to the sky. Through this instrument he saw stars where none had been known to exist, mountains on the moon, spots moving across the sun and the moon and the orbiting Jupiter. Some of Galileo's colleagues at the University of Padua were so unnerved that they refused to look through the telescope because it revealed the heaven to be different from the teachings of the Church and the Ptolemaic theories. Galileo published his findings in numerous works, the most famous of which is his *Dialogues on the Two Chief Systems of the World* (1632). This book brought down on him the condemnation of the Roman Catholic Church. His life was spared only after he agreed to withdraw his views. He spent the rest of his life virtually under house arrest.

Isaac Newton was born in England in 1642, the year Galileo died. He solved the major remaining problems on the planetary motions and established a base for the modern physics. Much of the researches of Newton were based on the work of Galileo and other predecessors. In 1687, he published his treatise, *The Mathematical Principles of Natural Philosophy*. In this work he proposed that the planets and, in fact, all other particles in the universe moved through the force of mutual attraction, a law which came to be known as the Law of Gravitation. In this way, Newton combined mathematics and physics for the study of astronomy. Incidentally, he was preceded in this by **Varahamihira** and **Aryabhatta** in the 5^{th} and 6^{th} centuries A.D. in India.

The modern age of science that began with these Renaissance scientists not only increased man's knowledge but also established a method of study that could be applied to other branches of knowledge. Significant discoveries, for example

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were made in the study of the human body and circulation of the blood which helped to fight many superstitions. In 1543, the year in which Copernicus' book was published, **Vesalius**, a Belgian, published his profusely illustrated *De Humani Corporis Fabrica*. Based on his study of the dissections of the human body, this book provided the first complete description of the anatomy of the human body. **Servetus**, a Spaniard, published a book explaining the circulation of blood. He was condemned to death for questioning the Church belief in Trinity. A completed account of the constant process of circulation of blood, from the heart to all parts of the body and back to the heart was given by Harvey, an Englishman, in about 1610. This knowledge helped to start a new approach to the study of the problems of health and disease. It is important to remember that what the Renaissance scientists began learning by questioning, observation, and experimentation is the method that scientists continue to use even today. This is scientific method. It is by applying this method that our knowledge has grown so greatly. The knowledge produced during scientific revolution deeply influenced the attitudes and beliefs of people about nature and society. New scientific ideas influenced scholars to think about society in new ways. This is very important. Please keep this in mind when we discuss the ideas of enlightenment scholars later.

As mentioned earlier, that in medieval Europe Church was the epicenter of authority and learning. Knowledge was largely religious in nature. Nothing could challenge the 'dogmas' or rigid beliefs of the Church. Any idea or action which challenged the authority of the Church was, therefore, condemned as a heresy. This newly emerging scientific knowledge, which was based on empirical observation and experimentation, was not only different but also contradictory to the many teachings of the Church. This stimulated the process of 'reformation' in the religious sphere of the European society. Thus, European people with new spirit of inquiry and thought started questioning the superstitious beliefs and malpractices of the Catholic Church.

The term 'Reformation' refers to two major developments in the history of Europe towards the later part of the Renaissance. The first was the Protestant reformation which resulted in a split in Christianity and the secession of a large number of countries from the Roman Catholic Church and establishment of separate Churches in those countries, generally on national lines. The second development concerned reforms within the Roman Catholic Church, generally referred to as Catholic Reformation or Counter Reformation. But Reformation was not merely a religious movement. It was intimately connected with, and was in fact a part of, the social and political movement of the period which brought about the end of the medieval period and the emergence of the modern world.

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The Catholic Church, during the early medieval period, had become a vast hierarchical organization headed by the Pope in Rome. The Pope was the supreme authority over the entire hierarchy and he exercised this authority directly. The position of the Pope is often described by the phrase 'papal monarchy'. Systematic efforts were made to extend the authority of the Church over everyone, high or low, making an oral confession of his sins to a priest at least once a year and suffering the punishment imposed was made obligatory for everyone. The people who did not follow this were excommunicated. An excommunicated person was supposed to have been temporarily consigned to hell. If he died, his body could not be buried with the prescribed rituals. Other Christians were forbidden from associating with him. An important component of the religious thinking propagated by the Church was the theory of sacraments. A sacrament was defined as an instrument by which divine grace is communicated to men. The sacraments were regarded indispensable for securing God's grace and there was no salvation without them. Another was the theory of priesthood. It was held that the priest who was ordained by a bishop (who was confirmed by the Pope) was the inheritor of a part of the authority conferred by Christ on Peter. The priest, according to this theory had the power to co-operate with God in performing certain miracles and in releasing sinner from the consequences of their sins. Besides the sacraments, various other beliefs came to be accepted.

Reformation is often described as a revolt against abuses which had grown in the Catholic Church. Some of the priests and higher-ups in the Church hierarchy received their appointments through corrupt means. Many such appointees were utterly ignorant. They led lives of luxury and immorality. Religious offices were sold to the highest bidder and those who bought positions after spending money made good by taking high fees for the services they performed. The Popes and the higher clergy lived like princes. A new abuse was the sale of letters which remitted punishments of the sinners who bought them, both in this life and after their death in purgatory. Normally, the priests imposed a penance or punishment on a person who had sinned and he was required to perform a special service or make a pilgrimage to a holy place. But increasingly sinners with enough money could be freed from doing penance for their sins by paying the clergy for a "Letter of Indulgence". The sale of indulgences which began to be considered as passports to heaven became one of the major immediate issues which caused the protestant Reformation. Besides the sale of indulgences, one could now gain salvation in exchange for fees. The priests, the bishops and the wandering monks could pronounce a marriage lawful or unlawful. By payment of fees, the problem could be solved. There were fees for every transaction in life, from birth to death, fees for the peace of the soul and fees for the souls of the people dead long ago. The wandering monks when they wanted to, heard confessions, awarded punishments for sins and remitted the punishments for fees.

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The Protestant Revolution can be said to have begun in 1517 when **Martin Luther**, a monk of the Order of St. Augustine, nailed his ninety-five theses or statements which attacked the sale of indulgences, on the door of the Church in Wittenberg in Germany. He challenged people to come and hold debates with him on his theses and sent copies of his theses to his friends in a number of cities. During the next two years Luther wrote a series of pamphlets. He knew that his doctrines could not be reconciled with those of the Catholic Church and that he had no alternative but to break with the Catholic Church. In 1520, the Pope ordered him to recant within sixty days or be condemned as a heretic. Luther burnt the proclamation of the Pope in public. During this period, he was protected by the ruler of Saxony who was his friend. Many rulers in Germany were hostile to the Church and when Luther was excommunicated, he remained unharmed. During the next 25 years, he occupied himself with the task of building an independent German Church, and in expounding his doctrine. He rejected the entire system of the hierarchy of the Catholic Church, introduced German as the language of Church services, abolished the special status of priests as representatives of God on earth, eliminated most of the sacraments, and emphasized faith rather than pilgrimages. He gave the highest priority to the supreme authority of the scriptures. Another important change was the abandonment of the view of the Catholic Church that the Church was supreme over the state. The German rulers and common people of Germany supported Luther. There were political reasons for the support of the rulers. They wanted to be free from the authority of Popes and get possession of the wealth in German monasteries for themselves. The common people liked Luther's teaching because it gave them an opportunity to demand more freedom from their rulers.

Ulrich Zwingli and **John Calvin** became the leaders of the Protestant movement in Switzerland. Under the leadership of Calvin, the Swiss cities became a refuge for Protestants fleeing to other countries in western Europe due to religious persecution. Calvin established an academy for the training of Protestant missionaries, who in return would spread the true word of God in other lands. As part of the work of propagating his version of Protestantism, Calvin composed a treatise entitled, *The Institutes of the Christian Religion*, wherein he gave a more concise and logical definition of the Protestant doctrines than what had been given by any other leader of this movement.

In England the Protestant movement was led by political leaders, particularly King Henry VIII and Queen Elizabeth I. Their reforms were not driven by the ides of religious or social reforms but by the interests of the state and more practically, the personal ambition of Henry VIII. Henry VIII sought to divorce his wife Catherine of Aragon and wanted to marry his beloved Anne Boleyn. The Pope refused to grant the divorce on the ground that Henry, before marrying Catherine,

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had asked for and had received a special Papal dispensation declaring his marriage with Catherine as valid and indissoluble. Rebuffed by the Pope, Henry promptly declared himself the "sole protector and supreme head of the Church and the Clergy of England". After that he married Anne Boleyn. From this marriage was born Elizabeth I, who later became the Queen of England. England's final break with the Pope came in 1529, when in a special session of the British Parliament a series of laws were passed to make the English Church completely free from the jurisdiction of the Pope. The King of England was also declared as the head of the English Church, which hereafter came to be known as the Anglican Church.

The Roman Catholic Church had been shaken to its very root by the movements started by Luther, Zwingli and Calvin. To counter the damage caused by the Protestant Movements, a series of reforms began within the Catholic Church, which came to be known as the 'Counter-Reformation'. During Counter-Reformation efforts were made to restore the Catholic Church's universal authority. One of these efforts took place in the Council of Trent (1545) summoned by Pope Paul III. The Council was to consider the ways and means to combat Protestantism. So it decided to settle the doctrinal disputes between the Catholics and the Protestants; clean up moral and administrative abuses within the Catholic Church and organise a new crusade against the Muslims. The next step was the organization of an order of missionaries, known as the Jesuits, with the dedicated purpose of spreading the message of Christ. The above measures adopted by the Catholic Church were not sufficient to bring the whole of Europe under the authority of the Pope. The campaign, however, did achieve a considerable measure of success in checking the further spread of Protestantism. Though much of Europe remained Protestant, new lands overseas were being won to the Catholic Church.

Reacting to economic and political changes, the concomitant reorganization of social life, much of the eighteenth century was consumed by intellectual ferment. The intellectual revolution of the eighteenth century is commonly referred to as the ***Enlightenment***. In England and Scotland, the Enlightenment was dominated by a group of thinkers who argued for a vision of human beings and society that both reflected and justified the industrial capitalism that first emerged in the British Isles. For scholars such as Adam Smith, individuals are to be free of external constraint and allowed to compete, thereby creating a better society. In France, the Enlightenment is often termed the *Age of Reason*, and it was dominated by a group of scholars known as the *philosophes*. It is out of the intellectual ferment generated by the French philosophes that sociology was born.

This section is very important, not only for your written examination but also for the interview. Please read it carefully.

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The term 'Enlightenment' is used in an academic and technical sense to indicate the intellectual movement in 18th century western and central Europe especially in England and France. Its historical significance lay in breaking the shackles of ideas imposed by tradition or authority whether of state or Church. For a long period in history up to that time, the standard method of arriving at the truth lay in an appeal to authority. It meant in practice, that truth was determined by one's superiors and one was not expected to doubt or question their wisdom. To buttress their claim, both state and Church would base their authority on supernatural sanction rather than on popular sovereignty. This had been the basis of absolutism and absolute monarchs ruled in nearly all parts of Europe. Conflicts between Church and state were not infrequent but these rarely concerned the common man in an age when communications were poor and his struggle for existence much harder.

Things in the meantime had changed fast during the 16th and 17th Centuries. Significant advances had been made in discoveries of new lands and routes; technologies as applied to agriculture and industries had increased production, and that possibly accounts for the rapid increase of population that took place both in England and France. Urban areas expanded and a middle class emerged to avail itself of the new opportunities in sectors like banking, industry, trade, journalism and above all education that served as a catalyst in the movement of ideas.

The essence of Enlightenment lay in its challenge to absolutism, the questioning of authority through a new conception of truth. In the course of Enlightenment, reason supplanted authority as the accepted method of arriving at the truth. All who look part in this movement of ideas were convinced that human understanding is capable by its own power and without recourse to supernatural assistance, of comprehending the system of the world. A new optimism was breathed about man's capacity to usher in a happier social order. The basic difference between the Absolutist view and Enlightened view centered round the individual. Under absolutism, the individual had to submit to the authority which was supposed to possess the monopoly of the truth; but under Enlightenment the individual acquired a new importance, dignity and self respect. Any man's opinion was potentially worth something. One no longer had to be a bishop or prince to claim access to truth. Enlightenment stood for the classic trilogy - Liberty, Equality, Fraternity; and as such represented the fight against oppression imposed by the old social hierarchy that had developed a vested interest in keeping people ignorant and superstitious. A challenge was thrown to religious education since it was believed that such education sapped a young person's courage and killed initiative by training him to fear and obey.

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Thus, the enlightenment was a period of remarkable intellectual development and change in the philosophical thought. A number of long-standing ideas and beliefs – many of which related to social life – were overthrown and replaced during the Enlightenment. The most prominent thinkers associated with the Enlightenment were the French philosophers **Charles Montesquieu** (1689-1755) and **Jean Jacques Rousseau** (1712-1778).

Montesquieu in his book, *The Spirit of the Law*, held that there should not be concentration of authority, such as executive, legislative, and judicial, at one place. He believed in the theory of separation of powers and the liberty of the individual.

Rousseau in his book *The Social Contract* argued that the people of a country have the right to choose their sovereign. He believed that people can develop their personalities best only under a government which is of their own choice. For Rousseau, the social contract is the sole foundation of the political community. By virtue of this social contract, individuals lose their natural liberties (limited merely by their ability to exercise force over one another). However, man's natural liberty promoted unlimited acquisitiveness and avarice and thus encouraged individuals to destroy the freedom of others weaker than they. By submitting to a law vested in a social contract – a mandate that can be withdrawn at any time – individuals find in the laws to which they consent a pure expression of their being as civilized human entities.

Although the Enlightenment was fueled by the political, social, and economic changes of the eighteenth century, it derived considerable inspiration from the scientific revolution of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries. As noted earlier, the scientific revolution reached a symbolic peak, at least in the eye of eighteenth-century thinkers, with Newtonian physics. In the light of various revolutionary developments in science, particularly Physics, the universe (physical world) came to be viewed as orderly or patterned. It was argued that with scientific inquiry (based on empirical observation and application of reason) the underlying natural laws governing the universe can be discovered. Further, the knowledge of these laws would facilitate better prediction and greater control over the physical world. Thus, Physics was to become the vision of how scientific inquiry and theory should be conducted. And the individual and society were increasingly drawn into the orbit of the new view of science. This gradual inclusion of the individual and society into the realm of science represented a startling break with the past, because heretofore these phenomena had been considered the domain of morals, ethics, and religion.

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So, the enlightenment thinkers argued that just as the physical world was governed by the natural laws, it was likely that social world was, too. Thus it was up to the philosopher, using reason and research, to discover these social laws. And once such social laws are discovered, then with the knowledge of those laws we can control and create a better society (social engineering).

It is important to note that almost all enlightenment thinkers also shared 'a vision of human progress.' Humanity was seen to be marching in a direction and was considered to be governed by a "law of progress" that was as fundamental as the law of gravitation in the physical world. For example, with economic modernization and advancement of technology agricultural and industrial revolution took place leading phenomenal increase in the agricultural and industrial outputs. With commercial revolution (trade and commerce), unprecedented wealth or capital was generated. Further, scientific revolution demolished the traditionally held superstitious beliefs (sanctified by Church) and ushered in the age of reason. With its emphasis on empirical observation and application of reason, it significantly changed the social outlook of man and brought about social modernization.

At psychological level, modernity was reflected in terms of reflexivity. Reflexivity refers to the reflexive monitoring of action: that is, the way in which humans think about and reflect upon what they are doing in order to consider acting differently in future. Humans have always been reflexive up to a point, but in pre-industrial societies the importance of tradition limited reflexivity. Humans would do some things simply because they were the traditional things to do. However, with modernity, tradition loses much of its importance and reflexivity becomes the norm (psychological modernization). Social reflexivity implies that social practices are constantly examined and reformed in the light of incoming information about those very practices, thus continuously altering their character.

Further, with the rise various social and political movements, demands for greater individual freedom and democratization were being made. For the first time in human history, the idea of fundamental rights of the individuals was being entertained in the public discourse. Traditional authoritarian and autocratic systems of governance were being challenged. The enlightenment scholars argued that all humans had certain inalienable "natural rights" which must be respected such as right to freedom of speech and expression, right of participation in the decision-making process, etc. This marked a significant step towards political modernization.

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Thus, the enlightenment scholars saw these developments as the sign of progress and the enlightenment period was marked by a new optimism or hope about the man's capacity to usher in a happier social order.

Task:

1. Notes-Making Assignment

Identify the main features of Enlightenment period.

- ……
- ……
- ……
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2. Writing-Skill Assignment

Write a short note on 'Enlightenment'. (100-120 words)

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3. For Interview

Enlightenment Philosophy * Major Enlightenment Philosophers

Now let us briefly discuss the developments taking place in France, the birthplace of Sociology. In the years preceding the revolution, France retained the political and economic characteristics of a feudal society: rigid social hierarchy, social and economic inequality, monarchy, etc. The French society was divided into feudal **'estates'**. The structure of the feudal French society comprised the 'Three Estates'. Estates are defined as a system of stratification found in feudal European societies whereby one section or estate is distinguished from the other in terms of status, privileges and restrictions accorded to that estate. **The First Estate** (the Church) consisted of the clergy, which was stratified into higher clergy, such as the cardinal, the archbishops, the bishops and the abbots. They lived a life of luxury and gave very little attention to religion. In fact, some of them preferred the life of politics to religion. They spent much of their time in wasteful activities like drinking, gambling, etc. The Church owned one-fifth of the cultivated lands in France and enjoyed great influence with the Government. Like the nobles, the higher clergy was also exempt from paying most of the taxes. With the nobles they supported absolute monarchy. The Church collected tithe, a tax from the people for providing community services. It also maintained institutions of learning. In comparison to the higher clergy, the lower parish priests were over worked and poverty-stricken.

The Second Estate consisted of the nobility. There were two kinds of nobles, the nobles of the sword and the nobles of the robe. The nobles of the sword were big landlords. They were the protectors of the people in principle but in reality they led a life of a parasite, living off the hard work of the peasants. They led the life of pomp and show and were nothing more than 'high born wastrels'; that is, they spent extravagantly and did not work themselves. They can be compared to the erstwhile zamindars in India. The nobles of the robe were nobles not by birth but by title. They were the magistrates and judges. Among these nobles, some were very progressive and liberal as they had moved in their positions from common citizens who belonged to the third estate. However, these noble families continued to enjoy all the privileges such as non-payment of most of the taxes, avenues to higher positions in the French administration, and income from various feudal dues of the peasants.

The Third Estate comprised the rest of the society and included the peasants, the merchants, the artisans, and others. There was a vast difference between the condition of the peasants and that of the clergy and the nobility. The

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peasants worked day and night but were overloaded with so many taxes that they lived a hand to mouth existence. They produced the food on which the whole society depended. Yet they could barely survive due to failure of any kind of protection from the government. The King, in order to maintain the good will of the other two estates, the clergy and the nobility, continued to exploit the poor. The poor peasants had no power against him. While the clergy and the nobility kept on pampering and flattering the King.

As compared to the peasants, the condition of the middle classes, also known as the **bourgeoisie** comprising the merchants, bankers, lawyers, manufacturers, etc. was much better. These classes too belonged to the third estate. But the poverty of the state, which led to a price rise during 1720-1789, instead of adversely affecting them, helped them. They derived profit from this rise and the fact that French trade had improved enormously also helped the commercial classes to a great extent. Thus, this class was rich and secure. But it had no social prestige as compared with the high prestige of the members of the first and the second estates. In spite of controlling trade, industries, banking etc. the bourgeoisie had no power to influence the court or administration. They were looked down upon by the other two estates and the King paid very little attention to them. Thus, gaining political power became a necessity for them.

The clergy and the nobility both constituted only two per cent of the population but they owned about 35 per cent of the land. The peasants who formed 80 per cent of the population owned only 30 per cent of the land. The first two estates paid almost no taxes to the government. The peasantry, on the other hand, was burdened with taxes of various kinds. It paid taxes to the Church, the feudal lord, taxed in the form of income tax, poll tax, and land tax to the state. Thus, you can see how much burdened and poverty stricken the peasants had become at this time. They were virtually carrying the burden of the first two estates on their shoulders. On top of it all the prices had generally risen by about 65 per cent during the period 1720-1789. The French system of taxation was both unjust and unfair.

Like in all absolute monarchies, the theory of the Divine Right of King was followed in France too. For about 200 years the Kings of the Bourbon dynasty ruled France. Under the rule of the King, the ordinary people had no personal rights. They only served the King and his nobles in various capacities. The King's word was law and no trials were required to arrest a person on the King's orders. Laws too were different in different regions giving rise to confusion and arbitrariness. There was no distinction between the income of the state and the income of the King. The kings of France, from Louis XIV onwards, fought costly wars, which ruined the country, and when Louis XIV died in 1715, France had

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become bankrupt. Louis XV instead of recovering from this ruin kept on borrowing money from bankers. His famous sentence, "After me the deluge" describes the kind of financial crisis that France was facing. Louis XVI, a very weak and ineffective king, inherited the ruin of a bankrupt government. His wife, Queen Marie Antoinette, known for her expensive habits, is famous for her reply, which she gave to the poor, hungry people of France who came to her asking for bread. She told the people that, 'if you don't have bread, eat cake'.

Now let us examine the intellectual developments in France, which proved to be the igniting force in bringing about the French revolution. France, like some other European countries during the eighteenth century, had entered the age of reason and rationalism. Some of the major philosophers, whose ideas influenced the French people, were rationalists who believed that all true things could be proved by reason. Some of these thinkers were Locke (1632-1704), Montesquieu (1689-1755), Voltaire (1694-1778), and Rousseau (1712-1778).

Locke, an Englishman, advocated that every individual has certain rights, which cannot be taken by any authority. These rights were (i) right to live, (ii) right to property, and (iii) the right to personal freedom. He also believed that any ruler who took away these rights from his people should be removed from the seat of power and replaced by another ruler who is able to protect these rights.

Montesquieu in his book, *The Spirit of the Law*, held that there should not be concentration of authority, such as executive, legislative, and juridical, at one place. He believed in the theory of the separation of powers and the liberty of the individual.

Voltaire became internationally famous as a great writer and critic whose style and pungent criticism were inimitable. It was through his plays and writings that he launched his bitter attacks against the existing institutions like the church and the state. He made fun of the eccentricities of the nobles. He advocated religious toleration and freedom of speech. He also stood for the rights of individuals, for freedom of speech and expression.

Probably the greatest French philosopher of the age was **Jean Jacques Rousseau**. In his book *The Social Contract*, he argued that the people of a country have the right to choose their sovereign. He believed that people can develop their personalities best only under a government which is of their own choice. He further explained that the king and his subjects are parties to a contract, and therefore if the king does not rule the people according to their general will, he loses their loyalty. Rousseau was advocating popular sovereignty

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theory. His writings cast such a spell on his admirers that they were ready to revolt against the oppressive monarchy.

The major ideas of these and several other intellectuals struck the imagination of the French people. Also some of them who had served in the French army, which was sent to assist the Americans in their War of Independence from British imperialism, came back with the ideas of equality of individuals and their right to choose their own government. The French middle class was deeply affected by these ideas of liberty and equality. So far you have leant about the basic picture of the French society just before the Revolution. Now let us discuss some of the major events that took place during the Revolution.

It is worth noting that when the American colonists revolted against the oppressive rule of the mother country and won a resounding victory at Saratoga, the French government decided to help them with men, money and materials. It caused a serious strain on the finances of the country and cast a heavy burden on the poor peasants. Turgot was appointed as the Minister of Finance to suggest remedies. He advised the king to tax the privileged class. He was summarily dismissed at the instance of the queen. Unfortunately, France witnessed near-famine conditions in 1788 with the result that there was a serious food shortage. It was at this critical juncture that the king was advised by his courtiers to summon the Estates-General (French Parliament) to get approval for further dose of taxation.

When the Estates-General was summoned, the king ignored the importance of the Third Estate (600 representatives elected by the common people) and tried to consult the representatives of the three estates separately. The representatives of the third estate advised the king to bring together the representatives of all the three estates at one place for discussion of state problems. The king discarded their advice. Subsequently, it led to a quarrel between the king and the representatives of the third estate. This led to the formation of the National Assembly. The meeting of the National Assembly led by middle class leaders and some liberal minded nobles was met with stiff resistance. On 20th June 1789 when a meeting was to be held in the Hall at Versailles near Paris, the members found that it was closed and guarded by the King's men. Therefore, the National Assembly members led by their leader Bailey went to the next building which was an indoor tennis court. It was here that they took an Oath to draw a new constitution for France. This Oath, which marks the beginning of the French Revolution, is popularly known as the Oath of the Tennis Court.

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Next, on July 14th, 1789 took place one of the most important events of the French Revolution. It was the storming of the Bastille, an ancient royal prison that stood as a symbol of oppression. On this date the mobs of Paris, led by some middle class leaders, broke open this prison and set its inmates free. The causes for this event were the shortage of food, on the one hand, and the dismissal of a very popular minister called Necker, on the other. The mobs of Paris rebelled against the ruling class, especially the King. This day is celebrated in France as its Independence Day.

Shortly after these events, the National Assembly drafted the 'Declaration of the Rights of Man,' which was a central political document defining human rights and setting out demands for reform. The political rights and freedoms proclaimed by the 'Declaration' were so wide-ranging in their human emancipation that it set the standard for social and political thinking, and formed the central rallying point of the revolution. The 'Declaration' stated at the outset that all human beings were born free and equal in their political rights, regardless of their class position, and this proceeded to set up a system of constitutional principles based on liberty, security and resistance to oppression. With philosophical authority, the 'Declaration' proclaimed that all individuals had the prerogative to exercise their 'natural right' and that the law rather than the monarch was the expression of the common interest. This led to the elimination of all social distinctions on the one hand, and the right to resist oppression on the other. Thus, the ideas of Liberty, Equality and Fraternity were enshrined in this declaration. Liberty and equality put an end to the age of serfdom, despotism and hereditary privileges found in the old feudal society.

By August the National Assembly began to deal directly with political and legal reforms, first by eliminating feudal dues and then by abolishing selfdom. Second, by compelling the church to give up the right to tithes, the National Assembly altered the authority and class position of the clergy. Third, in declaring that 'all citizens, without distinction, can be admitted to ecclesiastical, civil and military posts and dignities,' it proclaimed an end to all feudal social distinctions.

As the criticism of social and political inequalities spread throughout society, there was a widespread critique of economic inequality altogether and this led to putting into question all other forms of subordination. With this came the idea that human beings, without distinctions, were the bearers of natural rights – a concept which had a corrosive effect on all other forms of inequality. Finally, from the assertions inherent in the 'Declarations of Rights,' a new category of social person came into being which came fundamentally to rest in the concept of the 'citizen,' whose social and political rights were brought within the framework of the state.

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As the political changes began to take effect, there were abrupt social changes in the form of altered politics and in the form of the political reorganization of the feudal way of life. This brought with it two central historical shifts. First, it transformed the existing class structure of feudal society and led to the decline of class privilege and a change in the relations of subordination which had existed up until that time. Second, it set loose political and legal reforms which brought about a change from a political aristocracy based on sovereign authority to a democratic republic based on the rights of the citizen. Thus French Revolution of 1789 marked the phase of political modernization.

Now let us once again return to our discussion of enlightenment. As we had discussed earlier, the enlightenment scholars saw these socio-economic and political developments as the sign of progress. The enlightenment period was marked by a new optimism or hope about the man's capacity to usher in a happier social order. So, enlightenment thinkers represented intellectual modernity. But there were also some scholars who viewed these changes otherwise. These scholars were not only skeptic about these changes taking place in European society but even condemned these changes. We call these scholars as Counter–Enlightenment scholars and their views as a Conservative Reaction to enlightenment (anti–modernity). The most extreme form of opposition to Enlightenment ideas was French Catholic counterrevolutionary philosophy, as represented by the ideas of **Louis de Bonald** (1754-1840) and **Joseph de Maistre** (1753-1821). These men were reacting against not only the Enlightenment but also the French Revolution, which they saw partly as a product of the kind of thinking characteristic of the Enlightenment. De Bonald, for example, was disturbed by the revolutionary changes and yearned for a return to the peace and harmony of the Middle Ages.

In general, these scholars deplored the disruption of socio-economic and political fabric of the traditional medieval society caused by Industrial Revolution and French Revolution. As mentioned earlier that there was massive dislocation of rural population due to enclosure movement. The newly emerging social life in towns and cities was bereft of close-knit community and kinship bonds, we-feeling, stability and harmonic social order. Since these cities had emerged spontaneously, without any proper planning, they lacked even the basic amenities such as proper sewage and sanitation. As a result, due such unhygienic living conditions, epidemics were a common phenomenon. Further, these newly emerging industrial cities were marked by gross socio-economic disparities. Workers, including women and children, were forced to work for long hours in the factories marked by inhuman working conditions. In this new mode of production, worker had lost control over both, the process of production as well as his product. He was simply reduced to a wage-labourer. In Marxist terms, the worker became alienated from the product of his labour.

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Further, demand for political rights fuelled by the writings of enlightenment scholars, often led to civil wars leading to political anomie. Furthermore, religion too, which until now regulated the social order started declining. Religion, as the source of solace and meaning of life, started losing its appeal with the advances in science. So, Conservatives saw these changes, i.e. decline of family & community life, decline of religion, economic exploitation of workers in factories, rising socio-economic disparities and political turmoil as a sign of social decay and not as progress. Hence, they were preoccupied with their concerns for peace and harmony, and stability in the society.

So, while enlightenment scholars glorified change, conservatives deplored such changes and emphasized on stability, peace and harmony. However, the idea that there must be peace and harmony in social life came to be generally accepted by scholars of both the traditions.

Thus, the social conditions prevalent in Europe in 18th and 19th centuries, generated by social changes such as Renaissance, Commercial Revolution, Scientific Revolution, Reformation, Counter-Reformation, Industrial Revolution and French Revolution created the need for a distinct discipline to understand and analyze these changes. As we know that the existing knowledge that was prevalent during those times was largely religious in nature. Traditionally, the only source of knowledge was religion, propagated by the Church. But, the then existing body of religious knowledge had no answer to these challenges. Further, with the growth of science, religion itself was under attack and religious ideas were loosing their plausibility. So, there was a need for a new body of knowledge. A new body of knowledge was needed to understand what was happening and also help people to find solutions to the newly emerging problems.

That is how, the social changes created by modernity in Europe in the late 18th and early 19th century created the need for new knowledge.

Thus, while social conditions created the need for sociology, intellectual conditions provided the means for building sociology as a distinct discipline. It is the combination of both enlightenment and conservative school of thought which led to the emergence of sociology.

How?

As the early social theorists were largely preoccupied with understanding the puzzle of social change unfolding in Europe and to create a harmonic social order, hence, we can say that the goals of sociology were dictated by the conservative reaction. As we had already discussed that how the Conservative scholars were

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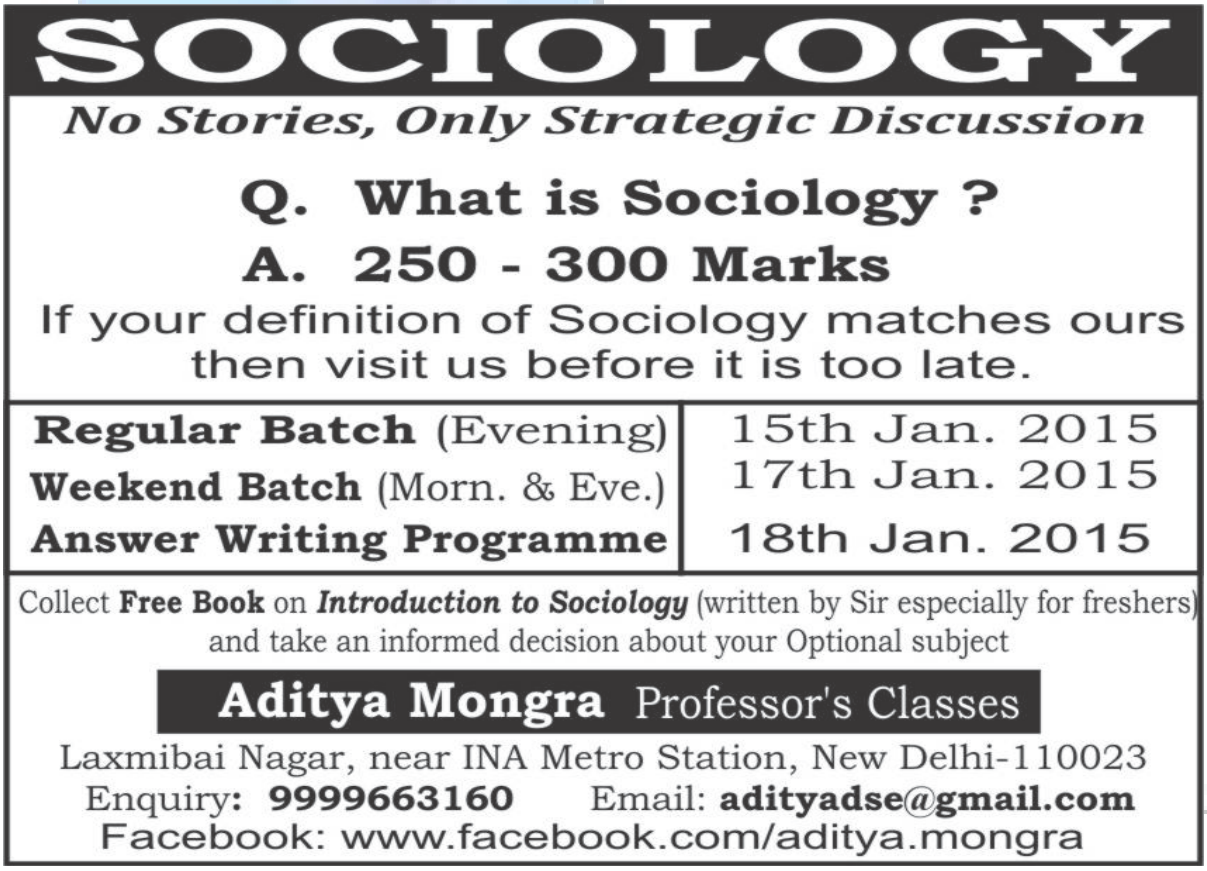
preoccupied with concerns for peace and harmony, and stability in the society. Therefore, sometimes it is also said that the early sociology developed as a reaction to the Enlightenment.

But, as far as the methodology or means to understand and study these social changes was concerned, it was largely influenced by the intellectual contributions of the Enlightenment scholars. Unlike conservatives, who yearned for a return to the peace and harmony of the Middle Ages, early social theorists emphasized on the need for scientific study of society based on empirical observation and reason (an idea of Enlightenment scholars) to be the basis of this new knowledge. They argued that through scientific study of society, social scientists can discover social laws that govern social order and thus, through corrective social legislation, can create a harmonic society. So, that is how the intellectual conditions helped in creating a new discipline which would use scientific method to study society, discover the laws that govern society and use that knowledge of laws to create a peaceful and harmonic society.

So, social conditions created the need for sociology, intellectual conditions provided the means for building sociology and that is how modernity and social change in Europe led to the emergence of sociology.



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Test Yourself

Q1. Write a note on 'Modernity and social changes in Europe and emergence of Sociology'. (300-350 words/ 30 marks)

Dear Candidate, before I give you a model answer for this question, I wish to discuss with you the correct strategy of writing an answer. I call this '**Dialectical Approach**', a term borrowed from Hegel. But before you apply the dialectical approach to a question make sure that you have read that question at least three times and understood it. It is a very common error on the part of the candidates to write in the examination 'what they know' rather 'what has been asked by the examiner.' Hence, the key to score well in this examination is to read the mind of the examiner and accordingly answer the question, meeting the expectations of the examiner. If you do this, you would get marks as per your expectations too.

All you have to do for this is to follow a very simple process. Firstly, read the question carefully and underline the keywords. Secondly, try to understand from which dimension the question has been framed on the topic. This is very important because questions can be framed from multiple dimensions or angles on the same topic. You would have no problem doing this if you sincerely follow the theme-based approach. Thirdly, divide the question into 3-4 logical sub-questions. When you do this it will not only keep you focused on the main theme but also help you complete the paper in time.

Now, let me share with you something about the structure of your answer. Your answer must be divided in four sections, viz. **introduction**, **thesis**, **anti-thesis** and **synthesis**. The Introduction section is the most important section of your answer as it introduces yourself as a candidate to the examiner. The examiner forms an image about you and your understanding of the concept just by reading the introduction. Hence, you must start by directly addressing the question, without beating the bush. By this I mean that given the limitations of Time and Word Limit, please avoid developing the background and glorifying the thinkers. In the introduction, briefly explain the key concept asked in the question. The introduction section should constitute nearly 20 % of the total length of your answer.

The next section is Thesis. In this section, you need to identify the main arguments in favour of the given concept or statement. Here, you must enrich your answer by highlighting the works of the scholars and case studies in support of

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your argument. In the Anti-Thesis section, you must write a critique of the concept or statement. This would balance your answer. Both, Thesis and Anti-Thesis should constitute nearly 30% each of the total length of your answer. Last, but not the least, is the Synthesis section. You may also call it as concluding remarks. Please remember that the concluding remarks reflect your overall understanding of the subject to the examiner. Your concluding remarks are not supposed to be your personal opinion about the ideas or concepts asked in the question. Rather, your concluding remarks must reflect the insight that you have gained as a student of Sociology. Thus, when write synthesis, make sure it is an academic conclusion rather than personal opinion.

Structure of the Model Answer:

Introduction: Briefly discuss the concept of modernity and the process of social change in Europe that brought about modernity

Thesis: Arguments in favour of the modernization process, viz. the ideas of Enlightenment scholars, with examples

Anti-thesis: Conservative reaction to Enlightenment

Synthesis: Emergence of Sociology as a by-product of the confluence of the two intellectual currents – Enlightenment and Conservatives

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Model Answer

Modernity refers to the rational transformation of social, psychological, economic and political aspects of society. In this sense, the process of modernization could be said to have begun in the late 18th and early 19th century in Western Europe. During that period, the entire social structure and the economic and political institutions were undergoing transition, particularly in the backdrop of Renaissance and Enlightenment movement. With industrial revolution, traditional feudal agrarian society was in decline and a new capitalist industrial society was emerging. The commercial and scientific revolutions which marked the period laid the foundations for the transformation of a predominant rural, agricultural and manual way of life to an urban industrial and mechanized pattern of living.

These extensive changes integral to the process of industrialization however, involved a major paradox. They brought a new society with great productive potential and more sophisticated and complex ways of living while at the same time generating extensive disruptions in traditional patterns of life and relationship. Thus, creating new problems of overcrowding, unhygienic urban conditions, poverty and unemployment. Demand for greater political rights gave rise to social and political movements, such as French Revolution, often leading to civil wars.

However, the early scholars who were carefully observing the changes in the patterns of social life with the rise of industrial society were divided in their opinion with regard to the nature, impact and direction of such changes. Enlightenment scholars like Rousseau, Montesquieu, Adam Smith, Saint Simon and Augusts Comte had a positive view of the newly emerging social order. They considered such changes as progressive and hence desirable. They favoured modern scientific knowledge, advanced technology, individualism and political ideas of justice and liberty. They encouraged the forces of liberalization and industrialization. Whereas, the Conservatives like Louis de Bonald, Joseph de Maistre and other such scholars had a rather skeptic view of these profound and far reaching institutional changes that were taking place in society. They were preoccupied with the concern for social stability and order in the society as the new social order was marked by violent political revolutions, class wars, extreme economic inequalities and widespread misery and poverty.

Thus, while social conditions created the need for sociology, intellectual conditions provided the means for building sociology as a distinct discipline. It is the combination of both enlightenment and conservative school of thought which led to the emergence of sociology.

Total Words: 355

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Dear Candidate, after completing a given topic and preparing your notes in pointer form, you must attempt questions asked so far in previous years and get them evaluated. As I have discussed before, what really counts here is how you are articulating the learned knowledge in the given Time and Word Limit. Always remember that Civil Services Examination is not about information, it is more about analysis. So, you must practice by writing more and more answers and getting them periodically evaluated.

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Nation / Nationalism

The term nation is derived from the Latin word '*nasci*', meaning 'to be born'. Thus nations are the groups originally believed to have been formed on the basis of birth. However, in contemporary plural societies, nations are far more complex, particularly in the light of naturalised citizenship.

Nations are complex phenomena that are shaped by a collection of cultural, political and psychological factors. Culturally, a nation is a group of people bound together by a common language, religion, history and tradition. Politically, a nation is a group of people who regard themselves as a natural political community. Although this is classically expressed in the form of a desire to establish or maintain statehood, it also takes the form of civic consciousness. Psychologically, a nation is a group of people distinguished by a shared loyalty or affection in the form of patriotism.

Nationalism can broadly be defined as the belief that the nation is the central principle of political organisation. It refers to '*a set of symbols and beliefs providing the sense of being part of a single political community*'. Nationalism is the main expression of feelings of identity with a distinct sovereign community.

According to **Hans Kohn**, 'nationalism demands the nation-state; the creation of the nation-state strengthens nationalism'. Similarly, **Max Weber** also argues that 'a nation is a community of sentiment which would adequately manifest itself in a state of its own'. Nationalism, thus, could be described as an ideology or movement that seeks to establish a particular nation state, or to consolidate its power. It is the belief that the nation is/must be the primary focus of loyalty for individuals and groups within a state; that it should be the sole object of people's allegiance.

Nationalism is commonly regarded by historians as having originated in the late 18^{th} & 19^{th} centuries in Europe, more specifically in Western Europe. Modernist scholars like Ernest Gellner and Benedict Anderson offer a functional account of the emergence of nationalism. They argue that nationalism emerged as a necessary product of modernization.

According to **Ernest Gellner**, nationalism has a structural connection with the needs of modern industrial society. He argued that the social organisation of agrarian society is not at all favourable to the nationalist principle. The move from an agrarian to an industrial society necessitated of the creation of a common culture and a standardized language. According to him, the need of modern industrial economies for a mobile and interchangeable workforce requires complex

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new skills and social formations beyond the resources of family and kinship ties. Such skills according to Gellner 'can only be provided by a public education system and integrated by (preferably) a single language and within a centralized political, economic, and educational system'; in other words, within the modern nation-state. The universality of nationalism in the contemporary world stems from the fact that it is the only form of political organization that is appropriate to the social and material conditions of modern society. Further, nationalism can unite sections of the population that would compete fiercely otherwise for valued modern occupations – jobs and political careers. Thus, seen through Gellner's eyes, nationalism is a *sine qua non* of industrialization, because it provides people with a powerful motivation for making painful changes necessary for creating modern industrial societies. The cultural homogeneity required by nationalism is also useful for industrial society in many ways. Thus, to simplify Gellner's thesis, nationalism is intrinsic to both modernity and industrialization.

Gellner, in his work *Nations and Nationalism* (1983), further argues that it is not nations that create nationalism but rather, that *nationalism creates nations*, a fact that certainly seems to be true for the history of most recent nation-states. In this process, according to Gellner, the principle of nationalism exerts a homogenizing pressure on pre-modern cultures, exploiting them and transforming them to fulfill its project of creating a homogenous 'national' culture. Nationalism also obliterates obscure 'little traditions' and reinvents and homogenizes 'great traditions' in order to create a basis for the modern nation. Gellner's analysis can be used by us to understand the rise of Hindu nationalism, or Hindutva in India. Hindutva seeks to promote the development of a (Hindu) Indian nation by the propagation of a homogenized Hindu 'high' culture that ignores diverse local, folkloric traditions in favour of a limited set of upper-caste, Sanskritic traditions. This project of Hindutva is expressed in the demand for a common national language (Sanskritized Hindi), a common deity (Lord Ram) and a common place of worship for all Hindus – the site of Lord Ram's birth in the north Indian city of Ayodhya. This last demand was expressed as the Ramjanmabhoomi movement and culminated in the destruction of a mosque – the Babri Masjid – that allegedly stood at the site of Ram's birthplace. Interestingly, there is a continuous reference in the Hindutva discourse to a glorious ancient past – the 'Vedic Age' – as the origin/root of the Hindu nation. As mentioned above, the idea of common origin or birth is a part of the history of nationalism in Western Europe, too. Therefore, in Gellner's words, '*nationalism is not the awakening of nations to self consciousness; it invents nations where they do not exist*.'

Benedict Anderson argues that the creation of printing presses led to the standardization of the written language around which a common culture could coalesce, leading to the creation of an 'imagined community'. Nation as an

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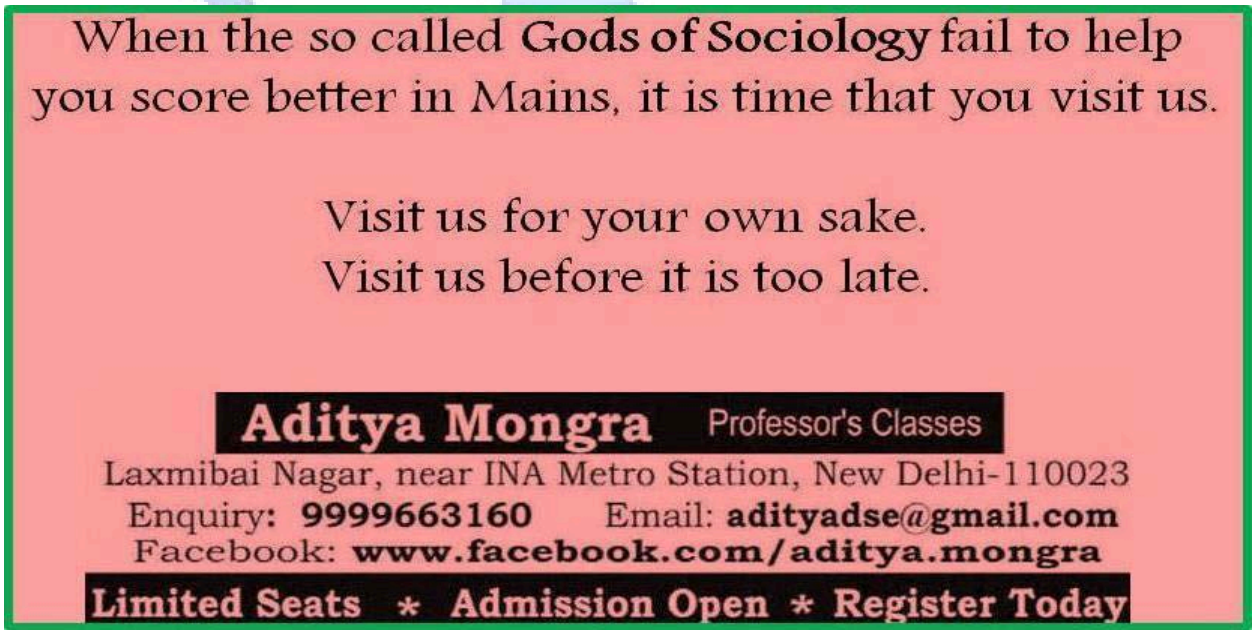
imagined community and *print capitalism* are Benedict Anderson's two concepts which have become justly famous for understanding nationalism. Our typical understanding of a community is that of a closely knit face-to-face group. Though the members of a nation are strangers to each other in real life, in their minds, they imagine and live the life of a community — primarily political and cultural. This was made possible by *print capitalism*, which enabled the vernacular languages to replace sacred languages like Latin. Millions of fellow readers of the printed language was the embryo of the nationally imagined community. Today it is no longer only print but, generally, *media capitalism* which is playing a very important role in creating and sustaining a nation.

Marxism believes that nationalism offers individuals an identity and a means to belong to a community that seems egalitarian and unified, but actually is not so. This is because all nations are characterized by deep economic and social inequalities even today. Thus, Marxists would argue that the unity in nationalist thought can be a mythical one, and does not reflect the real conditions of human beings in the modern, predominantly capitalist world. Benedict Anderson, an influential writer on nationalism expresses this Marxist insight when he calls nations as '*imagined communities*'. According to Anderson (1983), nations are imagined because,

'the members of even the smallest nation will never know most of their fellow members, meet them, or even hear of them, yet in the minds of each lives the image of their communion . . . regardless of the actual inequality and exploitation that may prevail in each, the nation is always conceived of as a deep, horizontal comradeship.'



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Nationalism in third world societies

Since for Gellner, early development of capitalist industries is a pre-condition for the emergence of nationalism, his theory cannot explain the origins of nationalist sentiments in most of the third world countries that saw very sparse industrial development till the mid-twentieth century, for example, India. Many of the nationalist movements seen in the developing world at the time of decolonization were the product of different forces. The nationalist movements which emerged were generally not the product of processes of modernization, and involved multiple communities. Often, the colonized territories were ethnically heterogeneous and the bond unifying the nationalist movement was a shared sense of difference from the colonial power – 'the other'. However this bond against the colonial power did not always exist, as can be seen in the different approaches of the Indian National Congress (perceived to be a Hindu organization) and the Muslim League to Indian independence. And even when a shared interest in removing the colonial power existed, this often disappeared once the colonial power had departed.

However, Benedict Anderson's suggestion in 'Imagined Communities' have had the deepest influence in the analysis of modern nationalism, particularly in the third world societies. Anderson offers a startling thesis that as a sense of membership towards religious communities decline, and modern social conditions force individuals to exist in abstract relationships outside of face-to-face pre-modern communities, nationalism produces a new kind of 'imagined' community which replicates the intensity of religious emotions of communal belonging. Anderson's thesis views the contribution of what he calls 'print-capitalism' to this process as crucial. It is true that the idea of print-capitalism suits the facts of early modern European history better than the colonial world, but if the attachment of capitalism is taken away, the hypothesis acquires much greater plausibility in colonial conditions. Print was less decisively linked to a form of capitalism in India, but in its artisanal form, it certainly played a decisive role in the growth of nationalist discourse.

Conclusion: The future of an idea

At the start of the 21st century, increasing economic globalization, mass migration, and technological advancements like the Internet and mobile phones seem to have dramatically 'shrunk the planet'. The lifestyles of the elites all over the globe are now strikingly similar; for many classes of people, national identity has become irrelevant at the everyday level – they use the same slang, travel in the same manner and even eat the same food! Migration of human beings has increased manifold, with a huge number of individuals seeking to live and work in

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countries far away from their own. Writers argue that in the face of an increasingly globalized world, old political formations like the nation will lose their earlier role and relevance. **David Beetham**, for instance, argues that the very forces that strengthened nationalism in the previous era will cause its downfall in the coming one. Some writers believe that rather than national formations, it is *trans*-national economic and political alliances that will set the agenda for the world's people in this, and in the coming centuries. In this context, writers point to the example of the European Union as proof of the decline of the nation state. Europe being widely regarded as the birthplace of nationalism, the formation of the European Union on this very continent has led some writers to believe that nationalism and other such 'primitive' ideologies will be overcome in this new epoch. Many writers and political commentators believe that the coming centuries will move in the direction of cosmopolitan, universal, global values, and the nationalist bloodbaths of the previous century will be distant memories.

However, well into the 21st century, a decline of nationalism seems nowhere in evidence. Nationalism as a *political force* seems alive, and well expressed in myriad forms like cultural revivalist movements in the East, debates on race and immigration all over the world, and most recently, in the controversy over business process outsourcing (BPO) in western states. You may recall that opposition to outsourcing in Western countries was conducted in nationalist language, with implicit elements of xenophobia and racism against workers in Third World states. Further, national 'self- determination' movements are active, whether in Kashmir, in Palestine, or as witnessed in the recent liberation of East Timor from Indonesia. Nationalism has been, and will in all likelihood continue to be, at the core of many of the most bitter and important struggles well into the 21st century. The theorist **Michael Billig**, for example, argues that nationalism as a phenomenon is too deeply and thoroughly ingrained in modern life to study it narrowly in terms of particular social movements and make sharp and sweeping distinctions *between* nationalisms. Billig's central claim is that if all states today are *nation*-states, then nationalism is simply the ideology that maintains *all* nation-states *as* nation-states. In this context Billig (1997) refers to the idea of 'banal nationalism' – the everyday, routine forms of nationalism practiced by First World states – from the restrictions on immigration to the widespread use of national symbols such as flags and songs.

To conclude, it may be useful to understand nationalism as a universal contemporary political phenomenon; not simply an occasional, spectacular outpouring of patriotic sentiment, but as a part of the history of the modern state. Nationalism has often joined hands with the democratic state and liberal politics, as the experience of Third World leaders like Gandhi, Nehru, etc. has shown. It can be a powerful transformative force that can achieve miracles in large and

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impoverished societies, as expressed in the idea of 'nation-building'. Nationalism has especially been an ally for post-colonial societies seeking to unite large and diverse populations and fulfill difficult developmental goals within an unequal global capitalist system. However, it has also become entwined with more dangerous ideologies like religious extremism of any sort, fundamentalism and even fascism. To understand way nationalism can be healthy or regressive, powerful or limited in its scope, one must remember above all the historical contingencies that accompanied its rise, and in particular its complex historical relationship with the modern state. The blending of the universal and the particular, the banal and the spectacular, the routine and the extraordinary, the reasonable and the irrational is what constitutes the most striking feature of nationalism anywhere in the world, and perhaps gives us a compelling explanation for the continuing power of this ideology well into the 21st century.

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Equality

"Unstratified society with real equality of its members is a myth that has never been realized in the history of mankind." – **P.A. Sorokin**

Equality is a modern value. It is also used as a measure of modernity and of the whole process of modernization. Equality is associated with the development of the nation state, political egalitarianism and social justice. Equality, both as a value and a principle, took a concrete shape in the slogan "Liberty, Equality and Fraternity", given in the French Revolution of 1789.

Traditional societies (except primitive ones), be it caste-based Hindu society or Western feudal societies based on estate system, were largely inegalitarian in nature. Hence, equality as a value and a concept is of recent origin, making an appearance during the post-Renaissance and Enlightenment period.

However, the concept of equality has developed through various stages. For example, during the French Revolution, one of the major cry of people was for ***equality before law***. Protesting against the exploitative estate system, people demanded that in the eyes of law all should be treated equal. Soon this led to the demand for ***political equality*** which resulted in universal adult suffrage. **Turner** writes that "the modern notion of equality cannot be divorced from the evolution of citizenship." [Bryan S. Turner]

Further, as the criticism against the exploitative capitalist system grew, demand for ***socio-economic equality*** also mounted. Marxist scholars argued that unless there is socio-economic equality, equality before law and political equality would remain illusory (not real). As a result the notion of **welfare state** developed and various reforms such as land reforms, tax reforms (progressive taxation) etc., were initiated to promote greater socio-economic equality.

John Rawls in his well-known work **'A Theory of Justice'** deals with the question of "equality" from the point of **social justice** than merely as a political concept. Rawls realized that a society could not avoid inequalities among its people. Inequalities result from such things as one's inherited characteristics, social class, personal motivation, etc. Even so, Rawls insisted that a just society should find ways to reduce inequalities in areas where it can act. He advocated that societies should strive to provide for **"fair equality of opportunity"** to all its members. One way for a society to do this would be to **eliminate discrimination**. Another way would be to **provide everyone easy access to education**. Rawls relates equality to the basic structure of society that governs the assignment of rights and duties and regulate the distribution of social and economic advantages.

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In recent times, feminist scholars have been very vocal about the issues related with ***gender equality***. The advocates of gender equality have extended their argument to the **human rights of transgenders** and **decriminalization of Article 377 of Indian Penal Code** related to homosexuality.

Equality, however, is meaningless unless we can answer the question: **equal in what?** In social sciences, the term equality has very different implications, depending upon what is being apportioned.

Foundational Equality: is the idea that human beings are 'born equal' in the sense that their lives are of equal moral value.

Formal equality: refers to the formal status of individuals in society in terms of their rights and entitlements. Its clearest expression is in the form of legal equality (equality before law) and political equality (universal suffrage and one person–one vote, one vote–one value).

Equality of opportunity: means that everyone has the same starting point, or equal life chances. Equality of opportunity concept developed in response to the inadequacies of formal equality. In a society marked by gross economic inequality, formed equality would serve little purpose. As a result it was argued that people should have a fair chance or level playing field in society. They should have equality in terms of various rights and resources so that they can nurture their talent. In other words, equality of opportunity tries to ensure **equality of conditions** so that people can become unequal based on their merit. Thus developed the concepts of welfare state and social justice to ensure equality of opportunity. For example, right to education is now a fundamental right in India. Similarly, UPSC has set Graduation as the minimum eligibility criterion for the candidates belonging to different castes, class or religion to complete in the Civil Services Examination conducted annually.

Equality of outcome: refers to an equal distribution of rewards. It is usually reflected in social equality, an equal distribution of income, wealth and other social goods. Marx's dream of communist society was largely based upon this form of equality.

Although foundational equality as a philosophical principal, and formal equality as a legal and political principle are widely accepted, at least in liberal-democratic societies, deep controversy continues to surround the idea of equality of outcome or rewards.

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Arguments in favour of social or material equality:

- It strengthens social cohesion and community by creating a common identity and shared interests ;
- It promotes justice in that the most obvious forms of social inequality are the result of unequal treatment by society rather than unequal natural endowment;
- It enlarges freedom in the sense that it safeguards people from poverty and satisfies basic needs, enabling them to achieve fulfillment;
- It is the only meaningful form of equality in that all other equalities rest upon it: genuine legal and political equality require that people have access to equal social resources.

Arguments against social equality:

- It is unjust because it treats unequals equally and therefore fails to reward people in line with their talents and capacities;
- It results in economic stagnation in that it removes incentives and caps aspirations;
- It can be achieved only through state intervention and a system of 'social engineering', meaning that it always infringes upon individual liberty;
- It result in drab uniformity; diversity is vanquished and with it the vigour and vitality of society.

Men have long dreamed of an egalitarian society, a society in which all members are equal. Karl Marx too in his theory of social change had predicted the arrival of communist society, a truly egalitarian society, without classes, without contradictions. However, in reality, the egalitarian society remains a dream.

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Inequality and Hierarchy

Human society is marked by great diversity, be it biological, psychological or social. Individuals or groups may differ either in terms of their biological attributes like age, sex, and race, or psychological attributes like aptitude, intelligence and motivation, or social attributes, such as wealth, power and prestige.

When such different categories of people are treated alike (or equal) and one is not treated as more significant than the other, it is called **Social Differentiation**. According to **Dipankar Gupta**, difference or social differentiation is salient when diversity in human society is understood in a 'qualitative sense'. According to this scheme, categories of individuals or groups are not arranged vertically or hierarchically, but horizontally or even separately. It is because the constitutive elements of these differences are such that any attempt to see them hierarchically would do offence to the logical property of these very elements. Such an arrangement can be easily illustrated in the case of language, religion or nationalities. It would be futile to hierarchize language, or religions or nationalities. India is an appropriate place to demonstrate this. The various languages that are spoken in India speak eloquently of an horizontal categorization where differences are paramount. Secular India again provides an example of religious diversity where religions are not hierarchized or unequally privileged in law, but have the freedom to exist separately in full knowledge of their intrinsic differences.

However, the concept of difference or social differentiation offers limited success in understanding the organization of human society in reality and the egalitarian society still remains a dream. All human societies from the simplest to the most complex have some form of social inequality. Inequality is both assumed as a fact of everyday life and denounced as an offence to a civilized society. In particular, power and prestige are unequally distributed between individuals and social groups. In many societies there are also marked differences in the distribution of wealth.

- **Power:** refers to the degree to which individuals or groups can impose their will on others, with or without the consent of those others.
- **Prestige:** relates to the amount of esteem or honour associated with social positions, qualities of individuals and styles of life.
- **Wealth:** refers to material possessions defined as valuable in particular societies.

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The term **social inequality** refers to the existence of socially created inequalities. Please note that when the differences among individuals or groups are recognized but not evaluated or associated with social rewards, then it is called social differentiation. But, when these differences among people are socially evaluated in terms of superiority or inferiority leading to unequal distribution of rewards (wealth, prestige or power) it results in social inequality.

Hierarchy is one special form of social inequality, which implies a ranking of individuals or groups according to some criterion of evaluation (for example, wealth, prestige or power) accepted as relevant within the system. According to **Louis Dumont**, hierarchy implies the regular ordering of a phenomenon on a continuous scale 'such that the elements of the whole are ranked in relation to the whole'. [Explain Dumont briefly]

It is important to note here that equality of opportunity is a political ideal that is opposed to caste hierarchy but not to hierarchy per se. Hierarchy in itself may either be **ascribed** (ritualistic, based on birth) or **achieved** (secular, based on merit).

For example, Hindu society in traditional India was divided into five main strata: four varnas or castes, and a fifth group, the outcaste, whose members were known as untouchables. Each caste is subdivided into jatis or sub-castes, which in total number many thousands. **Jatis are occupational groups** – there are carpenter jatis, goldsmith jatis, potter jatis, and so on.

Castes are ranked in terms of ritual purity. The Brahmins or priests, members of the highest caste, personify purity, sanctity and holiness. They are the source of learning, wisdom and truth. Only they can perform the most important religious ceremonies. At the other extreme, untouchable are defined as unclean and impure, a status which affects all their social relationships. They must perform unclean and degrading tasks such as the disposal of dead animals. They must be segregated from members of the caste system and live on the outskirts of villages. Their presence pollutes to the extent that even if the shadow of an untouchable falls across the food of a Brahmin it will render it unclean. In general, **the hierarchy of prestige based on notions of ritual purity** is mirrored by the hierarchy of power. The Brahmins were custodians of the law, and the legal system which they administered was based largely on their pronouncements. Inequalities of wealth were usually linked to those of prestige and power. In a largely rural economy, the Brahmins tended to be the largest landowners and the control of land was monopolized by members of the two highest castes. Thus, in a caste society, the assignment of individuals to various positions in the social hierarchy is fixed by birth. The child acquires the social status of his or her parents. Social mobility is

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limited in a caste society, and the process whereby one is admitted to a different level of the hierarchy is open only to some individuals depending on their initial ascriptive social status.

In contrast, in relatively open societies, where equality of opportunity prevails, the assignment of individuals to various positions in the social hierarchy is determined by some form of competitive process, and all members of society are eligible to compete on equal terms. Thus, open societies are marked by hierarchies based on secular dimension.

Thus the basis of hierarchy is unequal distribution of rewards, viz. wealth, prestige and power. So, when these rewards are unequally distributed in a given society, social hierarchy results. Social hierarchy may involve ranking of individuals or ranking of groups.

When social hierarchy involves **ranking of groups**, we call it **social stratification**. Social stratification is a particular form of social inequality. It refers to the presence of social groups which are ranked one above the other, usually in terms of the amount of power, prestige and wealth their members possess. Those who belong to a particular group or stratum will have some awareness of common interests and a common identity. They will share a similar life style which to some degree will distinguish them from members of others social strata. Thus, the members of a particular stratum have a common identity, like interests and a similar life style. They enjoy or suffer the unequal distribution of rewards in society as members of different social groups.

For example: Indian caste system – Four Varnas – Brahmins, Kshatriyas, Vaishyas and Shudras. And a fifth group of 'Untouchables'.

- Castes are ranked in terms of ritual purity.
- hierarchy of prestige → hierarchy of power → hierarchy of wealth
  (brahmin) (inequalities of wealth)

Please note that **social stratification, however, is only one form of social inequality**. **It is possible for social inequality to exist without social strata**. For example, some sociologists have argued that it is no longer correct to regard western industrial society, particular the USA, as being stratified in terms of a class system. They suggest that social classes have been replaced by a continuous hierarchy of unequal positions. Where there were once classes, whose member had a **consciousness of kind**, a common way of life and shared interests, there is now an unbroken continuum of occupational statuses which command varying degrees

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of prestige and economic reward. Thus it is suggested that a hierarchy of social groups has been replaced by a hierarchy of individuals.

Inequality of stratification can exist in 2 ways:

- Cumulative inequality of stratification
- Dispersed inequality of stratification

Cumulative inequality of stratification results when the status position of any social group overlaps on all the dimensions of societal rewards, viz. wealth, prestige, power, education, etc. [Note: **Karl Marx** argues that inequality tends to be cumulative in nature.]

Dispersed inequality of stratification results when a particular social group enjoys high status position on one dimension but does not automatically enjoys similar status position on other dimensions of societal rewards.

For example, traditional caste system, particularly in north India, was marked by cumulative inequality of stratification. Brahmins enjoyed higher position on all axis of societal rewards viz. social prestige, power, education and wealth, while the untouchables occupied the lowest position in the caste hierarchy along these dimensions. However, in modern India, cumulative inequality of stratification has given way to dispersed inequality of stratification on account of various welfare initiatives taken by Indian state such as policy of protective discrimination in educational institutions and government services, land reforms, reserved seats in political institutions, etc. Though Brahmins still occupy high prestige on account of their higher ritual position in the caste hierarchy but in the last few decades several lower caste groups have witnessed upward mobility in terms of education, power and wealth. While modern education, reservation policy and land reforms improved their economic position (land owning castes), their sheer numbers (numerical majority) facilitated their dominance in political sphere. For example, **Yadavs** of **U.P.** and **Bihar**, **Chamars** of western **Uttar Pradesh**, **Meenas** of **Rajasthan**, etc. [**Mayawati**, **Mulayam Singh Yadav**, **Lalu Prasad Yadav**, **Ram Vilas Paswan**, etc.]

*Please note that the dispersed inequality of stratification gives rise to **relative deprivation**. For example, **Dr. Ambedkar – Dalit Movement**.

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Gerhard Lenski also talks about two related and important concepts:

- **Status crystallization** – is the situation where an individual or a group is high or low on all the three dimensions of social rewards (traditional caste system).

- **Status inconsistency** – results when an individual or a group is high on one dimension, but low on another (caste system in modern India).

*Please note that status inconsistency results in the feeling of **relative deprivation → protest → conflict**.

For example, Dr. Ambedkar enjoyed a very high status in terms of his educational qualification yet he, and his caste (Mahar), occupied the lowest status in the ritual hierarchy of the caste system. Thus, leading to frustration, collective mobilization and protest against the inhuman and exploitative caste system. Ambedkar called for the annihilation of the caste system for the emancipation of dalits. Thus, the emergence of Dalit movement could be best accounted by status inconsistency and feeling of relative deprivation. However, this is only one of the explanations for the rise of Dalit movement.

Andre Beteille talks about two types of stratification systems:

- **Harmonic system of stratification** is the one in which the norms and values of society legitimize social inequality.

***** for example, traditional caste system – ***Purushasukta* hymn** of the tenth mandala of the Rig Veda – The *Purushashukta* hymn of *Rigveda* tells us that the *brahmana* emanated from the mouth of the primeval man (*Brahma*), the *kshatriya* from his arms, the *vaishya* from his thighs and the *shudra* from his feet. The particular limbs associated with these divisions and the order in which they are mentioned probably indicate their status in the society of the time, though no such interpretation is directly given in the hymn. In this particular account of the creation not only is the origin of the classes interpreted theologically, but also a divine justification is sought to be given to their functions and status. This may be a *post facto* rationalization of the occupations and of the positions that the various groups came to occupy in the social hierarchy.

*through its ***Guna* theory**, Brahmanism seeks to justify the social hierarchy of varna system (hitherto taken for granted) in terms of different qualities and capacities of the individuals. In the *Bhagavadgita* the Creator is said to have

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apportioned the duties and functions of the four varnas according to the inherent qualities and capacities of the individuals. This theory claims that all existing things, animated and inanimated, inherent three qualities (*Gunas*) in different apportionment. ***Sattva*** qualities include wisdom, intelligence, honesty, goodness and other positive qualities. ***Rajas*** include qualities like passion, pride, valour and other passionate qualities. ***Tamas*** qualities include dullness, stupidity, lack of creativity and other negative qualities. Thus, brahmanas are predominated by *sattva guna*, kshatriyas by *rajas guna*, vaishyas by *rajas* and *tamas guna* and shudras by *tamas guna*. Of course, this theory fails to explain how the individuals at the very beginning of creation came to be possessed of peculiar qualities and capacities. This theory of origin, though it slurs over the above difficulty, tries to provide a rational sanction for the manifestly arbitrary divisions. God separated the people into four varnas, not merely because they were created from different limbs of his body nor again out of his will, but because he found them endowed with different qualities and capacities.

*with the **doctrine of *Karma***, the lawgivers of the age propagated the view that the conscientious practice of the duties proper to one's own varna, led to a birth in a higher varna and thus to salvation. (Please note that after having legitimized the caste-based inequality, lawmakers of the age sought to reinforce it with the doctrine of *Karma*. However, interestingly, the *Karma* theory instead of being inner-worldly, tended to be other-worldly in its effect.)

Thus, the prevailing norms and values of society in the traditional caste system legitimized as well as reinforced social inequality on various grounds and by various means. Beteille argues that inequalities in such a system do not generate conflict. Conflict in harmonic system of stratification is minimal and does not threaten the existence or stability of the system.

- **Disharmonic system of stratification** is the one in which norms and values of society prescribe equality but in reality there is inequality. In other words, while the normative order prescribes equality, the existential reality is marked by inequality.

*for example, in modern India, the constitution (normative order) enshrines the values of equality, liberty and fraternity but the contemporary reality is marked by gross socio-economic inequalities, political marginalization, prejudices and discrimination.

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*thus, generates high aspirations among the people, giving rise to the sense of relative deprivation, protest and radical social movements. Beteille argues that disharmonic system of stratification is marked by greater conflict (Naxalite- Maoist insurgency, SIMI (Students Islamic Movement of India), etc.).

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Natural versus social inequalities

[Q: How does hierarchy get built into the systems of natural & social inequalities?]

In social sciences, the question of the relationship between biologically based and socially created inequality has proved extremely difficult to answer. For example, many stratification systems are accompanied by beliefs which state that social inequalities are biologically based. Such beliefs are often found in systems of racial stratification where, for example, Whites claim biological superiority over Blacks and see this as the basis for their dominance.

The French Philosopher **Jean-Jacques Rousseau** provided one of the earliest examinations of this question. He refers to biologically based inequality as 'natural or physical, because it is established by nature, and consists in a **difference** of age, health, bodily strength, and the qualities of the mind or the soul'. By comparison, socially created inequality 'consists of the different privileges which some men enjoy to the prejudice of others, such as that of being more rich, more honored, more powerful, or even in a position to exact obedience'. Rousseau believed that biologically based inequalities between men were small and relatively unimportant whereas socially created inequalities provide the major basis for systems of social stratification. Most sociologists would support this view.

However, it could still be argued that biological inequalities, no matter how small, provide the foundation upon which structures of social inequality are built. This position is difficult to defend in the case of certain forms of stratification. In the **caste system**, an individual's status is fixed by birth. A person belongs to his parents' jati and automatically follows the occupation of the jati into which he was born. Thus no matter what the biologically based aptitudes and capacities of an untouchable, there is no way he can become a Brahmin. Unless it is assumed that superior genes are permanently located in the Brahmin caste, and there is no evidence that this is the case, **then there is probably no relationship between genetically based and socially created inequality in traditional Hindu society**. The rise of Dr. B.R. Ambedkar, for example, defies the very logic of the argument of any biological basis of social inequality.

A similar argument can be advanced in connection with the feudal or estate system of medieval Europe. Stratification in the feudal system was based on landholding. The more land an individual controlled, the greater his wealth, power and prestige. The position of the dominant stratum, the feudal nobility, was based on large grants of land from the king. Their status was hereditary, land and titles being passed on from father to son. It is difficult to sustain the argument that feudal

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lords ultimately owed their position to biological superiority when a son, no matter what his biological make-up, inherited the status of his father.

The most stubborn defense of the biological argument has been provided for systems of racial stratification. In the USA, Black Americans, who make up 12% of the population, have traditionally formed a distinct social stratum at the base of the stratification system. The majority of Blacks occupied the most menial and subservient occupational statuses, being employed as agricultural labourers and as unskilled and semiskilled manual workers in industry. In the mid 1960s, the average income for Black families was only 54 % of the average for White families. Blacks had little political power being scarcely represented in local and national government: in 1962, in the southern states, only six Blacks were elected to public office. This system of racial stratification has often been explained in terms of the supposed genetically based inferiority of Blacks. In particular, it has been argued that Blacks are innately inferior to Whites in terms of intelligence. 'Scientific' support for this view has been provided by intelligence tests which indicate that on average Blacks score fifteen points below Whites.

However, most sociologists would argue that systems of racial stratification have a social rather than a biological basis. They would maintain that systematic discrimination against Blacks, made possible by the power of the dominant stratum, accounts for the system of racial stratification in USA. Thus Blacks have been excluded from high status occupations because of lack of power rather than the quality of their genes. Support for this view is provided by evidence from the late 1960s and 1970s. During the mid1960s, in the USA, laws were passed banning racial discrimination in areas such as employment, politics and education. Blacks are now moving out of the lowest stratum in ever increasing numbers. By 1971, seventy Blacks were elected to political office in the southern states. Although the figure is small, it represents a dramatic increase. Black family income is slowly approaching the White average. From 1960 to 1970, the percentage of Blacks employed in professional, managerial and technical occupations rose steadily and in some cases doubled. This evidence suggests that social rather than biological mechanisms were responsible for the traditional status of Blacks in the USA.

The question of the relationship between intelligence and social inequality is particularly difficult to answer. The average intelligence quotient of Blacks in America is still significantly below that of Whites. In addition, Blacks are still disproportionately represented in the lower levels of the stratification system. **Since it is generally agreed that intelligence has a genetic component, can it not be argued that social inequality has a biological basis?** A few preliminary remarks can be made to refute this view. Firstly, intelligence is based on both

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genetic and environmental factors; the two are inseparable. Thus an individual's social background will affect his performance in an IQ test. In particular, the deprivations he experiences as a member of a low social stratum will reduce his IQ score. Secondly, many researchers argue that intelligence tests are based on White middle-class knowledge and skills and are therefore biased against Blacks. Thirdly, the tests measure only a small part of the range of mental abilities. Most sociologists would therefore conclude that the social status of Blacks in the USA is the result of a social rather than a biological mechanism.

So far the question of what exactly constitutes biological inequality has not been answered. **It can be argued that biological differences become biological inequalities when men define them as such**. Thus Andre Beteille states that, 'Natural inequality is based on differences in quality, and qualities are not just there, so to say, in nature; they are as human beings have defined them, in different societies, in different historical epochs'. Biological factors assume importance in many stratification systems because of the meanings assigned to them by different cultures. For example, old age has very different meanings in different societies. In traditional aborigine societies in Australia it brought high prestige and power since the elders directed the affairs of the tribe. But in Western societies, the elderly are usually pensioned off and old age assumes a very different meaning. Even with a change of name to senior citizen, the status of old age pensioner commands little power or prestige. So-called racial characteristics are evaluated on the basis of similar principles, that is values which are relative to time and place. The physical characteristic of Blacks in America were traditionally defined as undesirable and associated with a range of negative qualities. However, with the rise of Black Power during the late 1960s, this evaluation was slowly changed with slogans such as 'Black is beautiful'. It can therefore be argued that biological differences become biological inequalities only to the extent that they are defined as such. They form a component of some social stratification systems simply because members of those systems select certain characteristics and evaluate them in a particular way. Andre Beteille argues that the search for a biological basis for social stratification is bound to end in failure since the 'identification as well as the gradation of qualities is a cultural and not a natural process'.

Beliefs which state that systems of social stratification are based on biological inequalities can be seen as rationalizations for those systems. Such beliefs serve to explain the system to its members: they make social inequality appear rational and reasonable. They therefore justify and legitimate the system by appeals to nature. In this way a social contrivance appears to be founded on the natural order of things.

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Thus, when natural or social differences, come to be socially evaluated or associated with social rewards (wealth, power, prestige), social hierarchy results, giving rise to natural or social inequality.

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Political party

The political party is the major organizing principle of modern politics. A political party, in a broader sense, is a group of people that is organised for the purpose of winning government power, by electoral or other means.

Joseph A. Schumpeter defines party as 'a group whose members propose to act in concert in the competitive struggle for political power.'

Emergence of political parties is an aspect of political modernization. In modern politics, the relationship of an individual with the state has been redefined from that of a subject to a citizen. Democratic theory considers citizens as rational, independent and interested political persons capable of expressing their opinion regarding the persons aspiring for holding offices and also competent in electing some person who deals with the policies of the government in a way conducive to the interest of the masses.

Political sociology is primarily concerned with the study of political parties as social institutions and their transformative character in the ever dynamic social system. It also attempts to understand the relations between party members, party leaders and the masses.

Let us now briefly discuss the views of some important social and political scholars.

Marx and **Engels**, in the '*Manifesto of the Communist Party*' (1848) furnished the proletariat with the programme which would take humanity to a classless society, i.e. a communist society. This is the programme and path that all must necessarily cross under the leadership of the proletariat materialized in its party. Marx and Engels realized their thesis on the necessity of building the working class party as an indispensable instrument to fight for its class interests. As they wrote, 'In its struggle against united power of the owing classes, the proletariat cannot act as a class unless it constitutes itself into a political party, distinct and opposed to all the old political parties created by the owning classes', and that 'This constitution of the proletariat into a political party is indispensable to ensure the triumph of the social resolution and its ultimate goal: the abolition of the classes.'

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Lenin reasserted the necessity of party to transform society. His great point was 'Give us an organization of revolutionaries and we'll shake Russia to its foundations.' He reasoned that a party was necessary to change the world. And its programme 'consists of the organization of the proletariat's class struggle and the leadership of this struggle whose final objective is the conquest of political power for the proletariat and the organization of socialist society.' Lenin was much concerned with the principle of party organization. He advocated the construction of a tightly knit revolutionary party, organised on the basis of **democratic centralism**, to serve as the '**vanguard of the working class**'. He argued that without democracy it was impossible for party members to express their opinions, and without centralism, it was impossible to achieve unity of action and to carry out party decisions.

Max Weber defines 'parties' as groups which are specifically concerned with influencing policies and making decisions in the interests of their membership. In Weber's words, parties are concerned with the acquisition of social power. Weber further argues that at times parties may represent class interests or status interests. In most cases, they are partly class parties and partly status parties. Weber's view of parties suggests that the relationship between political groups and class and status groups is far from clear cut. For instance, sometimes parties may cut-across both, class as well as status groups.

Max Weber said, parties 'live in a house of power' and 'are always structures struggling for domination'. However, political parties are not the only political groups that operate within the house of power. In most democratic countries there are many private and voluntary associations which influence political process. These include human rights groups, women's organizations, labour unions, environmental groups, chambers of commerce, manufacturer's associations, senior citizen's associations and any other organized interest group in society. These are known as 'para-political groups'.

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In a nutshell, there are two divergent views with regard to the role of political parties in the political process viz. (i) Liberal view and (ii) Marxist view.

The liberal view is that political parties along with pressure groups and others interest groups, engage in competition for power as the representatives of different socio-economic groups in society. As a result of open competition, power in pluralist political systems is non-cumulative and shared. However, this view of the role of political parties in liberal democracies has been criticized severely. It has been argued that certain groups dominate the political decision-making process, especially those who dominate in the political realm. The view was most famously articulated by **Robert Michels** in the form of the '**iron law of oligarchy**'.

While liberals emphasize the important role of political parties in representative democracies, neo-Marxists (like Adorno, Horkheimer, Marcuse, etc.) play down their significance. In their view, in capitalist societies, since the dominant economic class is also the ruling class, parliamentary politics is illusory, and simply an ideological strategy which diverts attention away from the real sources of socio-economic and political inequalities. Many have argued that both liberal and the Marxist views are unsophisticated. It is true that power may be concentrated, but it is also possible for the ordinary people to influence political outcomes as we have seen in Delhi Assembly elections held in 2013 and also in 2015, in which **Aam Aadmi Party,** which raised common man's issues, delivered a spectacular electoral performance.

Functions of political parties

Political parties are a vital link between the state and civil society. In other words, political parties link the state to political forces in society, giving organized expression to interests and making them effective politically.

A political party performs a wide range of functions. According to **Gabriel Almond**, some of the important functions of political parties are as follows:

1. **Articulation of interests:** As stated earlier, political parties perform the vital role of articulation of interests of different sections of society. Thereby give organized expression to interests and make them effective politically.

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2. **Aggregation of interests:** One of the most important functions of political party is 'interest aggregation'. A political party is a multi-interest group that represents diverse interests of the society. It tries to harmonise these interests with each other and thereby seeks to produce consensus among as many groups as possible. Political party thus acts as a very effective mediator in settling disagreements in society in a peaceful and institutionalized manner.

3. **Political communication:** Political party provides a link between rulers and ruled. In ensures a two-way communication process between the government and people. It is a channel of expression, upward and downward. It is mainly through the parties that the government is constantly kept informed about the general demands of the society. The upward flow of communication from the ruled to the rulers is relatively strong in competitive party systems, whereas in a single ruling party, the flow of communication is mainly downward.

4. **Direction to government and society:** Political parties give direction to government and society. When in government, party leaders are centrally involved in implementing collective goals for society. The radical transformations of Russian and Chinese society were brought about by vanguard communist parties. In Asia and Africa, nationalist parties played a crucial role in winning independence. In Western Europe, political parties contributed to the creation of welfare states.

5. **Political recruitment and socialization:** Further, political parties also work as agents of elite recruitment and socialization. In a democracy, political elite are recruited mainly through political parties. Leaders of governments are normally the leaders of political parties. The political party also plays an important role in the political socialization of the masses. The political socialization performed by political parties may however assume two distinct forms. The party many either reinforce the existing political culture or it may try to alter the established political cultural pattern by generating new attitudes and beliefs. However, sometimes, this process of political socialization may also result in the dysfunctional consequences. Thus, when parties represent strong traditional and ethnic subcultures and seek to reinforce the same, they in effect, tend to produce divisive forces, which may seriously affect the stability of the political system. Such tendencies can

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be witnessed in the contemporary India with the growth of numerous regional and religious parties, and coalition governments.

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Handout 1: The changing nature of the party system in India
Handout 2: The nature of coalition politics in India

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Political participation

Political participation is a necessary ingredient of every political system. All political systems encourage political participation in varying degrees. By involving the people in the matters of the state and governance, political participation fosters stability and order by reinforcing the legitimacy of political authority. There are many forms of participation and democracy is the form of government which encourages maximum participation in governmental process. Participation does not mean the mere exercise of their franchise by the people, rather it means their active involvement which in a real manner influences the decision making of the govt.

Political participation can either be active or passive. People may participate actively in the political process either by exercising their franchise (right to vote) or by joining any political party, or contesting elections independently to an office. However, people may also participate in the political process by other ways such as reading, listening or watching the daily news about the various policies and programmes of the government and other political developments. People may also participate by taking part in political discussions and sharing their views on matters of national interest through newspaper columns. Such passive participation is equally important for a democracy to be a truly representative and participatory democracy as it not only reviews the actions of the government but also indicates a high level of political awareness among the masses.

However, **Seymour M. Lipset** has pointed out that high level participation cannot always be treated as good for democracy. It may indicate the decline of social cohesion and breakdown of democratic process. While some other scholars are of the opinion that when majority of the people in a society are contented, the political participation is low. This should be taken as a favourable rather than unfavourable sign because it indicates stability and consensus within society and also the absence of broad cleavages.

As stated earlier, individuals can participate in government and politics in numerous ways. They can choose to take an active part in their government by the easiest form of political participation – voting. They can also participate in the political process in their individual capacity by contesting elections to an office. They can also form an interest group or join a political party to articulate their interests and opinions in the given political system.

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Interest / Pressure Group

Decision-making is the essence of political dynamics. Decisions involve compromises among conflicting interests of social groups and political parties. Interest groups or pressure groups play an important role in decision-making. Such groups allow an orderly expression of public opinion and increase political participation.

Interest groups are the groups based upon **common attitudes, concerns or interests**. These are **voluntary associations of individuals** and their **primary objective is to promote or protect the shared concerns or interests of the respective members**.

Interest groups, according to **Blondel**, may be classified into two types: promotional and protective. **Promotional groups** tend to defend specific points of view (such as environmentalism, human rights, prevention of cruelty to animals, nuclear disarmament, etc.) and their membership remains open to all citizens. **Protective groups**, on the other hand, defend certain specific interests of some particular social groups (such as trade unions, professional associations, peasants, businessmen, etc.) and their membership is limited.

Some scholars are of the opinion that **if interest groups, in their pursuit of common interests, try to influence the public policy or government's decision-making process, without formally becoming a part of the government (i.e. without sharing any responsibility) then they become pressure groups.**

Definitions:

- Well known political scientists **Harold Lasswell** and **Abraham Kaplan** remarked, '*a group is an organized aggregate and an interest group is an interest aggregate*.'

- According to **Schaefer** and **Lamm**, '*an interest group is a voluntary association of citizens who attempt to influence public policy*.'

- According to **The Blackwell Dictionary of Sociology**, 'an interest (or pressure) group is an organization whose purpose is to influence the distribution and use of political power in a society.'

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- According to **Andrew Heywood**, 'an interest group or pressure group (the terms are often but not always used interchangeably) is an organised association which aims to influence the policies or actions of government.'

Thus, it may be argued that interest groups or pressure groups are voluntary associations of people having mutual concern about a wide array of economic, social, cultural, political, religious or any other issues. These are formally constituted organizations which are designed at least partly to put pressure on government, civil service and other political institutions to achieve ends that they favour.

Broadly speaking, pressure groups may be any group attempting to bring about any change in the working of any formal organization – state, government or any other social or economic organization. They are private associations to influence mass public policy. These groups are vital part of the political process. The political process is seen to result from a large number of competing interest or pressure groups.

Pressure groups, lobby groups and interest groups are distinct from clubs or social groups, in that their explicit purpose is to mobilize public opinion in support of their aims and to put pressure on decision-making bodies to agree to and support their demands – be they are for continuation of the existing state of affairs or for some change or innovation.

Pressure groups are found only in liberal-democratic political systems, in which the rights of political association and freedom of expression are respected. Pressure groups, however, differ from political parties in that they seek to exert influence from outside, rather than to win or exercise government power. Further, pressure groups typically have a narrow issue focus, in that they are usually concerned with a specific cause or the interests of a particular group, and seldom have the border programmic or ideological features that are generally associated with political parties.

The most positive perspective on group politics is offered by **pluralist theories**. These theories not only see organized groups as the fundamental building blocks of the political process, but also portray them as a vital guarantee of liberty and democracy. Arguments in favour of pressure groups include the idea that they strengthen representation by articulating interests and advancing views ignored by political parties; that they promote debate and discussion and thus create a more informed electorate ; that they broaden the scope of political participation; that they check government power and maintain a vigorous and healthy civil society;

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and that they promote political stability by providing a channel of communication between government and the people.

However, a more critical view of pressure groups is advanced by the **Marxist scholars**. Marxist scholars argue that group politics systematically advantages business and financial interests that control the crucial employment and investment decisions in a capitalist society, and that the state is biased in favour of such interests through its role in upholding the capitalist system which they dominate. Thus, from the conflict perspective, the limitation of interest groups or pressure groups is that they tend to represent mainly the wealthier or better-educated sections of the public, leaving the poor and minorities largely unrepresented.

Almond and **Powell**, in their work *Comparative Politics*, have classified interest groups into four types:

- **Institutional Interest Groups:** These interest or pressure groups are found within formal institutions such as political parties, legislatures, armies, bureaucracies, etc. Examples of such institutional interest groups are the representatives of weaker sections of society in the legislature (such as MLAs or MPs representing the interests of scheduled castes, scheduled tribes, religious and linguistic minorities, women, etc.), civil servants' association of a particular department, conservative business interests within mass political parties, labour leaders in social democratic parties, etc.

- **Associational Interest Groups:** Associational interest groups have both organized structures with full-time professional staff, and well-established procedures for the formulation of demands. The organizational base of these pressure groups places them in an advantageous position vis-à-vis other groups, and they often tend to regulate the development of other interest groups. For example, Confederation of Indian Industries (CII), Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FICCI), trade unions, organizations of businessmen (Oilseeds Dealers' Association) or of manufacturers (Jute Manufacturers' Association), organizations of religious denominations (the Vishwa Hindu Parishad), various civic groups (such as Peoples' Union of Civil Liberties), etc. The effectiveness of associational interest groups, however, depends on, as Almond and Powell have pointed out, the degree of autonomy they enjoy vis-à-vis political parties. This is particularly true of worker's, peasant's and student's organizations. These

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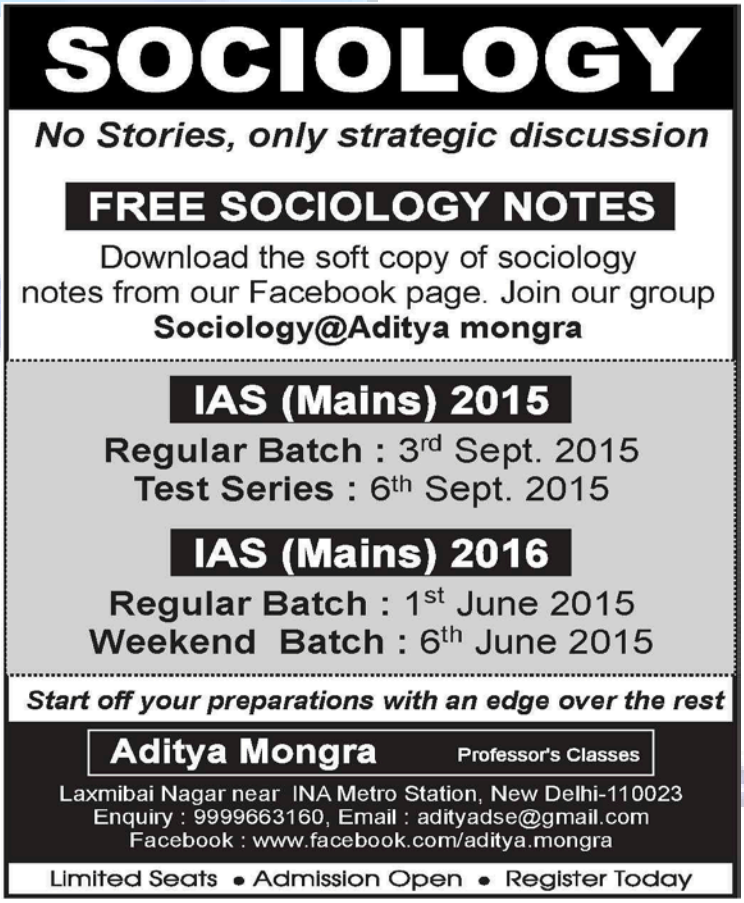
associational groups, when subordinated by political parties, instead of articulating the needs perceived by their members, serve only as instruments to mobilize support for the party.

- **Non-associational Interest Groups:** These are groups that lack both an organized structure as well as an organized, well-established procedure of articulation. Articulation of interests may take the form of a petition of an informal delegation from a linguistic group regarding language instruction in schools, appeals by relatives to a cabinet minister for some preferred treatment, etc. Kinship groups, ethnic, regional, and status groups are examples of non-associational interest groups.

- **Anomic Interest Groups:** When individuals or organized groups fail to obtain adequate representation in the political system, the resultant discontent leads to the spontaneous emergence of anomic groups. Riots or demonstrations may be sparked by an incident or by the emergence of an enthusiastic leader. Such spontaneous groups have limited organization.



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Protest

Collective acts of disruption and violence are sometimes viewed as expressions of social protests, and sometimes as crime or rebellion, leading to different community reactions. The verdicts of several politically sensitive commissions in the 1960s and 70s marked a dramatic turning point in American reactions to racial disorder. These verdicts identified mass violence by Blacks primarily as acts of social protest and stated that such disorders must be understood as acts of social protest, and not merely as crime, anti-social violence, or revolutionary threats to law and order.

Ralph H. Turner, in his paper, *The Public Perception of Protest* attempts to investigate several theoretical vantage points from which to predict when a public will and will not view a major disturbance as an act of social protest.

Protest has been defined as "an expression or declaration of objection, disapproval, or dissent, often in opposition to something a person is powerless to prevent or avoid."

An act of protest includes the following elements: the action expresses a grievance, a conviction of wrong or injustice; the protestors are unable to correct the condition directly by their own efforts; the action is intended to draw attention to the grievances; the action is further meant to provoke ameliorative steps by some target group; and the protestors depend upon some combination of sympathy and fear to move the target group in their behalf. Protest ranges from relatively persuasive to relatively coercive combinations, but always includes both. Many forms of protest may involve no violence or disruption at all.

The term protest is sometimes applied to trivial and chronic challenges that are more indicative of a reaction style than of deep grievance. For instance, we speak of a child who protests every command from parent or teacher in the hope of gaining occasional small concessions. It is in this sense that the protestations by some groups in society are popularly discounted because "they just protest everything." But the subject of this analysis is ***social protest***, by which we mean protest that is serious in the feeling of grievance that moves it and in the intent to provoke ameliorative action.

When violence and disorder are identified as social protest, they constitute a mode of communication more than a form of direct action. Looting is not primarily a means of acquiring property, as it is normally viewed in disaster situations; breaking store windows and burning buildings is not merely a perverted form of amusement or immoral vengeance like the usual vandalism and arson; threats of

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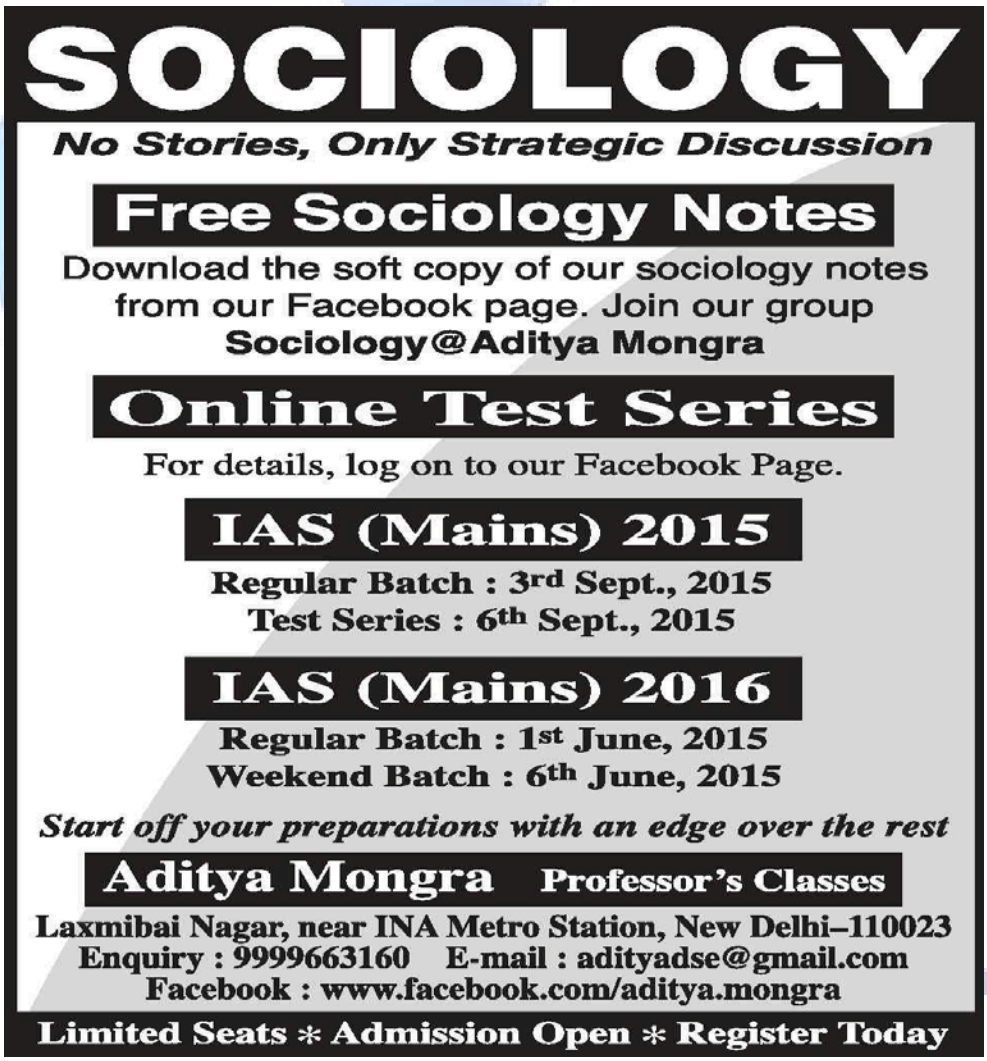
violence and injury to persons are not simply criminal actions. All are expressions of outrage against injustice of sufficient magnitude and duration to render the resort to such exceptional means of communication understandable to the observer.

According to Marvin Olsen, the principal indicators of a protest definition are concerned with identifying the grievances as the most adequate way of accounting for the disturbance and the belief that the main treatment indicated is to ameliorate the unjust conditions.

Interlinking Concepts: Social Exclusion, Relative Deprivation, Disharmonic System of Stratification, Social Movements, Theories of Social Change, etc.



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Race and Ethnicity

Race refers to a classification of the human species in terms of observable physical differences resulting from inherited biological characteristics. Such physical characteristics may include a particular skin colour, eye or nasal shape, hair texture, etc. The popular classification of human races recognizes three groups: Caucasoid, Mongloid and Negroid. These three are also referred to as "White", "Yellow" and "Black" races, respectively. However, there are at least two problems with this classification of races. First, some groups fit into none of these categories. For example, natives of India and Pakistan have caucasoid facial features but dark skin. Another problem with the biological classification of races is that there are no pure races. People in these groups have been interbreeding for centuries. (Miscegenation - process of intermixing of races)

Further, with the scientific development of genetics and the human genome as fields of study, most scholars now recognize that the differences in physical characteristics found among racial groups are probably the evolutionary result of environmental adaptation. For example, the dark skin of Negroid people protects them from the burning rays of the sun; the relative lack of body hair aids the cooling action of evaporation when they perspire. Similarly Eskimos, a Mongoloid people, have compact frames and tendency towards heaviness, which helps insulate them from their cold climate.

Although it is true that people can be differentiated by their inherited physical characteristics, racial identities are often more due to cultural factors than biological characteristics. According to **Alex Thio**, "race is not a biological or genetic fact, but a socially constructed myth". Race is socially defined on the basis of biologically determined characteristics. There is no statistically significant difference in the genetic makeup between racial groups, thus it is often said that race is socially constructed. There is in fact more genetic variation within a particular racial group than between racial groups. Nonetheless, the perception of racial differences is a powerful social force.

Since there are no clear-cut biological distinctions between racial groups - in physical characteristics or genetic makeup - sociologists define race as a social rather than a biological phenomenon. Defined sociologically, a race is a group of people who are perceived by a given society to be biologically different from others. People are assigned to one race or another not necessarily on the basis of logic or fact but by public opinion, which in turn, is molded by society's dominant group.

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More than "race", it is "racism" that is practiced through a false attribution of inherited characteristics of personality. Racism is an ideology which correlates the racial or physical characteristics of people with negative valuated social and psychological traits, and therefore gives rise to the idea of racial superiority. In other words, racism is an ideological orientation and a form of ethnocentrism in which it is maintained that one's own group is a distinct race that is inherently superior to other races.

In light of the disagreement among scholars with regard to the definition, identification and classification of pure races, the term 'ethnic group' is being more commonly used in contemporary sociological literature. The term 'ethnic group' refers to a collectivity or group of people who share common racio-cultural traits. Whereas race is based on popularly perceived physical traits, ethnicity is based on cultural characteristics. Sociologists use the term ethnic group to refer to any kind of group, racial or otherwise, which is socially identified as different and has developed its own subculture. In other words, an ethnic group is one recognized by society and by itself as a distinct group. An ethnic group, then, is a collection of people who share a distinctive cultural heritage. Member of an ethnic group may share a language, religion, history, or national origin. They always share a felling that they are a distinct people.

According to **Anthony Giddens**, an ethnic minority is the one:

1. sense of belonging together (group solidarity)
2. usually to some degree, it is physically and socially isolated from the large community (endogamy)
3. its members are disadvantaged, as a result of discrimination.

Sociologically, an ethnic minority is characterized by its experiences of prejudice and discrimination at the hands of the dominant group in modern plural societies. Prejudice comes from two Latin words, *prae* (before) and *judicum* (a judgement). It implies a judgement expressed before knowing all the facts. Prejudice is a negative attitude toward a certain category of people. Whereas prejudice is an attitude, discrimination is an act. More specifically, discrimination is an unfavourable action that is taken against certain individuals because they are members of a certain category. Sometime, even state may actively promote such discriminatory policies and programmes. Such prejudiced and discriminatory attitude toward ethnic minorities has serious implications on their access to opportunities and share in social resources.

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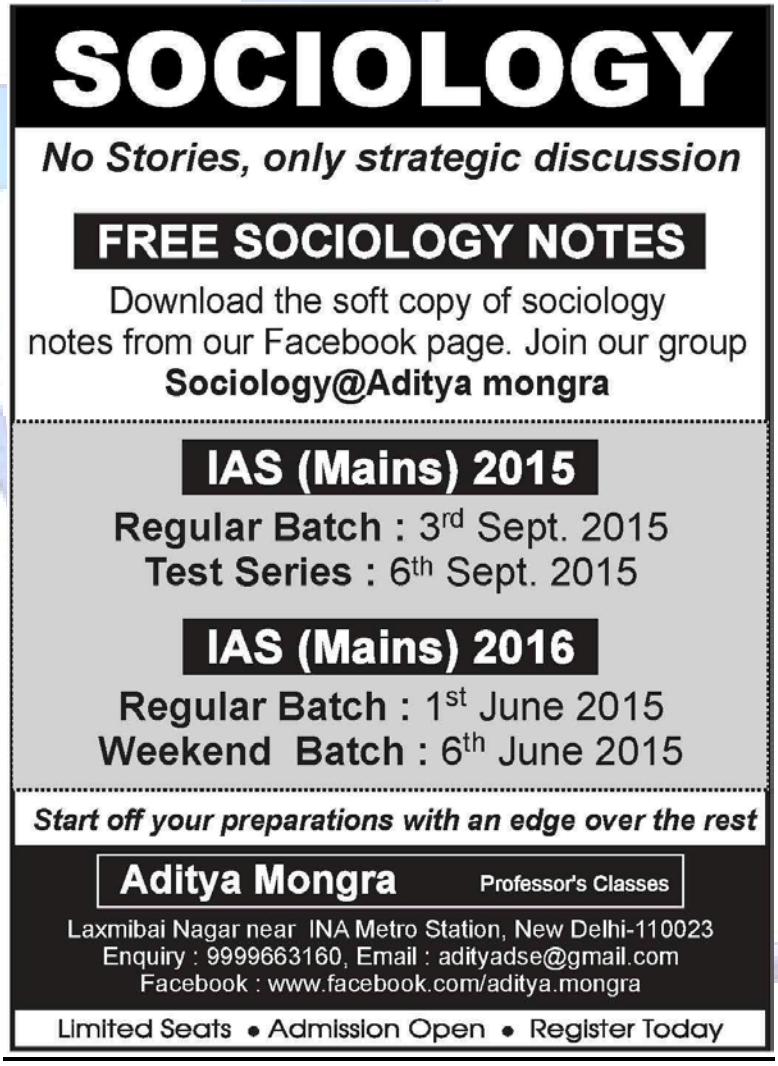
In most cases, however, ethnic differences overlap with socio-economic and political discrimination thus giving rise to ethnicity based inequality. For example, Muslims in India – low on educational parameters, government employment, political representation, etc. – Sachar committee report. However, in some cases, minorities are prosperous – Jews, Jains, Parsis, Sikhs, etc. – ahead in socio-economic indicators such as per capita income, gender equality, sex ratio, education, etc. This leads to inequality in society based on ethnicity, which in turn, gives rise to ethnic conflict.

Please note that an ethnic minority is not necessarily a small percentage of the population. Blacks are considered a minority in South Africa, even though they make up about 70% of the population, because they are the subordinate group. Similarly the dominant group need not make a large part of the population. People of English descent in the USA today constitute only about 13% of the population. But because of their continuing social and cultural influence, they are still considered the dominate group.



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Prejudice and discrimination against minorities may take many forms:

- **Segregation** – defined as the involuntary separation of residential areas, services or other facilities on the basis of the ethnic or racial characteristics of the people using them. For example, Jim Crow Laws in USA (1876-1965), separate hamlets for untouchables in the traditional caste society in India.

- **Expulsion** – forcing people out of an area. For example, in1970s, expulsion of non- Africans from Uganda by its President Idi Amin.

- **Partition** – Hindus and Muslims (India and Pakistan, 1947)

- **Annihilation** – the ultimate form of discrimination (Genocide). Genocide implies the deliberate and systematic extermination of an entire ethnic or racial group. For example, Hitler – extermination of Jews in Germany – "Holocaust".

Contemporary relevance: India – Hindus vs Muslims – communal riots
Bangladeshi migrants (Muslims) in Assam
Tamils in Sri Lanka

Remedial measures:

- **Policy of Affirmative Action (USA)** – The Civil Rights Acts of 1960, 1964 and 1968 outlawed discrimination. Government action against discrimination was followed by a policy of affirmative action, which required not only that there be no active discrimination but that positive preference be given to groups who are victims of past discrimination. It also requires employers and educational institutions to make special efforts to recruit qualified minorities for jobs, promotion and educational opportunities.

- **Welfare and social legislations** (cite examples)

Interlinking concepts: Relative Deprivation, Social Exclusion

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Religion and science

Science without religion is lame,
religion without science is blind.

\- **Albert Einstein**

According to Emile Durkheim, the essence of religion is a division of the world into the sacred and profane. The sacred is non- utilitarian and non-empirical in nature. Science, on the other hand, refers to a systematic body of certified and changing knowledge which is based upon observable and verifiable facts and the methods used to acquire this knowledge. Science is thus utilitarian and based on empirical observation (fact), while religion transcends empiricism and is based on faith.

British anthropologist, **James G. Frazer** in his major work *The Golden Bough* traced the gradual evolution of human thought, progressing from magic, through religion, to science. According to Frazer, the highest stage of cultural evolution is characterised by replacement of religious beliefs by scientific knowledge.

Religion and science, as alternate cognitive systems, offer explanations about the nature of reality and its aspects, both known and unknown. Religion and science generally pursue knowledge of the universe using different methodologies. Science acknowledges reason, empiricism and evidence, while religion includes revelation, faith and sacredness. In certain aspects, these explanations appear to be contradictory while in others they are complementary to each other.

The contradiction is rooted in the fact that the boundary between the known and unknown is the shifting one, given the rapid advancements in science and technology. What was unknown yesterday is known today. In the modern world, science has replaced many of the religious interpretations of the nature of the universe with tested – or potentially testable – rational theories. For example, the literal account of creation of universe in the Bible is challenged and supplanted by the finding of geology and the theory of evolution. **Copernicus** demolished the hypothesis of the geocentric (Earth-centred) universe and in its place he advanced the **heliocentric (Sun-centred) theory of universe.**

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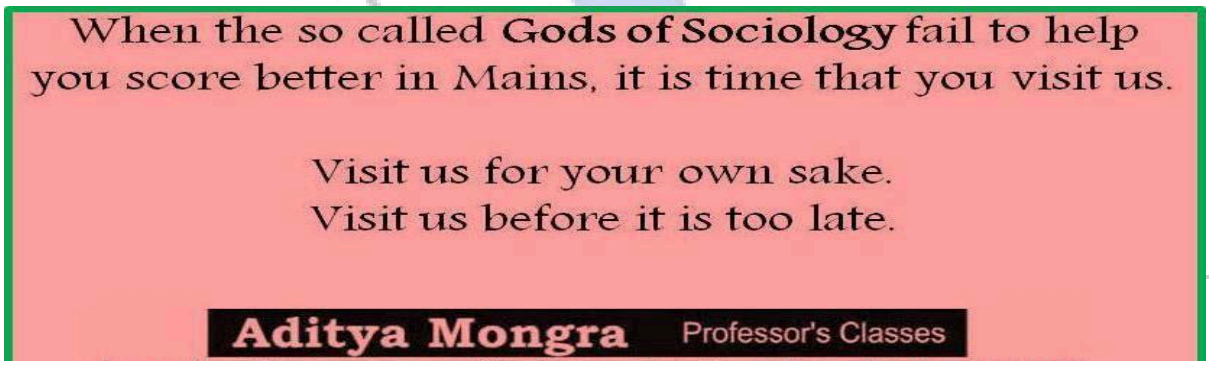
Further, the contradiction also underlies the orientation that guides these two cognitive systems. While religion is particularistic and collectivist, science tends to be universalistic and individualistic in nature. For example, religions such as Catholicism, Islam and Hinduism are largely collectivist in nature and repress heretical ideas.

However, religion has not always been hostile to science. As **Merton** argues that the 'golden age' of science, the 17th century in England, was brought about partly by the influence of the protestant ideas. **Weber** too, in his work, *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism* argues that an inner worldly-ascetic religious ideology leads to the rationalisation of social life and hence encourages individualism and secularisation in society, which in turn facilitates growth of science. Similarly, **Durkheim** and **Parsons** too argued that modern industrial societies, characterised by high degree of division of labour, and marked by rapid advancements in science and technology, would increasingly have secular institutions as the basis of their integration.

Answering to the debate on religion and science in modern societies, sociologist **Robin Williams** argued that '**neither mass religiosity nor complete secularisation appear to be permanent historical possibilities**'. There is good reason to believe that religion will never be at the center of modern societies, as it had been in almost every past society. **The rise of scientific secularism has not destroyed religion as some feared. Instead, people's need for reassurance and meaning has endured, and interest in religion now appears to be at a high level. While religious forms may change, religion survives.** There are human needs which only religion can fulfil. Despite phenomenal achievements of science, religion may become more important to people in modern society, in lending emotional support, giving a deeper meaning to their values, and helping them to express ultimate concern and commitment.



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To conclude it may be argued that despite the differences in orientations and methodologies, religion and science can play complementary function in modern societies. While on one hand, science, through its empirical research can help modify and correct various religious assumptions about the nature of physical and social reality, religion, on the other hand, can act as a moral guideline to scientific research. Science and scientific inventions can best serve the mankind when subjected to the moral force called religion.

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Religious Fundamentalism

According to **Schaefer** and **Lamm**, the term 'fundamentalism' refers to strict adherence to a set of principles or beliefs and is often accompanied by a literal application of historical beliefs and scriptures to today's world.

Religious fundamentalism is one of the forms of religious revivalism. But not every religious revivalism is fundamentalist in character. Religious fundamentalism describes the approach taken be religious groups which call for the literal interpretation of basic scriptures or texts and believe that the doctrines which emerge from such reading should be applied to all aspects of social, economic and political life. Religious fundamentalists believe that only one view - their own - of the world is possible and that this view is the correct one: there is no room for ambiguity or multiple interpretations. The term 'fundamentalist' refers to those who oppose any kind of deviation from religious orthodoxy.

Religious fundamentalism is also defined as a movement called for a return to the basic texts or 'fundamentals' of revealed religion. It encourages 'fixed identities' where 'slippages are suppressed' and 'sameness is prized'. It is commonly associated with the attempt to revive archaic modes of conduct and belief from the past. It is usually contrasted with modernism and liberalism in religion. It emphasizes the absolute truth of essential or 'fundamental' aspects of faith, especially those rooted in sacred texts such as the Christian Bible, the Islamic Quran or the Vedas of Hindus. These new trends in religion are sometimes termed as '**resurgent fundamentalism**', meaning the revival of a conservative approach to religion.

Religious fundamentalism is a relatively new phenomenon. It is only in the last two to three decades that the term has entered common usage. **It has arisen largely in response to globalization. As the forces of modernization progressively undermine traditional institutions of social organizations – such as family, community – fundamentalism has arisen in defence of traditional belief system.** Please notes that in the traditional societies, family, kinship, community, etc., served as a source of identity for the individual and the group as well as an agency for social solidarity social control.

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Hints:

Modernization – the term 'modernization' implies **the rational transformation of social, psychological, economic and political aspects of society**

– the process of modernization can either be an **indigenous process** – as in the case of western European societies – Renaissance – Scientific Revolution – Enlightenment – hence, modernization was a gradual process – allowed the various subsystems of society to develop, adapt and gradually evolve – without any drastic changes or major upheavals – alternative secular institutions evolved to take over the functions of social solidarity and social control that were performed earlier by the traditional institutions such as religion, family, kinship, etc.

– or, **by diffusion of ideas** or **acculturation** – as in the case of most of the third world societies – when the liberal ideas of equality, liberty, democracy, secularism, social justice, etc., of the west were introduced in the traditional societies which were deeply rooted in particularistic values and dominated by traditional institutions of religion, caste, race, ethnicity, family, kinship, etc. – it lead to **contra-acculturative response** in the form of religious fundamentalism – a reaction to foreign ideas which challenged the core values of the traditional culture and threatened the traditional basis of social solidarity and social control as well as leading to the **identity crisis** of the individuals or the social group – for example, India – which is marked by strong religious sentiments and particularistic values – manifested in the form of religious fundamentalism, communalism, caste-conflict, vote-bank politics, etc.

– relate it to the concepts of **alienation** (Marx), **anomie** (Durkheim), **structural strain** (Parsons and Merton), **formal and substantive rationality** (Weber).

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According to **Anthony Giddens**, religious fundamentalism can be understood in two ways:

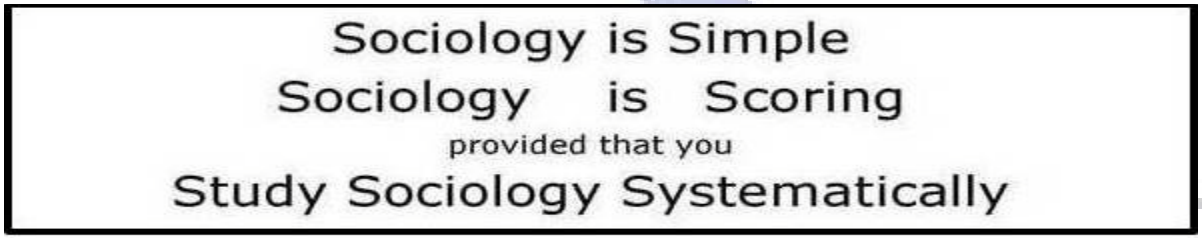
1. **revival of 'fundamentals'** – a conservative attempt in response to the moral crisis in society – degeneration of lifestyle.

For example, the growth of Christian fundamentalist religious organizations in the UK and Europe, but particularly marked in the United States, is one of the most notable features of the past few decades. Fundamentalists believe that 'the Bible, quite bluntly, is a workable guidebook for politics, government, business, families, and all of the affairs of mankind. The Bible is taken as infallible by fundamentalists – its contents are expressions of the Divine Truth. Fundamentalist Christians believed in the divinity of Christ and the possibility of the salvation of one's soul through the acceptance of Christ as personal saviour. Fundamentalist Christians are committed to spreading their message and converting those who have not yet adopted the same beliefs.

Christian fundamentalism is a reaction against liberal theology and supporters of secular humanism – those who favour the emancipation of reason, desires and instincts in opposition to faith and obedience to God's command.

According to **Anthony Giddens**, Christian fundamentalism emerged in response to 'moral crisis' wrought by modernization – the decline of traditional family, the threat to individual morality and the weakening of relationship between man and God.

For example, in the United States, Reverend Jerry Falwell's group **Moral Majority** (1970s) – later, in the United States, some fundamentalist groups became increasingly involved in what has been termed as the '**New Right Movement**' – some other fundamentalist groups in USA – **Southern Baptist Convention**, **Assemblies of God**, etc.



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2. as a **contra–acculturative response** – to rapid and uneven modernization in the societies of the third world.

Dear Candidate, **acculturation** refers to the modification of the culture of a group or an individual through contact with one or more other cultures and the acquiring or exchanging of culture traits. In other words, it refers to the process whereby an individual or a group acquires the cultural characteristics of another through direct contact and interaction. From an individual point of view this is a process of social learning. From a social point of view acculturation implies the diffusion of particular values, techniques and institutions and their modification under different conditions. It may give rise to culture conflict and to adaptation leading to a modification of group identity. Some scholars defined acculturation as 'those phenomena which result when groups of individuals having different cultures come into first hand contact, with subsequent change in the original cultural patterns of both groups.

Religious fundamentalism is more a characteristic feature of the traditional societies of the third world which are undergoing through a process of modernization, as a result of westernization and globalization. Religious fundamentalism can be better understood as a contra– acculturative response to the rapid and uneven modernization in the third world societies. This process can best be understood with the help of the concept of **cultural lag** given by **William F. Ogburn**.

The concept of cultural lag was introduced by Ogburn who applied it especially to modern industrial societies in which the **material culture** through rapid advances in technology and science has developed at much faster pace than the **non –material culture** (ideas, value, etc.) which regulates the man's adjustment to the material culture. The concept of 'cultural leg' suggests that there is a gap between the technical development of society and its moral and legal institutions. The failure of latter to keep pace with the former in certain societies is cited as the basic factor to explain social conflict and social problems.

According to Anthony Giddens, for example, Islamic fundamentalism plainly cannot be understood wholly in religious terms; it represents in part a reaction against the impact of the west and is a movement of national or cultural

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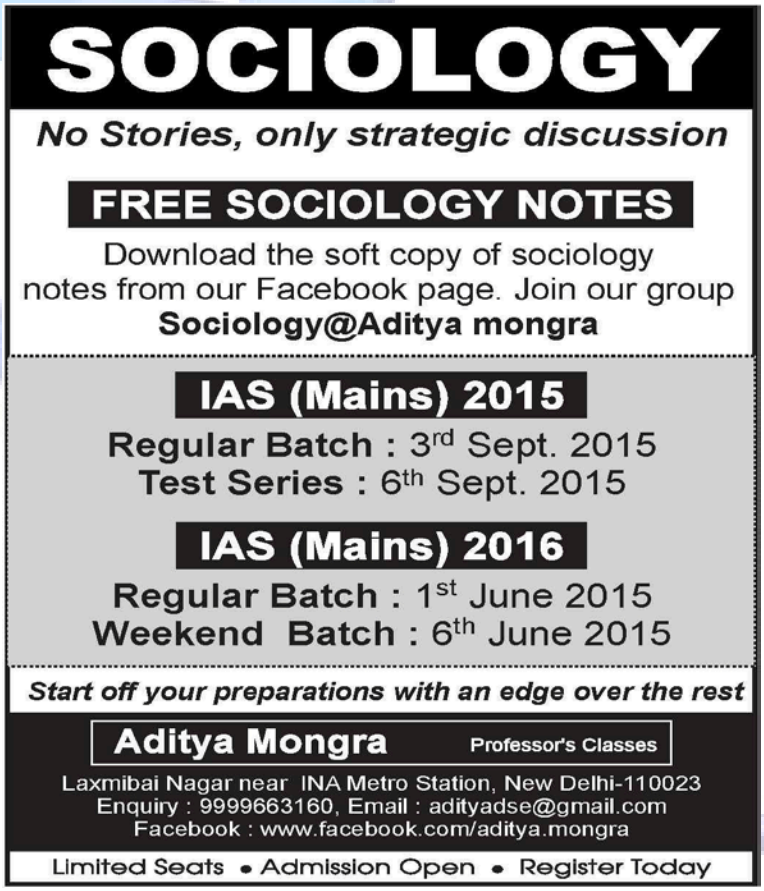
assertion. For example, the Islamic revolution in Iran (1979) was fuelled initially by internal opposition to the Shah of Iran who had accepted and tried to promote forms of modernization modeled on the west – for example, land reforms, extending the voting rights to women, secular education, etc. The most prominent leader of the Islamic revolution in Iran was Ayatollah Khomeini who provided a radical reinterpretation of Shiite ideas. Following the revolution, Khomeini established a government organised according to traditional Islamic law. Religion, as specified in the holy Quran, became the direct basis of all political and economic life. Under Islamic law – *sharia* – as it was revived, men and women are kept rigorously segregated, women are obliged to cover their bodies and heads in public, practicing homosexuals are sent to the firing squads and adulterers were stoned to death. The strict code is accompanied by a very nationalistic outlook, which sets itself especially against Western influences. The aim of the Islamic republic in Iran was to Islamize the state – to organize government and society so that Islamic teachings would become dominant in all spheres.



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Fundamentalism is sociologically important not only because of its unique place among religions, become it easily extends itself into political realm. There is an increasing entanglement of religion in politics around the globe. Despite its theological character, it is usually linked to projects of social reform and the acquisition of political power. In Middle East (Iran), Iraq, Afghanistan and more recently Egypt, Syria, Bangladesh, Indonesia, Pakistan, many countries of Europe and even that the most modernized the Unites States of America and to some extent India, religious fundamentalism has affected the political process and has given rise to conservative political movements and blind faith in nationalism.

Religious fundamentalists oppose secularization of society on one or the other basis. They sometimes even question about the removal of certain chapters from educational books. In recent years, there has been increasing effort by fundamentalists to censor books used in school curricula. In Islam, fundamentalists issue *fatwa* against those who go against the principle of Islam. For example, Ayatollah Khomeini of Iran issued one such *fatwa* against Salman Rushdie, the writer of *The Satanic Verses* in 1989. There have been several deaths apparently related to the *fatwa* at many places. In Britain and in some European countries, male Sikhs had come into conflict for wearing turban in public. Recently in France girls were banned to wear *burqua* in the school premises.

Fundamentalism is associated with a militant and sometimes violent attitude to enforcing 'moral purity' as defined by the fundamentalists. Frequently, fundamentalists seek to use the state to establish and enforce what they see as morality as we had seen in Taliban and Al-Qaeda (fundamentalist organizations) which controlled Afghanistan a few years back. Recently, some fundamentalist organizations banned yoga exercises in Far East countries like Indonesia. In Pakistan, a girl of sixteen years, Malala, was attacked by the fundamentalist organizations for attending school. Fundamentalist organizations compel people to act according to the respective religious doctrines rather than the state laws.

It is very interesting and striking that fundamentalists are using latest modern communication technology such as T.V., Radio, Internet, etc., to disseminate their ideas. While religious leaders directly attack many core values of the secular world, they are nevertheless willing to use its artifacts in their spiritual campaigns.

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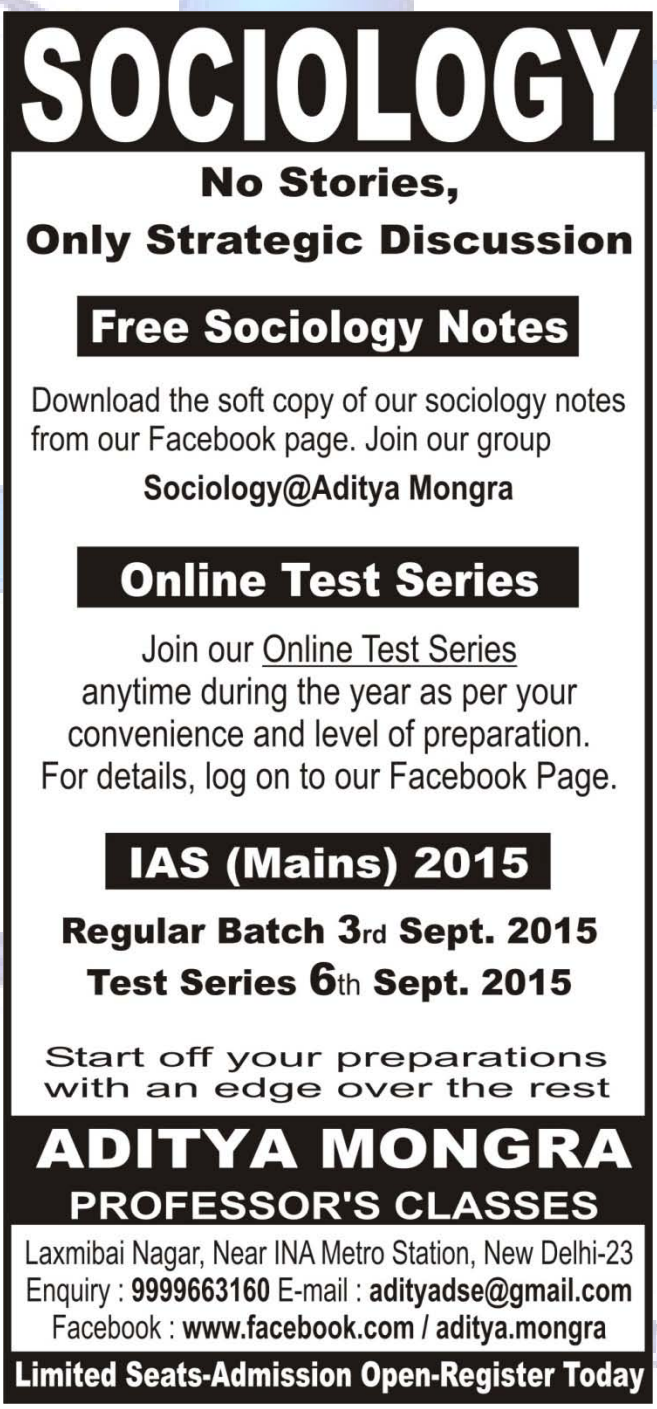
Sociologist **James Hunter** (1983) argues that fundamentalists see 'technology as either neutral and thus not challenging to their faith, or positive – as a gift of god to further his work on earth – and thus, an enhancement to faith.'



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Scope of Sociology and its comparison with other social sciences

Sociology is the study of man's behaviour in groups, or of interaction among human beings. It seeks to understand the nature and purpose of human association; the manner in which the various kinds of association arise, develop, and change; and the beliefs and practices that characterize them. Thus sociology is a scientific study of society and a variety of interactions that unfold within and between individuals and groups.

The principal task of sociology is to obtain and interpret the facts regarding human association, not to solve social problems. Its ultimate aim, however, is to improve man's adjustment to life by developing objective knowledge concerning social phenomena which can be used to deal effectively with social problems. In this respect sociology bears the same relation to the solution of social problems as, say, biology and bacteriology bear to medicine, or mathematics and physics to engineering. Without the research done in the theoretical and experimental sciences, modern techniques for curing disease or those for bridge-building would be impossible. Similarly, without the investigations carried on by sociology and the other social sciences, no really effective social planning or lasting solutions to social problems would be possible.

Sociology has been defined in a number of ways by different sociologists. Lester Frank Ward and William Graham Sumner defined it simply as "the science of society," and Franklin Henry Giddings as "the science of social phenomena." Sociology has also been defined as "the science of institutions" (Durkheim) and as "the science of social organization and social change" (Kovalevsky). Others have conceived of sociology as the science that studies human relationships (Simmel), as the study of "social action" (Weber) or of "social processes" (Small), or as "the science of collective behaviour" (Park).

The subject matter of sociology is society itself rather than the individual. Most sociologists, however, regard the study of the individual as essential to an understanding of society. Although sociology deals with problems involving values, sentiments, and interests very close to man's heart, it endeavors to keep aloof, to refrain from passing judgment as to the goodness or badness of a thing, its propriety or impropriety, its desirability or undesirability. It is ethically neutral. Sociology takes this attitude because of the conviction, long accepted in all science, that the true nature of any phenomenon cannot be discovered or cannot be adequately understood (and, hence, that the problems connected with it cannot be effectively solved) if the investigator makes up his mind in advance about the subject being investigated. In other words, it the investigator has predilections, he will tend to see the phenomenon or problem not as it actually is, but rather as he

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wishes it to be. Only an objective study can reveal the real nature and purpose of the phenomenon. Because of the lack of an objective approach many erroneous conclusions regarding social phenomena have been made. Of course, it is impossible to achieve complete objectivity in anything, particularly when dealing with human values, but a large measure of it can be attained with the proper effort and training.

In order to arrive at a complete, rounded picture of man, the sociologist is often obliged to draw upon findings of biology, psychology, anthropology, geography, and history. Furthermore, since man's social life cannot be divorced from his economic and political activities, the sociologist has to utilize the data made available by economics and political science. This dependence upon other discipline might give one the impression that sociology is a kind of parasite, living off the efforts of other sciences. As a matter of fact, these contributing sciences (particularly psychology, economics, and political science) are just as dependent, if not more so, upon the data and conclusions of sociology, for their special problems cannot be fully or satisfactorily understood apart from the more general social aspects of life with which sociology is chiefly concerned.

Sociology includes within its scope all of man's behaviour which may be called social. Since many different phases of social life have to be studied, the science of sociology can be subdivided into specialized areas of inquiry, each of which may employ techniques of its own. This subdivision was inevitable since no individual could possibly become expert in every phase of this ramified subject. The specialized areas of inquiry include such problems, phases of social life, and institutional forms as the origin and nature of human group life; the pattern of man's spatial distribution and the factors determining it; institutions, such as the family, school, and church; the nature of group behaviour; the community; and social problems, such as poverty, crime and delinquency, vice, and physical and mental disease. Then, too, since no science can exist and develop without cultivating a philosophy and methodology of its own, some sociologists devote their main attention to the philosophical and methodological aspects of the science.

Sociology is divided into several major fields. *Sociological Theory* analyzes principles, concepts, and generalizations of the science. *Historical Sociology* studies societies of the remote as well as of the recent past to discover origins of, and find explanations for, our present ways of life. *The Family* considers the origin, evolution, and function of this institution, the forms it has assumed in various periods of history and in different societies, as well as the contemporary problems connected with it. *Human Ecology and Demography* investigate the spatial distribution of human groupings (primarily communities and neighborhoods), their relationship to one another, and the forces determining their

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distribution and relationship, and also analyze population changes and movements. *The Community* (a field closely allied with and dependent upon ecology and demography) analyzes the organization and problems of both rural and urban types of communities. Since the problems of city and country are in many respects quite distinct, this field of study is subdivided into *Rural and Urban Sociology.*

Sociology of Religion studies the church as a social institution, inquiring into its origin, development, and forms, as well as into changes in its structure and function. *Educational Sociology* studies the objectives of the school as a social institution, its curricular and extracurricular activities, and its relationship to the community and its other institutions. *Political Sociology* studies the social implications of various types of political movements and ideologies and the origin, development, and functions of the government and the state. *Sociology of Law* concerns itself with formalized social control, or with the processes whereby members of a group achieve uniformity in their behaviour through the rules and regulations imposed upon them by society. It inquires into the factors that bring about the formation of regulatory systems, as well as into the reasons for their adequacies and inadequacies as a means of control. *Social Psychology* seeks to understand human motivation and behaviour as they are determined by society and its values. It studies the socialization process of the individual, i.e., how he becomes a member of society; it also studies the public, the crowd, the mob, and various other social groupings and movements. Analysis of mass persuasion, or propaganda, and or public opinion has been one of its major interests. *Social Psychiatry* deals with the relationships between social and personal disorganization, its general hypothesis being that society, through its excessive and conflicting demands upon the individual, is to a large extent responsible for personal maladjustments, such as various types of mental disorder and antisocial behaviour. In its applied aspects it is concerned with remedying this situation.

Social Disorganization deals with the problems of maladjustment and malfunctioning, including problems of crime and delinquency, poverty and dependency, population movements, physical and mental disease, and vice and prostitution. Of these subdivisions, crime and delinquency have received perhaps the greatest attention and have developed into the distinct field of *Criminology*. *Group Relations* is concerned with studying the problems arising out of the coexistence in a community of diverse racial and ethnic groups.

Although the foregoing are the main divisions of sociology, new areas and subareas are evolved as the problems coming within the scope of this science are explored more thoroughly and systematically, and as new techniques are devised and developed for dealing with them, Thus, in addition to the areas listed above, there are a number of others such as *Cultural Sociology, Folk Sociology,*

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Sociology of Art, *Industrial Sociology*, *Medical Sociology*, *Military Sociology*, *Sociology of Small Groups*, and such special topics as social stratification, mass media of communication, public opinion, and bureaucracy.

Sociology, therefore, is the study of social life as a whole. It has a wide range of concerns and interests. It seeks to provide classifications and forms of social relationships, institutions and associations, relating to economic, political, moral, religious and social aspects of human life.

Sociology has a long past but only a short history. Since the dawn of civilization, society has been a subject for speculation and inquiry, along with every other phenomenon that has agitated the restless and inquisitive mind of man. There is warrant, indeed, for saying that *The Republic of Plato* is the greatest of all sociological treatises in the West, and the *Analects* of Confucius in the East. But it is only within the last hundred years that the study of society has become a separate subject and a separate science.

All inquires were once a part of philosophy, that great mother of the sciences (*mater scientiarum*), and philosophy embraced them all in an undifferentiated and amorphous fashion. One by one, however, with the growth of Western civilization, the various sciences cut the apron strings, as it were, and began to pursue separate and independent courses. Astronomy and physics were among the first to break away, and were followed thereafter by chemistry, biology and geology. In the nineteenth century two new sciences appeared: psychology, or the science of human behaviour; and sociology, or the science of human society. Thus what had once been natural philosophy became the science of physics; what had been mental philosophy or the philosophy of mind, became the science of psychology; and what had once been social philosophy, or the philosophy of history, became the science of sociology. To the ancient mother, philosophy, still belong several important kinds of inquiry – notably metaphysics, epistemology, logic, ethics, and aesthetics – but the sciences themselves are no longer studied as subdivisions of philosophy.

Sociology as a science, and particularly as a separate field of study, did not make its appearance until about the middle of the nineteenth century. Emerging like other sciences, however, it was preceded by a series of attempts to explain human relations and behaviour, few, if any, of which could be strictly called scientific. "Social thought" existed, of course, in ancient times and thereafter, consisting now and then of systematic thinking and analysis, but based primarily upon speculation. In fact, this effort to understand the nature of social life may be regarded as having prepared the ground for the development of sociology as the scientific study of society. Perhaps the earliest attempts at systematic thought regarding social life, at least as far as Western civilization is concerned, may be

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said to have begun with the ancient Greek philosophers, particularly the great masters of human thought, **Plato** (427-347 B.C.) and **Aristotle** (384-322 B.C.). But their efforts were little more than profound reflections. This was inevitable, as their method of investigation consisted primarily of logical deduction. Now, logic is an indispensable tool, to be sure, in all orderly thinking, but in itself it is not a means of arriving at scientific truth, at an understanding of reality. Consequently, the labourious investigations of many of ancient sages resulted in blueprints, so to speak, of an ideal state, a Utopia where unruffled peace and justice prevail. Aristotle showed a more realistic but, in the main, he succeeded only in drawing up the prerequisites, arrived at mainly through the syllogistic process, of the ideal social order. Moreover, the ideal social order which these two thinkers described was mainly an idealization of the society in which they lived.

Social thought of this prescientific kind, with few exceptions, advanced very little between the time of Plato and Aristotle and early modern times. The works that could lay claim to any systematic social thought at all during and immediately preceding the Middle Ages reflected the teachings of the Church and were for the most part metaphysical speculations regarding the place of man on earth. In any case, none of the thinkers associated with those eras thought of themselves, and few are now thought of, as sociologists. However, there was one exception as discussed by George Ritzer in his book *Sociological Theory*. This refers to one **Abdel Rahman Ibn-Khaldun** (1332-1406), born in Tunis, North Africa. He challenged the divine theory of kingship. In his book '*Muqadimma*', he presented his ideas which are quite similar to the present day sociology. For example, he was committed to the scientific study of society, empirical research, and the search for causes of social phenomena. He devoted considerable attention to various social institutions (for example, politics, economy, etc.) and their interrelationships. He stressed the importance of linking sociological thought and historical thought.

However, barring this one exception, it was not until the sixteenth century that there appeared writers who treated life's problems on a more realistic level. Perhaps the most notable among these was the Italian **Niccolo Machiavelli**, in whose work, *The Prince*, published in 1513, we find an attempt at an objective discussion of the state and statecraft. This book, unlike his other works, was devoted chiefly to an exposition of the principles governing the successful state, or rather the successful ruler of a state. It is a practical guide for the ruler who would maintain his power. Insofar as Machiavelli sought to base his theories of the state upon historical data, he may be considered in a sense an objective writer. Another author in this period worth noting was **Sir Thomas More**. Although his book *Utopia*, Published in 1515, represented an approach virtually the opposite of that found in Machiavelli's writings, it was nevertheless a step in the direction of dealing with everyday social problems, albeit by means of depicting an ideal social

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order which presumably was presented for emulation. More's *Utopia* pictured a perfect state where all the problems with which society, or rather the England of his day, was beset, have been solved and where complete justice reigns. This perfect society is made possible by putting into practice the rules of natural law. More's technique of presenting a picture of the ideal life as a way of pointing out what real life ought to be was utilized by several other writers among them Thomasso Campanella, in his *City of the Sun*, Sir Francis Bacon, in his *New Atlantis*, and James Harrington, in his *Commonwealth* of *Oceana*.

Considerable strides toward the objective analysis of social forces were made in the writings of the Italian **Vico** and the Frenchman **Montesquieu**, who, while primarily political philosophers, had considerable influence upon the consequent rise of a science of society. Giovanni Battista Vico in his book *The New Science*, contended that society was subject to definite laws which can be discovered through objective observation and study. Charles Louis de Secondat Montesquieu exerted an even greater influence than Vico in the direction of scientific investigation of social phenomena through his brilliant works, particularly his *Esprit des lois (The Spirit of Laws),* which presents a keen analysis of the role certain external factors, especially climate, play in the life of human societies. To these two writers may be added two more, **Condorcet** and **Saint-Simon**, whose contributions toward the development of a science of society were even more direct. In his *Historical Sketch of the Progress of the Human Mind,* Marie Jean Antonie Condorcet formulated a theory of social change which had a far-reaching influence upon later sociological theories. In this book he propounded a stage theory of social evolution, according to which civilization passed through ten developmental stages, each higher than the preceding one, the highest still to be attained in the future. Claude Henri Comte de Saint-Simon, though primarily a utopian reformer, insisted that social reform can be achieved only when scientific or "positive" data have been collected. These four writers, although their contributions were primarily in the field of political thought and philosophy, may be considered among the forerunners of sociology.

It was in the nineteenth century that a French philosopher named **Auguste Comte** (1798-1857) worked out, in a series of books, a general approach to the study of society. He believed that the sciences follow one another in a definite and logical order and that all inquiry goes through certain stages, arriving finally at the last, or scientific, stage. He thought that it was time for inquiries into social problems and social phenomena to enter the last stage and so he recommended that the study of society become the science of society. The name that Comte gave to this new science was "sociology", and this, from a number of points of view, was an unfortunate choice. "Sociology" is composed of two words; *socius*, meaning companion or associate; and *logos*, meaning word. Thus, the term

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formed from these two parts means talking about society, as geology (*geos*, earth) means talking about the earth; biology (*bios*, life), talking about life; and anthropology (*anthropos*, man) talking about man. Unfortunately, however, *socius* is a Latin word and *logos* is a Greek word, and the name of our discipline is thus an "illegitimate" offspring of two languages. John Stuart Mill, another philosopher and social thinker of the nineteenth century, proposed the word "ethology" for some part of the new science. This term has the merit of being all Greek, but apparently it never appealed to other writers. When, in the latter half of the century, an Englishman, **Herbert Spencer** (1820-1903) developed his systematic study of society and frankly adopted the word "sociology" in the title of his work - on the ground that "the convenience and suggestiveness of our symbols are of more importance than the legitimacy of their derivation" – it became the permanent name of the new science, and sociology, especially with Spencer's own contributions, was well launched on its career.

Auguste Comte is traditionally considered to be the father of sociology. He is regarded as such not because of any significant contributions to the science, but rather because of the stimulating effect he had upon it. Comte is credited with the coining of the term "sociology" (in 1839) and with having defined the scope of this social science and the methods which it should employ. Judging him by his extensive work, we must regard him as a sociologist. Comte devoted his main efforts to an inquiry into the nature of human knowledge, a gigantic task which he performed with singular brilliance, seeking to classify all knowledge and to analyze the methods of achieving it. His major labours were directed toward determining the nature of human society and the laws and principles underlying its growth and development, as well as the methods to be employed in studying social phenomena. He saw the needs for the creation of a distinct science of society, which he at first called "social physics" and, later, "sociology," that should concern itself with an analysis and explanation of social phenomena.

Comte's chief work is his *Cours de philosophie positive (Positive Philosophy)*, published in six volumes, during 1830-1842. It formulated his theory of the three stages through which human knowledge develops, namely, the Theological, the Metaphysical, and the Positive, or empirical. Comte maintained that only when this last stage has been reached is real science possible. In the Positive stage, objective observation is substituted for speculation and there is a concentration upon the discovery of causal relationships. Social phenomena, like physical phenomena, he asserted, can be studied objectively by employing the positive method. He thus blazed the trail for a science of society – for sociology.

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Sociology came into its own as an autonomous discipline with the appearance of the sociological works of the Englishman Herbert Spencer, who is considered one of the most brilliant intellects of modern times. He undertook to create what Comte had merely indicated as desirable – an all encompassing science of society. This resulted in a multivolume work, called *Synthetic Philosophy*, the chief sociological part of which is the *Principles of Sociology*. Spencer employed the inductive method in his study of social phenomena; he arrived at his conclusions after an examination and analysis of data based mainly upon what was then known of the life of primitive man. One of his most noteworthy theories was that social phenomena, or the "superorganic," as he termed them, like the organic, undergo an evolutionary process of growth from the simple and homogeneous to the complex and heterogeneous. Primitive man to him represented the simple human type from which civilized man evolved. Another significant contribution of his is the so-called *organic analogy*, in which society is compared with the human organism. Spencer was influenced by theory of evolution of his contemporary Charles Darwin, although to an extent he also anticipated it. Many of Spencer's theories had to be greatly modified or even abandoned in the course of the development of sociology, but the contributions of this pioneer can hardly be exaggerated.

In the next section, let us explore the relationship of sociology with other social sciences. As stated earlier, sociology is nothing but a scientific study of society. But, as we know that man's social life cannot be divorced from his economic and political activities, the sociologist has to utilize the data made available by economics, political science, history, psychology and other social science disciplines, in order to arrive at a comprehensive understanding of the social phenomena. Particularly with the rise of interdisciplinary approach and growing interdependency of these disciplines, it would be useful to have a look at the nature of these disciplines and their relationship with sociology.

Sociology and Anthropology:

Anthropology is a study of the biological and socio-cultural aspects of human beings. It is a scientific study of man in all its dimensions, both biological and socio-cultural. The branch of anthropology that studies the biological aspects of humankind is called physical or biological anthropology, while the study of social and cultural aspects is known as social anthropology. In the United States of America, this branch is, however, known as cultural anthropology. The third branch of anthropology is a study of languages in a comparative perspective. It is known as linguistic anthropology or anthropological linguistics. The branch of anthropology that studies the pre-historic past of mankind, before writing began, is

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called archaeological anthropology or pre-historic archaeology. Of the four branches of anthropology, sociology is most closely related to social anthropology.

It is often said that although sociology and social anthropology had quite different origins (the one in the philosophy of history, political thought, and the social survey, the other in physical anthropology and ultimately in biology) they are now practically indistinguishable. Sociology as a subject came into existence during the late eighteenth and early nineteenth century. Social anthropology had its beginnings as a discipline during the second half of the nineteenth century but it came to occupy a respectable place in the first half of the twentieth century. Initially, there was a period of extreme divergence when the functional approach was generally adopted in anthropology while sociology (at least in the European countries) continued to be historically oriented and concerned with problems of social development; and that finally, in recent years, there has been a new convergence of the two disciplines.

The division of labour that traditionally developed was that sociology concentrated on the study of complex, modern, and urban-industrial societies, whereas social anthropology studied tribal, peasant, and pre-literate societies of the world, those societies that were largely untouched by the forces of civilization. In the beginning, sociologists studied the societies which were their own, while anthropologists studied societies that were different from theirs. This was the reason why sociology came to be regarded as the study of one's own society, while anthropology earned the reputation of being the study of 'other cultures'. In other words, the broad differences between sociology and social anthropology that emerged during the period of divergence can easily be related to differences in the object of study. Social anthropologists, once field work had become a fundamental requirement, were involved in studying small societies, of a very different character from their own societies, relatively unchanging, and lacking historical records. The methods followed from these facts; such societies could be observed as functioning wholes, they could be described and analysed in ethically neutral terms since the anthropologist as an outsider was in no way involved in their values and strivings, and since they changed little and had no records of past changes, a historical approach was unnecessary and more or less impossible. The distinction between sociology and social anthropology could be applied without much problem where the different between the 'our' and 'their' societies, i.e. between 'civilized' and 'primitive' societies, was huge and perceptible. For example, it was the case in America, Australia, New Zealand, or Africa, where the native population was totally different from its white colonizers.

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However, due to forces of industrialization, urbanization and globalization, this situation has now radically altered. Many if not most primitive societies are changing under the influence of Western ideas and technology, larger groupings are beginning to predominate over tribal societies, and social and political movements are developing which involve the social anthropologist in the same kind of value problems which the sociologist has had to face in studying his own society, or societies of the same civilization. For example, both sociologist and anthropologists have to face the fact of revolutionary movements in the Third World. In brief, we can see that the object of study now is societies in the process of economic growth and social change, and thus an object for both the sociologist and the social anthropologist, who work increasingly in Africa and Asia upon the same kinds of problems. It should be added that as primitive societies, regarded as the preserve of the social anthropologist, have more or less disappeared, so to some extent the special prerogatives of the sociologist in studying advanced societies have been challenged. There is an increasing number of anthropological studies in advanced societies; studies of the 'little community', of kinship groups, etc. Sociology and social anthropology are still divided by differences of terminology, approach and method but there is both convergence and a desire to further it. With the passage of time, social anthropologists have included within their orbit of study to societies, such as urban and industrial, that were supposed to be studied by sociologists. It all happened because tribal societies were on their way to transformation because of urbanization and industrialization. At the same time, sociology has increased it scope to include tribal and peasant societies. The outcome of all this is that in so far as the subject matters of sociology and social anthropology are concerned, there is hardly any distinction.

We should also note that, among contemporary societies, there is a third very important category of those which are neither primitive nor industrially advanced. In such societies, of which India may be taken as an example, the distinction between sociology and social anthropology has little meaning. Sociological research in India, whether it is concerned with the caste system, village communities or the process of industrialization and its effects, is and should be carried out by sociologist and social anthropologists.

Because at one time, sociology and social anthropology specialized in the study of different types of societies, they contributed to the development of different theoretical interests. Sociologists have made significant contribution to survey methods of data collection, whereas anthropologists' contribution has been to fieldwork methodology. Anthropologists have contributed immensely to the understanding of kinship and religion, because these two have been institution of crucial importance in simple societies. To the understanding of social stratification, education, and urban-industrial society, the contribution of sociologists is

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unparalleled, because these institutions are of primary importance in modern societies. These specializations apart, there are more similarities between sociology and social anthropology than are between either of them and other social sciences. Both studied human society in a holistic manner, and attempted to generalize. Both were comparative in nature. In fact, a French sociologist Emile Durkheim called anthropology as 'comparative sociology'. Social anthropology was considered a branch of sociology, or better, as a 'sociology of primitive societies'.

Sociology and History:

Both, sociology and history are social science disciplines and both are concerned with human activities and events. The relationship between sociology and history is also connected with another question, whether sociology is a science of society, like one of the natural and biological science, or a kind of history writing (historiography). Sociologists of the nineteenth and early twentieth century thought that sociology was a 'natural science of society'. But later, the weaknesses of this view started surfacing, and sociologist felt that there was no doubt that their subject was social science.

History is a study of the past, which people have already lived. Data for historians come in the form of records from archives, museums, libraries, and personal collections of people. Historians of ancient times also study inscriptions. Historical data may not be complete. Some might have been destroyed, lost, stolen or inaccessible. Therefore, historians have to build up their interpretations of the past on the limitations of the material.

Sociologists must hold up the past to understand the present. What is common between sociology and history is the society. Sociology is concerned with the present and to some extent with future. History studies the past. The present society cannot be analyzed without reference to the past society; and it is here that these are related to each other. This has given rise to a special kind of sociology and history i.e. historical sociology. According to this, sociological analysis is based on historical data. This is primarily done by the use of primary sources available in archives or by the use of written history.

Historians are concerned with specific societies. They tell about the system that prevailed in a society at a particular time. Whatever comparisons historians make are of limited scale. They may compare societies inhabiting the same area, but vast comparisons of societies different in scale and time are beyond the scope of history. Therefore, historians rarely attempt to generalize about human society as a whole. They provide a detailed account of a specific social situation. By comparison, sociology is principally concerned with the study of contemporary

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societies. Sociologists not only refer to the historical data but they also generate their own data by studying various contemporary societies, for which the term 'primary data' is used. Primary data can be collected through various methods of sociological research such as, survey, questionnaire, interview, schedule, field work (including both participant and non-participant observation), focus group discussion, etc. As a result, collected data by sociologist are more comprehensive than the historian who has to content himself with whatever is available.

The essential difference between history and sociology is that the former is concerned with the past, the latter is mainly concerned with present day societies. While history does not concern itself with contemporary societies, sociology certainly extends its frontiers to include past societies in its scope. The other significant difference is that the historian interests himself in the particular character of events over a period of time. The sociologist is interested in the regular and the recurrent social phenomena; generally, we may say that history occupies itself with the differences in similar events and sociology deals with the similarities in different events. History seeks to establish the sequence in which events occur; it is the arrangement of social events in time. Sociologist is concerned with relationship between events occurring more or less at the same time. Historians generally restrict themselves to the study of the past, from the more recent to the remotest one. Sociologist shows interest in the contemporary scene or the recent past. Sociologist seeks to know the inter-relations between events with a view to propose causal sequences. The historian prides himself on the explicitness and concreteness of details. The sociologist abstracts from concrete reality; and then categorizes and generalizes about the observed phenomena.

To summarize we may say that while sociology is an observational, comparative, and generalizing science, history, on the other hand, is a particularizing or individualizing discipline. Sociology is an analytical disciplines where as history is a descriptive discipline. Sociology emphasizes on the regular and the recurrent where as history investigates the unique and the individual. An event that has occurred only once in the human past is of no sociological significance unless it can be related to a pattern of events that repeats itself generation after generation, historical period after historical period and human group after human group.

Sociology and Political Science:

Political science is also known as the 'science of government' or the 'science of polity or politics'. Political science studies political institutions such as the state, government, political parties, executive, legislative and judicial institutions. Political science also studies behaviour of the people in power. Thus,

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the concept of power is important. Political science can be defined as a study of power. Power is the ability of a person or a group to control or influence the behaviour of others despite their resistance. 'Authority' refers to the power that is legitimized and institutionalized in a society. This form of power is attached to a social status and is accepted as proper and legitimate by all members of the society.

Sociology also studies power in terms of its social contexts. In other words, the processes which enable a man or a group to wield power and exercise dominance in society - are the focal points of study in sociology. Thus, the stratification of society in terms of power by different groups, castes, classes and tribal groups becomes the basis of sociological analysis. The interface of political science and sociology can be termed as political sociology. Political sociology, in fact, acts as a bridge between political science and sociology.

Political science generally studies the complex, advanced, and modern societies; in other words, those societies that have the machinery of state and written law. It is concerned with larger systems, i.e. whole societies and their political states. Sociology studies all types of societies, irrespective of whether they happen to be classified as 'tribal', 'peasant', or 'urban-industrial'. It is comparative in nature. It also gives information about the distribution of power in those societies (tribal and peasant) that political scientists do not study. For instance, sociologists and social anthropologists also study those societies that were without the institution of state. They were called the stateless societies. One of the outstanding examples of which was the Nuer of the Sudan. Anthropologists described how in stateless societies order was maintained. The absence of state does not imply the absence of deviance and conflict. Each society has its own procedures to handle the cases of the breakdown or rules and customs. Sociology supplements the understanding of political scientists by providing information about the mechanisms of social control in simple societies.

Sociology is devoted to the study of social aspects of society, whereas political science restricts itself mainly to the study of power as embodied in formal organizations. Sociology stresses upon the inter-relations between institutions such as state, government, political parties, whereas as political science focuses its attention on the governmental processes. Nevertheless, political sociology has for long shared with political science, many of the common interests and a very similar style. If we look at the relationship between political science and sociology in India, the study of caste and the role it plays in electoral politics would give useful insights. How caste becomes an interest group and an instrument of mobilization? This has brought sociology close to political science in particular.

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Sociology and Economics:

Economics studies the aspects of production, distribution and exchange, and consumption in society. It begins with the observation that resources are scarce and limited whereas human needs are unlimited. Hence, there is a need to strike a balance between limited resources and unlimited needs and wants. The strategy human beings adopt is to make the best use to the resources available with them, and at the same time, put a check on one's needs. The process of striking a balance between the two, resources and needs, is called economization, and the science of economics studies this.

Today, economics is regarded as the most developed of all social science. It has been able to develop both the traditions of qualitative and quantitative research. One of the branches of economics is called econometry, which is concerned with a quantitative assessment of economic phenomena. Compared to the other social sciences, including psychology, modem economics is highly mathematical.

Thus, the economist concentrates on the study of economic behaviour of the people, while the sociologist is interested in the study of sociology of economic life, such as income, occupation, consumption patterns and styles of life etc. The sociologist critically examines the limitations of economic theory and makes contribution to the study of economic phenomena.

Economics concentrate upon the study of economic systems in modern, complex, and urban-industrial societies. Economics looks at modern economic institutions (finance, banking, market) in a comparative perspective, aiming to arrive at general propositions. Although it recognizes the role of social factors (such as kinship, religion, values) in influencing economic behaviour of man, it considers them as essentially 'irrational', which tend to slow, or even retard the growth of economy. It asserts that for developing economy, one has to take rational decisions because they will lead to gains and profits. Each economic system is based on the principle to the maximization of gains and returns. Thus, economics is primarily concerned with the relationship between demands and supply in a society, the rational use of resources for fulfilling one's needs and the issues of economic development.

However, for sociologist, economic institution is one of the several institutions of human society. He examines the functioning of the economic institution in relationship with other institutions of society such as social, political, religious and cultural institutions. The contribution that social factors make to economics is examined in detail in sociology. Sociologists submit that social factors exercise a tremendous impact on the decisions people make with respect to

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resources, their use and distribution. The factors that seem irrational to economists are in fact, quite meaningful from the perspective of people. From their studies in tribal and peasant societies, sociologists have confirmed this point. In many societies, people indulge in what is called 'wasteful expenditure' but this is done knowingly to enhance one's prestige and honour.

Sociologists look at the social aspects of economy. In this term, their work is different from that of the economist, who is mainly concerned with the economic consequences of people's actions. For instance, Adam Smith, a foremost economist, explained that division of labour in society came when there was need to have mass production. Adam Smith argued that if there had to be more production, division in society had to come. Thus, for him the division of labour in the society was required for mass production. Division of labour brings about differentiation and social ranking in terms of differential wages and rewards. However, eminent sociologist Emile Durkheim took a different view on division of labour. He argued that transformation of mechanical (simple) society into organic (complex) society was not for large scale production but it was a need of the society itself. Increased population, differentiated needs and rules and regulations necessitate division of labour.

Economic and sociology have a two-way relationship in general. There is much give and take between the two. For instance, anthologists have described the exchange theory in terms of marriage relations drawing from the property system. The origin of caste has also been analyzed in terms of economic division of labour reflected through *jajmani* system. Thus, the relations between economic and sociology are deep rooted.

Sociology and Psychology:

Sociology is the scientific study of modern society. It studies the behaviour of people in groups. In other words, it takes a macro level perspective in its study of behaviour. Psychology, on the other hand, takes a micro level perspective and studies the individual behaviour. The intimate interaction between sociology and psychology has given birth to a hybrid discipline 'social psychology', which studies the behaviour of the people in group settings but the focus is always on the individual.

The individual and society are the two main concepts in social sciences. Society is defined as an enduring set of relations between persons. It is an aggregation of individuals, which is different from a crowd. Each individual of a society has its own identity, autonomy, and mental makeup. This would explain why there is a variation between the behaviours of two individuals belonging to

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the same society. The knowledge about how one should behave comes from society. The individual internalizes this knowledge and behaves accordingly. However, while putting this knowledge into action, the individual introduces the element of variation. Even when it is the same kind of situation, each individual will behave differently.

The discipline that focuses upon the individual is known as psychology. It studies the mental structure of the individual, his memory, intelligence, deep-rooted complexes and psychological problems, etc. In other words, psychology tries to understand why an individual behaves in the manner he does. It studies psychic (or mental) facts. It addition to a qualitative assessment, psychology makes a lot of use of quantitative techniques, for it measures phenomena is precise terms. For understanding certain psychological phenomena, knowledge of the human biological system is also required. Thus, psychology pays a lot of attention to the understanding of human body, especially the nervous system.

The branch of psychology that studies the behaviour of people in a situation of crowd or mob is called social psychology. Crowd behaviour is often called collective behaviour, which is the subject matter of psychology, and is distinguished from behaviour that takes place in enduring groups and institutions (such as neighbourhood, family). The latter is called social behaviour, the study of which is the subject matter of sociology. Social psychology lies in between sociology and psychology.

If psychology is the study of psychic facts, the facts that pertain to the mental structure of the individual, sociology is the study of social facts. An example will clarify the distinction between sociology between and psychology. Suppose, a law court is in session, and the accused, lawyers, and judges are discussing the case. The rules according to which they would decide the case are of interest to sociologists. The rights and duties of each of the members involved in the judicial process are also of sociological interest. In short, sociologists are interested in the totality of the judicial process. But, of interest to psychologists is what goes in the minds of people engaged in the court proceedings. That is the reason why sociologists make a distinction between social and psychic facts, the former are studied by sociologists and the latter, by psychologists.

Here, we should note that the concepts of status and role, link the disciplines of psychology and sociology. Status is usually defined as the rank or position of a person in a group, or of a group in relation to other group. Role is the behaviour expected of one who holds a particular status. However, Theodore M. Newcomb made a distinction between the expected behaviour (prescribed role) related to a position or status and the actual behaviour (role behaviour). He pointed out that the

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way in which a person behaves may not always be what is expected of him. That is to say, sometimes a person's actual behaviour may not conform to his expected role. Newcomb regards 'prescribed role' as a sociological concept and 'role behaviour' as a psychological concept. Thus, the concepts of status and role link society with individual, and in turn, they establish a link between sociology and psychology.

Sociology and Philosophy:

Philosophy, in literal sense, implies enquiry or search for knowledge about life and the universe. Sociology originated largely in a philosophical ambition; to account for the course of human history, to explain the social crisis of the European nineteenth century, and to provide a social doctrine which would guide social policy. In its recent development sociology has for the most part abandoned such aims; and some would say that it has abandoned them too completely. However this may be, there remain connections between sociology and philosophy in at least three respects. First, there can be, and is, a philosophy of sociology in the sense of philosophy of science; that is, an examination of the methods, concepts, and arguments used in sociology. And this philosophical scrutiny is more common and more needful in sociology than in, for example, the natural sciences, because of the peculiar difficulties experienced with sociological concepts and reasoning. Secondly, there is a close relationship between sociology and moral and social philosophy. The subject matter of sociology is human social behaviour, which is directed by values as well as by impulses and interests. Thus the sociologist studies values and human valuations, as facts. But he should also have some acquaintance with the discussion of values, in their own context, in moral and social philosophy. Only by some training in social philosophy can the sociologist become competent to distinguish the different issues, and at the same time to see their relationships to each other. Thirdly, it may be held that sociology leads on directly to philosophical thought. All that is intended here is to suggest that sociology raises, to a greater extent than other social sciences, philosophical problems, and consequently that the sociologist who is at all concerned with the larger aspects of his subject is led on to consider philosophical issues which are always in the background of sociological reflection. It is not, in my view, at all harmful to sociological theory or research that the sociologist should interest himself in such problems and should seek to acquire a philosophical education which will equip him to deal with them, for much of the weakness of sociological theory is due to philosophical naivete, and much of its triviality comes from disregard of the larger issues involved in any study of man. The vigour and the stimulating character of early Marxism in the field of social research was due in large measure to the fact that Marxism was not only a sociological theory but a philosophical world view and a revolutionary doctrine.

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Sociology and Social Work:

The relation between sociology and social work is like the relation between a 'pure science' and an 'applied science'. Social work is concerned with the 'technology of application' of ideas for improving human lot. Social work is essentially an American interest. It grew out of a concern for human welfare. In the early twentieth century, it was realized that social scientists were mainly concerned with acquiring knowledge about the working of society and leading a philosophical dialogue on it. The question of the ideal society also figured. But which technology should be adopted for building it up was not given a serious thought. As changes were taking place in the society of the twentieth century, the gap between the poor and the rich was fast increasing. Groups of people who were leading the life of a destitute were also emerging. Against this background, the central question was how to improve upon the condition of people. Knowledge was of no significance unless it was put to use. Social work was a product of this background. It charted out the suitable technology for human upliftment. But, for any type of action, it is essential to have a complete knowledge of the social situation, and sociology provided such knowledge. Therefore, social work is dependent upon sociological insights. Sociology generates holistic knowledge about society. It also discusses the possibility of applying this knowledge. The branch of sociology that takes up the areas of application is called applied sociology. Between sociology and social work lies applied sociology. Let us now understand the difference between social work and applied sociology. The latter is an attempt to explore the areas where sociological knowledge may be put to use, but sociologists themselves do not carry out the action. What should be the nature of action and how it should be carried out are the areas that interest sociologists. Social workers, on the other hand, not only plan action but they also carry it out. Therefore, social work, truly speaking, is an applied area; it is the 'technology of action'.

Thus, being a social science, sociology shares a wide variety of commonality with other social sciences. This commonality is because of the fact that in order to build a theoretical framework for the society, man has to be studied in totality. The commonalities are in terms of data and method but there are differences also in the approach of study and in the perspectives adopted for study. Sociology has many similarities with other social sciences. It is concerned with history, economics and political science as it studies the bearing of the present on the past, political and economic aspects of social life. Sociology also studies the impact of historical events, state, government and economy on social life of the people. Despite this two-way relationship, sociology has its distinct nature and scope of study.

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Secularization

Secularism is a modern value and is understood as the anti-thesis of communalism. Secularism as an ideology emerged from the dialectic of modern science and religious reformation in modern Europe.

However, in contemporary debates, the concept of secularism is subjected to two different interpretations. These two interpretations are that of secularism as the **separation of state and religion**, and secularism as **equality of all religions**.

The first interpretation holds that –

a) the state shall not concern itself with religious beliefs, practices and institutions;

b) that the state shall not be associated with a particular religion;

c) that the state shall permit freedom of conscience, belief and religion for all its citizens; and

d) that the state shall not discriminate between citizens on the basis of their religious beliefs.

This understanding of secularism comes to us from the history of Western Europe, during the course of which the domain of state policy and that of religion was separated. In particular, it has come to us from the U.S.A., in the formulation of President Thomas Jefferson that a 'wall of separation' exists between the state and religion. Jefferson in effect referred to the First Amendment to the constitution of the U.S.A. The Establishment Clause in the First Amendment prohibits the establishment of a national religion by the Congress, and prohibits preference for one religion over another. The clause also meant that government should not prefer one religion to another, or religion to irreligion. The second part of the clause, known as the 'Free Exercise Clause', states that the Congress cannot prohibit the free exercise of religion. The freedom to believe is part of the general grant of freedom to expression, assembly, and association.

The second interpretation of secularism was generated in and through the Indian historical experience; that the state shall treat all religious groups equally.

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Secularization, according to **Peter Berger**, is the "process by which sectors of society are removed from the domination of religious institutions and symbols". The process indicates the decline in the religious permeation of other social institutions. It also refers to the process through which religion's influence on other institutions diminishes. It emphasizes that religion should be delimited to the private sphere of individual and family life. At the same time, other social institutions, such as economy, politics and education, maintain their set of norms independent of religions guidance.

According to **Bryan Wilson**, "secularization is a process in which religious thinking, practice and institutions lose social significance". Secularization doesn't necessarily imply that people have become areligious or anti-religious, or that religion has disappeared from both the public domain and the domain of personal life. What it does imply is that religion is just one, and not necessarily the most important, way in which people understand themselves and their relationships.

Secularization may be said to consist fundamentally of two related transformations in human thinking. The first is the '**desacralization**' of the attitude towards persons and things. Desacralization is a process in which there is a decline in the overarching religious symbolism for the integration of society and in which an understanding of human beings and their society is no longer stated primarily in religious terms. Secondly, it is a move from supernatural to rational explanation. There is the **rationalisation of thought**; rationalisation implies a cognitive attitude relatively free from emotion, and the use of logic rather than an emotional symbolism to organize thought.

In the contemporary world, one can point to evidence both in favour of and against the idea of secularization. It is widely accepted by social scientists that the dominant trend in most western societies is towards secularization. There is fair enough evidence to suggest a steady decline in formal religious observances. Nowadays fewer people are visiting churches regularly, they are moving away from supernaturalism. **Advocates of secularization hypothesis argue that secularization has been de-institutionalizing the religion. In the modern world, the rational perspective of science becomes a major organizing belief for a secular and increasingly rationalized society.**

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However, the critics of the secularization hypothesis argue that though it is a fact that old type of religiosity (attending churches regularly and the intensity of religious feelings) seem to be decreasing but its manifestation in other forms is heavily increasing. **Critics of secularization hypothesis talk about religious revivalism.** More and more religious activities (religious festivals, rites, rituals, ceremonies, rallies, etc.) are being performed with much pomp and show and with much attendance of the followers. In the last few decades many new places of worship (church, temples, mosque, etc.) have been constructed and many new religious organizations with great paraphernalia have cropped up. Religious texts are being reinterpreted and new rituals are being added or given new shape to suit their circumstances.

An important development in religious life has been the dramatic rise of religious programming (performance of religious ceremonies, delivering religious discourses, sermons and prayers, etc.) in the electronic media. Organizing religious rallies and performing religious functions in public have increases tremendously. Religious personalities and groups have realized that the mass media represents an effective means of spreading religious values. Technological advances such as Television, Cable Television, Satellite transmission, etc., have facilitated the rise of '**e-religion**'. Aastha and Sanskar are the two new and important television channels which relay such religious programmes regularly at appointed times. These channels are most popular among Hindus. Besides these, there are many other television channels which relay religious programmes of different faiths. The audience of these religious programmes is increasing day by day.

Increase in this type of religious consciousness may be said to be the by-product of modern life which is full of stress and strains, pulls and pressures, great competitiveness and uncertainty. Modern religious activities and observances give some solace to the people torn by the exigencies of modern life. People visit temples or churches for getting fast blessings just like fast food. To use the phrase of **Thorstein Veblen** - 'conspicuous consumption' - we may call modern religiousness as '**conspicuous religiosity**'.

Critics further argue that religion in the late modern world should be evaluated against a backdrop of rapid change, instability and diversity. Even if traditional forms of religion are receding to a degree, religion still remains a critical force in our social world. The appeal of religion, in its traditional and novel forms, is likely to be long lasting. Religion provides many people with insights into complex questions about life and meaning that cannot be answered satisfactorily with rationalistic perspectives. It is not surprising then, that during these times of rapid change, many people look for and find answers and calm in religion. Fundamentalism is perhaps the clearest example of this phenomenon. Yet,

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increasingly, religious responses to change are occurring in new and unfamiliar forms such as new religious movements, cults and sects. While these groups may not 'look-like' forms of religion on the surface, many critics of secularization hypothesis believe that they represent transformations of religious belief in the face of social change (**religious pluralism**).

Critics also argue that secularization has not affected modern societies uniformly. There seems to be little evidence of secularization in non-western societies. In many areas of Middle East, Asia and Africa, trends of religious revivalism, fundamentalism, and communalism can be identified.

S.C. Dube argues that in the process of secularization, religion loses control over several fields of social activities such as economy, trade, education, medicine and so on. Many of the traditional functions of the religions are taken care of by secular institutions. But secularism varies from society to society. India perhaps has failed to develop diversified institutions that may take over the traditional functions of religion (remember **Durkheim**). As such, it remains communal, and religious beliefs continue to prevail.

To conclude it may be said that although the influence of religion definitely has declined, religion is certainly not on the verge of disappearing, and continues to unite as well as divide people in the modern world.

Anti-thesis of secularization:

- Religion as an ideology of protest
- Religious fundamentalism

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Social Exclusion in India

As stated earlier, compared with established concepts such as poverty, class or social mobility, social exclusion has a relatively short history. The term itself was coined in the 1970s by French politician **Rene Lenoir** to describe that section of the French population that had been cut-off or marginalized from mainstream society and had slipped through the 'welfare net'.

Social exclusion terminology was adopted at a European Union level in the late 1980s and early 1990s. The concept of social exclusion has increasingly replaced the concept of poverty amongst the policy makers within the European Union. Social exclusion, presently, has become the central theme of social policy in many European countries.

According to **Amartya Sen**, social exclusion emphasizes "the role of relational features in deprivation". It refers to the norms and processes that prevent certain groups from equal and effective participation in the social, economic, cultural, and political life of societies. It is both an outcome and a process that renders similar outcomes more likely. Social exclusion thus involves at least four factors: the excluded, the institutions from which they are excluded, the agents whose actions result in the exclusion, and the process through which exclusion occurs. Social exclusion is a relational phenomenon, implicating those with power and affecting those without. To complicate the dynamic, power asymmetries are observed even within groups of excluded individuals.

In brief, social exclusion refers to the process through which groups are, wholly or partially, excluded from full participation in the society in which they live. These main processes include discrimination, deprivation, isolation, shame, etc. It involves both the act of restricting access to resources and the consequences that follow.

Christine Bradley pointed out following five main mechanisms through which social exclusion is practiced:

1. **Geographical segregation:**

Social exclusion can be a function of geography and direct correlations between rural isolation and poverty are often found. In general, the poor live in the most marginal areas, which compound the cycles of poverty and exclusion. It is generally observed that the so-called untouchables (dalits) and even minorities are residentially segregated from the mainstream society. They are made to live and construct their residential places and dwellings outside the villages or at the

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periphery of village or town. Most of the tribals live in hills and forests and are excluded from the mainstream population.

2. **Intimidation:**

As a mechanism of social exclusion, it is often used to reinforce social stereotypes and power relations. In general, those with power use the threat of harm to maintain their dominance over those without power. In India there is deeply entrenched caste exclusion. The threat of violence is reported to be the major form of control of upper castes over backward castes and men over women. To exclude, intimidation in any form is used as the main arm. Verbal abuse, sarcastic remarks, threat of harm, etc., are the main means of intimidation. It can be observed at every level in a society.

3. **Physical Violence:**

When threat of harm does not work, actual violence is used. It can be committed by the state, community, group or individuals. Violence against women in the household and against poor people and ethnic and religious minorities is reported to be practiced all over the world. Domestic violence is rooted in the norms of gender inequality and patriarchy. Violence against dalits and service castes is a common feature in many rural areas of India.

4. **Barriers to entry:**

Transaction costs and documentation requirements are the two most common barriers to entry. Transaction costs are those costs that are involved in acquiring a good or service above and beyond its actual price. Barriers to entry involving the state bureaucracy are mostly related to documentation requirements. The state, which is often inflexible in helping the excluded, denies them access to resources. Documentation is also held responsible to for the inability of the poor to gain access to resources. Documentation allows the state to humiliate and deny services to the excluded. Other barriers to entry include hostility and unfairness confronted by excluded people while dealing with bureaucracy.

5. **Corruption:**

Corruption as a social evil is a common problem in all parts of the world. Corruption not only makes access harder for the poor in financial terms, but also destroys the trust that a society needs to function effectively. It makes equal access and fair treatment from the state impossible for the poor and excluded and accelerates their disengagement from a wider society.

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Excluded Sections of Indian Society

Exclusion as a social phenomenon is expressed in different forms all over the world. In almost all human societies, certain groups are excluded and deprived of some opportunities. While the way in which each of these groups is excluded is context-specific, certain social differences continue to serve as grounds for exclusion. These differences include belonging to a particular ethnic, gender, caste, religion or age-group, living in a particular area or having certain disabilities. Various forms of social differences overlap and intersect in complex ways over time.

In Indian context, the main bases of social exclusion are religion, ethnicity, gender and caste. In India, unique forms of exclusion are observed, where certain groups like the dalits, backward classes, women and religious minorities experience systematic exclusion in regard to accruing the advantages of development. Institutional inequality and discrimination have been pervasive features of the Indian society. **Narayan** calls it a process that prevents certain groups from equal and effective participation in the social, economic, cultural and political lives of the societies. Discrimination, inequality and isolation are the main features of social exclusion which negatively affect the quality of life.

In the Indian context, exclusion revolves around institutions that discriminate, isolate and deprive the subordinate groups on the basis of identities such as caste, religion and gender. It is mainly based on caste and patriarchy. The salient features of social exclusion on the basis of caste are social stratification, social inequality, hierarchy and hegemony. Patriarchy breeds gender inequality and social exclusion of weaker sections is closely associated with the discriminatory practices and inequality embedded in the institution by caste. Some of the common categories of excluded groups are described below:

Ethnic Groups: Social exclusion due to ethnic differences is a common feature across the globe. In India the exclusion on the grounds of ethnicity is seen in the form of caste system. For example, in traditional India, each caste group maintained strict norms about interdining and also accepting water from other communities. Any violation would lead to conflict within the village. The practice of untouchability can be seen in most villages of India. Similarly, various linguistic and religious minorities also face social exclusion in various forms at interpersonal and institutional levels.

Women: In most of the societies women are considered subordinates to men. They are just considered important to look after their family but in the globalization world the increasing role of women in low-paid formal and informal job markets

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has brought new opportunities as well as burden. Now they have dual responsibilities, increasing violence at home and exploitation at work place clearly indicate the transformation of society and new emerging threats to women.

Children: Children are among the most disempowered groups in the society and they are more susceptible to abuse. Customary law considers children as property of their respective families and gives them no individual rights. Exclusion from schools and prevalence of bonded child labour are problems related to children. The widespread acceptance of highly exploitative labour practices and the practice of child prostitution are among the most extreme examples of vulnerability of children.

The poor: social exclusion and poverty are different but still they are connected. Poor people live in the vicious cycle of exclusion of everything and it is difficult for them to break the shackles of poverty. In India around 30% of population is below poverty line and most extreme thing about poverty is that it translates itself into intergenerational poverty.

Please note that while social exclusion and poverty are distinct concepts, they are deeply connected. Poor people remain poor because they are excluded and deprived from access to the resources, opportunities, information, and connections the less poor have. For poor people in developing countries this translates into intergenerational poverty. In addition, poverty is socially stigmatized, making it even harder for poor people to gain access to the networks and resources they need for survival. This vicious cycle is difficult to break. Poverty carries with it painful and humiliating stigma and powerlessness.

People with HIV/AIDS: In India HIV/AIDS infected people face social exclusion. Our society is not very progressive and it is considered as if the infected person has committed a sin. The major fear associated with HIV/AIDS is the fear of social isolation that would befall on the household or individual if the infection is disclosed. This causes many to hide the fact, thereby hampering further awareness.

The Elderly: In India the elderly are treated with deference and respect. Their vulnerability is compounded by the rapid collapse of support systems that provided them security in their retired lives. With increasing economic stress and breakdown of family solidarity, the elderly are emerging as a new category of excluded poor in many countries across the globe.

Widows: In many parts of India, widows are considered as an excluded group. The widows are excluded from attending certain social ceremonies and rituals at both

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family and community levels. The combination of social prejudices, kinship, customs and lack of accountability on the part of state explains why widows face great risk of poverty and exclusion. Socially they are often neglected and considered a burden to the family. The widow beggars in Vrindavan are examples.

The Disabled: Disability is frequently reported as one of the important reasons cited for exclusion. The disabled are excluded at work place as well as home.

Impact of Social Exclusion

Social exclusion results in the following main consequences:

1. It leads to various kinds of deprivations—economic, educational, cultural and social.

2. It leads to the impoverishment of human life and develops a poorer sense of well-being.

3. It leads to inequality, poverty, unemployment and involuntary migration.

4. It leads to social stigmatization and marginalization.

5. It develops fear complex among the excluded.

6. It puts various restrictions on the excluded about their free and full participation in the economic, cultural and political activities.

7. On the whole, it puts an intense negative impact on the quality of life.

Human Rights and Indian Constitution

India has adopted a clear policy on human rights set forth in the constitution, such as, right to equality, right to freedom, right against exploitation, right to freedom of religion, cultural and educational rights and right to constitutional remedies. Article 14, 15, 16 have been provided with equality provisions. Article 14 of the Indian Constitution ensures equality before law to all persons within the territory of India. Article 15(1) and (2) prohibits discrimination between citizens on the grounds of religion, race, caste, sex, place of birth or any of them. The constitution has abolished untouchability under Article 17 and forbids its practice in any form. Right to shelter has been held to be necessary for the enjoyment of

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'right to life' guaranteed under Article 21 of the constitution. Freedom of movement is guaranteed by the Articles 19(1)(d) and 21.

Different laws have been enacted to protect the right of citizens. For example, for women various acts like Hindu Marriage Act 1955, Hindu Succession Act 1956, Hindu Succession (Amendment) Act, Dowry Prohibition Act 2005, Sati Act 1961, Widow Remarriage Act 1856, Immoral Traffic Act 1956 and Equal Remuneration Act, etc., have been enacted from time to time to remove gender discrimination and protect women's rights. To check caste discrimination The Protection of Civil Rights Act, 1955 has been enacted. The Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989 gave more teeth to the law enforcing agencies to bring to book those who humiliate and dishonor scheduled castes and scheduled tribes.

Social exclusion and inclusive policy

In the Indian context, where structural and systematic exclusion based on caste, gender and ethnicity and in some cases religious minorities combine with the class inequality, it results in accumulative social exclusion. Overcoming 'exclusion' constitutes the most elementary pre-requisite for building of a democratic society and can be done through the 'policy of social inclusion', particularly by the state by taking affirmative action to change the circumstances that lead to social exclusion. Indian Constitution provides equality to all citizens irrespective of caste, creed, religious and gender. It also directs the State to take various measures to remove the different forms of discrimination and inequality and thereby help to eradicate social exclusion. **Social inclusion is a coordinated response to the very complex system of problems that arise because of social exclusion. It operates both at the public and private levels; it becomes the responsibility of the civil society as well as the state to ensure social inclusion is a reality and inclusion as desirable.**

Conclusion

It can be said mere enacting laws against social exclusion will not help. It is the implementation part that is more important. The gaps in the laws should be rectified and implemented in a better way. Secondly it is the cooperation of the society and state which is very much essential for social inclusion. In India focus is upon the Human Development Index and not on any measurement of deprivation and exclusion, which is the need of hour. Focus upon exclusion will help to understand the dimensions of exclusion, the true needy people will be identified and policies will be directed in order to empower these people/sections.

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Social Exclusion

In almost all human societies, exclusion in some or the other form exists. Certain groups or individuals are excluded from the mainstream society. They are deprived of some opportunities which are needed for the full blossom of human life. While, the way in which individuals or groups are excluded is context-specific, certain social differences continue to serve as grounds for exclusion. These differences include belonging to a particular ethnic, religious, caste, gender, or age group; or living in a particular geographic area; or having certain physical or mental disabilities. Various forms of social differences overlap and intersect in complex ways over time.

Compared with established concepts such as poverty, class or social mobility, social exclusion has a relatively short history. The term itself was coined in the 1970s by French politician **Rene Lenoir** to describe that section of the French population that had been cut-off or marginalized from mainstream society and had slipped through the 'welfare net'. The concept has particular resonance in countries which share with France a Republic tradition, in which social cohesion is held to be essential in maintaining the contract on which society is founded.

Social exclusion terminology was adopted at a European Union level in the late 1980s and early 1990s. Right-wing governments, including the Thatcher government in the UK, did not recognize the existence of poverty in their own countries, while commentators on the left were becoming increasingly concerned about the social polarization associated with rapidly growing income inequality. By the 1980s, the concept had a prominent place in the European political agenda and today, the European Social Charter guarantees all citizens of the European Union protection against poverty and social exclusion. By the mid-1990s, use of the term 'social exclusion' by Labour politicians in the UK was commonplace, and the Social Exclusion Unit was set up shortly after the 1997 General Election. [Please note that while poverty and income inequality were high on the agenda of Old Labour in UK, social exclusion was the central theme of New Labour. New Labour in UK, for example Tony Blair, was keen to establish that social exclusion was more than traditional 'poverty'. It is more damaging to individual self esteem, corrosive for society as a whole and is more likely to be passed down from generation to generation than material poverty.]

In the international arena, the United Nations Development Programme has been at the forefront of attempts to conceptualize social exclusion across the developed and developing world. A series of country studies led to the formulation of a rights-focused approach, which regards social exclusion as lack of access to the institutions of civil society (legal and political systems), and to the basic levels

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of education, health, and financial well-being necessary to make access to those institutions a reality.

There are a multitude of definitions of social exclusion but no single official definition of the concept exists, and apart from the shared notions of marginalization and non-participation, particular definitions often emphasize different aspects of exclusion. The Social Exclusion Unit described social exclusion as 'what can happen when individuals or areas suffer from a combination of linked problems such as unemployment, poor skills, low incomes, poor housing, high crime environments, bad health and family breakdown'.

The statement alerts us to the possibility that communities and not simply individuals can experience social exclusion. In addition, different forms of exclusion are cumulative and do not stand in isolation from each other. They are interlinked and mutually reinforcing. For example, poor health can impact on employability or family breakdown may impact on a child's educational performance and poor quality housing can undermine physical and mental health. **Ruth Levitas** focuses on this interconnectedness and the multidimensional nature of social exclusion. There is also an acknowledgement that exclusion is not just an individual experience but has wider implications related to the question social cohesion.

Ruth Levitas argues that social exclusion is a complex and multi-dimensional process. It involves the denial or lack of resources, rights, goods and services, and the inability to participate in the normal relationships and activities, available to the majority of people in society, whether in economic, social, cultural or political arenas. It affects both the quality of life of individuals and the equity and cohesion society as a whole.

Walker and **Walker**, drawing on T H Marshall's framework, identify social exclusion as denial of citizenship. They recognize that exclusion is not simply an absolute state but that it has gradations:

> The dynamic process of being shut out, fully or partially, from any social, economic, political and cultural systems which determine the social integration of a person in society. Social exclusion may, therefore, be seen as the denial (or non-realization) of the civil, political and social rights of citizenship.

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Social exclusion: a more powerful concept than poverty?

How useful is the concept of 'social exclusion' and does it have greater explanatory power than poverty? Similarly, does social exclusion offer us enhanced insights into the experiences of marginalized group and communities? Many would argue that poverty is a narrower, more limited concept than social exclusion. Poverty focuses essentially on the distribution of material resources, on matters related to income, wealth and consumption. Social exclusion is a broader, more multidimensional notion which focuses on economic, political, cultural and social detachment (Walker and Walker, 1997).

G.J. Room has argued that the notion of poverty is primarily focused upon ***distributional*** issues: the lack of resources at the disposal of an individual or household. In contrast, notions such as social exclusion focus primarily on ***relational*** issues: in other words, adequate social participation, lack of integration and lack of power, etc.

Poverty and social exclusion often go hand in hand. Poverty is frequently a significant element in social exclusion and can trigger social exclusion. However, the relationship is contingent rather than categorical; someone can be socially excluded without being poor. For example, there is no evidence that the experience of sexual minorities is essentially defined by poverty. Nevertheless, their lives continue to be defined by a social, cultural and political exclusion. They continue to be vulnerable to hate crimes and have their sexuality denied legitimacy. Likewise, not all people with a physical disability may be poor but will experience a degree of social exclusion, most obviously a lack of accessibility which impacts on their mobility and on social relations. Some elderly people may not be poor but in an ageist society they will experience a degree of social exclusion. The value of social exclusion lies in the fact that it offers explanatory insights beyond that of poverty.

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Social exclusion and mental health

The Social Exclusion Unit report described people with mental health issues as 'one of the most excluded groups in society'. It is clear that the concept of poverty fails to capture and explain their experience, although poverty is often part of their lives.

> For some of us, an episode of mental distress will disrupt our lives so that we are pushed out of the society in which we were fully participating. For others, the early onset of distress will mean social exclusion throughout our adult lives, with no prospect of training for a job or a future in meaningful employment. Loneliness and loss of self-worth lead us to believe we are useless, and so we live with this sense of hopelessness, or far too often chose to end our lives. Repeatedly when we become ill we lose our homes, we lose our jobs and we lose our sense of identity.

The severity of the social exclusion experienced by people with a mental health problem is well documented – poor physical health, high level of unemployment, social isolation, vulnerability to stigma and suspicion. The Social Exclusion Unit recognized that these deprivations are interconnected and may form a 'cycle of deprivation'. Some elements in this cycle are particularly significant. In terms of work, it has been said that there is greater discrimination against those with a record of mental illness than those with a criminal record. People with mental health problem have one of the lowest employment rates of all disabled groups. Unemployment can be an important driver of social exclusion as it often has significant financial, social and psychological implication. Financially, unemployment means restricted power to consume in a society in which consumption is an important source of status. Exclusion from employment means a loss of, or reduced, social networks and psychologically, our sense of identity, our sense of self, is often defined by our occupation. As Secker argues:

> In addition to the negative impact on confidence, self-esteem and mental health itself, unemployment can result in restricted income, fewer opportunities to meet other people or develop skill, and loss of a productive identity that, for many people, is central to a sense of belonging within society.

Through such studies, one begins to develop a sense of the intensity of social exclusion experienced by people with mental health problems.

The concept of social exclusion alerts us to dynamic and complex process; the way in which different forms of deprivation do not exist independent of each other but interact and are mutually reinforcing. Poor mental health can be both a cause and consequence of social exclusion, and mental illness can cause or intensify social exclusion; similarly, social exclusion can deepen mental illness. While the concept of poverty will remain a vital tool for student of social policy,

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social exclusion expands the realm of our enquiries into issues of marginalization and disadvantage that may not be related to income and wealth.

Competing discourses of social exclusion

Dear candidate, as previously noted, there is no simple, single, accepted definition of social exclusion and the concept implies diverse things to different people with politicians of different political persuasions seeking to harness the concept for diverse ends. There are competing discourses of social exclusion which variably stress that the causes of social exclusion may be seen as being located at the level of the individual, the family, or locally, nationally or even globally.

Ruth Levitas (2005) has made an important contribution to our understanding and identifies three discourses of social exclusion. Please note that social exclusion discourses are underpinned by different assumptions about the way in which society is structured and the distribution of power within it. They offer opposing accounts of the causes and extent of, and solutions to, social exclusion.

The first discourse identified by Levitas is a **Moral Underclass Discourse** (MUD). Here, individuals and communities are seen as deviant, immoral, impulsive, welfare dependent, unhealthy and criminal. Often, poor parenting and the notion of the dysfunctional family is implicated. Deviant values and norms are passed from generation to generation (deviant culture). There is often a spatial dimension to this discourse, with an identified 'underclass' concentrated in deprived neighbourhoods, characterized by high levels of crime, poverty, unemployment and poor health, and low levels of educational attainment. This kind of analysis, notably associated with the work of American political scientist Charles Murray, has attracted a powerful sociological and political critique. It is worth noting that cultures do not develop in a vacuum but can be understood as a response to a particular set of material conditions. In other words, individuals or communities cannot be understood in isolation from their relationship to wider societal structures and groups. The application of a MUD-type discourse is ideologically driven and diverts attention away from social divisions such as 'race' and 'class', which are rendered insignificant in explaining and understanding the deviance and social protest.

The second discourse identified by Levitas is the **Social Integrationist Discourse** (SID). Here, social exclusion is viewed primarily as a consequence of exclusion from the paid labour market. SID was at the forefront of New Labour's attack on social exclusion where access to paid work was seen as the most effective way of overcoming social exclusion and entry into the labour market was

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considered to be the key to inclusion. It was stated that 'The best defence against social exclusion is having a job, and the best way to get a job is to have a good education, with the right training and experience'. Under New Labour's **conditional welfare state**, welfare policy became a way of integrating people into the labour market. This strategy involved using a mixture of 'carrots' such as benefit incentives, and 'sticks', i.e. the threat of a reduction or withdrawal of benefits for those who failed to recognize their responsibilities to work. There is a moral dimension to SID, as paid work is seen to offer more than simply income. The employed citizen is a 'responsible' citizen and exposure to the discipline of the workplace is viewed as important because it is said to give a structure to unemployed people's lives.

The idea that work is the key to social inclusion has an attractive simplicity but Levitas herself is less than convinced. A social integrationist discourse seems to suggest that those in employment are equally included but this ignores the hierarchical structure of the paid labour market and the fact that much work is poorly paid, insecure and casual and that many people who work hard remain in poverty despite their best efforts. It makes no reference to the status of the working poor – those who remain poor in spite of being in paid work. Inclusion in the labour market through marginal, low paid, insecure jobs under poor working conditions does not constitute genuine poverty free social inclusion. Also, work within this discourse is very narrowly defined – it is paid work. Levitas argues that many of those excluded are employed. They are simply not in *paid* employment, rather they are engaged in informal, familial, 'caring' work. Such work, generally carried out by women, is often invisible, undervalued and unrecognized. More broadly, a SID lacks sociological rigour. It closes down analysis prematurely by failing to consider adequately the structural causes of unemployment.

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In the third discourse identified by Levitas, the **Redistributionist Discourse** (RED), a social exclusion is viewed as a consequence of poverty and structural inequality. If SID was a defining idea of New Labour, then RED is associated with Old Labour and socialism. Here, poverty is not seen as a residual problem but as an inevitable product of capitalism. Social exclusion is therefore rooted in de-industrialization, global economic change and a rolling back of the welfare state. The other two discourses, i.e. MUD and SID, are seen as distraction or diversions which shift attention from the broader processes that cause social exclusion. New questions begin to emerge under RED, about power and the way it is exercised. If someone is excluded, than someone or something is doing the excluding. The focus is on the structural causes of that exclusion, and not simply the operation of the labour market or the individual 'immorality' of the excluded.

If the causes of social exclusion are seen as structural, then structural change is required to counter it, for example a programme of redistribution (through state intervention) including a reform of the taxation system and an expansion of welfare benefits and public services: 'RED broadens out from its concern with poverty into a critique of inequality, and contrasts exclusion with a version of citizenship which calls for substantial redistribution of power and wealth'. RED offers a radically different perspective on the social disturbances, refuting any notion of 'pure criminality'. Thus rioting or any form of social protest is not simply a meaningless, abnormal phenomenon but is deeply rooted in the history and culture of a given society. Social protest can be understood as a form of political action – as a meaningful, if chaotic, protest by those who are socially excluded.

It is important to recognize Levitas's discourses as artificial constructs. They are ideal type accounts – grounded in reality but not capturing the diversity and complexity of that reality; nonetheless they have heuristic value and offer a framework to develop competing understanding of social exclusion. Thus it would be misleading to suggest, in a simple way, that MUD is a discourse of the New Right, or SID of New Labour or RED of Old Labour; the reality of policy is more complex.

It is important to go beyond the simple binary (i.e. consisting of only two parts) divisions in our understanding of social exclusion. For example, mental illness may be the defining experience of a person or group but it does not exist in isolation from other aspects of difference, and people with mental health issues are not a homogenous group. The experience of a person with mental illness may also be defined by their class, gender, ethnicity, etc. In other words, mental illness can be an important driver of social exclusion but when this condition is associated with membership of an ethnic minority community, for example, that exclusion can be sharpened and even more debilitating.

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Finally, social exclusion is not simply an issue for the socially excluded. It has wider significance for issues of equality, citizenship, social stability and cohesion. Social exclusion is not just a problem for those who are excluded, it is a problem for social structure and social solidarity generally. If significant numbers of people are excluded……..then social order will likely become more polarized and unequal – and ultimately perhaps more unstable for all.

Social Exclusion in India: refer class notes

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Sociology and Common Sense

To many people, sociology appears to be a labourious study of the obvious, an expensive way to discover what everybody already knows. To these people, sociology is merely common sense. But sociology is more than common sense because it is based largely on scientific evidence. Often ideas or beliefs derived from common sense turn out to be false, contradicted by facts from sociological research.

Sociological findings such as those that contradict commonly held myths may surprise you. Of course, not every finding in sociology is surprising. In fact, some confirm what you have known all along. You should not be surprised, therefore, to learn from sociology that there is more joblessness among Blacks than among Whites or that there are more poor people than rich people in prison. But many other commonsense ideas have turned out to be false. By systematically checking commonsense ideas against reliable facts, sociology can tell us which popular beliefs are myths and which are realities. For thousands of years, people's common sense told them that the earth was flat, that big objects fell faster than small ones, and that character was revealed in facial features; yet today we know none of these is true. Today, science is replacing common sense as a source of dependable knowledge.

When we do not know where our ideas come from or that they are based on, we sometimes call them "common sense". If we call them common sense, we do not have to prove they are true, for then others will join us in the collective self-deception of assuming they have already been proved. If one presses for proof, one is told that the idea has been proved by experience. The term "common sense" puts a respectable front on all sorts of ideas for which there is no systematic body of evidence that can be cited. What often passes for common sense consists of a group's accumulation of collective guesses, hunches, and haphazard trial-and-error learnings. Many common sense propositions are sound, earthy, useful bits of knowledge. "A soft answer turneth away wrath", and "birds of a feather flock together", are practical observations on social life. But many common-sense conclusions are based on ignorance, prejudice, and mistaken interpretation. When medieval Europeans noticed that feverish patients were free of lice while most healthy people were lousy, they made the common sense conclusion that lice would cure fever and therefore sprinkled lice over feverish patients. You may have heard the encouraging message that "Absence makes the heart grow fonder," but you may still remember the discouraging warning "Out of sight, out of mind". When facing such conflicting commonsense ideas, how can we tell which are correct and which are false? We can get the answer from sociological research. It has shown, for example, that the effect of one person's absence on another depends

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on the strength of the initial relationship. If two people have loved each other deeply, like Romeo and Juliet, absence will make their hearts grow fonder, but a high school romance tends to disintegrate because such relationships are usually not deep or serious enough to begin with. Common sense thus preserves both folk wisdom and folk non-sense, and to sort out one from the other is a task for science.

Only within the past two or three hundred years has the scientific method become a common way of seeking answers about the natural world. Science has become a source of knowledge about our *social* world even more recently; yet in the brief period since we began to use the scientific method, we have learned more about our world than had been learned in the preceding ten thousand years. The spectacular explosion of knowledge in the modern world parallels our use of the scientific method. You will learn more about scientific method in the section 'Science, scientific method and critique.'

In sum, it is not true that sociology is only common sense. If it were, we wouldn't bother to study sociology. Why would we spend our time learning something we already know? Common sense requires only a willingness to believe what it tells us. It cannot tell us whether those beliefs have any basis in fact. But sociology can. This is one of the reasons that sociology is exciting. It enables us to see that what has long been familiar - or just common sense - may turn out to be unfamiliar or uncommon. While common sense gives us familiar and untested ideas, sociology offers factually supported ideas as well as the excitement of discovering something new about ourselves.

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Dear Candidate, after completing a given topic and preparing your notes in pointer form, you must attempt questions asked so far in previous years and get them evaluated. As I have discussed before, what really counts here is how you are articulating the learned knowledge in the given Time and Word Limit. Always remember that Civil Services Examination is not about information, it is more about analysis. So, you must practice by writing more and more answers and getting them periodically evaluated.

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Sources and causes of social mobility

I. Structural factors:

1. Expansion of industrial economy

- change in the occupational structure

- agrarian – industrial – post-industrial
(farming) (manufacturing) (service sector)

- with industrialization and mechanization – manual jobs decline – unskilled jobs taken over by machines – technical and high skill jobs require specialized skills and knowledge

- manual labourers and farmers – unskilled and less educated – witnessed downward mobility

- For example, in USA – in 1900 – agricultural workers constituted 40% of labour force. But, in 2000, agricultural workers constitute only 4% of the total labour force.

- in the age of globalization – international competition – even well educated managers, technicians and other professionals witnessed downward mobility – because of outsourcing of jobs (BPOs)

- but at the same time, industrialization and the growth of service sector has led to the diversification of the occupational structure – leading to the creation of numerous high status jobs

2. Government sponsored mass education programmes

- such as National Literacy Mission, etc. – opening up various industrial training institutes (ITIs) – for specialized knowledge and vocational skills

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3. <u>Lower birth rate in higher classes</u>

- as economy expands, more higher positions are created

- but, due to low birth rate, self-recruitment in higher classes is not sufficient enough

- as a result, people from lower classes get an opportunity to occupy higher positions so created.

II. Individual factors (high education, talent, achievement motivation, hard work, etc.)

Some personal characteristics are achieved, such as education, talent, motivation and hard work. Others are ascribed, such as family background, race and gender. As has been suggested, both achieved and ascribed qualities have a hand in determining the degree of mobility an individual or group attain in a given society. But the popular belief in equal opportunity would lead us to expect career success to be attained through achievement more than ascription. Is achievement then, really the more powerful determining force in upward mobility?

According to most sociological studies, achievement may appear on the surface to be the predominant factor, but it is actually subject to the influence of ascription. It is well known that the more education people have, the more successful they are in their careers. But the amount of education people have is related to their family background. Thus, compared with children from blue-collar families, children from white-collar families can be expected to get more education and then have a better chance for career mobility. [Case studies: **Jencks et al.** (1994), **Erickson and Jonsson** (1996)]

III. Social factors

1. Government policy of redistribution and social justice

- for example, land reforms, reservation policy, etc.

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- has facilitated upward mobility of socially and economically weaker sections of society in India, such as scheduled castes, scheduled tribes, other backward classes, etc.

2. **Collective mobilization**
   - in wake of the democratization of societies
   - dalit movement, backward class movement (eg. Yadavs of UP and Bihar), peasant movements, etc.

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State

The word state derives from the Latin word 'stare' (to stand) and more specifically from 'status' (a standing or condition). The state can most simply be defined as '*a political association that establishes sovereign jurisdiction within defined territorial borders and exercise authority through a set of permanent institutions*'. The modern state, as a form of political organization, could be said to have evolved in early modern Europe, and was transmitted primarily through colonialism to other parts of the world. Thus, the modern state and the modern system of states have not been permanent and universal features of human history. Further, the trajectory of the development of the state in other parts of the world has been very different from that in Europe. What is distinctive about the modern state in terms of its difference from earlier kingships is the distinction between the rulers, and the office and institutions they occupy. Thus the modern state is characterized by its impersonal standing. The current holders of power in the government do not constitute the state. The state exists before they come to power and continues to be there after they leave. It aims to gain autonomy from the contending parties or groups that come to hold political power. Thus the modern state is a public order distinct from and located above both the ruler and ruled.

One of the most important things to remember is that when we talk about the state, we are referring to a whole gamut of different organized institutions that are connected to one another and enjoy some cohesion. That is, the state is organizationally highly differentiated as well as centralized. Thus, it is not a monolithic structure; it consists of a set of institutions and organizations. The three arms of the modern state are the judiciary, the executive and the legislature – each different, but with a certain level of cohesion with each other. The different arms of the state exercise the authority that they have, not on their own behalf, but on the basis of the authority they are entitled to as part of the state. The government refers to the administrative organ of the state and is constrained by the constitution of the state. The government may change but the state persists.

State and Government

A distinction should be drawn between the state and the government, two terms that are often used interchangeably. The state is more extensive than government. The state is an inclusive association that encompasses all the institutions of the public realm and embraces all the members of the community (in their capacity as citizens), meaning that government is merely part of the state.

In this sense government is the means through which the authority of the state is brought into operation; it is 'the brains' of the state. Nevertheless, the state

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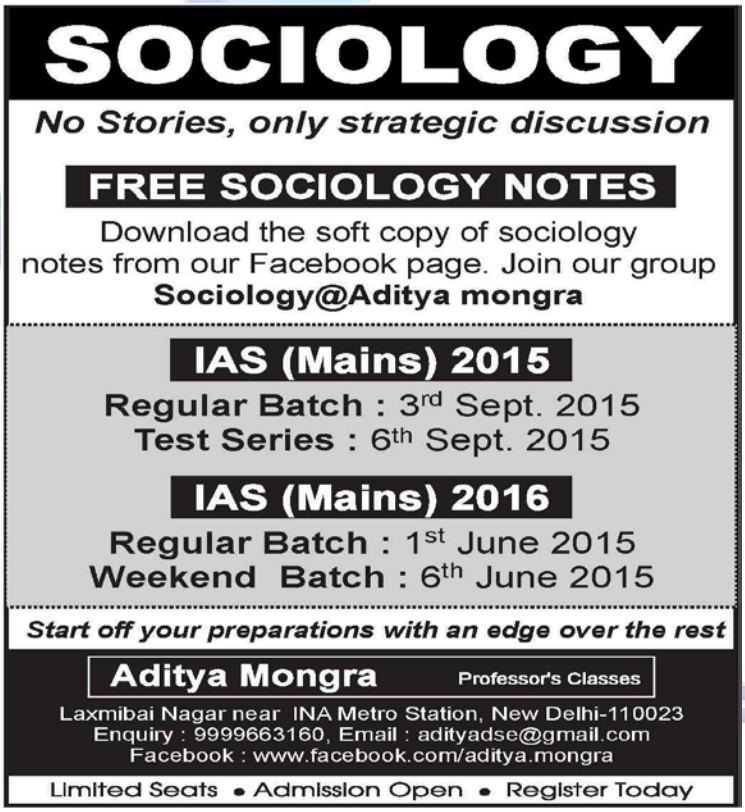
is a continuing, even permanent, entity, while government is temporary. Within an enduring state system, governments may come and go, and system of government may be reformed and remodeled. Moreover, the state exercises impersonal authority, in the sense that the personnel of state bodies is recruited and trained in a bureaucratic manner and is (usually) expected to be politically neutral, enabling state bodies to resist the ideological enthusiasms of the government of the day. Finally, the state, in theory at least, represents the public interest or the common good. Government on the other hand, represents the partisan sympathies of those who happen to be in power at any particular time.

State and Civil Society

The distinction between state and civil society is based on the recognition that individuals who are subject to the power of the state also have capacities and interests of a non-political nature. Further, while the state represents coercion, civil society is said to be based on voluntary participation.

States vary in the amount of independence that they permit to other social institutions. This determines the nature of the state as totalitarian or liberal. A state that seeks to fuse the distinction between its sphere of activity and that of the society is called totalitarian state, because it seeks to intervene in the totality of human life. A totalitarian state might supervise what books you read, what your political views are and even what careers you opt for.



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State and Nation

The distinction between the nation and the state is particularly important in view of the struggle by many nations for statehood. When we talk about international relations, we are actually referring to inter-state relations. A nation could be defined as community feeling among people who recognize that they are distinct from other communities and wish to control their own affairs. This distinction could be based on their possession of a common language, religion, political values and attitudes, a sense of having done things together in the past, and a desire to do things together in the future. The entire population in the same state share this feeling, giving rise to the term 'nation-state'. However, this is not the case with all the states in the world today. So the nation and the state do not coincide. There are people who feel part of the same nation, and are spread across different states. The Kurdish people, for instance, are spread across Iran, Iraq, Syria and Turkey and consider themselves to be a nation. A similar argument can be made for the Israel-Palestine conflict and the demands of various secessionist groups in north-east India, for example, Bodos.

However, most of the societies in the world today are largely organized into nation-states. A **nation-state** is a nation governed by a state whose authority coincides with the boundaries of the nation. Its system of government lays claim to specific territories, possess formalized codes of law and is backed by the control of military force. Nation- states are modern phenomena and have come into existence generally after 19th century.

According to **Anthony Giddens**, the main characteristics of the modern state (nation-state) are as follows:

1. Territoriality: The modern state is territorially based. This means that the state exercises its authority within its territorial borders which are acknowledged by other states. This acknowledgement distinguishes the state from other forms of political organizations, where governance is over people rather than over land, and people allegiances are not territorially determined. So one's rights and duties depend on one's place in the hierarchical social order within a tribe or clan or other forms of ethnic organization. For instance, in the traditional caste system in India, one's location in the hierarchical structure of the caste system used to determine one's right and duties.

The modern state has no authority outside its borders, and no other state possesses authority within another state's borders. Within the boundaries of the state, there is a single system of governance, distinct from others that operate externally. The territorial foundations of the state distinguish it from other types of

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organizations and associations, which could be religious. The demands of statehood by groups are often for the recognition of the claim to territory. One of the most tragic, poignant, and complex struggles over the claim to territory in the recent past has been the Palestine-Israeli conflict. The Palestinian struggle for statehood could be a struggle for the recognition of the claim to land.

2. Sovereignty: Sovereignty refers to the state being the ultimate source of political authority within the territory under its jurisdiction. There are two aspects of sovereignty – internal and external. Internal sovereignty refers to the fact that within its boundaries, there are no authorities higher than the state. The state is supreme, and a citizen cannot appeal against the state to any other authority. The state has the right to make binding decisions upon its citizens and upon those who enter its territory. Thomas Hobbes (1588-1679), for this reason, portrayed the state as a 'leviathan', a gigantic monster.

External sovereignty of the state refers to the recognition that other states accord to a particular state, and the acceptance that the state can speak for its citizens in international affairs. External sovereignty implies the autonomy and independence of the state in the international sphere. The sovereignty of the state can be challenged in many ways; the state might lose its sovereignty partly after having voluntarily entered into international treaties, or other states might intervene in the affairs of the state on the grounds of a deemed violation of human rights, the possession of weapons of mass destruction, etc.

3. Public institution: State institutions are recognizably 'public', in contrast to the 'private' institutions of civil society. State bodies are responsible for making and enforcing collective decisions in society and are funded at the public's expense.

4. Legitimacy: Legitimacy is derived from the Latin verb 'legitimare' which means to legitimate, and signifies rightfulness in a broad sense. It confers a binding or authoritative character on an order, thus transforming power into authority. The state has the authority to ensure that its laws are obeyed and the power to punish those who disobey. Its decisions are usually (although not necessarily) accepted as binding on its citizens because, it is claimed, it reflects the permanent interest of society.

5. Coercion: The state is an instrument in domination – it possesses the coercive power to ensure that its laws are obeyed and that transgressors are punished. **Max Weber** has described state as "a social institution that has a monopoly of legitimate violence within a specific territory".

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The state's monopoly over the legitimate use of coercion is reflected in the institutions of the armed forces, the paramilitary forces, and the police. This indicates the immense power that the state has over people's lives. Imprisonment, death penalty, declaration of war – all these involve the use of violence, and only the state is entitled to the legitimate use of these powers. That is why the state is said to have a monopoly over the legitimate use of violence. The coercive institutions help to maintain the supremacy or the sovereignty of the state, and to ensure the observance of laws and the maintenance of order when these are considered to be infringed.

6. Citizenship: In modern societies most people living within the borders of the political system are citizens, having common rights and duties and knowing themselves to be part of a nation. Almost everyone in the world today is a member of definite political order.

7. Nationalism: Each community acquires a distinctive character through its association with nationalism. Nationalism can be defined as 'a set of symbols and beliefs, providing the sense of being part of a single political community'. Thus, individuals feel a sense of pride and belonging in being Indian, British or American. It is the main expression of feelings of identity with a distinct sovereign community.

Nationalistic loyalties do not always fit with the physical borders marking the territories of states in the world today. While the relation between the nation-state and nationalism is a complicated one, the two have come into being as part of the same process. Nationalism has become an increasingly powerful force in the world, serving as a basis not only of collective social identity but also for political mobilization and action, especially through the use of warfare.

The consequences of nationalism (cultural) often breed extremism and feelings of ethnocentrism (a tendency to think and act blindly that our culture is superior to those of others) resulting into political conflicts. Extreme forms of nationalism have engulfed many nations into warfare (Nazism, Fascism, etc.).

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Theories of state (on the need of the state and the nature of state power)

The state has always been central to political analysis, to such an extent that politics is often understood as the study of the state. Political sociology, in particular, is interested in understanding and analyzing two important dimensions of state, firstly, need of state and secondly, the nature of state power.

Need of the state

The classic justification for the state is provided by **social contract theory**, which constructs a picture of what life would be like in a stateless society, a so-called 'state of nature'. In the view of thinkers such as Hobbes and Locke (1632 -1704), as the state of nature would be characterized by an unending civil war of each against all, people would be prepared to enter into an agreement – a social contract – through which they would sacrifice a portion of their liberty in order to create a sovereign body without which orderly and stable existence would be impossible. In the final analysis, then, individuals should obey the state because it is the only safeguard they have against disorder and chaos. (Social contract theory: Thomas Hobbes, John Locke, Rousseau, etc.)

Eminent sociologist **Emile Durkheim** looks at state and its relation with the individuals from a functional perspective. Durkheim traced the development of the state to the division of labour in the society, as societies became more complex there occurred the distinction between governing and governed, which in turn results in the formation of the state. Mechanical solidarity is the trademark of less developed or primitive society where division of labour is very little. Whereas societies with highly developed division of labour are held together by organic solidarity.

For Durkheim there was no politics or state existed in primitive societies because there was no or little division of labour and hence no grouping into government and governed. On the other hand, modern industrial societies are marked by high division of labour leading to the emergence of a number of different secondary social groupings. For Durkheim state essentially is a mediator between secondary groups.

Durkheim further argues that state derives its legitimacy from the conscience collective and becomes its directive organ and symbol. Please note that here he differs with **Karl Marx** who argued that state only represents the interest of the ruling class.

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With regard to the relationship of the state to the individual, Durkheim argues that this is not an issue in societies where mechanical solidarity is dominating and where individuals were absorbed into the social whole. But as organic solidarity develops, the power of the state develops and so also the rights of the individuals. The growth of the state does not threaten but enables the rights and freedom of individuals. [Durkheim - unbridled individualism - cause of chaos and conflict in society - so need for state - for social control - true freedom lies in being bound or regulated by social facts (state) - thus, subordinating the individual to collectivity (state).]

Nature of state power

The second important dimension that political sociology is interested in is the nature of state power. Before moving on to the various rival theories of the state, let us briefly discuss the various types of states that are classified on the basis of varying degree of power.

1. **Minimal states** ('nightwatchman' states): Minimal states, as advocated by classical liberals, are merely protective bodies whose sole function is to provide a framework of peace and social order within which citizens can conduct their lives as they think best. Liberals view the state as a neutral arbiter amongst competing interests and groups in society, a vital guarantee of social order. For liberals, the state is at worst a 'necessary evil'.

2. **Developmental states:** Developmental states operate through a close relationship between the state and major economic interests, and aim to develop strategies for national prosperity in a context of transnational competition. For example, India, Japan, 'tiger economies' of the South-east Asia, etc.

3. **Social-democratic states:** Social-democratic states are the ideal of both modern liberals and democratic socialists. Such states intervene widely in economic and social life in order to promote growth and maintain full employment, reduce poverty and bring about a more equitable distribution of social rewards. For example, UK, Scandinavian Countries - emphasize a great deal on social welfare.

4. **Collectivised / Communist states:** Collectivised states, found in orthodox communist countries, abolished private enterprise altogether and set up centrally planned economies administered by a network of economic ministries and planning committees.

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5. Totalitarian states: Totalitarian states penetrate every aspect of human existence through a combination of comprehensive surveillance and terroristic policing, and a pervasive system of ideological manipulation and control. For example, Myanmar, North Korea, etc.

Let us now discuss the various theories with regard to the nature of power of the state. (Please refer class notes and handouts)

Handout 1: Utilitarian view
Handout 2: Liberal view
To add: Contemporary liberalism has been most exercised by the notion of social justice and social welfare [John Rawls (1921-2002), Ronald Dworkin)]
Handout 3: Marxian view
Handout 4: Feminist view (Patriarchal state)
Handout 5: Globalization - a short note
Handout 6: Imported state and its consequences in the third world societies
Handout 7: Globalization and Politics

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Social Movements:

Social movements are collective ways of promoting or resisting change. According to the Oxford Dictionary of Sociology, "Social movements are an organized effort by a significant number of people to change (or resist change in) some major aspect or aspects of society." The term was first used by Saint-Simon in France at the turn of the eighteenth century, to characterize the movements of social protest that emerged there and later elsewhere, and was applied to new political forces opposed to the status quo. Nowadays, it is used most commonly with reference to groups and organizations outside the mainstream of the political system. Sociologists have usually been concerned to study the origins of such movements, their sources of recruitment, organizational dynamics, and their impact upon society. Social movements must be distinguished from collective behaviour.

The social movement is one of the major forms of collective behaviour. Social movements are purposeful and organized; collective behaviour is random and chaotic. Examples of social movements would include those supporting civil rights, gay rights, trade unionism, environmentalism, and feminism. Examples of collective behaviour would include riots, fads and crazes, panics, cultic religions, rumours, and mass delusions. Social movements are one of the basic elements of living democracy, and may be catalysts of democracy and change in authoritarian societies. Social movements have specific goals, formal organization, and a degree of continuity. They operate outside the regular political channels of society, but may penetrate quite deeply into political power circles as interest groups. Their goals may be as narrow as legalizing marijuana, or as broad as destroying the hegemony of the capitalist world system; they may be revolutionary or reformist; but they have in common the active organization of a group of citizens to change the status quo in some way.

A social movement is formally defined as "a collectivity acting with some continuity to promote or resist change in society or group of which it is a part" (Turner and Killian). In other words, social movements refer to the collective action by people, in a coordinated manner, driven by certain ideology, which is sustained over a period of time with its orientation (or resistance) towards change. Stated less formally, a social movement is a collective effort to promote or resist change.

An early typology of social movements, developed by **David F. Aberle** classifies social movements along two dimensions: the locus of change sought (society or individuals) and the amount of change sought (partial or total). The four categories derived from this classification are **transformative**, **reformative**,

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redemptive, and **alternative**. These are (respectively) movements which aim at the complete restructuring of society (for example millenarian movements); those which attempt to reform some limited aspects of the existing order (such as nuclear disarmament group); movements which seek to lead members away from a corrupt way of life (as in the case of many religious sectarian groups); and, finally, those which aim to change only particular traits of the individual member (for example drug or alcohol de-addiction). The first two of these are therefore aimed at changing (all or part of) society, the latter pair at changing the behaviour only of individual members.

[Please note that a **Millenarian movement** is a social movement based on the expectation of a sudden transformation of society through the intervention of the supernatural. For example, in New Guinea and surrounding islands, a religious movement developed which was popularly known as 'cargo cult', resulting in a great variety of similar cults. Cargo cults are based on the expectation that a great cargo ship (or in later cults, airplane) will be brought by the spirits of deceased ancestors, loaded with modern machines, tools, and other goods for the native population. With the aid of this cargo and the help of the spirits, the Europeans will be killed or driven out, and the native population will have the products and standards of living currently enjoyed by the Europeans. The cargo cults are classified as millenarian movements because they are directed toward a millennium, a day when a sudden supernatural event will occur that will radically change the members' lives. The cargo cults began to appear in the late nineteenth century, but became more widespread after World War I, particularly in the 1930's.]

Various other scholars have also tried to understand the nature of social movements through different typologies. One of the criteria for classifying movements is their objectives or the quality of change they try to attain. **Ghanshyam Shah** classifies movements as **reform**, **rebellion**, **revolt**, and **revolution** to bring about changes in the political system. Reform does not challenge the political system per se. It attempts to bring about certain desired changes within the existing socio-political structure in order to make it more efficient, responsive and workable. That is why the state shows a lenient attitude towards such movements. A rebellion is an attack on existing authority without any intention to seize state power. A revolt is a challenge to political authority, aimed at over-throwing the government. In a revolution, a section or sections of society launch an organised struggle to overthrow not only the established government and regime but also the socio-economic structure which sustains it, and replace the structure by an alternative social order.

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Various scholars have proposed different-different theories of social movements. These include both psychological as well as sociological theories. The psychological theories find the roots of social movements in the personalities of the followers. The two important **psychological theories** are discontent theory and personal maladjustment theory.

Discontent theory holds that movements are rooted in discontent. People who are comfortable and contented have little interest in social movements. Discontent can be of many kinds, ranging from the searing anger of those who feel victimized by outrageous injustice to the mild annoyance of those who do not approve of some social change. It is probably true that, without discontent, there would be no social movements. But discontent is an inadequate explanation. There is no convincing evidence of any close association between the level of grievance and discontent in a society and its level of social movement activity. People may endure great discontent without joining a social movement. Many societies have endured great poverty, inequality, brutality, and corruption for centuries without serious social protest. And all modern societies always have enough discontent to fuel many social movements. Thus, discontent may be a necessary condition but not a sufficient condition for social movement. [Muller, 1972; Snyder and Tilly, 1972; Turner and Killian, 1972]

Personal maladjustment theory sees the social movement as a refuge from personal failure. Many scholars believe that movements find their supporters among the unhappy, frustrated persons whose lives lack meaning and fulfillment. A widely read book written by a self-educated manual labourer, *The True Believer* [Eric Hoffer, 1951], describes the kinds of people drawn to social movements: the bored, the misfits, the would-be creative who cannot create, the minorities, the guilty sinners, the downwardly mobile, and others who for any reason are seriously dissatisfied with their lives. They add meaning and purpose to their empty lives through movement activity.

It is plausible that people who feel frustrated and unfulfilled should be more attracted to social movements than those who are complacent and contented. Those who find their present lives absorbing and fulfilling are less in need of something to give them feelings of personal worth and accomplishment, for they already have these. Thus, the movement supporters - and especially the early supporters - are seen as mainly the frustrated misfits of society. While plausible, the misfit theory is not well substantiated. It is difficult to measure a person's sense of nonfulfillment. It is yet another theory which sounds reasonable but which cannot easily be proved or disproved.

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The **sociological theories** study the society, rather than the personality of individuals. The three important sociological theories are relative deprivation theory, strain theory, resource mobilization theory and revitalization theory.

The concept of relative deprivation was introduced by **Samuel A. Stouffer et al**. in their classic social psychological study '*The American soldier'*, 1949, but was later formalized by **R. K. Merton** in *Social Theory and Social Structure*, 1961, and extended to a theory of reference group behaviour. Individuals see themselves as deprived (or privileged, hence 'relative gratification') by comparing their own situation with that of other groups and categories of persons. The extent to which they will see themselves as deprived will vary according to the category or group selected as the basis of comparison. In other words, the concept of relative deprivation holds that one feels deprived according to the gap between expectations and realizations. The person who wants little and has little feels less deprived than the one who has much but expects still more.

Merton's understanding of relative deprivation is closely tied to his treatment of reference group behaviour. Essentially, Merton speaks of relative deprivation while examining the findings of '*The American Soldier*', a work published in 1949. It was found that the privileged members of army were relatively more unhappy and dissatisfied as compared to the relatively unprivileged members who were found to be happier and with high morale. Thus it was discovered in this study that the state of negative emotions and objective conditions are not symmetrically linked. Hence the sense of deprivation is relative, not absolute.

"Comparing himself with his unmarried associates in the army, the married man could feel that induction demanded greater sacrifice from him than from them; and comparing himself with the married civilian friends, he could feel that he had been called on for sacrifices which they were escaping altogether".

It is important to note that happiness or deprivation are not absolutes, they depend on the scale of measure as well as on the frame of reference. For example, his unmarried associates in the army are relatively free. They don't have wives and children, so they are free from the responsibility from which married soldiers cannot escape. In other words, married soldiers are deprived of the kind of freedom that their unmarried associates are enjoying. Likewise, the married soldier feels deprived when he compares himself with his civilian married friend because the civilian friends can live with his wife and children and fulfil his responsibility. The married soldier therefore, feels deprived that by virtue of being a soldier he cannot afford to enjoy the normal, day to day family life of a civilian. It is precisely

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because of the kind of reference group with which the married soldier compares his lot that he feels deprived.

Relative deprivation is increasing throughout most of the underdeveloped world. The recently established independent governments of Third World countries have little hope of keeping up with their peoples' expectations. The clouds of mass movements and revolutions seem to be widespread in these countries. According to Brinton, revolutions seem most likely to occur not when people are most miserable but after things have begun to improve, setting off a round of rising expectations.

Relative deprivation theory is plausible but unproved. Feelings of deprivation are easy to infer but difficult to measure, and still more difficult to plot over a period of time. And relative deprivation, even when unmistakably severe, is only one of many factors in social movements.

The 'strain theory' of social movement has been propounded by **Neil J. Smelser**. This theory considers structural strain as the underlying factor contributing to collective behaviour. Structural strains may develop when the equilibrium of society is disturbed due to uneven changes between its various sub-systems. Strain may occur at different levels such as norms, values, mobility, situational facilities, etc. Because of these structural strains some generalised belief that seeks to provide an explanation for the strain, may emerge. Both strain and generalised belief require precipitating factors to trigger off a movement. Smelser's analysis of the genesis of social movements is very much within the structural-functional framework. Smelser considers strain as something that endangers the relationship among the parts of a system leading to its malfunctioning.

The 'resource mobilization theory' stresses techniques rather than causes of movements. It attributes importance to the effective use of resources in promoting social movements, since a successful movement demands effective organization and tactics. Resource mobilization theorists (**Zald** and **McCarthy**) see leadership, organization, and tactics as major determinants of the success or failure of social movements. Resource mobilization theorists concede that without grievances and discontent, there would be few movements but add that mobilization is needed to direct this discontent into an effective mass movement.

The resources to be mobilized include: supporting beliefs and traditions among the population, laws that can provide leverage, organizations and officials that can be helpful, potential benefits to be promoted, target groups whom these benefits might attract, any other possible aids. These are weighed against personal costs of movement activity, opposition to be anticipated, other difficulties to be overcome, and tactics of operation to be developed.

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Resource mobilization theory does not fit expressive or migratory movements, which can succeed without organization or tactics. Evidence for resource mobilization theory is largely descriptive and is challenged by some scholars. It is likely that societal confusion, personal maladjustment, relative deprivation, discontent, and resource mobilization are all involved in social movements, but in undetermined proportions. As usual, we have several theories, each plausible, each supported by some evidence, but none clearly proved. Social movements are of so many kinds, with so many variables involved, that possibly no one theory will ever be conclusively established.

The 'revitalization theory' was initially put forward by **A.F.C. Wallace**. Wallace postulated that social movements develop out of a deliberate, organised and conscious effort on the part of members of a society to construct a more satisfying culture for themselves. This explanation of genesis of social movement substantially departs from the above explanations. Both the relative deprivation and the strain theories are based on negative conditions. They argue that movements emerge because people experience deprivation and discrimination. The revitalization approach, however, suggests that social movements offer a positive programme of action to revitalise the system. Thus, according to this theory, social movements not only express dissatisfaction and dissent against the existing condition but also provide alternatives for resurgence of the system.

Herbert Blumer and other scholars have posed a life cycle which many movements follow. The stages include: (1) the *unrest* stage of growing confusion and discontent; (2) the *excitement* stage, when discontent is focused, causes of discontent are identified, and proposals for action are debated; (3) the *formalization* stage, when leaders emerge, programs are developed, alliances are forged, and organizations and tactics are developed; (4) an *institutionalization* stage, as organizations take over from the early leaders, bureaucracy is entrenched, and ideology and program become crystallized, often ending the active life of the movement; (5) the *dissolution* stage, when the movement either becomes an enduring organization (like the YMCA) or fades away, possibly to be revived at some later date.

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